

S. HRG. 118-520

Senate Hearings

Before the Committee on Appropriations

Department of Defense Appropriations

Fiscal Year 2024

118th CONGRESS, FIRST SESSION

H.R. 4365/S. 2587

DEPARTMENT OF DEFENSE
NONDEPARTMENTAL WITNESSES

Department of Defense Appropriations, 2024 (H.R. 4365/S. 2587)

**DEPARTMENT OF DEFENSE APPROPRIATIONS FOR
FISCAL YEAR 2024**

HEARINGS
BEFORE A
SUBCOMMITTEE OF THE
COMMITTEE ON APPROPRIATIONS
UNITED STATES SENATE
ONE HUNDRED EIGHTEENTH CONGRESS

FIRST SESSION

ON

H.R. 4365/S. 2587

AN ACT MAKING APPROPRIATIONS FOR THE DEPARTMENT OF DEFENSE
FOR THE FISCAL YEAR ENDING SEPTEMBER 30, 2024, AND FOR
OTHER PURPOSES

**Department of Defense
Nondepartmental Witnesses**

Printed for the use of the Committee on Appropriations



Available via the World Wide Web: <http://www.govinfo.gov>

U.S. GOVERNMENT PUBLISHING OFFICE

50-509 PDF

WASHINGTON : 2024

COMMITTEE ON APPROPRIATIONS

PATTY MURRAY, Washington, *Chair*

DIANNE FEINSTEIN, California ¹	SUSAN M. COLLINS, Maine, <i>Vice Chair</i>
RICHARD J. DURBIN, Illinois	MITCH McCONNELL, Kentucky
JACK REED, Rhode Island	LISA MURKOWSKI, Alaska
JON TESTER, Montana	LINDSEY GRAHAM, South Carolina
JEANNE SHAHEEN, New Hampshire	JERRY MORAN, Kansas
JEFF MERKLEY, Oregon	JOHN HOEVEN, North Dakota
CHRISTOPHER A. COONS, Delaware	JOHN BOOZMAN, Arkansas
BRIAN SCHATZ, Hawaii	SHELLEY MOORE CAPITO, West Virginia
TAMMY BALDWIN, Wisconsin	JOHN KENNEDY, Louisiana
CHRISTOPHER MURPHY, Connecticut	CINDY HYDE-SMITH, Mississippi
JOE MANCHIN, III, West Virginia	BILL HAGERTY, Tennessee
CHRIS VAN HOLLEN, Maryland	KATIE BRITT, Alabama
MARTIN HEINRICH, New Mexico	MARCO RUBIO, Florida
GARY PETERS, Michigan	DEB FISCHER, Nebraska
KYRSTEN SINEMA, Arizona ²	

EVAN SCHATZ, *Staff Director*

ELIZABETH McDONNELL, *Minority Staff Director*

SUBCOMMITTEE ON DEFENSE

JON TESTER, Montana, *Chairman*

RICHARD J. DURBIN, Illinois	SUSAN M. COLLINS, Maine, <i>Ranking</i>
DIANNE FEINSTEIN, California ¹	MITCH McCONNELL, Kentucky
PATTY MURRAY, Washington	LISA MURKOWSKI, Alaska
JACK REED, Rhode Island	LINDSEY GRAHAM, South Carolina
BRIAN SCHATZ, Hawaii	JERRY MORAN, Kansas
TAMMY BALDWIN, Wisconsin	JOHN HOEVEN, North Dakota
JEANNE SHAHEEN, New Hampshire	JOHN BOOZMAN, Arkansas
CHRISTOPHER MURPHY, Connecticut	SHELLEY MOORE CAPITO, West Virginia
CHRISTOPHER A. COONS, Delaware ³	

Professional Staff

KATE KAUFER
MIKE CLEMENTI
LAURA FORREST
ABIGAIL GRACE
KATY HAGAN
BRIGID KOLISH
ROB LEONARD
RYAN PETTIT
KIMBERLY SEGURA
RYAN KALDAHL (*Minority*)
TODD PHILLIPS (*Minority*)
JASON POTTER (*Minority*)
JESSE TOLLESON (*Minority*)
MIKE WAKEFIELD (*Minority*)

Administrative Support

GABRIELLA ARMONDA
ALEX SHULTZ (*Minority*)

¹ Died September 29, 2023.

² Appointed to Committee October 18, 2023.

³ Appointed to Subcommittee November 2, 2023.

CONTENTS

HEARINGS

	Page
TUESDAY, MARCH 28, 2023	
Department of Defense: Department of the Navy: Office of the Secretary	1
TUESDAY, APRIL 18, 2023	
Department of Defense: Department of the Air Force and Space Force: Office of the Secretary	91
WEDNESDAY, MAY 2, 2023	
Department of Defense: Department of the Army: Office of the Secretary	143
THURSDAY, MAY 11, 2023	
Department of Defense: Office of the Secretary of Defense	185
THURSDAY, JUNE 1, 2023	
Department of Defense: National Guard and Reserve	251

BACK MATTER

List of Witnesses, Communications, and Prepared Statements	341
Nondepartmental Witnesses	325
Subject Index	345
Department of the Air Force: Office of the Secretary	345
United States Space Force	345
Department of the Army: Office of the Secretary	345
Department of the Navy: Office of the Secretary	345
United States Marine Corps	345
National Guard and Reserve	346
Office of the Secretary of Defense	347

DEPARTMENT OF DEFENSE APPROPRIATIONS FOR FISCAL YEAR 2024

TUESDAY, MARCH 28, 2023

U.S. SENATE,
SUBCOMMITTEE OF THE COMMITTEE ON APPROPRIATIONS,
Washington, DC.

The subcommittee met at 10 a.m. in room SD-192, Dirksen Senate Office Building, Hon. Jon Tester (chairman) presiding.

Present: Senators Tester, Murray, Schatz, Baldwin, Shaheen, Murphy, Collins, Murkowski, Graham, Moran, Hoeven, Boozman, and Capito.

DEPARTMENT OF DEFENSE

DEPARTMENT OF THE NAVY

OFFICE OF THE SECRETARY

STATEMENT OF HON. CARLOS DEL TORO, SECRETARY

OPENING STATEMENT OF SENATOR JON TESTER

Senator TESTER. I call this committee meeting to order. Good morning. I want to welcome our witnesses.

Secretary Del Toro, Admiral Gilday, General Berger, thank you for your service to our Nation, and thank you for leading the Navy and the Marine Corps.

I look forward to discussing your fiscal year 2024 budget priorities today. The fiscal year 2024 budget request for the Navy and the Marine Corps is \$255.8 billion, \$11 billion more than in fiscal year 2023, and about \$32 billion more than fiscal year 2022. This increase sounds robust but it is irrelevant unless we enacted Defense Appropriations bill for fiscal year 2024.

Our key priority this year must be to get the budget done on time. Continuing resolutions kill military modernization and cause billions in wasteful spending. And it is no secret that the Chinese don't operate under continuing resolutions.

I am encouraged by the work that Chair Murray and Vice Chair Collins, have already put in to restore regular order to the Appropriations Committee. Their commitment to writing Bipartisan Appropriations Bills that addresses the critical challenges facing our Nation have my full-throated support.

This budget request represents continuity from last year's budget by furthering implementing the National Defense Strategy. And it reinforces what we already know, despite Russia's ongoing unjust war in Ukraine; China remains our number one pacing threat.

We must continue to modernize our Military to stay ahead of that threat. The Navy and Marine Corps play an important role in defending our national and economic security by providing unparalleled maritime capabilities.

Every week Senator Collins and I hear from commanders in the field about the varying threats facing our Nation. So the question I have is: Are we spending taxpayer on the right things?

We look forward to hearing from you on where we have made progress, and what challenges remain. And once again, I want to thank each one of you for your service to our country.

Before you make your opening statements, I want to turn it over to Senator Collins for her opening statement.

STATEMENT OF SENATOR SUSAN M. COLLINS

Senator COLLINS. Thank you very much, Mr. Chairman. It has been a great pleasure to work with you as we proceed as the Chair and Vice Chair of this very important subcommittee.

I want to echo the Chairman's thank you to each of our witnesses, for your service, it is greatly appreciated. And I would ask that you also pass on our gratitude to the Sailors and Marines that you represent.

I also want to recognize the Department's many civilians, and their industry partners who build and maintain the ships, aircraft, and munitions that sustain the Navy and the Marine Corps. They make invaluable contributions, and I am personally proud that so many Mainers have chosen to serve their country in these capacities, such as, by working at Bath Iron Works, the Portsmouth Naval Shipyard, and the Naval Computer and Telecommunications Center in Cutler, Maine.

The administration's 2022 National Defense Strategy accurately describes the accelerating threat of China, as the Chairman has indicated, and its unprecedented military modernization.

However, in my judgment, the administration's budget request does not fully reflect the challenges identified in its own National Defense Strategy.

For example, the President's budget request would result in a fleet of 291 ships at the end of the next 5 years. That is smaller than today's fleet of 296 ships, and significantly smaller than the Navy's own requirement of 373 ships. I am also concerned with the contrast to more than 440 ships that China is expected to have by the year 2030.

The budget requests also inadequately accounts for the impact of Inflation and Investment and Readiness Accounts. The Navy's proposed budget increase of 4.5 percent, which includes the Marine Corps' 2.6 percent increase, would likely provide less buying power than the fiscal year 2023 enacted budget after accounting for inflation.

For example, the budget request assumes a fuel price of \$140 per barrel, yet on the very day that the budget was rolled out fuel was \$169 per barrel, that is 20 percent more than budgeted.

Why does this matter? It matters because the Department of the Navy consumes roughly 24 million barrels of fuel each year, and each one dollar per barrel increase carries a \$24 million dollar cost. At \$29 per barrel below current rates, this budget would equate to

a \$700 million dollar unfunded cost just for the Department of the Navy.

It is no surprise that Admiral Gilday and General Berger's unfunded priorities which highlights some of the shortfalls of this budget, totaled \$5.7 billion.

With that backdrop, Navy leadership deserves credit for redoubling its commitment to ship maintenance. This is evidenced by the \$1.8 billion dollar increase for ship repair, and the continued full funding for the Shipyard Infrastructure Optimization Plan at the Navy's four public shipyards, including the Portsmouth Navy Shipyard in Kittery, Maine. These investments are critical to keeping a greater portion of the Navy's Fleet available for operations.

I also want to commend the Navy for pursuing a record number of multiyear procurement contracts for munitions this year. Ukraine's War has taught us that we must transition from just-in-time stockpiles of weapons and munitions to just-in-case stockpiles. If implemented well, these multiyear contracts will provide industry with the certainty necessary to make that transition a reality, and deliver cost savings for the taxpayers at the same time, and help with workforce challenges.

I look forward to discussing all of these issues with our distinguished witnesses today.

Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

Senator TESTER. Thank you, Senator Collins.

You will each be given 5 minutes for your presentation. Know that your full written testimony will be a part of the record.

And we will start with you, Secretary Del Toro.

SUMMARY STATEMENT OF HON. CARLOS DEL TORO

Secretary DEL TORO. Thank you, Mr. Chairman. Chairman Tester, Ranking Member Collins, distinguished Members of the Committee. It is an honor to appear before you, alongside General Berger and Admiral Gilday, to discuss the Posture of the Department of the Navy.

Today, our Nation faces challenges in every region and domain we operate in, from the seabed to the stars. We recognize the People's Republic of China as our pacing threat executing a strategy aimed at upending international order.

To preserve our way of life the National Defense Strategy calls upon the Joint Force to deter aggression while being prepared to prevail in conflict. A strong Navy and Marine Corps are the foundation upon which the success of the Joint Force exists.

The President's 2024 budget sends a strong signal to the American people of the value President Biden, and Secretary Austin, and myself place in maintaining a robust Navy and Marine Corps team to confront the threats that we face. This year's budget request supports our three enduring priorities: strengthening maritime dominance, building a culture of warfighting excellence, and enhancing our strategic partnerships around the globe.

With your support over the past year we have made major strides to modernize our fleet and our force. In 2022 we saw the first deployment of the aircraft carrier USS Gerald R. Ford, providing the Navy with lessons learned that will benefit future Ford-class carriers.

With the support of our partners in Congress we are proud to field capable aircraft carriers as part of our fleet with a lower service life cost than their Nimitz-class predecessors. Construction of high-end surface combatants continues, including the first Constellation-class frigate, USS Constellation, and the first of our Early Bird-class Flight III destroyers, the USS Jack Lucas, which we are scheduled to commission in the fall.

We continue progress on our first Columbia-class Ballistic Missile Submarine, the District of Columbia, our pre-construction activities on the second Columbia-class Ballistic Missile Submarine, the USS Wisconsin, have also begun.

On the innovation front, Task Force 59 in Bahrain continues to test a wide range of uncrewed surface vessels. We look forward to bringing the capabilities that these platforms provide us to additional regions that we operate in around the globe.

When we consider the composition of our fleet we seek to strike a balance between readiness, modernization and capacity, with an immediate emphasis on readiness.

This year, our divestment request includes three amphibious ships, at least two cruisers in poor material condition that offer limited warfighting capability. Our decisions to divest or extend the ship's life are based on a hull-by-hull evaluation. For example, we recently announced the modernization of the destroyer, USS Arleigh Burke, DDG-51, to keep it sailing through 2031, 5 years beyond its estimated service life. We hope to be able to continue that trend with other ships when possible.

We owe it to the American people to be responsible stewards of our taxpayer dollars, as you have stated Mr. Chairman; investing in platforms with limited capability conflicts with that responsibility. The Navy and Marine Corps are not just about platforms and systems, however, our Sailors and our Marines are our greatest strength. This year's budget request contains multiple investments to support them and their families, with services, benefits, housing, and education.

In addition to our commitments to our people, we are reinforcing our relationship with our allies and partners around the globe, including our Ukrainian partners as they defend their sovereignty in response to Russia's illegal and unprovoked invasion.

In the Indo-Pacific we continue to play our leading role in the AUKUS Security Partnership. Just this month, President Biden announced the optimal pathway for Australia's acquisition of conventionally armed nuclear-powered, fast-attack submarines. Our Navy will be critical to this initiative's success as we support a very important ally.

In addition to our partnerships abroad, we are also committed to strengthening our relationships here at home with industry. We value your support and recommit our leadership toward defueling and remediating the Red Hill Bulk Fuel Storage Facility spill as well. We are committed to doing what it takes to address the concerns of our service members, their families, the people of Hawaii, and all other communities throughout the U.S.

As I have said before, we build trust one day at a time, one action at a time, and we are committed to doing the right thing.

Lastly, I am grateful for the trust you have placed in me to lead this Department. I look forward to discussing how best to support our Sailors, our Marines, and their families in defense of our Nation.

And I thank you, sir.

[The statement follows:]

PREPARED STATEMENT OF CARLOS DEL TORO

Chairman Tester, Vice Chair Collins, distinguished members of the committee, it is an honor to appear before you alongside General Berger and Admiral Gilday to discuss the posture of the Department of the Navy (DON). We appreciate your trust and confidence in us to lead the DON, and appreciate opportunities like this to come together with you and address how to best to recruit, train, equip, and prepare our Sailors and Marines so they can fulfill their vital role in support of the Joint Force, protecting our national security interests.

The United States requires a strong Navy and Marine Corps. The national and economic security of our Nation depends on free and open access to the sea. Ninety percent of international trade travels over the seas and one third of that transits the South China Sea. Over 400 undersea fiber-optic cables carry more than a trillion dollars in transactions every day. And the rules-based international order that benefits us all requires a strong maritime force, campaigning forward alongside allies and partners to provide the sea control and integrated deterrence we need to counter strategic competitors today and into the future.

We find ourselves at an inflection point, one that demands we renew our commitment to naval primacy as we chart a course through this century of intense maritime competition. Over the past two decades, the People's Republic of China (PRC) has more than quadrupled its export trade and used its growing wealth and economic power to rapidly expand and modernize its military and its navy. The People's Liberation Army Navy has added over one hundred combatants to its fleet in that time—a naval buildup that is a key component of its increasingly aggressive military posture. Today it has approximately 340 ships, and is moving towards a fleet of 440 ships by 2030. The PRC is conducting active, aggressive maritime activities in the South China Sea and beyond that have the potential to undermine our system of international law, including the freedom of the seas, a foundational U.S. interest.

Our maritime challenges are not confined to the Indo-Pacific. Moscow has not abated in its efforts to control large swaths of the Black, Baltic, and Arctic Seas, trying to intimidate and deny other countries the opportunity to exercise their rights to free passage. That is why six of seven of NATO's priority operating regions are maritime-focused, and NATO is moving to adopt its first maritime strategy.

Our Navy and Marine Corps team are meeting these threats on the sea, under the sea, in the air, and in cyberspace every single day. To defend freedom of the sea, we must ensure our Sailors and Marines have the capability and forward presence to stand by our allies and our partners.

That is why I have directed our Navy and Marine Corps team to prioritize our investment in readiness, to make sure our ships and aircraft are always prepared to deploy. This approach will deliver the integrated deterrence at sea required by our National Defense Strategy.

THREE ENDURING PRIORITIES GUIDING THE DEPARTMENT OF THE NAVY

Last year I had the privilege of introducing my strategic vision for the Department of the Navy to this committee, centered on our Department's three enduring priorities, which are complementary to and supportive of both the CNO's Navigation Plan 2022 and the Commandant's Force Design 2030.

First, we are strengthening our maritime dominance so that we can deter potential adversaries, and if called upon, fight and win our Nation's wars. Second, we are building a culture of warfighting excellence, founded on strong leadership, and rooted in treating each other with dignity and respect. And third, we are enhancing our strategic partnerships, across the Joint Force, with industry, with academia, and with our allies and partners around the globe. Over the past year and a half, our DON team has made irreversible progress across our three enduring priorities, supporting positive growth and modernization in our naval force. I highlight the progress we've made and successes we've enjoyed over the past year through the support of the committee and your other colleagues throughout Congress.

Strengthening maritime dominance requires us to rapidly field the concepts and capabilities that create advantage relative to our pacing threat, with the sustainment necessary to generate integrated, all-domain naval power. That is why we are making the investments now, guided by the CNO's Navigation Plan and Marine Corps Force Design 2030, to ensure we remain the most lethal, capable, and globally postured force on this planet for decades to come.

Last June, our shipbuilders laid the keel for *USS District of Columbia*, the first of a new class of nuclear-powered ballistic missile submarines that will underwrite the Nation's nuclear deterrent out to the year 2080. The second *Columbia-class* hull, *USS Wisconsin*, has begun pre-construction activities.

In July, we commissioned *USS Fort Lauderdale*, an amphibious warship that will help modernize our amphibious fleet and extend the reach of our Marines to fight from the sea wherever there is a need.

What's more, *USS Tripoli*, the second of our America-class amphibious assault ships, completed its maiden deployment in 2022, operating throughout the Indo-Pacific with our larger, traditional aircraft carriers as a test of our F-35B "Lightning Carrier/Assault Carrier" concept. Deployments like this one highlight the Navy and Marine Corps' interoperability as well as the strategic and operational advantages that amphibious ships continue to provide to the Joint Force.

With regard to aircraft carriers, we've made significant progress on *USS Gerald R. Ford*, the first new carrier to be deployed in almost 50 years. We are taking the lessons learned from the *Ford* as we build the future *USS John F. Kennedy*, *USS Enterprise*, and *USS Doris Miller*. Our carriers are not only vital to deterrence, they are also the cornerstone of our interoperability with our allies.

Our most advanced fighter aircraft, the F-35 Lightning II, now brings fifth-generation stealth and multi-role, multi-mission reach and power wherever we need to fight. Meanwhile, the F/A-18E/F Super Hornet will be the numerically predominant aircraft in the carrier air wing well into the 2030s. Service-life modification initiatives and capability upgrades enhance our inventory by advancing the tactical relevance of the F/A-18 E/F and closing the Navy's strike-fighter gap. We are working with industry to ensure trained mechanics are prepared to support induction schedules, and that they are bringing electrical and avionics experts onboard to support Block III transition efforts.

Marine aviation continues to build capability and capacity in the image of the future force. Recently, we stood up Marine Aerial Refueler Transport Squadron 153 in Kaneohe Bay, Hawaii, significantly increasing the reach and sustainment capabilities of Marines in the Pacific theater.

The fifteen KC-130J tanker aircraft that VMGR-153 will have by 2026 will enhance the organic mobility available to Marines during training, in response to crisis, or in conflict. We are approaching 1 year since the CH-53K Sea Stallion program became operational, and we are well underway transitioning Marine Heavy Helicopter Squadron 461 into our first fully operational Sea Stallion squadron. While it is still in transition, HMH-461 is already conducting heavy-lift assault support missions previously impossible with legacy aircraft.

Over the past year, DON personnel have also demonstrated the immense potential of unmanned and autonomous vehicles. The Overlord Surface Vessel Ranger successfully transited from the Gulf Coast to the West Coast without an embarked crew. These unmanned surface vehicles will reduce the risk to our personnel, lower operating costs, and protect access to areas like the South China Sea. In addition, U.S. Naval Forces Central Command's Task Force 59, a new, first-of-its-kind task force, is rapidly integrating unmanned systems and artificial intelligence into maritime domain awareness in the Fifth Fleet area of operations, and we will soon expand that capability to other regions of the world.

In addition to procuring the modern platforms, we are also expanding the areas available for our personnel to train. With our partners in Congress, through the National Defense Authorization Act of 2023, we are expanding and modernizing our training ranges at Naval Air Station Fallon. This initiative will provide our pilots with the airspace and ground necessary to hone their skills in the advanced aircraft we field.

Another area of improvement is shipyard performance: our significant investment in the Shipyard Infrastructure Optimization Program, known as SIOP, is modernizing our four aging public shipyards by optimizing facilities and infrastructure as well as increasing dry-dock capacity and capability. We are also looking at establishing a parallel high-end technical track in nuclear welding, robotics, hull technology, software and electronics integration, as well as additive manufacturing for high-paying blue collar career.

We have made significant improvements to surface ship readiness. Working with industry partners, we have reduced maintenance delays on major maintenance peri-

ods in private shipyards by 39 percent since 2019. On-time completion of availabilities has also steadily increased from 34 percent in FY19 to 41 percent for all maintenance periods completed in FY22. We have brought data and advanced analytics to inform the plan for each maintenance and repair availability period, and improved our processes to better scope work and structure each availability well before ship arrival dates.

Public shipyards are also improving from FY19 in both fewer days of maintenance delay and increases to on-time completion percentages. In FY22, despite lingering COVID challenges to production, the public shipyards reduced number of days of maintenance delay by 29 percent from 2019 with on-time completions now at 33 percent.

Our second enduring priority, building a culture of warfighting excellence, demands more aggressive recruiting, more “training like we fight,” and a stronger commitment to retaining a strong, diverse, and healthy force—a force that is ready at all times and focused on warfighting and strong, positive leadership at every level. That’s why we have expanded community- and school-based outreach while simultaneously increasing media campaigns in underserved and minority markets. We must attract the broadest possible talent pool from throughout our all Nation, including more women.

Recognizing that quality of life for our service members and families is inseparable from warfighting excellence, we have directed substantial investments in quality-of-life initiatives, infrastructure improvement, and the largest military pay raise in over 20 years. All of these efforts are centered on one goal: combat readiness. Our Sailors and Marines are better prepared and more focused when they know their families are being cared for and doing well.

Our third strategic priority, enhancing our strategic partnerships, sustains and expands our advantage by seeking to achieve seamless integration, communication, and collaboration with each of our partners. With our Government partners, we have strived toward greater agility, adaptability, trust, and transparency in support of our warfighters. Globally, we have strengthened our relationships with like-minded maritime nations, deepening interoperability and interchangeability in order to enable mutual action to address shared challenges.

Our actions in the face of adversity will long be remembered by our allies and partners. Since the start of the conflict in Ukraine, the Navy and Marine Corps have supported our Ukrainian partners as they continue to defend their sovereign territory in the face of unprovoked Russian aggression. Together, we have risen to the occasion, supplying an unprecedented volume of capabilities to assist in their time of need. In 2022 alone, the Department of the Navy coordinated the identification, adjudication, and delivery of over \$1.3 billion in critical systems, weapons platforms, munitions, and support equipment to address critical Ukrainian needs.

Beyond tending to our international partnerships, we are working to expand on relationships here at home. We have made a concerted effort to support our defense industrial base, with special attention paid to supporting entrepreneurs leading small and medium-sized businesses. As a direct result of the President of the United States’ Executive Order 13985, “Advancing Racial Equity and Support for Underserved Communities Through the Federal Government,” the DON took action to further develop and refine our strategic and tactical approaches to maximize small-business utilization across a diverse industrial base. These deliberate actions have increased our outreach to small businesses, improved subcontracting compliance and oversight, fostered more opportunities to fully utilize the Department of Defense (DoD) Mentor-Protégé Program, and increased Phase III Small Business Innovation Research program funding by 16 percent over the previous year.

All of these endeavors contribute to our desired expansion of the DoD’s supply chain marketplace.

THE FISCAL YEAR 2024 PRESIDENT’S BUDGET

Despite the successes and progress highlighted above, there is still work to be done on all fronts. The President’s Budget for Fiscal Year 2024 (PB24) request to Congress is a clear signal of

President Biden’s support for our Navy and Marine Corps team and of the recognition of our critical role in the Joint Force especially in light of the complex strategic environment. Our request this year totals \$255.8 billion, a 4.5 percent increase over last year. Every dollar of this request will contribute to the warfighting strength of our Navy and Marine Corps, from research and development of next-generation technologies and systems to procurement of high-end platforms critical to defending our Nation, infrastructure improvements, and most importantly, taking care of our Sailors, Marines, and their families who sacrifice so much.

STRENGTHENING MARITIME DOMINANCE

Fleet Investments

A modern, capable, and lethal Navy requires sustained investment across a variety of platforms to complete missions in all environments. PB24 prioritizes the development, procurement, and sustainment of our Navy's ships to provide our Nation with the most capable platforms. The request includes the full funding for two destroyers, two nuclear-powered attack submarines, two frigates, one T-AO fleet replenishment oiler, and one AS(X) submarine tender, while providing the next increment of funding for construction of CVN 80, CVN 81, and LHA 9, as well as the first year of incremental funding for the second Columbia-class ballistic missile submarine.

The budget request also includes a significant investment in submarine maintenance with the goal of reducing maintenance periods and improving the operational availability of these critical assets. These funds are aimed at improving material availability and strengthening the private and public industrial bases.

PB24 prioritizes modernization of the Zumwalt Class (DDG-1000) guided-missile destroyer to enable the Navy's first fielding of the conventional prompt strike sea-based hypersonic weapon system. It also includes key enablers for the Integrated Combat System such as Infrastructure-as-Service. The Integrated Combat System will allow the Navy to deliver future capabilities through software uploads instead of hardware installations.

Fleet Divestments

Within PB24 is the request for the divestment of eight surface combatants: three cruisers (CG); three Landing Ships, Dock (LSD); and two Littoral Combat Ships (LCS). The three CGs—USS Cowpens (CG-63), USS Shiloh (CG-67), and USS Vicksburg (CG-69) are all within 3 years of their end-of-service-life dates. While these cruisers have a large vertical-launch capacity for a variety of weapons, the cost associated with repairing, modernizing, and sustaining the hulls requested significantly outweigh any warfighting contribution they provide to the fleet, and occupy limited, valuable private shipyard space that could be better used for maintaining more lethal ships.

In addition to the three cruisers, we are requesting divestment of USS Jackson (LCS-06) and USS Montgomery (LCS-08), both Independence-Class LCS variants. We acknowledge that both hulls are a third of the way through their projected service life of 25 years. However, these platforms are less lethal, less capable, and far more expensive to sustain than what is needed for the contested seas our Navy now finds itself operating in.

Finally, we are requesting the divestment of USS Germantown (LSD-42), USS Gunston Hall (LSD-44), and USS Tortuga (LSD-46), three amphibious ships that are all at or over 34 years of service and in unsatisfactory material condition. The planning and repair periods required for these ships to reach a deployable status would put all three at or near their 40-year end-of-service-life mark. Undertaking the repair of these ships, with potential cost growth, would tie up funding, shipyard capacity, and take an enormous personal toll on our Sailors assigned to the projects. However, we recognize this request brings us below the 31 amphibious ships we are required to maintain per the National Defense Authorization Act for Fiscal Year 2023. The CNO, Commandant, and I are committed to ensuring we meet this requirement and doing so in a timely manner, but with a capable, sustainable mix of ship classes that will support our Marines and Sailors for decades to come.

In PB23, the DON proposed 16 ship divestments, but was only allowed to divest four. Ultimately, it is our Sailors and Marines who pay the price when we are restricted from retiring legacy platforms and investing in the capabilities needed for the future.

Research and Development (R&D) of Enhanced Capabilities

PB24 requests a total of \$26.9 billion to increase innovation and modernization efforts in R&D. The budget request commits \$718 million of R&D funding to the recapitalization of all portions of the undersea leg of the triad including Columbia-class submarines, Take Charge and Move Out (TACAMO) capability, and the Trident D5 life extension 2. The next-generation air defense family of systems includes the F/A-XX, the "Quarterback" of the manned/unmanned team concept, directing multiple tactical platforms at the leading edge of the battlespace. PB24 also funds \$861 million in R&D for unmanned platforms, including the MQ-4 Triton, the MQ-25 Stingray, the Large Unmanned Surface Vessel, the Extra Large Unmanned Undersea Vehicle, and the MQ-9A Reaper.

Sustaining Maritime Information Superiority

Information is combat power, and we will continue modernizing our information technology infrastructure, ashore and afloat to ensure this essential backbone of our maritime power remains secure and survivable and continues to deliver information everywhere to maintain decision advantage over our adversaries. PB24 budgets approximately \$13 billion for enterprise IT, cyber activities, business systems, and other communications across the DON.

These investments are a critical warfighting priority for the Department. The DON is building information superiority to win the naval fight by modernizing its infrastructure, innovating and deploying new capabilities, and defending its information. These initiatives are enabled by data that is managed as a strategic asset.

Bringing the DON's enterprise infrastructure to parity with Industry is essential for us to maintain our advantage in competition, crisis and conflict. We have charted a path to a digital work environment where users can securely access their data anywhere on any device with performance that rivals best-in-class experiences in Industry.

The DON is accelerating the modernization and transformation of our IT capabilities by ensuring that decisions made to sunset or rationalize unneeded, obsolete, unproductive, insecure, and un-auditable IT applications are realized. This effort, coined Cattle Drive, will accelerate modernization within multiple business and core IT portfolios and self-identify funds for potential re-alignment to transformational investments.

The DON is accelerating adoption of game-changing low-earth orbit commercial satellite technology to provide resilient, low-latency, high-speed communications for warfighting, support, and quality-of-life-and-work solutions. We are adopting a new approach to cybersecurity that will move the DON from its current ineffective compliance-based cybersecurity approach to one based on readiness where the right to operate is earned and managed every day.

The DON is a leader within the DoD on the initiative to implement a more effective cybersecurity model called zero trust that is better adapted to today's threat and computing environments. Finally, data management and analytics progress the DON is making on multiple fronts is enabling us to improve decisionmaking, sustain information superiority and meet the goals of the DoD data strategy by ensuring quality data are accessible, understood, and shared to the point of need.

Enabling Cyberspace Superiority

In addition to building information superiority, the Department will ensure our networks and systems are secure, our critical infrastructure and weapon systems are survivable, and our cyber forces can impose costs on adversaries in and through cyberspace when required.

Adversaries and competitors worldwide leverage cyber vulnerabilities to hold our capacity and capabilities at risk. This malign behavior requires a robust response, and we will prioritize building cyber resilience and strengthening our capacity to withstand, fight through, and recover quickly from disruption. To do this, the Department must "bake in" cybersecurity to new capabilities and platforms we procure while "bolting on" cybersecurity capabilities to legacy platforms. This strategy also requires training our Sailors and Marines to operate in cyber contested environments.

In addition to building cyber resilience, the Department is advancing the technology, tactics, and readiness of our military cyberspace operations forces. One example of this force development is the Navy's forthcoming establishment of a specific cyber warfare officer designator and enlisted rating. The Department is similarly committed to improving the readiness of the cyber forces we present to U.S. Cyber Command, and we will expand the integration of non-kinetic effects afloat.

Marine Corps Information Command, which operates under the Marine Forces Command, achieved initial operational capacity in January 2023. Marine Corps Information Command provides critical linkages at the operational level as well as task-organized elements to support campaign objectives by providing decision-makers the ability to leverage authorities and approvals across the cyber, space, influence, and intelligence functions, generating multi-domain advantages.

Our information space requires new approaches to training, such as the Persistent Cyber Training Environment, which integrates capabilities to continuously evolve cyber training and exercises. This joint capability has expanded access over the last year, enabling force readiness and driving decisions on the tactical, operational, and strategic levels.

Munitions Procurement

PB24 takes full advantage of new authorities granted by Congress in the Fiscal Year 2023 National Defense Authorization Act that provided a streamlined multiyear procurement process for critical munitions. Not only will this authority allow the Department to replenish munitions stockpiles which are reduced in support of the war in Ukraine, it will also support efforts to strengthen the industrial base capacity to develop, produce, and field munitions. We are requesting funding for the procurement of 34 Block V Tactical Tomahawk missiles for the Marine Corps, as well as several hundred Tactical Tomahawk recertification kits, navigation and communications kits, and Maritime Strike Tomahawk kits for the Navy. Additionally, PB24 supports the awarding of multi-year procurement contracts for critical munitions, including Standard Missile (SM-6), the Naval Strike Missile, and Long Range Anti-Ship Missile (LRASM). Overall, funding for these and other weapons increased by \$2 billion in this budget— a growth of nearly 50 percent compared to last year.

Organic Industrial Base

The DON's organic industrial base is vital to our national security, and the DON is committed to ongoing depot modernization and optimization efforts. A modernized and ready organic industrial base generates Fleet readiness and strengthens our Nation's security.

PB24 continues the investment in our industrial base to further efforts to train, recruit, and retain the workforce, expand capacity and enable the development and integration of new technologies. Deliberate investments in the planning and design of facilities and optimization within the depots, as well as contract execution in dry-dock repair and refurbishment are focus areas of the budget cycle.

PB24 reflects the three named efforts within the Organic Industrial Base where these investments highlight the commitment to the Nation's security with regard to maintaining our wartime assets. First, the Shipyard Infrastructure Optimization Program consists of four public shipyards located in Portsmouth, VA; Kittery, ME; Bremerton, WA; and Pearl Harbor, HI. PB24 funding totals \$2.7 billion across multiple accounts. Replacing Dry Dock 3 at Pearl Harbor Naval Shipyard is a critical enabler of increased naval capability. This project will construct a graving dock in order to support Pearl Harbor Naval Shipyard's ability to continue serving the Navy decades into the future by maintaining and modernizing the Pacific Fleet's nuclear-powered submarines. Second, the Fleet Readiness Center Infrastructure Optimization Program consists of three Fleet Readiness Centers located in NAS North Island San Diego, CA; NAS Jacksonville, FL; MCAS Cherry Point, NC. And finally, the Marine Corps Organic Industrial Base consists of two Marine Corps production plants located in Albany, GA and Barstow, CA.

The Presidential Budget request funds public shipyard depot maintenance to 100 percent, and increases the overall workforce from 37,089 to 37,234 full-time employees, adding an additional 145 full-time employees for the Pearl Harbor Naval Shipyard and Intermediate Maintenance Facility Guam Detachment. PB24 also aligns funding to improve supply-chain capability and materiel availability in order to make proper budget and schedule decisions for items such as long-lead-time materiel.

Aviation Investments

The F/A-18E/F Super Hornet will be the numerically predominant aircraft in the carrier air wing into the 2030s. PB24 funds service-life modification initiatives and capability upgrades that enhance our strike-fighter inventory by maintaining the tactical relevance of the F/A-18 E/F and minimizing the Navy's strike-fighter shortfall. The presidential budget request also funds delivery and support of survivable, reliable, and resilient airborne command, control, and communications through the installation of critical modifications to the existing E-6B fleet, along with platform recapitalization to procure a follow-on TACAMO capability.

We will prioritize the continued development and production of unmanned aircraft systems to support current Fleet intelligence, surveillance, and reconnaissance requirements and to support future unmanned aircraft system integration into the carrier air wing. The budget funds two MQ-4 Tritons, three MQ-25 Stingrays, and five MQ-9A Reapers for the Marine Corps. PB24 requests funding for 35 F-35s: 19 F-35C variants for the Navy and Marine Corps and 16 F-35B variants for the Marine Corps. These aircraft will be the backbone of DON air combat superiority for decades to come, complementing the carrier strike group with a dominant, multirole, fifth-generation aircraft capable of projecting U.S. power and deterring potential adversaries.

PB24 also requests funding for the procurement of 15 CH-53K King Stallions. These production assets will be part of a two-year block buy contract authorized by Congress in the FY23 NDAA. The program recently achieved a Full Rate Production decision.

Climate Readiness

For the Navy and Marine Corps, a changing climate means a contested operational environment. Climate change brings extreme weather events, more humanitarian crises, and heightened friction around essential natural resources. A more volatile world increases demands on our Navy and Marine Corps forces while simultaneously impacting the capacity to respond to those demands. Improving the energy performance of our platforms and weapons systems is essential to providing a combat-effective force in contested operating environments. To do this, the Department is working to establish rigorous, energy-informed requirements for new capabilities that are then sustained throughout our acquisition decisionmaking.

Last year, the DON published *Climate Action 2030* to maintain the superiority of our naval forces through resilience and reducing the national security threat of climate change. In support of this initiative, last December, the Naval Postgraduate School signed an education partnership agreement with Stanford University's Doerr School of Sustainability. In bringing together these two globally recognized institutions, it is our hope to realize solutions our Navy and our Nation can employ to mitigate and reduce effects of a changing climate.

Jointly with our partners in Congress, we are constantly seeking innovative solutions, leveraging science, partnering with industry and other government entities, and investing responsibly to ensure mission readiness. Climate readiness is a tactical, operational, and strategic enabler, and we must ensure our naval forces can operate and succeed in any environment.

BUILDING A CULTURE OF WARFIGHTING EXCELLENCE

Building the Future Force

The civilian work force is comprised of talented individuals from all walks of life whose experiences and skillsets are critical not just to our economic success, but to the overall security of our Nation. Today's Navy and Marine Corps team is a forward-deployed highly sophisticated network that is one of the most technologically advanced networks ever conceived and which operates either in concert with other combat units or fully self-sustained, and able to dominate in the air, sea and under-sea.

As we become a more technologically advanced force, top civilian talent is increasingly critical to maintaining America's might upon the sea. Technical talent is needed for the wide array of challenges the DON faces. More than half of the civilian workforce are top-tier scientists, logisticians, engineers, mathematicians, technology specialists, or cyber experts; almost a quarter of the workforce are artisans performing critical work at the shipyards, depots, civilian mariners, or safeguarding our facilities and activities. As one indication of the quality and expertise of our workforce, the DON was issued 225 patents (more than the Air Force and Army combined) in FY22 and holds more than 58 percent of all active DoD patents (4,129).

Our civilian workforce ensures a 24/7 rapid response to warfighter requirements, develops and manufactures critical systems, repairs and maintains our ships and aircraft and develops game-changing technology and equipment. The civilian workforce is present in 55 countries, supporting Sailors and Marines around the world.

We are in a competition for talent with many other employment sectors, which is driving us to re-evaluate how we manage the careers of our Sailors, Marines, and civilians, from initial recruitment to retirement. To maintain a Fleet that is prepared to defend our Nation from all potential adversaries, we must continue to enhance our ability to attract, develop, and retain a workforce equally as talented and diverse as the American people they serve. This includes maintaining an appropriate number of senior executive leadership (general officer, flag officer, and SES) billets to ensure optimal operational readiness.

The Marine Corps continues to make great strides toward retaining more experienced Marines under the Service's Talent Management program. Leveraging authorities previously enabled by Congress, the Service enacted nine initiatives in 2022, from which they will expand and accelerate in 2023 including Early Reenlistment Authority, SNCO Promotion Board Realignment, Recruiting Station Commanding Officer Selection Boards, the Special Duty Assignment volunteer program, MarineView 360-degree leadership reviews, officer promotion opt-outs, Digital

Boardroom 2.0, Separate Competitive Promotion Categories, and the Career Intermission Program.

As a result of many of these programs, the Marine Corps met or exceeded its first and subsequent term alignment program goals for the first time in 13 years and retained a statistically higher-quality group of Marines. The Service is examining numerous other evolutionary initiatives and remains committed to evolving the talent management system with the primary goal of improving warfighting readiness in an increasingly complex world.

As another example of a positive development in force development, in August 2022, Naval Special Warfare Command (NSW) formally established its Assessment Command (NSWAC) to transform how its units compete for talent by building a sustainable architecture for diversified outreach. It conducted more rigorous pre-assessments for character, cognitive, and leadership attributes, and strengthened NSW's culture of continuous assessment. NSWAC is taking a whole-person approach to identify, prepare, and mentor qualified candidates from diverse backgrounds to complete training programs and pursue a successful career in NSW. As this new command was being developed, NSW conducted 60 outreach events with more than half specifically focused on increasing force diversity and inclusivity with underrepresented demographics. These efforts will enhance the way NSW continuously assesses and selects its incoming officers and enlisted personnel.

Educational Initiatives

Last year I talked about the Targeted Re-entry Program, which empowers commanding officers to identify and nominate their Sailors for an accelerated return to active duty. This year we want to highlight our increased partnership with the Department of Education, trade schools, and colleges and universities to develop and recruit the military and civilian workforce we need.

As we become a more technologically advanced force, education will be a crucial warfighting enabler to maintaining America's might upon the sea. Our naval education enterprise is working to develop leaders with warfighting knowledge, intellectual dynamism, and creativity to maintain a strategic advantage against competitors and global adversaries. Through our naval university system, we are creating a continuum of learning that develops such leaders to serve at every level and equips them with skills to maintain and operate increasingly complex systems in an ever-changing warfighting environment.

PB24 requests a \$480.2 million investment to continue supporting and growing our naval education institutions. We maintain several world-class institutions, including the US Naval Academy, Naval Postgraduate School, Naval War College, and Marine Corps University. This requested funding will also sustain our efforts to expand our enlisted personnel's access to the Naval Community College to support their education goals. We are deeply committed to formalizing a culture of lifelong learning for both our enlisted and officer communities.

Resiliency & Readiness

Mental health concerns and rising suicide rates are national-level issues to which the Services have not been immune. We are well aware of the inextricable link between mental health, resiliency, and the readiness of our force. To that end, Admiral Gilday, General Berger, and I are committed to supporting and ensuring the mental health, safety, and well-being of all Sailors, Marines, and their families, and the Department's civilian workforce.

We must do everything we can to foster the well-being of our people and prevent suicide. No one solution applies to every Sailor, Marine, family member, or civilian. We are constantly evaluating how we do business when it comes to providing services and resources to ensure they are meeting needs. Military service entails sacrifice not just for the service members, but for their families as well, and we want to make sure family members feel seen, heard, and taken care of regardless of whether their Sailor or Marine is home, stationed overseas, or deployed. The DON offers multiple mental-health and counseling resources to all service members at all levels. As we continue to encourage positive help-seeking behaviors and combat the stigma around mental healthcare among our Marines and Sailors, PB24 requests \$87 million for mental health support, an increase of \$13.1 million from last year. This additional funding will provide for increases to our Sailor Assistance and Intercept for Life (SAIL) program, which provides rapid assistance to those in crisis, as well as the addition of two Warrior Toughness Teams for each coast.

Given the complexity of this challenge, our Office of Force Resiliency has taken an integrated approach to enhance holistic, data-driven suicide-prevention strategies which recognize the benefits of addressing common risk and protective factors to promote healthy cultures and climates. As such, our suicide prevention efforts draw

from and harmonize with the Defense Strategy for Suicide Prevention and the White House Strategy to Reduce Military and Veteran Suicide. We are taking action on the recently released report from the Suicide Prevention and Response Independent Review Committee, and will work within DoD's coordination framework to implement key recommendations that will strengthen our prevention effort.

The Department of the Navy is laser-focused on countering sexual assault and sexual harassment at every level. In addition to the toll on victims, sexual assault and sexual harassment directly impact unit cohesion and ultimately undercuts our readiness. We must create environments that foster respect, maintain the dignity of military service, and increase our warfighting readiness. Sexual assault and sexual harassment are a persistent challenge requiring a multi-pronged approach that leverages a wide range of initiatives, not only to address these issues, but also to prevent them before they occur.

I directed the establishment of an Implementation Advisory Panel for the Department of the Navy last spring, bringing leaders to the table to pinpoint strategies for the Navy and Marine Corps to implement the recommendations of the Independent Review Commission on Sexual Assault in the Military, as approved by the Secretary of Defense. Through the Implementation Advisory Panel, the DON has already made significant strides to implement the Independent Review Commission's recommendations, focusing on the committee's highest-priority efforts first. We fully recognize that we need to continue to confront and prevent these destructive behaviors. We are investing significant resources to fuel the needed changes and we have made substantial progress in standing up a dedicated prevention workforce to prevent harmful behaviors, professionalizing the sexual assault response workforce to better provide victim care and support, and establishing Offices of Special Trial Counsel.

Additionally, our Office of Force Resiliency actively synchronizes the DON's sexual assault awareness and training, prevention, victim response, and accountability initiatives with the DoD Office of Force Resiliency. Sexual assault and harassment are more than just criminal matters. They undermine the trust and commitment that are foundational to our forces and they erode faith in our leaders, institutions, shipmates, and Marines. This is a leadership issue, and you have my commitment to clearly and actively support these efforts and to demonstrate that sexual assault and sexual harassment will not be tolerated in any way, shape, or form.

Taking Care of Our People

We continue to make great strides in providing quality-of-life services and improving housing options available to our Sailors, Marines, and their families. In PB24, we are asking you to support our DON families with \$622 million aimed at sustaining our child and youth services. Additionally, we continue our investments in housing for both accompanied and unaccompanied personnel. Notably, our request includes \$131.8 million for the construction of a Bachelor's Enlisted Quarters and Support Facility at Marine Corps Barracks, here in Washington, DC. We are also requesting funding to support housing renovations at multiple bases, to include Naval Base San Diego, Naval Air Station Lemoore, Naval Air Station Oceana, and Naval Base Ventura County. These investments will yield dividends for years to come as we continue to offer safe, affordable, and convenient housing to those who defend our Nation.

STRENGTHENING STRATEGIC PARTNERSHIPS

Community Partnerships

The DON is leveraging the Department of Defense Readiness and Environmental Protection Integration Program (REPI) to partner with local governments and non-governmental organizations to advance mission readiness through mutually beneficial, sustainable communities near our installations and ranges. The recently announced 2023 REPI Challenge includes several projects that support DON installations, to include: invasive species management and reef preservation near Pacific Missile Range Facility Barking Sands and Marine Corps Base Hawaii; habitat improvement and species management at Marine Corps Base Camp Pendleton, Naval Base Coronado, Naval Base Ventura County Point Mugu, and Naval Weapons Station Seal Beach in California; and shoreline stabilization near Marine Corps Base Quantico, Virginia.

Outside our fence lines, the communities that host our Navy and Marine Corps installations continue to utilize the Defense Community Infrastructure Pilot (DCIP) program to fund community infrastructure projects that benefit local installations, enable the DON's warfighting mission, and provide support to our service members and their families. Using 2022 DCIP grant funds, Onslow County in North Carolina

will upgrade a runway at a local airport to benefit travel in southeastern North Carolina, including Marine Corps Base Camp Lejeune, Marine Corps Air Station New River, and Marine Corps Air Station Cherry Point. In Florida, a new water main will improve capacity and pressure for not only for Naval Station Mayport, but also the surrounding community where many of our Sailors, Marines, civilians and their families live.

Finally, the city of Newport News in Virginia will undertake a \$15 million project at the Harwood's Mill Reservoir Dam to increase flood protection for the entire community and ensure a reliable water supply to Naval Weapons Station Yorktown.

We continue to work with our partners across the Federal Government, the State of Hawaii, and Congress to close the Red Hill Bulk Fuel Storage Facility and remediate the effects of the 2021 spill. We are committed to doing what it takes to address the concerns of service members, their families, and the people of Hawaii. As I've said before, we rebuild trust one day at a time, one action at a time. Aging infrastructure such as that at Red Hill is a challenge we face at the national level, and we appreciate Congress's support and partnership as we increase our focus on revitalizing the shore infrastructure our Navy and Marines Corps rely upon.

Joint Force and Government

The Department of the Navy is committed to providing the right mix of capabilities and remaining dominant against threats defined in the National Defense Strategy. Across both Services and throughout the DON, PB24 will invest in capabilities for maritime dominance. Successful implementation of the concepts within the Navigation Plan and Force Design 2030 will be pursued through a unified, integrated effort at every echelon. But our fully integrated naval force is only part of the formidable Joint Force team that stands united in the protection of the American people. Collaboration between military departments and with the interagency is critical to the defense of the United States.

We are constantly seeking opportunities to maximize the combined efficiency and effectiveness of our Navy and Marine Corps in cooperation with the Army, Air Force, and Space Force. For example, we continue to work with our fellow Services on critical advanced research programs including hypersonic weapons. And worldwide, the Joint Strike Fighter program is yielding unprecedented reach and agility for the entire Joint Force.

The Department of the Navy, as a forward-deployed force, is a key contributor to Integrated Deterrence as our daily interactions with allies, partners, and potential adversaries impact diplomatic, economic, and intelligence equities in addition to the obvious military impacts.

Our most significant contribution as a military department is America's naval forces. The combat-credible forces of the Marine Corps and the Navy are unique as America's most timely, flexible, and forward-deployed force across the full spectrum of challenges—from naval diplomacy to strategic deterrence, resource competition, crisis, and conflict. Our allies and partners as well as our potential adversaries see these forces conducting forward operations and training, alongside partner nations. This constant forward presence engenders trust through episodic engagements as well as urgent response in the event of a national emergency.

The iconic presence of Marines in our embassies is just one highly visible way the Department of the Navy supports the State Department and whole-of-government activities. Behind the scenes, military attachés strengthen our bonds with international partners as they facilitate and coordinate activities, from small-scale personnel exchanges to large-scale multi-lateral military exercises.

Allies and Partners

Over the past 18 months, the Department of the Navy has been fully committed to the multi-phased, commitments-based process, known as the Australia—United Kingdom—United States Partnership (AUKUS) to facilitate the development of the optimal pathway for Australia's acquisition of conventionally-armed nuclear-powered submarines, which will contribute to maintaining peace and stability in the Indo-Pacific region by enhancing deterrence. As part of this initiative, Australian sailors will embed on U.S. SSNs and the U.S. Navy will increase SSN port visits to Australia beginning this year. Additionally, as early as 2027, the Navy plans to rotate up to four U.S. Virginia-class submarines to HMAS Stirling near Perth, an initiative we are calling "Submarine Rotational Force—West (SRF-W; "Surf West"). Beginning in the early 2030s, pending statutory authority, we intend to sell Australia at least three Virginia-class SSNs, and potentially an additional two more if needed. The AUKUS partners will begin delivering the trilaterally-developed SSN—AUKUS in the late 2030s. The cost sharing through the different phases of AUKUS will be fair, transparent, and proportional—with the United States and Australia

making investments to upgrade the U.S. submarine industrial base. We will continue to lead and advance this effort as directed by the President and Secretary of Defense.

As the world has seen over the last year with Russia's unprovoked and indefensible invasion of Ukraine, and the strengthened resolve and solidarity of NATO and like-minded nations around the world, the value of allies and partners cannot be overstated; the global landscape offers a stark contrast between those countries with strong international partnerships and those who are isolated due to their antithetical stance vis-à-vis the rules-based international order. Globally, we have strengthened our relationships with like-minded maritime nations, deepening interoperability in order to enable mutual action to address shared challenges.

As we emerged from the COVID pandemic and returned to our historic operating pace, we have looked for ways to expand cooperative deployments and operations around the world. Our recent growth in cooperative efforts with our partners has been focused on increasing interoperability and moving towards interchangeability with allied and partner maritime forces. In every international engagement, I have consistently heard the same message from our allies and partners: "We want to do more with the U.S. Navy and Marine Corps"—a signal that we are the partner of choice across the globe.

In January 2023, the United States and Japan reaffirmed the necessity to optimize our force posture and enhance response capability through a readjustment in the laydown of U.S. Forces in Japan. This will provide for stationing of the 12th Marine Littoral Regiment in Japan by 2025, and with it, advanced intelligence, surveillance, and reconnaissance capabilities as well as anti-ship and transportation capabilities.

In a demonstration of the capabilities and resolve of NATO, the USS George H.W. Bush Carrier Strike Group recently completed Exercise Neptune Strike 22.2., operating under the command of Striking Forces NATO (STRIKFORNATO), and flexing the capabilities of all-domain warfare at a critical time.

During the same period, we employed the USS Gerald R. Ford Carrier Strike Group for the first time with our NATO allies during Exercise Silent Wolverine. The exercise was designed to test the carrier's capabilities through integrated high-end naval warfare scenarios, leading to its inaugural deployment this year. The USS Kearsarge Amphibious Ready Group and 22 Marine Expeditionary Unit provided persistent presence in the Baltic Sea. This demonstration of capability exemplifies the unparalleled power of alliance and partnerships.

Last year, I personally witnessed the power of partnership during RIMPAC 2022, when forces from 26 nations from nearly every continent converged at Pearl Harbor. We came together as capable, adaptive partners, and declared our commitment to work together, to grow our collective capability, and to nurture and enhance relationships that are critical to ensuring the safety of the sea lanes and the security of the world's interconnected oceans.

Strengthening maritime dominance requires us to rapidly field the concepts and capabilities that create advantage relative to our pacing threat with the sustainment necessary to generate integrated, all-domain naval power.

Alongside our Filipino allies, Marines from 3rd Marine Littoral Regiment completed the largest iteration of Exercise Balikatan last April. This was the initial operational employment of 3rd Marine Littoral Regiment, and they used it to flex their capability to deploy from Hawaii and carry out amphibious landings in northern Luzon, ultimately enabling combined coastal defense training. This exercise not only strengthened the bond with our Filipino partners but tested small, distributed, and austere encampments, resulting in refinements of the concepts integral to the Marine Littoral Regiment.

This month, Marines and Sailors with the 31st Marine Expeditionary Unit completed the first Japan-based Iron Fist exercise, which increased interoperability and strengthened relationships between the DON and the Japan Self-Defense Forces, and demonstrated the commitment of U.S. and Japan forces to maintain a free and open Indo-Pacific.

Last November I had the chance to visit my Indian counterparts in an effort to drive forward high-end navy-to-navy cooperation to address challenges in the under-sea warfare domain. While we continue to advance thinking on concepts and technology, we are furthering our defense information sharing and exercising in ways that are relevant to our shared goals, as exemplified by the USS Ronald Reagan Carrier Strike Group's participation in Exercise Malabar with India, Australia, and Japan, and which included high-end tactical anti-submarine warfare.

While in Brazil, I had the privilege of presiding over the opening ceremony of the longest-running maritime exercise, UNITAS, and took the opportunity to spotlight the importance of partnerships in our own hemisphere and the Atlantic basin. It

was a particular honor to meet with the Cameroonian Head of Navy and visit his two ships, which had conducted their first-ever trans-Atlantic voyage in order to participate in the exercise. Their pride, determination, and dedication to being a part of this U.S.-led multinational exercise were evident as they celebrated this exceptional achievement. Strengthening our relationships across Africa and the Western Hemisphere is an important aspect of furthering the National Defense Strategy as the PRC endeavors to extend its influence over our neighbors and African partners.

One of the most significant detriments to local economies is illegal, unreported, and unregulated (IUU) fishing. I have been keenly interested in this complex challenge, and we are working with our partners across the globe to increase maritime domain awareness, information sharing, and information operations to counter this scourge. Massive fishing fleets from countries such as the PRC prey on countries with weak capabilities to protect their exclusive economic zones. Closely linked to the IUU fishing problem is a country's ability to effectively conduct maritime domain awareness.

As the Navy and Marine Corps team works tirelessly to ensure our forward presence, we are in an intense global competition with the PRC for strategic access and influence. That competition is particularly concentrated in the Indo-Pacific. To prevail, we will continue to innovate, leveraging our naval diplomacy to maximum advantage. Improving ports and enabling enhanced maritime patrolling capacity from modern airfields serves U.S. security interests as well as island nations' interests.

Combined, these critical enablers of U.S. influence, posture, and readiness in the Indo-Pacific are also the core components of the DoD's ability to deliver humanitarian assistance and disaster relief in the region as the catastrophic consequences of climate change accelerate. A resilient, distributed posture to meet our operational needs and outcompeting the PRC for strategic access and influence in the Indo-Pacific go hand in hand.

PB24 will strengthen global alliances and partnerships with funding for joint operations and exercises around the world, including CARAT, Malabar, and Balikatan in the Indo-Pacific; NATO operations in the Mediterranean; and exercises like UNITAS in our own hemisphere.

We will continue to foster opportunities for Sailors, Marines, and DON civilians to train, learn, and operate side-by-side with their counterparts in partner and allied forces. We will work on operationally integrating with our allies and partners through shared warfighting concepts, continually campaigning forward to deter adversaries and protect the rules-based international order.

Our Sailors, Marines and civilians are warrior-diplomats for our Nation. Their professionalism and dedication promote the connections that strengthen our collective security and cultivate shared ideals that send the message that the United States is a friend worth having.

CLOSING

The United States Navy and Marine Corps Team is on the front lines of defending the free and open rules-based international order against those who would cast us into a new dark age defined by the principle of "might makes right."

I have a sacred obligation to Congress and to the American people to ensure that our Navy and Marine Corps are always prepared to defend those liberties, those non-negotiable American values wherever the Nation's interests may be threatened. The Navy and Marine Corps remain, after all, this Nation's single most versatile instrument of national power.

For this, I am grateful for your sustained, bipartisan support of a strong Navy and Marine Corps. I look forward to working with old friends and new partners in Congress to advance the Nation's security with a Navy and Marine Corps supremely able, first and foremost, to deter all potential adversaries, and if called upon to fight and win our Nation's wars.

Senator TESTER. Thank you, Secretary Del Toro.

Next, we have, Admiral Gilday.

STATEMENT OF ADMIRAL MICHAEL M. GILDAY, CHIEF OF NAVAL OPERATIONS

Admiral GILDAY. Chairman Tester, Vice Chair Collins, distinguished Members of the Committee; Good morning, and thank you for the opportunity to appear today with Secretary Del Toro and General Berger.

For the past 77 years the United States Navy has been an anchor of world stability; deterring war, upholding international law, and assuring access to the seas. Today, our Navy's role has never been more expansive or consequential.

This past year, our Navy and Marine Corps team executed more than 22,000 steaming hours, and nearly one million flying hours. We participated in roughly 100 exercises with allies and partners across the globe, and at this moment we have nearly 100 ships at sea, reassuring America's allies and partners that we stand the watch alongside them, and reminding potential adversaries that we seek to preserve peace, but we are prepared for any fight.

The United States has always been a maritime Nation, to preserve our security and prosperity America needs a combat-credible Naval Force to project our interest in peace and to prevail in war, not just today, but for the long run. Our fiscal year 2024 budget request remains consistent with the Navy's enduring priorities.

And to your point, Mr. Chairman, about whether or not the taxpayers, are being consistent for the taxpayers in these investments, we are prioritizing readiness: First, with an emphasis on the sailors who empower everything that we do, ensuring that we are always combat ready.

Second, we are modernizing our capabilities, ensuring that our forces today stay combat-ready, now and into the future in a rapidly changing world.

Third, we are continuing to build our capacity ensuring that we have relevant lethal platforms to achieve warfighting advantage with a hybrid fleet of manned and unmanned platforms on, above, and below the sea.

Our budget request reflects the Navy's commitment to deliver, and deploy, and maintain our fleet. It fully funds the Columbia-class submarine, as the Secretary stated, ensuring the on-time delivery of the most survivable leg of our Nation's strategic deterrent triad. It keeps our fleet ready to fight tonight dedicating the resources necessary to train, and to educate resilient sailors that can out-think, that can out-decide, and that can out-fight any potential adversary.

It funds private and public sector ship maintenance to 100 percent, increasing capacity and retaining highly skilled labor to get our ships back to sea faster, with full magazines and spare parts in their store rooms, to be prepared for any contingency.

It invests in modernizing our fleet, procuring weapons with range and speed, along with integrated systems to improve fleet survivability in a resilient, cyber secure network infrastructure. And then invest in capable capacity, building towards a larger distributed hybrid fleet, fielding a ready fleet today while modernizing for the future.

Our competitors are investing heavily in warfighting capabilities of their own, and the oceans we are operating in are growing more lethal and more contested every single day. Failing to modernize to meet those threats would erode America's maritime superiority, at a time when the command of the seas will determine the balance of power for the rest of this century.

This means we can no longer afford to maintain ships designed for a bygone era, especially at the expense of readiness, moderniza-

tion, and new platforms, and buying new ships most relevant to today's fight.

America cannot afford a hollow force. We have been there before and we have seen tragic results. It is a mistake we must never repeat. Ships, submarines, and aircrafts are, no doubt, expensive instruments of national power, as are the costs of maintaining them. But history shows that without a powerful Navy the price tag could be much higher.

Thank you again for inviting me to testify. And I look forward to answering your questions.

[The statement follows:]

PREPARED STATEMENT OF ADMIRAL MICHAEL M. GILDAY

Chairman Tester, Ranking Member Collins, and distinguished members of the Committee, thank you for the opportunity to testify on the posture of the United States Navy. On behalf of every American Sailor, Navy civilian, and their families, thank you for your continued leadership and support.

With increased funding in the 2023 Defense Appropriations Act, Congress has provided the means for the U.S. Navy to deliver the fleet our Nation needs in support of the 2022 National Defense Strategy. This investment will help us turn the corner on readiness to meet strategic competitors in peace and war, ensuring our ability to maintain free and open oceans and the international rules-based order. Moreover, consistent, steady funding is necessary to provide a clear signal to our industry partners, especially our shipbuilders, on the way ahead. This statement will detail where we are—and what we must do—to ensure our maritime dominance deep into this century.

Flanked by two oceans, the United States has always been a maritime nation. The seas remain the lifeblood of our economy, our national security, and, consequently, our way of life. Our livelihood depends upon free, open, and secure maritime trade. A strong naval force is essential to U.S. national security and long-term economic health. The United States Navy has and will continue to serve as our Nation's primary instrument of sea control and power projection, ensuring our global maritime access during times of peace and war.

From our humble beginnings with six wooden frigates, the composition of the U.S. Navy has steadily evolved to defend U.S. interests around the world and ensure American security. For the past 247 years, the U.S. Navy has played a critical part in defending and advancing national policy. For the past 77 years, we have been an anchor of world stability by deterring war, upholding international law, and assuring access to the global maritime domain for our Nation, our Allies, and our partners.

Today, our Navy's role has never been more expansive or consequential. We now face challengers who are attempting to rewrite the rules-based international order and reshape the world to meet their autocratic desires. The People's Republic of China (PRC) has aggressively modernized its militaries and fielded offensive warfighting capabilities at unprecedented speed and scale across all domains. These developments are not solely to support regional designs.

They are for global ambitions. At the same time, Russia's unprovoked, full-scale invasion of Ukraine has triggered the largest conflict in Europe since the Second World War—with combat occurring on both land and sea. The future of the global order depends on the actions we take in this moment.

Our Fiscal Year 2024 budget request remains consistent with the Navy's priorities. To meet the challenges of today while building the fleet of tomorrow, our Navy continues to prioritize readiness first—with a special emphasis on the Sailors who empower everything we do. Next, we are focused on modernizing our capabilities. Then, we will continue to build the capacity of the fleet. Prioritized investments in people, technologies, and platforms ensure that we are ready to fight tonight, while making progress on the capabilities we need to maintain our combat credibility far into the future. To enable Distributed Maritime Operations (DMO), we must generate cost-effective capacity to achieve warfighting advantage with acceptable risk. We have already begun building the future fleet—a hybrid force enhanced by unmanned platforms operating on, above, and below the waterline.

NAVY'S UNIQUE PEACETIME MISSION

With the passage of the fiscal year 2023 National Defense Authorization Act, the United States Navy has a new mission statement. The old mission statement, articulated in Title 10 of U.S. Code, called for the Navy to be “organized, trained and equipped primarily for prompt and sustained combat.” Now, Congress has additionally charged the Navy with supporting “the peacetime promotion of the national security interests and prosperity of the United States.”

Though the mission statement is new, the mission is not. U.S. naval power has always played a unique and vital role in promoting our Nation’s security and prosperity during peacetime. The law now accurately reflects our Navy’s contributions throughout the history of our Republic.

Whether providing humanitarian assistance and disaster relief, countering sea-based illicit activity, safeguarding global shipping lanes, saving lives, or deterring conflict, Sailors advance U.S. interests every day. Constantly on call, our Sailors are forward deployed in submarines, ships, and aircraft, standing guard with our Allies and partners around the world. In part, the change to Title 10 acknowledges our historic mission and recognizes that peacetime activities can produce strategic results. However, the change does more than describe what the Navy has always done. It also highlights the need to build a healthy, ready naval force that will safeguard our Nation—one that is properly sized, equipped, and trained for the vast array of operations needed to preserve peace and prevail in competition, crisis, and conflict.

Of all the peacetime missions that promote security and prosperity, deterring conflict is foremost. Our Sailors are constantly present, operating, and training, often in parts of the world that may become hotspots. We are America’s away team, deployed in peace and ready to answer the call if we are needed in war.

During peacetime, the U.S. Navy must continue strengthening and expanding our network of Allies and partners. Whether in day-to-day competition, crisis, or conflict, Allies and partners add significant defense capabilities and resources. They provide integrated deterrence against adversaries by expanding access to maritime infrastructure through cost-effective, secure, reliable, and geographically distributed bases, and provide information in support of distributed operations.

Thanks to support from Congress, we are starting to rebuild our fleet following two decades of ground wars. Still, rebuilding will not happen overnight. It will require years of stable and predictable funding and a long-range plan that incentivizes our industry partners to invest in the infrastructure and capacity needed to support our growing fleet.

While most combat forces generally only meet in times of war, navies are in contact with potential adversaries every single day. We are forward deployed around the globe, sailing waters in close proximity to other navies, coast guards, and maritime militias, contesting threats to the rules-based international order and ensuring the world’s waterways are free and open for all. In this critical decade, the challenges we face are mounting.

THE MARITIME CHALLENGES TO U.S. NATIONAL SECURITY

The United States continues to face pacing, acute, and persistent challenges to our national security. Above all, our pacing challenge is the PRC. As we have witnessed over the past several decades, the PRC seeks to undermine U.S. alliances and security partnerships in the Indo-Pacific region, and leverage its growing capabilities, including its economic influence and the People’s Liberation Army’s (PLA) growing strength and military footprint, to coerce its neighbors and threaten their interests. In only two decades, the PRC has tripled the size of its Navy—and is on pace to quadruple to over 400 ships by 2030. Additionally, it has expanded its strategic nuclear capacity and capability, advanced its cyber and space capabilities, and constructed a system of sophisticated sensors and long-range precision weapons to intimidate neighbors, challenge free and open access to the seas, and hold U.S. forces at risk.

The PRC seeks to deny U.S. and allied forces access within the First Island Chain and beyond. Advances in missile technology by the People’s Liberation Army (PLA) Rocket Force have provided the PRC with the offensive means of striking U.S. and Allied forces. As the PRC has attempted to displace the U.S. Navy from the waters in the Western Pacific, the PLA Navy, alongside the People’s Armed Forces Maritime Militia (PAFMM) and China Coast Guard (CCG), has increasingly conducted aggressive operations—actions just short of war—to intimidate neighbors and force nations to submit to Chinese territorial claims. Through these “gray zone” operations, the PRC has staked illegal maritime claims to offshore resources that threaten the peace, prosperity, and ecological stability of the world’s oceans. Without ques-

tion, the PRC's investments in offensive warfighting systems—across all domains—are aimed at the heart of America's maritime power.

Russia remains an acute threat as its unprovoked war of aggression against Ukraine continues. Although the Kremlin predicted Ukraine would fall within days and NATO would fracture, the citizens of Ukraine have successfully contested Russian forces on land and sea, bolstered by the support of the United States and other like-minded nations. This conflict has reminded Russia, and would-be aggressors everywhere, of the power and importance of Allies and partners. Along with our Allies, we draw inspiration and strength from the tenacity and courage of the Ukrainian people, and we remain resolute in our responsibility to uphold the rules-based international order, and every nation's inherent right to freedom and self-determination.

In its most provocative year of missile launches ever, North Korea has been a persistent threat on the Korean Peninsula as it continues to expand its nuclear and missile capability to threaten the U.S. homeland, deployed U.S. forces, and the Republic of Korea (ROK) and Japan. With forces on the peninsula and vessels in the surrounding seas, the U.S. Navy and the Joint Force stand with our ROK Allies. During my visit to the ROK this past November, I confirmed that our alliance and friendship remain strong. We left no doubt that our commitment to extended deterrence for the Korean Peninsula is ironclad.

Iran, beyond its nuclear advancements, has been building and exporting missile systems and unmanned aircraft, most notably to support Russia's brutal campaign in Ukraine. All the while, Iran is advancing maritime capabilities that threaten maritime chokepoints, putting at risk the free flow of energy resources and international commerce. Further, Iran is undermining regional stability supporting terrorist groups and military proxies, employing its own paramilitary forces, engaging in military provocations, and conducting malicious cyber and information operations. Global terrorist groups have had their capabilities degraded, but some may be able to reconstitute them in short order, which will require monitoring indications and warning against this threat.

Whether they are pacing, acute, or persistent challengers, our adversaries are focused on acquiring sophisticated technologies that are changing the battlespace. From drone technologies to robust networks of sensors, our adversaries—both state- and non-state-sponsored—have the ability to harm our national interests in myriad ways. In the coming years, developments in new technologies such as artificial intelligence (AI), quantum computing, and additive manufacturing will continue to disrupt the way war is conducted.

CONTRIBUTIONS TO THE JOINT FORCE, NESTED IN THE NATIONAL DEFENSE STRATEGY

A combat-credible U.S. Navy—forward-deployed and integrated with all elements of national power—remains our Nation's most potent, flexible, and versatile instrument of military influence. Together with the U.S. Marine Corps and U.S. Coast Guard, our Navy must deploy forward and campaign with a ready, capable, combat-credible fleet. Decisive naval power is a critical component of the Joint Force.

This past July, I released an updated Navigation Plan, aligning our priorities of Readiness, Capabilities, and Capacity to the 2022 National Defense Strategy (NDS). The U.S. Navy remains committed to (1) strengthening our Nation's deterrence, (2) campaigning through forward presence, and (3) building enduring warfighting advantages. In this rapidly changing world, a formidable naval force is crucial in effectively implementing the NDS and the 2022 National Security Strategy (NSS). The Navy's FY24 budget request will deliver on our commitments to the Joint Force by aligning our planning, resources, and investments with national policy objectives:

Strengthening Deterrence. Integrated deterrence—the cornerstone of the 2022 NDS and a strategic focus of the 2022 NSS—is how the Department of Defense (DoD) aligns DoD's policies, investments, and activities to sustain and strengthen deterrence. It is tailored to specific competitors and coordinated to maximum effect inside and outside of the DoD. Integrated deterrence leverages the Joint Force's combined capabilities in all domains. It emphasizes a unity of effort throughout the U.S. Government as the Department of Defense (DoD) coordinates with and supports the State Department, Intelligence Community, and other government agencies. Additionally, integrated deterrence promotes the importance of working with our Allies and partners to uphold the international rules-based order throughout the globe. Neither the DoD nor the public sector holds a monopoly on delivering deterrent effects—thus, we must work with America's vast and innovative private sector to ensure peace.

A secure and reliable strategic nuclear deterrent backstops integrated deterrence. Our Navy operates and maintains the most survivable leg of the Nation's nuclear triad, representing approximately 70 percent of America's treaty-accountable, nu-

clear arsenal. Navy's FY24 budget requests the resources to replace the 14 *Ohio-class* submarines with the more capable *Columbia-class* and continue development of the second life extension of the TRIDENT II D5 missile, as well as refresh supporting infrastructure and modernize our nuclear command, control, and communications systems. Our *Ohio-class* submarines have been patrolling the oceans on deterrent missions for 42 years. This once-in-a-generation overhaul of our ballistic missile submarine force comes with a massive price tag, but it is a must-pay bill for the Nation so that we maintain America's assured second-strike capability.

In addition to our nuclear forces, our combat-credible conventional naval forces reinforce deterrence. These forces deploy globally to protect American interests across the spectrum of conflict. Operating far from U.S. shores, naval forces provide the first physical line of U.S. Homeland Defense, preventing potential adversaries from using the seas to threaten the American homeland. Naval Forces are the only element of national power that can fulfill this role.

To deter war, we must continue to work more seamlessly with our Allies and partners across all domains and by integrating key technologies and other instruments of national power. Among other initiatives, we have been working hard to bolster the trilateral security partnership of Australia, the United Kingdom, and the United States, known as AUKUS. AUKUS is a generational opportunity to reinforce the collective defense and prosperity of the United States and two vital Allies who always stand beside us. With the overarching objective of promoting peace and stability in the Indo-Pacific, through our efforts to enable Australia to acquire a conventionally-armed, nuclear-powered submarine capability, AUKUS provides a unique opportunity to strengthen the U.S. Submarine Industrial Base while enhancing two of our Allies' military capabilities. This trilateral security partnership also provides an opportunity to set a historic precedent in naval nuclear propulsion, setting the highest standards of nuclear nonproliferation. To successfully compete with the PRC and ensure a free and open Indo-Pacific region, we will continue to find ways to integrate our efforts with our robust network of Allies and partners.

The naval service's ability to control the seas and project power has underpinned America's national defense and economic vitality for generations. Sea control provides freedom of maneuver to the Joint Force and our Allies while denying it to our adversaries in conflict. Our ability to project power deters aggression by convincing rivals they have no viable means of achieving their objectives through force. Should conflict arise, forward deployed Sailors and Marines stand ready to fight alongside the rest of the Joint Force, our Allies, and our partners to deny enemy objectives, destroy enemy forces, and compel war termination.

Forward Presence and Campaigning. Naval forces provide the United States strategic advantages in position, influence, and flexibility, independent of access to overseas land bases. Our forward posture guarantees our Nation the ability to respond to crisis, blunt gray-zone activities, and preserve a stable and secure global maritime order. The Navy's global maneuverability supports diplomacy, reassures our Allies, and generates favorable influence and access in critical regions.

Alliances and partnerships remain the United States' greatest strategic advantage. Our Allies and partners recognize U.S. naval forces as their on-scene partner of choice for building combined maritime strength. In turn, the U.S. Navy recognizes the value of America's unmatched network. Having met with over 40 heads of navies around the world over the past year, I have witnessed the power of personal connections to bolster our collective strength. Relationships forged on the seas for over seven decades have been the bedrock of the free and open, international, rules-based order. And they will continue to be so.

Our adversaries do not have the same reinforcing strength and global backing that America shares with like-minded nations. In turn, the United States provides maritime power that no other country can. The U.S. Navy also brings to NATO an ability to assemble and further the interoperable naval combat power of Allies and partners and enable continued deterrence in response to Russia's war on Ukraine. We also leverage the strength of our allies and partners as part of our integrated deterrence of the PRC as well. We are constantly strengthening interoperability, sharing maritime domain awareness, and helping to build capacity for resilient, integrated logistics for our allies and partners.

Across the spectrum of conflict, the U.S. Navy operates forward, exposing and contesting malign activities of our adversaries. The U.S. Navy remains the partner of choice not just because of our strength, but also because of our respect for the rule of law.

Building Enduring Warfighting Advantages. To maintain our warfighting advantage at sea, America needs a larger and more capable Navy. Faced with competitors and emerging disruptive technologies, we must become more agile in developing and delivering our future force. Above all, our naval forces must be combat credible—

measured by our ability to deliver lethal effects in contested and persistently surveilled battlespaces.

In collaboration with the other U.S. Armed Services, we have prioritized the future capabilities we need to employ our warfighting concepts and maintain credible deterrence. As we build the future fleet, we group these critical capabilities into six overarching Force Design Imperatives, as I described in Navigation Plan 2022.

Expand Distance. Long-range precision fires across all domains and platforms with greater reach enable naval forces to strike hostile targets while increasing our own survivability.

Leverage Deception. Deceptive measures—including stealth, concealment and maneuver, emissions control, and electronic warfare—degrade enemy surveillance and increase adversary uncertainty, enabling naval forces to operate effectively in contested battlespaces.

Harden Defense. Integrating directed energy with hard-kill and soft-kill defensive systems disrupts attacks and keeps naval forces survivable when targeted by adversaries.

Increase Distribution. Distributing forces geographically and in all domains enables them to threaten an adversary from multiple attack axes. Smaller, lethal, and less costly platforms—including those manned, unmanned, and optionally manned—further complicate threat targeting, generate confusion, and impose dilemmas for our adversaries.

Ensure Delivery. Resilient logistics connecting the foundry to the fleet—enabled by secure communications and information technology—refuel, rearm, resupply, repair, and revive distributed naval forces down to the last tactical mile.

Generate Decision Advantage. Naval forces will out-sense, out-decide, and out-fight any adversary by accelerating our decision cycles with secure, survivable, and resilient networks, accurate data, and the assistance of AI-enabled decision aids. Connecting sensors, weapons, and decision-makers across all domains enables naval forces to mass firepower and influence without massing forces.

Together, these six Force Design Imperatives enable DMO and other Joint warfighting concepts. These imperatives also define the requirements for the surface, subsurface, aviation, and information platforms that our fleet needs and will guide our priority investments going forward.

U.S. NAVY PRIORITIES

Navy's FY24 budget request delivers a combat-credible Navy designed to deter and, if necessary, prevail in conflict. To deliver that fleet today, tomorrow, and in the future, we will continue to focus on three priorities: Readiness, Capabilities, and Capacity.

Our central challenge is balancing our investments in the future fleet while sustaining a forward posture that keeps America safe and prosperous. It is increasingly costly to operate and maintain our ships. We appreciate Congress' support with additional funding in FY23 to mitigate the effects of inflation. We will continue to need congressional support of the robust budget in FY24.

In today's fiscal environment, we face the enormous challenge of simultaneously recapitalizing our strategic nuclear deterrent, century-old dry dock facilities, and strategic sealift capacity, while investing in weapons and platforms we will need in a future fight. Our focus on Readiness, modernizing Capabilities, and building Capacity is a result of the threats facing our Nation today and the challenges we face in the decades to come. To defend our homeland and protect our national interests, we cannot field a fleet larger than we can sustain. Hollow fleets cannot fight tonight, and sacrificing current readiness for future capabilities or increased ship counts would severely constrain our Navy's ability to respond in crisis or conflict. Our Nation needs a larger, more capable, more lethal fleet—but we must build the future fleet at a sustainable rate; not at the expense of warfighters that must be ready to stand the watch tonight.

READINESS

Readiness remains our top priority. Forward-deployed, combat-credible forces deter conflict and protect the free and open system underpinning American security and prosperity.

Across the Navy, from our shipyards and aviation depots, to our global network of bases and stations, to the steaming and flying hours our Sailors need to hone their skills, we are focused on readiness. Our FY24 budget request dedicates the resources necessary to train and educate resilient Sailors that can out-think, out-decide, and out-fight any potential adversary. Today's security environment demands

ships, aircraft, and submarines, as well as expeditionary, information, and special warfare forces that are ready to fight and win.

The Navy is committed to accelerating our warfighting advantage by unleashing our people, and our “Get Real, Get Better” call to action empowers our warfighters to find and fix problems, and to innovate at every level, from the deckplates to our senior leaders. While our Navy team remains the most capable maritime force in the world, we have identified unacceptable variability in our performance. To address this, we must standardize and incentivize best practices, leadership behaviors, and problem-solving techniques throughout the force to reduce this variability and unleash our full potential. The essential element is fostering a healthy ecosystem—a culture—that assesses, corrects, and innovates better than the opposition, accelerating our warfighting advantage in this critical decade.

This past year, the Navy-Marine Corps team executed more than 22,000 steaming days and nearly one million flying hours. Additionally, the Navy participated in roughly 100 exercises with Allies and partners across the globe, strengthening America’s integrated deterrence. We are planning for similarly robust level of exercises and engagement efforts over the next year and in years ahead. As our naval forces remain in high demand, our budget request emphasizes critical aspects of our readiness. Our Sailors stand ready all over the world, from Sasebo to San Diego and from Norfolk to Naples, as our Navy keeps the oceans open and free.

Since the invasion of Ukraine, the Navy has had a continuous Carrier Strike Group presence in the Mediterranean, from the extended deployment of the USS Harry S. Truman (CVN 75), to the current deployment of the USS George H. W. Bush (CVN 77) Carrier Strike Group. Furthermore, the Navy provided early support to European Command operations with surge deployments of additional forces, to include six destroyers, two P-8 aircraft, two submarines, and a destroyer squadron staff. Our Sailors have been present where it matters, when it matters. Additionally, America’s first-in-class aircraft carrier USS Gerald R. Ford (CVN 78) returned to Naval Station Norfolk in November after successfully completing its inaugural deployment in the Atlantic, conducting exercises, strategic engagements, and port visits with Allies and partners.

We have deepened our integration with the U.S. Marine Corps with the establishment of Task Force 61/2 under Naval Forces Europe. This effort streamlined command and control of Navy and Marine Corps forces deployed to act as a deterrent and reinforce Alliance cohesion in the wake of Russia’s invasion of Ukraine. We operationalized this cohesion with the deployment of the USS Kearsarge (LHD 3) Amphibious Readiness Group (ARG) with the 22nd Marine Expeditionary Unit (MEU) embarked. After the USS Kearsarge ARG-MEU deployment, the same team provided the core U.S. military command element that quickly established humanitarian support for Türkiye after the recent earthquake, utilizing the USS Hershel “Woody” Williams (ESB 4) to deliver disaster relief supplies for those affected by the earthquakes.

To deliver forward presence and capability, our Navy continues to make progress improvements. For example, our aircraft depots are reducing the time it takes to conduct maintenance and return aircraft and engines back to the Fleet. Our PB24 request improves funding over FY23 enactment to sustain gains in our aircraft mission capable rates. Of note, in our aviation depot maintenance account, we increase funding for engines by \$25 million, \$9 million for components, and \$1 million for our Depot Readiness Initiative. The PB24 request provides for the operation, maintenance and training of nine active Navy Carrier Air Wings, with the necessary flight hours and maintenance efforts to ensure their carrier and expeditionary strike groups are combat ready. The budget request aligns with our broader focus across Naval Aviation to increase lethality and readiness through process improvement and finding efficiencies at all organizational levels. As aviation costs—across both the private and public sectors—continue to increase, the Navy recognizes the need to maintain a relentless drive to reap the full benefit of every investment dollar.

Better maintenance performance has been a point of emphasis across the Navy. Repeatedly deploying combat-credible forces starts with performing high-quality maintenance on time and in full. Data-driven reforms such as Performance-to-Plan (P2P), the Naval Sustainment System (NSS), and other initiatives continue to improve maintenance processes and increase operational availability. Over the last several years, the aviation community has enhanced readiness as we maintained over the threshold Mission Capable Rate for most Type-Model-Series Aircraft, including the F/A-18E/F, E/A-18G, E-2D, P-8A, MH-60R, and MH-60S. This represents a significant improvement in Navy aircraft readiness, but we are not yet satisfied. We are getting real and getting better at applying what we have learned in aviation to our maintenance processes across the fleet.

We continue to take a data-driven approach to improve surface ship and submarine maintenance, and we have seen positive results. However, unprecedented hiring challenges in a competitive job market, along with sustained, pandemic-induced delays and supply chain issues, have hampered progress for our public and private shipyards. Our budget request funds both private and public sector ship maintenance to 100 percent, with a focus on increasing capacity and retaining highly skilled labor at the public shipyards. On top of those resources, we have invested considerably in other requirements essential to the material condition of our Fleet. Completing maintenance for our *Virginia-class* submarines and returning them to the Fleet on time is a critical warfighting priority. To that end, we added \$541 million for *Virginia-class* materiel and spares to build depth and breadth in on-hand inventory to help ensure that the necessary parts are available when required during maintenance availabilities.

We remain committed to driving down costs wherever and whenever possible. In particular, P2P-driven improvements—such as the goal of awarding contracts 120 days before the start of a maintenance availability, level loading ports through better prediction of workload, better availability planning, and improved long-lead-time material acquisition—have provided effective solutions for readiness. Still, just like our industrial partners, our public shipyards face headwinds from workforce constraints, supply chain logjams, and increased costs due to inflation. We recognize the challenges, are not satisfied with current conditions, and will continue to invest in people, processes, and infrastructure to drive maintenance delays down to the only acceptable number—zero.

Today, the average age of U.S. naval shipyard facilities and related infrastructure is 62 years, while the average dry dock age is approaching 100 years. The Shipyard Infrastructure Optimization Program (SIOP) provides a strategic roadmap for necessary investments in our public shipyard dry docks, capital equipment, and facilities. We are committed to taking a holistic, analytic approach to our critical shore infrastructure, making necessary investments to overhaul and optimize our Nation's shipyards through SIOP, and ensuring our shore establishment can support fleet operations. With \$2.7 billion requested for SIOP in our budget request, the Navy can continue to upgrade and reconfigure our four public shipyards. This robust investment in the infrastructure and facilities of our four public shipyards is a vital effort to maintain and support upgrades of current and future submarines, aircraft carriers, and surface combatants.

When fully executed, SIOP will deliver required dry dock repairs and system upgrades that will optimize workflow within the shipyards through significant changes to their physical layout. Moreover, the SIOP investments allow the public shipyards to recapitalize industrial plant equipment with modern technology that will substantially increase productivity and worker safety. As a result of previous SIOP investments, we have already completed construction of the Super Flood Basin at Portsmouth Naval Shipyard, construction of the Norfolk Naval Shipyard Production Training Facility, and design of Pearl Harbor Naval Shipyard Dry Dock 3 Replacement. We remain committed to working with Congress, DoD leadership, the shipyard workforce, impacted communities, regulators, and industry leaders as we continue to drive down maintenance delays. We acknowledge that submarines are still experiencing an unacceptable amount of delay days. Still, these investments in our four public shipyards are rebuilding the industrial base we need to maintain, upgrade, and return our ships, submarines and aircraft carriers back where they belong—deployed at sea.

Maintenance delays and other readiness issues are not solely shipyard problems. To ensure fleet readiness, we must also reinforce and build resiliency into our supply chain. The Naval Sustainment System-Supply is driving end-to-end naval supply chain integration and reform as it streamlines the Navy's supply chains to increase readiness, decrease turn-around times, increase availability of spares, and reduce costs. The key to sustained success will come from the better use of data as we improve the resilience and responsiveness of the Naval Supply System.

Our Sailors—and the civilian workforce that supports the fleet—remain our most important weapon system. We must continue to evaluate and improve our capabilities to achieve our mission of attracting, developing, and managing talent to ensure our advantage at sea while providing exceptional service to our Sailors and their families. Notably, our budget request contains a substantial 5.2 percent pay raise for our military and civilians. From education and training to overall health and wellness, our budget invests in our Navy's most important asset—our people.

To ensure the readiness of every operational unit, we are working hard to resolve the manpower problems that exist in the fleet. The solution begins with more robust recruiting and retention efforts. We also need to keep honing and optimizing personnel readiness metrics to include the experience and proficiency of Sailors to de-

termine whether operational units are getting personnel with the right skills. The solution demands the continuous effort of leadership as we must continue to prioritize and care for our Sailors and Civilians.

The Navy continues the Fleet Training Wholeness initiative to integrate live platforms and simulators across our strike groups. This initiative funds Live, Virtual, and Constructive (LVC) training at the unit and strike group levels. In the fleet, LVC continues to be a game-changer in training our combat leaders. To date, fleet exercises like Large Scale Exercise-21 have connected eight Maritime Operations Centers, three Marine Force Operations Centers, eight Carrier and Expeditionary Strike Groups, and 30 ships into a single LVC training environment. As we look ahead to Large Scale Exercise-23, planned for August of this year, our expanding LVC capabilities will only increase the numbers of total participants—training both at-sea and pierside—in an advanced, global scenario. From the pilot in the cockpit to the technician on the radar scope, LVC initiatives allow warfighters in all domains to train together at unprecedented levels of integration and complexity.

Investments in training like the Ready Relevant Learning (RRL) initiative allow the Navy to continue to modernize Navy training and accelerate new delivery methods, supplementing our traditional brick-and-mortar schoolhouses with modern, multi-media, multi-platform solutions. In addition, RRL will develop Career-Long Learning Continuums for Navy ratings to map out technical, professional, and leadership training requirements for apprentice, journeyman, and master level milestones in a Sailor's career. Career-Long Learning Continuum efforts will change the paradigms of Navy training by delivering Navy Enlisted Classification refresher training, performance support at the point of need coupled with journeyman and master core training to close not only existing capability gaps, but also enhance fleet readiness.

To maintain a Fleet prepared to fight and win in long-term strategic competition, we continue to evaluate and improve our capability to attract, develop, and manage a talented and diverse workforce. Furthermore, at a time of intense talent competition and a rapidly evolving tactical and technical landscape, we are committed to modernizing and enhancing our entire talent management approach to recruit and retain the best and brightest. We are also reengineering advancement and assignment policies and practices to deliver a positive Sailor experience in terms of transparency, flexibility, and career-driven choice, while attempting to balance Sailor personal and professional desires with Navy priorities.

As part of this initiative, we released MyNavy Assignment (MNA)—an upgrade to our detailing platform providing visibility of all available billets as part of the Detailing Marketplace Assignment Policy (DMAP). MNA is a modern user interface providing Sailors the ability to bookmark billets of interest and provide amplifying information. DMAP continues to expand Sailors' options beyond the traditional enlisted career paths. It also rewards Sailors in sea-intensive ratings who stay on sea duty by offering assignment-based monetary incentives and early advancement opportunities for many Sailors who possess the requisite proficiency and experience. We expanded this practice and policy to supervisor positions through the Senior Enlisted Marketplace (SEM), beginning with Master Chief billets during FY 2024 advancement selection boards. We plan to expand to Senior Chief and Chief Petty Officer billets in the following 2 years to expand SEM to become the primary means of advancement.

To accelerate those Sailors with the highest competence and strongest record, we expanded the Advancement-to-Position (A2P) program to fill priority supervisor and journeyman-level billets in eight additional ratings. A2P assists in filling critical gaps and rewards proven performers willing to take a difficult assignment with a spot promotion. We have also empowered commanding officers and officers-in-charge to reward top performers with both an advancement and geographic stability allowed by a guaranteed follow-on three-year assignment at the same unit through the Command Advancement-to-Position program. These talent management initiatives support Sailor development, increase transparency, and generate Fleet-wide, warfighting readiness.

With great sadness, we recognize that suicide rates increased in 2022. Navy leaders and I have been traveling to ships, squadrons, and bases to listen, learn, and help. Every loss of life is a tragedy. As we continue to destigmatize mental health treatment, we are working to ensure every Member has access to the full continuum of mental health support. Our budget request expands mental health programs like Sailor Assistance and Intercept for Life, adds support for the 21st Century Sailor Office, and increases our Warrior Toughness Teams to help foster the mental, physical, and spiritual resilience of our forces. Along with these programs, we are working to ensure the availability of mental health and wellness support worldwide, including at specialty and primary care clinics, Navy installation counseling centers,

on the waterfront, embedded within the fleet, and via virtual health platforms. Navy Chaplains and deployed resiliency counselors provide confidential counseling and are essential in ensuring the spiritual readiness and resiliency of the Naval Force. The Navy's budget request continues to resource quality care for our Sailors and support services for them and their families.

Though we work in the profession of arms and accept the hazards that come with defending our country, all Sailors deserve to be treated with respect and dignity and should feel safe among their fellow shipmates. We are focused on creating a culture intolerant of sexual assault and are actively executing and evaluating the DoD Prevention Plan of Action. This is a comprehensive approach to promote prevention and reduce destructive personnel behaviors that lead to incidents. In addition, we are implementing the 82 Independent Review Commission (IRC) recommendations on accountability, prevention, climate, culture, and victim care. Sexual Assault Prevention and Response (SAPR) personnel remain fully available to Sailors worldwide to address victims' physical, mental, and emotional well-being, strengthen resilience, encourage reporting, and support victim recovery.

Moreover, we do not accept any form of sexual harassment in our Navy. To ensure Sailors are heard, and to remove actual or perceived bias from the process, Navy Sexual Harassment investigations are now conducted by an independent third party assigned from outside the command. Likewise, the establishment of the Navy's Office of Special Trial Counsel ensures that accountability for sexual assault and sexual harassment, among other serious offenses, will be handled by an independent, specialized, and expert cadre of professionals. We listen, and we continue to learn. Our work to eliminate sexual assaults and remove sexual harassment from our fleet is not done.

When Sailors are valued for their diverse talents and are treated with respect and dignity, they feel a sense of belonging to their teams and deliver a higher level of performance. With nearly 50 percent of recruitable talent coming from diverse populations, the Navy must be deliberate in advancing a culture where every person, regardless of their background, has the opportunity to succeed as a Sailor and where our Navy, in turn, benefits from our Sailors' talents, experiences, and insights. We have built on lessons learned from our findings in Task Force One Navy and have launched 53 Task Force One Navy initiatives, which remain on track for full implementation.

All of our most pressing challenges require strong leadership. However, in the past year, as required to support the Space Force and by the FY17 National Defense Authorization Act, the Navy reduced more than 8 percent of its Flag Officer billets. These leadership reductions

come at a high cost to maintaining operational readiness, impeding the Navy's efforts in an already challenging operational environment. At present, nearly one-third of the Navy's remaining 149 Flag Officer billets are double- or triple-hatted. These significant additional demands on leadership have ripple effects on readiness that negatively permeate across the fleet. To ensure our Navy can respond in crisis and win in conflict, we need Flag Officers with the focus and bandwidth to respond thoughtfully to the many challenges the Navy must navigate.

In the Navy, we serve as families. To improve the lives of our Sailors and their families, we continue to focus on improving the consistency of Sailor pay, quality of unaccompanied housing, and other quality of life services. This includes installing broadband Internet services and wireless connectivity, improving berthing barge living conditions, improving crew parking and transportation, and ensuring an overall better experience for Sailors on the waterfront. Access to high-quality childcare is critical to supporting our warfighters. Our budget request supports increased staff salaries and adds two new Child Development Centers. Funding will also support adding full-day pre-Kindergarten opportunities at overseas locations.

We know that to retain our Force of talented and trained Sailors we must continue to invest in ways that benefit them and their families, while providing environments that make them feel valued and enable them to serve honorably. Continued funding to improve the lives of Sailors will be our greatest return on investment. Our people form the keel of our fleet's readiness and they will inspire the next generation to answer our Nation's call to serve.

CAPABILITIES

The Navy's budget request makes substantial investments that will modernize our capabilities. The Navy prioritizes delivering capabilities that can achieve lethal and persistent effects inside adversary weapon engagement zones, generate advantages to create off-ramps in crisis, and decisively win should crisis escalate into conflict. As the challenges in this era require the support and unified effort of Allies and

partners, it is fundamental to our success that we develop compatible and complementary capabilities. To win now and in the future, we strive not only for interoperability with Allies and partners, but also for interchangeability across the combined force.

As we build and deploy a Navy capable of deterring and, if necessary, defeating a strategic competitor, we must prioritize capabilities for DMO—our Navy’s foundational operating concept for maintaining warfighting advantage in contested seas. The Navy’s budget request focuses on delivering these critical capabilities. To expand our reach, we are investing in hypersonic weapons, space-based capabilities, unmanned tanking, and long-range precision fires. For increased deception and defense, we are investing in undersea platforms, weapons, and systems, next-generation aircraft and surface platforms, cyber capabilities, counter-surveillance, and integrated weapons systems. Finally, we are investing in smaller, lethal platforms, autonomous systems in all domains, AI, resilient logistics, and integrated combat systems and networks, all of which enable a more distributed fleet, the delivery to sustain it, and expand our decision advantage.

Our adversaries are also heavily investing in emerging technologies. In response, the Navy will adopt a more agile approach to experimentation and force modernization, leveraging partnerships with industry and academia. Working closely with Allies and partners, we will expand our partnerships across the entire technology ecosystem. Maritime dominance has always depended upon the employment of game-changing capabilities in combat.

Rising to meet today’s challenges with unmatched capabilities, the Navy-Marine Corps combat team completed its first deployment of F-35C and CMV-22B this past year. The warfighting advantages these platforms bring to the battlespace provide the Joint Force with an undeniable, lethal edge over our adversaries. Both aircraft, though different mission sets, allow our forces to project power deep behind enemy lines. In addition, the USS Gerald R. Ford completed its first deployment. This aircraft carrier not only signals the next generation of our fleets’ principal weapon of power projection has arrived, but also that our nation remains poised and committed to maintaining our warfighting advantage for decades to come. Deploying such capabilities and platforms marks the culmination of many years and many people’s hard work, showing the capabilities that our Nation can bring to bear.

One of the key areas that is shaping and will continue to shape future warfare is the incorporation of cyber-warfare tools to detect and defeat adversary attempts to infiltrate and disrupt our warfighting systems. The Navy continues to make this a priority focus area to ensure our forces are ready to respond to adversary cyberattacks. In addition, the Navy is working closely with the Joint Force to develop cyber capabilities that can be used across the entire spectrum of conflict. As such, the Navy will continue moving from its current compliance-based cybersecurity approach to one where the right to operate is earned and managed every day. Teams organized around the Department’s recently-announced Cyber Ready effort will develop solutions, select tools, and produce methods, policies, guidance, and concepts of operation for instituting this new approach. A critical element to implementing this approach is the need to ensure the Navy has a skilled cyber-workforce comprised of both military and civilian cyber experts. To ensure the Navy has the cyber workforce the nation needs, and in alignment with Congressional intent, we are implementing a dedicated cyber designator. We remain committed to growing this capability alongside the Joint Force, as well as with our Allies and partners, collectively building a more robust security outlook.

In response to potential adversaries developing and fielding hypersonic missile systems, the Navy collaborated with the rest of the defense enterprise to make hypersonics one of our highest priority modernization efforts. This past year has been marked with certified successes for our Conventional Prompt Strike capability. In 2022, we conducted one First Stage and one Second Stage Solid Rocket Motor static fires, marking five successful static fire tests of the newly developed missile. In another joint effort, the Navy Strategic Systems Programs and the Army Hypersonic Project Office successfully conducted the second High Operational Tempo for Hypersonics flight campaign in October, 2022. These developments represent significant progress in our hypersonic capabilities, and both programs are on track to support the first fielding of a hypersonic capability to the Army later this year. Both the Army and the Navy programs are on track to support the first fielding of a hypersonic capability to the Army later this year. Stable funding at the requested level will keep this critical capability on track to field on Zumwalt-class DDGs, followed by *Virginia-class* SSNs equipped with the Virginia Payload Module. The rapid development and demonstration of conventional land and sea-based hypersonic strike weapon systems support our Nation’s ability to deter and, if nec-

essary, defeat potential strategic competitors. Modernizing capabilities will remain a priority to ensure our Navy maintains warfighting advantage.

Weapons with range and speed are critical capabilities. Our budget request pursues four multi-year procurement contracts for Advanced Medium Range Air-to-Air Missiles and Standard Missile-6 (SM-6). In addition, our request allows us to continue to work jointly with the Air Force in the procurement and production of Joint Air-to-Surface Standoff Missiles and Long Range Anti-Ship Missiles. We are also increasing our investments in Maritime Strike Tomahawks, as well as refreshing and recertifying existing Tomahawks and MK-48 Heavyweight Torpedoes.

Above the sea, we remain resolute in our commitment to the Joint Force in establishing air superiority in the maritime domain, and sustaining our unique ability to project power from the flight decks of our aircraft carriers. The Navy's PB24 request supports procurement of thirty-four aircraft, modification, spares and support equipment. In this budget, our significant aviation investments include 15 F-35C Lightning II's, 14 Multi-Engine Training Systems, 2 MQ-4 Tritons, and 3 MQ-25 Stingray II's. These advanced platforms are helping us drive down risk in our future carrier airwings, which will fully integrate unmanned carrier aviation. This past year, we completed MQ-25A aircraft in-flight refueling of Navy carrier-based aircraft and its first carrier demonstration. This unmanned aerial platform will complement the capability of our combat strike fighters and extend the range of our aircraft carriers.

We continue to make progress on the future technologies we need. This past year, we completed over 4000 hours and 46,000 nautical miles of unmanned surface vehicle operations. These unmanned systems, and others like them, will play a key role in building our capability to conduct DMO. To operationalize the Department's Unmanned Campaign Plan, we established Task Force 59, which has been a game-changer for the fleet. As we prioritize the Indo-Pacific and push warships to patrol those waters, we have leveraged unmanned surface vessels and achieved outstanding maritime domain awareness in a critical region with three major chokepoints—the Suez Canal, the Bab Al-Mandab, and the Strait of Hormuz—spanning a maritime area the size of California. This achievement provides the Navy with scalable solutions to monitor the world's waterways and keep the oceans open and free.

As AI and other disruptive technologies rapidly proliferate, we must proactively work to gain every advantage. Many of these rising technological developments play to our strengths as a nation. More sensors, providing more information, create more battlespace transparency. Our application of AI solutions will provide our forces with decision superiority as we map, measure, manage, and govern the battle space. We will continuously leverage such technological developments to better the fleet and our Sailors. While strengthening our Force, we must remain aware that no nation has a monopoly on innovation—and history has shown us the navy that continues to adapt, learn, and improve the fastest gains a strategic warfighting advantage.

To enhance our current and future hybrid fleet, we are maturing AI-enabled warfighting capabilities and developing an AI-ready workforce. This past year, Task Force 59 led and participated in International Maritime Exercise (IMX) 2022, the largest maritime AI and autonomous system exercise ever held. Along with this IMX, we executed Digital Horizon, an event exercising 15 advanced unmanned systems, 10 of which operated in the Middle East for the first time. Task Force 59 led industry partners during phased evolutions, both ashore and at sea, to advance fleet efforts to enhance regional maritime awareness with greater effectiveness and reduced cost.

Along with building testing platforms and driving operational concepts for the future fleet, Task Force 59 advances our understanding of commercial technology that has the potential to complement other government-sponsored AI procurement and operations. In support of these efforts, the Unmanned Task Force continues to focus on rapid experimentation and solving operational problems to quickly inform acquisition strategies. We also continued work with partners and Allies in events such as NATO Maritime Unmanned Systems Initiative Exercises.

CAPACITY

Congress's support of the Navy's shipbuilding budget this past year helped us signal our partners in industry—as well as our challengers around the world—that we will remain the world's strongest maritime power. Authorizing and appropriating the procurement of 12 battle force ships displays Congress' continued commitment to the Navy's shipbuilding programs. We appreciate the strong support by Congress

for naval shipbuilding during FY23 enactment. This year, our budget requests funding for procurement of an additional nine battle force ships.

With sustained funding, the Navy can turn the corner on beginning to build the fleet this Nation needs: a combat-credible, hybrid fleet capable of succeeding across the continuum of day-to-day competition, crisis, and conflict. We also need a fleet with the capacity to distribute assets and deliver larger volumes of kinetic and non-kinetic effects across all domains to meet the strategic and operational demands of the Joint Force.

The Navy's most critical role in support of our national defense and robust nuclear posture continues to be maintaining the most lethal ballistic missile submarines in the world. Thus, our number one acquisition priority remains the on-time delivery of the *Columbia-class* ballistic missile submarine. Originally designed for a 30-year service life, the first of the *Ohio-class* ballistic missile submarines will be retired in 2027 after 42 years of highly effective deterrent patrols. The *Columbia-class* will replace it as the Navy's contribution to the nuclear triad—which remains the most survivable leg of the U.S. strategic nuclear deterrent force. This is a once-in-a-generation investment, and sustaining our Nation's most secure and reliable strategic nuclear deterrent will require considerable resources. When the *Columbia-class* enters full-rate production in FY26, delivering the Nation's sea-based nuclear deterrent will consume nearly a quarter of the Navy's entire shipbuilding budget. The Navy's request funds the second *Columbia-class* submarine and delivery of the first vessel in FY28. Specifically, the *Columbia-class* program request of \$5.8 billion, includes the first of 2 years of incremental full funding for the second submarine, to be awarded in FY24. The budget request also includes continuing Integrated Enterprise Plan funding initiatives, material procurement for future boats, and continued funding for Submarine Industrial Base investments. The strategic significance of this platform requires the Navy and the Nation to dedicate the necessary resources to ensure its on-time delivery.

Shipbuilding remains critical to increasing our fleet's capacity, and requires significant investments from both the government, as included in the FY24 request, and the private sector. A combined commitment ensures healthy competition in the shipbuilding industrial base, which is vital to meeting Navy requirements in support of our national interests and defense of the homeland. With the help of Congress, the Navy and private shipbuilders are identifying opportunities to generate resiliency and productivity in the shipbuilding workforce. Part of the challenge of growing the fleet is having enough shipyards with the capacity and workforce to build the ships that we are budgeted.

The shipbuilding industrial base faces an increase in demand across the enterprise, particularly in nuclear ship construction. As the Navy ramps up production of the *Columbia-class*, we continue to procure two *Virginia-class* submarines per year. The *Virginia-class* submarine budget requests \$10.3 billion, or 32 percent of this appropriation, funding two Block V submarines and Advance Procurement for two FY 2025 and two FY 2026 submarines. Additionally, we continue production of the world's most capable, most lethal surface vessels. The *Ford-class* carrier program requests \$1.9 billion, and funds the seventh increment of funding for CVN 80, and the sixth increment of funding for CVN 81. As part of the surface combatant portfolio, our budget requests \$4.5 billion for two Arleigh Burke-class Destroyers as part of the FY23–FY27 multi-year procurement of modern Flight III Destroyers. We plan to award these destroyers this fiscal year. To support the building of our Constellation-class Frigates, our request includes \$2.2 billion for the fifth and sixth ships of this class. These investments ensure that we field a fleet that sails forward, keeps the oceans open, and ensures our maritime advantage on and below the seas.

To ensure that we can build the future submarines and aircraft carriers, we are taking steps to expand and strengthen the nuclear industrial base by investing in six key areas: shipbuilder infrastructure, supply chain capability/capacity, scaling new technologies, addressing workforce trade skill gaps and constraints, expanding productive capacity via strategic outsourcing of large scale fabrication, and government oversight of expanded industrial base efforts. In the Navy, any time we are splitting atoms, we know the work will be demanding, but these nuclear-powered platforms require our sustained commitment and continued support of the shipbuilders delivering these critical assets to the fleet.

Beyond these nuclear shipbuilding projects, we are working closely with private shipyards to strengthen the Surface Combatant Industrial Base and Frigate Industrial Base. A key focus has been on the Workforce Development investments that address risk in schedules, increase capability to meet future force structure, promote job creation and economic security, and address risk in single or fragile supply chains. Expanding the capabilities of suppliers and shipyard infrastructure in the surface ship industrial base results in greater industrial base stability, cost savings,

and improved efficiency as production increases to build greater quantities of surface combatants. These initiatives are paralleled by ongoing private sector investments to expand the nation's shipbuilding industrial base. We support any efforts to grow our capacity to build more ships annually. This is all part of a long-term commitment and clear signal to industry that the unique work done in our private shipyards is essential to the nation, and the workforce they provide will be gainfully employed for years to come. The Nation's shipbuilding industrial base remains a strategic asset. It requires continued support to expand its capacity, and to recruit and retain the workforce the Nation needs to deliver the fleet of tomorrow.

A robust munitions industrial base, capable of delivering critical munitions in large quantities and in strategically relevant timeframes, is also an essential component of our Nation's warfighting capacity. The rapid expenditure of munitions in Ukraine has demonstrated the timeless truth that industrial capacity is a key enabler of victory. Our budget request adds over \$2 billion in critical munitions investments, including supporting multi-year procurement contracts. We are working closely with our defense partners to make the necessary investments to allow us to rapidly ramp up production of critical munitions right now. We are taking a multi-pronged approach to introduce both stability and competition into the weapons acquisition process in order to accelerate delivery times, increase inventories, and lower costs. This includes use of multi-year contracts and large lot procurements, recertification of existing munitions, new production, and exploration of alternative systems designed to circumvent our adversaries' advantages and play to our strengths. We are also working with our partners and Allies to ensure their requirements are met, as well. Today's weapons are intricate, specialized, and depend on complex supply chains, which challenges our ability to quickly ramp up production. We cannot afford to wait until conflict begins to make these critical munitions capacity investments.

Unmanned systems will play an ever-increasing role in expanding the capacity and distribution of our fleet. We will explore opportunities to scale proven capabilities of unmanned Maritime Domain Awareness systems, such as those demonstrated by Task Force 59. In addition, the AI-enabled software that meshes our network of systems and platforms will provide an array of decision advantage solutions as we track forces, manage the battlespace, and maintain our dominance at sea. Finally, we must focus on accelerating the adoption of technologies and scalable platforms that provide increased capability and capacity, while laying the foundation for our future hybrid fleet.

CONCLUSION

The U.S. Navy's mission has never been more essential for the preservation of American security and prosperity. Facing increasingly aggressive challengers, the Navy's priorities—Readiness, Capabilities, Capacity—will help us maintain our combat credibility in contested seas.

In line with the NDS, the Navy's Fiscal Year 2024 budget request keeps us on a steady path to modernize U.S. naval power, while maintaining readiness and sustaining a forward posture that keeps America and our Allies safe and prosperous.

Capable ships, submarines, and aircraft are expensive instruments of national power, as are the costs of maintaining and sustaining them. However, without a ready, powerful Navy, the costs we incur in potential conflict could be much higher. The investments we make now will shape the global maritime balance of power for the rest of this century.

This is my final testimony before this Committee. It has been the honor of a lifetime serving as the Chief of Naval Operations these past three-plus years.

On behalf of more than 600,000 active and reserve Sailors and Navy Civilians, thank you for allowing me to testify today. I am grateful to this Committee and to your colleagues in Congress for your steadfast commitment to the Navy. Let us continue our work to deliver the Navy that this Nation deserves—a Navy that will preserve peace, strengthen prosperity, and defend America for many decades to come.

Senator TESTER. Thank you, Admiral Gilday.

Next up, we have got General Berger.

STATEMENT OF GENERAL DAVID H. BERGER, COMMANDANT OF THE UNITED STATES MARINE CORPS

General BERGER. Thank you. Three years ago,—it did a rapid change, and was required to meet our statutory missions and the mandates of the National Defense Strategy, and with the bipar-

tisan help of this committee and the support of my civilian leadership in the Pentagon. The Marine Corps Force Design is no longer a future aim point, it is today. It is a reality.

And in INDOPACOM (Indo-Pacific Command), for example, Task Force 76.3 creating advanced information webs to support Maritime Awareness, they took what they learned in experimentation, and turned it into kill webs during exercise in the Philippines and in Japan earlier this spring, right in the Chinese backyard. And the EUCOM (European Command) Task Force 61.2 found ways to create greater Air and Maritime Domain Awareness for the Sixth Fleet, focusing on Russian naval and air activities.

In CENTCOM (Central Command), General Kurilla has Marine Corps MQ-9s, providing persistent ISR (Intelligence, Surveillance, Reconnaissance) that he needs to monitor the key Maritime Terrain. Next month, our new Marine Littoral Regiment, Third MLR, will demonstrate some of its newest sensing and lethal capabilities in the Philippines during an exercise called Balikatan, right alongside our allies and partners.

And in January of this year, a couple months ago, Japan agreed to host our Second Marine Littoral Regiment, which is Twelfth MLR that will be forward into the first island chain, where persistent Marine Corps presence matters most. So in short, your Marines are aware it matters most today, just as they always have been.

Three years ago, I described how the Marine Corps would not just modernize quickly, but we would self-fund those changes we had to make. We would get leaner, lighter, and more naval. And in 3 short years your Marines have done just that. Marines are in the field, and those changes are in the field today, we are not waiting for 2025, or 2027, or 2030, your Marines are ready to handle any crisis, anywhere now.

Our major divestments are done. We are at our fighting weight. Now we have to sustain our modernization efforts while focusing, as the Secretary mentioned, on the quality of life issues most important to the Marines, Sailors, and the families. People are the real source of our competitive advantage. And I ask for your help now to invest in their quality of life.

We must focus now on where Marines and families live, where they eat, where they work, Marines and Sailors expect that from us, and they deserve it. Restoring and modernizing our infrastructure is directly tied to retention, supporting our families and generating readiness.

So on behalf of all Marines I ask for your support now as we bring our facilities up to par with the quality of Marines and Sailors operating from those warfighting platforms.

And I would also ask for your support to our Naval Expeditionary capability, the CNO (Chief of Naval Operations) and I agree on three key principles when it comes to amphibious ships. First, the absolute minimum of L-class amphibious ships the Nation needs is 31. That is the warfighting requirement. Second, block buys save money, and they give industry predictability. And third, divesting without replacing creates unacceptable risk.

Amphibious ships are critical to crisis response for this country. That is how we evacuated citizens, U.S. citizens out of Lebanon.

That is how the U.S. made initial entry into Afghanistan after 9/11, from the sea. And when DOD (Department of Defense) sends its life-saving support after hurricanes, and typhoons, and earthquakes around the world, and here in the U.S., amphibious ships with embarked Marines were the only practical option.

Today, we need to do all that plus directly contribute to campaigning in integrated deterrence. Here is the bottom line from where I see it, the first time we can't respond to an ally or partner in time of crisis it will probably be the last time they depend on us for help, and we cannot let those partnerships erode.

In my final year as commandant, I will finish by just saying thank you. Your Marine Corps wouldn't be where it is today without your oversight, your guidance, your unwavering support.

And with that, I welcome your questions. I look forward to working closely with this committee in the months to come. Thank you, sir.

[The statement follows:]

PREPARED STATEMENT OF GENERAL DAVID H. BERGER

Chair, Ranking Member, and distinguished members of the Committee, I am thankful for the opportunity to report the progress of your Marine Corps over the last year and seek your support in continuing to prepare the Service to face an increasingly uncertain and challenging future. I would be remiss, in my final year as Commandant, if I did not first acknowledge the unwavering support of this Committee over the last 3 years. Simply put, the Marine Corps of today is a better fighting force because of your guidance, commitment, and resourcing decisions. But there is still much work to be done. A brief review of world events over the past few years tells us we are moving in the right direction, but we cannot slow down. In fact, we need to accelerate our efforts so your Marine Corps can effectively deter while remaining ready to immediately respond to any crisis, anywhere on the globe, at any time. The work of this Committee is crucial to the modernization of the Marine Corps into a force that will continue to do just that.

POSTURE

Today, more than 32,000 Marines are forward-deployed or stationed across 50 countries. There are also, on average, 102 Marine Corps fixed-wing aircraft (F-35, F/A-18, and KC-130J) forward-deployed or stationed overseas, a 22 percent increase since 2018. This forward posture is a critical requirement for integrated deterrence and reinforces a national source of strategic advantage—our global network of allies and partners.

Most Marine forces west of the International Date Line are based in Japan. In January, the Government of Japan announced its intention to host the future 12th Marine Littoral Regiment (MLR). This unit will possess advanced intelligence, surveillance, and reconnaissance (ISR) capabilities as well as long range precision fires capabilities, improving both maritime domain awareness and our ability to deter potential adversaries. When combined with the other stand-in force capabilities of III Marine Expeditionary Force (MEF), 12th MLR will provide a major lethality upgrade for the fleet and joint force in the Indo-Pacific.

While our posture has become more robust in the Indo-Pacific, fewer of our forward-deployed Marines are serving afloat with the fleet. In 2018, 16,000 Marines served aboard ships, but in 2022, just 12,660 did so—a 20 percent decrease. The principal reason for this decline was the lack of amphibious warfare ship availability. As directed by the Fiscal Year 2023 (FY23) National Defense Authorization Act (NDAA), 10 LHA/LHD and 21 LPDs are the bare minimum necessary for our amphibious fleet. Additionally, in my best military judgment, the Marine Corps needs a minimum of seven Amphibious Ready Group/Marine Expeditionary Units (ARG/MEU), three MLRs, and 35 Medium Landing Ships (LSM) to provide a strong forward posture for building partnerships in the littorals and to contribute to integrated deterrence.

RESOURCES

The FY24 budget request for the Marine Corps is \$53.2 billion (B). To date, the Marine Corps has taken every possible opportunity to self-fund our modernization. This required hard choices and difficult, unpopular decisions. With the support of our civilian leadership in the Department of the Navy (DoN), Department of Defense (DoD), and Congress, from Presidential Budget 2020 (PB20) to PB23 this approach succeeded. Over the last five program objective memorandum (POM) cycles, the Marine Corps divested \$18.2B across the Future Years Defense Program (FYDP) in structure and legacy platforms and systems and has reinvested \$15.8B directly into modernization. The success of these divest-to-invest actions would not have been possible without the support of our civilian and Congressional leadership.

To be clear, the Marine Corps is now complete with our major divestments. Reducing the approved acquisition objectives (AAO) of major programs like the CH-53K or F-35 at this point would not produce resources for investment elsewhere and would be premature decisions. We approached FY24 as a program review year. Limiting the introduction of new programs in FY24 allows the Marine Corps to maintain or even accelerate progress on investments from preceding budget cycles that are directly tied to our pacing threat.

The suggestion that we may have to choose between preparing to fight tonight—which your Marines are fully prepared to do—and preparing for some distant point in the future presents a false dichotomy. Readiness, lethality, and modernization to meet future challenges are all required today. Our collective challenge is to balance the resource tension between the force we employ today and the development of the force to compete and win in the years to come.

WARFIGHTING READINESS

In many ways, Marine Corps readiness has improved since 2018. Our units have higher levels of persistent manning/staffing, more equipment and supplies, enhanced individualized training, and more collective training—much of it force-on-force. Our combat arms units are equipped with modern capabilities far superior to those of past formations. Yet, while many things have changed, the foundational elements have not. We remain the most elite infantry in the world, with the most proficient combined arms teams on the globe.

While there have been substantive readiness improvements across the force, nowhere have these improvements been more visible than in Marine aviation. Across all type/model/series of aircraft, our mission capable rate has increased from 57 percent in 2018 to 66 percent in 2023—an achievement that would not have been possible without Congressional support and the herculean efforts of Marine aviation mechanics and maintenance crews. We anticipate further improvements to aviation readiness as we retire older airframes (e.g., F/A-18 and CH-53E) and accelerate acquisition of newer platforms like the F-35B/C and CH-53K.

In 2018, we employed a lethal, though primarily fourth generation, tactical air (TACAIR) force of 173 F/A-18C/D and 126 AV-8B, with 72 fifth generation F-35B/Cs. Today, our TACAIR force is comprised of 174 F-35B/C and 178 fourth generation aircraft—a major step forward. Despite the challenges associated with transitioning the force from fourth to fifth generation aircraft, the overall readiness of our TACAIR fleet increased from 56 percent in 2018 to 68 percent in 2023.

We have also achieved significant gains in the readiness of our MV-22 fleet, rising from 52 percent in 2018 to 64 percent in 2023. The current challenges surrounding a series of hard clutch engagements caused each of the Services to take immediate action to replace certain transmission components in our V-22 fleets. That action is ongoing, and we expect to see a rebound in readiness this spring and summer.

Amphibious Combat Vehicle (ACV): The introduction of the ACV has the potential to greatly enhance our littoral mobility and expeditionary reach. However, as with all new systems and technologies, there have been a few notable challenges. At present, we are working with BAE Systems to address two major component issues—one with the struts/shock absorbers, and the other with the central tire inflation system. Both issues have caused part failures, resulting in a decrease in reliability and a corresponding decrease in readiness. We have also identified issues related to possible water incursion into the power train and are working with our industry partner to resolve those as well. In addition to these mechanical issues, we have experienced three incidents in the surf zone that resulted in vehicles rolling over. According to BAE Systems and confirmed by our safety investigations, these rollovers were caused by a lever effect generated when the vehicle becomes parallel to the surf-line and is struck by a large wave. These events were, in large part, the product of training shortfalls. We are actively working with BAE Systems to rectify

all mechanical concerns and are enhancing the training regimen for our vehicle operators on this new and more sophisticated amphibious vehicle.

F135 Engine: In both PB22 and PB23, Congress enacted funding to support F135 engine modernization. In addition to this funding, the Office of the Secretary of Defense (OSD) added significant resources for an engine core upgrade and for power and thermal management system (PTMS) modernization. We will continue to monitor the current F135 engine and F-35 PTMS's ability to support Block IV mission systems and will work with the Joint Program Office to ensure our requirements are being met.

Unmanned Aircraft System (UAS) Pilot Training: As an integral part of Force Design, we embarked along a path in late 2019 to double our uncrewed aircraft capacity across the force from three unmanned aerial vehicle squadrons (VMU) to six squadrons, while transitioning from the RQ-21 to the much more capable MQ-9. While our commitment to uncrewed systems is unshakeable, we have concluded the Air Force's capacity to generate trained MQ-9 UAS officers is insufficient to satisfy Marine Corps requirements. At present, half of our total inventory of UAS officers (72 of 148) are not yet trained and qualified to operate the MQ-9. We are working with the Air Force to remedy this throughput issue. However, there is a need to direct the necessary resources in future budgets to establish a Naval UAS School to resolve this larger joint force issue.

Pilot Readiness Concerns: Service Chiefs are routinely asked about how the joint force can effectively compete against the Department's pacing challenge—the People's Republic of China (PRC)—or our acute threat—Russia. But there is a different competition that is more directly and more adversely impacting the joint force than that emanating from either Russia or China, and that is the unhealthy competition between the Services and the airline industry. As the head of personnel for the Air Force stated during testimony in 2017, we cannot compete with the airlines. We could not then and we cannot now. This is an issue that requires your oversight. We are at a competitive disadvantage and risk our reservoir of pilots drying up. As an example, in 2018, the Marine Corps had 88 of the 203 required F-35 pilots (43 percent of the requirement). At the end of 2022, we had 218 of 498 F-35 pilots (44 percent of the requirement). At the end of 2022, we had 200 F-35 pilots in flight school and another 62 at our fleet replacement squadrons with FY23 and FY24 completion dates. We are making some progress, but not enough—and certainly not quickly enough. We are exploring various options for structuring aviation bonuses and aviation incentive pay under the new authorities granted in the FY23 NDAA. But ever-larger monetary incentives are neither sustainable nor the appropriate remedy. This is not just a Marine Corps problem. It is a joint force problem, and we will continue to work with the other services and Congress as our understanding of this issue develops.

FORCE DESIGN AND CURRENT OPERATIONS

There is a misperception by some that Force Design might create a gap in Marine Corps capabilities between divestment and fielding new capabilities. The reality is that fielding new capabilities associated with Force Design is already well underway. Many of these “future” capabilities tied to Force Design 2030 are already being employed by Marine forces today. Six examples from 2022 are illustrative:

TF 61.2 and Reconnaissance and Counter-reconnaissance: In March 2022, U.S. Sixth Fleet partnered with II MEF to create Task Force (TF) 61.2. TF 61.2 was designed as a joint task force crisis response capability to command and control naval forces supporting contingencies in Europe and Africa. This force was delegated tactical control of amphibious forces (ARG/MEU) in theater, allocated Marine forces (Marine Rotational Force—Europe), and a task organized reconnaissance/counter-reconnaissance force. Near simultaneously, II MEF and 2d Marine Division were tasked with “accelerating experimentation with maritime, multi-domain reconnaissance constructs and activities to enhance the ability of the stand-in force to dominate the information environment, sense and make sense of the situation, and win the reconnaissance vs. counter-reconnaissance competition.” Commander, Sixth Fleet, immediately volunteered TF 61.2 to support these broader Service experimentation efforts. During the next several weeks, TF 61.2 conducted training aboard both the USS Woody Williams (ESB-4) and USS Georgia (SSGN-729), and engaged in combined-arms training in both Greece and Turkey. Those initial exercises demonstrated that maritime expeditionary forces could increase surface, subsurface, and aerial domain awareness for the fleet commander—regardless of theater—and allowed us to focus on the information web required to create domain awareness in a contested space. TF 61.2 then transitioned these experimental capabilities to the Baltics, where it participated in bilateral training on maritime domain awareness

with the Estonian Navy in the Gulf of Finland. During this period, TF 61.2 participated in an amphibious landing in Estonia and Exercise BALTOPS with 16 North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) nations, utilizing 47 ships and 7,000 personnel. This new organization has been so successful the previous Commander, U.S. European Command (EUCOM) chose to highlight the value of the task force during his spring 2022 annual testimony. The bottom line is that your Marines' ability to conduct reconnaissance and counter-reconnaissance is a current force capability that directly contributes to competition and deterrence today.

TF 76.3: Building upon the success of TF 61.2, in October 2022, the 3d Marine Expeditionary Brigade and Naval Task Force 76 staffs merged into a completely integrated naval task force in the Indo-Pacific. Over the next several months, TF 76.3 experimented with naval concepts at sea and ashore via a broad campaign of learning labeled NOBLE FUSION 22.2. TF 76.3 also participated in exercises KAMANDANG in the Philippines and RESOLUTE DRAGON in Japan. Once again, Marines and Sailors demonstrated the ability to create advanced information webs to support maritime domain awareness across the theater. Just as importantly, they demonstrated this capability to potential adversaries.

USS Tripoli: The most recent deployment of the USS *Tripoli* (LHA-7) demonstrated the strategic and operational advantage that amphibious warfare ships create today. In early 2022, *Tripoli* set sail as an independent deployment, in part to test our F-35B "Lightning Carrier/Assault Carrier" concept by which 16-24 F-35Bs were embarked and operated in concert with a traditional carrier strike group. During *Tripoli's* time in the Indo-Pacific, embarked Marines and Sailors trained with and supported the USS *Abraham Lincoln* (CVN-72) and USS *Ronald Reagan* (CVN-76), among other traditional surface combatants. Not only did the deployment illustrate the potency of the Lightning Carrier concept in support of carrier strike group operations, it also demonstrated the versatility and value of the platform for the integrated Navy-Marine Corps team. During Exercise VALLANT SHIELD 2022, the Commander of U.S. Seventh Fleet, Vice Admiral (VADM) Karl Thomas, embarked his staff aboard the *Tripoli* and used it as his command platform for 15 days—a strong endorsement of the platform's importance within the larger fleet. VADM Thomas noted, "One day you can have F-35Bs on the flight deck, the next day you could have MV-22s and you can be putting Marines ashore. . . it just is a very versatile instrument . . . [with] 14 5th-gen fighters on board—it's an incredibly capable sensor."

The LHA's size, which closely mirrors the amphibious warfare ships of our allies, makes it an attractive partnership and learning platform. During their deployment, Marines and Sailors from *Tripoli* and the 31st MEU trained with forces from Japan, Australia, the Philippines, and Singapore.

Multifunction Air Operations Center (MAOC): In March 2022, 2d Marine Aircraft Wing (MAW) conducted the Service's first operational deployment of a multi-function air operations center (MAOC). In Lithuania, under the command of U.S. Air Forces Europe, the MAOC conducted air surveillance and multi-domain awareness in support of NATO operations. This is not simply an evolutionary step in fixed aviation command and control (C2) nodes, but rather, a transformational, expeditionary capability that can serve as a hub for Marine Corps, naval, and joint kill chains and webs. The MAOC provides the Marine Corps with the capability to control aircraft and missiles, and enables decision superiority. It also offers the ability to gain and maintain custody of adversary targets and hold those targets at risk via fires with its organic TPS-80 Ground/Air Task-Oriented Radar (G/ATOR), Common Aviation Command and Control System (CAC2S), and highly proficient aviation C2 Marines. The MAOC is scalable by task-organized units, small enough to support distributed teams or large enough to support a multi-MEF or Corps-level fight. This agency construct is also the model we are using for the development of all-domain C2. 3d MAW is now leading the Service's MAOC experimentation efforts and employed this capability as part of Marine Rotational Force—Darwin (MRF-D), integrating C2 and sensor services for 16 allied and partner nations during Exercise PITCH BLACK. From these initial efforts, 3d MAW has matured the MAOC, creating a persistent hub to enhance the common tactical picture for I and III MEF. Recent experiments in February 2023, which included U.S. Indo-Pacific Command (USINDOPACOM), have further demonstrated the MAOC's ability to integrate additional capabilities from the MEF Information Group and improve the common tactical picture for a carrier strike group, and is visible evidence of Joint All-Domain Command and Control (JADC2) in practice.

Marine Corps Information Command (MCIC): In October 2022, we streamlined and simplified much of the coordination required for space and cyberspace operations at the headquarters level, by realigning current relationships and structure at Headquarters, Marine Corps (HQMC) from a staff officer to an operational com-

mander, to create the MCIC. The MCIC is a service-retained command designed to integrate global Marine Corps capabilities in information, intelligence, cyberspace, and space to support Fleet Marine Forces (FMF) resulting in decision advantage. This two-star command operates under Marine Forces Command (MARFORCOM) and provides critical linkages across operational level planning. It also provides task organized detachments to support the FMF commander's campaigning objectives. This allows the commander to leverage the authorities needed to synchronize global cyber, space, influence, and intelligence effects and generate multi-domain advantages in support of the commander's objectives. The MCIC achieved initial operational capability (IOC) in January 2023.

VMGR-153 and HMM-461: In January 2023, we activated Marine Aerial Refueler Transport Squadron 153 (VMGR-153) in Kaneohe Bay, Hawaii. By 2026, VMGR-153 will bring 15 KC-130J aircraft to the region, building on the organic mobility available to Marines responding to crisis or conflict in the region. We are also approaching 1 year since the CH-53K program achieved IOC and are well underway transitioning Marine Heavy Helicopter Squadron 461 (HMM-461) into our first fully operational CH-53K squadron. Despite their ongoing transition, HMM-461 is already demonstrating the significant impact of this new capability, conducting heavy lift assault support missions previously impossible with legacy aircraft. In parallel, the operational test and evaluation squadron (VMX-1) continues to push the boundaries of heavy lift operations. Last December, they successfully lifted an F-35C, demonstrating the platform's utility in conducting next generation tactical recovery missions.

FORCE DESIGN AND THE GROUND COMBAT ELEMENT (GCE)

Infantry Battalion Experiment (IBX): IBX is an ongoing Service-level initiative designed to evaluate the future infantry battalion's ability to conduct expeditionary, offensive, and defensive operations as an element of a MEU, MLR, or infantry regiment in support of fleet and joint operations. The results of IBX live-force experimentation represent a critical component of our campaign of learning and are one of several inputs informing our ongoing assessment of the future infantry battalion.

After 24 months of experimentations and force-on-force exercises with three infantry battalions, our combat developers, division commanders, and MEF commanders recommended an 811-person infantry battalion. This new battalion demonstrated improved C2, sensing, and lethality. Importantly, this recommendation reflects the value of our campaign of learning. In 2019, we experimented with a 735-person battalion. But force-on-force experimentation made clear our initial assumptions were off. It also demonstrated a need for additional ground ISR and indirect fires capacity. In line with these findings, we right-sized personnel, added back indirect fires capacity, and added organic UAS platforms and personnel to improve surveillance and target acquisition. Future infantry battalions will possess Block IV Javelins at the company-level to increase anti-armor capability and will have loitering munitions (organic precision fires (OPF)) at the squad and platoon levels to increase lethality, enhance maneuver, and facilitate distributed operations. They will have additional communications, logistics, and intelligence capabilities at the company-level, and new signals intelligence and electromagnetic warfare capabilities at both the battalion and company levels. They will possess vehicle-mounted and canister-launched OPF at the company and battalion level to enhance the lethality, multi-domain awareness, and reach of those units, and will have improved C2 systems at the company-level. But our learning never stops. We will build from past efforts and conduct another round of experiments with two additional battalions this year. These experiments will evaluate the new infantry battalion design against a peer adversary, with the aim of further refining its structure and capabilities to the demands of the modern battlefield. We will also begin incorporating our lessons learned into FMF battalions not directly involved in IBX later this year.

Close Combat Lethality: In 2018, former Secretary of Defense James Mattis convened the Close Combat Lethality Task Force (CCLTF). As we approach 5 years since that effort was launched, we should take stock of its significant impact. The CCLTF's insights have been instrumental in informing the ongoing transformation within our infantry formations, the most visible of which being the success of the Multi-purpose Anti-armor Anti-personnel Weapon System (MAAWS). It provides a multiple-effects rocket system to infantry and combat engineer squads to increase firepower and enhance their ability to close with and destroy the enemy. The MAAWS is a medium-range, multi-purpose, man-portable, line-of-sight, reloadable, recoilless, day/night, anti-armor, and anti-personnel weapon system with an available suite of 84mm rockets. MAAWS munitions will be capable of obscuration, illumination, personnel denial, armored vehicle denial and penetration, bunker and

hardened facility penetration, and soft target destruction capabilities. Every rifle squad, combat engineer squad, and Marine Special Operations Command (MARSOC) team will be equipped with one MAAWS. Fielding began in the 3d quarter (3Q) of FY21 and will be complete in 3QFY25.

The Marine Corps has also fielded lightweight body armor including a new plate carrier (PC Gen 3), and an enhanced combat helmet—all of which address the significant weight of the individual Marine's combat load so well documented from operations in Iraq and Afghanistan. In addition, new night vision devices (AN/PVS-31A) have enhanced night movement and weapons lethality for our infantry, improving their situational awareness and ability to acquire targets. The MAAWS, Squad Common Optic, M27 squad automatic rifle, M17 pistol, and Mk13 and Mk22 precision rifles have all increased organic lethality within our small units. Multi-domain sensing and targeting is being addressed with a new signals intelligence/electromagnetic warfare (SI/EW) program called Marine Electromagnetic Ground Family of Systems (MEGFoS). This SI/EW suite of equipment, crewed by dedicated SI/EW and cyberspace personnel, will be employed in the future infantry battalion, greatly enhancing tactical level target identification and engagement. All these capability enhancements make our squads and platoons more lethal.

3d MLR and 12th MLR: On 3 March 2022, we activated 3d MLR and it is on track to achieve IOC this year. 3d MLR has an established littoral combat team (LCT), combat logistics battalion (CLB), and littoral anti-air battalion (LAAB), all of which have been exercising in operations, activities, and investment events in the Indo-Pacific region. 3d MLR continues to operate in coordination with the Naval Surface Group Middle Pacific (NAVSURFGRU MIDPAC) to further develop its maritime fires capabilities, and most recently, deployed to Marine Air-Ground Task Force—Training Command (MAGTF—TC) to execute the first Service-level MLR training exercise. This exercise focused on the MLR's ability to sense and make sense of the operating environment and rapidly close kill chains. 3d MLR is designed to be a stand-in force, but it is not the Service's sole stand-in force. Rather, it is one part of the larger III MEF system of stand-in forces that includes our forward deployed naval force, as well as other expeditionary capabilities including the F-35B/C.

We are on track to activate 12th MLR by 2025. The Government of Japan and Secretary Austin recently announced that 12th MLR will be forward stationed on Okinawa to create greater maritime domain awareness and enhance our collective ability to deter in the region. As Secretary Austin stated during the announcement, "We will equip this new formation with advanced intelligence, surveillance, and reconnaissance, as well as anti-ship and transportation capabilities that are relevant to the current and future threat environments." 12th MLR's presence and capability suite will augment our existing stand-in force capacity in the first island chain.

These littoral regiments provide the joint force two essential capabilities. First, they serve as eyes and ears of the joint force—meaning their persistent, forward, and distributed posture enables the joint force to reach well inside of weapons engagement zones. Second, they provide decision space and time for the other joint forces to deploy, while maintaining continuous maritime domain awareness.

FORCE DESIGN EMERGING CAPABILITIES

In addition to current operations that demonstrate Force Design in action today, a number of emerging capabilities on the horizon will increase the Marine Corps' ability to enable full-spectrum operations for the Joint Force in contested environments.

Unmanned Logistics System-Aerial (ULS-A): As the ongoing conflict in Ukraine has illustrated, even traditional ground resupply, executed over interior lines and relatively short distances, can be disrupted with operational level effects. Consistent with these lessons, the Marine Corps is developing the ULS-A Small or Tactical Resupply Unmanned Aircraft System (TRUAS). The TRUAS has a 9-mile range and maximum payload of 150 pounds, which is sufficient to fly in ammunition, food, medical supplies, and batteries, among other supplies. This small system only requires two Marines to operate and will be a game-changing capability for our distributed forces. The TRUAS is anticipated to achieve IOC in 2023 with fielding completed in 2027. Fielding this capability is critical toward setting conditions for the development of the ULS-A Medium system, which is the required capability for large-scale tactical distribution in a contested space. The emerging ULS-A Medium will be fielded in 2025 and will provide payloads between 300 and 600lbs with a range of up to 100 miles.

Marine Air Defense Integrated System (MADIS): MADIS is an expeditionary, upgradable, and state-of-the-art capability to protect maneuver forces, installations,

and other designated critical assets from fixed/rotary wing (FW/RW) aircraft and Group 1–3 UAS. It uses sensor-integrated C2 to provide beyond line-of-sight cueing, targeting, and engagement. Current air defense capabilities only defend against FW/RW targets and Group 3 UAS within line of sight. The MADIS is composed of a complementary pair of Joint Light Tactical Vehicles (JLTV). The Mk1 JLTV is designed to kill FW/RW variants with a turret-mounted 30mm cannon, Stinger missiles, and an electromagnetic warfare (EW) jammer. The Mk 2 JLTV provides redundant, non-kinetic and kinetic fires while primarily employing C2 software and sensors to collect, interpret, and pass radar tracks to the Mk 1 via a wireless local network for target engagements. The AAO is 131 systems comprised of 262 vehicles; the FY24 budget request provides for 13 MADIS (26 vehicles). We will achieve IOC in 4QFY24 with the delivery of 17 systems, and we anticipate reaching full operational capability (FOC) in FY31. The FY24 budget request for the MADIS family of systems is \$265 million (M).

Medium Range Intercept Capability (MRIC): The MRIC defends forward-deployed forces against the threat of cruise missiles and other aerial threats with similar flight profiles. This is accomplished through the integration of already-fielded Marine Corps and Israeli systems that include CAC2S, the TPS-80 G/ATOR, the Iron Dome Battle Management Controller, and the Tamir missile and guidance uplink. Each MEF will be fielded with one MRIC battery. A battery is comprised of a headquarters element and four independently deployable firing platoons. To date, there have been four successful live fire events: August 2019, November–December 2021, April–June 2022, and September 2022. Each live fire successfully demonstrated the destruction of multiple operationally challenging missile threats. The Service's FY24 budget request is for \$44 million.

Navy-Marine Expeditionary Ship Interdiction System (NMESIS): The Marine Corps is transitioning the majority of its existing lightweight 155mm towed artillery batteries into medium-range missile (MMSL) batteries equipped with NMESIS to conduct anti-surface warfare operations as a component of an integrated naval force. By 2030, the Marine Corps will have 14 MMSL batteries: three batteries forward deployed in support of MLRs and 11 continental U.S. (CONUS)-based batteries supporting the rotational and MEU deployments. The program will enter low-rate initial production (LRIP) in 3QFY23. The first six operational launchers will be fielded to MMSL Battery, 3d MLR in 4QFY23 to give the Service its first capability to contribute to sea denial and sea control operations with ground based anti-ship missile (GBASM) fires. We anticipate reaching IOC in FY25 after fielding five MMSL batteries and a MMSL battalion headquarters. We anticipate reaching FOC in FY30 when all 14 MMSL batteries have been fielded. The Service's FY24 budget request for \$402 million supports procurement of 24 NMESIS launchers and associated equipment, and 90 Naval Strike Missiles (NSM) keeping the program on track to reach 774 NSM. The 774 NSMs provide one combat load plus one combat load resupply per deployed MMSL unit.

Long-Range Fires (LRF): OSD directed the Marine Corps to develop and field a ground-launched Tomahawk Land Attack Missile (TLAM) capability to support joint force long range, precision fires requirements. The LRF weapons system is composed of a Remotely Operated Ground Unit for Expeditionary (ROGUE) Fires leader kit, LRF launcher, LRF C2 System (LC2S), and LRF Reload and Resupply System (LRRS). All four components are required to complete a full mission of loading, transporting, and firing a Tomahawk missile. This capability leverages existing Navy and Marine Corps hardware and software such as the Mk41 Vertical Launch System, Tactical Tomahawk Weapon Control System, Tomahawk cruise missile, and JLTV to reduce risk by accelerating capability delivery to the FMF and combatant commanders. The current plan is to establish three 16-launcher, long range missile (LMSL) batteries to form one LMSL battalion capable of deploying one battery at a time by 2030. The first four operational launchers are scheduled to be fielded during 4QFY24. Remaining batteries are planned for activation between FY26 and FY28. OSD provided \$1.2B in research, development, testing, and evaluation (RDT&E) and Procurement Marine Corps (PMC) funding through FY26 to support the development and procurement of 56 LRF launchers, C2 and support equipment, and 152 Tomahawk (TLAM and MST) missiles. The FY24 budget request for LRF is \$142 million.

RESEARCH, DEVELOPMENT, TEST & EVALUATION (RDT&E)

This year, we will invest heavily in the next generation of RDT&E efforts. We are placing an emphasis on the future of Marine aviation, JADC2, persistent sensing, and contested logistics, while expanding our experimentation efforts. With the support of the Office of the Under Secretary of Defense for Research and Engineering's

Joint Capability Technology Demonstration office, we will begin the Long-Range Attack Munition (LRAM) project, to rapidly develop and field a low-cost, air launched, family of loitering and swarming munitions. The LRAM can be employed by not just H-1s and F-35s, but also palletized and employed from MV-22s, CH-53Ks, and C-130s, thereby significantly expanding our magazine depth. Likewise, we have moved out in earnest on experimentation with our capstone research and development effort, the family of integrated targeting cells (FITC). FITC accelerates the evolution of combined arms to a new level. It fuses operations, intelligence, and fires functions together in one center and creates the means by which the Marine Corps will be able to participate in and control joint fires, while also gaining and maintaining persistent custody of adversary targets. We will also expand our ground launched loitering munitions capabilities by demonstrating a common launcher for the family of munitions, and we continue testing a low-cost, hypersonic booster that will be in a form factor the Marine Corps can logistically support in a contested environment. For maritime mobility, we are also investing in our first Stern Landing Vessel (SLV) prototypes, which are helping buy down risk and advance the Medium Landing Ship (LSM) program. We will continue efforts to develop a medium-sized, uncrewed logistics aircraft and will begin small boat experimentation to determine the future of our surface reconnaissance capabilities.

FORCE DESIGN EXPERIMENTATION IN SUPPORT OF CONTESTED LOGISTICS

The Marine Corps Warfighting Laboratory, in close collaboration with both the Navy and III MEF, is currently experimenting with more than a dozen new technologies and potential future capabilities focused on enabling logistics in a contested environment. These operational experiments include well-known capabilities such as the SLV and wing-in-ground-effect (WIG) craft, as well as lesser-known, emerging capabilities such as the autonomous low-profile vessel (ALPV). Based on our existing experimentation plans, operational experimentation with these and other capabilities will continue over the next 3 years and inform future capability investment decisions.

FORCE DESIGN EXPERIMENTATION WITH LITTORAL MOBILITY

Mobility is a key characteristic to the dispersion and persistence of stand-in forces. In the case of the Indo-Pacific, littoral mobility will be essential to our ability to maneuver through the complex geography of the region. We recognized this capability gap early in the design process and identified the LSM as a mechanism to transport Marines in this unique maritime environment.

Medium Landing Ship (LSM): Distinct, yet complementary to traditional L-Class amphibious warfare ships, the LSM is purpose-built to provide tactical maneuver for regimental sized units, forward-deployed naval forces, and other expeditionary advanced base-enabling forces operating within contested environments. The LSM is a maneuver asset, and as a shore-to-shore connector, is unique and critical to expeditionary littoral mobility. It will facilitate campaigning and support diverse missions such as security cooperation, humanitarian assistance/disaster relief (HA/DR), and logistics support. While not optimized for any one threat or region, we envision the LSM being of particular utility in the maritime gray zone contests omnipresent in the Indo-Pacific. Given its size and characteristics, this vessel could be employed with a lower risk of escalation than larger platforms.

After extensive research and wargaming, we calculated a need for nine LSMs to support a single regimental sized unit. The DoN's Amphibious Force Requirements Study over the last 2 years validated this number, articulating a requirement of no fewer than 18 LSMs to support littoral maneuver. Given that current force structure plans call for three MLRs, we require 35 LSMs to account for operational availability and mobility for those units. We anticipate an initial request for 18 of the 35 LSMs we seek will be a step toward enabling us to more effectively counter adversaries' strategies, support and reinforce alliances and partnerships, and do so at a relatively low cost.

Despite focusing our efforts over the past 3 years on deterring, competing, and if necessary, contesting the pacing challenge, the Marine Corps will not fully realize the capabilities of the MLR until we have the littoral mobility assets that enable these forces. The decision to delay LSM procurement from FY22 to FY25 was a setback in our ability to bring this capability online within an operationally relevant timeframe. As Marines do best, we have adapted to this challenge and are developing bridging solutions to experiment with LCU-1700s and leased Expeditionary Fast Transports (T-EPF) and SLVs. While these platforms will inform the eventual employment of the LSM, they will fall short of desired capabilities if called upon in an operational setting. Our modernized expeditionary forces need a comparably

modern mobility platform to bring the full weight of their capability to bear on competitors or adversaries, particularly in littoral regions.

FORCE DESIGN CAMPAIGN OF LEARNING

Marine Corps Wargaming and Analysis Center (MCWAC): Wargames play an essential role in concept development and operational planning, and provide the basis for informed decisionmaking. The Marine Corps is undergoing a shift from human-driven to technology-enabled processes that will provide disproportionate benefits—not only to the Service, but the joint force writ large.

Upon completion in 2024, the MCWAC in Quantico will provide a state-of-the-art facility designed to help decision-makers better visualize the threat environment, gain competitive advantages over adversaries, and simulate future operating environments. It will also provide data that informs force development, force management, and system functionality. Simulations will support existing and developing weapons platforms and capabilities in all regions of the globe.

MCWAC will incorporate elements of artificial intelligence and machine learning to amplify decision accuracy on issues that determine the way we organize, train, and equip for the future fight. This facility will also provide a critical asset to the joint force and senior leadership currently unavailable in the National Capital Region. Its location facilitates participation by joint, interagency, and multinational organizations, in addition to Service-specific analysis.

Lessons Learned: Between July 2019 and December 2022, we executed 25 wargames. This calendar year, we will conduct another 9 wargames and welcome the participation of any Member, or their staff, interested in observing. These wargames will primarily focus on two subjects: (1) reconnaissance and counter-reconnaissance, and (2) III MEF deployment and sustainment during major combat operations.

One of the persistent lessons from our wargames is that our current logistics concepts and capabilities are not optimized for maritime campaigns in a contested environment. Improving joint and combined logistics integration, and streamlining logistics C2, are critical areas for further planning and development. The number and capabilities of current logistics distribution platforms are insufficient to adequately deploy, maneuver, and sustain stand-in forces. Due to geographical distribution of forces, all Services will be challenged to meet their sustainment requirements. This suggests the Marine Corps will have reduced access to connectors under the operational control of the other Services.

Our learning is continuous, and we have already refined some of our initial Force Design decisions based on that learning. For example, when we initially reduced the number of cannon batteries, we assumed that the existing 6-gun per battery model would be sufficient to meet requirements. After additional study, we decided to expand those batteries back to their original, pre-2015, 8-gun structure and added back two batteries. Next, we initially assessed 10-plane fighter-attack squadrons (VMFA) as the operationally suitable and sustainable approach for the future force. After multiple studies, a series of experiments and wargames, and emergent capabilities development, we know the 10-plane model requires redress and are undertaking that effort now. Likewise, initial assessments of our heavy-lift helicopter capacity demonstrated we could cut several squadrons; yet real-world considerations have resulted in a modification to our original plans and restoration of some of that structure and capacity.

AMPHIBIOUS WARFARE SHIPS

Achieving the priorities of the National Defense Strategy requires a Navy that creates advantage for the joint force across the competition continuum. Sustaining and recapitalizing our nuclear deterrent and nuclear command, control, and communications systems; enhancing and expanding our undersea advantage; and creating advanced naval expeditionary forces that consist of all classes of ships and are capable of persisting and prevailing against any threat, are all things we must do now. We cannot create and sustain this force on the time horizons necessary to achieve competition and deterrence objectives without a significant expansion of our defense industrial base, which is currently organized for peacetime efficiency. We are a maritime nation that requires naval forces capable of answering the Nation's call, whenever or wherever that might be. Amphibious warfare ships are, and will continue to be, a critical component of the Nation's fleet. They provide an essential capability to the joint force that cannot be overstated. As the amphibious fleet requirement authority, as designated in the FY23 NDAA, it is my obligation to ensure this Committee is aware of the current status of your amphibious fleet.

Secretary of the Navy Amphibious Ship Studies: Since 2019, three DoN studies have examined amphibious warfare ship force structure requirements. Combining the findings of those studies with amphibious warfare ship readiness trends over the past 10 years and projected ship availability rates, I conclude that the Nation requires no fewer than 31 traditional amphibious warfare ships (10 LHA/LHD and 21 LPDs/LSDs) to ensure the warfighting readiness and responsiveness of amphibious naval forces.

The Importance of Amphibious Warfare Ships and the ARG/MEU: Our Nation's amphibious warfare ships enable Marines to execute three essential missions in support of the National Defense Strategy. First, unlike traditional surface combatants whose role is to sink enemy surface combatants and submarines or destroy enemy aircraft and missiles, amphibious warfare ships are meant to project the national power of the United States globally as both a warning to our adversaries and as a visible sign of our commitment to allies and partners. Our defense strategy clearly identifies those allies and partners as a source of our strategic advantage. As Secretary Austin has previously stated, we "need resources matched to strategy, strategy matched to policy, and policy matched to the will of the American people." Our strategic aims are clear: we must deter any act or activity intended to disrupt the rules-based international order. Our strategy is to not fight unless necessary; we seek only to deter conflict. Effective integrated deterrence requires amphibious warfare ships. More so than any other Marine Corps operation, activity, or investment, amphibious warfare ships with embarked Marines provide a flexible, scalable, and visible capability for our combatant commanders to employ at the time and place of their choosing in support of integrated deterrence campaigning.

Second, amphibious warfare ships enable Marines to immediately respond to crisis or contingency. When the Japanese nuclear reactor in Fukushima was damaged by an earthquake in 2011, an amphibious Task Force responded immediately. Non-combatant evacuations in Lebanon, the response to Hurricane Katrina in New Orleans, the rescue of downed U.S. aircrew in contested areas, and numerous other situations around the world have all required an amphibious response, either due to lack of inland access or a determination that a large U.S. military footprint ashore would exacerbate an already dire situation.

Third, amphibious warfare ships and their embarked Marines ensure the President and his ambassadors, as well as all U.S. citizens living outside the United States, have the on-call crisis response protection required to ensure their safety. Whether in Haiti, Venezuela, South Sudan, Yemen, Eswatini, or anywhere else on the globe, MEUs are ready to respond and protect. We must maintain forward-deployed ARG/MEUs with the operational reach to rapidly respond to our highest threat consulates and embassies globally. Marines forward-deployed aboard ships are the operationally desirable solution.

Lastly, the 31 combined amphibious warfare ships are vital components of our Nation's seven ARG/MEUs. This number of ships allows the Nation to maintain at least two ARG/MEUs at sea, with the option to surge to five. Assuming our present trajectory, we will fall below the congressionally mandated floor of 31 amphibious warfare ships. From my perspective, this is a result of divesting these platforms faster than we are procuring their replacements. The result of not meeting this requirement became most acutely visible when we were unable to provide traditional disaster-relief response following the earthquake in Turkey earlier this year. Our ARG/MEU deployments are a visible sign of commitment to our allies and partners and provide evidence to the PRC of our readiness to contest any malign activities. They also provide a visible sign to Russia about our commitment to NATO. In fact, when the Prime Minister and Minister of Defense for Sweden wanted to send a clear signal to Russia regarding Sweden's intention to join NATO, they did so by making a statement on the flight deck of the USS Kearsarge—a Wasp-class amphibious assault ship.

LPD Flight II Program: The PRC is accelerating their production of amphibious warfare ships. We cannot overlook the fact that since 2019, the People's Liberation Army Navy (PLAN) has launched three Type 075 "LHA-like" and three Type 071 "LPD-like" amphibious warfare ships. The PLAN intends to launch an additional five Type 075 "LHA-like" amphibious warfare ships in the next 5 years. It appears that the PLAN sees amphibious warfare ships as highly relevant and a critical instrument in power projection as evidenced by their recent deployments extending beyond the South China Sea. In my opinion, there is also a soft power component to our amphibious warfare ships that cannot be replaced by other platforms. It is obvious the PRC is learning this lesson and is pursuing their own amphibious warfare ship program as a competitive act.

Next, an LPD's or any other amphibious warfare ship's vulnerability to an anti-ship missile is no more relevant to its value than an aircraft's vulnerability to being

shot down is relevant to its value. Over 5,000 helicopters were destroyed during the Vietnam War, yet we do not hear persistent arguments related to their survivability. In a recent series of wargames held by the Center for Strategic and International Studies, 2 carriers and 10–20 destroyers and cruisers were sunk in the Pacific during each of the 24 iterations. Just as these wargames do not signal the irrelevance of these surface warships, conjecture about the survivability of amphibious warfare ships does not either. Instead of focusing exclusively on the survivability of platforms in a high-end fight, we should instead seek an appropriate balance of capabilities needed to effectively campaign and maintain deterrence with those capabilities optimized for major war. As evidenced by constant year cost, the LPD Flight II is the most effective and affordable answer until a follow-on amphibious warfare ship is developed.

FORCE DESIGN AND MARINE FORCES RESERVE

The Marine Innovation Unit (MIU), manned by Marine Reservists, was recently established aboard Stewart Air National Guard Base in New York. This cutting-edge unit will make considerable contributions by focusing Marine talent toward accelerated identification and adoption of advanced capabilities, transforming naval service capacity for technology employment, and retaining and investing in human capital. MIU is expanding Marine Corps reach into the wider innovation ecosystem and developing key partnerships with the Defense Innovation Unit (DIU), NavalX, Army Futures Command, and others to increase tempo and progress toward Force Design objectives.

The MIU is just the beginning. We continue to explore the efficacy of establishing a maritime reconnaissance capability within our Reserve Component (RC) as part of our larger multi-domain reconnaissance initiatives across the force. We are currently evaluating the potential to establish a reserve MQ–9 squadron, as well as reserve augmentation detachments with active duty squadrons.

In addition to its role supporting Force Design, Marine Forces Reserve (MARFORRES) continues to function as both an operational and strategic reserve to augment and reinforce the Active Component (AC). In 2022, more than 1,100 Marines and Sailors activated to support Operation ALLIES WELCOME (OAW), honing their security and humanitarian relief skills. From that activation, 103 Marines volunteered to deploy to OAW-Kosovo aboard Camp Bondsteel. Finally, as the Service brought new capabilities online during FY22, MARFORRES provided High Mobility Artillery Rocket Systems (HIMARS) and Amphibious Assault Vehicle (AAV) rotations in support of USINDOPACOM requirements. This augmentation enabled the AC to execute Force Design experimentation and unit transitions without an impact on combatant commands. The Marine Corps' continued employment of the RC demonstrates our total force approach and has proven to be a critical component of force modernization efforts.

FORCE DESIGN AND MARINE SPECIAL OPERATIONS FORCES

As part of the larger Force Design effort, our Marine special operations forces are modernizing through their Next Generation Raider Force (NGRF) initiative. The NGRF is intended to implement the strategic shaping and reconnaissance (SSR) operating concept, and its two major sub-components—irregular warfare and special reconnaissance, both focused in the littoral regions of the globe. In a manner consistent with other Marine forces, MARSOC seeks to provide the joint force with the capability to shape the operating environment; illuminate adversary actions, activities, and intentions; and provide options to impose cost, both kinetically and non-kinetically, from competition to conflict.

TALENT MANAGEMENT

Talent Management 2030 (TM2030) directed accelerated personnel reforms and oriented the Service toward retaining more experienced Marines. In February 2022, I directed the Assistant Commandant of the Marine Corps to form a Talent Management Strategy Group to align and harmonize Service-wide talent management efforts. This group focuses on future demographics, economic, and human capital trends, while working with academia, research organizations, pertinent departments in HQMC, and commanders in the FMF to identify initiatives that will better align individual abilities, skills, and desires with the warfighting needs of the Service. Since the release of TM2030, we have better aligned departments and organizations involved in talent management, assessed, and mapped out interdependencies of total force personnel policies, and begun to generate momentum with a sense of urgency. Leveraging authorities previously enabled by Congress, we enacted nine initiatives in 2022, which we will expand and accelerate in 2023:

Commandant's Retention Program (CRP): During FY23, the CRP offered pre-approved reenlistments to top-performing Marines by streamlining the process and giving priority access to primary military occupational specialty (MOS) monitors for duty station and assignment options. The CRP resulted in a 72 percent increase of first-term reenlistment submissions by top-performing Marines with the average reenlistment approval accomplished in 24 to 48 hours, much quicker than the previous norm. Going forward we will expand the program to more first-term Marines as well as our career force.

Staff Non-Commissioned Officer (SNCO) Promotion Board Realignment: Beginning in FY24, we are realigning SNCO promotion boards to sequence more effectively with the assignments and reenlistment processes. This initiative will reduce SNCO billet gaps in the FMF and decrease the processing time of reenlistment packages. The realignment will provide greater predictability for SNCOs and their families while dramatically reducing the number of permanent change of station (PCS) moves across the force.

Recruiting Station Commanding Officer Selection Board: We implemented two initiatives for the fiscal year 23 Recruiting Station Commanding Officer (RSCO) selection board. First, officers now have the opportunity to volunteer for command, including officers otherwise not scheduled for consideration. Second, officers may also request removal from RSCO consideration for 1 year, without penalty, should they prefer to complete a deployment or other professional obligation, or due to a personal life circumstance.

Special Duty Assignment (SDA) Volunteer Program: Prior to 2022, we screened and selected Marines for Special Duty Assignments en masse. But last year, we launched a pilot SDA volunteer program, expanding incentives to provide duty station preference for volunteer recruiters, drill instructors, and combat instructors. As a result, volunteers increased by 62 percent, reducing the number of involuntarily screened Marines by 38 percent. This minimized disruption to our Marines, their families, and FMF units while also reducing SDA school attrition. We will improve and expand this program in 2023.

MarineView 360-Degree Leadership Review: MarineView360 is a development tool for leaders that helps Marines identify their strengths, personal blind spots, and areas for focused improvement through the polling of their supervisors, peers, and subordinates. Leaders receive feedback and advice through a dedicated mentor and coach. The MarineView360 pilot began with a group of 150 sitting commanders and is now leveraging the experience of 200 additional selected commanders and senior enlisted advisors. The final phase of the pilot will expand to 1,000 Marines of varying rank from gunnery sergeant to colonel.

Officer Promotion Opt-Out: Starting in 2022, both the AC and RC offered certain officer populations the ability to opt-out of consideration for promotion once without penalty. This allowed officers increased flexibility in their career paths to pursue unconventional career experiences or formal education that would otherwise take them off track for key developmental assignments. We are currently exploring the expansion of this initiative to enlisted Marines to afford them the same flexibility in their careers.

Digital Boardroom 2.0 (DBR 2.0): DBR 2.0 increases the functionality and accuracy of information presented to board members, enhances the conduct of virtual boards, safeguards data, and improves this critical talent management process. The Enlisted Career Retention and Reserve Aviation boards successfully used DBR 2.0 in 2022. With the availability of cloud-based data, we will expand use of DBR 2.0 while simultaneously assessing the outcomes, cost and time savings, and professional depth and breadth of board members to benchmark with our legacy process.

Separate Competitive Promotion Categories: To meet the demands of the future, the Marine Corps must retain the highest quality officers with the necessary skill sets at all ranks. To that end, we are exploring options to reorganize the unrestricted officer population into separate competitive categories to better meet the Marine Corps' needs for diverse expertise and experience at all ranks by competing for promotion with peers having similar skill sets, training, and education. We will conduct a pilot program to evaluate the merits of this reorganization during the 2025 field grade officer promotion boards.

Career Intermission Program (CIP): Many Marines desire to pursue specialized education, or to focus on family for a significant life event. The CIP is an initial step toward allowing Marines an option to temporarily pause their active-duty service and later resume their careers without penalty. This program enables career flexibility, and in doing so, also encourages retention of experienced, talented Marines.

TALENT MANAGEMENT WAY-AHEAD

Manpower Information Technology System Modernization (MITSM): In February 2022, Deputy Commandant, Manpower and Reserve Affairs (DC, M&RA), created a business capability requirements document that outlines the capabilities required to begin the MITSM acquisition process. MITSM will aggregate legacy systems and capabilities into a device-agnostic, data-driven, and dynamic human resources information technology solution that meets the evolving needs of the Marine Corps' talent-based work force. One aspect of the MITSM will be a web-based "talent marketplace," which will enable a collaborative and transparent assignment process and increase the role of both commanders and individual Marines. This capability will help us better align the talent of individuals with the needs of the Service to maximize the performance of both. Despite its criticality to modernizing our talent management systems and processes, MITSM is currently challenged by the acquisition process.

Potential Implementation of "Indefinite End of Active Service" Policy for Enlisted Personnel: As we seek to mature the force, we also seek to eliminate antiquated processes and policies that induce both friction within the personnel system as well as personal and familial stress. There is little reason why those who have served honorably for 16+ years need to worry about re-enlistment before completing twenty-years of service. This year, we will explore the feasibility of senior SNCO career designation to establish an indefinite expiration of active service. This shift will align senior SNCO retention practices with those of officers, increase flexibility in assignments, reduce administrative burden and needless paperwork, and minimize uncertainty for SNCOs and their families.

Small Unit Leader Initiative: Under the current policy, first-term Marines are ineligible for promotion to sergeant. While the spirit of that policy is reasonable, it creates a disincentive to the highest performing Marines across the force by establishing an administrative obstacle they cannot overcome regardless of individual talent. Going forward, if one of our talented Marines with at least 36-months of service wishes to re-enlist, then that Marine will become eligible for promotion to sergeant upon their re-enlistment. This program will incentivize the most talented who desire to stay for another enlistment and should help mitigate the persistent need for sergeants across the FMF.

Active and Reserve Permeability: During the next year, we will explore options to increase the permeability between the AC and RC. The aim is to better match the diverse—and often immediate—operational needs of AC commanders with the specialized skills of individual Marines in the RC. Due to statutory limitations on reserve employment, we will work with the Administration to identify potential opportunities for improvement to AC–RC permeability.

Orders Issuance: In an attempt to give individuals and their families as much time as possible when executing a PCS move, we will increasingly attempt to issue orders up to twelve months before the execution date. We will also assess the feasibility of issuing follow-on assignment orders to those individuals selected for resident professional military education. This should do two things. First, it should provide greater clarity to service members and their families to facilitate proper planning for any school transitions, childcare needs, and special healthcare needs, and will provide spouses more time to secure desirable employment. Second, earlier issuance of orders would allow the Service to clarify a unit's incoming personnel picture to increase long-term planning, effectiveness, and risk management.

Five-Year Orders: The importance of unit cohesion cannot be overstated. To achieve that cohesion, we need to shift from a three-year tour model toward a five-year tour model—with notable exceptions for some of locations such as Okinawa, Japan and Twentynine Palms, California. In addition to creating greater unit cohesion and, as a result, greater readiness, a five-year model would facilitate improvements to family stability and family readiness. Using the standard twenty-year career timeline, the new assignment length would only require a family to relocate three times after the initial assignment. This suggested tour length should enable children to finish elementary or secondary school in one location, and would enable extended periods of spouse employment—minimizing the impacts on dual-income households.

Assignment Incentive Pay/Hardship Duty Pay: Congress and the Department have provided us with the authorities necessary to incentivize service at some of the more challenging duty stations and we have a plan to use them. We will increasingly utilize Assignment Incentive Pay (AIP)—consistent with the other services—to increase the attractiveness of hard-to-fill duty stations. Notably, Army soldiers stationed at Fort Irwin, California or in Korea, have many of the same concerns as our Marines at Twentynine Palms and Okinawa. In addition to AIP, we are explor-

ing other authorities provided by Congress, to incentivize duty by our most talented Marines in our hardest-to-place locations.

Weapons Systems Officers (WSO) & Electronic Countermeasures Officers (ECMO): As we transition from the F/A-18D and EA-6B to the F-35, we will have the opportunity to transition some of our most talented Naval Flight Officers (NFOs) currently serving as WSOs and ECMOs into our expanded uncrewed aircraft squadrons (VMUs). At present, we have 95 WSOs and 32 ECMOs. While the legacy aircraft these officers were previously associated with are being retired, their individual skills remain critical to the future force.

Attracting, developing, incentivizing, and retaining dedicated professionals that increase our readiness and lethality is a priority and necessary to improve our efficacy as a force. The initiatives undertaken since the publication of TM2030 demonstrate our commitment to our expeditionary warfighting legacy and our drive to fight and win in 2030 and beyond. Our performance in future battles will be defined by the investments we make in our Marine Corps today. All actions to evolve our talent management system are aimed squarely at supporting our warfighting requirements. They will incentivize and optimize our talent and sustain our ability to serve as the Nation's premier expeditionary force in readiness within the rapidly evolving world we face.

RECRUITING AND RETENTION

The Marine Corps is not insulated from the challenging recruiting and retention environment impacting the entire DoD. The FY24 budget supports an active-duty end strength of 172,300 Marines, an achievable target. The Marine Corps will monitor and reevaluate end strength, even as we continue to increase retention as part of our Talent Management strategy. We appreciate the support and flexibility that Congress provides us on retirement, retention, and end strength.

In 2022, we achieved our annual recruiting mission and exceeded both our first-term re-enlistment goal (101 percent) and our subsequent-term re-enlistment goal (107 percent). To put this in perspective, 5,063 first-term Marines re-enlisted in 2018, while 5,820 re-enlisted in 2022. Further, we are re-enlisting those Marines earlier. In FY22, the Service met its First Term Alignment Program (FTAP) mission on 8 July 2022, which at the time was considered a major accomplishment. In fiscal year 23, we met our FTAP mission of 6,225 Marines on 6 February 2023—a full 6 months earlier—and retained higher quality Marines than we have in the last few years.

The Marine Corps met or exceeded both our FTAP and Subsequent Term Alignment Program (STAP) goals across the force for the first time in 13 years. In FY23, we expanded early re-enlistment authorizations for Marines with at least 24 months' time in service from 200 to 600. We reached 150 in the first weekend, and then reached 200 (last year's total) within three weeks. We then expanded this program to accommodate the 700+ submissions we had received by 1 February this year. Completing these early re-enlistments will help mitigate any recruiting challenges across a two-year period (FY25–27). In FY23, we satisfied our retention goal of infantry Marines before December for the first time in over a decade. As a result of these retention efforts, we are gradually maturing the force. This will result in more mature non-commissioned officers leading our youngest Marines and will generate better operational outcomes on the modern battlefield.

As noted by RAND economist Dr. Beth Asch, we should never forget that we do not have an all-volunteer-force; but rather, a predominantly all-recruited force. To overcome current challenges in recruiting, we have challenged all assumptions. We have also resurrected and reviewed ideas and options previously generated over the years, but never actioned or implemented. The results have been very promising.

While some assumed five year "infantry-only" contracts would not be well received, that assumption has been invalidated. During the past year, we conducted a limited experiment in which we offered recruits a 60-month infantry-only contract. This 400-spot program "sold out" immediately and was subsequently expanded to accommodate the demand. Infantry-only contracts ensure unit cohesion and almost guarantee Marines two deployments in a single contract, mitigating unit turnover between deployments. Since the completion of that pilot program, we continue to find that our young Marines prefer the stability afforded by these 60-month contracts and are choosing this option over 48-month contract options.

Some assumptions related to the utility of monetary incentives have also been invalidated. Big sums of money are not required to incentivize potential Marine recruits. This past year, we implemented a \$5,000 shipping bonus program for new enlistees with great success. In exchange for this one-time payment, we direct shipping at a date of our choosing, which gives us greater predictability and flexibility.

This experiment was very successful. We also implemented a \$9,000 shipping bonus program with similar success. In exchange for this one-time payment, the individual's contract time does not officially begin until they arrive at their first unit. As a result, those in this program that become infantry Marines will average 2 deployments during their first contract, because their initial 7 months of entry-level training will not count towards their obligated service.

Finally, we want to make the statement, "there is always boat-space for talent," a truism across the Marine Corps. In the past, talented individuals were denied re-enlistment due to "closed" MOSs or other administrative obstacles beyond their control, such as an inability to transition from an MOS they didn't choose or perhaps never wanted. These talented Marines want to re-enlist, but they also want a new (primary MOS) PMOS. The ability to "laterally move" talent into a new PMOS is an obstacle at present, but we are working on this issue. This is a training issue, not a personnel issue. Regardless, we are not going to let 8–12 weeks of retraining costs prevent us from benefiting from the talents and leadership of these proven Marines for another 4 years or more of service. If we must choose between proven leadership and MOS credibility, we will prioritize proven leadership for a greater return-on-investment. Retraining costs less than the \$42,000 cost to recruit a Marine. While recruiting will remain challenging for the foreseeable future, the Marine Corps is up to the challenge. But there is one option that we will not exercise: we will not lower our standards. This is non-negotiable. Despite the well-known recruiting challenges in recent years, from 2018 and 2022, the average Armed Forces Qualification Test (AFQT) and average General Technical (GT) scores of our infantry Marines (0311s) have actually increased across the force.

CHILDCARE

Addressing the availability of childcare remains a top priority for the Service. Unfortunately, persistent supply and demand imbalances have resulted in unacceptable wait times for our Marine families. At present, there are notable waitlists for full-time childcare at Marine Corps Base (MCB) Quantico, MCB Camp Lejeune, MCB Camp Pendleton, and MCB Hawaii. These locations still maintain approximately 77% of the Service's unmet waitlist for ages six weeks to 5 years. This is primarily due to a shortage of qualified workers, high turnover due to less competitive pay, lengthy hiring and background check processes, seasonal PCS fluctuations, and facility renovations. While we have capacity to serve 6,523 children at present, we only have sufficient staff to serve 5,880 children. To provide a variety of options that fit families' needs and to mitigate lengthy Child Development Center (CDC) waitlists, we also offer fee assistance for eligible Marines who are geographically remote, reside more than 15 miles from an installation, or are assigned to an installation with a lengthy CDC waitlist.

In 2022, with the support of OSD Office of Military Family Readiness Policy, we established the Child Care in Your Home (CCYH) Pilot Program. CCYH is a DoD fee assistance pilot program that helps military families cover the cost of full-time childcare (30–60 hours per week) provided in their homes.

Designed to support families with non-traditional work schedules, care can be provided every day of the week and during non-traditional hours, such as evenings and weekends, or on rotating schedules. At present, we maintain 58 childcare facilities (32 CDCs and 26 school-aged care facilities). Renovations are currently in-progress aboard MCB Quantico and Marine Corps Air Station (MCAS) Beaufort. We recently completed a \$37.7M construction project aboard MCAS Miramar, which will provide 412 new childcare spaces to our families. In addition, we have construction planned aboard MCB Butler in Okinawa for a new school-aged care facility, aboard Camp Pendleton for a new CDC that will add 250 additional spaces, and aboard MCB Camp Blaz in Guam to satisfy the needs of 276 children in the future.

SUBSTANCE ABUSE PREVENTION

The Marine Corps' Substance Abuse Program focuses on three distinct areas: drug demand reduction, alcohol misuse prevention, and substance misuse non-medical counseling services. As part of our continued vigilance, we have expanded our urinalysis testing to include both illicit and prescription drugs, including the most misused and abused opiates. One hundred percent of urine samples are now tested for fentanyl. Additionally, due to a regrettable resurgence in lysergic acid diethylamide (LSD) in some of the communities surrounding our major bases and stations, we added LSD testing back to the standard drug testing panel. Delta-8 tetrahydrocannabinol (THC) was also added to the standard drug testing panel in July 2021, expanding testing for THC products. THC remains the most prevalent drug detected during our testing. While expansion in testing did result in an in-

crease in positive test results, the Marine Corps remains below the DoD benchmark for positive test results and current data indicates that prescription drug misuse is low.

SEXUAL ASSAULT PREVENTION AND RESPONSE

As a Service, we have focused on countering sexual assault within our ranks by professionalizing the prevention workforce, improving training for Marines at all levels, professionalizing the sexual assault response workforce, and strengthening an environment of accountability by establishing an Office Special Trial Counsel. As of January, our newly established Office of Special Trial Counsel reached IOC and is on track to reach FOC by December 2023, putting prosecutorial discretion for these offenses in the hands of trained attorneys. In addition to these efforts, the Marine Corps continues to implement the recommendations of the Independent Review Commission on Sexual Assault in the Military, as approved by the Secretary of Defense. These efforts include developing organizational structure, hiring qualified professionals, and ensuring our prevention workforce is trained and postured to provide this crucial support to commanders. We are also investing in education to enable prevention, focusing on leadership responsibilities to both prevent and respond to sexual assault and sexual harassment, and providing training for trauma-informed leadership. While this larger societal problem persists, we are actively pursuing solutions to improve prevention and ensure offender accountability when prevention efforts fail.

SUICIDE PREVENTION

As part of our larger human performance management efforts, we continue to examine our mental health programs and suicide prevention efforts. Every life lost to suicide is one too many. As an organization known for our camaraderie, we take every loss of life seriously and continue to pursue all opportunities to reduce the incidence of suicide amongst our Marines, Sailors, and their family members.

The Secretary of Defense recently released a report from the Suicide Prevention and Response Independent Review Committee. The committee concluded that the most important preventative measure is engaged quality leadership, and we agree. This has long been a focus of ours, as have many of the recommended personnel reforms, which mirror our on-going talent management initiatives. We also embrace the Committee's conclusions about the criticality of access to mental healthcare professionals and services, and their recommendations related to TRICARE reform to enable such access.

HEALTHCARE

Developmental Pediatricians: Generating ready forces requires building and sustaining readiness at-home among our military families. Military service is demanding. Extended training, frequent military moves, and routine deployments—scheduled and unscheduled—strain marriages and stress families, regardless of a Marine's rank or time-in-service. That stress is magnified in cases where children have special medical needs, such as Autism Spectrum Disorder (ASD). Regrettably, we are currently unable to provide sufficient developmental pediatric care across the force, even in areas where we enjoy highly developed military healthcare infrastructure, such as San Diego or the National Capital Region. Parents are often forced to wait 6 months or longer for an appointment. This is not acceptable. The scholarship is clear and undisputed: early intervention is the key to better outcomes for children with ASD. Today, we have four active duty and three civilian developmental-behavioral pediatricians to support the force, which is insufficient to meet the needs of our families. The force requires at least two developmental-behavioral pediatricians per medical treatment facility to meet the needs of our families. If providing these additional developmental pediatricians is considered unsupportable, then we would ask for Congress' support in creating legislation to make it easier for families requiring this care to obtain it from the civilian market. Parents should not be forced to choose between their profession and calling to serve, and their need to provide for their families.

Defense Health Agency (DHA): The DHA has undertaken the largest transformation in the history of the military health system. From the lens of providing support to service members and families, this undertaking has failed to satisfy expectations, and has resulted in both unsustainable costs and degraded services. While the DHA is maturing in its role as a combat support agency (CSA), the lack of agreement between the DHA and military departments regarding DHA's roles and responsibilities as a CSA, as well as business rules governing employment of uniformed personnel inside the medical treatment facilities (MTFs), has created sig-

nificant challenges. This problem is compounded by a recent exodus of military and civilian healthcare professionals due to “burn out” from the COVID-19 pandemic and operational tempo, the ability to double or even triple salaries in the civilian sector, and uncertainty and frustration over the DHA transition. Due to the nationwide shortage, the DoD is competing for the same finite resources when attempting to hire contract healthcare professionals. Unfortunately, the DoD contract pay rate is near the lowest, if not the lowest, in the industry, making recruitment particularly challenging.

In terms of improving the affordability of healthcare as promised, these cost savings have not been realized. In fact, the transition has come with higher costs. An additional undesired outcome of the movement away from Service authority, direction, and control of healthcare delivery is the lack of consideration for Service-specific requirements and the impact to healthcare operations. Specifically, in remote locations such as Okinawa and Iwakuni, decisions to reduce access to care inside MTFs has negatively impacted dependents and civilian personnel, which impacts operational readiness.

I ask for your continued oversight of the DHA and help in addressing the overwhelming gap between DoD contract healthcare labor rates and the civilian market. The success of the military health system (MHS) requires the ability to hire qualified, civilian healthcare labor. The MHS must have contract rates that can compete in a highly competitive market for a finite and highly valuable resource. Failure to remedy this issue will have catastrophic consequences on the readiness of the force.

TRAINING AND EDUCATION

The Marine Corps enjoys a hard-earned reputation as a learning organization. The previous 3 years of Service-level training exercises, along with other large and small exercises, wargames, and live force experiments, established a sound foundation for organizational learning. Collectively, they provided clear evidence that change is required. We have learned that today’s training and education system must rapidly evolve to prepare individual Marines and units to succeed on an all-domain battlefield. Those changes are articulated in the recently published Training and Education 2030 report.

Training and Education and the Russo-Ukraine Conflict: While the future remains uncertain, clear trends are emerging from the conflict in Ukraine that are consistent with much of what we have seen in other recent conflicts, evidencing the need for accelerated modernization across the joint force. However, we should not lose sight of the fact that the Ukrainians succeeded in the early phases of the conflict not because of superior equipment, but because they were adaptable—especially at the tactical level—and rapidly innovated new concepts of employment to address specific areas where the Russians had achieved advantage. In fact, their bias for action, unit cohesion, and emphasis on decentralized C2 had a significant impact on the readiness of Ukraine’s infantry and maneuver forces. These factors allowed Ukrainian battalions to effectively operate in and control battlespace we would normally associate with an Army Brigade or Marine Regimental Combat Team—units 3 or more times larger than a traditional battalion. The operational requirements associated with these expanded areas of responsibility are placing more and more demands upon junior leaders that can only be addressed through greater investment in the training and education of our Marines. The conflict is demonstrating that advanced capabilities will be available and employed at much lower tactical levels than we have witnessed in our own recent past. In future conflicts, we are going to ask junior leaders at the company level and below to do things battalion commanders may not have had the authority to do in recent years. It is clear this will require an increasing investment in the training and education of our leaders at all levels and across the entire joint force.

DOCTRINE

Doctrine establishes the basis for developing operational concepts and requirements. It also describes our understanding of how those capabilities are to be employed and ultimately, details training and associated resource requirements. Marine Corps Doctrinal Publication (MCDP) 1, Warfighting, tells us that doctrine “establishes a particular way of thinking about war and a way of fighting. It also provides . . . a mandate for professionalism, and a common language.” Our doctrine, including its bedrock in Warfighting, has given us a solid grounding in the essential elements of maneuver warfare, upon which we expect our philosophy of warfare to remain anchored for the foreseeable future. This is not enough. The character of warfare has always been subject to the constant and uneven pressures of technological advance and social and geopolitical change. Warfare’s changing char-

acter means we must constantly review and revise our assumptions; they will change and we must change with them. Doctrine, in turn, must evolve, adapt, and keep pace. For example, in June 2022 we published MCDP 8, Information, describing how the Marine Corps gains and exploits information advantages in all warfighting domains across the competition continuum. We also recently revised MCDP 4, Logistics, updating our doctrinal foundation of this critical warfighting function to meet the challenges of the future.

Changes to our warfighting ideas, theories, and concepts must be expressed clearly and quickly. This leads to greater emphasis on the rapid creation and dissemination of doctrine at a level of specificity below that of our capstone publications and tied tightly to our campaign of learning, including feedback from the FMF. Most importantly, we must hold ourselves accountable for training and operating in accordance with our refined doctrine.

ENHANCED INFANTRY AND LEADER TRAINING

14-week Infantry Marine Course (IMC): Before our IMC pilot effort began, the Marine Corps underwent a deliberate process to identify the infantry skills necessary to win in a fight against a peer adversary. During this process, Training and Education Command developed 39 behaviors required for all infantry Marines. These required behaviors range from traditional skills like employing the service rifle, patrolling, and land navigation to skills such as “embodying the Marine Corps’ warfighting philosophy” or “manag[ing] signature.” Based on feedback from our division commanders, a subset of 20 of the original 39 infantry behaviors were prioritized as a requirement for entry-level training. Those 20 infantry behaviors became the foundation for a new program of instruction (POI) and the first pilot of the 14-week IMC.

IMC Marines are held to a much higher physical standard to both enter training and to graduate than previously required. Marines earning the infantry MOS are now challenged to achieve first class scores on the Physical Fitness Test (PFT) and Combat Fitness Test (CFT), achieve a minimum swim qualification of Water Survival Intermediate (WSI), and pass an evaluation on the Shallow Water Egress Trainer (SWET), which simulates procedures for evacuating a sinking aircraft. Student physical graduation requirements also include a 10-kilometer (km) Combat Endurance Assessment (CEA) and completion of a 20km hike with a 75-pound fighting load.

In addition to better physical fitness, IMC Marines develop better decisionmaking skills. By the end of the course, students make thousands of decisions, receiving constant feedback from both combat instructors and peers, significantly increasing the experiential foundation for sound decisionmaking. As IMC builds a better decisionmaker, it also produces a significantly more lethal Marine. IMC graduates are trained to a markedly higher standard in rifle marksmanship and are combat capable in all environments with the M27 Infantry Automatic Rifle (IAR). They are further trained in the employment of medium machine guns, grenade launchers, anti-armor systems, and light mortars—all of which are new weapons skills for basic riflemen.

Better-trained Marines generate operational tempo—a key to success in maneuver warfare. The outcomes thus far are remarkable. IMC graduates are trained to be quicker-thinking and better decision-makers, more physically fit, and much more lethal at earlier points in their careers than their predecessors. All these things should increase the readiness of their units and the overall force. To date, 3,524 Marines have graduated from this program. While it is too early to make any definitive conclusions, initial findings suggest IMC graduates may have lower non-EAS attrition rates.

THE MODERNIZED MARINE CORPS TRAINING ENVIRONMENT (PROJECT TRIPOLI)

We train how we fight. But we are limited by the number of ranges and training areas available, environmental limitations, airspace restrictions, and several other factors that ensure Marines can employ the full range of capabilities they will have at their disposal. One solution to this challenge is to expand and modernize the Marine Corps training environment (MCTE) through an effort called Project Tripoli, which seeks the integration of the live, virtual, and constructive training domains. The MCTE is our combined arms training concept for the future that will enable us to realistically train and exercise with our advanced capabilities both internally and as part of the joint force. Importantly, it permits training with capabilities in a manner concealed from our adversaries and in ways that would otherwise be resource prohibitive in terms of materiel, ordnance expenditure, and personnel. The MCTE will enable combined arms training in the broadest sense and will allow new

and expanded dimensions in force-on-force (FoF) exercise capabilities. Conceptually, a modernized MCTE integrates all training enablers—from high-fidelity flight simulators, to ranges and training areas, to FoF training systems—into C2 architectures and networks supporting training events. MCTE is not a single acquisition program, but a system comprised of multiple training programs. To further improve the MCTE network, we will continue to build interoperability among existing training systems as we bring new systems online, pre-designed with enabling technologies to support increasingly dynamic training environments.

Our next big step will be to field our Force-on-Force Training System (FoF-TS) Next Program across the force to equip units with the training tools necessary to conduct realistic and challenging FoF training. This system is designed specifically to accommodate rapid changes and refinements in the training continuum. Additionally, it will process the tremendous amounts of sensor data needed for our FoF-TS, UAS, cyber, electronic warfare, and loitering munition capabilities to facilitate readiness. The FY24 budget request for training and education modernization is \$581 million.

TRAINING AREAS AND RANGES

At present, ensuring sufficient range access and training in the Western Pacific region is challenged by a lengthy supply chain, environmental constraints, infrastructure challenges, and access restraints. To ensure the persistent readiness of Marines in the region, the Marine Corps has a number of planned investments across the Commonwealth of the Northern Mariana Islands. Investments planned for Guam include: a live-fire training range complex, a multi-purpose machine gun range, and urban combat training facility, and a training support center. On Tinian, the Marine Corps is pursuing a platoon level live-fire and maneuver range and an explosive ordnance disposal range. These efforts are pending a positive determination of ongoing environmental impact studies. The Marine Corps is also involved in the Pacific Multi-Domain Training and Experimentation Capability (PMTEC) initiative. PMTEC will better integrate existing capabilities and expand the ranges and training areas available to Marines, to include the Joint Pacific Alaska Range Complex and the Pacific Missile Range Facility.

Training areas and ranges in Alaska continue to grow in importance to overall Marine Corps readiness. The sophistication, instrumentation, infrastructure support, and sheer size of Alaska ranges make them indispensable for the development of 5th generation fighter aircraft tactics. During 2022, Marines participated in four joint exercises in Alaska, to include the high-end rehearsal exercise RED FLAG. The Marine Corps provided 38 F-35Bs across different phases of the exercise as well as leading edge air C2 capabilities. In 2023, we will expand our participation in exercises in Alaska to include Exercises NORTHERN EDGE and ARCTIC EDGE.

While our efforts to prevent encroachment have focused on protecting the ranges and training areas we have, modernized training requirements are going to push us to expand training areas in multiple domains to ensure we have trained and ready forces to meet our Nation's needs into the future. MCAS Yuma makes an outsized contribution to the training readiness of Marine aviation due, in part, to the presence of Marine Aviation Weapons and Tactics Squadron One (MAWTS-1) and the conduct of the biannual Weapons and Tactics Instructor (WTI) courses. In addition to the decades long challenges associated with the location of the Yuma Fairgrounds, the continued use of Marine Corps Air Station (MCAS) Yuma's Barry M. Goldwater Range (BMGR) in support of modernized aviation training is at risk due to the loss of Flat Tailed Horned Lizard (FTHL) habitat associated with border wall construction. By risk we mean, the loss of habitat increases the likelihood that the FTHL would be listed under the Endangered Species Act. Listing the FTHL could result significant restrictions to our ability to train and experiment to meet force design objectives. To prevent this from occurring, we need to act now to secure necessary FTHL habitat and are leveraging the Readiness and Environmental Protection Integration Program as one tool to support habitat protection efforts.

In addition to physical ranges, we will also leverage a variety of virtual ranges like the Persistent Cyber Training Environment (PCTE) for joint qualification requirements and rehearsals. The PCTE integrates capabilities that support continuous evolution of cyber training and exercises, enabling force readiness and driving decisions on tactical, operational, and strategic levels. Over the past year, the PCTE has expanded access to cyber operating forces in the FMF. We are confident that access to these modern training environments will significantly enable the all-domain nature of our Marine forces.

INSTALLATIONS AND LOGISTICS

In recent years, we have identified logistics as the “pacing function” for warfighting. Among the seven warfighting functions, logistics most dictates the tempo of operations and the operational reach of a unit. No other warfighting function more profoundly affects our ability to persist in contested spaces. Moreover, logistics and sustainment capability and capacity have a deterrent effect. Persuading an adversary that a quick win is not possible by demonstrating an ability to generate, re-generate, and sustain combat power is, in itself, a deterrent.

An uncertain future, the threat of peer and near-peer competitors, and developing challenges in all warfighting domains create wide-ranging implications for sustaining the current and future force. To support emerging and future operational requirements against peer and near-peer adversaries, we will have to transform our approach to logistics. Simply put, we must transition from a force optimized for supporting sustained operations ashore to a maritime force capable of supporting operations in austere, expeditionary, and littoral environments that are contested across all domains. This process of change and adaption began with the release of our Installations and Logistics 2030 report and our revised foundational doctrinal publication on logistics, MCDP 4.

While our current approach worked well in the past, it is insufficient to meet the demands of the future operating environment, particularly when contested across all domains. The magnitude of change required to prepare the Marine Corps installations and logistics enterprise to support the future force mandates a fundamental reevaluation of our approach to logistics.

INSTALLATIONS ASSESSMENT AND RESOURCES

Ready and resilient bases and stations are a critical requirement today and into the future. Years of under-funding the installations portfolio has resulted in a funding shortfall across the FYDP in the tens of billions of dollars. Earlier decisions to take near-term risk in these accounts and shift resources to support readiness-related accounts resulted in longer-term systemic risks to the Service that we must address.

Beginning in 2023, we will engage in a comprehensive and informed infrastructure recapitalization that directly contributes to the requirements of the future force. This will require additional funding, and while it will take more than one FYDP to accomplish, the foundation must be laid today.

FACILITIES SUSTAINMENT, RESTORATION AND MODERNIZATION (FSRM)

Fiscal Year 2024 will be the second year using our pilot Readiness Maximization Tool. This pilot program prioritizes restoration, modernization, and demolition in order to achieve a better facility readiness outcome as opposed to the traditional emphasis of focusing on sustainment metrics. The Marine Corps’ FY24 FSRM budget request for the active and reserve forces totals \$1.3B.

INSTALLATIONS PLAN 2023 (IPLAN)

In the near future, we will publish our first ever Installations Plan (IPLAN), modeled after the Aviation Plan (AVPLAN), to create a shared understanding of the Marine Corps Installations Command (MCICOM) enterprise. We intend to produce this reference document annually to show military construction (MILCON) and FSRM funding framed across time by region, base, and station. The report will further identify the five priority MILCON projects (funded or unfunded) by base and station for the next 1—10 years. Finally, future versions of the IPLAN will include a threat-based resiliency assessment by base and station regarding resiliency of force protection; airfield operations; range support; and command, control, and communications. It will also describe the scope, cost, and schedule to achieve resiliency.

MILCON PRIORITIES IN SUPPORT OF FORCE DESIGN

The FY24 budget includes \$1.3B to support a total of 16 projects, which includes both planning and design. This funding includes seven projects totaling \$457 million to continue our efforts to relocate Marines from Japan to Guam.

INFRASTRUCTURE

Water Infrastructure: Aging drinking water and wastewater systems were not designed to meet increasingly stringent environmental requirements. These old systems also require significant maintenance to continue operation. Since FY16, the Marine Corps has invested approximately \$400 million to upgrade or replace drink-

ing water and wastewater infrastructure, improving environmental compliance and reducing risk to personnel and the environment. We are currently evaluating the need for future support.

Energy Infrastructure: The vast majority of our installations are dependent on a commercial electrical grid vulnerable to disruption due to a variety of threats such as aging infrastructure, severe weather, and both physical and cyber-attacks. While procedures and infrastructure are in place to respond to short-term power outages, there is a growing need to ensure we can maintain essential functions and critical services during a prolonged outage. As part of our renewed focus on installations, we will produce energy resilience plans by base and station in 2023.

Fuel Storage Tanks: In April of 2022, in response to an inquiry by the Assistant Secretary of the Navy for Energy, Installations, and Environment, MCICOM conducted a risk assessment of significant (>10,000 gallon) fuel storage tanks located on Marine Corps installations, and the risk to drinking water sources and systems. This assessment included tank condition, tank location relative to systems and sources, and condition and adequacy of containment systems. The assessment concluded no immediate threat for this population of storage tanks. However, the assessment did identify two >10,000-gallon tanks with a high-risk for release due to condition, but due to their locations, concluded any release from either tank would not impact water sources or systems. Since the completion of this assessment, the high-risk tank located aboard Camp Fuji has been replaced, and the other tank, located aboard MCB Quantico, is scheduled to be replaced this fiscal year. As an additional risk mitigation, the tank aboard MCB Quantico has been drained pending replacement.

Barracks: The Marine Corps possesses 672 barracks with 155,329 bed spaces. On average, those barracks are 32 years old and in need of renovation. In FY22, we renovated 14 barracks for a total cost of \$118 million, and in FY23, we plan to renovate another 16 at a cost of \$262 million. The barracks renovations completed in FY22 to FY23 will positively impact 8,116 Marines living in them. The per barracks renovation costs over the past 2 years have risen from \$8.4M to \$16.4M. At present, 16 percent or 108 Marine Corps barracks are in poor (Q3 on the facilities conditions index ratings) or failing (Q4) condition. Current estimates to recapitalize, sustain, or demolish require an additional \$3 billion to return all assets to Q2 (>80 facility condition index) by 2031. Clearly Q2 is not our goal; Q1 is and will be. In FY24, we plan to use approximately \$270 million to renovate 25 barracks including some renovations previously deferred.

GUAM AND H2B VISAS

Earlier this year the Marine Corps reactivated Camp Blaz—a facility that secures a geographically distributed and operationally resilient posture for the Marine Corps in the Indo-Pacific. It also strengthens DoD's ability to deter, defend, and support allies and partners in the region. The continued build-out of Guam projects will require a reassessment of the H-2B visa issue, based on available qualified workforce.

CLIMATE CHANGE RESILIENCE

Currently, the Marine Corps is undergoing a review of installation master plans to build resilience against all hazards such as wildfires, water scarcity, rising sea levels, and hurricanes. Marine Corps Recruit Depot (MCRD) Parris Island (PI) has already completed a master plan (2021) and a Climate Change Resiliency and Adaptation Plan (2020), which are being used to develop MILCON and FSRM investment projects to reduce existing and projected localized flooding. The Military Installation Resilience Review of the low country community surrounding MCAS Beaufort and MCRD PI developed a toolkit for structural interventions and nonstructural planning approaches to enable the low country communities to adapt to climate change. The toolkit has been applied to three pilot projects: St. Helena Island wastewater treatment plant, Lady's Island neighborhood, and the Shell Point Interchange. MCRD PI's efforts to address sea-level rise and climate change with regional conservation groups and the local community is growing stronger. MCRD PI currently has five initiatives in process with our regional partners: Lowcountry Sentinel Landscape Application, National Fish and Wildlife National Coastal Resiliency Fund (carbon sequestration \$550,000), South Carolina Department of Natural Resources, Readiness and Environmental Protection Integration Program, and US Army Corps of Engineers.

CONCLUSION

On-going conflicts across the continent in Africa, along the line-of-actual-control between India and China, along the Turkish-Syrian border, and in Ukraine remind us that despite our best efforts, we can never know with certainty when, where, or how an adversary might precipitate conflict—especially against an ally or partner. We must be ready—not simply available—to respond tonight, tomorrow, and every night into the future. We are. As a Service, we must ensure that your crisis response force is globally deployable. We are. But we don't have the luxury of building a force for only one threat, one region, or one form of warfare. The Marine Corps must be organized, trained, equipped, and postured for the full range of operations in places we might not expect, and on timelines we did not anticipate. We are. In these times of increasing complexity and uncertainty, the Nation needs one force, maintained at the highest levels of readiness, that can respond to the crises that few saw coming. We are that force.

This Committee's support to our modernization efforts—anchored on Force Design 2030, Talent Management 2030, Training & Education 2030, and Installations and Logistics 2030—has been crucial to our success thus far. Today is an opportunity to re-commit to our modernization program and help facilitate its acceleration, while at the same time addressing issues often mistakenly deemed secondary to readiness such as barracks, housing, childcare, and healthcare. Which are equally essential to the readiness of the force.

Based on your continued support, 2022 and 2023 will be known as the years Force Design transitioned from ideas to operational capabilities. Force Design is now; it is here today. But with updates to organization and equipment well underway, we must turn both our attention and our resources to manning, training, and retaining. We must never lose sight that our most critical warfighting advantage is our people, and that they deserve the best quality-of-life that we can provide them given the anticipated stress associated with military service. I look forward to working with the Committee members and staff over my final months as Commandant, and thank each of you and your staff for the tireless efforts in support of the Marine Corps.

Senator TESTER. Thank you, General Berger. It is also fair to say, the Marine Corps wouldn't be where it is today without your leadership. So we thank you for that.

I am going to yield my time to Senator Murray, who is the—
Senator MURRAY. Go ahead.

Senator TESTER. No, no, no. I know where the bread's buttered.

I am going to yield to Senator Murray, the Chair of the Full Committee.

STATEMENT OF SENATOR PATTY MURRAY

Senator MURRAY. Thank you, very much Chairman Tester, Vice Chair Collins, really appreciate it. And we really are fortunate to have two really tremendous leaders steering this subcommittee. So I am grateful to both of you. And I am very glad to join today's hearing with you, as we continue to work towards regular order here in the Senate for the first time in years.

And as Senator Collins and I have made very clear, we know we have a responsibility to work in a timely fashion to write the bipartisan bills that will fund our country, build us as a stronger country, and make our communities safer, and ensure that we stay ahead of our global competitors.

And the conversations that we are having today, including this hearing, really help us show how we are going to make those investments decisions, here in DC, that will help strengthen our country and protect our families, which as we all know, is especially important when China and others are making significant investments in their own Navy and military right now. And if we are going to keep pace with those countries we have to work together to get a bipartisan funding bill done.

So I am really glad to have this opportunity to hear from the witnesses today about the President's budget request for the Navy and Marines, particularly how we can make sure we are supporting our service members and their families. And we need to remember that includes making sure that our military families, as you just alluded to, get things like child care, and mental healthcare, and good housing, and schools, and a lot more, because at the end of the day our best naval ships can't go very far without the brave men and women who are willing to put themselves on the frontlines to keep our country safe.

So with that, I do have some questions for you today. And Admiral Gilday, I would like to start with you, because in February seismic deficiencies were found at three of the dry docks as you know, at Puget Sound Naval Shipyard in Bremerton, and the Delta Pier at the Trident Refit Facility in Bangor. Two very critical facilities in my home State of Washington. And as a result submarines were prohibited from using three of those six dry docks at Puget Sound, and the only dry dock at Bangor. Puget Sound Naval Shipyard is the primary location for attack submarine and aircraft carriers maintenance as we know, on the west coast, so I wanted to ask you today: How exactly is the Navy working with Puget Sound Naval Shipyard, and Trident Refit Facility to plan and implement the near-term mitigation? And what resources do you need to have to accomplish that?

Admiral GILDAY. Thank you, ma'am. We are making good progress right now on the repairs in three of those, facilities. So the first one at TRF (Trident Refit Facility) Bangor will be completed in June that is the most substantial work that we are doing, essentially, repairing both sides of the entire dry dock; the two other docks will be finished in April and May.

As they are progressing well. We are focused there on those portions of the dock that are closest to the nuclear power plant and the submarines, where we actually put them up in the dry dock.

There is a \$300 million request in my unfunded list as you know, that was a late-add that didn't make it into the budget, so I request your help there.

Longer term, we will be looking at other upgrades that we need to make in order to ensure the Seismic Resiliency of that facility. As you stated we really count on it, in terms of providing submarine maintenance for the fleet.

Senator MURRAY. So the \$300 million is for the short term; that is your request?

Admiral GILDAY. Yes, it is.

Senator MURRAY. And then longer term?

Admiral GILDAY. So longer term, too early for me to state what that requirement is. We are right now scoping the long-term repairs in conjunction with the SIOP (Shipyard Infrastructure Optimization Program's) work that we are planning up there as well.

Senator MURRAY. Okay.

Admiral GILDAY. So we want to make sure that it is Seismically Resilient.

Senator MURRAY. Okay. And you will stay in touch with us on that?

Admiral GILDAY. Absolutely, ma'am.

Senator MURRAY. Secretary Del Toro, back in 2021, it was announced that Naval Station Everett had been designated as the future Home Port for Twelfth Constellation-class Frigates scheduled to be delivered in 2026. That is great news. The Navy's long-term commitment to Everett and Snohomish County, my State, is really clear. But as we get closer to that date, we need to make sure that not only the Navy has the resources they need, but the Everett community also has the support it needs to accommodate the influx of sailors and their families. Are those still on track to arrive in 2026?

Secretary DEL TORO. We are currently looking at the lay down plans, ma'am, for all of our ships given the increasing Indo-Pacific threat that we face. I myself have visited the Puget Sound area and looked at all the different infrastructure issues that are at play there, and we are looking and discussing with the CNO exactly what investments need to be made over the next several years, so that we can move in the right direction, including greater support for the hospital in the Puget Sound area as well, too.

And if I could just briefly comment, and thank you for your leadership, as well as the collaboration that we have had with the community of Puget Sound, as we actually moved very aggressively to effect the repairs to the dry docks very expeditiously. It has been nothing but a great relationship.

Senator MURRAY. Thank you very much.

And just really quickly, Mr. Chairman; if I could just ask the Secretary again about the Navy suicide rate; nearly 17 deaths per 100,000 sailors, that is just devastating. Does the President's budget request support any additional mental health?

Secretary DEL TORO. Very much so, ma'am. In the Department of the Navy's budget we actually have additional funds, upwards of \$200 million that are dedicated to this. In addition to the actual human element of actually trying to bring everyone together to try to solve this grave problem that we face as a Nation; and the Navy too.

Senator MURRAY. Okay. Thank you very much.

Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

Senator TESTER. Senator Collins.

Senator COLLINS. Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

Admiral Gilday, the fiscal year 2022 NDAA (National Defense Authorization Act) sought to empower the CNO by requiring the CNO to submit his or her fleet size requirements directly to Congress. In July of 2022, the first such requirement was submitted and called for 373 ships, compared to 296 in the fleet today. Your navigation plan, which was released that same month, called for 96 large surface combatants like those built at Bath Iron Works in my home State.

Two questions: First, when do you anticipate that your analysis will be released so that we have the benefit of your guidance in drafting the bill? It likely that your updated fleet requirement will be greater than the 373 ships in light of China's modernization?

Admiral GILDAY. Ma'am, on the first question, I have committed to Congress to deliver the report by the 10th of June, this year. And I will make the deadline. We are on track with our analysis team to do that.

Secondly, with respect to not only the size but the composition of the fleet, I would expect that to change from the last report, particularly in terms of composition. It is too early to tell with respect to size, but quite honestly, ma'am, I can't see it getting any smaller than 373 manned ships.

Senator COLLINS. Thank you. And that is quite a ways from where we are today?

Admiral GILDAY. Yes, it is.

Senator COLLINS. General Berger, as we were sitting here, a headline came across my phone, and it says, "Pentagon comes out against law requiring military wish lists", and it came across just as you were explaining why you need more amphibious ships. And that that was your number one unfunded priority. Isn't it important for Congress to know what your chief unfunded priorities are?

General BERGER. From my perspective it has been useful I think to submit it from each of the services, and you to have visibility on what is not in the budget, for whatever reason. So from my perspective, it seems useful if it is useful to members. And it has been in the past.

Senator COLLINS. It is definitely useful to us. And I don't think that Congress is going to take the Pentagon's advice on doing away with the unfunded priorities list.

Admiral, let me return to you. Could you explain to the Committee why our surface Navy is so, important as a deterrent from a deterrence perspective?

Admiral GILDAY. So the destroyers, the cruisers that we have at sea today are really the backbone of the fleet, along with our aircraft carriers and our amphibious ships. You just can't replace forward presence. It is there to not only ensure that U.S. interests are looked after, but also poised in case any crisis comes up, we reassure allies and partners that we are there 24/7, 365.

A full-third of the Navy is forward on any given day. A second-third is in maintenance, and the remaining third has either just returned from deployment, or is ramping up to go. That is where we belong out forward.

The Secretary of Defense has directed readiness levels to us, and those, our ships that are ready to respond within 10 days, those ships are all at sea now. So what we are trying to do in order to take advantage of the firepower that we have today is to improve our maintenance cadence as an example to send more ships to sea, the more the better; the bigger fleet, the better.

Senator COLLINS. Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

Senator TESTER. So I will start with you, Secretary Del Toro. Last year Congress accelerated investment in weapons so that our weapons magazines are loaded up for future contingencies. In this year's budget the Department is proposing to lock in procurement quantities for nine different weapons programs over 5 years. This would provide significant predictability and stability to the industrial base. However, I note in some cases, such as the Naval Strength Missile, quantities requested this year are lower than appropriated last year. Further, it is not clear what the private sector investment will be in return for this procurement predictability from the Government.

So Secretary, could you explain how multiyear procurements can help stabilize the industrial base? And furthermore, what investments are you expecting in return from this predictability?

Secretary DEL TORO. Mr. Chairman, I believe that multiyear procurements are critical to growing the size of the fleet in terms of buying individual platforms, and ships, as critical as it is, to invest in munitions. We appreciate the support of the Congress and being allowed to use these multiyear procurements for the purchase of Missile Systems as well, too.

Our budget, in this year's fiscal, President's budget submission, increases the investment in munitions by 50 percent, investing in Tomahawks, SM-6, Mark 48 torpedoes, LRASM (Long Range Anti-Ship Missile), across the entire threshold of the missiles that are needed, actually, for the Navy to be able to accomplish its mission. I am also a big supporter of the Naval Strike Missile, just on the LCS (Littoral Combat Ship) class of platforms, we are looking to put them on all our LCS platforms moving forward.

So I wasn't aware of the slight decrease in the numbers of NSMs (Naval Strike Missile), I thought the numbers had actually gone up, but I will go back and validate that and get back to you if there has been a small decrease in the numbers of NSMs. I believe we are purchasing over 99 across the entire fleet.

Senator TESTER. Okay. And what do you expect in return from the industrial base with long-term predictability?

Secretary DEL TORO. I expect their commitment to recapitalize in order to be able to provide these Missiles at the pace that we are requiring them, for both the challenge that we face these—versus Ukraine, as well as the potential need to be able to deter China in the Taiwan scenario as well. These missiles will be required in the numbers necessary to be able to get there, so industry has to do its parts with a consistent signal being sent by the Department of Defense, that we will be purchasing these Missiles for a long period of time, they should feel comfortable in their confidence that they can invest in their own capitalization and their workforce to be able to produce these missiles and systems that are needed.

Senator TESTER. Despite repeated investments in the defense industrial base and the shipbuilding industrial base in particular, we don't really see improvements towards ships being delivered on cost and on time. In fact, your annual report to pay for cost overruns on new ships is about two billion bucks, or close to.

It seems like I ask this every year, but what else can we do to support the shipbuilding industry to be able to get ships out on time in particular, and under cost?

Secretary DEL TORO. Mr. Chairman, I think that our investments in the P2P (Performance-to-Plan) Plan that the CNO has been committed to for the past several years, actually is starting now to make some advancements in being able to get ships out of shipyards, are far faster than before, whether they are ships being repaired, or new construction ships for that matter as well. With regards to the increased cost of the ships, much of it has been due to inflation, and certainly the negative impacts of the CR (Continuing Resolution), and the workforce shortage that we are all existing.

I am hopeful that as we actually come out of COVID, and start fixing some of these work shortages that we have, we will be in a better place.

I want to thank the Congress, and you particularly, for your investment in over \$2.3 billion in workforce, and industrial-based investments last year, and the number this year is equally significant, \$1.7 billion.

We will continue to make sure that those dollars get used wisely with a return on investment on behalf of the American taxpayer, with the right oversight that is necessary to create these programs that hopefully will provide far greater numbers of workers to the shipyards themselves.

Senator TESTER. The two Senators to my right and to my left have made it clear that they intend to follow regular order and get a budget up by the end of September. I think that is good news. The other side of that coin is, is that we do need to do our job, but also the industrial base needs to deliver on time. Is there anything that we can do to help you make sure that they are delivering our assets that we are having them built on time?

Secretary DEL TORO. As Secretary of the Navy, I have held them accountable, actually, for delivering ships on time. I have had numerous meetings with all of the CEOs (Chief Executive Officers), I have walked all the shipyards myself to take a look at exactly how engaged they are in the construction of ships, and providing the quality of materials that are necessary.

I think from the Congressional perspective, your continued commitment to invest in the industrial base, not just in the submarine community, but as the Vice Chairwomen mentioned, in the surface warfare industrial base as well, is critically important. Those are measures I think Congress should continue to take in order for us to get to a better place.

Senator TESTER. Senator Moran.

Senator MORAN. Chairman, thank you very much.

Welcome to our panel. I appreciate your service and your presence here.

General Berger, let me begin with you. Both the Marine Corps budget submission, and unfunded priority list invest heavily in CH-53 King Stallions; explain why this particular aircraft is critical to the Force Design 2030, and the Marine Corps Mission, if you would?

General BERGER. Late last fall, I went down to North Carolina, and the Senator, to fly on that aircraft, having grown up in CH-53Ds and Es. This is a state-of-the-art aircraft. It has a glass cockpit, it is a fly-by-wire digital airframe, it doesn't fly itself, literally, but it is just exponentially years ahead of where anything else that we have.

Around the world, it is one of a kind, it has range, altitude capability, refueling, lift, and it is marinized to go aboard ship like we do. To your question on how does it fit into Force Design? Both the CNO and I believe strongly that we will need to operate in a distributed manner. That means you are going to have to move troops and supplies around, the 53K is critical for that, especially in regions where you have long distances where you got to do that over water, this is the machine built for that.

And the price, which I am glad to see happen, gone down from 117 to 113 in the most recent lot, that is the direction you want to see costs go as they learn how to build better airframe. The cost is headed in the right direction.

Lastly, I will just say, it is scheduled to deploy later this fall. I will be pretty excited to see what it does aboard ship when it is actually deployed.

Senator MORAN. Thank you. Admiral Gilday; P-8s, advancing technology, submarine capability of our adversaries, the P-8 Poseidon, I assume, continues to be critical to deal with those threats. I visited SOUTHCOM (Southern Command) last month, or a few weeks before that, and the Commanding General in our conversation, but also in a conversation with Senator Shaheen, indicated that the drug flow coming across our southern border is at an all-time high, SOUTHCOM's allocated resources to see this situation, Her ISR assets quote, "Are at an all-time low."

The Navy's procurement has stopped short of meeting the original risk-informed requirements for the 138 aircraft, what risk assessments went into this decision to halt the procurement of this critical capability?

Admiral GILDAY. Sir, right now the estimate is 127, and we are sticking to that, so this is based on evolving, wargaming analysis that we are doing on an annual basis. The same thing goes into our ship numbers, and our ship mix. As you said, P-8s are vitally important. So I have never had to ask a combatant commander twice if they need another P-8, they are in very, high demand.

They are not the only asset out there that we rely on for ISR, but particularly with respect to an ASW (Anti-Submarine Warfare) mission, which is what they were really designed for, they are less optimum for SOUTHCOM, as an example, let us say, a Russian submarine threat coming from the high north. As they tend to come out with more frequency these days, as well as a growing Chinese threat.

Our focus has really been on both of those primary global threats, as outlined in the National Defense Strategy.

Senator MORAN. Thank you. And let me turn to you, Mr. Secretary. Last year's PACT Act was signed into law. It provides benefits to veterans exposed to toxic substances. The law included a provision allowing for individuals impacted by contaminated waters at Camp Lejeune to file for damages in court, Federal court.

The PACT Act required claimants to present their claims to the Navy before going to court, and this is certainly additional burdens on claimants, the Department of Justice, the Federal court system, if the Navy can't find a way to provide an administrative remedy in these cases. Would you explain where the Navy is in its effort to set up an administrative claims process? How many claims have been filed with the Navy since the law became—took effect on August the 10th? How many claims has the Navy acted on? And can you provide a reasonable timeline for the Navy to process and respond to those claims?

Secretary DEL TORO. Thank you, Senator. And we are very grateful for the support that was given by the Congress in order to pass the PACT Act to take care of our Troops, our Sailors, our Marines, and their families as well too.

Senator MORAN. Thank you.

Secretary DEL TORO. We have stood up an outward-facing website at the Processing Unit. It is my understanding that we have received over 20,000 claims. We are obviously going to have to increase the personnel assigned to the Processing Unit, to be able to address those claims. I will get back to you on an exact number of claims that have already been addressed. I believe this is just the beginning, and there is much more work to be done, but we are committed to actually being able to process those claims in a responsible manner in order to move down that path.

Senator MORAN. Does the President's budget request reflect that additional personnel?

Secretary DEL TORO. I will have to get back to you, Senator, I don't believe it does right now.

Senator MORAN. Okay. Thank you, Mr. Secretary.

Senator TESTER. Senator Schatz.

Senator SCHATZ. Thank you, Mr. Chairman. Thank you all for being here.

Secretary Del Toro, just very quickly; are we on track for defueling Red Hill?

Secretary DEL TORO. Senator, we are very much on track for defueling Red Hill. As you know, we have also submitted our closure plan for Red Hill, we have submitted addendum number one, and we are working on addendum number two as well, so it will be submitted later this year.

Senator SCHATZ. Do you have any reason to believe that defueling will adversely impact the DOD's ability to support military operations in the AOR?

Secretary DEL TORO. I do not, Senator. In all my conversations with senior leadership at the Pentagon, and looking at the strategic lay down plan for defueling afterwards, I don't see any challenges whatsoever to executing that plan, over the course of time, absolutely not.

Senator SCHATZ. Thank you. And do I have your commitment to make sure that the Navy works with State and local partners on the healthcare aspect of this as well, as environmental remediation?

Secretary DEL TORO. Senator, you have always had my commitment on that subject, and you will continue to have my commitment on that subject, working with the Office of Secretary of Defense, and DHA (Defense Health Agency) in particular, to ensure that the service members, and also the people of Hawaii, have the services they need from a health care perspective moving forward.

Senator SCHATZ. Thank you very much.

Admiral Gilday, given that the INDOPACOM unfunded priorities list includes Military construction, Joint training with regional partners, and Logistics, can we be confident that—this is a delicate question,—so I wish you luck with the answer. Can we be confident that member-driven priorities aren't crowding out our more foundational budget priorities?

I am talking about divestment here, and we have had some good conversations, and even on the committee we have been talking about divestment, but everybody talks about divestment every year. And as I look at these priorities, it seems to me that these

are things that should not be on the unfunded priorities list, but on the list, that we are planning to fund. Can you reassure me that we are not accommodating all of the members, and all of their hometown business interests, in contradiction, of what the Department of Defense needs?

Admiral GILDAY. Sir, the friction point with divestments, specifically ship divestments, directly against those members that are interested in ensuring that repair yards have a sufficient throughput going through them, right? And so if I look out to 2026, with a high degree of confidence, I can tell you that as an example, in Norfolk, through those shipyards will increase by 10 percent.

In San Diego, it will increase by 9 percent. There is a bit of a dip there in 2024, but it does stabilize. If I could draw a parallel, and to our ship-building plan, so our submarines you can look out for 20 years and you know that we are in a cadence to build one SSBN, and two SSNs. Likewise, that gives stability to the Force in terms of what you are going to look at, in terms of the battle force you are going to field under the sea, and what those repair requirements are, with a high degree of fidelity.

We are just now getting to that point in the surface build production lines, destroyers, LPDs, we want to keep, that line going.

Senator SCHATZ. I get all that, and that—

Admiral GILDAY. It gives a higher degree of fidelity in terms of what the future looks like for those repair yards.

Senator SCHATZ. Sure. And I am obviously supportive of keeping the industrial base up and running.

Admiral GILDAY. Yes, sir.

Senator SCHATZ. And also the predictability, and probably the price predictability of long-term contracts, and long-term Investments. But I just worry that we are giving short shrift to the kind of boring stuff, making facilities more resilient, funding our partnerships in the region, sewer, water,—

Admiral GILDAY. I get your point.

Senator SCHATZ [continuing]. Housing, all of it.

Admiral GILDAY. I get your point. So if I were to take our investment strategy with respect to infrastructure in the Indo-Pacific, and I have another billion, and then another \$0.5 billion on my unfunded list for infrastructure, most of that is in the Pacific, and it is completely aligned with INDOPACOM's plan for bases in places that we need to expand in the Indo-Pacific, or to shore up because we have not done any work there in a while.

We work our budget with respect to that, sir, hand in glove with the combating commander.

Senator SCHATZ. Thank you. And just one final question for Secretary Del Toro: Red Hill is not the only aging infrastructure in Hawaii, that is for sure, and I would like you to speak to the sort of more basic, more mundane needs regarding infrastructure in the State of Hawaii?

Secretary DEL TORO. Very much, Senator. And we have actually dedicated in this year's budget, over a billion above last year or two, investments in the infrastructure, and they are going to have to continue. Historically, we have invested less than 1 percent of the budgets over the last 10, 20 years actually, in infrastructure.

And it is as critical to combat readiness as the readiness of our ships, and our aircraft, et.

With regards to the infrastructure on the Island of O'ahu, and throughout Hawaii as well, it is challenged, it is very old, and it needs to be replaced. I believe the CNO has actually executed three recent assessments to take a look at the water, the sewage, and electricity, actually on the island, in order to support the infrastructure, and the ships that are there, and the families that are there as well.

We have to continue that investment moving forward. We cannot ignore it. I myself, have called for a 30-year infrastructure plan for the Department of Navy, it will take us, a year to get it in the right direction, but both of the Marine Corps and the Navy, are actually paying a lot more attention to infrastructure because it is the right thing to do.

Senator SCHATZ. Thank you.

Senator TESTER. Senator Murkowski.

Senator MURKOWSKI. Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

This morning, in Alaska, there is—500 speakers that are lined up to participate at the Arctic Encounter Symposium, the largest Arctic gathering here in the country. We are talking a lot about the Arctic nowadays. One of the principal issues of discussion will be the China-Russia intersect and the interest in the Arctic. I am all eyes on the Arctic all the time.

And I was a little concerned, Mr. Secretary, as well as Admiral Gilday, in going through, at least your written testimony this morning, some 50 pages of text between the two of you, there is zero mention to resourcing your Department's Arctic Strategy, or defending America's Arctic.

That worries me. We have seen Arctic strategies released by each one of the services, that is greatly important, but we all know that just having a strategy is nothing if we do not resource it, and resources are reflected in the budget.

So Mr. Secretary, can you explain to me why you haven't been conducting more overt operations in the Arctic? And just, more generally, if you would like: whether or not you think that this budget properly resources the Navy's Arctic strategy?

Secretary DEL TORO. Senator, let me say that I deeply am concerned about what is happening in the Arctic, obviously, the United States is an Arctic nation, just like Russia. Unfortunately, they have been investing far greater resources than we have, historically, in the Arctic, whether it has been icebreakers, or troops, et.

We need to do a better job of our investment in the Arctic. I think we have been challenged, obviously, with the current situation in Ukraine, as well as challenged by the current increasing threat of China, as the pacing threat, and the scenario with regards to Taiwan, which has demanded additional resources to be able to address those significant challenges.

But nevertheless, the CNO, myself, and the Marine Corps, and General Berger, are looking at trying to increase the number of operations that we have actually in the north, and also taking a look at future deep-water ports, that perhaps we could reinforce, in terms of the piers, and et. I am planning to go to Alaska in June—

Senator MURKOWSKI. Good.

Secretary DEL TORO [continuing]. To address some of these issues myself, so I look forward to that continued conversation with you and the rest of Congress as we need to address these significant threats that are evolving.

Senator MURKOWSKI. Good. We will certainly welcome you in June. Any time you want.

General Berger, let me ask you the same, whether or not you feel this budget appropriately resources the issues as they relate to our Marine Corps and the footprint in Alaska?

General BERGER. Thanks for the question, ma'am. It gives us the resources we need to train there, yes. Both in exercises that are regularly scheduled, like you mentioned, the Arctic Edge being one of them. Where we go up and, frankly, can train to a level we can't inside the rest of the United States, both because of the airspace and the sea space; and the force-on-force opportunities that you have in Alaska that it is really difficult to generate down here.

There is also the unit deployments that we do to Alaska, and I took my Battalion to Alaska because you can build readiness there and get a regular deployment. You can do things, again, that you can't do at home station. It does provide us the resource like the Marine Corps, the resources to do that right now.

Senator MURKOWSKI. Okay. Well, it is something that, again, we recognize that this is a matter—this is an issue when it comes to Arctic and Arctic readiness, that we are not there yet. I think we would all recognize across all the Services, we are not there yet. You mentioned icebreakers, and I am sure you know this, Mr. Secretary, that we are sitting here still at one-and-a-half icebreakers on a good day, compare that to Russia's 56. China is moving forward, even India is talking about building an icebreaker.

So we are well behind in the construction of how are we going to facilitate our icebreaking fleet. I have two questions. And I am probably not going to be able to get to them, so I would ask that you both take these for the record.

And this is to you, Admiral Gilday, and to you, Mr. Secretary. And they relate to World War II munitions and explosives of concern, unexploded ordinances that were left near Unalaska, at the end of the Aleutians, there have been several areas identified, where these hazards can be. It has been concluded that risks to public safety are present in many of these areas. It is a concern amongst the people in the region, most notably.

Now, we are told that Navy says it does not plan to conduct another survey until 2027, until more advanced underwater search technology is developed. I want you to be aware of this, because I am going to include language in the Defense Appropriations Bill to conduct a more thorough survey in 2024. I think the people there deserve it. And it is in addition to the unexploded ordinances.

I am also going to inquire about the chemical weapons, the Mustard agent, the Lewisite that was deposited off of AT2, and again the survey of that chemical weapons dumpsite. So just put that on your horizon. If you can get back to me earlier than that, it might obviate the need for it for language.

Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

Senator TESTER. Senator Baldwin.

Senator BALDWIN. Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

Secretary Del Toro, building on this committee's prior shipbuilding investments, I am advocating for additional funding for the frigate industrial base and workforce in fiscal year 2024. The ship will be a central part of the future fleet.

And as a new class will undoubtedly face workforce, supplier, and shipyard infrastructure challenges, last year Congress provided \$50 million for the Frigate Industrial Base and Workforce Development Program. I want to thank you for noting your support of this funding during last year's hearing. First, can you share your thoughts on how the fiscal year 2023 funding will be executed to benefit this program? And then secondly, please follow up with, because I believe a sustained and robust investment is required to continue supporting the ship's production ramp up. How do you see sustained industrial-based funding helping the program?

Secretary DEL TORO. Thank you, Senator. First let me thank you for your commitment to ensuring the Constellation gets built on time, and on track. I am pleased to report that she is on time and on delivery. And we want to make sure that we continue that record.

And the industrial-based investments are necessary. Most of the monies, I believe, will be dedicated towards—Constellation will go in the force of Workforce Development programs to try to help the shipyard recruit additional, and train additional individuals in Wisconsin to train them to be able to support, an increasing need for the workforce in the shipyard itself.

I think that will be the best use of the monies. The shipyard itself has invested a lot in CapEx, and has reinvested a lot of its own profits, and its own capitalization as well too, to try to keep the frigate on track.

So I am hopeful that the monies in 2023 are going to be better used in workforce development than in actual CapEx like investments in the shipyard.

Senator BALDWIN. Okay. Thank you.

General Berger, the Marine Corps listed LPDs, that is the amphibious transport dock ships, as their number one priority on their unfunded priority list. However, the Navy has halted its pursuit of the transport dock line, citing the program's growing costs. Can you explain why supporting the LPD Project is important to the Marine Corps? And what the Second and Third order effects would be, if the LPD Project is not funded?

General BERGER. Senator, in my opening comments I tried to highlight the operational, and the statutory minimums, both mandated by Congress, and what I see, as the warfighting requirement. And that is a floor, not a ceiling. And it consists of 10 big decks, LHAs, LHDs, and 21 medium or small LPDs, and is the bare minimum.

This budget proposes early decommissioning of three of those LSDs, with no construction, no acquisition of an LPD, so from my role as defining what the requirements are, and the statutory minimums of 31, there is no plan to get there.

From my perspective, I didn't see any other way than to put it on the unfunded list in order to reflect that there is no plan to get to the minimum requirements.

If we don't have it, to your question, what is the risk? The risk is our inventory atrophies to a point where we cannot deter, can't campaign, can't respond. And as I tried to highlight, when we can't respond when we have to, then our allies' and partners' trust goes down, and in all likelihood the way the Chinese Navy is growing, they are expanding, but they are liable to try to step in. And we can't afford that to happen.

I would say the last part of this, of course, is maintenance which is the number one priority for the CNO, for four straight years, and recovering that maintenance making sure we have the fleet that we need that is ready, as he points out, is key also.

Senator BALDWIN. You have previously cited that the buy now or block buy acquisition strategy will mitigate costs by footing the bill up front. Can you explain why you think this will be an effective way to mitigate costs, such as inflation; or if there are other methods to help mitigate those costs?

General BERGER. The CNO is better qualified to explain the variables here. But from my perspective, a predictable pattern of construction on what they call centers, is key. Key for parts, key for labor, and for LPDs it is 2 years, so we have to have a battle rhythm, a cadence that allows them the predictability that they need. If we don't have that, then they can't hold the workforce, they can't keep the supply chain working, and it starts to tumble downhill.

Senator BALDWIN. Yes. I note that I have run out of time, but maybe for the record, Admiral Gilday, I would like to give you the opportunity to respond on the topic of LPDs, and feel free to submit that to the committee in writing.

Admiral GILDAY. Thank you, ma'am.

Senator TESTER. Senator Graham.

Senator GRAHAM. Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

What is the inflation rate today, Mr. Secretary, do you know, for the Nation?

Secretary DEL TORO. Senator, I believe it is approximately 4.6 percent, or so.

Senator GRAHAM. For the country?

Secretary DEL TORO. Overall.

Senator GRAHAM. Okay. Is the Navy budget equal to inflation?

Secretary DEL TORO. No, sir, it is not.

Senator GRAHAM. Okay. What is the Navy budget—how far below inflation is it?

Secretary DEL TORO. I believe it is about 2 percent below inflation, sir.

Senator GRAHAM. Okay. How many ships do we have in the Navy?

Secretary DEL TORO. And when I mentioned the 4.6, that is the predictors that were used.

Senator GRAHAM. All right. What's the actual inflation rate?

Secretary DEL TORO. Somewhere in the 6 percent range, sir.

Senator GRAHAM. Okay. So the predictor was wrong?

Secretary DEL TORO. Predictors are often wrong.

Senator GRAHAM. Yes. Okay. Have you accounted for that?

Secretary DEL TORO. Have we accounted for?

Senator GRAHAM. Yes.

Secretary DEL TORO. Well, we are very thankful for the additional \$9 billion that the Congress provided to Department of Defense.

Senator GRAHAM. Well, the point is that you are a couple of points below inflation. I think that is my point. So, how many ships in the Navy?

Secretary DEL TORO. 296, sir, as of today.

Senator GRAHAM. Okay. How many ships in the Chinese Navy?

Secretary DEL TORO. It is upward of 300.

Senator GRAHAM. Like 340?

Secretary DEL TORO. Yes, sir.

Senator GRAHAM. Okay. By 2028 how many ships will we have?

Secretary DEL TORO. By 2028 we will have approximately 291 ships, or so.

Senator GRAHAM. That is less than 296, right?

Secretary DEL TORO. Yes, sir.

Senator GRAHAM. Okay. How many will the Chinese have?

Secretary DEL TORO. I can't predict exactly what the Chinese will have, but estimates are upward of 440, or so.

Senator GRAHAM. Yes. Okay.

Secretary DEL TORO. I will add that our ships are extremely more modern than they ever have been, as well.

Senator GRAHAM. Let us hope so. I believe, let us hope so.

Secretary DEL TORO. And lethal.

Senator GRAHAM. If not, we are in a world of hurt.

Let me ask you this, CNO, how many ships do we actually need?

Admiral GILDAY. 373 manned, and probably 150 unmanned.

Senator GRAHAM. Okay. So under this budget the one—do you support this budget?

Admiral GILDAY. I do.

Senator GRAHAM. Okay. If we have 296 today, and under this budget we are going to be at 291 in fiscal year 2028, how do we get to 373?

Admiral GILDAY. Sir, right now we have 56 ships under construction, and another 76 that are under contract. We can't buy back time. For 20 years we are focused on ground wars, and understandably so, the Navy wasn't the priority. Sir, keeping old ships, that are not usable or workable is not going to make us a stronger Navy.

Senator GRAHAM. I am not arguing with you, I am just asking: Does the budget get you to 373 ships?

Admiral GILDAY. If we follow the shipbuilding plan, that there is three alternatives in the shipbuilding plan, the third alternative, assuming about a 5 percent increase above inflation, above our top line.

Senator GRAHAM. Okay. You are assuming 5 percent above inflation. The actual budget is 2 percent below inflation. How can you support a plan that requires 5 percent to get you where you want to go, and the actual plan is 2 percent below inflation? I mean that doesn't make sense to me. Does that make sense to you?

Admiral GILDAY. Well, sir, part of it gets at, what can the shipbuilding industry actually produce?

Senator GRAHAM. Do we have a shipbuilding industry problem, or do we have a budget problem?

Secretary DEL TORO. We have a shipbuilding industry problem currently, Senator.

Senator GRAHAM. Okay. Well, let me just go back to the budget. He just said you need 5 percent above inflation, am I quoting you right?

Admiral GILDAY. They is a——

Senator GRAHAM. To get to that 373 number. You just said that the Navy's budget is 2 percent below inflation, and when you look out, over time, in year ten, do you know what percentage of GDP (Gross Domestic Product) we will be spending on defense?

Secretary DEL TORO. I cannot predict that in 10 years, sir.

Senator GRAHAM. Well, I can. And tell you right now; it is 2.5 percent. How many times has this Nation spent less than 3 percent on GDP for defense in the in the modern era? I know, I will just tell you, four times?

Secretary DEL TORO. Four time.

Senator GRAHAM. 1940, 1999, 2000, and 2001. This budget is going to get us to 2.5, in fiscal year 2028 it goes to 2.9, so your budget is taking GDP spent on the Navy and the Military to historic lows, the budget you are supporting is below inflation, and you are telling us, to get to where we want to go we have got to be above inflation by 5 percent. If this is a good budget, I would hate to see a bad budget. Thank you.

Senator TESTER. Senator Shaheen.

Senator SHAHEEN. Thank you, Mr. Chairman. And thank you to each of you for being here today, and for your service to the country.

I don't know, Mr. Secretary, or Admiral Gilday, which of you would like to answer this question. But the Portsmouth Naval Shipyard has done the first Shipyard Infrastructure Optimization Program Dry Dock Modernization—it is a mouthful. Are there lessons learned there that you think should be applied to similar future projects in Hawaii and Washington, and what are they?

Secretary DEL TORO. Very much so, Senator. And actually I am pleased that the progress in Portsmouth actually has remained on track, but it has been at the expense of many years of trying to understand exactly what we needed to do there from an engineering perspective. And those lessons learned are being applied actually in Hawaii. I just signed the first contract out in Hawaii for \$2.8 billion, my staff did.

And we have applied those lessons to what we are experiencing in Hawaii, although both shipyards actually aren't exactly the same nor are the projects themselves are exactly the same.

Senator SHAHEEN. Right.

Secretary DEL TORO. But I will ask the CNO to comment further on.

Admiral GILDAY. I think one of the things—ma'am, that we learned, because these projects are so complex and we haven't done them in a hundred years, is to bring the best in industry together in a group to inform how we move together. We didn't do that as well in Portsmouth. We relied on a single contractor. We have brought together many more experts when we did the estimate for Hawaii, and the contract was just signed 2 weeks ago. I think we

are in a better position with a design that will keep us on track, in a bit more challenging area in Hawaii than Portsmouth.

But that said, we have learned a lot from Portsmouth in terms of how we both design and then move forward in execution.

Senator SHAHEEN. Thank you. Well, thank you both for your support for that project and for coming to see it. I think it has been very impressive.

General Berger, the Marine Corps is in its fourth year now, Force Design 2030. What have you seen in the Nagorno-Karabakh War, or the Ukrainian War, that has validated your approach to Force Design 2030? Are there lessons there? Or are there changes that we need to make in response to what you have seen?

General BERGER. Well, that could be a long explanation I am patient.

Senator SHAHEEN. You have 2 minutes and 33 seconds.

General BERGER. I am patient in drawing long-term lessons learned while there is a fight going on, because you can make a mistake too early on thinking you have seen something and we should change everything. We need to be a little bit patient.

That said though, I think we have seen enough to draw some conclusions, as you point out, because this is 10, 12 years observing this.

First, the ability of a force to operate more spread out and empower authorized junior leaders to make decisions at speed, matters. There is almost ubiquitous sensing nowadays everywhere you need counter for that. And some of the counter to that is basics of camouflage, and some of it is much more technical and logistics.

And lastly, I would say the ability of a force to adapt is huge. It is hard to quantify, ma'am. But the fight that you are in is never the fight that they taught you in school. We should be very impressed by the ability of Ukraine to adapt over the past year, all along the way, and the failure of Russian units to do the same. You and the force has to adapt to the environment they have got. And they have done a marvelous job of that.

Outmanned, outnumbered, they have all the odds against them, except for NATO (North Atlantic Treaty Organization) and the U.S., but they have adapted. We need to be able to do the same.

Senator SHAHEEN. Well, one of the things as I understand, you are working to do, and how does this complement that? But it has been described to me, hoping to change from the Marine Corps' historically young Force to a more experienced Force. So how does that help us in those kinds of environments?

General BERGER. It is directly tied to it. If you are going to empower, you are going to authorize junior tactical leaders to make really critical, key, tactical, and operational decisions, they need the maturity to do that. By maturity I don't mean in age.

Senator SHAHEEN. Right.

General BERGER. I mean enough repetition, seen enough, done enough, to see a close semblance of what they have trained for before, and make a very quick decision. We have to mature the Marine Corps' Force to reach a better balance of a very, young Force, versus a Force that has enough experience in there to make those tactical decisions, which is at the root of what Force Design for us is doing. Reach that right balance, retain more talent, and balance

the experience that we are going to need, with the youth that we have always had.

Senator SHAHEEN. Thank you. And Secretary Del Toro, I am out of time, but one of—we had a hearing last week in the Armed Services Committee on Recruitment and Retention and the challenges that we are facing in our military. One of the issues that I think is very important to helping with recruitment—with retention, in particular, is ensuring that there is child care for families who are serving.

I am going to submit this for the record, but I would like to know what we are doing to better expand our ability to provide child care for DOD families? We have done a really interesting Congressional Defense award in New Hampshire between the shipyard, and Pease National Guard, who are doing a child care facility jointly. Are there creative ideas like that that we are working on? But I will submit for the record.

Secretary DEL TORO. Very quickly, we had two in the budget last year. We have three in the budget this year.

Senator SHAHEEN. Great. Thank you.

Thanks, Mr. Chairman.

Senator TESTER. Senator Hoeven.

Senator HOEVEN. Thanks, Mr. Chairman.

Secretary, in your testimony you highlight the significance that—of the challenge that China poses to our Navy and our Marine Corps. But last fall the administration released a draft regulation that would require contractors to report on any greenhouse gas emissions linked to the work that they perform on DOD contracts, and then prioritize emissions' reductions regardless of the cost or impact on the warfighter.

This regulations “finaled”: it will increase costs, it will discourage contractors from working with DOD, and put green mandates ahead of operational requirements. And I would guess China would be pleased to learn that U.S. is willing to spend more to make weapons greener instead of getting more weapons or more lethal weapons to combat our adversaries.

Can the Navy afford to have contractors increase their prices, and so forth, and focus on how green their weapons are in the face of the China challenge? And will somehow reducing the emissions of our weapon systems help either the Navy or the Marine Corps to more effectively meet the challenge that China poses, as you outline?

Secretary DEL TORO. Senator I am not exactly sure that the relationship between green gas; gas emissions were tied directly to the weapon systems themselves. There is a lot of other utilities that the United States Navy depends upon, in which case green technology does make a lot of sense, and we are investing in a lot of green technology.

The Marine Corps alone, we have actually taken Marine Corps Base Albany to zero essential emissions, essentially, and that pays off tremendous dividends in being able to provide us more resources to actually put into combat readiness, and to be able to buy more weapon systems themselves.

Senator HOEVEN. Have you seen the proposed regulation I am referring to?

Secretary DEL TORO. I will have to look—no, I haven't—

Senator HOEVEN. I would encourage you to take a look at it, because that is not what it does. It requires additional focus on making the systems, weapon systems, and so forth, the contractors provide more green. And it is hard for me to understand, we were talking about lethal weapons, that that would be the focus, or how that could not be costly and counterproductive to our warfighters. So I would encourage you to take a look at it.

Secretary DEL TORO. I promise to look at it and get back to you, Senator.

Senator HOEVEN. Yes. Thank you, Secretary.

And then, Commandant, let me ask, General Berger, the UAS pilot training, in your testimony you mentioned the Air Force probably does not have the capacity to train the number of MQ-9 officers that you need. So what are you doing to get that training? And you know, are there enough trainers? Have you looked at contract training? Have you looked at alternatives then to address it?

General BERGER. The way I captured it in the written testimony, is as accurate, as picture is, me and General Brown, and the CNO have. That we don't see any shrinking of reduction of that demand. So the CNO, we have got a couple options here. As you have pointed out, one is contract. Two, is a naval school for unmanned pilots ourselves.

In other words, opening up a UAS (Unmanned Aerial Systems) school ourselves, which we are talking about. We don't know yet what that would cost, and where we would put it. The instructor base, all that sort of thing, but it is pretty clear that relying on the Air Force, as we have the last couple years, we wouldn't be where we were without them. This is not going to meet the requirement going forward. So it is probably going to be in either a Naval UAS school, or a contract solution.

Senator HOEVEN. I would like to talk to you about that. We have put a lot of time and effort into working with Air Force at the Grand Forks Air Force Base, both to have a Technology Park, Grand Sky Technology Park, on that base, as well as a test site, Great Plains Test Site. General Atomics is located there, the manufacturer, they are training their Foreign Military Sales Pilots. They have the Brits there right now on the MQ-9.

And so I would sure like to talk to you about that, existing facilities, the ability to fly in the NAS (National Airspace System) without—beyond visual line of sight aircraft. You know, manned aircraft having to chase all these things that might give you a tremendous head start. I would like to explore that with you.

General BERGER. Absolutely, sir.

Senator HOEVEN. Thank you, General.

General BERGER. You are welcome.

Senator HOEVEN. Admiral, number one, two, and three things you need to really advance your ability to address the challenge of China in the Pacific?

Admiral GILDAY. One is to keep shipbuilding on track clear, stable, and demand signals.

Senator HOEVEN. I think Lindsey might agree with you on that one.

Admiral GILDAY. A clear stable demand signal to the industry. We haven't always done so well in the past. We have been sinusoidal; we can't afford to be like that anymore. A continued investment in readiness, so the investment in capacity cannot be at the expense of current day readiness, we have to be ready for today, and tomorrow.

And then I think a continued focus on modernization, 70 percent of the fleet today we are going to have 10 years from now. So continuing to upgrade those capabilities, as well as taking care of the material condition of those ships is really important.

Senator HOEVEN. I think you made a really important point earlier, it is not just the numbers of ships, it is having the ships you need to do the job.

Admiral GILDAY. Yes. Yes, sir.

Senator HOEVEN. And I think that was an important point that you did make.

I would like to thank all three of you for your service, very much appreciate it, and for being here today.

Admiral GILDAY. Thank you, sir.

Senator TESTER. Senator CAPITO.

Senator CAPITO. Thank you, Mr. Chairman. And I want to thank Senator Collins as well. Thank you all for being here, and thank you for your service.

Thank you, Secretary Del Toro, for the visit to my office several weeks ago.

Over the past year, you and other defense leaders have spoken about the urgent need to increase production, particularly in munitions, to replenish our stockpiles, and be ready for the future contingencies. In particular solid rocket motors, are a critical component in our precision-guided munitions, and we need to increase our capacity. I am proud that some of these solid rocket motors, for many of our critical munitions, are made from a Navy-owned facility in the State of West Virginia.

So I would first like to ask you to visit there. Or I don't know if you have already been there, but I would love for you to have an opportunity to tour that facility in the future. So I extend that to you.

But Mr. Secretary, how important is the production of these solid rocket motors to our national security objectives and readiness?

Secretary DEL TORO. It is—

Senator CAPITO. And where are we on the pendulum here? I know we have expended a lot.

Secretary DEL TORO. Well first, Senator, thanks for your invitation. I will most certainly take you up on that.

Senator CAPITO. Right.

Secretary DEL TORO. And not just to visit West Virginia because it is a wonderful State, but because of the criticality of these solid rocket motors, we are a bit of an extremist in terms of being able to produce these at the rates that we actually need in the future. And so we have to look for additional suppliers that can produce them, we have to make sure that we don't have continued mergers of companies, for example, so that we have more competition in the industry as well, they are critical to most of our missile systems, whether it be SM-6s, or some of our larger missiles as well.

Senator CAPITO. Yes. Well, they are maximizing their space out there, so they are putting a little bit more space, or a lot more space in. Let me ask you this? Is the impact of this has anything to do with the munitions that we have sent to Ukraine? Is that why—are stockpiling enough there? Or is it just hard to keep up with the production, which one of those would be true, do you know?

Secretary DEL TORO. We have a commitment to provide Ukraine the munitions that it needs.

Senator CAPITO. Correct.

Secretary DEL TORO. And we will continue to in the future. And so that obviously has expended a lot of the munitions that we do have, therefore we have to make a commitment to increasing munitions across the board. The Office of Secretary of Defense, the Under Secretary of Defense for Acquisition and Sustainment has been completely devoted to this effort, and working with manufacturers across the country, around the world indeed.

The Secretary of Defense, himself, has invested a tremendous amount of time to working with other nations to ensure that we bring as many munitions as possible to the support of Ukraine. And that of course has allowed, or it requires us to continue to refurbish those stockpiles that we have here in the United States, in order to get to a better place.

Senator CAPITO. Right. General Berger, could you speak to this, the importance of a stockpile, and where you see that right now, where we are?

General BERGER. A couple of thoughts, ma'am. First, based on what we have seen in Ukraine in the last year the rate of expenditure of munitions, is probably a lot higher in some scenarios, some situations, than we recognize.

Senator CAPITO. Mm-hmm.

General BERGER. It is a good—in other words, a good reminder to the rest of us, war isn't a 48-, 72-hour kind of event all the time. And every day, every week the expenditure amounts are very high. We have a great process in place. I am very comfortable with it in the Department of Defense, for each request from Ukraine, getting analyzed and examined, and who can provide what.

But it is very clear that our stockpiles for training and for warfighting, we need to reassess the assumptions in those to make sure that we have the depth, because to highlight your point, our industrial base, using a phrase from the Vice Chair earlier, can't be just-in-time if we have to go to a conflict.

Senator CAPITO. No.

General BERGER. We have got to have it just-in-case, we have the depth in that industrial base to account for a big surge.

Senator CAPITO. Right. Yes. I mean, I think that is a source of concern.

Admiral, do you have a comment on this?

Admiral GILDAY. I agree with everything the General said. I think the biggest thing we learned was the expenditure rates it has caused us to go back to take a look at our own wargaming and analysis, what our predicted and expenditure rates would be, and the questions and assumptions we made. So that is why, for the

Navy and Marine Corps, you see four multiyear procurements of weapons in this budget proposal.

Senator CAPITO. So maybe your initial wargaming estimates might have been low?

Admiral GILDAY. Yes.

Senator CAPITO. Or just used differently?

Admiral GILDAY. Yes. Yes, I think that we all assumed that our expenditure rates would be lower, weapons are more technologically advanced, and that is not playing out so well, in Ukraine.

Senator CAPITO. Yes.

Admiral GILDAY. So it has informed our thinking.

Senator CAPITO. Okay. Thank you.

Admiral GILDAY. Yes, ma'am.

Senator CAPITO. General, let me ask you a question on fentanyl use in the Navy and Marine Corps. It is a national problem. It is reflected in your Force. I understand between the years 2017 to 2021, 332 of our men and women in uniform succumb to an overdose. Are you all focusing on this in the Marine Corps?

General BERGER. Absolutely, yes. I would say anywhere that you travel in a Navy and Marine Corps, on any base, any station, you are going to find fentanyl as a top-of-the-list discussion when it comes to the drug issues that are difficult to detect, and readily available and affordable, absolutely. And it is, to your point, it is a killer. Every commander, every leader, enlisted officer, is focused on it, to answer your question. Yes, ma'am.

Senator CAPITO. Well, thank you. Yes. And Mr. Secretary, I am sure that would be the same. I am out of time, but I would say it is such a different substance, and so lethal. You know, I think on the prevention and education side, you can't over-educate, and over-emphasize, just because you are taking a little pill doesn't mean that this little pill is actually what they say it is.

Mr. Secretary, I am out of time but—

Secretary DEL TORO. Senator, it is a major crisis in our Nation, and we, in the Department of Defense and the Department of the Navy are paying tremendous attention to it, to ensure that our troops understand that, and they should never be using drugs to start with, but for them to understand the real danger and threat that this immediately presents to one's life, and that there is no second chance, or it could be very little second chance—

Senator CAPITO. Right.

Secretary DEL TORO [continuing]. When it comes to the use of fentanyl.

Senator CAPITO. Thank you. Thank you all.

Admiral GILDAY. If I could just?

Senator CAPITO. Yes.

Admiral GILDAY. We characterize it as a poison, yes.

Senator CAPITO. Good.

Admiral GILDAY. To your point.

Senator CAPITO. Good. It is.

Admiral GILDAY. You don't know what you are putting in your body, and it is killing people, 107,000.

Senator CAPITO. Yes, yes. Well, thank you all very much. It is a tough fight. Thank you.

Senator TESTER. Senator Collins.

Senator COLLINS. Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

Admiral Gilday, I was pleased that my colleague from New Hampshire brought up the Shipyard and Infrastructure Optimization Program, as she says, that is a mouthful, the SIOP Program. And that is well resourced in the budget, which I am pleased to see, not only because the work that we both are interested in, at the Portsmouth Naval Shipyard in Kittery, Maine, is underway, one phase has been completed, but there is more to come, but also, because I am concerned about the number of submarines that aren't operational because they need maintenance, or refueling.

And that is a trend that we need to reverse. I am told that nearly twice as many submarines as planned were not deployable in recent months because of maintenance or other issues. Are the investments in this budget sufficient for us to try to reverse that trend?

Admiral GILDAY. I think so, ma'am. A lot of this is on us in terms of process. There are three areas that we are really focused on. One, is eliminating surprises for whether it is a private or a public yard, in terms of what they need to do. It is just like doing a house renovation. It surprises, drive your budget up, and they drive you off schedule, so we have focused on that. And I will talk about numbers in just a minute.

The second thing is material. So you have given us a pilot using OPM (Office of Personnel Management) money, so multiyear money, to not only put private yard availabilities on contract across fiscal years, but to also use that money to frontload the material so that the workers aren't waiting for that to arrive, and it is mitigating the risks that we are seeing with supply chain vulnerabilities.

The third piece is the workforce. And I know you are well-informed about, you know, developing an experienced workforce. As we continue to work with industry on that, based on those three areas, and the work that we have been doing, we have seen delay days out of shipyards come from more than 7,000 down 3,000. That is not good enough.

I predict, that based on the track that we are on, will be less than a thousand a-year-and-a-half from now. So by the end of fiscal year 2024, our goal is actually below 900. I think we are on track for that, but again the investments really in the material side, in terms of money, there is a \$0.5 billion in Virginia-class submarine repair parts in this budget alone, to address some of that.

So I think we are on the right track we are not satisfied yet, but the more operational availability that we return to fleet commanders, to your point about the submarines, the better off that we will be in terms of having a Navy operating forward.

Senator COLLINS. Thank you. With regard to the workforce, let me just mention that the Portsmouth Naval Shipyard has one of the best apprenticeship programs that I have ever seen. Each year they bring in about a hundred new people into this apprenticeship program, they train in very realistic conditions, and very confined spaces, for example, and it really is a great program. And that is what I think we need to do more of, in industry as well, so that we have a pipeline of experienced workers.

Mr. Secretary, I just have—well, I have many final questions I could ask, but I didn't want you to think I was ignoring you by not asking you a question today. And I do want to go back to the point that I made about the budget's assumptions on fuel costs, in my opening statement, because the budget request assumes some fuel price of only a \$140 per barrel. And it was ironic that on the day of the presentation of the budget the fuel costs, as measured per barrel, was 20 percent higher than budgeted.

So my final question for this hearing is: Will you work with us to make sure that we do have sufficient funding for fuel? And explain to the Committee, what would be the implications if we have under-budgeted for fuel, in terms of flying hours, steaming days, training exercises, and other readiness activities?

Secretary DEL TORO. Yes, ma'am. And it is a serious impact, because as the CNO said earlier, at any given day one-third of our Fleet and Aircraft are operational, and therefore we use fuel quite a bit. And so we are significantly impacted by the cost of that fuel. It is important to estimate those costs appropriately.

And certainly, again, you know, we thank the Congress for the support they gave us in 2023 by putting \$9 billion towards inflation, but it certainly makes it more difficult to be able to budget properly, if we don't have the budget perfectly aligned to inflation.

But that is a real difficult problem to do for OMB (Office of Management and Budget), and others, to be able to predict well ahead exactly what inflation might be next year. However, I think the greatest threat to our budget and the things that we are trying to accomplish today, actually is if the Congress were not able to pass an Appropriations Bill on time this year, and that will unquestionably, threaten all the things that we have talked about at this hearing today.

Senator COLLINS. Well, I certainly agree with you on that. And I know that the Chairman does too. And that is why the sooner we can get information back from you, including, June 10, seems awfully far off for the plan, but the sooner we can get responses the better off that we can be in getting our work done as well.

I want to sincerely thank all three of you for the time you have spent with me, and also for your testimony today. Thank you.

Senator TESTER. Thank you, Senator Collins. I will echo those remarks. We appreciate your service, we appreciate the folks that you represent, and the commitment they have to keeping this country the country it is today.

ADDITIONAL COMMITTEE QUESTIONS

I appreciate your testimony. And Senators may submit additional written questions, and we would ask that you respond to them, if you get them, in a reasonable amount of time.

[The following questions were not asked at the hearing, but were submitted to the Department for response subsequent to the hearing:]

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED TO CARLOS DEL TORO

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR JON TESTER

Question. As part of its Fiscal Year 2024 budget request, the Navy plans to de-commission 8 ships before the end of their service life, including 2 Littoral Combat

Ships. Mr. Secretary, you told us that you have enough LCS to cover your mission, but these ships are newer than my tractor back home and still have plenty of life left in them. There is no shortage of demand within the Department for additional maritime assets-particular among the Combatant Commands. Further, you last year mentioned the possibility of transferring LCS the Navy no longer wants to foreign nations.

Have you made any progress in that regard?

Answer. We have made good progress. In February 2023, Navy International Programs Office issued correspondence soliciting interest from foreign governments on potential transfer of decommissioned LCS. In response, we received formal Letters of Request for the transfer of the LCS from five (5) countries. As part of the next step, we are beginning the process of determining which interested countries can effectively operate and sustain these platforms, with the ultimate goal of allocating specific hulls for transfer.

Question. I want to ask about a pressing healthcare issue in Japan that is affecting our military readiness. When we talk to Marines stationed there, the top concern we hear about is the lack of healthcare for their dependents and DoD civilians. Constituents from Montana stationed in Japan and working for DoD have also contacted my office voicing the same concerns. I raised this issue during our recent Subcommittee briefing with the Defense Health Agency, and while I understand some policy changes have been made, concerns about Japanese hospitals denying care remain.

What are you doing to fix this problem?

Answer. Healthcare access issues impacting Sailors, Marines, families, and civilian employees stationed in Japan is an important topic for the Navy. The Japanese healthcare system operates fundamentally differently than in the United States, but we are actively working with the Defense Health Agency and other DoD components to address these issues and ensure our Sailors, Marines, families, and civilian employees get the support they need both in the continental United States and overseas, in locations like Japan.

Question. In February, the Government Accountability Office reported that the Navy is facing persistent and worsening sustainment challenges across its ten classes of surface ships. From data collected over a ten-year period, operating and support costs grew by about \$2.5 billion, while the number of operating hours of the ships actually decreased. We already have a smaller fleet than China, we can't afford ships to be stuck in port when they should be steaming. Unfortunately these findings are not surprising. Your Fiscal Year 2024 budget request adds \$1.9 billion to the Ship Maintenance account, fully funding our maintenance to capacity at the public and private shipyards. This is a good thing, but I'm not sure money alone will fix the issue.

What are some specific action items you have directed to improve fleet readiness?

Answer. I have directed Navy leadership to continue to evolve a myriad of endeavors to improve fleet readiness. Two examples include: Naval Sustainment System-Shipyards and Surface Warfare Enterprise Performance-to-Plan.

The Naval Sustainment System-Shipyards (NSS-SY) is the Navy's approach to identify and execute initiatives that reduce nuclear ship and submarine maintenance durations. NSS-SY is focused on three critical levers: reducing unplanned work, increasing throughput, and increasing material readiness. Each of these efforts is analytically supported by Center for Naval Analysis. NSS-SY waterfront efforts are focused on people-centric initiatives. NSS-SY will continue through the end of 2023 targeting on-time delivery of all availabilities. Upon completion of the NSS-SY contract, the government will assume control of all initiatives and continue improvements to work towards meeting class maintenance plans by FY 26.

Surface Warfare Enterprise Performance-to-Plan (P2P) remains the key driver to Get Real on the Navy's baseline readiness performance, identifying the most consequential levers that move the needle on outcomes and communicating performance barriers to accountable supported commanders. Through P2P-Surface (focused initially on DDG 51 Class availability performance), Navy is seeing positive results in execution leading measures including planning, reduced growth work, early contract awards, reduced contract change cycle time, and improved long lead time material (LLTM) processes reducing DDG 51 Class Days of Maintenance Delay (DoMD) by 27%, from 424 (Q1 FY 21) to 308 (Q4 FY 22).

Question. Nearly 1 year ago, three Sailors assigned to the USS George Washington committed suicide in the same week. The Navy's initial investigation found no correlation between these deaths, but found manning shortages, mental health provider shortages, and quality of life issues to be contributing factors. The Suicide Prevention and Response Independent Review Committee referred to these as "day-to-day stressors."

We have heard alarming statistics about the Navy's vacant mental health positions, and senior leaders receiving a dozen sailor suicide risk reports daily.

What reforms has the Navy implemented to respond to these suicides?

Answer. The Navy is focusing resources and action on areas with higher risk of suicide, such as units that are in a maintenance phase.

The Navy is increasing the number of mental health providers and chaplains on the waterfront. For Newport News Shipyard in particular, additional mental health professionals are now assigned to Refueling and Complex Overhaul (RCOH) aircraft carriers and have offices in close proximity to the ship. This increases accessibility and reduces commute times.

In March, the Navy published the Mental Health Playbook to help normalize conversations around mental health and provide Sailors a roadmap to navigate care options.

The Navy is also overhauling the totality of its prevention programs through the Advance Navy Culture initiative. This initiative will streamline and integrate related efforts and programs to enable on outcomes critical to readiness including increased connection, cohesion, and inclusion within commands, more effective stress management tools for Sailors in challenging environments, and an overall reduction in harmful behaviors across the force.

At the Newport News Shipyard, the Navy has taken numerous actions to improve the quality of life of Sailors. These include:

- Improving access to food options consistent with 24/7 work hours by bringing in food trucks in the evenings, reopening the self-use kitchen in the unaccompanied housing, and opening a Navy Exchange-mini-mart within the confines of the shipyard;
- Increasing Wi-Fi access, which is now available for Sailors' personal use, to increase connections to family' and friends;
- Centralizing parking, increasing the number of shuttles from parking lots to the shipyard and adding shuttle service inside the controlled industrial area;
- Implementing unit-level morale efforts on the USS George Washington by reopening retail sales, resuming monthly birthday celebrations of Sailors, hosting therapy dogs onboard and increasing engagement with the command resilience team.

More broadly, all aircraft carriers in RCOH have reviewed their sponsorship and mentorship programs, incorporating changes that benefit first-term Sailors. Welcome handbooks have been rewritten to cover mental health and other critical resources and information relevant for a first-term Sailor audience. First-term Sailors also receive command handbooks that provide a broad overview of the ship and the ship services tailored to a carrier in the shipyard.

The Department of the Navy (DON), in coordination with the Department of Defense (DoD) and the other Military Departments, is reviewing the 127 recommendations made in the Suicide Prevention and Response Independent Review Commission (SPRIRC) report from February 2023. Recommendations include policy reforms, increased services, and overall improvements to quality of life for Service Members. The DON submitted prioritization and implementation plans to the Secretary of Defense in June 2023, and anticipates further guidance upon his review.

Question. When will the final investigation report be released?

Answer. The Phase I investigation specifically looked into the contributing factors and any causal links between the three tragic suicides in April 2022. Phase I is complete and was briefed to the families in December 2022.

The Phase II investigation focused on the command climate and quality of life onboard the USS George Washington including the availability of support services, the challenging environment in the shipyard, lessons learned from past shipyard refueling overhauls, any possible effects of the COVID-19 pandemic and systemic challenges that impact aircraft carrier overhauls or construction in Newport News. Given the breadth and complexity of the investigation, a review is underway to inform the prioritization and resourcing of the recommendations. The report was released on 18 May 2023.

Question. Does the Navy have the funding it needs in this budget request to make the necessary quality of life improvements?

Answer. The DON is continuing to execute the President's Budget 2023 and has sufficient funding based on current requirements. The Navy is committed to improving quality of life for Sailors and has significantly increased mental health and suicide prevention and response investments in out years. Fiscal Year (FY) 2022 investments totaled \$62M. This increased to \$74M in FY 2023, and the projected FY 2024 investment is \$102M. These additional investments will expand clinical and non-clinical mental health resources to support Service Members in:

- Offering programs aimed at strengthening resilience and well-being

- Increasing access to embedded mental health providers
- Providing reintegration support to Service Members after a suicide attempt, and,
- Deploying rapid behavioral health support to units following a suicide.

The DON is currently assessing any need for additional funding and resources for FY 2024 and beyond to support the implementation of the 127 recommendations from the February 2023 Suicide Prevention and Response Independent Review Committee (SPRIRC) report on Preventing Suicide in the Military and the recommendations from Phase II of the USS George Washington investigation.

Question. The Department of Defense Fiscal Year 2021 Annual Report on Sexual Assault in the Military found that the Department of the Navy had the highest prevalence rate for sexual assault and unwanted sexual contact across all Services. Female Marines and male Sailors had the highest rates overall. The Suicide Prevention and Response Independent Review Committee visited with Sailors assigned to a ship in drydock. Sailors were sleeping in cars to prevent being sexually assaulted on the ship.

The recently released Annual Report for Sexual Harassment and Violence at the Military Service Academies also found an alarming prevalence increase at the U.S. Naval Academy, your pipeline for officers.

What is the Department of the Navy doing about these disturbing and unacceptable trends?

Answer. The Department of the Navy (DON) is continuing to implement the recommendations from the 2021 Independent Review Commission on Sexual Assault in the Military (IRC). In Fiscal Year 2022 (FY22), I released ALNAV 024122 Interim Policy Governing Investigations of Formal Sexual Harassment Complaints under IO US. C 1561. This interim policy requires that Investigating Officers charged with investigating formal complaints of sexual harassment come from outside the command of the victim and the subject; creating an environment that encourages victims to come forward. Additionally, I released the No Wrong Door Policy and Safe to Report Policy in June of 2022 that ensures victims receive care and support or have a “warm hand-off” appropriate service providers, as well as assurance that they will not be disciplined for minor collateral misconduct for filing an unrestricted report of sexual assault.

The DON is continuing to make strides in removing collateral duty Sexual Assault Response Coordinators (SARCs) and Sexual Assault Prevention and Response Victim Advocates (VAs) by hiring personnel at the 0–6 command level. The additional personnel will increase a workforce specifically trained to assist victims of sexual assault and sexual harassment. Hiring actions from both Navy and Marine Corps SARCs and VAs are underway and expect to replace all collateral duty personnel by FY26.

After a review of the IRC recommendations, I directed the DON to prioritize five recommendations that focused on developing, educating, and promoting our leaders, to include those in the pipeline at the United States Naval Academy. These recommendations will equip leaders with the training and education necessary to deter violence and set conditions for healthy personal and professional relationships, thereby promoting protective command climates. These five recommendations are:

DEVELOPING, EDUCATING, AND PROMOTING LEADERS

3.3b	Educate leaders on cyber harassment and technology-facilitated sexual harassment and sexual assault.
3.4d	Review and revise Professional Military Education (PME) and Department of Defense (DoD) schoolhouse curricula to mainstream Women, Peace, and Security (WPS) priorities.
3.5a	Use qualitative data to select and develop the right leaders.
3.6	Building a climate for the reduction of sexual harassment and sexual assault as a fundamental leader development requirement.
4.4c	Revise and update training modules on appropriate response to sexual assault and sexual harassment in PME for Officers and NCOs.

In August 2022, the DON defined “cyberharassment” allowing the DON to develop targeted training for Service Members and leadership on the prevention and appropriate response to harassing behaviors, including those of a sexual nature, that occur online. The DON anticipates launching cyberharassment training modules and webinars no later than (NLT) 30 September 2023 (Recommendation 3.3b).

The DON is reviewing all PME and DoD schoolhouses for WPS principles. The Marine Corps has developed two MarineNet WPS courses: one for executives and one for junior/general population to help establish a WPS baseline understanding (Recommendation 3.4d).

To select and develop the right leaders, the Navy is implementing the Naval Leadership Assessment Program (NLAP) to add more relevant and timely data to the process of selecting leaders to include reliable, and valid cognitive and non-cognitive data assessments, 360° evaluations, structured job-related psychological interviews, and formal board interviews with Navy leadership (Recommendation 3.5a).

The Navy and Marine Corps have conducted a comprehensive assessment to include a gap analysis of their leadership training curricula to ensure that the IRC recommended elements are fully integrated into future training modules. Currently, the Marine Corps Curriculum Review Board is in the process of approval for curriculum design, course descriptions, assessment overview and special areas of emphasis. The Navy is addressing curriculum gaps by piloting specific training to equip leaders to foster healthy climates (Recommendation 3.6).

The Navy and Marine Corps have evaluated their existing PME training. Both Services are on track to design curricula that would eliminate reprisal, ostracism, and retaliation for survivors that report their experiences of sexual violence. Additionally, newly formed curricula has specifically designed modules to support leaders in helping survivors that are particularly vulnerable to sexual violence. All five of these recommendations will be implemented NLT 30 September 2023 to aide in developing healthy climates and driving down the trends of sexual assault and sexual harassment as highlighted in the 2021 report.

Question. Where is the Department in hiring its prevention workforce and implementing the recommendations of the Independent Review Commission on Sexual Assault in the Military?

Answer. The DON is continuing to implement the recommendations from the IRC. In November 2022, I signed a memorandum formally establishing the DON's Integrated Primary Prevention Policy. The DON, Navy, and Marine Corps intend to hire 1,055 full-time prevention workforce personnel between Fiscal Year (FY) 2022–2028. The Navy has hired and onboarded 43 personnel. The Marine Corps has hired and onboarded 18 positions. Both Services have many hiring actions in progress and offers waiting to be accepted as it begins to ramp up the workforce.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR DIANNE FEINSTEIN

Question. The Navy has recently modernized its graving dock in San Diego and is also planning for an additional auxiliary floating dock in FY 25. While we welcome the Navy's investments in surge capacity, we also need to make sure that the Navy isn't discouraging the private sector from making and sustaining their own investments.

What is the Navy doing to ensure that the ship repair industrial base remains healthy in San Diego and that these public investments are not negatively impacting critical, existing private sector capacity?

Answer. The Navy is committed to enabling a healthy industrial base in San Diego and ensuring its actions do not have unintended negative consequences on our industry partners. The Navy's goal of utilizing the Naval Base San Diego (NBSD) graving dock remains to foster a competitive private industrial base that enables the Navy the opportunity to conduct all ship docking availabilities in ships' homeports. The NBSD graving dock was returned to service and certified to dock DDG 51 Class ships in August 2022, and within a month, the additional capacity provided by the NBSD graving dock was leveraged for an emergent docking. Had the government facility not been available, the docking would have been either delayed by approximately 8 months or the ship would have been forced out of port for the docking work, negatively impacting the crew and their families with next to no advance notice.

In its efforts to mitigate any negative impacts to our industry partners, the Navy has refined its solicitation considerations for use of the NBSD graving dock and has implemented mechanisms that can allow for the place of performance to be changed to a private dock post-award if the contractor's dock would otherwise remain empty. The Navy continues to engage private repair yards and solicit feedback and refine its approach to maximize private dock usage and to use public docks to maintain competition. The Navy remains committed to working with industry and Congress to meet maintenance requirements while also promoting health of the industrial base.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR LISA MURKOWSKI

Question. I understand the Navy is collaborating with the Coast Guard in designing the Polar Security Cutters.

Can you discuss how far along you are in the design process and elaborate on this project?

What is the Navy doing to assist with the stopgap while we wait for the ice-breaker?

Answer. The Navy is collaborating with the Coast Guard on the Detail Design and Construction of the Polar Security Cutter (PSC), having formalized the relationship with a Memorandum of Agreement signed in 2017 to define specific roles and resource contributions. The PSC program is managed by an Integrated Program Office (IPO) comprised of Coast Guard and Navy personnel.

The PSC remains in the Detail Design phase. An Initial Critical Design Review (CDR) was held in March 2022 and planning for the Final CDR is ongoing. The IPO expects the Final CDR to be held within the next 8 months. Design efforts related to the Final CDR directly support Production Readiness Review (PRR) milestones and ultimately the start of construction.

Additionally, the IPO created a Prototype Fabrication Assessment (PFA) period, which is projected to start this summer and will provide a ramp up period to facilitate a seamless transition to construction. This risk reduction effort will allow for the construction of as many as eight PSC modules prior to PRR to accelerate industrial learning, allow the shipbuilder to test its production processes, and train its skilled workforce on the unique characteristics of the steel being used to construct this polar icebreaker.

Question. There has been significant activity from our adversaries in the Arctic, however I have noticed a significant lack of presence from our own Navy by comparison.

Do you have the shore side infrastructure to support a naval presence in the Arctic?

Answer. Naval forces are unique in their ability to operate at sea away from fixed land bases. The ability to sustain and replenish surface ships, at sea and the persistent presence of our submarines gives the Navy a tremendous advantage in the austere and remote regions of the Arctic. Following National Defense Strategy guidance, the Navy accomplishes defense and protection of the homeland by using our bases in the Atlantic and Pacific, along with the bases offered by our Allies and Partners. The bases the Navy operates from are considered the fixed posture that allows the Navy to have presence anywhere in the world. This is the same whether the Navy operates in the Indo-Pacific, Atlantic, Caribbean, or the Arctic. Additionally, Naval air presence is supported by Joint Force and Interagency partner shore-side infrastructure. Of note, Naval Air Facility Adak was closed during the base realignment and closure (BRAC) in 1997.

Question. Does this budget address the shore side needs of the Navy to have an Arctic presence?

Answer. Navy does not currently have any specific military construction requirements in the Arctic; therefore, the budget does not address any shore side needs of the Navy to have an Arctic presence.

Question. After WWII, the DoD dumped hundreds of tons of chemical weapons (mustard agent and Lewisite) at 2,000 fathoms depth off Attu. DoD was required by the 2007 Defense Authorization Act to conduct a survey of such sites in Hawaii and Alaska, yet it only conducted such surveys in shallow, tropical waters of Hawaii (two sites), and then argued that such a survey in Alaska was not needed, as the Hawaii and Alaska sites were 'substantially similar.' This is categorically not so.

Why the DoD decline?

Answer. The Navy respectfully defers to OSD to explain DoD policy for representative site selection in response to Sec. 314 of the FY 2007 NDAA.

Question. Will the Navy conduct a survey in Alaska?

Answer. The Navy reviewed the language in accordance with Sec. 314 of the FY 2007 NDAA, the Navy has and will comply with direction from the Secretary of Defense on locations to be surveyed.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR JERRY MORAN

Question. It is my understanding that the CDC-Agency for Toxic Substances and Disease Registry (ATSDR) is on-site in Hawaii reviewing records of families who were affected by the Red Hill water contamination, at the request of the Navy. I think the ATSDR's presence is a step in the right direction to find answers for the 93,000 affected individuals. I understand that Service Members do not need to grant authorization for this type of review, but families of Service Members have reported no communication or transparency relating to CDC-ATSDR's presence in Hawaii.

What is the purpose of the review and when will you be communicating with families about this review and its purpose?

Answer. Defense Health Agency Public Health requested CDC/ATSDR epidemiologic assistance to better understand the illnesses reported by families impacted by the Red Hill fuel release. CDC/ATSDR officers reviewed the medical records of 653 individuals potentially exposed to the fuel release. Defense Health Agency Public Health will communicate the findings to the Red Hill community through multiple platforms including a Red Hill Health e-update, website, and webinar.

Question. What guidance have you put out to commanders on the ground about what to communicate to these families?

Answer. First and foremost, Navy leaders—at all levels—encourage individuals to seek medical attention if they are experiencing symptoms. In January 2023, the Defense Health Agency established the Red Hill Clinic, which provides same-day consultations for those experiencing symptoms potentially related to the Red Hill fuel release. Regarding the CDC-Agency for Toxic Substances and Disease Registry (CDC/ATSDR), local Navy leadership and public affairs offices publicized the CDC/ATSDR survey and strongly encouraged participation. The Navy has also hosted town halls that included representatives from EPA, DOH and the CDC/ATSDR to provide information and answer questions from military personnel, families and the local community. The Navy will continue to coordinate closely with the Defense Health Agency, the Hawaii Department of Health, and the CDC/ATSDR to share information with the public as soon as it is available.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR JOHN BOOZMAN

Question. Congress strongly supports increased funding to build, maintain, and expand our naval fleet. While supporting the domestic American manufacturing base. However, our defense manufacturing base is facing challenges from foreign competition. For example, it is my understanding that the Navy's Constellation Class power systems upgrade was completed by a European manufacturer over a domestic manufacturer because the Navy focused on cost instead of enforcing domestic content requirements for power generation equipment.

Can you please share what the Navy is doing to ensure strong enforcement of domestic content and Buy America standards, which will in turn support our domestic manufacturers? Do you support stronger domestic content requirements for power generation equipment?

Answer. The health of the shipbuilding industrial base and sub-tier suppliers is vital to meeting our National Defense Strategy. Balancing imperatives such as strategic industrial base capabilities, supply chain resiliency, and affordability is a complex task. Through collaboration and smart investments, the industrial base can adapt and grow to build and maintain the fleet we need. The Navy is in compliance with domestic sourcing requirements and continually monitors and works with industry partners, including sub-tier suppliers, to assess the general health of the industrial base and identify opportunities for strengthening areas in need of reinforcement. This is almost always accomplished by encouraging competition while ensuring key domestic suppliers have sufficient work to sustain themselves. The Constellation Class power and propulsion systems are being manufactured to baseline requirements and have not undergone an upgrade. Although Section 8113(b) of Public Law 116-9, the FY 2020 Consolidated Appropriations Act, directs all propulsion engines and main reduction gears be manufactured domestically by the 11th ship, the Constellation Class will deliver ship 2 with 100% domestically built power and propulsion systems. Additionally, the power and propulsion equipment manufacturing transition has begun on the first ship with training United States workers on foreign production lines. The Navy supports all current domestic content requirements and will continue to assess opportunities to strengthen the domestic shipbuilding industrial base.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED TO ADMIRAL MICHAEL M. GILDAY

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR JON TESTER

Question. All military Services are facing historic recruiting challenges. There are many factors at play here, but notable causes remain a shrinking pool of eligible candidates, and a competitive job market. Last year, the Navy took a significant number of recruits from its Delayed Entry Program (DEP) Pool to try to meet its recruiting goals, thereby significantly depleting the Navy's accessions pipeline for

this year. The Marine Corps reduced the size of its force below its Force Design 2030 goal.

How is recruiting going for the Department of the Navy this year?

Answer. Navy Recruiting Command (NRC) continues to aggressively work towards the Fiscal Year 2023 (FY23) accession mission, but is experiencing challenges. The previous FY was one of the toughest in recruiting history and NRC was unable to refill the DEP pool back to a healthy level of 50 percent. The inability to rebuild a healthy DEP created conditions for a contract-and- ship environment, which places additional stress on achieving the required mission. Throughout this FY, NRC has experienced great difficulty attracting Sailors in specific high-demand fields (Nuclear Field, Information Warfare, Special Warfare/Operations, Submarine, and certain aviation specialties), due to strong competition from the other Services and industry, a decline in labor force participation rate, a decline/loss of relationships and recruiter contacts, and a low market propensity among the target demographic. Propensity to serve declined from 13 percent to nine percent, which equates to approximately 1.2 million fewer prospects. In order to be successful this year, Navy will have to match or exceed the highest average contracting rate (927 Net Contract Attained (NCA)/week) in more than a decade to make the accessions mission.

Question. Are you on track to meet your authorized strength levels?

Answer. The Navy is employing numerous recruiting, attrition, and retention mitigations to help mitigate the end strength shortfalls in FY23. However, due to the challenging recruiting environment and the growing strength profile from FY22 to FY23, Navy does not anticipate achieving authorized strength levels in FY23.

Question. In February, the Government Accountability Office reported that the Navy is facing persistent and worsening sustainment challenges across its ten classes of surface ships. From data collected over a ten-year period, operating and support costs grew by about \$2.5 billion, while the number of operating hours of the ships actually decreased. We already have a smaller fleet than China, we can't afford ships to be stuck in port when they should be steaming.

The GAO report was specific to surface ship maintenance, but submarines are also plagued with longer than expected repair periods.

What are we doing to increase readiness of the submarine force?

Answer. Navy leadership remains dedicated to reducing our submarine's days of maintenance delay and returning our fighting force back to the fleet as expeditiously as possible. The Navy is executing multiple initiatives for improvement to eliminate the root causes of the delays. These initiatives are part of the Naval Sustainment System-Shipyard (NSS-SY) and referred to as Pillars of effort. Each Pillar is led by a flag officer to ensure enterprise accountability. The Pillars include Engineering, Inside Shops, Waterfront, People, Fleet Ops, Infrastructure, Information Technology, Cost, and Planning. The Navy is engaged across the spectrum of submarine maintenance and modernization and is targeting improvements that will increase overall submarine readiness.

In conjunction with these Pillars, the Navy established several critical efforts to drive change and improvements to the maintenance and sustainment periods through the implementation of a VIRGINIA Class (VACL) Material Strategy as well as additional focused efforts in the areas of Supplier Development, Shipyards Infrastructure, Strategic Outsourcing, and Workforce Development.

VACL Material Strategy comprises four critical actions:

1. Ensure proper phasing of material funding to support having a majority of the material at start of maintenance availabilities.
2. Ensure proper levels of material funding per availability.
3. Ensure the material funding is clearly separated/identified.
4. Develop and implement a Bill of Material strategy to increase material availability.

Key PB-24 investments in SSN maintenance are:

- Fully funds Submarine Maintenance (1B4B) which will improve confidence in schedule execution and material availability for planned submarine overhauls. (\$972M (FYDP))
- Invests in the long lead-time (LLTM) materials that are causing significant delays in VCS availabilities. (\$896M (FYDP))
- Addresses obsolete systems or components and invests in outsourced work to enable shipyard worker focus on critical path work. (\$761M (FYDP))
- Restores Navy Working Capital Fund investment in VCS material made in FY23. (\$350M (FYDP))
- Funds planning of a private shipyard VCS availability in heel-to-toe fashion following BOISE EOH, continuing Navy's partnership with private industry. (\$170M (FYDP))

The Navy is aggressively pursuing this VACL Material Strategy with all stakeholders to address material issues impacting VACL maintenance performance. A key focus is to bolster the industrial base in the following areas:

Supplier Development

Develop existing suppliers and expand the number of Submarine Industrial Base suppliers to better support material needs. The Navy is working with stakeholders, including the two prime submarine shipbuilders—General Dynamics Electric Boat (GDEB) and Huntington Ingalls Industries—Newport News Shipbuilding (HII–NNS), to improve oversight and assessment of the supply chain, including conducting annual health and readiness assessments of the supplier base that supports the submarine shipbuilding enterprise. Using a comprehensive risk management approach, critical suppliers are evaluated on their ability to meet current demand and grow to meet future demand. This oversight and accountability model enables greater visibility of supply chain health and data informed decisionmaking that transition information to action.

Investments in the Submarine Industrial Base ultimately provide additional benefits to sustainment, as beneficiary companies and suppliers supporting new construction also manufacture spares used for submarine maintenance availabilities.

Shipyard Infrastructure

The Navy, GDEB, and HII–NNS, have each invested to expand and modernize facilities and shipyard infrastructure to support submarine construction capacity. The Navy has primarily used capital expenditure (CAPEX) and Construction Readiness Incentives (CRI) to support both shipbuilders' capital investments. The Navy and both shipbuilders have reached a common understanding of the current facilities, fixtures, footprint, and resources needed to achieve the construction capacity to reach the COLUMBIA SSBN and two VACL SSN (1+2) serial submarine construction rate, as well as the risks and constraints as part of that baseline. Additionally, the Navy is investing in the modernization and expansion of facilities and infrastructure at the public shipyards through the Navy's Shipyard Infrastructure Optimization Plan (SIOP). Specifically, SIOP is designed to update the physical layout of the four public shipyards, upgrade and modernize their dry docks, and replace antiquated capital equipment. FY23 enacted appropriations included \$1.8B for SIOP efforts. PB24 continues SIOP investments requesting \$2.7B in FY24 and \$9.9B across the FYDP.

Strategic Outsourcing

Strategic outsourcing provides the dual benefit of supporting increased production at the public shipyards while leveraging existing capacity and stabilizing the workload for other industry partners. These efforts are focused on increasing depot-level capacity and reducing CNO availability duration. This work includes a combination of preservation, onboard ship system work, structural, electrical shop work, support services, and component repairs.

At the private shipyards, GDEB is continuing to execute a combination of traditional "buy" purchase orders and the Focus Factory (FF) outsourcing concept, which is a dedicated approach to allow the transfer of work and technical rigor to the industrial base using shipbuilder instructions, processes, and supervision. Newport News Shipbuilding (NNS) is outsourcing approximately 1 million labor hours per year to address footprint and work center capacity constraints. This work includes a combination of large structural assemblies, steel fabrication, machining, and blast and coat operations. NNS intends to maintain this level of outsourcing over the next 5 years based on current demand signals. An extensive amount of work has been performed to assess and develop suppliers to support this workload. Suppliers are beginning to demonstrate the ability to overcome the learning curve but workforce development and employee retention remain challenging.

Workforce Development

To keep pace with the existential threat of shrinking manufacturing base expertise and experience, the nation must view the generational increase in requirements for submarine shipbuilding and maintenance as an opportunity to reimagine traditional approaches. These approaches must address skilled labor resource shortages, bridge disconnects between school-based education and domestic defense manufacturing skillsets and reinvigorate community connection with the Navy mission. The Navy is implementing a strategy in partnership with the Office of the Secretary of Defense Industrial Base Analysis and Sustainment Program, industry, regional trade associations, and state/local governments to address critical Submarine Industrial Base workforce challenges in the attraction, recruitment, training and development, and retention of the vital defense industrial base workforce.

Workforce Pay and Retention

NAVSEA is leveraging a three-pronged approach to address hiring challenges and improve retention.

- Special Pay Rates: One of the leading indicators related to under performance of hiring plans is the disparity of pay in comparison to private industry. Each shipyard developed data-driven positions to be considered for Special Pay Rates
- Through the Naval Sustainment System-Shipyard (NSS-SY) People Pillar, the Expert Tradesperson initiative creates a career path that incentivizes our best and brightest mechanics to stay in the Wage Grade field. The Expert Tradesperson position was established with a clear vision and intent to enhance a career in trades and increase responsibilities and authorities within the production department, thereby dramatically improving throughput and productive capacity.
- Pursuing Exceptions to Pay Increase Limitations: Annual appropriations law found in the Financial Services and General Government Appropriations Act places limits on wage schedule increases for Federal Wage System positions. This limitation does not provide parity with private industry and places undue burden on the naval shipyards to recruit or retain qualified employees.

Strategic Submarines Sustainment Efforts

OHIO Class SSBNs remain the cornerstone of our national security. The Navy established Program Management Office (PMS) 396 in October 2021 to focus on the sustainment of OHIO Class SSBNs for fleet tasking and is taking a multi-pronged approach to SSBN sustainment and readiness. This includes technical rigor and adherence to requirements, proactive solutions to maintenance and material issues, incremental modernization to meet future needs/threats, continuous data feedback and analyses to routinely refine and improve maintenance requirements, work execution, and develop/execute depot maintenance schedule.

Similar to the VACL, the Navy remains dedicated to reducing our strategic submarines' days of maintenance delay and returning our fighting force back to the fleet. We are ensuring VACL lessons are implemented and applied and have focused efforts in the areas of Supplier Development and Sea-Based Strategic Deterrence Infrastructure.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR TAMMY BALDWIN

Question. Admiral Gilday, during the hearing, General Berger explained his justification for listing the LPD as his number one item on the Marine Corps Unfunded Priorities List, can you please respond to his points?

If the Navy does not plan to purchase an LPD for the next 5 years, how will the Navy fill that capability gap and/or mitigate associated risks with ceasing acquisition of the LPD?

Answer. General Berger and I agree on the requirement for 31 amphibious ships, and we are committed to ensuring we meet this requirement and do so in a timely manner, but with a capable, sustainable mix of ship classes that will support our Marines and Sailors for decades to come. The FY24 budget reflects a pause in procuring LPDs in order to conduct an LPD 17 Flt II amphibious ship cost/capability study and complete the Battle Force Ship Assessment & Requirement (BFSAR) report to Congress which will inform the FY25 budget's way ahead for LPD acquisition.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR LISA MURKOWSKI

Question. The Navy has conducted three surveys of WWII munitions and explosives of concern (including Unexploded Ordnance, UXO) on the seabed at Unalaska, and has identified several areas where these hazards may be. It has concluded that risks to public safety are present in many of these areas. I, and I believe the Navy view these seabed MEC/UXOs as a serious risk to public safety in the Unalaska/Dutch Harbor area. Yet, the Navy does not plan to conduct another survey until 2027. To date the Navy has apparently only used Side Scan Sonar in its surveys, but no underwater metal detectors, ROVs, Synthetic Aperture Sonar, to locate these explosive hazards.

Why?

Answer. The Navy is committed to protecting human health and the environment by investigating, remediating and implementing response actions at munition sites on land and at sea. To protect public safety in the Unalaska/Dutch Harbor area, the

Navy is implementing response actions to include land use controls, notifying the public, and conducting outreach to communities that might access the area.

While there have been great strides in the past several years to develop and obtain technologies that can find munitions on the seafloor, there are currently no technologies or equipment that can operate in the challenging sea conditions in Alaska and provide high-fidelity information to identify and classify Munitions and Explosives of Concern (MEC). The Navy has assessed the ability of other equipment, such as Remotely Operated Vehicles and currently available metal detectors, to operate in the Unalaska/Dutch Harbor area as well. Unfortunately, these technologies do not generate data results that are superior to side scan sonar.

The planned MEC survey dates in Fiscal Year 2027 (FY 27) are based on the expected timelines to develop new technology through the Department of Defense's Strategic Environmental Research and Development Program (SERDP) and the Environmental Security Technology Certification Program (ESTCP). The Navy plans to use synthetic aperture sonar along with other equipment FY27. The Navy remains committed to moving forward on underwater investigation and remediation as soon as possible, and will adjust timelines as suitable equipment is available.

Question. Will the Navy use all technologies at its disposal, to locate these MEC/UXOs, and to the extent that is safe, remove or contain these munition hazards such that they no longer pose a threat to the local public?

Answer. Yes, the Navy is committed to taking all actions necessary to protect human health and the environment.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR JERRY MORAN

Question. The Skillbridge program is a valuable and effective program for servicemembers to gain practical civilian work experience prior to separation. The Navy recently released guidance restricting access to Skillbridge for its senior enlisted and officers. While, the Navy's recruiting challenges are not as drastic as others, I believe the Navy should be prioritizing programs to stay ahead of this issue.

Can you share what specific information and factors influenced this guidance?

Answer. The Navy's rationale for these program changes is to balance between mission readiness and Sailors' ability to improve post-service employment opportunities, consistent with the MyNavy HR Strategic Goal to Build a Navy that can Fight and Win.

The Navy understands the value of SkillBridge for transitioning Sailors. Our policy changes focus SkillBridge opportunities on junior Sailors who are less likely to have extensive formal education, or highly developed skillsets, placing them at the highest risk for post-service unemployment. These changes focus the program on those whom it was intended to help, while also taking into account critical manning needs and mission readiness.

The Navy is also mindful of the significant investment we make in officer education. These policy changes ensure maximum return on that investment by requiring officers to fulfill their commitments to the Navy before embarking on SkillBridge.

Question. Did you consult with DoD before issuing these new guidelines?

Answer. Yes. We socialized our proposed policy changes with SkillBridge leadership at the Office of the Under Secretary of Defense for Personnel and Readiness.

Question. Private sector firms are providing incredible fellowships and internships at no cost to the Services beyond sustaining the service members' pay and benefits.

Does the Navy have an alternative program that costs less and delivers similar outcomes while also improving the transition experience?

Answer. The Navy is fully committed to assisting our Sailors' successful transition to civilian life. It is our goal to enable former Sailors to become productive citizens and ambassadors for the Navy in which they served. We fully support and encourage their participation in the Transition Assistance Program as required by law, along with participation in other transition or internship programs, such as SkillBridge, as the individual unit's mission requirements allow.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR JOHN BOOZMAN

Question. In a potential conflict in the Indo-Pacific region, the strength of our Navy will be one of the key factors for control of the region. Given the current pace of the People's Republic of China (PRC) naval expansion, now more than ever we must focus on improving and maintaining the readiness of our current fleet.

Admiral Gilday, I know that you understand this problem better than anyone. Can you please talk to the initiatives that the Navy is implementing to modernize

and optimize our shipyards to ensure our fleet is prepared for the possibility of future conflict?

Answer. The Navy's primary initiative to modernize and optimize the four public shipyards is the Shipyard Infrastructure Optimization Program (SIOP). Shipyards with resilient facilities, efficient layouts, modernized equipment, and digital interconnections generate Fleet readiness and strengthen our Nation's security.

With the support received from Congress—to include the \$1.7 billion appropriated in Fiscal Year (FY) 2023—SIOP is advancing three lines of effort (LOE): (1) deliver required dry dock repairs and upgrades to support current and planned classes of nuclear-powered aircraft carriers and submarines, (2) optimize workflow within the shipyards through significant changes to their physical layout and modernizing facilities, and (3) recapitalize obsolete industrial plant equipment with modern technology, substantially increasing productivity and safety. In addition, SIOP provides a unique opportunity to address environmental stewardship, climate change, and energy resiliency, while updating the shipyards to Navy criteria and industry standards.

SIOP has already achieved a number of accomplishments:

- Completion of the Portsmouth Naval Shipyard (PNSY) Super Flood Basin construction project and the modernized Norfolk Naval Shipyard (NNSY) Dry Dock 4.
- Construction contract awards for the NNSY Dry Dock 8 Saltwater Upgrades and the Pearl Harbor Naval Shipyard (PHNS) Dry Dock 3 Replacement.
- Preliminary design of a Gerald R. Ford-class aircraft carrier capable dry dock at Puget Sound Naval Shipyard (PSNS).
- Awarding multiple Facilities Sustainment, Restoration, and Modernization projects across all four shipyards.
- Making a of range of capital equipment investments to include delivery of a 175-ton portal crane to PNSY.

The foundation of SIOP's optimization effort is made up of the industrial modeling and simulation, engineering studies, and area development plans underway for each shipyard. SIOP completed the first increment of industrial modeling in 2022, which provided facility-level data describing optimized workflow among buildings and validated reductions in ship maintenance availability durations achievable by optimizing facility layouts and infrastructure. The second increment of industrial modeling started in 2022 and focuses on processes within each building to optimize shop floor layout and equipment to further increase efficiencies. Using the modeled data from the first increment of industrial modeling and data gathered from engineering studies, area development plans are underway at all four shipyards. Leveraging a SIOP-tailored major defense acquisition process, the Navy will make investment decisions that will lead to design and construction of the preferred alternative at each shipyard.

As the deliberate, long-term planning progresses that will create the efficiencies and throughput needed in our public shipyards, the Navy is making significant near-term investments in facilities and equipment to support the platforms in the fleet and entering service. The Navy's FY 2024 President's Budget Submission confirms the Administration's commitment to SIOP with \$9.9B of funding across the FYs 2024–2028 Future Years Defense Program.

Navy readiness demands that all SIOP investments are coordinated with fleet operational commitments to ensure alignment of requirements, construction, and ship maintenance, while remaining mindful of the impact SIOP will have on our shipyard workers and our need for sustainable infrastructure. This includes ensuring the program is integrated with the Naval Sea Systems Command Performance to Plan, the Naval Sustainment System—Shipyards efforts, local communities and regulators, and the Administration's climate initiatives.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED TO GENERAL DAVID H. BERGER

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR JON TESTER

Question. You recently quoted a 32 percent readiness rate for our amphibious fleet. You're not proposing to buy any new amphibious ships in the 2024 budget, but at the same time are proposing to retire 3 amphibious ships, further shrinking the fleet.

What size amphibious fleet do we need to support Force Design 2030?

Answer. We need no less than 31 Amphibious Warfare Ships to enable Marine Corps Title 10 missions in support of the joint force while providing minimal ARG/MEU presence globally in support of Combatant Commanders. This number is

threat informed and risk assessed. It is scenario based, and model driven through a multiple phase event executed by the analytic arms of the Navy and the Marine Corps. It is imperative for delivering our Marines and their equipment on time, at decisive locations, to contest strategic areas in support of our Nation's most demanding war planning efforts. However, there is still significant risk with only 31 amphibious warfare ships due to readiness. Even with an inventory of 31, four of our last five ARG/MEUs have been delayed, and one patrol executed with two ships instead of three. This requirement is consistent with 11 amphibious warfare ship inventory studies completed over the last 14 years.

Question. Is it accurate that last year, the Marine Corps was unable to support certain recent deployment requirements from the Combatant Commanders?

Answer. The Marine Corps remains postured and prepared to serve as the Nation's crisis response force, providing credible forces where the Nation is least ready. Last year, following the Russian invasion of Ukraine in February of 2022, Marines stood ready to sortie to the U.S. European Command. However, due to readiness issues of certain Amphibious Warfare Ships, we were unable to provide this option to the EUCOM Commander and Secretary of Defense.

Then, in February of this year, when Turkey experienced one of the most devastating earthquakes in the region's history, Marines who are trained and prepared to support humanitarian aid operations were once again ready to deploy. Due to the availability of amphibious shipping, this deployment option was not available to the Secretary of Defense. An amphibious ship with embarked Marines could have provided the Combatant Commander with capabilities such as a hospital, large berthing spaces, water purification, heavy lift helicopters, debris removal, and transportation via MV-22 tiltrotor aircraft, and a landing force of 2,400 Marines trained in Humanitarian Assistance/Disaster Relief (HA/DR). Instead, Marines forward based in Naples, Italy established a forward crisis response operations center at Incirlik Air Base in Turkey. Without the organic and sovereign capabilities of an embarked MEU aboard amphibious ships, this HA/DR response option was severely reduced, and the nation was unable to support a NATO partner as we traditionally have in a crisis.

Question. All military services are facing historic recruiting challenges. There are many factors at play here, but notable causes remain a shrinking pool of eligible candidates, and a competitive job market.

Last year, the Navy took a significant number of recruits from its Delayed Entry Pool to try to meet its recruiting goals, thereby significantly depleting the Navy's accessions pipeline for this year. The Marine Corps reduced the size of its force below its Force Design 2030 goal.

Is readiness now a concern for the Marine Corps?

Answer. The Marine Corps remains the Nation's force-in-readiness—a postured naval expeditionary force ready to deter adversaries, respond to crisis and conflict, and contribute to Naval and Joint Force operations. Our identity as Marines centers on being ready to deter, fight, and win. As individuals, as units, and as a Corps, everything we do is in support of warfighting advantage and being most ready when the Nation is least ready. This is our obligation to the American people.

Our FY23 end strength target is 172,300. While enlisted recruiting continues to face unprecedented challenges, retention is responding positively across almost all metrics. For both first term reenlistments and career-oriented Marines we have retained over 104% of our goal. This retention rate of this magnitude is record setting. Current plans achieve the Force Design 2030 floor of 174,600 by FY30; the intent is to achieve the floor sooner if possible. The Marine Corps adjusted its Active Component enlisted recruiting mission in FY22 by 1,500 to mitigate the effects of COVID and new medical screening system implementation. Despite FY22 challenges, the Marine Corps achieved its enlisted recruiting goal. However, doing so reduced the Service's delayed entry recruit pool from a historical average of over 50% to approximately 30%. The FY23 Active Component enlisted recruiting mission was modified in December 2022 from 31,900 to 28,900 to mitigate risk due to the current recruiting environment and limit further delayed entry pool degradation.

Our Nation is facing a recruiting strain that is unparalleled in the All-Volunteer Force era. All Services are affected by the current confluence of a stagnant youth population, declining youth propensity to serve, declining percentage of qualified youth, and fragmented advertising markets. This is a national problem requiring a whole-of-nation dialogue. In keeping with the tenets of Force Design 2030, the Marine Corps is increasing retention of our highest performing Marines, especially within leadership and highly technical billets. This will prepare our forces to succeed on dispersed, complex, distributed, and high-technology future battlefields. We will continue to refine our policies consistent with Talent Management 2030 to best align the innate aptitudes, unique skill sets, and personal and professional aspira-

tions of individual Marines to the warfighting requirements of the Marine Corps—over the entirety of a Marine’s career. Young Americans who earn the title of “Marine” can expect to be challenged through higher quality, more intense, and more sophisticated training and education than ever before.

Question. I want to ask about a pressing healthcare issue in Japan that is affecting our military readiness. When we talk to Marines stationed there, the top concern we hear about is the lack of healthcare for their dependents and DoD civilians.

Constituents from Montana stationed in Japan and working for DoD have also contacted my office voicing the same concerns.

I raised this issue during our recent Subcommittee briefing with the Defense Health Agency, and while I understand some policy changes have been made, concerns about Japanese hospitals denying care remain.

Are you hearing the same from Marines and civilians stationed in Japan?

Answer. Yes, healthcare access issues impacting Marines, families, and civilian employees stationed in Japan is an important topic for the Marine Corps. At the recent Executive meeting of USMC 3 and 4 star Generals, this topic was prioritized. The Japanese healthcare system operates fundamentally differently than in the United States. There is a different mechanism for accessing care both in a prehospital setting and specialty care. We are actively working with the Defense Health Agency and other DoD components to address these issues and ensure our Marines, families, and civilian employees get the support they need both in the continental United States and overseas, in locations like Japan.

Question. Last fiscal year, the Marine Corps did not spend all of its initial funding to begin hiring its prevention workforce.

What is the status of the Marine Corps hiring for these positions?

Answer. To date, 85 positions are posted or have selected candidates with Tentative Job Offers and 24 personnel have been hired. The Marine Corps noted in the OSD Implementation Roadmap development that execution of IRC recommendations require time for implementation planning and assessments, clarification of tasks, and Service-specific input to support a phased, iterative approach. The accelerated funding the Marine Corps received at the beginning of the 3rd quarter FY22 in support of the IRC was not obligated. Originally, the Marine Corps was planning for FY23 implementation of the IRC recommendations. Since notification of FY22 funding, the Marine Corps has completed the necessary administrative actions and all hiring/payroll processes to commence IRC hiring actions in support of IRC requirements. The full implementation of Marine Corps hiring, based on SAPR IRC recommendations, is in progress.

Question. Are you on track to fill these positions this fiscal year?

Answer. No. We are behind. That said, we are working to get on track with filling these positions this fiscal year and are currently at 14 percent of our FY23 goal to hire 369 positions worldwide, with new vacancy announcements being posted regularly. These positions include 121 SARCAs, 194 Victim Advocates, 23 Primary Prevention Integrators, and 31 Equal Opportunity Advisors. Marine Corps implementation of all IRC requirements will require significant enduring resourcing, programmatic changes for manpower training, and military justice policy and authorities.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR JOHN BOOZMAN

Question. General Berger, I read in your written statement that you have invested significantly in quality-of-life improvements for Marines living in the barracks. However, I also saw that 16% of the facilities are in poor or failing conditions.

What investments can we make to ensure that Marines and their families have the high-quality housing they deserve, and do you see a correlation between the quality of your barracks and housing and the recruiting and retention issue?

Answer. The Marine Corps sees a direct correlation between the condition of our quality of life (QOL) facilities with recruitment and retention. As stated in the Marine Corps’ Talent Management 2030 plan, “Quality of life is one of the leading reasons Marines choose to depart our Corps. We must renew our focus on meeting Marines’ needs like high-quality barracks, family housing, and chow halls; adequate childcare center capacity; and sufficient options for pediatric care.”

To achieve these goals, the Marine Corps will invest \$116M to renovate 13 barracks in FY24, as well as over \$201M in family housing construction and operations. The Marine Corps strives to improve the QOL for its service members and their families, and with these investments, hopes to increase retention and recruiting measures.

Question. General Berger, I understand a large part of Force Design and the stand-in forces concept is forward deployed Marines who are already in place when the worst-case scenario unfolds. This plan requires resiliency, self-sufficiency, and the ability to punch back, after taking a punch. It seems the MRIC, or Medium-Range Intercept Capability system is important for this capacity.

Can you tell me about this systems progress and your planned investments for FY24?

Answer. MRIC is an expeditionary, land-based, medium-range, surface-to-air fires system that will enable Joint, Marine Corps, and partner forces to operate and persist within contested areas by providing these forces with the capability to defend against cruise missiles and other aerial threats. The Marine Corps is utilizing a Middle Tier Acquisition (MTA) approach to procure an MRIC prototype system. The MRIC rapid prototype effort began in FY21, demonstrated success against relevant target profiles through a series of multiple live fire tests during FY22 and FY23, and remains on track to deliver a prototype system to conduct operationally relevant demonstrations by the end of FY25. This will inform the Marine Corps' follow-on materiel development decision in order to meet the Force Design requirement to field an MRIC Battery to each of the three Low Altitude Air Defense (LAAD) Battalions in FY26, FY27, and FY28.

The FY24 President's Budget request \$44M to support munition and component level procurement of the prototype system, as well as the operation and maintenance, and research and development requirements for the planned operational demonstration and necessary preparatory events and activities. These include training Marines to operate the prototype system, performance of an operational demonstration in Arizona, and conducting a quick reaction assessment in New Mexico. The last event will be overseen by the Marine Corps' Operational Test and Evaluation Activity.

SUBCOMMITTEE RECESS

Senator TESTER. Look, I think predictability in the industrial base is really, really important. And I think, making sure we are getting the biggest bang for the buck, by getting folks to have competitive contracts, and getting these out on time is also very important.

And I look forward to working with all three of you, as do Senator Collins, to make sure that when this budget hits the ground, we all know what is in it, and we all know what to expect the results of it are, because I think it is a critically important moment in time. So thank you all for what you do.

This defense subcommittee will reconvene on Tuesday, April 18, at 10 a.m., to hear from the Air Force.

We stand in recess.

[Whereupon, at 11:33 a.m., Tuesday, March 28, the subcommittee was recessed, to reconvene at 10 a.m., Tuesday, April 18.]

DEPARTMENT OF DEFENSE APPROPRIATIONS FOR FISCAL YEAR 2024

TUESDAY, APRIL 18, 2023

U.S. SENATE,
SUBCOMMITTEE OF THE COMMITTEE ON APPROPRIATIONS,
Washington, DC.

The subcommittee met at 10 a.m. in room SD-192, Dirksen Senate Office Building, Hon. Jon Tester (chairman) presiding.

Present: Senators Tester, Murray, Baldwin, Shaheen, Collins, Murkowski, Moran, Hoeven, Boozman, and Capito.

DEPARTMENT OF DEFENSE

DEPARTMENT OF THE AIR FORCE

OFFICE OF THE SECRETARY

STATEMENT OF HON. FRANK KENDALL, SECRETARY

OPENING STATEMENT OF SENATOR JON TESTER

Senator TESTER. Good morning, everybody. And I want to call this committee meeting to order.

I want to welcome our witnesses; Secretary Kendall, General Brown, General Saltzman, thank you for your leadership and commitment to our Air Force and Space Force; I look forward to discussing your fiscal year 2024 budget, priorities today.

General Saltzman, this is your first hearing before this committee, and we look forward to continuing to work with you.

Secretary Kendall, I want to thank you for joining me to visit the 341st Missile Wing at Malmstrom Air Force Base, and the 120th Airlift Wing of the Montana Air National Guard a couple weeks ago tomorrow, I think it was. And I appreciate your visit. I look forward to continuing our discussions to ensure that our service members have the tools they need to protect this country's freedoms.

The fiscal year 2024 budget request for the Department of the Air Force is \$215.1 billion, \$9.3 billion more than fiscal year 2023, and about \$41 billion more than fiscal year 2022. With China's pacing threat, and Russia's destabilizing actions, necessitated robust National Defense budget. However, modernization efforts in the fielding of crucial systems and aircraft are frozen unless we enact the Defense Appropriations Bill for fiscal year 2024.

We cannot allow CRs (Continuing Resolutions) to block our progress towards a modernization, and robust, and capable Air Force and Space Force, it is imperative that the fiscal year 2024

budget is enacted on time. And I look forward to working with Senator Murray and Senator Collins, to position us for success.

Our national security is equally undermined by leaks of classified information, while the damage assessment of recent leaks by a member of the Air National Guard is ongoing; I would like to hear from you today why this individual had access to such highly classified information in the first place.

Until we can confidently guarantee that our folks receiving security clearances will keep our Nation safe, I will continue to push for commonsense reforms to the background check and security classification process.

Further, while it was important to explore and invest in modernization improvements of our assets and systems, these efforts fall flat unless they can be translated into capabilities delivered to the warfighter.

As in previous years, your requests for modernization programs grow significantly, while your procurement request remains relatively flat. This is concerning because it implies that experiments, prototypes, and modernization efforts are not transferring to a large-scale production. We cannot let record high investments, and innovation, and modernization go unrealized.

Once again, I want to thank you, each of you, for your service to this country.

Before you make your opening statements, I want to turn it over to my Ranking Member, Senator Collins, for any comments she would like to make.

STATEMENT OF SENATOR SUSAN M. COLLINS

Senator COLLINS. Thank you very much, Mr. Chairman. I appreciate your holding this hearing on the Air Force's fiscal year 2024 budget request.

To our witnesses, thank you so much for your service and leadership, and that of the Airmen and Guardians who serve our Nation.

Secretary Kendall, the seven operational imperatives that you and the Chiefs have established for the Air Force and Space Force provide a useful framework for our analysis this morning.

In many respects, the budget request reflects your continued focus to implement them, such as proposals to double funding for missiles, to increase funding for the Space Force by 15 percent, and to accelerate the development of the Next-Generation Air Refueling Systems optimized for the Indo-Pacific Theater.

Until that new system is in place, I welcome the Department's continued commitment to recapitalizing all of the legacy KC-135 aircraft across the Air Force, including the 60-year-old airframes flown by the MAINEiacs of the Air National Guard in Bangor, Maine. However, there is a lot in this request, or perhaps more accurately not in it, that raises questions about whether the budget will achieve the seven imperatives before our country faces the challenges that you seek to address.

Let me highlight just three of them: First, the Department is proposing to retire three times as many aircraft as it plans to buy this year. If this request were to be enacted with no changes, by my calculation, the Air Force would have 800 fewer aircraft in 2028 than it does today. Meanwhile, China continues to increase both

the number and the capability of its most advanced fighter aircraft, the J-20 and the J-16.

Second, the mission-capable rate for the F-35 in February was just 53 percent. It is not clear to me how this budget request will tackle this problem. And the Air Force, obviously, is far less effective if many of its planes are grounded. I would like to know how this budget request will improve the operational availability of the F-35.

Finally, the Air Force is the largest consumer of fuel in the Federal Government, therefore, the Air Force has the greatest exposure of budget shortfalls and readiness risks if the cost assumptions in this request understate the actual price of fuel. For 2 years in a row that is exactly what has happened, the budget request has underestimated fuel costs, and Congress has come to the rescue to protect training and readiness. We were able to do that because of a substantial increase in the Defense top line for the past 2 years.

So the question I will have for our witnesses is: What is the Air Force doing to maintain its flying hours, programs, and operations? What will it do if fuel costs, once again, exceed the estimate in the budget request?

There are many issues for us to cover today, not the least of which is, as the Chairman mentioned, the disturbing revelation last week that a young Cape Cod-based Air National Guardsman was, allegedly, able to remove, photograph, and disseminate many classified National Security documents for months without notice from the Office of Special Investigations, the Pentagon, or the Intelligence Community.

I look forward to discussing these issues with our witnesses. Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

Senator TESTER. Thank you, Senator Collins.

Next up, we have the Honorable Frank Kendall, Secretary of the Air Force.

SUMMARY STATEMENT OF HON. FRANK KENDALL

Secretary KENDALL. Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

Chairman Tester, Ranking Member Collins, Members of the Subcommittee, thank you for the opportunity to testify on the Department of the Air Force's fiscal year 2024 budget submission.

Approximately 1 year ago, I began my testimony before this committee with a quote from General Douglas MacArthur reminding us that "The history of failure in war can almost always be summed up in two words: too late." That warning is even more valid today.

Over the past year, under the rubric of the seven DAF (Department of the Air Force) operational imperatives, that Senator Collins mentioned, the Department of the Air Force has worked to define the capabilities and technologies that we need, along with the programs and resources required, to deter, and if necessary prevail over our pacing challenge, China, China, China.

In fiscal year 2024, we are requesting approximately \$5 billion as a direct result of this work, and over \$25 billion for operational imperative-related investments. War is not inevitable, but successfully deterring conflict is heavily dependent on our Military capabilities.

In our fiscal year 2024 budget request, there are approximately 20 completely new, or significantly rescope program elements, some of which are classified, that we must develop, produce and field, if we desire to maintain the air and space superiority that America and our allies have counted upon for decades. In order to proceed with any of these programs the Department of the Air Force needs timely authorizations and appropriations.

The Department of the Air Force is ready to move forward with the next generation of capabilities we need. And there is no time to lose.

In addition, to these new starts or enhanced efforts, the fiscal year 2024 budget includes requests for additional resources to increase production and accelerate development of programs essential to the Department's missions, as defined in the National Defense Strategy.

For the Strategic Triad, we have fully funded the Sentinel ICBM (intercontinental ballistic missile), the B-21 Raider Bomber, the Long-Range Standoff Weapon, and our Nuclear Commander Control Programs.

For the Conventional Force, we are increasing production of both the F-35 and the F-15EX. The Next Generation Air Dominance Program is funded to move forward, and as indicated last year, an Uncrewed Collaborative Combat Aircraft Program of record, is fully funded in our fiscal year 2024 request.

We are also continuing the acquisition of sensor programs, like the E-7 Wedgetail, and the new resilient missile warning and tracking space system. As we indicated last year, hard choices have been required to move the Department into the future.

We deeply appreciate the support of the Congress and this Committee for the divestitures we requested last year. This year, we must continue the divestment of the over-40-year-old A-10 Warthog. This program has served us well, but it is absorbing resources needed for higher priorities; we ask for Congress' continued support for this and other identified changes we must make to field the forces we need to be successful against our pacing challenge and other threats.

But of course it isn't all about the equipment we need to perform our missions; it is also about the men and women who serve in the Total Force, Active, Guard, Reserve, and those who support them.

I recently returned from the Indo-Pacific where I met with a number of armed teammates—excuse me—I think I may have skipped a page.

We appreciate Congress' support for 4.6 percent pay raise last year. This year we are asking for our 5.2 percent pay increase. The largest 1 year increase we have ever requested.

In line with Secretary Austin's Taking Care of People Initiative, we are continuing to invest in child development centers and housing to meet the highest priority needs of the Airmen, Guardians, and their families.

Like the other Services, with the exception of the Space Force, the Air Force faces challenges in recruiting in a generation where the propensity to serve is the lowest that we have seen in decades. We are removing barriers to ensure that anyone with a capability and desire can serve to their full potential.

Under our National Defense Strategy, we are strengthening teams, both in the Joint Force and with our allies and partners, building these relationships, investing in our ability to work together is the essence of integrated deterrence. The effectiveness and importance of these relationships are on display in Europe today, where NATO (North Atlantic Treaty Organization) is stronger than ever.

I recently returned from the Indo-Pacific where I met with a number of our teammates where I participated in a ground-breaking event for one of the Enhanced Defense Cooperation Agreement bases in the Philippines. Our budget request also supports strengthening our partnerships around the world, especially where we confront our pacing challenge and most acute threats.

I started by talking about the value of time, and I will finish by highlighting a legislative proposal that can save up to 2 years of that valuable time. Our proposal would expand Rapid Acquisition Authority so that Military Departments can more quickly respond to emerging threats and take advantage of evolving technology.

Within reasonable constraints, this legislative proposal would allow progress on compelling national security needs that would, otherwise, be delayed, until the next submission and approval of the President's budget. I have been pushing this reform for many years, and we look forward to working with the Congress on this proposal.

In closing, I believe the Department of the Air Force is well positioned to move into the future. Our work to define that future is not complete, but it has produced compelling results that are reflected in our fiscal year 2024 budget submission.

We look forward to your questions today; and would like to offer a more complete briefing on the classified details of our submission, at your convenience.

Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

Senator TESTER. Thank you Secretary Kendall.

General Brown, you have the floor.

STATEMENT OF GENERAL CHARLES Q. BROWN, JR., AIR FORCE CHIEF OF STAFF

General BROWN. Good morning, Chairman Tester, and Ranking Member Collins, and distinguished Members of this Subcommittee.

I am proud to represent the 689,000 Total Force Airmen serving our Nation. I want to thank you for your steadfast support to our Airmen and their families.

It is an honor to join Secretary Kendall and General Saltzman to testify in the fiscal year 2024 budget submission. This budget builds on the progress made in fiscal year 2023, and marks the next milestone towards the transformation of the Air Force to address the evolving security challenges outlined in the National Defense Strategy.

As I emphasized last year: we must continue to accelerate change or risk losing our strategic advantage. The Department of the Air Force's operational imperatives describe key capabilities that must be attained to enable the Air Force's modernization in the face of a rapidly changing threat environment, remain dedicated to ensuring our investments and resources outlining this budget submission

are aligned with the National Defense Strategy so the Air Force can continue to deter our adversaries, prevail in conflict, and to execute our mission to: Fly, Fight, and Win, Air Power Anytime, Anywhere. Not sometime in some places, but Anytime, Anywhere.

This budget ensures the Air Forces continue to provide the Nation the assurance of air superiority, the advantage of global strike, the agility rapid global mobility, and you combine that with the adaptability of intelligence, surveillance, and reconnaissance, and the authority in our command and control capabilities, providing the ability to sense, make sense, and act. This is what we must do today, and we must be prepared to do tomorrow.

In order to provide these core functions to the Nation, we must accelerate development of programs essential to our mission with this budget submission. The right of the assurance of air superiority, we are increasing production of the F-35 and F-15EX, as highlighted by the Secretary, while the Next Generation Air Dominance Program continues development.

To provide the advantage of global strike, we fully funded the Sentinel ICBM and the B-21 Raider Bomber. To provide the agility of Rapid Global Mobility we must continue the recapitalization of the KC-135 Fleet, while moving towards the Next-Generation Air Refueling System. To provide the adaptability of intelligence, surveillance, and reconnaissance, we are transitioning to the E-7A, complemented by other persistent, connected, and survivable and systems, and to provide the authority of our command and control we continue to mature Advanced Battle Management System by investing in digital infrastructure and modernizing cloud-based communications.

Last year's budget has started our necessary transformation, as we indicated, that hard choices would have to be made. Often, these choices are between current capacity, readiness, and future capabilities.

Our message this year has not changed. The Air Force must modernize to counter strategic competitors, by balancing risk by investing in platforms and capabilities that have decreasing relevance against our pacing challenge, investments in speed, agility, and the lethality of the Air Force capabilities underwrites the entirety of the Joint Force.

Our Airmen remain the backbone of our Air Force, and we are committed to ensuring their well-being and development while providing them the resources and opportunities to reach their full potential whenever and wherever the Nation calls.

The Air Force is dedicated to reducing barriers, improving quality of service, and quality of life for Airmen and their families. Addition to excess of air power doesn't happen alone, the excess is only possible through the collaboration with many of our stakeholders and teammates.

I want to thank the Congress and this Subcommittee for their past and continued support.

We look forward to working with you on our fiscal year 2024 legislative priorities, like Expanding Rapid Acquisition Authority, furthering modernization efforts at the Nevada Test and Training Range, preventing encroachment on our nuclear launch and control

facilities, and supporting pilot production, through civilian contractor position conversion.

While we remain the strongest Air Force in the world, we must continue the change required to address both today and tomorrow's national security threats. We must have teamwork and collaboration with all of our key stakeholders, to accelerate, providing our Airmen the capabilities they need to deter, and project credible combat power.

We must have on-time appropriations and avoid continuing resolutions to stay ahead of the pacing, acute, and unforeseen challenges now, into the future. There is not a moment to lose.

Thank you for the opportunity to be here with you today. And I look forward to your questions.

Senator TESTER. Thank you, General Brown.

General Saltzman.

STATEMENT OF GENERAL B. CHANCE SALTZMAN, CHIEF OF SPACE OPERATIONS, UNITED STATES SPACE FORCE

General SALTZMAN. Chairman Tester, Ranking Member Collins, distinguished Members of the Committee, thank you for your continued support and for the opportunity to testify on the Space Force fiscal year 2024 budget submission.

As the Space Force enters its fourth year, we continue to mature as an independent service, and are fully delivering on assigned missions. Since assuming my responsibilities in November I have traveled globally to engage with guardians, combatant commanders, and military service chiefs from partner nations to better understand where the Space Force should focus our efforts.

Across the board, each of these groups emphasized the vital role space plays in strategic competition and integrated deterrence.

As this committee well understands, competition and deterrence require investment in and modernization of technology, training, and partnerships. That is what the fiscal year 2024 budget submission for the Space Force does.

This budget submission is directly in line with the National Defense Strategy, and the Department of the Air Force operational imperatives. As the fiscal year 2024 budget will allow us to further efforts to develop a resilient Space Order of Battle, and preparing for Rapid transition to a wartime posture against any potential adversary to fight and win in a high intensity conflict.

In conjunction with ongoing modernization projects, the Space Force has several new starts for fiscal year 2024 to support these efforts. Investing in these modernization projects will allow us to execute our assigned missions as we move forward to better posture for the emerging complexities of the space domain, and the threat systems being fielded by strategic competitors.

Space is now undeniably a contested warfighting domain; China and Russia define space as such, and are investing in technology meant to undermine U.S. advantage in the domain.

China, our pacing challenge, is our most substantial threat into and from space, but Russia also remains an acute threat. Both present serious challenges with space capabilities that can track and target U.S. Military Forces on land, at sea, and in the air. Both can hold U.S. space assets at risk with cyber and electronic

warfare, lasers, ground-to-space missiles, and space-to-space orbital engagement systems.

These systems threaten the space architecture the Nation relies on for prosperity and security. To meet this challenge the Space Force will prioritize three lines of effort: First, fielding ready, resilient, and combat-credible Forces. Second, amplifying what I call the “Guardian Spirit”; and three, partnering to win.

These are directly in line with Secretary Austin’s Mission, People, and Team priorities. In sum, this budget request is designed to deliver the forces, personnel, and partnerships the Space Force requires to preserve U.S. advantages in space.

To build resilient-ready, combat-credible Forces, we are accelerating the pivot towards modern, more defensible satellite constellations, and support infrastructure. We are conducting transformational Force design analysis based on threats, operational needs, and costs, so that we can maximize our budget while investing in effective missile warning, space domain awareness, communication, and navigation systems.

Additionally, we are investing to ensure our networks are hardened to defeat cyber threats and that we have the operational test and training infrastructure necessary to prepare Guardians for high intensity conflict.

With our second line of effort, we are amplifying the Guardian Spirit by recruiting, developing, and retaining the best talent, and empowering Guardians to succeed. Investment in space-centric curriculum for entry-level schools will build Guardians laser-focused on space operations in competition and conflict.

Guardians will be empowered through mission command to innovate and execute in those scenarios. Notably, and with Congressional support, we plan to integrate the space mission elements of the Air Force Reserve into the Space Force to offer Guardians flexible career paths, including both full-time and part-time duty to retain talent and bring private-sector experience to the Force.

The third line of effort acknowledges that the Space Force relies on Partnerships to accomplish our mission. We are investing in training, education, data sharing, and integrated capabilities with our allies and partners. The Space Force will strengthen our presence in all combatant commands where Guardians are already making solid connections with allies and partners.

Because of its critical importance, the Space Force is collaborating with commercial partners to build resilient capacity and leverage emerging technologies. To enhance this partnership, the Space Force is working to eliminate barriers to such collaboration so that we can build enduring advantages, and field them more rapidly.

In conclusion, thank you for the opportunity to discuss the Space Force’s fiscal year 2024 budget request. The Space Force continues to be the preeminent military space organization in the world. Our adversaries seek to challenge our advantage in space, but with the support of this committee our Guardians will be able to outwork, out-innovate, and out-compete our potential adversaries to ensure that we maintain that advantage.

The fiscal year 2024 budget request will make this possible, but only if the Congress passes timely appropriations.

I look forward to your questions. Thank you.
[The statement follows:]

PREPARED STATEMENT OF FRANK KENDALL, GENERAL CHARLES Q. BROWN, JR., AND
GENERAL B. CHANCE SALTZMAN

OVERVIEW

The Department of the Air Force (DAF) remains focused on implementing the National Defense Strategy (NDS) and the priorities of the Secretary of Defense: mission, people, and teams. Our ability to perform our missions comes first, and everything we are doing to support and develop our people and build strong teams supports that goal. One year ago, we submitted a posture statement in which the need to modernize the Air and Space Forces, especially to meet our pacing challenge—the People's Republic of China (PRC)—was highlighted. Over the past year, we have provided threat briefings to Congress on the severity of that challenge. A year ago, we also outlined seven operational imperatives the DAF must meet to be successful, but we were only beginning our work to analyze and define the solutions to those imperatives. We are pleased to report we have made significant progress in identifying the capabilities the DAF will need to prevail against the PRC and in defining new programs and resources to develop and field these capabilities. That progress is reflected in over a dozen new efforts, including a mix of completely new or significantly re-scoped program elements, in our Fiscal Year 2024 (FY24) budget submission. With our budget submission, the DAF's ability to execute these plans and to keep pace with the threat is now in your hands, and we urge you to act promptly on our FY24 request.

Within the NDS, there are four priorities: defending the homeland, deterring strategic attacks, deterring aggression, and building a resilient joint force. The Nation's Air and Space Forces have key roles to play in each of these, and this is reflected in our FY24 budget request.

The need to defend the homeland is paced with the growing threat from the PRC. We have just seen a manifestation of this threat in the high-altitude surveillance balloon destroyed by an Air Force F-22 fighter aircraft. While the recent high-altitude balloon incursion into our airspace may have garnered significant attention, there are other, more concerning threats to the homeland. PRC and Russian satellites observe the United States continuously. Cyber-attacks focused on intellectual property theft, penetration of critical infrastructure, espionage against national security networks, and disinformation, from both the PRC and Russia, are a constant reality. As the PRC increases the range of its conventional strike capabilities, the potential for missile strikes of various types against the homeland is increasing. In our FY24 budget, we are once again requesting F-15EX and F-35 fighter production. We are also accelerating our acquisition of a new space-based missile warning architecture to improve our warning and enable defenses against missile threats.

To deter strategic attacks against the United States, our allies, and partners, the DAF continues programs to recapitalize the intercontinental ballistic missile (ICBM) and bomber legs of the nuclear triad. The Sentinel program, our ICBM replacement, is continuing in development. The Minuteman III, first deployed in 1970, is the oldest land-based strategic missile system in the world. FY24 budgets more than \$4.4 billion for its replacement, Sentinel, which is critical for our nuclear modernization. For the bomber leg, we recently rolled out the B-21 Raider, which is scheduled to achieve its first flight this calendar year. Complementing our new bomber is the modernization of the B-52 and development of the Long-Range Standoff Weapon. Stable and consistent Congressional support remains vital to ensuring a safe, secure, and effective nuclear deterrent. These programs and others that contribute to this priority are all fully funded in the FY24 budget request.

Our biggest challenge is maintaining and strengthening our capacity to deter aggression, and to prevail, if necessary, with priority to the PRC and the Indo-Pacific followed by the Russian challenge in Europe. While there is overlap with other priorities, the focus of our seven operational imperatives described in last year's posture statement has been on this challenge. The Nation's ability to project power, in the western Pacific in particular, is being challenged aggressively. The FY24 budget request includes approximately \$5 billion in funding focused directly on achieving the seven operational imperatives and includes several new initiatives. The DAF's Future Years Defense Program (FYDP) request includes nearly \$35 billion in funding to continue our investments designed to address the operational imperatives. The criticality of these efforts highlights the importance of an on-time appropriation.

Space has been recognized as a military domain of crucial importance to the joint force, allies, and partners, and to our ability to project power. The first operational

imperative is to define the Space Force that we will need and to put the programs in place to field that force. The Space Force has two fundamental missions: to provide essential services to the joint force and to protect the joint force from adversary hostile uses of space systems. The ability to perform these missions is at risk today and that risk is increasing over time. Our space systems are threatened by a variety of growing anti-satellite capabilities, and the joint force is threatened by increasingly sophisticated adversary space-based systems intended to target the joint force. Our FY24 budget request continues the work on a resilient missile warning constellation initiated last year. Our budget also builds out a more resilient space communications capability for the joint force, based on diversity and dispersion of communication satellites. This development work includes programs being managed by the Space Development Agency (SDA), now a part of the DAF and the Space Force, continuing to field distributed communications architectures. The total Space Force budget in the FY24 request is \$30 billion, 15 percent above the enacted Fiscal Year 2023 (FY23) Space Force appropriation. It includes over \$2 billion and seven new efforts for this imperative. Other initiatives in this portfolio can be discussed at a higher level of classification.

The Air and Space Forces play crucial roles in Joint All Domain Command and Control (JADC2). The second operational imperative is intended to ensure the totality of DAF Command, Control, Communications, and Battle Management (C3BM) programs provide an integrated capability with the resilience and performance needed to provide the Air Force and Space Force, the joint force, allies, and partners, with timely information and the systems to communicate, manage, and employ that information. Providing this capability resiliently is critical to enable our warfighters to make effective decisions in a high-speed, complex fight against our pacing challenge. The Advanced Battle Management System (ABMS) is one part of this overall effort, which has now been brought under the technical management of a recently created Program Executive Officer (PEO) for Integrated C3BM. Additionally, our Nuclear Command, Control, and Communications (NC3) capability investments will be synchronized with the PEO for Integrated C3BM efforts. The FY24 budget submission includes a net of roughly \$500 million for DAF C3BM, including an additional \$65 million for one new effort in this area.

If the United States is to deter aggression and prevail should conflict occur, we must have the ability to track and engage advancing enemy forces in the air, on the sea, and on land. The third operational imperative addresses this need with a combination of space- and air-based systems. For space-based systems, the Space Force is working in close collaboration with the intelligence community to ensure that the joint force has the support it needs from integrated intelligence and operational support systems located in space. This will include operational space sensing, coupled with tasking and data management, designed with joint tactical warfighting as a primary mission. For airborne systems, the DAF is continuing the acquisition of the E-7A replacement for the E-3 airborne warning and control system. Other initiatives can be discussed at a higher level of classification. Overall, the FY24 budget requests \$431 million for moving target related systems (exclusive of the Intelligence Community and classified funding) and includes six new efforts.

For over 75 years, the Air Force has dominated opponents in the air. The PRC is challenging that dominance, and we cannot afford complacency, nor can we afford Air Force capability and capacity composed largely of fighters that cost as much as or more than the F-35. The fourth operational imperative addresses the family-of-systems needed to sustain our dominance in the air. The centerpiece of this effort is the Next Generation Air Dominance (NGAD) platform, but this platform will be too expensive to be purchased in large numbers. The FY24 budget enhances funding to field uncrewed Collaborative Combat Aircraft (CCA) to complement the NGAD, F-35, and possibly other current and new crewed platforms. Concurrent with CCA development, the DAF will acquire assets for experimentation and testing to explore organizational structures, maintenance concepts, and operational tactics. CCA inventory goals have not been established, but for planning purposes, we are assuming an initial inventory of 1,000 CCAs, with nominally two CCAs paired with each NGAD aircraft, and a portion of the F-35 inventory. In addition to the CCAs, this operational imperative has addressed other aspects of the NGAD family-of-systems. In total, the FY24 budget submission requests approximately \$490 million for air dominance, with the entire CCA program and supporting elements encompassing three new efforts.

The PRC and Russian investments in long-range precision strikes have put our forward airbases at risk. The Air Force's Agile Combat Employment (ACE) concept partially addresses this threat. The fifth operational imperative team analyzed additional steps to enhance forward air base availability and resiliency. In the FY24 budget request, the DAF prioritized actions that could be taken quickly to increase

the overall resiliency of our forward-deployed air assets, including building hardened shelters and pre-positioning equipment and supplies needed to implement ACE. The FY24 budget includes \$1.2 billion to strengthen the resiliency and expand the availability of our forward airbases in the Indo-Pacific region. While not a new start, it represents a significant increase over FY23 funding levels.

The Air Force's global strike capabilities provide a powerful conventional and strategic deterrent. The sixth operational imperative examined ways to improve the cost-effectiveness of the family-of-systems surrounding the B-21 bomber. As noted above, the B-21 Raider is fully funded in the FY24 request, and it continues to make progress toward production and fielding. The Raider is more than a new platform, and this imperative identified new weapons, sensors, and communications that can make the B-21 more effective in the joint tactical fight. The fiscal year 24 request includes \$80 million to modernize our global strike capabilities and includes two new efforts.

Both the Space Force and the Air Force have a number of systems and facilities on which they depend to mobilize and transition to wartime operations. The final operational imperative addressed the need to ensure these systems and facilities would function as needed in wartime. Much of the work to date under this imperative focused on the cyber-security of our critical information systems and infrastructure, especially modernizing and hardening our network infrastructure and giving our cyber operators new tools for cyber defense. Air and Space forces must also be capable of operating in a contested cyberspace environment. Our current budget reflects initial investments to achieve these objectives by cyber hardening networks, weapon systems, and priority defense critical infrastructure, and we recognize that there is much work to do in this area. The FY24 budget request includes \$613 million in this area to strengthen the DAF's cybersecurity posture. This represents a significant increase in enterprise information technology and cyber defense funding over FY23 levels.

The work on the operational imperatives over the past year has informed the FY24 request, but it has also indicated some areas in which more effort is required. In just the last year, the threat has become more severe. As a result, the DAF is continuing and expanding our efforts to define solutions to the challenges we face. We are continuing the work of the seven operational imperatives to refine resource needs and plans across the lifecycle of these capabilities. In addition, we have started work on three cross-cutting operational enablers. These are mobility, electronic warfare, and munitions. These combined efforts will inform our Fiscal Year 2025 (FY25) request, but they have already influenced our FY24 plans.

In the DAF mobility portfolio, the tanker recapitalization effort has been our highest priority. The KC-46 is still working to meet all its requirements, but we believe they will be achieved. As the threat continues to increase the range at which it can engage our aircraft, we are being forced to reexamine how we will operate these platforms. The mobility study we have initiated will identify new ways to achieve more mission resilience and effectiveness with existing platforms and will define the requirements for the next generation of tanker and transport aircraft. While it is too early to provide any results, one outcome seems probable: the next tanker must be much more survivable than current designs and is unlikely to be a derivative of a commercial aircraft design. The DAF will conduct an Analysis of Alternatives to determine the requirements and concept for the Next Generation Air-Refueling System and we will evaluate our future mobility platform needs.

Russia's war against Ukraine, Korea Readiness Review, and the experience combating the Islamic State of Iraq and Syria (ISIS) have taught us that munitions planning, production capitalization, and stockpiling must account for the possibility of a longer and more intense conflict than previously assumed. The munitions cross-cutting operational enabler analysis will inform our FY25 budget, but we are not waiting to address our highest-priority munitions requirements. The target set for which we must be prepared is evolving. We must build a munitions inventory that is more diverse with greater capacity while accelerating design and production capability, which includes advanced weapons. In the FY24 budget, we are increasing our procurement of munitions and partnering aggressively with the other services, allies, partners, and industry.

The combat support area of electronic warfare (EW) must be reevaluated in light of emerging threats. Historically, EW development has been stove-piped for the sole purpose of providing enhanced survivability of individual platforms. As our adversaries have advanced their long-range sensing and targeting capabilities, we need to examine new ways to use EW as an offensive capability designed to defeat adversary kill webs. While most of this analytical work is classified, we expect new programs as well as some program restructuring in our FY25 budget.

Last year we indicated that hard choices would have to be made. Often those choices are between current and future capabilities. The DAF FY24 budget provides an acceptable level of operational risk for the current force in order to fund the future force. Affording the investments necessary to implement the operational imperative-derived recommendations requires both divestitures from the current force and an acceptance of risk in the level of readiness of the current force. Make no mistake: your Air Force and Space Force are ready and able to confront and defeat any adversary, but they are not being maintained at as high a level of readiness as might be possible. The fact is that the threat is racing to make those existing forces obsolete. The DAF must move as rapidly as possible to the future set of capabilities we need to sustain our deterrent and our ability to project power. There is not a moment to lose.

We deeply appreciate the support of Congress in FY23. Congress largely supported our divestiture requests in FY23 with one exception—the divestiture of 32 of our oldest and least capable F-22s. A year later, the threat is more severe, and the need to modernize is more pressing. This year we hope to continue the divestitures that were requested last year as we transition the force to one that is relevant to the threat. In particular, we are requesting the retirement of an additional 42 A-10s. This 40-plus-year-old fighter has served the Air Force and the Nation well, but it does not deter or survive against our pacing challenge, and we need to move forward.

The Air and Space Forces are working to fulfill the NDS priority of building a resilient joint force and defense ecosystem. All our mission capabilities rest on one single foundation—our people. The hard work and dedication of over 700,000 military and civilian Airmen and Guardians across the Active, Guard, and Reserve components power our department. In fiscal year 24, we vow to continue supporting them by ensuring they can serve to their fullest potential. We demand a culture of respect, will promote accountability, and aim to end harmful behaviors, such as sexual harassment, sexual assault, racial, ethnic, and gender disparities, domestic violence, domestic abuse, and suicide as well as hazing, bullying, and other forms of discriminatory harassment. We will also promote initiatives that improve diversity and inclusion, ensure quality healthcare access, advance recruitment and retention, and improve our talent management processes to strengthen readiness. Every current and potential Airman and Guardian should understand their value and the importance of service to our Nation.

As we move forward to meet our challenges, we do so as members of a much larger team. First, the Air and Space Forces are critical members of the joint team. We are also members of an international team with our allies and partners who collectively ensure our success at achieving integrated deterrence against any threat, but first and foremost against our pacing challenge.

Our people and our missions are successful because of teamwork. The fiscal year 24 budget continues numerous investments, such as \$194 million for Pacific Deterrence initiatives, to strengthen our relationships and interoperability with our joint force, allies, partners, and interagencies. The North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) is stronger than ever, and the ever-increasing F-35 community provides strong interoperability. In the Pacific, we are expanding our relationship with traditional partners like Japan, South Korea, and Australia, while strengthening our cooperation with nations like the Philippines and other Pacific Island nations. Our united resolve against Russian aggression and our combined focus on the pacing challenge in the Indo-Pacific highlight the incredible partnerships we have with democracies around the globe that share our values. As we research, test, acquire, and build the military capabilities of tomorrow, we strengthen and expand the Defense Industrial Base, and we do so in concert with our allied and partner nations.

UNITED STATES SPACE FORCE

The United States Space Force was created in recognition of the space domain's critical importance to national prosperity and the need to contest the domain for national security purposes. Recently, the US has seen dramatic changes in the domain with an exponential increase of launches, on-orbit active payloads, space debris, and proliferation of counter-space threats. This reality presents new risks and opportunities to national objectives across diplomatic, information, military, and economic instruments of power. Consequently, ensuring our Nation's ability to operate in, from, and through a stable space domain is a vital national interest for the Space Force to address.

Spacepower is not simply "important" in modern competition and conflict—it is foundational. Russia's war against Ukraine continues to validate this assertion in several ways. First, Russian counterspace attacks since the outset of the war rein-

force the reality that space is a warfighting domain. Second, proliferating constellations and disaggregating space missions are proving to be far more resilient and effective, especially with commercial augmentation. Third, equipment alone cannot win in the modern fight. Winning takes space-enabled, multi-domain operations and a joint force trained on the most current operational concepts. In this environment, we must shift to a resilient and effective Space Order of Battle and ensure we have the tools, talent, and experience to be ready to face the challenges to our missions of providing space superiority so that we can enable and protect the joint force, our allies, and partners.

SPACE FORCE'S ROLE IN DEFENDING THE NATION

A primary responsibility of the Space Force is to field ready, resilient, and combat-credible forces. To be ready, Guardians must be trained, exercised, and postured. To be resilient, our architectures must be designed to render threats operationally impractical or self-defeating. And to be combat-credible, space forces need systems for full spectrum operations utilized by competent warfighters practiced in their tradecraft.

Through the operational imperatives, we are defining the space systems and capabilities we need to prevail against the pacing challenges—the PRC and, secondarily, Russia. Through the work in the first operational imperative, we are focused on increasing resilience for space architecture by addressing the risks facing people, platforms, and processes through systems proliferated across multiple orbits. Resilient systems will allow us to prevent, respond, and campaign through competition and aggression. When operated by a ready, combat-credible force, resilient systems will disincentivize would-be aggressors.

The FY24 budget includes critical investments for meeting all four priorities demanded in the NDS and the DAF's first operational imperative by evolving toward more resilient space architectures. Building resilience must first consider the continuous operation of over 50 legacy platforms, which necessitates investing \$172 million in FY24 for additional cyber protection, evaluating select legacy systems for upgrades, and integrating space capabilities from several allies and partners. These upgrades will broaden the resilience of several mission areas, including military Positioning, Navigation and Timing (PNT), Command, Control, Communications, and Battle Management (C3BM) systems, and NC3 by migrating the Evolved Strategic SATCOM (ESS) system to a proliferated architecture that will be more resilient during a strategic attack.

Still, the surest way to lessen long-term risk is through the generational replacement of legacy platforms. This year's budget requests \$102 million to continue our analysis of the force design for how space-based systems support several critical warfighter needs, including delivering communications to the tactical edge, providing secure PNT information, and enabling data links that connect sensors, warfighters, and weapons. The insights gained from comprehensive force design analyses ensure we make effective and cost-effective transitions from legacy to next-generation space systems.

The first mission area to undergo this transformation will be Missile Warning/Missile Tracking (MW/MT), with the last legacy Space-Based Infrared System launch having occurred in 2022. In the FY24 budget, we turn the page into a new era of MW/MT with over \$2.3 billion to ramp up research, development, test, and evaluation of the first tranche of proliferated satellites, ground segment development, and interoperability testing which sets the way for a complete constellation in the years to follow. Additionally, we are on track to deliver the first Next-Gen Overhead Persistent Infrared geosynchronous space vehicle by 2025 to reduce risk and improve the transitional resiliency and effectiveness of MW/MT, missile defense, battlespace awareness, and technical intelligence.

Recognizing that joint warfighters need to sustain and expand SATCOM capabilities, this budget pursues new solutions. MeshONE, for example, is a \$151 million effort that will deliver a novel approach to a modern, scalable, resilient, cyber-secure Wide Area Network available to the joint force at the tactical edge. We are also leading the transformation of communications via the emerging space data transport layer. Beginning in FY24, our investment of \$1.8 billion will deliver an initial warfighter capability that will provide low-latency data transport and beyond-line-of-sight targeting, with persistent regional access to the joint force. Once fully operational, this capability will serve as the backbone of data transport in support of C3BM and JADC2.

We must also provide protection to the joint force and our allies from adversary space systems that threaten our forward-deployed forces and those of our partners. The FY24 budget includes funding for critical counter-space capabilities intended to

fulfill this mission need. Specific budgetary information is available at a higher level of classification.

Our ability to use space effectively requires assured access, being first to field the necessary capabilities, and the ability to reconstitute them, if necessary. This budget ensures the National Security Space Launch (NSSL) program is equipped to place essential capabilities in orbit when needed. The NSSL program is preparing for a new phase in which we are pursuing a dual-lane, hybrid approach that maximizes the use of the Nation's robust commercial launch market. Recognizing the exponential growth of the commercial space industry, we are investing \$99 million in FY24 and over \$1 billion over the FYDP into the Range of the Future vision, which aligns us with the accelerating domestic space launch market, and maintains safe and assured launch for commercial, civil, and Department of Defense users.

SPACE FORCE'S ROLE IN TAKING CARE OF PEOPLE

The Space Force is implementing a more modern talent management approach based on a competency framework that optimizes individual contribution. Over the past year, we have made progress toward achieving our end state described in the Guardian Ideal. The result has been tangible impacts on retention and the development of Guardians of all ranks. Our future hinges on recruiting and retaining a diverse and innovative force of highly talented Guardians, and we are proud to have met our recruiting targets. Guardians will soon be leading an innovative approach to holistic health by emphasizing a continuously healthy lifestyle rather than episodic fitness testing. We are retooling how we measure healthy living and providing Guardians and leaders with the resources they need to uphold the highest standards expected of military professionals.

We are also advancing opportunities and education for all ranks and phases of a Guardian's career. Starting with Basic Military Training, FY24 will see graduation standards fully established, with Guardians being held to service-specific requirements, while Air Force Officer Training School and Reserve Officers' Training Corps Space Force cadets will see increased space-related academic content. This budget will mature the University Partnership Program to inspire and recruit the right talent and provide additional opportunities for Guardians to obtain advanced academic degrees in essential Science, Technology, Engineering, and Math subjects. Reflecting our continued commitment to professional military education, this budget funds the program with our first graduates in 2024. With Congressional support, we intend to innovate by pursuing a personnel system with full- to part-time fluidity that will improve career flexibility and enhance retention tools.

Recruiting initiatives are only the beginning for Guardians as space professionals. To develop professional warfighters, this budget commits to enhancing readiness by increasing the quality and quantity of realistic testing of new systems and training of Guardians on them. By incrementally instituting Operational Test and Training Infrastructure and the National Space Test and Training Complex, FY24's investment of \$21 million will continue progress in delivering more realistic testing and training against a thinking adversary, much like the high-end fight our Nation may face in a future contingency. To do this, the Space Force will build agile operational capabilities and execute orbital experimentation to rapidly expand our technological prowess.

SPACE FORCE'S ROLE IN SUCCEEDING THROUGH TEAMWORK

Teamwork for the Space Force starts internally within the DAF, where the Space Force relies upon support from the Air Force. For example, the Air Force supports the six Space Force Bases with over 8,000 Total Force Airmen providing numerous activities to the Space Force. This includes, but is not limited to, finance, contracting, education and training, child and youth services, dining, fitness, lodging, manpower, logistics, communications, medical, emergency services, and base security. Externally, the Space Force is building teams in four key areas: joint force, commercial industry, the intelligence community, and internationally.

With Congressional support, the Chief of Space Operations is formally designated as the Force Design Architect for Space Systems of the Armed Forces. This is important because our closest partnering efforts are inside the joint team. We are exercising our role as the integrator of all space requirements from and for the joint force as we merge and integrate requirements through more-responsive processes from sister services and Combatant Commands. Moreover, this budget requests to restructure the Space Force's organizations responsible for this important analytic work, namely by redesignating the Space Warfighting Analysis Center as a direct-reporting unit, which will increase responsiveness to warfighter needs.

In coordination with the Intelligence Community (IC), Guardians are also taking the initiative and exploring joint service intelligence, surveillance, reconnaissance, and targeting needs and opportunities. Inherent coordination in integration with the IC ensures that operational and intelligence requirements are being met efficiently, especially when they overlap and use shared assets. For example, the IC and DAF are similarly seeking new means for moving target engagement, the fourth operational imperative.

To best partner with our industrial base and commercial space, we must improve space acquisition to be more dynamic, cost-sensible, and effective. In the past 3 years, several significant improvements have been made to the structure and relationships comprising space system acquisitions. For example, all major stakeholders in space acquisitions are collaborating to define resilient architectures, assess risks to identify needs, and drive rapid change that aims to deliver results faster than the threats can react. The nine acquisition principles developed by the Assistant Secretary of the Air Force for Space Acquisition and Integration will revamp acquisition strategy to epitomize responsive acquisitions that apply state-of-the-art commercial best practices.

Expanding the use and future of the commercial space industry and academia across all mission areas organic to the Space Force and the joint force remains critical. These include satellite communications (SATCOM), space domain awareness (SDA), launch, PNT, and more. A strategic advantage for the United States is our robust, innovative, and responsive industrial base, which includes the highly specialized traditional defense industrial base and the highly innovative new commercial space industry segment. We are embracing a hybrid architecture of commercial solutions across many mission areas. Our approach to hybrid architectures affords several benefits including resiliency, cost competition, responsive surge capacity, rapid technology refreshment, increased innovation, improved diversification to industry, and more expedient integration with international partners.

We continue to expand the team of allies we cooperate with across all mission areas. Space Systems Command recently delivered two SDA sensors on Japanese satellites to build SDA capacity and relations with a key ally in the Indo-Pacific region. In the European theater, our partnership with the Norwegian Ministry of Defense led to Enhanced Polar SATCOM payloads on two Norwegian satellites that will provide communications from highly elliptical orbits. The Space Force continues to address partnering challenges by implementing new classification guidance and sharing agreements, investing in more accessible hardware and software such as the Unified Data Library, and supporting DAF- and Department of Defense-wide solutions, particularly the Mission Partner Environment. The Space Force recognizes that the best solutions are preventative, such as the implementation of the Combined Space Operations Vision 2031 and the successful maturation of the NATO Space Centre. These structural improvements will help us to develop and operate resilient, interoperable architectures by and for coalitions.

UNITED STATES AIR FORCE

The United States Air Force is critical to our national defense, is committed to Airmen and families, and succeeds by teaming with our joint teammates, allies, and partners as we execute our mission to “Fly, Fight, and Win . . . Airpower Anytime, Anywhere.” Our speed, agility, and lethality are exponential force multipliers to any global military operation. Our capabilities underwrite the entirety of the joint force, and we are uniquely suited to provide this cornerstone of the Nation’s defense.

To meet the threats facing the force of today and in the future, we must implement the programs that have been defined by the analysis of the seven DAF operational imperatives and continue the momentum of Accelerate Change or Lose. We are orienting our decisionmaking processes and shaping investments around resilience and lethality against the pacing challenge, long-range kill chains, and the elements supporting them. We remain dedicated to ensuring our investments and resources are properly aligned with the NDS to deter our adversaries and prevail in conflict. As the combat environment and the character of war continue to evolve, our determination to be the leader in speed, agility, and lethality remains an irreplaceable role for the joint team and our allies and partners.

AIR FORCE’S ROLE IN DEFENDING THE NATION

As stated above, we must continue to make hard choices in Airpower modernization to keep pace with our strategic competitors while balancing risk. The difficult decisions are far from over, and the measured near-term risk decisions which prioritize essential modernization and acceptable current readiness continue. Airpower modernization is critical to address the four NDS priorities: defending the

homeland, deterring strategic attacks, deterring aggression, and building a resilient joint force.

The NDS priorities depend upon platforms and capabilities that support effective command and control and are survivable in the threat environment of both today and tomorrow. In FY24, we continue our modernization efforts while divesting platforms and capabilities that have decreasing relevance against our pacing challenge. Current airborne platforms, such as the E-3 and E-8, are not adequately survivable against emerging threats, are not optimal for joint or coalition operations, and need to continue divestiture as we look to the future. These airborne capabilities play a critical role in meeting the operational imperative to track and engage enemy forces at scale. A combination of space- and air-based systems will be needed to maximize lethality and close kill chains. We remain committed to balancing current, mid-term, and longer-term capability and capacity by divesting the E-3 while rapidly acquiring and fielding the E-7A to modernize efficiently.

A focused redesign of the C3BM network, being pursued under the second operational imperative, is overdue and a top-priority modernization effort that will define and field ABMS capabilities. The establishment of the C3BM Integrating PEO will align command and control modernization efforts across the DAF and with the joint force. ABMS will fulfill the Air Force's integral contribution to JADC2 and the FY24 budget focuses on building and maturing ongoing programs.

Air superiority for the joint force demands affordable Airpower modernization, which includes NGAD. The FY24 budget continues NGAD development. The NGAD family-of-systems operational imperative will provide an innovative suite of capabilities that allow us to establish and maintain air superiority, a precondition for the joint force's freedom of maneuver. The uncrewed CCA program included in this budget is a significantly enhanced activity for air superiority and is targeted to support both NGAD and the F-35. The CCA program will have three simultaneous lines of development—the platform, autonomy, and unit construct.

In addition to the longer-term operational imperative programs described above, the modernization decisions we are making consider the entirety of the Air Force's capability and capacity mix. As we work to develop a new generation of capabilities, we are also working to improve current and mid-term capability and capacity. This process includes replacing some legacy platforms, namely the MH-139A replacing the UH-1N, and the Survivable Airborne Operations Center replacing the E-4B. It also includes modernizing existing platforms that will remain in operation for many years, including the B-1, B-2, B-52, C-17, C-5, F-16, F-15E, F-22, and F-35 fleets. Within the FY24 budget, we have committed over \$12 billion to modernize these existing platforms. These modernization efforts are designed to improve mid-term capability and reduce risk while providing needed capacity to complement the improved capabilities provided by the programs defined by the operational imperatives and the new families-of-systems such as the B-21 and NGAD.

As noted earlier, capable, improved, and complementary munitions are needed for both our new and existing platforms. We are prioritizing investments in munitions and technology to counter pacing threats in highly-contested environments. This includes investments in both air-to-air and air-to-surface capabilities to engage mobile targets from standoff ranges in adverse weather. Investments into hypersonic munitions will enable us to hold high-value, time-sensitive targets at risk in contested environments from standoff distances. The FY24 budget invests over \$5 billion to support Small Diameter Bomb II, Joint Air to Surface Standoff Missile, Hypersonic Attack Cruise Missile, Air-Launched Rapid Response Weapon, and more munitions' facilitation across the defense industrial base. These investments will shorten the kill chain while supporting the moving target operational imperative.

For the current force, we are pursuing improved readiness through multiple channels, including the Air Force Force Generation model (AFFORGEN). AFFORGEN enables the presentation of sustainable, predictable capacity and capabilities while ensuring operational preparedness and required readiness. AFFORGEN balances risk between Combatant Command requirements, Air Force readiness, and modernization by deploying pre-identified units and/or teams who have trained together to improve performance. AFFORGEN will meet initial operational capability in FY24.

Agile Combat Employment (ACE) increases readiness by dispersing operations from large bases to networks of smaller locations and provides the basis for the operational imperative of resilient forward basing. We are standardizing the concepts and terms of ACE in Air Force Doctrine as well as incorporating them into ongoing exercises and worldwide training. There is \$1.2 billion to fund the resilient forward basing operational imperative this fiscal year in addition to funding for ACE. Additional work is being done to identify and create capabilities and formal-

ized training programs to field an agile force that sets the theater and establishes distributed command and control.

The Flying Hour Program (FHP) and Weapon System Sustainment (WSS) budget requests ensure our Airmen have the training and equipment necessary to “Fly, Fight, and Win.” The \$9 billion in FY24 funds our FHP to levels that can be reasonably executed and meet our readiness requirements. Our WSS FY24 funding of over \$19 billion is aligned with our FHP but is challenged by requirements growth due to an aging fleet, the fielding of more complex weapons systems, increasing operational requirements, and increasing organic and contract costs.

Execution of our mission requires appropriate infrastructure support and resilient basing. The Facilities, Sustainment, Restoration, and Modernization (FSRM) efforts focus on prioritizing existing quality-of-life requirements and maintaining our operational and training infrastructure. In addition to new mission builds for Military Construction (MILCON) projects, we are pursuing improvements for our Airmen, supported Guardians, and their families to our Child Development Centers (CDC) and dorms with targeted investments totaling \$107 million in FY24 MILCON and \$294 million in FSRM. Since 1990, we have 60 percent fewer fighter squadrons, 40 percent fewer Airmen, but only 15 percent fewer installations in the continental United States. Our FY24 budget reflects our commitment to right-sizing our facilities and infrastructure footprint through consolidations, demolitions, and optimizing our space utilization.

AIR FORCE’S ROLE IN TAKING CARE OF PEOPLE

Taking care of our people begins with recruiting the best military and civilian Airmen of tomorrow. In FY23, the active-duty component of the Air Force is projected to miss military enlistment requirements by about 10 percent, over three thousand individuals. The Air Guard and Reserve components are projected to miss their goals by even higher margins. To maximize our pool of eligible individuals and to recruit the best our Nation has to offer, we are working to reduce barriers and connect with young people and communities. While maintaining our established standards, we are reviewing and removing barriers to service and offering enhanced financial opportunities to those who wish to serve. Additionally, we are taking a targeted approach to open our bases to local communities to strengthen connections and help influencers and potential recruits see the many possible opportunities we have to offer for a rewarding career and personal development. We are also highlighting, particularly online, the positive experiences of Air Force veterans who have moved on to successful careers outside the military.

Once Airmen join our team, the focus shifts from recruitment to retention. Congress provided critical retention tools to the Services last year with increases in basic pay, housing, and subsistence rates—providing a viable compensation package. Our focus on improving the quality of life for our Airmen includes improving the childcare availability for our members. The FY24 budget includes new CDC construction, existing CDC facility improvements, staffing initiatives, and additional childcare providers.

Military housing is another important way we have focused on retention. Our FY24 budget includes funding for continued investment in DAF’s government-owned and government-leased housing based on the need to support mission requirements, address health and safety concerns, and modernize housing for unaccompanied personnel. Our FY24 budget also includes Family Housing Construction funds for prioritized investments in DAF’s Military Housing Privatization Initiative (MHPI) portfolio to improve the safety, quality, and habitability of select privatized housing projects and ensure their long-term financial viability. We remain committed to providing continued oversight of the private sector MHPI companies that own and operate privatized housing projects on DAF installations to hold MHPI companies accountable for project performance, problems with property management, and inappropriate business practices. In addition, we will continue to engage with local civic leaders to increase the availability of affordable, quality off-base housing options for our servicemembers and their families.

Retention efforts must also ensure military members and families have access to the care and support they need—including mental health. As the Nation struggles with a shortage of mental health providers, we are employing various innovative means to provide this care to Airmen and Guardians. The Targeted Care program improves access to care by connecting people to the most appropriate resource given their needs. Additionally, we are implementing the recommendations of the Independent Review Commission on Sexual Assault in the Military, as approved by the Secretary of Defense, and leaning forward on exploring the co-location of victim support services. Furthermore, we are implementing groundbreaking military justice

reforms to establish the Office of Special Trial Counsel, which will provide expert, independent, and specialized support for the investigation and prosecution of serious crimes such as sexual assault. We are also ready to begin implementation of the Department of Defense's Suicide Prevention and Response Independent Review Committee recommendations and have leaned forward on restructuring prevention training, increasing emphasis on lethal means safety and behavioral health workforce development.

Retention also requires that our talent management decisions are optimized for both the member and the Air Force. The Airmen Leadership Qualities we value must be reflected in our systems and transparent to our members. We are in the process of categorizing 161 specialties and approximately 19,000 functional skills to map flexible designs which align with the talent of our Airmen and are adaptive to emerging technologies and threats.

To develop the Airmen of tomorrow, our evaluation systems and supporting data systems must be modernized. FY23 saw the beginning of new officer and enlisted evaluation systems which will generate over 17 million data points to drive enhanced talent management decisions and reduce administrative burdens in the future. The new processes, enabled in part by the FY24 investments into digital infrastructure and tech refresh, will increase agility and flexibility to build the talent management structure we need. Concurrently, we are also implementing a dual-track "Civilians We Need" career model identifying functional expert and enterprise leader tracks on a model designed to allow flexible career paths based on the members' evolving needs.

AIR FORCE'S ROLE IN SUCCEEDING THROUGH TEAMWORK

Teamwork for the Air Force begins within the DAF, where the Air Force relies upon and supports the Space Force. The Air Force and Space Force are inextricably linked through shared history, current activities, and future operations. The Air Force relies heavily on Space Force for the technical development and execution of each of the operational imperatives and other necessary capabilities. Neither the Air Force nor the Space Force alone has the situational awareness and decision support tools to close hundreds of kill chains on relevant timelines in all domains in a highly contested environment. We can only be successful through teamwork to provide survivable, long-range, persistent families-of-systems across multiple modalities and as a part of a full joint and combined force. The Air Force depends upon a ready, resilient, and effective Space Force.

Our teamwork extends to the entirety of the joint force and Combatant Commands. Each of the operational imperatives and our broader capability investments supports the joint force by providing the capabilities necessary to deter and, if necessary, defeat any challenger. We play a vital role in homeland defense through air domain awareness and the provision of Airpower. We are also leveraging the capabilities of the mission and system level cyber risk assessment components of the Strategic Cybersecurity Program, led by the Under Secretary of Defense for Acquisitions and Sustainment, to help inform investments in cyber risk mitigation. The joint force's ability to effectively mobilize, deploy, and sustain forces cannot be accomplished without the mobility assets we provide. This FY24 budget includes \$252 million of investment in support of the integrated priority lists of the Combatant Commands. All our platforms and airborne capabilities contribute to joint force combat power, and we remain committed to providing capabilities to the Combatant Commands in the execution of their missions.

Beyond the joint force, we are seeking to expand how we team with our international allies and partners. Investments in readiness, human capital, infrastructure, and relationships with allies and partners remain foundational to balance present-day demands and set conditions for the future. This budget request, coupled with support from our allies and partners, enables responses to imminent threats while also seeking to improve the teamwork and interoperability of the allied and partner forces to win the fight of the future.

To ensure maximum teamwork with our allies and partners, we are seeking to expand interoperability through an Integrated by Design process. Integrated by Design is not a replacement for our current security efforts, but it ensures that we collaborate and make decisions together on interoperability, resource investment, information sharing, force development, and strategy from the very beginning of our programs with the end state constantly in mind. Conversations with allies and partners about developing capabilities that are complementary instead of competitive will also better align us to face future challenges in unity. That unity will be a comparative advantage against threats that seek military, technological, or economic means to challenge our collective national security.

CONCLUSION

The Department of the Air Force FY24 budget prioritizes defending the Nation, taking care of our people, and succeeding through teamwork by balancing the risk between maintaining current readiness, mid-term improvements, and longer-term modernization. Current readiness is being maintained at acceptable levels to support combatant commanders while investments are made in mid- and longer-term modernization that is critical to developing, building, and fielding the force needed for the future. The modernization efforts defined by the operational imperatives are not optional; they are called imperatives for a reason. No one can predict when a war with any potential threat may happen, and war is not inevitable. Nevertheless, the PRC, our pacing challenge, is actively and effectively developing the capabilities it believes are needed to defeat the American ability to project power. The PRC is also expanding and improving its strategic forces and experimenting with destabilizing novel concepts. The DAF must move forward as quickly as possible, or we will fall behind. No one should doubt our current capabilities, which remain the strongest the world has ever seen. Nevertheless, we are in a race for technological and operational superiority more challenging than anything we have ever experienced. In this environment, timely and soundly balanced investments in current, mid-term, and longer-term Air and Space Forces are essential to our continued security. Our most sacred duty to our Airmen and Guardians is to provide them with the tools they need to be successful. We believe the budget we have submitted for FY24 meets that need, but time is our most precious asset, and we urge Congress to move quickly to fund and authorize our proposed budget to enable the new starts, significantly rescoped program investments, and required capabilities that will allow us to keep pace with the threat.

Senator TESTER. Thank you General Saltzman. I want to thank all three of you for your testimony.

As I said in my opening statement last week, the FBI (Federal Bureau of Investigation) arrested a 21-year-old Air National Guardsman. He had access to highly sensitive information that we can't even talk about in this forum.

So General Brown, I have got three questions: Number one, why did this individual have access to this classified information? Number two, how could this Guardsman take this information and distribute it electronically for weeks if not months, and nobody knew about it? And number three, do we have protections in place, because we spend a lot of money trying to protect classified information, do we have protections in place to stop this from ever happening again?

General BROWN. Mr. Chairman, I appreciate the question, and let me go with your third question first. We do have protections in place to protect classified information, and all of our members are, as they get their security clearance, and then sign documents to have the process to protect the information.

Obviously, in this case this process fell apart. And so the aspect of this particular Airman for his particular job he had the access for information but he didn't actually have a need to know for some of the information.

We are going through an ongoing investigation associated with that, and then also determining how he was able to distribute. So ongoing, we have an ongoing investigation, and we have a process of looking at accountability, not only from the criminal standpoint for the individual, but also as we look at the organization itself, we are going to take a look at the overall processes across the Department of the Air Force.

And that Secretary Austin also sent out a memo to the Department of Defense, for us all to take a look at our processes, and then

we will look at how we review all of our processes across the Department of the Air Force, to include a standout on security.

Senator TESTER. So I am going to flesh this out a little bit more. You in your opening statement said that your oversight of 689,000 of some of the best people in the world that are under your command. How did this person even get access? Did he do it legally? Did he do it illegally? How did he have access to this information?

General BROWN. Chairman he actually has, because of his duties he has access to some aspects as he—based on his job as a cyber administrator. He took advantage of that access, and I don't want to go into more detail—

Senator TESTER. Okay.

General BROWN [continuing]. In too much detail, but I can talk to you in a closed session about that.

Senator TESTER. We will have a closed session with the Air Force, and I am talking a little off script here, but we will, because I think there are some things we need to talk about in the SCIF (Sensitive Compartmented Information Facility), not only this, but other things.

But this is very disturbing, and the fact that it happened is bad enough, and we have just got to make sure it doesn't happen again. I think you are on the same page with that.

General BROWN. I am.

Senator TESTER. A few months ago we saw an incursion of a Chinese spy balloon. I think Senator Murkowski would agree with me, that I think it should have been shot over the Aleutians, but it wasn't. And it had the ability to gather intelligence from bases across this country. The administration put in \$90 million in this budget to improve detection and assessment.

I assume this question is for you, Mr. Brown. Is there a point—General Brown, I am sorry. Is there a point person within the Air Force to improve our detection and assessment of the balloon issue, because I don't think it was the first one?

General BROWN. Chairman, we actually have an individual who is, Kristen Baldwin, who is actually not only for detection, but we are also looking at all the other aspects of detection, and tracking, and how you negate that—future threats like that.

Senator TESTER. Okay. And can you tell me who that person is, or?

General BROWN. Yes, sir. It is Kristen Baldwin. She works in our acquisition peripheral. What we have done is that we had a team that has come together to take a look at all the various capabilities that we have as a Department, but also outside of the Department of the Air Force, they are bringing in development to figure out what the best tools are to counter threats like that in the future.

Senator TESTER. Okay. The NORTHCOM (United States Northern Command) commander has told us that he has additional unfunded requirements for Air Force Over-the-Horizon Long Range Expeditionary Radars. We need to provide the resources, and I think this committee, on both sides of the aisle; wants to make sure our Nation is safe, okay, and provides the resources to do that.

So why has the Air Force decided to put this on the unfunded list instead of a higher priority?

Secretary KENDALL. Chairman, if I could?

Senator TESTER. Sure, Frank, go ahead.

Secretary KENDALL. We have funded two new Over-the-Horizon Radars in the budget. There is quite a bit of money in the budget to fill those, and get them in place. The money that I believe is on that list for General Vanherck is to accelerate that process on the margins. It is not a fundamental change; it just tries to move it a little bit faster.

Senator TESTER. Okay. Let us talk about the industrial base, because it is a concern on all the branches of the Military. There was about \$900 million put into last year's budget for the industrial base and supply chain issues. Can you tell me if that money has gone out the door, and what kind of benefits it has provided for the Air Force?

Secretary KENDALL. Yes. I think a large fraction of that money has gone out the door, but I will have to get that for you, for the record.

Senator TESTER. Okay.

Secretary KENDALL. There are a number of things we do with those funds, but essentially what we are trying to do is ensure that our supply chains are healthy.

Senator TESTER. Yes.

Secretary KENDALL. Identify any gaps in our supply chains that need to be addressed.

Senator TESTER. Yes. And does that include workforce?

Secretary KENDALL. Workforce in the industry?

Senator TESTER. In the industry, yes.

Secretary KENDALL. It can, but generally it has had some indirect effect rather than a direct effect.

Senator TESTER. I got you. So I would really like to, before I turn to Susan Collins, or Senator Collins. I would really like to get information as to the money that we put in: Is it actually having an effect? Is it actually doing what we want it to do? And this, by the way, will happen across the board for all the services. And is it actually making a difference?

Secretary KENDALL. Okay.

Senator TESTER. Because regardless of what number we put on the Defense budget, if it is not being utilized in a way that makes a difference for you then we have got to do something else.

Secretary KENDALL. It is fairly intensive work across the Department to identify weaknesses in the industrial base, and to prioritize the things that need some additional resources, you know, in ways appropriate. In the past we have done some things. In space, for example, we have already selected subcontractors in space specific technologies. There are other things we funded, like casting capabilities, and so on, where the return for industry isn't there to make those investments without the Department's support, assistance essentially.

Senator TESTER. Okay. Senator Collins.

Senator COLLINS. Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

Let me just follow up, General Brown, with the questions that the Chairman started with. As I read the press reports about the Airman First Class, who allegedly took, perhaps, hundreds of sensitive classified documents. The first thing that came to my mind is: Whatever happened to "Need to Know"? That is the principle

that is supposed to oversee and restrict access to sensitive classified information.

Instead, allegedly, this Airman First Class used the JWICS (Joint Worldwide Intelligence Communications System) System, the classified Internet system, to access all sorts of sensitive, classified documents that had absolutely nothing to do with his job. Is the Need-to-Know principle still in place?

Secretary KENDALL. Chairwoman Collins, it is very much—

Senator COLLINS. Or, Secretary Kendall?

Secretary KENDALL [continuing]. In place. General Brown mentioned the letter that the Secretary of Defense had put out tasking a review across the entirety of the Department, in very great detail, of all of our security practices. The two Chiefs and I put out a letter this morning which emphasized the point that you just made about, “Need to Know”.

We need to enforce it much more rigorously than it appears to have been in this case. I will say that we don’t know all the facts here yet. There is a criminal investigation going on, that has been the first priority, to make sure that wasn’t interfered with. But we have turned on three other things to look at this across the board.

I have tasked our Inspector General to go look at the unit, and anything associated with this leak that could have gone wrong, from the point of view of implementing our policies, to see what things allowed this to happen, to get the Senator Tester’s initial question.

We are turning on a complete review of our policies themselves, within the staff, to make sure our policies are adequate, and that will be illuminated by what we learn about what happened in this instant. We are asking the entire Force to do a stand down, to review their security practices, to conduct training as necessary, respond to the Secretary of Defense’s guidance.

There is a full court press going on about this. We are all disturbed about it. And we are working very, very hard to get to the bottom of it, and take corrective actions.

Senator COLLINS. Thank you, Mr. Secretary. One follow-up question for you on this issue, and that is, it appears that this was going on for many months without the Airman, allegedly, being caught and when he was caught, it was because of investigative journalism, not the controls within the Air Force. That is equally disturbing.

Secretary KENDALL. That is absolutely one of the things we will be looking at. And apparently he shared it, from press reports, with a group of friends in a chat group that was supposed to be isolated. It got out of that group, and it was there for, as you say, for a period of months. It got out of that group, and there is some press reports more recently about it being disseminated by some other people. And we are going to get to the bottom of all of that.

Obviously, we have to tighten up our processes and our practices to make sure this doesn’t happen again.

Senator COLLINS. Thank you. General Brown, last year I met with Former Defense Secretary Gates, and I asked him: What was the most important action that we could do to strengthen our national security? And I expected him to say: Have a larger Navy, or

improve recruitment; or answers like that. Instead, he said, “No more continuing resolutions.”

And you made a reference in your testimony. Could you, so that everyone understands the harm, of putting the Department on a continuing resolution, illustrate the problems that it causes for our Military?

General BROWN. Sure. The key area is that if we have a pacing challenge, we cannot outpace our pacing challenge if we have a continuing resolution. Those aspects of lost buying power, in this case, if we have continuing relations about \$9 billion of lost buying power.

The other aspect of the series of continuing resolutions we have had over the past, probably 10n to 12 years, we have lost probably about a quarter of that in continuing resolutions, which prevent us from doing new starts, getting equipment into the hands of our Airmen, and the rest of the Joint Team as quickly as possible. It impacts our families because their pay raises, and/or their ability to move to new locations and continue with their career, and their development, and education of their children.

I think the key part is just the aspect of us not being able to have a steady pace of acquisition and supporting—and to the Chairman’s point, on the Defense Industrial Base; when we have, what I would call, a bit of a rollercoaster ride, it is hard for them to “facilitize”, and get the workforce to be committed, and by having continuing resolution, it just slows us down, and when we are trying to accelerate, it is not helpful.

Senator COLLINS. I completely agree with you. And thank you for your answer.

Senator TESTER. Chairman Murray.

Senator MURRAY. Well, thank you very much, Chair Tester, and Vice Chair Collins. I am really glad to join both of you again as we continue to hear about the resources that our Nation needs to stay strong, and safe, and competitive on the world stage. And as Vice Chair Collins just talked about, it is so important that we return to regular order and work to pass our funding bills in a timely, bipartisan way, which is what we are really focused on doing.

These conversations also serve as a reminder to all of us about how the investments and decisions we make here in DC, help strengthen our country, and protect our families.

If we are going to keep pace with our adversaries like China, and others; that means our investments have to keep pace too. We can’t fall behind, and we certainly can’t fall into uncertainty due to partisan gridlock. So I am really glad to have this opportunity today on this committee to hear from our witnesses about what that means for our Air Force and Space Force, and of course, how we can support our service members and their families.

It is really important that we remember that includes getting our military families support, like child care, mental healthcare, good housing, schools, because really, at the end of the day, our best aircrafts aren’t going to go very far without the brave and talented men and women who pilot them and work to keep our country safe.

So let me thank all of you for your service to our country. This committee and all of our members have a deep appreciation for everything our Service members do to keep us safe.

With that, Secretary Kendall, let me start with you. Quality of life for our military families is a priority for me, and I am pleased to see child care prioritized in this budget across all branches. However, I consistently hear from families at Fairchild Air Force Base about Child Development Center wait lists, and challenges finding high quality and affordable childcare. I know those centers struggle to keep staff because, in part, due to low wages.

The President's budget seeks to address this critical issue, and it includes a standardized Child Development Center employee discount for child care workers. And the Air Force has previously, I know, ran a pilot program to provide additional benefit to Center employees, what other tools has the Air Force used to support current employees and future hires to keep these Child Development Centers fully staffed?

Secretary KENDALL. Thank you, Senator Murray. As you indicated, this is a major issue for those across the Force, and across the country, actually, particularly after the pandemic. The biggest problem, as you mentioned, is staffing, we do have some new facilities that we are funding but the main problem we have right now is staffing.

Secretary Austin is focused on this in his efforts to improve the quality of life for our service members and their families, and the Department of Defense put out a policy that could put a substantial discount, 50 percent, for staff members' first child in a child care with us. The Air Force have gone farther than that, we have gone to 100 for the first child, and then we do 25 percent for subsequent children. That has had an impact. We have gone from about 65- to 75 percent staffing overall, but there are still places where there are difficulties.

We have a number of other efforts underway. We work very hard to provide support for our men and women, and the hours that they work, which are not always standard hours. So we would need to have child care available more broadly. We are using child care from individuals in their homes, and we are doing things to encourage that and incentivize that, financially and otherwise. So there is a lot of effort going into this area. It is making a difference, but we have more to do.

Senator MURRAY. Okay. This is such an important issue for those families, and for recruitment, in general, for keeping those talented people that we need in the military, so I will continue to work with you this one.

Secretary Kendall, last year's Defense Appropriations Bill directed the Air Force to provide a plan to this committee on the transfer of KC-135s to Air National Guard units, like the 141st Air Refueling Wing in my State. We are still waiting for that plan. Can you give me a timeline for when we expect to see that?

Secretary KENDALL. Senator, that plan should be available within the next few weeks. And I will get a firm date for you after the hearing and let you know when you can expect it.

Senator MURRAY. Okay. And you have you been coordinating with the Air National Guard on the transfers?

Secretary KENDALL. We will definitely coordinate with the Guard, and I want you to know that. There has been no decision to make those transfers. It is an opportunity, we will look at them.

Senator MURRAY. Okay. I will look forward to hearing from you on that soon then.

General Saltzman, as our competitors around the world continue to closely link their space industries and militaries, they can quickly put new technology into the field. We need to make sure we are doing the same if we want to stay ahead of our adversaries. Washington State is home to a number of these cutting-edge commercial space companies that are developing really revolutionary technologies, and I believe this is the kind of innovation that we should be supporting.

How are you working with the rapidly growing space industry in Washington State, and really elsewhere, to bring these new technologies and capabilities into the Military?

General SALTZMAN. Thanks Senator Murray. We are working closely with industry. In fact, Secretary Kendall and I are leaving this afternoon to go out to Colorado for a Space Symposium to continue to work with industry.

Fully support Honorable Frank Kendall's—I am sorry—Honorable Frank Calvelli—

Senator MURRAY. He is sitting next to you, so.

General SALTZMAN [continuing]. Calvelli's Go Fast formula, which is buy small, have small requirement sets, small satellites, to use existing technology to reduce nonrecurring engineering costs. And then short-term, fixed-price contracts, 2 and 3 years, this allows us to advance the tech refresh cycle that actually pulls more contributors into innovating, and producing capabilities, that we can rapidly deliver to our Guardians.

And so, we are seeing, even in the Space Development Agency, that model play out very successfully. Putting satellites on orbit in about 27 months, and so that is one of the key efforts that we are taking to make sure we can deliver; work with industry and deliver capabilities faster.

Senator MURRAY. I appreciate the answer to that. And again, you just made the point that Senator Collins did, that a CR is not going to work for those short-term contracts. So thank you.

Senator TESTER. Senator Moran.

Senator MORAN. Chairman, thank you. Nice to know there is more than one Honorable Frank, we need all we can get.

Let me start, though, with you, Secretary Kendall. I have heard you say that the cost of hypersonics is a challenge that will drive a smaller inventory. DOD (Department of Defense) investment into hypersonics is primarily focused on capability with, in my view, minimal attention to ability to scale production. Are you looking at nontraditional suppliers, or commercial aerospace manufacturing companies to leverage their expertise, to scale production and to meet higher rate, needs?

Secretary KENDALL. Yes, we are, Senator. The components for hypersonics, in particular, tend to be very specialized, they have to endure very high temperatures, for example, and operate for a period of time, and we need high reliability for any of our weapon systems. But yes, we are always looking for suppliers outside the normal traditional Defense primes, if you will.

Senator MORAN. Is manufacturing the—and I think you have to answer this question, yes, but I want to highlight that manufac-

turing needs to influence the development of hypersonic technologies, right?

Secretary KENDALL. Absolutely, and our leading program, the HACM program, the Hypersonic Attack Cruise Missile; there are considerations being given in the design to manufacturability, and to reliability, so that we have a design that meets the technical requirements which are very stressing, but also is producible. So that that is a factor that we take into account through the design process.

We are about to transition that program which came out of a DARPA (Defense Advanced Research Projects Agency) Technology Program, into a full-scale development program, and I can assure you that manufacturability will definitely be part of that program.

Senator MORAN. Thank you, sir. You may have answered this when you responded to Senator Murray, but I am not sure it is the same. What is the Air Force's plan to recapitalize the National Guard Fighter Fleet? And how does that impact the Guard's ability to complete its missions?

Secretary KENDALL. We are recapitalizing across the Force. The Guard, of course, is an essential part of that. I think General Brown mentioned, and I mentioned the additional production of F-35s and F-15EXs. So we are bringing fighters into the Force faster than we had planned a year ago, but still not at a pace that can replace every fighter, one-for-one, as they retire.

We do need to retire some aircraft, like I mentioned, the A-10. And what we are trying to do, wherever we are retiring aircraft, particularly in the Guard, is replace programs with like programs, fighters with fighters, where we can. And if we can't do that, then we try to bring in a flying mission so it is still a flying mission. And if we can't do that, then we want to bring in a mission that is important to the Department and that the Guard can perform.

I think it is important to recognize that they are enduring missions, and missions that are critically important to the Department, that don't necessarily involve flying. ISR (Information, Surveillance and Reconnaissance) is one, C3 battle management is one, cyber is one, and electronic warfare is one.

So I think people need to be open to alternatives to what they might have traditionally done, if that is what the country needs the most. So we are working, as we lay out strategic plans for the different elements of the Force, including the Fighter Force, to try to get to the Force that we are going to need to be competitive with China. And it won't look exactly like the Force that we have today.

Senator MORAN. Mr. Secretary, I would only highlight what I think is, you know, when you talk about flying for flying mission, the importance in today's world of recruitment and retention, if we are going to have retention within our Air Guard that, I think, is an important component as you make these decisions: How do we keep our professionals in place? And I saw you shaking your head, so I feel comfortable—

Secretary KENDALL. I fully agree, Senator. Thank you.

Senator MORAN. Let me turn to General Saltzman for just a moment. You have testified about the Air National Guard's existing space capabilities as "must haves". In the context of establishing a Space National Guard, I understand that you are evaluating sev-

eral options, and you mentioned this in your oral testimony, and it is in your written testimony as well.

Can you explain to me the options that you are looking at, and the costs associated with them? How do you avoid degradation of readiness or capabilities with those options? And what is your best military advice, or that is yet to come?

General SALTZMAN. Well, thank you, Senator. The three options that we have looked at are, of course, our status quo. We can leave things as they are. But I think this is the most problematic course of action, because the capabilities that live inside the Air Force, in the Air National Guard, General Brown relinquished those capacities to train and develop those Airmen when the Space Force was established, in those capacities for organized training and equip of the space missions move to the Space Force.

And so we have a little bit of a disconnect between capabilities inside an Air Force, when the capacity to organize, train, and equip them are in the Space Force. So status quo is probably the most problematic.

The other two options are to establish the Space National Guard, which you mentioned, or reconstitute those capabilities inside the Space Force. We are currently going through a detailed analysis of exactly what the costs associated with each of those are, and there are pros and cons of both.

And my best military advice would simply be, to make sure that we choose the most cost-effective way of implementing, because we have a lot of high priority projects that require a lot of money, but also to minimize the operational impact in any kind of transition. So whichever one maintains the operational capabilities that are currently there in the most cost-effective way, would be my advice.

Senator MORAN. General, you mentioned earlier in your testimony that you would take the possibility into account for a time, different arrangements; is that a new opportunity within the Air Force?

General SALTZMAN. So slightly. There are two different concepts at play here. One is the legislative proposal that we have on the table, which is about taking the Air Force Reserve component performing space missions and integrate them into the Space Force, because those are already Title 10 Forces in both sides, it was a little easier to integrate in the near term, those capabilities. So that is the current ledge proposal. And that would create a full-time and part-time Force inside the Space Force. We think that is tremendous for retention, for flexible career paths.

Secondarily, we would consider: What is the best disposition of the capabilities in the Guard?

Senator MORAN. Thank you, all.

Senator TESTER. Senator Baldwin.

Senator BALDWIN. Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

General Brown, in April of 2020 the Air Force officially selected Truax Field in Wisconsin to receive the F-35 Mission. And I wanted to raise it again today because the F-35 aircraft will start arriving this month in Madison, and it will take roughly a year to get the full squadron in place. But as we discussed during last year's hearing, even though there is significant support for the basing de-

cision, I do continue to hear concerns about the potential noise impacts to residential areas in the flight path.

I worked with Senator Leahy to fund noise mitigation through our annual appropriations, and the Department of Defense has provided the Wisconsin Department of Military Affairs a grant to conduct community outreach about noise mitigation planning, to be followed by actual funding for that noise mitigation to begin to occur.

Because the F-35s are arriving this month, and throughout the next year, I am very anxious to be able to share with my constituents an update on that funding. Can you provide me with an update on the implementation of the F-35 transition? And what mechanisms are already in place to support these communities during the transition process?

And in particular, what your outreach and communication efforts are? Is the Air Force pursuing these outreach and communication efforts to ensure that the public is knowledgeable and has access to all of the relevant information about what is happening in their community, and what assistance is available?

General BROWN. Senator Baldwin, first of all, we are happy to have Truax join the F-35 community, it is a great capability. And one of the things that we will continue to work on, is the Department of Air Force will work very closely with the unit there, but also the community on the noise impacts. And so part of this is, as we bring in F-35s, and the warning of those noise impacts, but also working with the Airport Authority, the Federal Aviation Administration.

And then we will also put into place noise mitigation measures. And having flown fighter aircraft throughout most of my career, and having to do our departures and arrivals a bit differently just to support the noise mitigation, this is something we will work very closely with the community as we move forward.

I will have to get back to you and provide you a bit more details on the exact funding and the time lines as far as the engagements, but we will, you know, engage with the local community, and will be available to the local community to answer whatever questions they may have as we move forward.

Senator BALDWIN. Yes. Well, I will just share to underscore, that there is widespread support for basing the F-35s at Truax, but particularly I don't believe that the information about noise mitigation resources are getting out to folks who will be most impacted in the population centers, sort of immediately south of the airport. It is rather rural on the northern part of the airport, but people really are searching for information and need to be able to get that. So I urge you to continue, and double up on those efforts.

General BROWN. Most definitely.

Senator BALDWIN. All right. General Brown, also for you; I wanted to talk about the retention and recruiting shortfalls that remain an issue in all the service components, but of particular concern is the shortage of pilots in both the Active component and Air National Guard.

With a reported shortage of approximately 1,600 Active Duty pilots, the reliance then on the Air National Guard to fill those gaps is critical. However, the Air National Guard itself is short approxi-

mately 1,000 pilots, and this could have significant implications both in the near-term and long-term readiness for the Air Force's mission.

So can you speak to how the Air Force plans to address this shortage and attract more talent to the Active component, as well as to the Air National Guard, particularly in light of the significant competition for pilots from both the commercial sector, and other branches of the Military?

General BROWN. Most definitely, yes. You know, one of the key areas we focus on, as we do look at our shores, the first thing we do is to put 100 percent of our manning into—our 100 manning into our cockpits. It would take the shortage on our staff positions, where it says, we are inclined to take up that gap, versus on the flight line in the development of very young pilots.

We actually have a lot of young people that want to become pilots, and so one of our key parts is how do we increase that production, and would have some initiatives to do that. And one of the legislative initiatives is to convert some of our civilian SIM instructors to contractors so we can actually get more of our uniform members on a flight line to help the production and move that forward.

We also actually have to balance between our Active and our Guard, because if we retain a lot on the Active Duty, it impacts our Guard and Reserve, because that is how they get many of their pilots. So it is a combination of factors that we are working through on the production, and then the absorption into the cockpits as well.

So we have a number of initiatives in how we have adjusted our pilot training to increase that production, and then at the same time, as we take care of the Airmen, but also their families, also impacts retention.

As you mentioned, there is competition with the commercial sector, and that is something we have got to pay attention to as well, and how this is a national asset, from an aviation standpoint, both for commercial, but also for our military.

Senator BALDWIN. Yes. Well, please if you can, and follow up, point to any legislative measures or actions that this committee could take to support these efforts to increase recruitment and retention of pilots, please do let us know.

General BROWN. Will be happy to work with you. Thank you.

Senator TESTER. Senator Hoeven.

Senator HOEVEN. Thanks, Mr. Chairman.

I would like to thank all three of you for the work you are doing, and your strong leadership with the Air Force and Space Force. It is very much appreciated. And you are willing to be creative and innovative as we need to be these days.

Secretary Kendall, I was just in South Korea and Taiwan, clearly both want to continue to build their defenses, and work with us to do so. In regard to Taiwan they have about \$19-plus billion in hardware, military hardware, that they have ordered, and that they are paying for, and that they are waiting for, and they are, obviously, anxious to upgrade their defenses, and to do it soon.

What can we do to help? And things like the F-16, obviously, very important to them right now, what can we do to accelerate

getting them those weapon systems? And what can we do to work together, jointly, to strengthen their defenses?

Secretary KENDALL. Good question, Senator Hoeven. The best place to defend Taiwan from is Taiwan. And in having Taiwanese have the capability to defend themselves against the threat that they face I think is a high priority for us.

The F-16s are a program that we are trying to move through some supply chain and some production difficulties to get into place, getting through the bureaucratic pipeline would be very helpful getting those sales approved. One of the things that we have been working with Taiwan on is the mix of things that they have in their military, to make sure that it is appropriate to the mission, that they have their highest priority.

I think you may have seen in the press recently that they are attempting to buy some Harpoon anti-ship missiles, which would be very helpful actually.

Senator HOEVEN. Mm-hmm.

Secretary KENDALL. So we are working with Taiwan. It is not an area that I am leading in, but it is one that we work very hard on to make sure that their requirements are met. At the end of the day, Taiwan has got to decide for themselves what they want to have in their inventory. But once they do that, and we are happy to advise them on that, then we need to do everything we can to move that through as efficiently and effectively as possible. Appreciate your support for that.

Senator HOEVEN. Absolutely and we want to work with you, and with General Brown and General Saltzman to find ways to maybe help our military-industrial complex respond faster, not only for their needs, but also for yours, for ours.

Secretary KENDALL. Absolutely.

Senator HOEVEN. Along those lines, General Brown, in regard to modernization in your comments—which all three of you had and which I absolutely agree with, it's vitally important. The effort to modernize the nuclear mission which is incredibly important. It's certainly important to our Chairman, and myself, with bases at Malmstrom and at Minot Air Force Base, Minot being the only dual nuclear base.

How are we doing? And we have worked very hard to fund this. How are we doing? Are we on schedule with modernization of both the—not only the B-52, but the LRSO (Long Range Stand Off Weapon) as a replacement to the LCM, and also with the GBSD (Ground Based Strategic Deterrent) as a replacement to the ICBM?

General BROWN. Yes, Senator Hoeven, one of the things that has been really helpful to maintain the time lines associated with these programs and nuclear portfolio is the consistent funding and full funding. And that has helped us move in a very positive way. What I would tell you, as we look at, like Sentinel, for example, and the B-52, we do know that as we go into these large programs that there is potential supply chain and other issues, and we are working very closely, internally, with our industry partners to look ahead and figure out how best to do long lead items well in advance.

And so we have been able to restructure some of our approaches, acquisition approaches, with Dr. LaPlante from OSD (Office of the

Secretary of Defense), to help mitigate those areas so we can keep everything on time, and in some cases we are moving things forward. For example: some of our telecommunication lines, we will move those forward so we actually can get ahead in certain areas, and we don't have anything on a critical path that is going to impact the overall program; so good collaboration with—internal to the Department of the Air Force, but also with OSD and our industry partners.

Senator HOEVEN. Thank you.

General Saltzman, in regard to both the LEO Mission, which we work with; are you on schedule for getting those Low-Earth Orbit satellites into space for the Communications Mission; can you do so under the budget you have? And also what is your plan for upgrading PARCS in a timely way; obviously, highlighted by the recent Chinese spy balloon?

General SALTZMAN. Thank you, sir. First, the Space Development Agency is on track. We conducted our first launch of Tranche 0, just a couple of weeks ago. The satellites are performing well. And as I mentioned earlier, tremendous success, and I think it demonstrates a new model for acquisition, 27 months from putting it on order to being on orbit—

Senator HOEVEN. Wow.

General SALTZMAN [continuing]. Which is a pretty impressive capability.

Senator HOEVEN. Very.

General SALTZMAN. Especially for space acquisition. Congress added 250 million, which we greatly appreciated, to accelerate those. We are going to need the launch investment now to actually pay for putting them on orbit, so I think there is some cleanup that we are going to do across the program to make sure that happens, but the good news is, we are on track to not only deliver those capabilities, but accelerate the delivery of those capabilities.

And with regards to the PARCS Radar we have, with the plus-up, again, thanks to Congress, we are looking at, through RDT&E (finances research, development, test and evaluation), what is the most appropriate way to upgrade them, move them from analog capabilities into more digital, that includes data storage, some beam forming. We are going to bring that radar into the 21st century, and make sure that it can meet all those space situational awareness, as well as missile warning responsibilities.

Senator HOEVEN. Thanks Chair. I want to thank the Chairman and Ranking Member of this committee, too, for accelerating some of that funding in the last go round, which I agree was very important for that Low-Earth Orbit Satellite Mission, and we are seeing how important that is with what is going on.

Thanks to all three of you again.

Senator TESTER. Senator Murkowski.

Senator MURKOWSKI. Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

Gentlemen, thank you for being here today, and just—all, regarding your leadership. I understand that in questions from Senator Tester, he had acknowledged the NORAD, NORTHCOM, and the Department of Air Force's unfunded priority list. I am encouraged that you have placed the number one request there as the E-7 delivery, and the acceleration of that. I think we recognize that it

cannot come soon enough, and we are urging it along as quickly as we possibly can.

I want to ask about where we are with Long-Range Radars currently. They were fielded in the 1980s, to reach their life in 2025. Right now there is no current program of record to replace the existing Long-Range Radars, making the 3DELLR the only viable option to maintain the required domain awareness for Homeland defense there.

So this is directed to you, Secretary Kendall. Do you think that the budget that we are looking at adequately funds this 3DELLR System to include upgrades to the system, such as Over-the-Horizon Radar, or the advancement of the Archer? So where are we with the Long-Range Radars?

Secretary KENDALL. Thank you, Senator Murkowski. If I could just clarify, the Department of the Air Force does not have an upper list, we support the President's budget. General Brown has an upper list, which I think includes the E-7 acceleration that you are mentioning. We are funding the sustainment of the various Long-Range Radars that you mentioned for a missile warning system. Some of those Raiders, as you mentioned, are old. We just talked about PARCS a moment ago. The BMU System itself is quite old. We don't have a program in place, as far as I know, to replace that yet. We are sustaining it right now. But we are looking at all that.

The major investment we have in our budget for 2024, is the Over-the-Horizon Radars, that we talked about, as you mentioned earlier. Those are focused mostly on airborne threats coming across, particularly in the northern approaches. So we are looking at that entire suite of capabilities we have, to protect the United States against a variety of threats.

One of the things we are focusing on is the C3 battle management and the integration—excuse me—of all those systems together, so that we can get the most accurate picture as possible of any threats that emerge.

And I will be happy to get with you in a classified setting, and go through the details of all that. Show you what we are investing in, and what other things we are considering.

Senator MURKOWSKI. I would appreciate that, and I recognize that the value of this integration, I had an opportunity, just last week, to go out to Sparrevohn, in the center of Alaska, one of the older sites, actually not that old, got built in the '80s, but it seems old. But recognizing the role that is played with Over-the-Horizon, but also what we have had in place for it for some decades now.

And General Brown, we talk a lot in this committee about all that we do to modernize our Air Force, everything that we need to do to replace aging weapon systems, but we also know that the ability to train, and to train well has got to be key. And we talk about our exceptional training opportunity with the Joint Pacific Alaska Ranch Complex, JPARC.

What more do we need to do to ensure that the JPARC remains this extraordinary training asset for our Air Force and for those who also come to share partnership in the training exercises?

General BROWN. As you highlighted, training is very important to our Air Force, and the aspect of not only our Air Force, but the

Air Forces of other nations that come to participate with us and also our joint teammates. And two of them are premier Ranges, one of those is JPARC, and the other one is known as the Nellis Test and Training Range.

In this particular budget, in fiscal year 2024, we have over \$750 million that are placed into our Range infrastructure, to ensure that we have the right threat emitters to support our Airmen as they engage, so they have a threat emitter that replicates the threat as well as the improvements on the targets that they are able to go against it as well. And then on top of that it is the supporting infrastructure to support the Ranges.

So we are on a good path, but we have got to continue to keep focus on, and as we have this money into this year's budget, just continue to see that for both of those Ranges, JPARC and the Range at Nellis, are two key Ranges that we are going to continue to invest in to ensure we have the capabilities to train our Airmen.

Senator MURKOWSKI. Okay. I want to note that we are going to continue to place a priority on that.

Mr. Chairman, I have a question regarding the Combat Rescue Helicopter, and the significance of that mission, particularly for the 176th Wing on JBER, that is the primary SAR Rescue Force there in Alaska, but because my time has expired I will submit that question; as well as one for General Saltzman for the record.

Senator TESTER. Thank you, Senator Murkowski.

And with that question and others, we would ask that you get the response back as soon as possible.

Senator Boozman.

Senator BOOZMAN. Thank you, Mr. Chairman, and Ranking Member, for having this hearing. And we appreciate you guys very, very much, and all you do and represent.

I have had the opportunity to visit with many of our Allied Partners regarding training, the opportunity to train with our Airmen as far as F-35 training.

General Brown, can you speak to the importance of pilots from our partner nations training with our pilots here in the U.S., and how crucial that is to national security?

General BROWN. Senator Boozman; thanks for the question. I will tell you just from my own personal experience in my many years operating with our allies and partners, most of my time as general officer, working with allies and partners, and how much they value the opportunity to train together, whether it is at locations overseas, but primarily here in the United States where they can actually use some of our advanced Ranges like I just talked about.

And so there is real value in the aspect of them being able to train. And as we bring on the F-35, not only for the United States Air Force, but with our allies and partners, their ability for us to train very closely together as we bring in this new capability, it helps provide additional capacity as we look at our collective security, not just our security, but the security we share with their allies and partners as well.

Senator BOOZMAN. Very good. And this is the cream of the crop. So not only are they, you know, helping with defense, but also the

ability to develop those relationships with future leaders of their countries.

The other important point I continue to hear from our allies is the need for training to start on time. They have time lines and commitments along with the need to be ready to fight if needed. As we continue to build F-35 capacity, our U.S. bases are becoming resource constrained and affecting our allies' ability to train.

General Brown, with U.S. Air Bases becoming more crowded, can you speak to why it is important to have the ability to invest in future F-35 training centers?

General BROWN. What I would like to highlight to you, Senator, one of the areas we have looked at is, overall, as we have more and more countries that are interested in the F-35 and bring that in, we also have to take a look at how we, across the board, have our capability to not only train them but train ourselves, but as we remain our combat capability.

We have the locations where we have done traditional training, are starting to get a bit more crowded, and so, as you know, we have been looking very closely at Ebbing as a location, and we are doing that work to get Ebbing up to speed, and a part of that is also to meet the time line associated with the work we have done with our allies and partners so they can get their training on time.

And in the big scheme of things it helps us all to get their training on time, to get certain capability, but that we appreciate the support from your delegation. And we have done some really deep work internal to the Department of Air Force to align things, to make sure we get that capability on time at Ebbing.

Senator BOOZMAN. Good. Thank you.

Mr. Secretary, do you feel like you have got all of the authorities that you need regarding, you know, things going forward to help build the training capacity that we need?

Secretary KENDALL. Senator, yes, I do. I am not aware of anything that I need that I don't have. But I will be happy to share with you if I come to that conclusion.

Senator BOOZMAN. Good. We appreciate that. Let me just talk about one thing that I think has already been talked about, but I think it is so, so very important. Senator Tester, and I chaired a roundtable regarding quality of life issues, and Mrs. Brown came and, you know, she did a tremendous job, and could speak as somebody, you know, that not too-too long ago, was in the situation of our Airmen, Airwomen, you know, that are struggling now to starting their careers, making ends meet, all of the challenges as you move every 2 or 3 years.

So I guess what I would say, and it doesn't matter if you are in the Space Force, regular, you know, Reserves, whatever, but particularly, like I say, the challenge of moving, spousal, you know, opportunities regarding their ability to work, schools child care is such a huge issue.

And I want to compliment you all, you all are doing a really good job in those arenas. But also it is going to become more and more important, from recruiting and a retention standpoint, those quality of life issues.

Looking back, you know, now that I am older and appreciate my parents so much more than I did as a kid, as we all do, but my

dad doing 23 years as a Master Sergeant realizing that those were the first things they looked at, you know, taking care of us.

So I guess what I am saying is, we do appreciate the fact that you really are looking hard at those quality of life issues, and realize how important they are, and doing your very best to take care of the men and women that work for you, and we do appreciate that.

Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

Senator TESTER. The only thing I have to add to that is General Brown is a fine outstanding man, but you obviously, married up.

Senator BOOZMAN. I agree with you.

Senator TESTER. Exactly.

Senator BOOZMAN. After getting to know her, I agree with you totally. In fact, that is probably an understatement.

Senator TESTER. General Saltzman, and it was the same way in last year's budget, you submitted an unfunded priorities list that includes classified, high priority space programs. It seems to me that the decision did not include these programs in the budget, is not driven by physical constraints, but by disagreements within the administration over the future of our space architecture. Can you please explain those different schools of thought?

General SALTZMAN. Well, you know, you say it is not about priorities, but in the end I think all these resourcing issues do come down to some level of priorities, and where we are willing to fall in our sword or not. I am comfortable with the level of resourcing we have, especially in the classified programs. I think there was some back and forth towards the end of the budget submission that maybe align funds in a way that we are going to have to figure out other ways to manage the programs, for example.

But we have those ways. We can collaborate with the other stakeholders, we can make sure that our concept of operations are clean, and that we can put the right kinds of demand signals, for example, on partners that are building capabilities for us. So I feel like although it may not be the way we would have designed it, I feel like I am comfortable that we have the kinds of mechanisms in place to collaborate appropriately, and get what we need in place.

Senator TESTER. This committee added significant funding for your classified unfunded priorities last year. Can you give us some insight on the return on that investment?

General SALTZMAN. I am happy to say that I expect; that by the end of my tenure, if I make it all the way to 2026, that you are going to see a substantial on-orbit capability that allows us to compete in full spectrum operations.

Senator TESTER. Okay.

General SALTZMAN. I am not sure I could have said that 2 years ago, but the fact that we have accelerated the programs, and we have built a program that delivers in capability in terms of 3, 4, 5 years, I am very comfortable that we have a program in place that will do just that.

Senator TESTER. Okay. Secretary Kendall, you made a decision on a different power source for the F-35, and you chose the Pratt & Whitney over the GE, and I have got no dog in this fight, I want to just make sure we are doing what is right for the Air Force.

The question that I have was; that it is my understanding of the Pratt & Whitney engine is on paper, and the GE engine is sitting on a stand. Can you give me some of the thoughts, process that you went through when you made that decision? And why you chose one over the other?

Secretary KENDALL. Thank you, sir. That is a Department of Defense decision actually, and a decision I support. The competition, essentially, was between an advanced technology that had been in work for several years, I was part of the starting of that, and continuing, it is called the ATP, which provides a substantial improvement in fuel efficiency, as well as other features.

The unfortunate thing about this is that it is a very expensive program to continue. There is a large upfront cost associated with engineering, manufacturing development for that program. And at this point the only—of the three F-35 variants, the Marine Corps, the Navy, and the Air Force, the only one that is definitely compatible with that program is the Air Force.

So the Air Force sort of had to carry that entire cost, several billion dollars, to do development before you start production. So that was just simply not affordable. The enhanced core upgrade that we did fund; provides an acceptable level of improvement to meet our known needs, and it is compatible with all three variants of the F-35. So that was where we ended up.

Senator TESTER. So to add, the issue was compatibility?

Secretary KENDALL. Cost and incompatibility. I would say affordability for us was the first concern.

Senator TESTER. Okay.

Secretary KENDALL. We couldn't get past that threshold, and if we had then it would have been probably a different answer.

Senator TESTER. Okay. Senator Shaheen.

Senator SHAHEEN. Thank you, Mr. Chairman. And thank you all. I am sorry I missed much of the questioning, for other hearings.

But Secretary Kendall, and I guess General Brown, both; we continue to be concerned in New Hampshire about the level of PFAS (per- and polyfluoroalkyl substances) that continues to contaminate the former Pease Air Force Base. And I know that the Air Force is taking steps to address that, and to plan for the aqueous film forming foam, whatever is going to succeed that, in terms of being able to fight fires.

Can you speak to where you are in terms of developing that alternative, and what you expect to be a time line for when that will be available?

Secretary KENDALL. Senator, we have been unsuccessful in finding an equivalent alternative to the PFAS. So what we are doing, basically, is going to water as the alternative for now. I think, as you are aware, the EPA (Environmental Protection Agency) has come out with new criteria, which is in the final stages of regulatory consideration.

The Air Force has assessed our bases, including Pease, to understand how much contamination we have, and once there is a finalization of that, then we will start looking at remediation, and moving forward to try to do something to clean this up.

You and I spoke about this before but you know it is something of great concern. We want to make sure that nobody around any

of our bases is in an unsafe condition, particularly with regard to their drinking water.

Senator SHAHEEN. I appreciate that. And I do appreciate very much the cooperation that we have gotten from the Air Force in New Hampshire. It has made a huge difference. One current challenge, that I think you are aware of, is there is a difference in interpretation of something that was in the NDAA (National Defense Authorization Act) about making information available to the local public about contamination, and hopefully we will be able to work that out in a way that is agreeable to both the Air Force and communities.

Can you also speak to when the Remote Vision System—this may be for you, General Brown, for the KC-46 is going to be operational?

General BROWN. What?

Secretary KENDALL. You go, yes.

General BROWN. If I have my facts right, I think it will be fiscal year 2026, is when they will be operational, and will be able to start cutting it in. But I will make sure I come back to you, and get the answer.

Secretary KENDALL. I mean the current system is being used now. It is cleared for all but one of our aircrafts. But the fixable problems we have with the remote viewing system, as General Brown said, will be coming in, and I think in 2026. We will confirm that though.

Senator SHAHEEN. That has slipped again has it? It is my understanding that that was originally going to be fielded in 2025.

General BROWN. This may have slipped a little bit, but I think we are on a good path. And as the Secretary highlighted, we were able to, operationally, employ the KC-46 worldwide today, with the only exception, the only airplane we can't refuel with it is the A-10.

Senator SHAHEEN. And I understand that there is also a recently identified issue with the KC-46's load guidance system. Is that affecting the aircraft's ability to carry cargo, in a significant way?

General BROWN. I am not aware of that issue, but I will look into it, and I would be able to get back to you.

Senator SHAHEEN. I would appreciate that. Thank you.

General Saltzman, I know, I just had an opportunity to meet with a number of National Guard members in New Hampshire, and one of the things that they are still not clear about is how the one-component proposal is going to operate in terms of National Guard across the country. Can you talk about how you see that working, and what you are doing to address the concerns of the state adjutant generals on that issue?

General SALTZMAN. Yes, ma'am. Thank you. The legislative proposal that we put forward for this year simply takes the Reserve component and integrates them into the active Space Force. So that is just the Title 10 Air Force Reserve aspect of this. It was a simpler administrative lift to make sure that we understood exactly how to do this. But it also set aside the discussion for the National Guard at this point.

So it is a two-step process. I think if we get the legislative proposal in and signed off in law, that will allow us to start looking

at how the Space Force can actively use both full-time and part-time Guardians to do its Mission set. Then I think you have the opportunity to open up and evaluate whether that same model could be extensive—extensible out to the National Guard as well. But it is a two-step process at this point.

Senator SHAHEEN. And do you anticipate any opportunity for or adjutants general, or other representatives of the Guard to weigh in with you as you are thinking about and have this second iteration should go?

General SALTZMAN. I talk to Dan Hokanson all the time, he is of course the Chief of the National Guard Bureau. He reflects the opinions of all of those tags that are out there. And so I would say that, at least from a space perspective, we are engaged already to make sure we understand what the requirements are, what the limitations are, what the opportunities are to better integrate.

We are a little bit stuck, as I said, with the status quo, where the Air Guard has responsibility for training a space mission, but we don't really have the capacity on the Air Force side to do that; and so we have got to come up with some solution, and the tags are fully engaged in helping us do that.

Senator SHAHEEN. Thank you. Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

Senator TESTER. Senator Capito.

Senator CAPITO. Thank you, Mr. Chairman. And thank you all, here, and it is nice to see you again. And we had our meeting several weeks ago, and I appreciate that.

Secretary KENDALL, as you know, the conversion of the Air National Guard C-130 units to the J models has been ongoing. And I am pleased to say that I have seen the impressive J model myself while visiting the West Virginia Air National Guard's 130th Airlift Wing, in my hometown of Charleston. But they made us aware that the aircraft our Guard units are receiving may be behind in some of the modification processes for Tactical Data Link capabilities, an upgrade that is necessary to integrate with the rest of the Joint Force if we found ourselves in a combat environment. I am wondering: Does the fiscal year 2024 budget address this Tactical Data Link deficiency?

Secretary KENDALL. Yes, I believe it does, Senator. I think we are doing that. There was a period of time over which we were going to do that with some of the fleet. I can get the details to that, too, for the record though.

Senator CAPITO. Okay. So General Brown, how does improving that Tactical Data Link, what kind of difference does that make in a combat environment, and how important is that?

General BROWN. What the Tactical Data Link does is really increases situational awareness for the air crew. And so they have, not only a better sense of where they are, but a better sense of the other activities that is going on around their aircraft, and how they can help contribute to the mission. And so, you know, having flown with Tactical Data Links in Fighters, personally, it really does help your situational awareness to have a good understanding what is going on in the environment.

Senator CAPITO. So it was the goal to transition? I mean, you said "most". Secretary Kendall, is the goal to transition all of those to that more advanced data link; or some, or what?

General BROWN. Yes, Senator.

Senator CAPITO. Oh.

General BROWN. I mean, that the goal is to actually move as many of those as we can as the—as those aircraft have service life, and wanted to put the Tactical Data Link into.

Senator CAPITO. Okay. Good, that is good news.

Secretary Kendall, again, a more technical question here; and we know that range would mean everything if we ended up in an Indo-Pacific situation, and also have the 167th Airlift Wing in Martinsburg, West Virginia, which operates the C-17 Globemasters. But they are not equipped right now with the extended fuel range tank, which would make a big difference if we found ourselves in the Asia Pacific. How does the budget deal with that? Is that something that you are planning to transition all the C-17s to?

And then General Brown, I am going to ask you, too, what kind of impact that would have?

Secretary KENDALL. Yes. We are transitioning C-17s. I don't think the entire fleet will transition, the largest fraction, it will split among the parts of the Fleet that are in the Active Guard and Reserve.

Senator CAPITO. Mm-hmm.

Secretary KENDALL. Roughly equivalent percentages of each I think.

Senator CAPITO. Okay.

Secretary KENDALL. We can give you the exact numbers for that.

Senator CAPITO. Okay. Yes, we will follow up with that, and appreciate that.

General Brown, do you have a comment on that, what that could mean and what difference it makes?

General BROWN. You know, as the Secretary said, that modification is roughly equivalent across the Active Guard and Reserve, and what it does do is provide options as far as being able to go further in different locations.

Senator CAPITO. Right.

General BROWN. And be able to break capability and capacity. Particularly in the Indo-Pacific where, again, having served there as the Commander of Pacific Air Force, is just, you know, the extended ranges that we have to operate in, this is where that capability will be very helpful.

Senator CAPITO. Well, I mean, you won't find any better Airlift Wings than I have in West Virginia, I can tell you that. I have to put that advertisement in. I might have some disagreement here, but—

Senator COLLINS. I beg to differ.

Senator CAPITO [continuing]. I will say that. Secretary Kendall I know that—and I haven't been here for the whole hearing—but certainly the data breach and the leak of the classified information I think was alarming to everybody. And I could maybe even put you in that category, who are concerned about the damage that has been done. But I mean I think we need to look forward here.

I understand that DOD is conducting a review of the processes at the DOD level. Are you doing the same at the—within the Department of the Air Force?

Secretary KENDALL. Absolutely. And “alarming” I think is as good a word as any to describe what has happened. We are doing a number of things, and I discussed some of them earlier, but we are investigating to see what errors might have occurred, or breaches of policy, and so on, that could have allowed this to happen, in addition to, obviously, whatever wrongdoing by the individual.

We are looking at the unit, we are looking beyond the unit, other things that could have influenced this. We are reviewing all of our policies, and we have direction from the Secretary of Defense to do a review across the Department of a whole number of things that have to do with information protection, basically.

Senator CAPITO. Right.

Secretary KENDALL. So Secretary Austin signed out a memo yesterday on that, with a lot of detailed guidance, and a fairly quick suspense to come back. The two Chiefs and I signed out a memo this morning amplifying on what the Secretary had said, but also emphasizing some areas such as Need to Know, and enforcing Need to Know.

Senator CAPITO. Right.

Secretary KENDALL. This individual, whatever else was true, had no reason to be looking at, or having possession of those documents. And we have to do a better job of that. That is clear, if nothing else is from this.

Senator CAPITO. Well, we will be interested in hearing what the results of that are. I think that is important for not just system-wide, but for us to know, and the American public to know, so a transparent process there.

Just a quick comment on the information that has come out about this individual that was arrested, I think there is a lot of discouraging things about it, but for me, I was just sitting here thinking about it, thinking: it is almost like it was a game. You know, it was a—you are in this chat room with—supposedly, with small amounts of people. And, you know, all this kind of chatter.

It is not a game. You are endangering lives. You are endangering, you know, freedoms, just eroding trust. And so I think that that is one aspect of it that is incomprehensible, I think, to many of us. And I will put myself in that boat. You don’t need to comment on that. I just wanted to make a quick comment.

Secretary KENDALL. I agree with you. What you described it exactly the same way that any Airman, or Guardian, or anyone in uniform could not appreciate the seriousness of this material, and how damaging it would be to have it get out into public domain. That is a fundamental problem of its own, right. That is what the appearance is in this case. It is a criminal investigation.

Senator CAPITO. Right.

Secretary KENDALL. So we don’t want to say too much about the case itself.

Senator CAPITO. Right.

Secretary KENDALL. But that appearance is very disturbing.

Senator CAPITO. Thank you. Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

Senator TESTER. We have saved the best for last. Senator Collins.

Senator COLLINS. Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

Mr. Secretary, I want to return to the F-35 engine issue. As I understand it, there are two factors driving the administration's decision. And I support that decision.

One, is the Adaptive Engine Transition Program was not compatible with the Navy and Marine Corps variants of the F-35. The second factor, as I understand it, is the Joint Program Office did a business case analysis which described stark differences in the overall lifecycle costs between proceeding with the engine core upgrade path chosen by the administration, compared to the more expensive engine replacement.

As I understand it, the engine core upgrade would actually decrease the overall costs of the program while the engine replacement option would have the opposite effect, it would, substantially, increase the cost of the program well into the billions of dollars even after you account for fuel cost savings. Is my understanding correct?

Secretary KENDALL. Roughly, let me just tell you my view on this. I have seen a number of business analyses, but basically there is a large upfront cost associated with the ATP engine. You have to go through an engineering development program that is going to cost several billion dollars and take several years. So that upfront cost, the affordability of that, for the Air Force at least, it was a major factor.

There is a return. There is a value to having that enhanced performance. You get more range, you get more capability out of the aircraft, and you get more power off of the engine that you can use to drive all the things on the aircraft. So there is a judgment call, if you will, about the value of those things relative to their cost. The fuel savings, over time, would take a very long time to pay for themselves. So that is really not, I think, at the end of the day, in terms of financial impact, a major factor.

The fact that the ATP would not fit in all three, and it certainly will not fit in the Marine Corps version, there is some disagreement about whether it would fit in the Navy version, or could be made to fit in the Navy version. And I will defer to the Navy to give an opinion on that.

So at the end of the day, when you looked at the needs of the whole, Department of Defense, the decision was made, and I supported, was to go ahead with the engine core upgrade. It is not quite as mature, so there is a little bit of risk in that, but it gets us to our known requirements. And so that is the path that we are on right now.

Senator COLLINS. Thank you. In my opening statement I mentioned my concern about fuel costs. In the last 2 years the budget requests greatly underestimated fuel costs on the very day the budget was released, the fuel costs were already much higher, they appear to be going up again. Do you anticipate requesting a supplemental to cover increased fuel costs?

Secretary KENDALL. If we have to we will. Mike McCurdy, Under Secretary for Financial Management communicated earlier to the Congress about how we deal with inflation, or things like this. I believe the budget includes an assumption of fuel cost inflation between 3- and 4 percent, so what we will do, as we did last year, is we will watch and see what happens with fuel prices, and if nec-

essary we will work with the Congress to try to solve that problem, if it emerges.

Senator COLLINS. Thank you. General Saltzman, I applaud the Space Force's effort to develop a more resilient space architecture. However, we in Congress often hear complaints and concerns about how long it takes to develop new capabilities, especially for those in space.

The Space Development Agency recently launched the first set of its satellites in less than 3 years from contract award. Could you tell the committee, what other steps you are taking to accelerate the development and delivery of space-based capabilities?

General SALTZMAN. Yes, Senator. To some degree that is just a mindset shift. Instead of developing large exquisite satellites, and developing, and pulling in requirements from a myriad of stakeholders; because we know that when we launch a satellite we want it to last 10, 12, 15 years, that is what extends the length of the program; Mission Assurance that we have to layer on to those kind of programs.

We are taking a wholly different approach: smaller satellites, smaller requirement sets allow us to go faster, and the contracting piece of that, put something on orbit, recognizing that we may have to do some tech refresh on a faster time line but that will actually have better capability, and even more cost effective over the long run.

And so I think that what Frank Calvelli has done by establishing this formula for going fast, is effective and paying off, existing technologies, small contracts, fast contracts, fixed price, we are delivering the capability in much faster time lines.

Senator COLLINS. Thank you. Mr. Secretary.

Secretary KENDALL. If I could add to that. One of the things that we are taking advantage of is that the transformation of the commercial world in space to a much more efficient, much more cost-effective designs, and engineering practices that support the business case that commercial firms have. So we are basically able to capitalize on that in things that we are building for Military purposes. So it is a nice synergy there between the commercial world and the Department of Defense's world now.

Senator COLLINS. Thank you. Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

Senator TESTER. Thank you, Senator Collins.

And I want to express my appreciation to all three of you for your testimony here today, and the questions that you have answered.

ADDITIONAL COMMITTEE QUESTIONS

Senators may submit additional written questions, and as I said earlier, we would ask you to respond to all of them as quickly as possible.

[The following questions were not asked at the hearing, but were submitted to the Department for response subsequent to the hearing:]

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED TO FRANK KENDALL

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR JON TESTER

Question. Last year, Congress accelerated investments in weapons so that our weapons magazines are loaded up for future contingencies. In this year's budget, the Air Force is requesting \$1.0 billion to achieve time and cost savings via multi-year Procurement contracts for the production of several missile programs. This includes significant investments by the Government to increase industry's production capacity. However, it is not yet clear what the private sector investment will be in return for this procurement predictability from the Government.

Secretary Kendall, what industry investments are you expecting in return for these Government investments? General Brown, are these programs fully funded across future budgets and is the Air Force committed to protecting those investments in future years even as the Air Force seeks to increase procurement of newer, more modern missiles?

Answer. The FY24 budget request shows a renewed commitment to munitions procurement throughout the Future Years Defense Program (FYDP) by the Department. The Department of the Air Force (DAF) worked closely with industry partners while building this plan and does not foresee any additional or separate industry investment is necessary to ensure that our procurement profile is executable. Increasing industry production capacity and providing procurement predictability will benefit the DAF by maximizing procurement quantities and stabilizing the industrial base.

Additionally, the Air Force is pursuing a multi-year procurement strategy for our most critical munitions such as the Advanced Medium-Range Air-to-Air Missile (AMRAAM), the Joint Air- to-Surface Standoff Missile (JASSM), and the Long-Range Anti-Ship Missile (LRASM). We are fully funding these programs through the FYDP to their current maximum production capacities, which will protect these investments and ensure a stable industrial base over the next four to 5 years.

Question. In the last five budget cycles, the Air Force's request for research and development funds compared to the request for procurement funds has doubled. The Air Force has invested heavily in the development and testing of important systems and capabilities, but it is a disservice to the taxpayers if these investments don't translate into fielded systems.

Secretary Kendall, does the Department of the Air Force have a plan to combat this trend of funding disparity between R&D and Procurement? Why are programs not transitioning from the research, development, and prototyping phase?

Answer. The DAF increased its Research and Development (R&D) budget by \$20.0 billion from the FY20 budget request to the FY24 budget request. This is principally due to the stand-up and resourcing of the Space Force, but also driven by a shift in investments to address the pacing challenge, as well as ensure Air, Space, and Cyber mission dominance. The DAF is taking a balanced approach to implement the National Defense Strategy (NDS) by procuring capabilities that deliver this mission and making necessary R&D investments to transition technology to deliver future capabilities. The strategy includes modernization and pivots to address the China fight including Collaborative Combat Aircraft (CCA), Command, Control, Communication, Battle Management (C3BM), and resilient space architectures. While the Department begins R&D investments with the general intent to procure systems, each system is evaluated on its merits against cost, schedule, and performance requirements, as well as resource constraints. In limited cases, the outcome may result in a decision not to continue to procurement. DAF prioritization of Operational Imperatives facilitates a sharp focus on technology transition. This is complemented by a series of enabling initiatives including digital transformation, facilitating innovation pathways for small businesses and ensuring acquisition, requirements, as well as resourcing processes are integrated and tailored to accelerate capability delivery.

Question. Due to this large increase in R&D over the previous fiscal year, I presume a Continuing Resolution (CR) would have a significant impact on the Air Force modernization budget. What areas are most at risk in the event of a CR?

Answer. Modernization of the Air Force and Space Force is critical to DAF implementation of the NDS. At the forefront of the FY24 DAF budget request are the Operational Imperatives, modernization efforts intended to close key capability gaps and directly address our pacing challenges. A CR would further erode our competitive advantage to China by stopping the investment of at least \$2.0 billion in 88 new modernization efforts including 20 aligned to critical capabilities within the Operational Imperatives, including 71 Air Force new starts totaling \$1.4 billion and 17 Space Force new starts totaling \$595.0 million.

Further, during a CR, the DAF is limited to operating at FY23-enacted funding levels resulting in \$9.3 billion of lost buying power. The DAF would be forced to delay on-going development, stop work, or terminate programs to remain within funding limits if a CR extends into FY24 for a long period. These programs are key to the high-end fight with a near-peer competitor. Modernization is necessary to not only keep pace with our strategic competitors but required if we are to establish a new high ground in the Air, Space, and Cyberspace domains.

Question. The Air Force is requesting \$9.0 billion to continue modernizing the nuclear enterprise. For the air- and land-based legs of the nuclear triad, we are running out of time to replace existing, aging systems.

Secretary Kendall, we discussed the ongoing modernization of the ICBM fleet extensively during your visit to Malmstrom Air Force Base earlier this month. This is more than a missile program. We're talking about significant infrastructure and construction investments, too. Are we sufficiently tapping into our existing manufacturing workforce to achieve our ambitious construction goals for ICBM modernization?

Answer. The construction goals for ICBM modernization are ambitious. To best accomplish those goals, the Air Force is accelerating some initial construction efforts at FE Warren AFB, WY to begin in FY24 instead of FY26. The Air Force is also managing construction and transition risks from the industrial base, the age of the launch facilities, and the need to maintain Minuteman III operations while fielding LGM-35A Sentinel. Congress can help address these issues by supporting our request for contract type flexibility for the early construction lots.

Question. In January, we learned that former missileers at Malmstrom Air Force Base in Montana are dying of Non-Hodgkin's Lymphoma at rates higher than the national average.

Secretary Kendall, you recently joined me at Malmstrom—along with the Air Force Surgeon General, Lieutenant General Miller—to discuss the Air Force's response to this crisis.

As a follow up, can you tell us what the Air Force is doing to reach out to former missileers whose information is not captured in electronic health records?

Answer. The DAF has taken many steps to reach out to former servicemembers and other populations who have worked in missile fields to better understand the extent and severity of the issue, as well as track population trends over time. Leadership has been using townhalls, open forums, and webcasts to communicate updates to the impacted communities and leveraging installation Public Affairs offices to communicate directly to local communities.

Additionally, the Department is working with the Director of the Air Force Association of Missileers to amplify Air Force Global Strike Command (AFGSC) and Air Force Surgeon General communications on this issue. The Department of Veterans Affairs and other veteran service organizations have assisted in expanding outreach, as well.

Finally, AFGSC has consolidated pertinent information on a public-facing website which provides the most updated information on the progress of the ongoing study and addresses questions from the impacted community. The website can be accessed here: <https://www.airforcemedicine.af.mil/Resources/Missile-Community-Cancer-Study/>.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR LISA MURKOWSKI

Question. In the FY23 NDAA, SEC. 603 authorized several policies that will drastically improve the quality of life of Airmen stationed in Alaska. After making inquiries with the Air Force leadership in the state, I understand that there has been no guidance released for how these new policies should be implemented. Because of this, servicemembers in Alaska are missing out on time-limited incentives to help alleviate the unique hardships of serving in Alaska, as well as improve the recruitment and retention of Airmen.

What is the status of the implementation of Section 603(a) of P. L. No. 117–263 regarding pay for cold weather special duty pay? What is the status of the implementation of Section 603(b) of P. L. No. 117–263 regarding the requirement that the Secretary of the Air Force reimburse eligible servicemembers for the cost of airfare for that member to travel to their home of record while assigned to a duty location in Alaska? When should Airmen expect to begin receiving a cold weather duty pay and reimbursements for eligible travel to their home of record?

Answer. Alaska has several unique bases and missions vital to the Air Force. We understand the importance of providing quality-of-life improvements to our Airmen stationed there. The FY23 NDAA expanded our capabilities to offer additional bene-

fits for this initiative. AF/A1 is working closely with the Pacific Air Force team to request Cold Weather Special Duty Pay, under the authority created by Section 603(a), on behalf of Alaska. Then it will be routed through the Secretarial process.

The travel reimbursement incentive for service members who travel to their home of record from Alaska is near the end of the Per Diem Travel and Transportation Allowance Committee process. The final steps are to receive the Committee principal's signature, followed by the Joint Travel Regulations update. Once approved, the Air Force will implement the incentive. The Air Force has been monitoring both guidance initiatives closely and works diligently to implement these new authorities as soon as possible and continues to look for new, effective ways to improve the quality of life and the unique hardships for Airmen stationed in Alaska.

Question. Alaska provides the only location capable of supporting both short- and long-range hypersonic weapons testing within the United States. This unique geographical location offers the only location where hypersonic testing can be conducted without overflying populated areas and provide the DoD, with unrestricted flexibility to meet hypersonic mission objectives.

The Pacific Spaceport Complex.—Alaska (PSCA) provides an unparalleled test range for hypersonic vehicles and other advanced aerospace systems. Specifically, PSCA's launch site on Kodiak is ideally located to serve as the anchor for the Aleutian Test Range (ATR) stretching westward to Shemya Island. Through instrumentation strategically placed throughout the Aleutian Islands, AAC could provide telemetry data and vehicle safety throughout extended flight profiles.

Currently, the most feasible long-range capability for hypersonic testing requires the use of ships and aircraft positioned along the flight route of the hypersonic vehicle to track and receive data. This is a logistics challenge that is extremely expensive to mobilize for each test. Land-based instrumentation provides higher reliability and lower cost than ships and/or airborne platforms. Furthermore, the ATR can support air-, sea-, undersea- and land-launched systems to provide maximum test flexibility.

Additionally, the Federal Government and State of Alaska have jointly invested over \$120.0 million of capital improvements at PSCA. As only one of two U.S.-based spaceports that can launch into high-inclination and polar orbits, PSCA is a national asset to provide critical resiliency for U.S. access to space and to facilitate keeping national security space payloads launching from U.S. soil. This FAA-licensed commercial spaceport is a low-cost operation, capable of launching solid- and liquid-fueled rockets and has supported numerous government orbital, suborbital, and test missions since 1998. In recent years, Kodiak was the only spaceport able to support DARPA's Launch Challenge to demonstrate agility and flexibility key to military missions. However, the Space Force has not recently used PSCA.

SEC. 237 of the FY23 NDAA includes a provision directing the Secretary to identify non-DoD test facilities to expand testing of "operationally relevant, live-fire" hypersonic weapons. What steps has the Air Force taken to evaluate the PSCA and the Aleutian Islands for the potential to support hypersonic weapons testing? Do you support such an effort, and if so, when will we see a commitment to move this forward? What are the Space Force plans to make PSCA, and other orbital capable commercial spaceports, part of the USSF launch architecture and regularly fund missions at these locations to demonstrate critical resiliency capability for national security space, Responsive Space Launch, and Rapid Launch missions?

Answer. The Office of the Secretary of Defense (OSD) Test Resource Management Center (TRMC) has an extensive existing hypersonic test infrastructure road map and is the lead with oversight over all Department of Defense (DoD) hypersonic test infrastructure investment across the Major Range Test Facilities Base (MRTFB) in order to avoid duplicative Service investments. The Department of the Air Force supports any DoD efforts to expand hypersonic test infrastructure that will enable more rapid fielding of hypersonic weapons or vehicles.

The Space Force is seeing unprecedented demand for launch capacity from both government and commercial sectors. We are working hard to expand access to existing U.S. spaceports and increase the number locations available via a National Spaceport Interagency Working Group (NSIWG). The NSIWG is led by the FAA Office of Commercial Spaceports and has membership from the Space Force, OSD Policy, Department of Commerce, Department of State, and NASA. The NSIWG is drafting a National Spaceport Strategy that seeks to encourage the growth of spaceports nationwide and interoperability between them, all in an effort to expand resiliency to space access and ensure U.S. leadership in this domain.

Additionally, the Space Force recognizes that increased access to space by spaceports in diverse locations is important to our resilience and national security. The Rocket Systems Launch Program has used PSCA for several of their small-launch missions and continues to execute contracts to invest in PSCA. The Space Force also

plans to take advantage of the increased capability offered by new vendors in National Security Space Launch (NSSL) Phase 3, Lane 1. The Space Force procures commercial launch services and we are limited to locations where launch providers have established capabilities. Additionally, four locations in the U.S. can address high inclination launch: Cape Canaveral SFB, FL; Vandenberg SFB, CA; NASA Wallops Flight Facility (WFF), VA; and PSCA, AK.

Question. I understand the Air Force has had to make difficult budget decisions, but in my view, a top priority should be the capability to rescue our men and women in harm's way. I am concerned about the Service's decision to terminate the Combat Rescue Helicopter (CRH) program. I believe the moral imperative to "leave no one behind" is critical to show our commitment to the men and women who risk their lives to protect and defend us in all theaters of operation. It also concerns me that of the existing CRHs, the Air Force's current fielding plan places the National Guard at the lowest priority.

As you know, the 176th Wing on JBER is the primary Search and Rescue (SAR) force in Alaska. They have the Air Force's highest tempo and utilization rate (UTE). The Wing reports that their HH-60 Fleet has the highest UTE average at 130 by-month hours per tail over the last 6 years, with the next highest being Moody at 115 and Patrick at 107. Our footprint in the Arctic will only grow; the 176th must be better outfitted to support the AORs SAR requirements. Last year alone, they conducted 106 sorties and had 62 rescues. Further, I understand the additional 10 CRHs Congress added last year are planned to be Attrition Reserve aircraft, so you really only have 75 helicopters to accomplish what the original program of record says is 113 aircraft.

How does the Air Force plan to address this capability shortfall for the rescue mission?

Answer. The Air Force remains committed to the Joint Personnel Recovery (PR) mission and its own Combat Search and Rescue (CSAR) fleet, forces, and supporting architecture. The Air National Guard is a key component of the Total Force and will be recapitalized at all locations with HH-60Ws. The reduction in procurement of HH-60W will not result in a near-term capability shortfall, but will limit the capacity for dedicated CSAR forces available to the Joint Force. This will require the Joint Force to carefully adjudicate use of Air Force-dedicated CSAR forces and make use of other assets for less demanding PR missions. The Air Force recognizes the HH-60W's inherent capability limitations in the future threat environment and plans to mitigate this by modernizing how it trains and equips personnel for extended survival, improving communications architectures for distributed operations, enhancing its Find-Fix-Track capabilities in support of isolated personnel, supporting science and technology efforts to mature technological solutions that may provide enhanced capability, and layering PR forces to include traditional, non-traditional, Joint, and partner-nation capabilities.

QUESTION SUBMITTED BY SENATOR JOHN HOEVEN

Question. Last fall, the administration released a draft regulation that would require contractors to report on any greenhouse gas emissions they make that can be linked to the work they perform on DoD contracts. Further, it would make contractors set emissions reduction targets. This will severely impact oil and gas companies that are major contractors.

What is your plan to continue to procure fuel if this regulation makes it impossible to offer contracts to oil and gas companies?

Answer. The DAF and the Defense Logistics Agency (DLA), which procures most of the fuel on behalf of the Air Force, procure fuel in full compliance with all applicable laws, rules, and regulations. The DLA will continue to comply with all applicable laws, rules, and regulations when procuring fuel on behalf of the military services. If there is a regulatory change that impacts how we or DLA procures fuel, the DAF will work closely with DLA and in coordination with our industry partners to determine how to best meet all operational requirements for the military services.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED TO CHARLES Q. BROWN, JR.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR JON TESTER

Question. General Brown, we have very little margin in the modernization schedule for the land and air legs of the nuclear triad. Are you concerned about the modernization strategy?

Answer. As you point out, there is very little margin in our modernization schedule for the land and air legs of the nuclear triad. In the FY24 budget request, nuclear modernization remains the DAF top priority. Our acquisition professionals, working with our industry partners, are proactively identifying and looking for ways to mitigate potential schedule challenges and/or program risk. Also critical to successfully executing our modernization strategy will be on time and fully funded budgets and we greatly appreciate Congress' support for these programs.

Question. The Air Force has requested congressional support for the divestment of 310 aircraft in the FY24 budget request. However, you are only procuring 96 replacement aircraft. Furthermore, some of these divestments are planned to be replaced with modernized aircraft that are still in development and not yet ready for production.

General Brown, I'm all for getting rid of older systems that aren't relevant to current and evolving threats, but how do we avoid a capability gap if we're retiring more aircraft than we're able to field?

Answer. There are several challenges within our fleet today, many stemming from the age of our fleet and the number of missions performed over the past 20 plus years of continuous conflict in the Middle East and the relevance to the evolving threat. The FY24 budget request balances between current risk and future risks. While divesting older systems reduces current inventory numbers in some cases, divestment allows for procurement of new and more capable aircraft to address the current and future threat in a high-end conflict.

The Air Force endeavors to procure a modern force while remaining ready for today's challenges. We received great support from Congress for the last several budget cycles to move beyond legacy force structures that are not supporting the current defense needs for the Nation. These divestments free up dollar amounts and, most importantly, manpower to operate and maintain new aircraft. The transition from legacy aircraft to modernization requires a balanced risk and the Air Force is taking deliberate steps to manage near term capacity risk. Specifically, the FY24 budget requests to divest legacy A-10 and F-15 aircraft that would not contribute lethality in a high-end conflict, as well as balances risk across the Joint Force along with allies and partners.

In order to provide maximum capacity across the spectrum of conflict, the DAF is increasing its force mix of multi-role platforms while divesting older platforms designed for narrow mission sets.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR JOHN HOEVEN

Question. You've described the importance of domain awareness for both air and space. After the Chinese flew a spy balloon over the US earlier this year, the commander of Northern Command described how this revealed gaps in our domain awareness.

With atypical threats like high-altitude balloons, does the line between air and space responsibilities create a gap in our domain awareness investments?

Answer. Our acquisition model has been focused on specific platforms operating in specific domains. The shift to multi-domain operations has highlighted our need to reevaluate our approach to platform and domain integration. The DAF is reconciling that through the standup of the DAF Program Executive Officer (PEO) for Command, Control, Communications, and Battle Management (C3BM), which serves as an integrating PEO for DAF capability and system requirements. In particular, the PEO's Architecture and System Engineering Division is tasked with architecting solutions that work both in, and across, domains to architectural needs.

Question. The Air Force did not include Air National Guard Federal Tuition Assistance in its budget request. This continues to be a benefit only afforded to the Army National Guard. In your written testimony you acknowledged that in fiscal year 2023, the active-duty Air Force is "projected to miss military enlistment requirements by about 10%, over three thousand individuals" and that "the Air Guard and Reserve components are projected to miss their goals by even higher margins."

Do you agree that Air National Guard Federal Tuition Assistance could be an important tool in helping the Air Guard and Reserve and meet its recruitment and retention goals? Will this be prioritized in future budget requests?

Answer. Air Force Tuition Assistance (MilTA) is funded for those Air National Guard service members on Title 10 active-duty status and those on Title 32 Active Guard Reserve (AGR) orders under Title 10, U.S. Code, Section 2007. MilTA remains an important retention tool for those already serving on active-duty status. All Air National Guard States and Territories (except Guam) offer State Tuition Assistance programs and many Air National Guard service members qualify for Post-

9/11 GI Bill benefits. Considering these other opportunities members have, and due to competing budget priorities, the Air Force does not plan to budget for the National Guard Federal TA program (FedTA). The Air Force Recruiting Service continues to pursue accession goals by offering targeted enlistment incentive programs.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR SHELLEY MOORE CAPITO.

Question. Does the FY24 Budget include funding for Tactical Data Link upgrades for Air National Guard C-130J units? Will all Air National Guard C-130Js receive this upgrade? If not, how many? What is the projected timeline for these upgrades?

Answer. In FY24, 15 additional Active Component C-130J aircraft will be upgraded with Block 8.1, which includes the tactical data link (TDL) capability. Older C-130Js in the Air Force Reserve (AFR) and Air National Guard (ANG) are projected to begin receiving upgrades in FY28. The Mobility Air Force (MAF) fielding plan, approved in 2015, upgrades one Airlift Wing at a time. Air Mobility Command (AMC), ANG, and AFR Command concurred with the 2015 modification plan. ANG and AFR elected not to expend National Guard Reserve Equipment Appropriations (NGREA) on modifications and agreed Block 8.1 funding is an AMC responsibility.

The Block 8.1 modification includes TDL (Link-16) and many other upgrades. Block 8.1 is incorporated in aircraft production lines. All Air Force aircraft starting with FY20 congressional adds will be delivered in a Block 8.1 configuration. The 165th Airlift Wing, located in Savannah, GA, will begin receiving C-130Js in Block 8.1 configuration from the production line in December 2023. There are 48 Congressionally-added C-130J aircraft between FY20 and FY23. The ANG is expected to receive 40 Block 8.1 C-130Js directly off the production line by the second quarter of FY28.

The Block 8.1 system complexity impacts crew qualifications and the associated training pipeline. Factoring Congressional additions and established training pipeline limitations, the current phased approach addresses urgent operational needs while incrementally building qualifications across the total force.

Question. Will all U.S. Air Force C-17s, across components, receive the Extended Range modification? If not, how many Active, Guard, and Reserve C-17s, respectively, will receive the upgrade?

Additionally, what is the projected timeline for these upgrades? How would the cost and time schedule of these upgrades be affected by combining modifications for the Extended Range Fuel Tank with the On-Board Inert Gas Generation System (OBIGGS) II System upgrade?

Answer. The C-17 Extended Range (ER) modification provides additional fuel for increased range but does not increase aircraft efficiency. The Air Force is not planning to modify the remaining aircraft to ER configuration since the C-17 ER modifications provide minimal impact to pacing scenarios and we have higher priority modernization requirements. Ability to aerial refuel the entire C-17 fleet mitigates the mission completion risk. Currently 69% of the AFR fleet, 62% of the ANG fleet, and 79% of the Active Component fleet have received the upgrade.

The C-17 OBIGGS II System upgrade is a modification to correct a safety of flight issue known as "C-17 OBIGGS II Filter Fire Mitigation" on only those 112 aircraft equipped with the OBIGGS II System. This mod will continue to be installed until FY29. Additionally, to restart the C-17 ER production line would take an extensive reinvestment of Non-Recurring Engineering costs and would be executed separately from the current OBIGGS II program so as not to delay delivery.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED TO GENERAL B. CHANCE SALTZMAN

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR LISA MURKOWSKI

Question. Alaska is home to one of nation's few state spaceports on Kodiak Island. It is a national asset and I think it's not utilized as much as it should be. According to a recent FAA report—the National Spaceport Policy—the number of launches will increase from 74 last year to 186 in 2026, a nearly 300% increase. Meanwhile, according to the same report, 4 out of every 5 of these launches takes place either at Cape Canaveral or Vandenberg. Last year during Space Symposium you stated, "the United States Space Force must transform its space capabilities to increase our resiliency against these and other threats—and we must do so quickly." Meanwhile, RocketLab—a U.S. company—recently shifted a pair of NASA launches to New Zealand. This is in addition to the 4 launches that USSF/NRO has already allowed RocketLab to launch from foreign soil.

Should the Space Force make more of an effort to launch from U.S. spaceports instead of foreign ones? Without greater use of and investment in our state spaceports, is our domestic space launch infrastructure resilient and ready for a future conflict? Shouldn't we invest more in alternative spaceports to ensure we're not wholly dependent on a couple Federal space ports, one on each coast?

Answer. The Space Force is working hard to expand access to U.S. spaceports and increase the number of them via a National Spaceport Interagency Working Group (NSIWG). The NSIWG is led by the FAA Office of Commercial Spaceports and has membership from the Space Force, OSD Policy, Department of Commerce, Department of State, and NASA. The NSIWG is drafting a National Spaceport Strategy that seeks to encourage the growth of spaceports nationwide, and interoperability between them, all in an effort to expand resiliency to space access and maintain U.S. leadership in this domain.

The Space Force recognizes the importance of strong domestic spaceports, as well as the value of having access to diversified launch locations to increase resilience, including utilizing launch facilities available to us through our allies. In addition, launch locations are assigned to missions based on optimizing the path from launch to the desired destination of the satellite or spacecraft. These factors are each considered as the NSIWG develops their strategy.

The current Space Force OSP-4 launch contract enables launch from any of the U.S. ranges. Additionally, the intended Phase 3 dual-lane strategy extends the ability to launch NSSL Lane 1 missions from launch complexes other than those associated with the two Space Force-managed ranges.

Question. Phase 2 of the National Security Space Launch Program was designed when space was far less contested, congested, and competitive. In Phase 2, the Department chose just two providers in a 60%/40% split for 34 launches and this decision is proving to be, at best, minimally sufficient to meet the Department's space launch needs. Phase 3, which is currently being developed for a highly contested, competitive, and congested domain, includes 39 launches in the "block-buy" lane and 66 or more throughout Phase 3.

If two providers are just barely sufficient for Phase 2, how are the same two providers, 60%/40% split sufficient for Phase 3's block buy? How is this acquisition resilient if two providers just barely meet the need now and the need increases dramatically in Phase 3?

Answer. The NSSL Phase 2 acquisition strategy was designed to end U.S. reliance on Russian-made engines, drive competition, and deliver assured access to space for the Nation through two qualified launch service providers. Phase 2 does not restrict the number of missions the Space Force can order from each of its two contracted launch service providers and both providers have the required capacity to meet all NSSL needs. The Phase 2 Request for Proposal (RFP) forecasted about 34 missions across the five-year ordering period and is projected to end with a total of about 47 missions ordered.

For NSSL Phase 3, the Space Force selected an approach that aims to take full advantage of the United States' robust and evolving commercial launch market. The draft NSSL Phase 3 acquisition strategy proposes a dual-lane contracting approach, allowing access to an unlimited number of qualifying providers to promote resiliency through diversity and best meet Space Force and National Reconnaissance Office (NRO) requirements for launch. To meet this intent, the Space Force divided the 66 projected missions in the Phase 3, five-year ordering period between two contract lanes:

- Phase 3 Lane 1 (~27 missions): Designed to provide access to multiple launch system providers, systems, and launch sites, allow on-ramp of new launch systems and technology when ready, and offer tailored mission assurance based on a satellite's risk tolerance.
- Phase 3 Lane 2 (~39 missions): Designed to secure launch capacity and provide assurance and stability for our most stressing National Security Space missions through two qualified launch service providers. Lane 2 also garners economic order quantity savings. Lane 2 is projected to have approximately the same number of missions projected for NSSL Phase 2; therefore, two launch service providers can provide sufficient capacity to meet the Phase 3 projected mission count.

The projected 66 missions to be ordered in the NSSL Phase 3 enables the Space Force to employ a flexible acquisition strategy to meet multiple objectives and provide the warfighter more resilient launch capability.

Question. Space is more contested than ever, and the Department's need to access space has also radically increased with both proliferated constellations and exquisite needs. As you also know, and has been reported widely, you are also seeing dramatic increases in launch demand—commercial, civil, and national security. Even

ULA's CEO Tory Bruno has stated, "There is a worldwide shortage of launch . . . There'll be more missions than both [ULA and SpaceX] are really able to fly and that'll be for a number of years."

So why, in a supply-constrained environment of space launch would the Department further constrain supply by artificially limiting the numbers of providers in Phase 3 of the National Security Space Launch program to just two? Wouldn't a three-provider block buy promote additional competition, drive down launch costs, and be more resilient and redundant for the Department, especially if something bad were to happen to one of the launch vehicles or one of the space companies were to happen to one of the launch vehicles or one of the space companies were to be sold?

Answer. The draft NSSL Phase 3 acquisition aims to take full advantage of the United States' robust evolving commercial launch market. The draft NSSL Phase 3 strategy proposes a dual-lane contracting approach, allowing access to an unlimited number of qualifying providers to promote resiliency through diversity and best meet Space Force and NRO requirements for launch.

- The draft Phase 3 strategy fully supports the expected increase in launch demand and launch providers while simultaneously fostering greater competition.
- Phase 3, Lane 1 is designed to capitalize on emerging launch capability for our more risk-tolerant missions and provide annual on-ramp opportunities for the Space Force to tap into new launch technology as systems are ready.
- Phase 3, Lane 2 is designed to secure launch capacity and provide the full mission assurance required by our nation's most stressing NSSL missions.
- The Phase 3 Lane 2 strategy is a full and open competition and the 60/40 allocation split incentivizes launch service providers choosing to compete to provide their most competitive pricing to meet all NSSL requirements.
- With only three potential bidders for Phase 3 Lane 2, awarding three contracts is likely to disincentivize launch providers to bid competitively and will drive increased costs.
- The Space Force estimates that carrying a third launch service provider in Lane 2 could drive a \$1.0 billion increase or more due to additional launch service support (NSSL-unique costs not directly associated with any one mission), and space vehicle integration costs across three different launch vehicles versus two.

Question. I understand the Air Force has had to make difficult budget decisions, but in my view, a top priority should be the capability to rescue our men and women in harm's way. I am concerned about the Service's decision to terminate the Combat Rescue Helicopter (CRH) program. I believe the moral imperative to "leave no one behind" is critical to show our commitment to the men and women who risk their lives to protect and defend us in all theaters of operation. It also concerns me that of the existing CRHs, the Air Force's current fielding plan places the National Guard at the lowest priority.

As you know, the 176th Wing on JBER is the primary Search and Rescue (SAR) force in Alaska. They have the Air Force's highest tempo and utilization rate (UTE). The Wing reports that their HH-60 Fleet has the highest UTE average at 130 by-month hours per tail over the last 6 years, with the next highest being Moody at 115 and Patrick at 107. Our footprint in the Arctic will only grow; the 176th must be better outfitted to support the AORs SAR requirements. Last year alone, they conducted 106 sorties and had 62 rescues. Further, I understand the additional 10 CRHs Congress added last year are planned to be Attrition Reserve aircraft, so you really only have 75 helicopters to accomplish what the original program of record says is 113 aircraft.

How does the Air Force plan to address this capability shortfall for the rescue mission?

Answer. The Air Force remains committed to the Joint Personnel Recovery (PR) mission and its own Combat Search and Rescue (CSAR) fleet, forces, and supporting architecture. The Air National Guard is a key component of the Total Force and will be recapitalized at all locations with HH-60Ws. The reduction in procurement of HH-60W will not result in a near-term capability shortfall, but will limit the capacity for dedicated CSAR forces available to the Joint Force. This will require the Joint Force to carefully adjudicate use of Air Force-dedicated CSAR forces and make use of other assets for less demanding PR missions. The Air Force recognizes the HH-60W's inherent capability limitations in the future threat environment and plans to mitigate this by modernizing how it trains and equips personnel for extended survival, improving communications architectures for distributed operations, enhancing its Find-Fix-Track capabilities in support of isolated personnel, supporting science and technology efforts to mature technological solutions that may

provide enhanced capability, and layering PR forces to include traditional, non-traditional, Joint, and partner-nation capabilities.

SUBCOMMITTEE RECESS

Senator TESTER. This Defense Subcommittee will reconvene on Tuesday, May 2, at 10 a.m., for a Hearing with the Department of the Army.

We stand in recess.

[Whereupon, at 11:39 a.m., Tuesday, April 18, the subcommittee was recessed, to reconvene at 10 a.m., Tuesday, May 2.]

DEPARTMENT OF DEFENSE APPROPRIATIONS FOR FISCAL YEAR 2024

WEDNESDAY, MAY 2, 2023

U.S. SENATE,
SUBCOMMITTEE OF THE COMMITTEE ON APPROPRIATIONS,
Washington, DC.

The subcommittee met at 10:01 a.m. in room SD-192, Dirksen Senate Office Building, Hon. Jon Tester (chairman) presiding.

Present: Senators Tester, Murray, Schatz, Shaheen, Murphy, Murkowski, Moran, Hoeven, Boozman, and Capito.

DEPARTMENT OF DEFENSE

DEPARTMENT OF THE ARMY

OFFICE OF THE SECRETARY

STATEMENT OF HON. CHRISTINE WORMUTH, SECRETARY

OPENING STATEMENT OF SENATOR JON TESTER

Senator TESTER. I call the subcommittee to order.

I want to thank Secretary Wormuth and General McConville for being here. Welcome back to both of you. We appreciate your leadership of our Nation's Army and look forward to discussing the Army's budget priorities for fiscal year 2024.

Before we begin, I'd like to express my condolences to the entire Army family following last week's tragic death of three soldiers in a helicopter accident in Alaska and that comes on the heels of the recent death of nine soldiers following a midair collision of two helicopters in Kentucky.

Ensuring our brave men and women in uniform have access to the best training and equipment they need is the Number 1 priority of this committee. I will want to hear more from you about your order for Army aviation units to complete a 24-hour safety stand-down and any corrective actions that you plan to take.

The fiscal year 2024 budget request for the Department of Army is a \$185.5 billion, which is \$300 million below the amount enacted in fiscal year 2023 and nearly \$11 billion more than enacted in fiscal year 2022.

So let me repeat that. \$185.5 is \$300 million below last year's but \$11 billion more than the year before that.

Worldwide challenges and threats are constantly evolving. The Army's response to increasingly complex battlefield of the future is to transform the Army into the Army of 2030. This transformation includes investments of people, the reorganization of forces, the de-

velopment of new equipment, and adoption of new concepts to defeat our adversaries.

We can best help the Army on its path to transform to the Army of 2030 through the timely enactment of a defense appropriations bill for fiscal year 2024. On-time appropriations provide the resource predictability that enables the Army to execute training and operate plans effectively and efficiently for the entire fiscal year.

Let me put it this way. In order for the Army to be all it can be, we, Congress, must do our jobs.

I look forward to working with Senators Murray and Collins, the Chairman and Ranking Member of the Full Committee, for putting us in a position for success in getting the budget passed on time.

The Army's biggest military advantage is its people but these are difficult times. We look forward to hearing more about how you're tackling recruiting challenges. Given the need to modernize in light of an ever-evolving threat, we also look forward to an update about the pace of modernization.

You all have my full support to develop and field modernized capabilities, but I'm growing increasingly worried about repeated proposals by the Army to break production lines and destabilize industrial base when we need them most.

Once again, I want to thank you for your service to the country. Senator Collins is not here, as you can see. She has a Health, Education, Labor, and Pensions Committee markup this morning. She may arrive later, but before we get to your opening statements, I have one quick statement. Then I want to turn it over to Senator Moran.

We heard yesterday that the moment in time we default on our debt is coming up in 1 month, June 1. I talked about getting a budget out on time. I do not know what the people in this Senate, House are thinking. The truth is, the deficit needs to be dealt with in a common sense way. What the House has done last week is not a common sense way and it makes us a weaker country.

If we continue down this line, I'm very concerned about funding for the military, funding for Homeland Security, funding for every agency that we have within the government, and so hopefully, hopefully common sense will prevail here and we'll be able to continue on the path of getting a budget out, a defense budget in this case, by the end of September so that you guys have the certainties, not to waste a lot of taxpayer dollars, and the military industrial base has the certainty to know what we need and are able to deliver it on time.

With that, I'll turn it over to Senator Moran.

STATEMENT OF SENATOR JERRY MORAN

Senator MORAN. Chairman Tester, thank you.

I would add my support for all of our efforts in this committee to make certain that we get our appropriations process completed and done on time and that we avoid a continuing resolution that would be very damaging to lots of aspects of government but particularly to our national security.

As I begin my opening statement, I'd like to take a second to recognize the three Army aviators who lost their lives in a training accident over the weekend in Alaska. Another solemn reminder of

the sacrifices servicemembers and their families make every day, whether deployed or at home.

Thank you both for your service to our Nation and for being here today to discuss the United States Army's budget request for fiscal year 2024.

General McConville, it's my understanding that this will be your last posture hearing. While that saddens me, it may be a pleasurable thought for you. This is your last posture hearing as Chief of Staff for the Army. I'd like to especially thank you for your decades of service in uniform to the defense of our Nation.

I'm grateful for the relationship, the friendship that we've had, the conversations that you're willing to engage with me, and I'm especially grateful for your visits to Fort Riley and Fort Leavenworth last summer.

Kansans take a lot of pride in the Army's presence in our State and in these installations' role in the defense of our Nation. Kansas communities are engaged and supportive of the soldiers and their families who call these posts home.

Secretary Wormuth, as we discussed recently, in fact as recently as 5 minutes ago, I look forward to hosting you in Kansas in the near future to showcase the capabilities of Kansas military posts and the support of our Army's soldiers.

The United States is in the midst of one of the most challenging national security situations of my lifetime and the Army is critical to the support of the security of our Nation. The Army is critical to the future of our country.

This Administration's Army's budget request for fiscal year 2024 does not adequately address these concerns. Assuming the best inflation estimates, the Army's fiscal year 2024 request represents a real growth rate of a negative, a negative 2.4 percent.

As Co-Chair of the Senate Army Caucus and a Member of this subcommittee, it is my priority that the Army have the resources necessary to fill the national security obligations.

We continue to hear of the ongoing recruiting crisis within the Army. The force will look different from just 2 years ago, roughly 35,000 below its fiscal year 2022 authorized end strength of 485,000 soldiers.

Congress should be informed of all the alternatives as the Army considers options to manage this significant reduction. Let's work with you, let's work together to find satisfactory solutions and help the Army in its recruitment efforts. We need to overcome this deficit of soldiers.

No one, I think it's true in this room, wants to see the Army return to a tiered readiness model. I believe the retention of Army force structure is critical. While force structure reductions may be a quick fix solution, it will set the Army back at a time when the need for a ready Army is as essential as ever.

Army senior leadership should keep Congress aware of any changes under consideration. I want to be your ally, not your critic. The Russian invasion of Ukraine has highlighted deficiencies in the U.S. industrial base, particularly as its ability to produce an adequate munitions stock and supply.

American and Kansan workers stand ready to support the U.S. warfighter. I support the Army's recent investment into the muni-

tions industrial base. I recently had a chance to visit the former Kansas Army Ammunition Plant, which will have a vital role now re-engaging and supporting the increased munitions production needs.

I also want to applaud the Army's recent selection of the V-280 to be the Army's future long-range assault aircraft. This aircraft provides the needed speed and distance to support the Army 2030.

I will continue to use my position on this committee to help support the modernization of the Army aviation fleet to keep pace with our challenges.

The Army is the backbone of the Joint Force. If the United States is in conflict, our Army answers the call. While air and Marine superiority are essential, this is only possible with the Army's presence.

The U.S. ability to project power, to hold critical ground relies upon the Army's ability to compete in the Pacific Theater.

I highlight just at least from my own perspective that our country faces real and serious challenges. We need to do the things necessary to make sure we counter those circumstances. The Army has a significant role. This Congress has a significant role in supporting that effort.

I look forward to your testimony and your responses to the questions.

Thank you both.

Senator TESTER. Thank you, Senator Moran.

We'll start with you, Secretary Wormuth. You have the floor.

SUMMARY STATEMENT OF HON. CHRISTINE WORMUTH

Secretary WORMUTH. Thank you.

Good morning, Chairman Tester, Senator Moran, and Distinguished Members of the Committee.

Thank you for your ongoing support as we continue to build the Army of 2030 and thank you in particular for your condolences for our Army aviators. It has been a difficult several weeks for our aviation community and as soon as we got the word about the incident in Alaska, I asked the Chief to look into making sure that we were going to do a stand-down to make sure that we understand exactly what's going on here and that we can make sure that our aviators share lessons learned from these recent incidents.

We're both very pleased to appear before you today. I want to thank General McConville for his decades of service and leadership in the Army. This is indeed his last hearing and it has been a pleasure to do three cycles of budget hearings with you, Chief. So congratulations.

We've accomplished a lot in the last year but we still have a lot of work ahead of us. We remain focused on our three priorities: people, modernization, and readiness. The fiscal year 2024 budget enables us to support the National Defense Strategy, provide ready forces to our combatant commanders, and take care of our people.

By investing over \$39 billion in procurement and RDT&E (research, development, test, and evaluation), we are maintaining our momentum on our modernization programs and are largely on track to bring 24 systems across the finish line in 2023.

This is a big year for long-range precision fires. Prototypes of the precision strike missile, the mid-range capability, and the long-range hypersonic weapon will be in the hands of soldiers in this fiscal year.

It's also a big year for next generation combat vehicles. Mobile protected firepower is in production and the AMPV (Armored Multi-Purpose Vehicle) is also being fielded, and it's a big year for our Integrated Air and Missile Defense Programs and the Future Vertical Lift Program, as well.

As we shift from two decades of counterinsurgency and counterterrorism operations to large-scale combat operations, we're also transforming our force structure. We are going to need to adapt our force structure to make room for things like the multi-domain task forces as well as other new units, like the indirect fire protection capability and our M-SHORAD battalions.

We are a ready Army and we continue to emphasize readiness in everything we do. We're funding 22 combat training center rotations. We have a robust exercise program, and we're implementing our new readiness model which helps us balance modernization, training, and ongoing missions.

We're also investing in preposition stocks which have served us very well in Europe and will continue to serve us well in other theaters.

To assist Ukraine in fighting Russia, the Army has provided over \$20 billion in lethal assistance, including a wide range of munitions, radars, and combat vehicles, just to name a few items.

One of the most important lessons we've learned from the situation in Ukraine is the need for a more robust defense industrial base. So in our budget this year, we have \$1.5 billion to invest in arsenals, depots, and ammo plants.

We're also working very closely with our Defense partners and industry to increase munitions production so that we can continue to help the Ukrainians but also very importantly to replenish our own stocks.

Even as our soldiers provide lethal assistance and train the Ukrainian Armed Forces, we haven't taken our eye off of the pacing challenge of China. INDOPACOM (Indo-Pacific Command) may be a theater named after two oceans, but the Army does have an important role to play there.

The best way to avoid fighting a war is to show that you could win any war you might have to fight. So the Army is contributing to strengthening the deterrence in INDOPACOM every day as we campaign in the region through our exercises and partnerships and if deterrence fails, the Army will be a key player on the Joint Force Team if there's a conflict.

As important as it is to build new weapon systems and maintain our readiness, people are the strength of our Army. This budget includes a 5.2 percent pay raise and funds important quality of life improvements, like family housing, childcare initiatives, and new and renovated barracks.

We also, of course, want to build cohesive teams of soldiers that are trained, disciplined, and fit. So the Army is committed to positive command climates across the force where our soldiers can be all they can be.

We're also continuing to strive to prevent suicide in our ranks. Suicide is a national challenge, of course, but we have to do everything we can to reduce suicide in the Army.

So we're pursuing a range of initiatives to help our soldiers be more resilience. One of the most important things we can do is make sure that we have engaged leaders at every level who know their soldiers and make sure that their soldiers are connected to their leaders, to their buddies, and to their families.

Our Army is the greatest Army in the world but to keep it that way, we have to solve our recruiting challenge. The difficult recruiting landscape we face didn't happen in a year and it's going to take us more than a year to turn this around. We are laser focused on this challenge and we are not going to lower our standards to solve the problem.

We are generating positive momentum from initiatives, like our Future Soldier Prep Course, our Soldier Referral Program, and our new advertising campaign Be All You Can Be.

Our efforts are geared towards one thing: reintroducing the Army to the American public and inspiring a renewed call to service. We very much need your help to be successful in that effort.

I'm proud of everything our soldiers do to protect our country and look forward to your questions this morning.

Senator TESTER. Thank you, Madam Secretary.

Next up we have General McConville.

STATEMENT OF GENERAL JAMES C. McCONVILLE, CHIEF OF STAFF OF THE ARMY

General McCONVILLE. Secretary, thank you for your leadership.

Chairman Tester, Senator Moran, and Distinguished Members of the Subcommittee, thank you for the opportunity to be here today and for your continued support. We appreciate your condolences and certainly, our condolences go out to the families of our fallen aviators in Alaska.

The United States Army exists for one purpose, that is, protect the Nation by being ready to fight and win our Nation's wars as a Member of the Joint Force. To do this, the Army has set three clear priorities: people, readiness, and modernization or, in other words, future readiness.

We have remained aggressively committed to these priorities while answering the Nation's call during every crisis and every challenge.

This year the Army continues to undergo its greatest transformation in almost 50 years and we are delivering on modernization because we have been consistent and we have been persistent on our modernization priorities.

Last year we officially updated our capstone warfighting doctrine to Multi-Domain Operations, which incorporates emerging lessons from Ukraine. We continue to stand up new organizations to support our new doctrine.

Last June we reactivated the historic 11th Airborne Division in Alaska. In September, we stood up the third of our five multi-domain task forces. As the Secretary noted, we are on track to field 24 signature weapon systems in fiscal year 2023.

But at the end of the day, we must get the right people in the right place in order for any of these initiatives to be successful. This is why people remain the Army's Number 1 priority.

We want every young person and every parent to know that service in the Army is a pathway to success both in and out of uniform. Whether you serve for 4 years or you serve for over 40 years, the Army offers endless possibilities. We are not only a profession of arms but we are a profession of professions. You can be whatever you want to be in the United States Army. In fact, you can be all you can be.

I'm often asked how people can help us and my answer is inspire young men and women to serve because when we get the call, we go with the Army we have. The Army we have is the world's greatest fighting force because we serve with the world's greatest soldiers. With your continued support, we're going to keep it that way.

Thank you and I look forward to your questions.

[The statement follows:]

PREPARED STATEMENT OF CHRISTINE E. WORMUTH AND
GENERAL JAMES C. McCONVILLE

ENDURING ARMY PRIORITIES

For nearly 248 years, the United States Army has dedicated itself to fighting and winning the Nation's wars. As old threats evolve and new ones emerge, the Army is making decisions and prioritizing investments that not only contribute to current readiness but will also pay dividends on the battlefields of 2030 and beyond. That is why we are especially grateful to Congress for providing the funding necessary to produce highly trained and lethal forces ready to meet an array of challenges at home and abroad. Our ability to maintain continuity through crisis is a testament to our solemn commitment to the Army's three enduring priorities: people, readiness, and modernization. The Army's Budget Request for Fiscal Year (FY) 2024 of \$185.5 billion supports these priorities and will enable us to deliver the Army of 2030 in support of the National Defense Strategy.

READY TO FIGHT AND WIN

America's Army exists to protect the Nation by fighting and winning our wars as a member of the Joint Force. There is nothing more reassuring, and no greater deterrent, than American soldiers on the ground, standing shoulder-to-shoulder with our Allies and partners.

Linchpin of the Joint Force in the Indo-Pacific. From Washington and Alaska, to Hawai'i and Guam, to Japan and South Korea, there are currently 71,000 soldiers serving in the Indo-Pacific theater. The Indo-Pacific is not just an air and maritime theater, but a joint theater with joint problems that require joint solutions. The Army is the linchpin Service, enabling and sustaining our joint and Allied partners. Our fundamental goal is to deter conflict in the region. Thus, the best way to avoid fighting a war is to make it very clear that the Joint Force, in concert with our Allies and partners, can and will win such a war. To that strategic end, the Army contributes to deterrence by campaigning, which plays three important functions in the Indo-Pacific: complicating Chinese decisionmaking; enhancing U.S. access to the region; and placing combat-credible and interoperable land forces forward to create interior lines for the Joint Force.

This year is going to be one of historic modernization for our force posture in the Indo-Pacific. We are working closely with our regional Allies and partners to secure greater operational access and basing arrangements in strategic locations to enable adversary-focused training and exercises. In terms of logistics, the 8th Theater Sustainment Command in Hawai'i will oversee the delivery of supplies, fuel, munitions, and activity sets for U.S. Army Pacific's (USARPAC) joint and multinational training and exercises. Strengthening our ability to operate across the theater requires not only logistics at scale, but also the resiliency to operate in contested environments.

It has been a consequential year for the Army in the Indo-Pacific. USARPAC completed its inaugural iteration of Operation Pathways, representing the Theater Army's new posture paradigm to build and thicken Joint Force interior lines. This

gives USARPAC the operational endurance to see, sense, and understand regional threats; sustain, protect, and command and control (C2) large-scale operations; and conduct maneuver and fires. USARPAC demonstrated those capabilities by off-loading APS afloat in support of exercise Salaknib in the Philippines. USARPAC, alongside our Indonesian partners, expanded exercise Super Garuda Shield from a modest bilateral venture to a major regional undertaking with 14 partner nations and 4,000 combined forces. Next, we established the Joint Pacific Multinational Readiness Center, bringing the first combat training center to the Indo-Pacific with inaugural rotations at our Hawai'i and Alaska campuses, along with an exportable capability we employed in Indonesia.

Capitalizing on that momentum, the 5th Security Forces Assistance Brigade (SFAB) persistently trained and advised 12 of our Allies and partners across the region. The Army also activated the 11th Airborne Division in Alaska—a unit with an historic Indo-Pacific lineage that provides our soldiers with a clear purpose, identity, and mission. As part of our Arctic Strategy, the 11th Airborne Division is being tailored as a rapidly deployable operational command headquarters. Finally, USARPAC initiated the Unified Pacific Wargame Series, offering key insights on Army capabilities, posture, and contested logistics for a protracted conflict in the Indo-Pacific. In October 2022, America's First Corps certified as a Joint Task Force as part of the Mission Command Training Program Warfighter Series, with participants from Washington, Hawai'i, Colorado, and Kansas. I Corps' experimentation with distributed C2 will enable commanders to present multiple dilemmas to a potential adversary. We also activated the third of five planned Multi-Domain Task Forces (MDTF), task-organized to provide anti-access, area-denial capabilities through long-range precision fires and effects. The 3rd MDTF at Fort Shafter, Hawai'i joins the 1st MDTF at Joint Base Lewis McChord, Washington as the second MDTF supporting U.S. Indo-Pacific Command.

Tip of the Joint Spear in Europe. Since Russia's unjust and unprovoked invasion of Ukraine in February 2022, the U.S. Army's tactical readiness and strategic readiness have been on full display across continental Europe. The 43,000 American soldiers in Europe underscore our ongoing commitment to the region, further bolstered by President Biden's force posture announcement at the NATO Summit last June. In Germany, we are forward stationing an air defense artillery brigade headquarters, a short-range air defense battalion, a combat sustainment support battalion headquarters, and an engineer brigade headquarters. In Italy, we are forward stationing a short-range air defense battery. In Poland, the Army has forward-stationed the V Corps Headquarters Forward Command Post—the first permanent U.S. forces on NATO's eastern flank. We are maintaining a substantial rotational force in Poland, including an Armored Brigade Combat Team (ABCT), combat aviation brigade, and a division headquarters. In Romania, we have headquartered a rotational brigade combat team, supporting an additional maneuver force on the eastern flank. In the Baltics, we have enhanced our rotational deployments—which include armored, aviation, air defense, and special operations forces—to reinforce Baltic security, enhance interoperability, and demonstrate the flexibility and combat readiness of U.S. forces.

We have been able to demonstrate our steadfast support to NATO thanks to years of investments in setting the European theater, where we continue to invest in and modernize a robust set of Army Prepositioned Stocks (APS). Importantly, we are moving some of our APS into Poland this year to reinforce NATO's eastern flank. We are also leveraging NATO Common Funding to build a new equipment complex in Poland to house, maintain, and issue an ABCT equipment set. The XVIII Airborne Corps—America's Strategic Response Force—similarly highlighted the Army's investments in rapid power-projection capabilities. The XVIII Airborne Corps' nine-month deployment to Wiesbaden, Germany built upon years of cooperation with the Ukrainian military, providing the training and support required to aid the heroic defense of their homeland. These investments in strategic readiness would not have been possible without congressional foresight and support. This is especially true for the European Deterrence Initiative (EDI). Total EDI funding for the Army in FY 2023 is \$2.8 billion to support 9,800 rotational Army forces in Europe, and enhance our forward posture, training, and interoperability.

The United States remains committed to supporting Ukraine's near-term combat needs and its long-term defense requirements against future Russian aggression. The Department of Defense (DoD) has established Security Assistance Group—Ukraine (SAG-U), commanded by an Army three-star general under U.S. European Command, in Wiesbaden, Germany. SAG-U is purpose-built to execute the full range of our security assistance activities in a more efficient and sustainable manner. SAG-U will reach full operational capability in Q3 FY 2023. The lessons we observe in Ukraine underscore our Army's greatest strengths: combined arms ma-

neuver at scale; the importance of empowered leadership through mission command; and the immeasurable value of a professionalized Non-Commissioned Officer corps.

The Army continues to supply critical weapon systems, equipment, and munitions to Ukraine, including Stinger anti-aircraft systems, Javelin anti-armor systems, 155mm artillery rounds, and other items. We have provided billions of dollars of Army materiel to Ukraine through the Presidential Drawdown Authority. We are also working to execute billions in procurements for Ukraine through the Ukraine Security Assistance Initiative.

The Army will initiate multi-year procurement contracts for artillery rounds and artillery charges in FY 2023. For FY 2024, the Army will work with Congress to explore additional multi-year procurement contract opportunities for critical munitions. In addition to these potential multi-year contract efforts, the request includes additional funding for a range of munitions, including Javelin and Stinger missiles, and artillery, combat-vehicle, and small-arms ammunition.

We were able to fill critical gaps in Ukraine's defense thanks to our comprehensive modernization initiatives, but we must be able to replenish these stocks. Russia's war in Ukraine is further highlighting lessons from the pandemic that military readiness depends upon a robust and modern Organic and Defense Industrial Base. The Army is working closely with the Office of the Secretary of Defense (OSD) and our industry partners to rapidly increase production capacity and transform our processes from vulnerable supply chains to a more resilient supply fabric.

Readiness is our most effective form of deterrence. The best way to win without fighting is by demonstrating our ability to win decisively by fighting. Forward deployed combat capability, prepositioned stocks, and a resilient sustainment infrastructure will be key to future deterrence. One of the many ways we showcase our combat-credible forces in Europe is through DEFENDER-Europe, the Army's annual joint and multinational exercise series. Last year, concurrent with our support to Ukraine, and alongside our NATO Allies, DEFENDER-Europe 22 stretched across nine European countries, featuring 3,450 American troops and 5,200 multinational service members from eleven Allied nations. DEFENDER-Europe 23 will include over 7,800 U.S. troops, training alongside 15,000 multinational forces from 26 Allied and partner nations. National Guard units from 10 U.S. states will also participate, marking the 30th anniversary of the National Guard State Partnership Program.

DELIVERING THE ARMY OF 2030

The Army continues to progress through our greatest transformation in almost half a century. Fifty years ago, Army senior leaders closely observed the 1973 Arab-Israeli War and incorporated its lessons into the emerging AirLand Battle doctrine, the creation of new Army organizations, and the development of the "Big 5" weapons systems. Today, we are not only supporting Ukraine but paying close attention to the characteristics of modern warfare as they unfold, and incorporating those lessons into new doctrine, organizations, training, and materiel. Last October, the Army officially adopted Multi-Domain Operations (MDO) as our official capstone doctrine, the most significant shift in warfighting doctrine since AirLand Battle. MDO acknowledges that the Army of 2030 will be contested in every domain—air, land, sea, space, and cyberspace. Our soldiers must be ready to fight and win in multiple domains simultaneously to get from fort to foxhole in a contested environment.

The Army has been consistent and persistent in pursuing our modernization initiatives as we work to deliver the Army of 2030 and design the Army of 2040. We remain aggressively committed to our six modernization portfolios—long-range precision fires, next generation combat vehicle, future vertical lift, the network, air and missile defense, and soldier lethality—and are on track to deliver 24 new systems into the hands of soldiers by the end of FY 2023. That includes eight fielded systems, six systems issued for testing, and ten systems undergoing soldier touchpoints. Our annual Army Futures Command-hosted experiment, Project Convergence, continues to evolve and expand from the Army-centric inaugural event in 2020 to last fall's combined, joint series of experiments with the entire Joint Force, the United Kingdom, and Australia.

To succeed on the future battlefield and continue to dominate the land domain, there are six operational imperatives the Army of 2030 must do. First, we need to see and sense more, farther, and more persistently at every echelon than our enemies. That is why we are modernizing our aerial intelligence, surveillance, and reconnaissance capabilities, to include the Multi-Domain Sensing System, Terrestrial Layer System, and the Tactical Intelligence Targeting Access Node, or TITAN.

Second, we have to concentrate highly lethal, low signature combat forces rapidly from dispersed locations to overwhelm adversaries at a time and place of our choos-

ing. To do this, we are investing in a faster, more survivable armored fist. Upgraded tanks and Bradleys will be joined by Armored Multi-Purpose Vehicles, or AMPVs, which are already in production. The Mobile Protective Firepower System, which was just awarded for production, will provide greater protection to infantry forces without sacrificing speed or mobility.

Third, we must win the fires fight by delivering precise, longer-range fires as part of the Joint Force to strike deep targets and massing enemy forces. Since 2016, the Army has invested significantly in fire support systems, and we have made long-range precision fires a top modernization priority. We are working tirelessly to ensure that we have multiple options to service targets at ranges from 40 miles (Extended Range Cannon Artillery) to over 1,700 miles (Long-Range Hypersonic Weapon).

Fourth, we need to protect our forces from air, missile, and drone attacks. We are continuing to field Maneuver Short-Range Air Defense, or M-SHORAD, to protect our maneuver forces against a wide range of air threats. The Army is also developing an enduring Indirect Fire Protection Capability, or IFPC, that will work together with the Army's Integrated Air and Missile Defense Battle Command System to provide an unparalleled ability to identify, track, and defeat aerial threats. Current events also highlight the proliferation and significance of enemy Unmanned Aircraft Systems (UAS). To address this threat, we are investing in counter-UAS division sets that place fixed, semi-fixed, mobile, and portable counter-UAS capabilities in the hands of our maneuver forces.

Fifth, we must rapidly and reliably communicate and share data not just with ourselves, but with our Sister Services, and Allies and partners. The Army has demonstrated how to rapidly combine targeting data from our joint teammates and pass that information to the correct Army fires element—reducing the targeting cycle to mere minutes. The Integrated Tactical Network architecture, in fielding now, enhances classified data transfer with both better network bandwidth efficiency and resilient relay links to ensure persistent connectivity for our warfighters.

Finally, we must sustain the fight across contested terrain for both short, sharp operations as well as for protracted conflict. This will require not only standard equipment, like field kitchens, fuelers, and trucks, but also the niche, often overlooked capabilities like Army watercraft and Joint Logistics Over-the-Shore, or JLOTS. Sustainment must be at the forefront of our planning, preparation, and training—not something that we can assume will always be readily available. Army logisticians are the best in the world, and they are up to the task.

PEOPLE ARE OUR GREATEST STRENGTH AND FIRST PRIORITY

Recruiting Initiatives. We are experiencing the most challenging recruiting landscape in a generation. There is no one-size-fits-all solution. Nevertheless, we are committed to tackling these problems head on by recruiting a force that looks like the Nation it serves. All our recruiting initiatives will be informed by first principles: (1) we will not sacrifice quality for quantity; (2) we will not lower our standards; and (3) we will invest in America's young people so they can meet our standards. The Regular Army Accessions Mission for FY 2023 is 65,500. While we are singularly focused on meeting this mission, we need help from community leaders, parents, educators, coaches, and influencers to inspire young people to serve.

The Army is implementing several important changes to improve organizational understanding, recruiter management, regional awareness, marketing, and applicant eligibility. First, we established the Army Recruiting Task Force, under the direction of a two-star general, to examine the current state of the Army's recruiting enterprise and to make recommendations to Army senior leaders for action. Second, we are overhauling how the Army recruits by selecting recruiters differently, improving recruiter training, increasing recruiter resources, and creating new incentives for high-performing recruiters. For instance, the Army recently launched a "Recruiting Scholars" program to identify, incentivize, and send top-notch captains to graduate school after completing a recruiting-company command. There are 21 talented captains in the first cohort.

Next, the Army designated 15 major cities as priority markets for FY 2023. With help from community partners, including Veterans Service Organizations, Military Support Organizations, and our Soldiers for Life, we are saturating these markets with activities and initiatives to maximize awareness regarding the benefits of Army service. Fourth, we established the Future Soldier Preparatory Course (FSPC) pilot program in July 2022 at Fort Jackson, South Carolina to support the accession of recruits who are inclined to serve but might need help improving their test scores or physical fitness. As of March 22, 2023, 4,219 FSPC recruits have graduated and moved on to Basic Combat Training (BCT). This represents a 98 percent success

rate. FSPC recruits improved their Armed Forces Qualification Test score by an average of 18.5 points. Similarly, 97.6 percent of FSPC recruits achieved the Army's accessions body composition standards. Most importantly, FSPC graduates are performing very well in BCT with just a 4.8 percent attrition rate, as compared to the average BCT attrition rate of 6.1 percent in 2022.

Be All You Can Be. On March 8, 2023, the Army officially reintroduced "Be All You Can Be" as our marketing slogan. "Be All You Can Be" featured prominently in Army advertisements and marketing materials from 1981 to 2001. After a two-decade hiatus, we are excited to introduce "Be All You Can Be" to a new generation of young people. The Army Enterprise Marketing Office hosted numerous in-person focus groups and tested "Be All You Can Be" against 18 other taglines, eventually surveying 20,000 people across five target audiences: prospects, soldiers, veterans, influencers, and engaged citizens. Our extensive market research revealed that the "Be All You Can Be" slogan, once popular with Generation X, resonates with Generation Z by signaling a sense of purpose, passion, possibility, community, and connection unique to the Army. With support from Congress, the Army will spend \$116.7 million in FY 2023 to launch this rebranding campaign across multiple media platforms. Additionally, we believe that the "Be All You Can Be" narrative will help veterans and retirees tell their Army stories and inspire a new generation of young people toward military service.

Quality of Life. Recruiting and retaining the next generation of the All-Volunteer Force requires sustained investment and quality-of-life improvements in Army housing, barracks, child care, spouse employment, healthcare, and the exceptional family member program.

High-quality housing and barracks are key to ensuring overall health and wellness, thereby contributing to readiness and critical for retaining Army soldiers and their families. First, the Army supports DoD's continuous assessment of Basic Allowance for Housing (BAH) rates, ensuring military paychecks keep pace with market conditions across the country. Average BAH rates have increased 12.1 percent since 2022. Personnel in 291 of 300 military housing areas received a BAH rate increase. Second, privatized housing companies began a six-year, \$3-billion investment plan in 2020 to improve the Army's housing inventory, to include new builds and major or medium renovations through 2026. The Army has programmed \$1.6 billion for FY 2024–2028 to improve the government-owned Army Family Housing inventory. Third, the Army historically invests an average of \$1 billion per year in barracks for construction, restoration, and modernization across all three Army components. In FY 2024, the Army is requesting support for permanent-party barracks in Fort Wainwright, Alaska; Joint Base Lewis McChord, Washington; Fort Bragg, North Carolina; and Natick Soldier Systems Center, Massachusetts. Importantly, Army senior leaders remain vigilant in their housing and barracks oversight responsibilities.

With congressional support, the Army has expanded on- and off-post child-care options by increasing staff compensation and benefits, investing in facilities, growing family child care, and extending care hours. Entry level salaries are now \$17.39 per hour. We are offering recruiting and retention bonuses for child-care staff and providing them with a 50 percent child-care discount for the first child and a 15 percent multiple-child discount for additional children. In terms of off-post care options, we continue to provide Army Fee Assistance to approximately 10,000 children of the active and reserve component per month, all while exploring new initiatives and partnerships. We also increased the provider rate cap to \$1,700 per month, thereby reducing out-of-pocket expenses for hard-working Army families. Since FY 2021, Congress has funded seven new Child Development Centers (CDCs) in Alaska, Hawai'i (2), Georgia, Kansas, Kentucky, and Louisiana. The Army is planning to fund more CDCs in the out years.

Army spouses—over 431,000 across all three components—play an important role in soldier and family readiness and soldier retention. Leveraging both Army and DoD programs, and partnerships with other Federal and non-governmental organizations, we remain committed to improving spouse employment and career opportunities. When spouses are satisfied with their careers, employment options, access to services, and overall quality-of-life, they are far more likely to support their soldier's continued service.

There are 46,000 active-component soldiers—nine percent of the force—with family members enrolled in the Exceptional Family Member Program (EFMP), totaling 55,000 family members. We are committed to reforming the EFMP and to providing comprehensive and all-inclusive support to Army families with a family member with a qualifying condition. In August 2022, we launched the Enterprise EFMP system to improve enrollment, transparency, assignment coordination, and access to support. We have also created a centralized EFMP office within the Headquarters,

Department of the Army to coordinate healthcare services, reassignment processes, and education support services. Taken together, these initiatives will help reduce the bureaucratic burden on Army families. Moreover, the Army continues its close partnership with the Defense Health Agency to ensure access to high-quality healthcare for our soldiers and their families.

Reducing Harmful Behaviors. People are the Army's number one priority. We take care of our people by building cohesive teams that are highly trained, disciplined, and fit, that are ready to fight and win, and where each person is treated with dignity and respect. Leaders across the Total Army are steadfastly committed to reducing the harmful behaviors that break trust with our soldiers and the American people—including sexual assault and harassment, acts of extremism, and racism, among others. To reduce harmful behaviors, we are shifting the paradigm from focusing on intervention and response to prioritizing integrated prevention activities. Integrated prevention activities address the conditions that lead to harm by reducing risk factors and increasing protective measures to preclude harmful behaviors. To that end, we are aggressively implementing the FY 2022 Independent Review Commission's recommendations to counter sexual assault and sexual harassment within our formations, to include realigning Sexual Assault Response Coordinators (SARCs) and Victim Advocates from the operational chain of command to the Lead SARC at each installation. This independent reporting structure will enable Sexual Harassment/Assault Response and Prevention, or SHARP, professionals to advocate for victims more effectively.

The Army is committed to working with Congress and the OSD to effectively implement the military justice reforms directed by the FY 2022 and FY 2023 National Defense Authorization Acts. In July 2022, the Army issued a General Order establishing the Office of the Special Trial Counsel (OSTC) as a field operating agency. The Senate confirmed our nominee for Lead Special Trial Counsel in November 2022 and set his subsequent promotion to brigadier general in January 2023. The Army expects the OSTC to reach full operational capability by December 27, 2023, as required by law.

Every single suicide is one tragedy too many. Exposure to harmful behaviors, such as sexual assault, harassment, or other acts of violence, may increase the risk of suicide. The Army is committed to supporting those exposed to harmful behaviors and doing everything we can to address this critical issue. Fortunately, we saw significant decreases in suicide across all Army components in 2022. The Army is leveraging a new public health approach to prevent and respond to suicide at the individual and community levels. We will publish a comprehensive suicide prevention regulation to define this new approach for the force by the end of Q3 FY 2023. Army leaders continue to employ the Health Readiness and Suicide Risk Reduction Tool across our formations. Last year, we introduced the "Stories of Hope" podcast to raise awareness, reduce stigmas, and increase help-seeking behaviors.

50 YEARS OF THE ALL-VOLUNTEER FORCE

As we commemorate 50 years of the All-Volunteer Force, it has never been more important to recruit and retain the talented individuals who make our Army the world's greatest fighting force. We win through our people—our active duty, Guard, and Reserve soldiers; our families; Army civilians; and our veterans and retired Soldiers for Life. We need every American to know that the U.S. Army is an organization of endless possibilities that provides a pathway to success both in and out of uniform. Our message is clear: if you want to serve something greater than yourself, if you want to belong to the world's greatest team, if you want to BE ALL YOU CAN BE, then join us. With the limitless talent our Nation has to offer and continued support from Congress, we will remain ready to fight and win, against any adversary, anywhere in the world.

Senator TESTER. Thank you each for your testimony.

Last week, as I said in my opening statement, the three soldiers were tragically killed when the helicopters collided during a training mission in Alaska, and as I also pointed out, this is on the heels of another fatal helicopter accident in Kentucky that cost nine lives on February 2. Two soldiers lost their lives in a helicopter accident also in a training mission this time in Alabama.

So, General McConville, you issued a stand-down order to the Army Aviation Units last week and directed additional safety training.

Would you please give us an update on what you will be reviewing specifically?

General McCONVILLE. Thank you, Chairman, and, you know, last year for Army Aviation was the safest we've had in the history, but we're only as good as our last flight and as you mentioned, we've had two tragic flights in the last month and as a result, the Secretary and I directed a safety stand-down.

That's an opportunity for all our aviation commanders and senior commanders to bring their aviators together to take a look at the procedures that they're using, to take a look at crew mix, to understand the type of training they're doing, and making sure that we have the right crews in place, that we're taking the proper steps, crawl, walk, run, to get after some of the maneuvers we're going after, and to realize that this is a very dangerous business.

Unlike maybe operating a vehicle close to a curb, with aviation if you make a mistake or something happens it can be very catastrophic and we need to bring that safety philosophy we've had for the last couple of years back into the cockpits and make sure we're able to do that.

Senator TESTER. So assuming that the stand-down will result in some solutions to the problem, whether it's in safety or whether it's in crew training, how long do you think it'll take to implement anything that comes out of this stand-down?

General McCONVILLE. Well, I think it's going to be over the next couple of days. So they'll bring it back and we're expecting immediate results.

Senator TESTER. All right. Secretary Wormuth, in addition to the lives that were lost, those accidents also cost—aviation accidents since 2020 have cost the Army about \$600 million in equipment.

Are you appropriately funding for some of the training the General just talked about for spares, for simulators?

Secretary WORMUTH. Yes, we have been fully funding our flying hours for the last two budgets that we've submitted, for example, and so, you know, we have put investments into making sure that we have sufficient resources for our simulators, for our flying hours for all of our pilots.

You know, there are challenges, of course, in terms of looking at spare parts and maintenance on all of that. So I think one of the things that we need to look at is are our pilots actually getting enough flying hours but to do that, we've got to make sure that the aircraft are ready to fly and so there's sort of a lot of pieces that fit together in that, but we are definitely investing fully in that in my view.

Senator TESTER. Any of the money in this budget to be able to continue to invest fully in that?

Secretary WORMUTH. Yes.

General McCONVILLE. Yes.

Senator TESTER. Thank you.

A little over a year ago you informed this committee of the decision to reduce end strength from 485,000 to 476,000 in order to maintain what you talked about in your opening statement, a high quality Army.

Now based on the latest recruiting data that number looks to be further reduced to about 452,000 which, by the way, we should

have an exact number on that, but around 452,000 for this fiscal year, and we understand that that goal may not be reached.

So where do things stand with Army recruitment? Are you seeing a positive connection between additional advertising and recruitment bonuses resulting in more men and women signing up for the Army?

Secretary WORMUTH. Chairman, we are seeing improvements in our recruiting situation. We are in a better position, for example, at this time last year than we were in the previous year.

At the same time, the Chief and I set a very ambitious goal of 65,000 new recruits this year and we are not going to make that goal. We are doing everything we can to get as close to it as possible but we are going to fall short of that, and as I said in my opening statement, you know, we didn't get into this situation in a year and I think it's going to take us more than a year to increase recruiting and we are going to have to look at, as I also mentioned in my opening statement, that for our (audio glitch.)

Senator TESTER. This is not a good thing and it's not a good thing for a couple reasons.

First of all, this is information that a new system should be able to do without a lot of screwing around and, quite frankly, it's not giving you the numbers to be able to track and have solid data on recruitment. You get soldiers that are booted off of Tricare because of a glitch in a damn program. That's a problem.

How are you able to track needs without solid data?

Secretary WORMUTH. It took us 6 years to build IPPS-A and it brought together 40 different systems. So it was very complicated and that's why we had glitches, for example, like the soldiers with Tricare, but we have worked through that. We have a Tiger Team that is working all of the specific, you know, problem areas that have emerged as we've gone live with IPPS-A (Integrated Personnel and Pay System—Army).

The challenge with our recruiting numbers, frankly, is more that our models don't incorporate some of these new initiatives that we've undertaken, like the Future Soldier Prep Course, but we know how important it is to this subcommittee to get that data and we will work with you to get it to you as soon as possible.

Senator TESTER. I appreciate that. I would just tell you that Senator Moran and I serve on the VA Committee as the Chairman and Ranking Member, too, and if I have one major main in my behind it's computer systems and it doesn't matter if it's military, it doesn't matter if it's VA, it doesn't matter if it's Montana State Tax System. There's always something wrong, and, I mean, it's just not something that can make the Army all it can be or the VA all it can be either.

So with that, I'll turn it over to Senator Moran.

Senator MORAN. Chairman Tester, thank you for concluding that conversation by indicating that pain was the computer system. The way you started I wasn't certain where you were going to go.

Let me start with really both of you. So if we're not going to meet our recruitment goals that means consequences in a practical way to how the Army operates.

What can you tell me first as someone who's interested in the overall well-being of the Army what you are thinking, what are

your plans that will alter the structure of our Army across the country and around the globe and then as a Senator from Kansas tell me what concerns, if any, I should have about what those changes mean to installations and the assignment of soldiers to places, to bases, to forts, to posts across the country?

Is this a consequence that will have a modest impact across the board or a consequence in which you will be making decisions about who stays the same, who gains, and who loses?

Secretary WORMUTH. Thank you, Senator Moran. Let me try to answer that concisely.

We do not want a hollow Army, as you indicated. You know, we do not want to have tiered readiness. So part of the hard work of the Army in the next couple of years is going to be bringing down that over-structure, you know, what we call the spaces, to be closer to the actual amount of spaces, soldiers that we have.

We are—and, frankly, we have to undertake that transformation in any case because we have to make room for some of the new types of structure we need for the Army of 2030.

So what we're trying to do is basically spread out some of those changes really and so, for example, we did sort of what I would call a people night court where we basically went and looked at all the different types of soldiers in units and said do we need to have 60, you know, cooks or can we use 40 cooks? So we're doing that.

We have looked at what we call unit priority and we've looked over the years at the units that we have used very heavily as opposed to those that we may have used much less frequently and those are areas where we can probably do some thinning out.

So the reality is, you know, our end strength right now is about 455,000. So at most large installations around the country right now the number of actual soldiers is fewer than the authorizations that are there. So I think, you know, we'll be able to make many of these changes without it having large impacts to any of the major installations.

But if we don't turn our recruiting situation around, I can't guarantee you that the Army won't have to make some more substantial potential force structure reductions because we've got to make sure that our units, for example, that are on the immediate response force are manned adequately so that they're ready to go.

Senator MORAN. Your planning and your conversations, have they gone to that point in which you are discussing about what significant changes might take place if recruiting doesn't turn around?

Secretary WORMUTH. We are looking at that right now, Senator, but we haven't come to any firm conclusions. I think, you know, we would very much obviously like to avoid making any large force structure changes because it can be hard sometimes to reverse that.

Senator MORAN. It can be very hard to reverse that. What kind of timeframe—when could this committee have a view as to what your thinking is in a more formal way?

Secretary WORMUTH. I think, Senator, we will probably be able to come to you in the next few months and talk with you about how all of that is looking for us.

Senator MORAN. And that would be before a decision is made?

Secretary WORMUTH. Well, we have a document called The ARSTRUC (Army Structure Memorandum) which essentially does look at finalizing the changes and I think we would want to come and talk to your staffs, for example, about how that's looking.

Senator MORAN. And when does the decision have to be made in order for this to really live up to the consequences of the less end strength?

Secretary WORMUTH. Well, the ARSTRUC looks 5 years out and we do one every year. You know, I think major—we won't have to make final decisions probably about any significant changes until 2025, but we need to start thinking about that because again we want to make sure that our brigades are adequately manned.

Senator MORAN. Madam Secretary, you understand why this is such a significant topic of conversation for the country, for this committee, for you.

Secretary WORMUTH. Of course.

Senator MORAN. I appreciate that.

General McConville, anything you would want to add to that response?

General MCCONVILLE. I think, you know, one of the concerns why we really need to increase recruiting is because I think as we take a look at, you know, getting ready for the next fight that we see is we're moving from counterinsurgency, counterterrorism, irregular warfare. So those type systems that would be more valuable in large kill combat operations, like some of the systems that you have at Fort Riley and other places are going to be more important, but we're also developing long-range precision fires, air and missile defense, counter UAS (Unmanned Aircraft Systems) systems, and we're going to do this on pretty much a flat budget and flat end strength. So there will be some decisions eventually what that looks like.

The concern we have right now is on end strength is, you know, it may not be a structure change, but if we can't fill the actual units, you know, they may be at 70 percent strength and so, you know, the structure still there but you don't have the soldiers filling those ranks and that's what we're concerned about.

Senator MORAN. Let us know how we can help recruit. Thank you.

Senator TESTER. Senator Schatz.

Senator SCHATZ. Thank you, Chairman.

Thank you both for being here. I want to start with the status of the lease negotiations with the State of Hawaii.

In 1964 the United States military was awarded a 65-year lease for 23,000 acres of Hawaii State lands for \$1. We are now coming up on the potential renewal of that lease and I think we're all in agreement that the people of the State of Hawaii are entitled to a fair deal on all leasing moving forward.

Many of these leases do expire in 2029. That includes Pohakuloa Training Area, Kakaaho Training Area, Makua Valley, and I think where we are all landing is that promoting our national security and treating the citizens of the State of Hawaii with fairness and respect are not mutually exclusive. In fact, at this point they're completely intertwined.

So, Secretary, could you just give me an update on the status of the negotiations?

Secretary WORMUTH. Certainly, Senator Schatz. As you know, we have two environmental impact statements that are underway right now that are relevant to looking at the lease agreements and those I believe will be completed at the end of this year and then the next step would be for, you know, the Army to be looking at what we would come forward with as a proposal for what the final agreement would look like and that record of decision won't come forward until 2025.

So we have some time to be talking with—you know, when I was last in Hawaii I met with Governor Green, had a very productive discussion with him. I met with leaders from the Native Hawaiian community, and we are very much now trying to engage—you know, as the environmental impact statements work their way through the process, we are trying to engage with all of the different stakeholders in Hawaii to understand, to help us understand what the shape of an arrangement might look like.

Senator SCHATZ. Thank you.

General McConville, we all agree Hawaii is entitled to the same guarantee of homeland defense as every other State.

Army's IBCS (Integrated Air and Missile Defense Battle Command System) expands the line of sight for defensive launchers to better our odds of intercepting missile threats.

Are there considerations for how the IBCS Program could apply to the defense of Hawaii?

General MCCONVILLE. Well, right now it just is a potential consideration. I'm not aware of anything right now that put IBCS, but as you said, it's a game-changing technology that allows us to integrate sensors and shooters for air missile defense and that does give us that capability and if we lay out that requirement, then we can take a look at it.

Senator SCHATZ. There's a lot of talk about Guam and the defense of Guam. I completely support that. I want to just remind everybody that Hawaii is the homeland. Hawaii is not an insular area. It is the 50th State. It is the home of INDOPACOM. It is the home of U.S. Army Pacific. It is the home of Marine Forces Pacific, and even if it's difficult, even if it's expensive, we still need to have—and I get that HDRH (Homeland Defense Radar-Hawaii), you know, was abandoned and perhaps for legitimate reasons, but I just want to flag for you that as we're gaming out our scenarios that we are focusing right now on the kind of Central and Western Pacific and then the Continent and Hawaii deserves protection, too.

On recruiting, just following up, Secretary, on what Senator Moran talked about, you know, you're going to fall short and I think you are doing what is necessary to try not to fall short, but I think it's fair to say that the Pacific is the priority area and although I know you're kind of pre-decisional here, I'd like you to kind of talk at least in conceptual terms about how you're going to absorb some reduction in the number of Army soldiers in a way that is consistent with our Indo-Pacific strategy.

Secretary WORMUTH. Certainly. And I'll maybe draw again a little bit on what I said before.

One, I think it's important to realize that the actual number of soldiers that are at places like, you know, 25th ID at Fort Riley, for example, at Fort Bragg, at Fort Hood,—

Senator SCHATZ. Fort Humphreys.

Secretary WORMUTH. Exactly. Is below the number of authorizations that are on the books. So, you know, we have the soldiers that we already have.

What we're trying to do is look at—you know, as we think about the new kinds of force structure that we need to build, as the Chief mentioned, the multi-domain task forces, the indirect fire protection capabilities, a lot of the integrated air and missile defenses, for example, we are looking at where can we shed maybe some types of structure that was very useful for COIN and counter-terrorism but we don't need as much of right now to make room for new structure and the way we've gone about that, among other things, is we've looked at, as I said, what we're calling people optimization.

So there's places where we can just kind of thin out across the whole force structure and then we're also looking at the types of units that are maybe under-utilized. Those are obviously candidates for elimination, for example.

So, you know, I think all of this will be spread around our major installations and, you know, National Defense Strategy requirements are primary. We've got to be able to have the readiness levels and the structure that we need to execute the strategy and certainly paying attention to the Indo-Pacific is core to that.

Senator SCHATZ. Thank you.

Senator TESTER. Senator Murphy.

Senator MURPHY. Thank you very much, Mr. Chairman. Thank you both for being here today.

Mr. Chairman, I wanted to take my time to ask a few questions about the Future Vertical Lift Program.

First of all, this is the first opportunity to talk about this in this subcommittee. Mr. Chairman, as you know, I made, along with Senator Blumenthal, a series of requests of the Army to get a briefing on a Flora Award and was denied that briefing by the Army multiple times.

I think this subcommittee and more broadly the Appropriations Subcommittee has to pretty rigorously guard our equities when it comes to getting information from the Army and from the Administration when it comes to contract awards.

In fact, the regulations governing the awarding of contracts carves out a very specific role for Congress to be briefed on these matters even while the award is pending, and I hope this committee will continue to work on what I think is a misaligned equilibrium right now between the Administration, the Department of Defense, and this committee when it comes to how much information is shared.

Ms. Wormuth, I wanted to talk to you about this specific award. I understand I have parochial interests, right? This was a contest between Bell, Textron, and Sikorsky, and the award went to the Bell Program, but I guess I want to talk to you a little bit about my concerns regarding Tilt Rotor Aircraft.

My understanding is that past performance did not factor in to the contract award and this committee is going to be charged with

picking up the full cost of this new program. Tilt Rotor Aircraft, like the V-22 Osprey, have a pretty miserable performance, reliability, and safety record over the last 30 years.

The V-22 is supposed to have a mission readiness of 82 percent but over the last 5 years the Osprey has been at 56 percent. The procurement cost went from \$33 million to almost a hundred million. Today, the cost per flight of the V-22 is \$10,000 an hour which is double the initial estimate.

You know, what was interesting about this particular contract award is that the bid that came in from Textron was twice, twice the amount of the bid that came in from Sikorsky. Layered on top of that, this history suggesting that the Tilt Rotor is going to end up costing our taxpayers inordinately more than even the initial bids and I worry that we're going to have a hard time being able to fund the full cost of this award.

So I guess my question is do you have any information as to why the Army did not take past performance of Tilt Rotor Aircraft into account when awarding the Flora contract, and what do you say about my concerns that if the cost curve on this new helicopter, which is obviously a foundational program for the Army is anything like what we saw for the Osprey, then we're in for some pretty big unexpected costs that we're going to have to bear on this subcommittee?

Secretary WORMUTH. Senator Murphy, first of all, I want to say, you know, of course, I completely support and value the important oversight role of Congress in these matters. So we want to be good partners with you in terms of being transparent and if you have not already, you know, received a detailed briefing now that the GAO (Government Accountability Office) has issued its decision, if you will, on the competition, I certainly will make sure that Mr. Doug Bush and their team get up to talk with you about that.

My understanding is that the things that were valued or emphasized, if you will, in the selection process did include looking at lower technical risk precisely because of the fact that in the past if the technical risk is higher, a lot of times that means the costs in the out years are higher. The sustainment costs can be higher because they're not appropriately baked into the competitive process.

So one of the reasons, as I understand it, that we selected the Bell-Textron aircraft was because it was assessed to have lower technical risk, even though the bid that came in from Sikorsky from an overall dollar amount was lower. You know, it was a best value competition. It wasn't strictly based on price, and we in the Army had some considerable concerns about our visibility into the design process that came from Sikorsky.

So I can get back to you in more detail in terms of how exactly we incorporated past performance of the Osprey into the calculations, but we absolutely emphasized the importance of having lower technical risk in the program.

Senator MURPHY. Mr. Chairman, I will just note that our subcommittee has a GAO report on this very specific question of whether risk is being properly calculated when awarding programs within the Future Vertical Lift Aircraft process and what this GAO report comes to the conclusion is that right now the Army is not

properly identifying sort of long-term risk on these programs and so look forward to being in a dialogue about some of the recommendations in this GAO report and getting a better holistic sense of how much this is going to cost the taxpayer in the long run.

Thank you very much.

Senator TESTER. Very quickly, Senator Murphy, have you been briefed by the Defense Department?

Senator MURPHY. And I have, I have, and I thank you for arranging for that.

Senator TESTER. Senator Hoeven, would you yield to the Chairman of the Full Appropriations Committee?

Senator HOEVEN. Absolutely.

Senator TESTER. Thank you.

Senator Murray.

Senator MURRAY. Thank you so much, and I do have to get back to a markup. So I really do appreciate that.

But, first of all, let me just say, Chairman Tester and Vice Chair Collins, who is being filled in by Senator Moran today, I'm really glad to join both of you to keep talking about the investments that we've got to make to support our troops and keep our country safe.

These hearings that we're having are so important to remind us that we need to return to regular order and pass our Nation's funding bills in a timely bipartisan way and I will keep saying that till we get back to regular order.

Now if we are going to stay ahead of our competitors, like China and others, that means that our investments have to keep up, not fall behind or fall into uncertainty because of partisan gridlock.

So I'm really glad we have this opportunity today to hear from our witnesses about what that means for the Army and, of course, how we support our servicemembers and their families, like the troops at Joint Base Lewis McCord and Yakima Training Center in my home State of Washington.

It's really important to me that this conversation also focuses on getting our military families the support they need, like childcare and mental healthcare and good housing and schools, and we also have to make sure we're keeping men and women in uniform safe. My heart goes out to the families of the soldiers we lost in the recent helicopter crashes. I expect to hear more following the Army's review of the safety procedures about how we are preventing future tragedies because at the end of the day the heart of our military isn't our weapons or our equipment, it is the brave and talented men and women who are willing to put their lives on the line to keep our country safe.

So before I ask my questions, I just want to thank each of you for your service to this country. This committee has a deep appreciation for everything our servicemembers do to keep their members safe.

With that, let me just ask a few questions. Secretary Wormuth, in my home State of Washington we are still seeing issues with the availability of suitable and affordable housing, especially at JBLM (Joint Base Lewis-McChord), and I'm hearing that as many as 250 servicemembers and their families spend from three to 4 months in hotels or other accommodations while they wait for a home on

base to become available. These servicemembers and their families have to have a safe and reliable and affordable place to live, period.

I wanted to ask you what you were doing to make sure that housing needs are being met both on and off base.

Secretary WORMUTH. Thank you, Chair Murray.

Availability of housing is a challenge around JBLM and in a number of other locations around the country. We're doing a few things to try to work on that.

First of all, this budget has \$690 million in it for family housing and then we also obviously have our privatized housing that we work with the five different companies that provide that housing. So we are constantly looking at how can we invest more, how can we encourage those companies to invest more so that we're able to generate more inventory at places like JBLM.

Another thing that we're doing, I think, is we are really pushing OSD (Office of the Secretary of Defense) to reopen how they calculate the basic housing allowance and this goes to obviously being able for our soldiers and families to afford housing off post and I think the way that we have calculated—I personally am not fully comfortable with how we're doing BAH (Basic Allowance for Housing) and I think we're going to look at that, open it up, look at the anchor points that we use, look at the utilities, the cost factors that we're using because in some cases I think we may need to raise the BAH rates to allow our soldiers and families to be able to afford housing off post. So that's some of what we're trying to do.

Senator MURRAY. Good. I look forward to hearing more about that. Thank you.

A Department of Defense review that was finished last year found that the drinking water supplying 24 installations exposes about a 175,000 servicemembers a year to dangerous levels of chemicals linked to cancer and other illnesses.

The presence of these environmental contaminants, including PFAS (Army Per- and Polyfluoroalkyl Substances), on installations and their surrounding communities continues to be a huge concern of mine and I know many others here in the Senate, especially with some of the worst contamination levels at JBLM and Yakima Training Center.

Are there barriers you have identified in cleaning up these contaminants on active installations?

Secretary WORMUTH. Chair Murray, to my knowledge, there are not barriers to cleaning that up. I mean, you know, if there are cases where drinking water is not found to be safe, we will immediately work with the affected areas to get, you know, access to safe drinking water, whether that's by looking at, you know, new wells or other ways to solve that problem.

I am aware that I think the EPA (Environmental Protection Agency) is contemplating making some changes to how it assesses what is a safe level of PFAS and I think that will have potentially very substantial—

Senator MURRAY. So are you coordinating with the EPA to make sure the Army is testing at the most recent recommended lifetime drinking water health advisory levels?

Secretary WORMUTH. I'm sure that we're coordinating with the EPA. If the EPA changes what they determine to be a safe stand-

ard that will have implications for us that I think will be significant financially.

Senator MURRAY. Okay. Thank you very much. Thank you, Mr. Chairman, and thank you, Senator Hoeven. I appreciate it.

Senator TESTER. Senator Hoeven.

Senator HOEVEN. Thanks, Mr. Chairman.

First, thanks to both of you for your service. Secretary Wormuth, are you aware that the Administration has released a draft regulation that would require contractors to report—defense contractors to report—on their greenhouse gas emissions for the weapon systems they make and also set emission reduction targets? Are you aware of that regulation?

Secretary WORMUTH. Senator, I don't think that I'm aware of that specific proposal at this time. It hasn't come to my attention.

Senator HOEVEN. It's a draft proposal, but essentially if we're going to make contractors track their emissions on the weapon systems they make as well as from their suppliers, aren't we starting to prioritize, I guess, emission standards over weapons performance?

Secretary WORMUTH. Well, Senator, without seeing the specifics of the draft, I can't really speak to the implications of it. I mean, for example, if contractors are being asked to just track their emissions and maybe report them, that's different from having some sort of a consequence if their levels are deemed to be, you know, not acceptable. So I think I would just need to know a little more about the proposal.

Senator HOEVEN. So the tracking the emissions and setting standards for things like munitions and bombs and things like that, we're going to now make that a factor in deciding which ones that the military procures? And won't that affect both the effectiveness of those weapon systems for our warriors as well as the cost?

Secretary WORMUTH. Well, Senator, again I haven't seen the proposal, so I hesitate to comment on it. What I will say is obviously our soldiers need to have the best possible equipment to defend this country and I would want to make sure that that's what we would put our emphasis on.

Senator HOEVEN. Thank you. Thank you.

And then, General, so I was just in South Korea and Taiwan. Taiwan's ordered and is paying for I think on the order of \$19.5 billion worth of military hardware that they want to use obviously to counter aggression by the PRC (People's Republic of China), China, in the Taiwan Strait and obviously we're working with other allies in the Indo-Pacific, Japan, Philippines, the South Korean President is here now and so forth, to deter China's aggressive behavior.

One of the issues is getting those munitions. So it's not just about modernizing our forces, which we must do and obviously this committee funds that effort and is working with you to do it, it's also providing those enhanced armaments to our friends, our allies, partners and friends—that should sound familiar to you—in the Indo-Pacific.

By the same token, we need to and are providing assistance to Ukraine but they're needing to procure these weapon systems, as

well, and we're modernizing our forces. That puts a real strain on the supply chain.

What are we doing, what can we do to expedite that which is crucially important in Ukraine right now, it's crucially important in the Indo-Pacific right now, and it's crucially important to our own forces and making sure they have the very best armaments?

General McCONVILLE. Well, Senator, I think it's really important that we invest in our organic industrial base and, you know, as we talk about—and for the long term, and as we—

Senator HOEVEN. Sir, I agree with the investment, but my question is we need to expedite the production now. That's—what can we do to expedite the production now with the investment we're making is my question, sir.

General McCONVILLE. Yes. I guess, you know, my response, having watched this, is, you know, the defense industry doesn't operate on enthusiasm. They want contracts. They want long-term contracts they can invest in their systems and when they see that, you know, we're starting to ramp up. We're doing 155 rounds. We're doing it on some of the systems that we're doing right now and I think it's very, very important that we project outwards in some cases with multiyear contracts. That helps. They know that when they invest this year, they're going to have a 3- or 4- or 5-year funding stream that's going to allow them to invest and ramp up these capabilities.

We also need to work with our allies and partners to make sure they're doing the same thing in their organic industrial base because these countries need to have the capabilities with the weapon systems. They need to have the capacity, which is enough of them. They need to have the confidence in those weapon systems and their soldiers need to have the will to fight if they're going to defend their country.

Senator HOEVEN. For both of you, are we providing the assistance in terms of the weapon systems requested by Ukraine to end the conflict so they can be successful rather than stalemate? I would ask first you, Secretary, and then you, General.

Secretary WORMUTH. Senator, I believe that we are providing the Ukrainians with what they need to fight against the Russians. So, you know, we are giving them systems and certainly the Army is giving them systems—

Senator HOEVEN. Win versus stalemate now.

Secretary WORMUTH. I think we—

Senator HOEVEN. Win versus stalemate.

Secretary WORMUTH [continuing]. Want to see the Ukrainians prevail obviously. I think that is in the national interests of the United States to do more than achieve a stalemate. You know, we can't let the—there can't be a precedence of being able to just declare that a country doesn't exist.

So we need to give them the equipment they need to defeat the Russians and I think that we are doing that.

Senator HOEVEN. General?

General McCONVILLE. I would add it's not just the equipment, it's the training, and we're seeing and there's a lot of higher level combined arms training up to the brigade level and, you know, in another venue we can give you the exact numbers, but we have sig-

nificantly increased their capability to do combined arms operations at the brigade level and above.

Senator HOEVEN. Again, thanks to both of you. Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

Senator TESTER. Senator Shaheen, 20 minutes ago you were one minute away from asking questions. It's your turn.

Senator SHAHEEN. Finally. Well, it was worth waiting for.

Secretary Wormuth, I'm sorry Senator Murray isn't here because your response on the testing of our servicemembers I think was not totally accurate. I've been trying to get that done through the MBAA for several years now and in fact what we're being told by DOD (Department of Defense) is that we don't have the lab capacity to do that and there's been opposition from the Department of Defense to actually get that done.

So, Mr. Chairman, I intend to share that with Senator Murray so that she knows that in fact we are not doing that.

Secretary WORMUTH. Well, I'm happy, Senator Shaheen, to look into that and do what I can.

Senator SHAHEEN. That would be great. Your advocacy would be very much appreciated.

For both of you, when you appeared before the Armed Services Committee earlier this year, I asked why the Army had once again failed to include full funding for the enhanced night vision goggles binoculars, ENVGB. Congress stepped in last year to restore the full \$300 million.

Senator Murphy talked about the GAO report on the Vertical Lift. There's also a GAO report on the potential impact of what will happen if an IVAS (Integrated Visual Augmentation System) System gets fielded before it's ready and the potential for men and women in the military not to actually make use of that because there's so much concern about it.

So again how do we explain the fact that you haven't requested funding for the ENVGB? We've seen just last week another 2-year delay in terms of fielding the IVAS System. So do we not think the ENVGB is working well, and as we're talking about Senator Hoeven's question about the defense industrial base and as you replied, General McConville, very appropriately, they're concerned about contracts.

Well, when we say to companies we want you to produce these, they gear up to do that and then the contracts aren't forthcoming. It sends a message that we can't be counted on and we don't really need what's being proposed.

So tell me again because I don't feel like I've gotten an adequate answer on why you're not requesting funding for the ENVGB Program in this year's budget.

Secretary WORMUTH. Okay. Senator Shaheen, I will try again. First of all, I want to emphasize that the ENVGB is a great system. This may surprise you, but the Pentagon had take your child to work day last week and in our courtyard the Army had many of our systems that kids could look at and the ENVGB was one of them.

Senator SHAHEEN. Doesn't surprise me at all because I think it is a great system——

Secretary WORMUTH. It is.

Senator SHAHEEN [continuing]. And that's what we've heard from you.

Secretary WORMUTH. It is a very good system. Our soldiers like it and they're very comfortable with it.

I think (1), you know, we have a finite amount of resources that we can apply to modernization. So we are having to make choices and that is, you know, relevant whether it's about JLTV (Joint Light Tactical Vehicle) and other kinds of vehicles or whether it's about, you know, what I would call wearable tech for our soldiers.

What we're trying to do with ENVGB and IVAS is strike a balance. IVAS, as I know you know, does more than what the goggles do. It is a system that allows our soldiers to train, rehearse, and then fight in a synthetic training environment.

Senator SHAHEEN. But it's not ready yet. Our soldiers—

Secretary WORMUTH. We are working on it. You are absolutely right. We are still working on it and I think if Congress gives us the money that we've requested for IVAS in this year's budget, we are going to use that to work with Microsoft to get the system to a place where our soldiers will want to use it and if Microsoft isn't able to do that, we will not develop the program further.

You know, we are not—I know the GAO report, you know, talks about \$22 billion. That assumes fully—

Senator SHAHEEN. And the IG report. I mean,—

Secretary WORMUTH. Right.

Senator SHAHEEN [continuing]. It's not the only report, and the Army's own report all said the same thing.

Secretary WORMUTH. We're not going to spend \$22 billion on a system if it doesn't work, but I think the Chief and I both believe that this is important wearable technology for our soldiers. We want to see if we can get it to a place where it is going to be desirable for our soldiers. We think it can be, but I think Microsoft knows that this is it. They either get it done and get it to a place where our soldiers want to use it or we will move on and I don't know, Chief, if you want to add to that.

General McCONVILLE. I think, you know, first of all, the enhanced night vision goggles bravo (ENVG-B) is a cutting edge technology.

Where we are today, I would say that is—you know, if you go back when we first started flying goggles with PVS-5s, they were big clunky things you wore on your head and how far we've taken the technology is great, but to me IVAS is transformational. It's going to fundamentally change the way our soldiers operate in the battlefield and when we take a look at where we are with resources is we want to give the next 3 to 5 years to get that edge that's going to transform how our soldiers are going to fight and that's the trade-off that we're trying to make right now.

Senator SHAHEEN. And I understand that aspiration, but it's not working yet and until it works, it seems to me that we are short changing those people who need the current system that does work in a way that is not acceptable as we're looking at warfighting.

So thank you, Mr. Chairman.

Senator TESTER. Senator Murkowski.

Senator MURKOWSKI. Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

Thank you both for being before the committee here. I join other colleagues in expressing sadness and condolences at the loss of life with the helicopter crash in Alaska this week. Families are grieving, the community is grieving, and I know for Army all are grieving, and there is a great deal of review that will come forward as a consequence of this.

General McConville, I'm looking forward to being with you in Alaska on Friday, hopefully the opportunity to be up there at Fort Wainwright.

Secretary Wormuth, I know we have in place now this stand-down for a period of time. I am hoping that this stand-down will achieve the desired outcome which is really to really determine the safety there and not just a messaging tool that we're kind of looking at this, but I think we recognize that not only this horrible tragic incident but that this follows others that we have seen unfortunately.

So if you care to comment very quickly on that?

Secretary WORMUTH. Yes, Senator. The safety stand-down, as the Chief and you have discussed, will, you know, allow all of our aviators to focus on safety, to review their procedures, you know, make sure that they are doing everything that they should be doing and that absolutely will involve more than just messaging.

And then, of course, you know, there will be investigations. There's already an investigation underway at the crash that we had at Fort Campbell, and we will probably learn additional insights from those investigations that we will also make sure the aviation community has and can make any changes that are needed.

Senator MURKOWSKI. Thank you for that.

Let me ask a couple questions about provisions within the 2023 NDAA (National Defense Authorization Act) and this is under Section 603. We authorized some policies that we're hoping will improve the quality of life for the soldiers that are stationed in Alaska.

I have been told that right now there has been no guidance released for how and when these new policies are going to be implemented and my concern is, is that we have servicemembers that are missing out on some of these time-limited incentives that are again designed to help alleviate some of the hardships that are just inherent with being in the North.

One is the provision that allows for cold weather special duty pay and the second is the requirement that the Secretary reimburse eligible servicemembers for the cost of airfare to travel to their home of record when they're assigned to Alaska as a duty station.

Can you give me any information in terms of when soldiers can expect to receive either the cold weather pay or again receiving the reimbursement for eligible travel?

Secretary WORMUTH. Yes, on the cold weather pay, the Army has actually been providing cold weather pay to soldiers since 2020 through our Remote and Austere Location Incentive Pay. I don't quite have the acronym off the top of my head, but basically if you're above 63 degrees North, so if you're at Fort Greeley, for example, or Fort Wainwright, single soldiers get \$2,000 and soldiers

with dependents get \$4,000. So we have been paying that since 2020.

Senator MURKOWSKI. Right. But this provision in NDAA was additional to that.

Secretary WORMUTH. My understanding, and I'm not an expert on this, Senator, so I may have to get back to you for the record, I think there's concern with OSD that somehow we will be double counting. So, you know, I would be happy to work with you and your office if you think that the amount of the current incentive isn't sufficient, but I think there's concern from OSD about creating a second incentive.

Senator MURKOWSKI. Okay. Well, then we need to talk about this and do so quickly because this is not about double dip. This is truly about addressing some of the realities that come when you are in these cold weather environments and the ability to take care of yourself and your family with that.

How about on the travel piece of it?

Secretary WORMUTH. The travel piece is in draft right now and, frankly, when I learned that it's in draft because I'd heard personally from soldiers how important it is to be able to fly home sometimes and I know how expensive those are.

So I will commit to you to sort of look to see if we can speed that up. There's no issue with it. It's just sort of going through the staffing process.

Senator MURKOWSKI. Okay. I know that when I'm up there this weekend, these will be questions that I will be asked and I'm sure, General McConville, you will, as well. So the more information we have on that the better.

Thank you.

Senator MORAN [presiding]. Senator Murkowski, thank you very much.

Senator Capito.

Senator CAPITO. Thank you, Mr. Chair, and thank you all both for being here, very much appreciate not just being here but your service and appreciate all the men and women that serve with you.

I would just add my voice of concern to the accidents that we've seen. Obviously you're working very affirmatively, too. I'm sure it hurts everybody's heart and the hearts of the folks that you serve with probably more than others with the families.

I wanted to ask about munitions, General McConville. How has the observing the Ukraine conflict helped the Army assess the performance of existing Army munitions and assumptions about our requirements for the future fight?

General MCCONVILLE. Yes, Senator. First of all, you know, as far as our performance, I think it's showing. You know, things like HIMARS (High Mobility Artillery Rocket System) become game changes. We look at the amount of 155 rounds that are being utilized. They're very, very effective and, quite frankly, you know, U.S. weapon systems across the board have been in great demand and are working extremely well, but the usage rates have gone beyond what we, you know, historically have used.

So we have been at war, you know, 20 years. We've never used the amount of, you know, 155 rounds doing that. So, you know, at the Secretary's directive we are doing that right now but really

standing up our organic industrial base so we can manufacture and have the capability to do it in a timely manner to get our stockage rates up to what we think we may have to use in large-scale combat operations.

Senator CAPITO. Madam Secretary, would you say in terms of what our capacity is now—let's just say we were to be engaged—I know hypotheticals are terrible, but be engaged in something where we would need those munitions for our own purposes, are we ready to do that? I mean, I know we're not bleeding ourselves down to a point where we would not be ready, but we need to replenish. Is that the case?

Secretary WORMUTH. As we've looked at the Ukrainian request for support, we've weighed that very carefully. So we are not, you know, giving away more than we can afford to, if you will, although I think we've been very creative at finding ways to be able to give them as much as we possibly can without going too low in our own stockpiles.

But we have a lot of work to do, I would say, Senator, in regenerating our industrial base and that's why we're investing \$1.5 billion in this budget to invest in our own organic industrial base. You know, we've made, I think, very good use of the resources Congress has given us through the supplementals to get that on contract quickly and get our partners in industry, like Lockheed-Martin and Raytheon, to increase their production, and I think we are rebuilding that capacity now and that will, I think, serve us quite well in the future.

Senator CAPITO. Good, good. In West Virginia, we have some good resources that can help with that.

Let me switch gears and talk about recruitment. I understand that in August you stood up a pilot program, the Future Soldier Prep Course, to help those individuals, in other words, improve up to the standards rather than lower your standards.

So, General, how is that working? Are you getting a lot of uptake on it? Is it making improvements? I know you're having recruiting issues. How do you see that program?

General MCCONVILLE. Yes. I think it's transformational, Senator. You know, I think the one thing the Secretary and I've done is made a blood oath. We're not going to lower standards and I think this is really important.

Senator CAPITO. Right.

General MCCONVILLE. So we're going to invest in young men and women and as we talked, recruiters, they said they were having challenges passing what we call our Armed Forces Vocational Aptitude Battery Test, which is like an SAT for the military and also having challenges meeting the physical requirements because of body weight.

So we've stood up the program and with that a little over 8,000 actually go through the program right now. We've seen a 95 percent success rate. I think there's something there. I think it's the future and it's amazing. Not only are they meeting the standards, in many cases they're exceeding and they're going on to do really good things in the Army.

So I think this is something we really need to take a hard look at and is a potential for expansion.

Senator CAPITO. So when you're looking at, say, a high school graduating class that's interested in pursuing the Army as a next step, how does somebody find that? I mean, do you have to be in a recruiting program to be able to access that? Is it generally accessible?

General McCONVILLE. Well, the best way—it's very accessible, you know. You can go on the Internet and contact a recruiter. You can go to a local recruiting station and then what happens, you start taking the tests and if you're having challenges, we can help you get into the program.

Senator CAPITO. So the best way to access that is through a recruiter, an actual recruiter?

General McCONVILLE. Sure. On the Internet or through a recruiter.

Senator CAPITO. Yes. Okay. A couple weeks ago, hundreds of soldiers for the 101st Airborne and the 82nd Airborne came to Rural West Virginia for a unique training experience. They were able to get their hands on developmental technology, use it in a realistic training environment and provide real feedback that will impact the final product.

I don't know if you're aware of that training exercise and if you'd have any comment on what that looks like in the future.

General McCONVILLE. Well, you know, firstly, I'm a little privy to 101st Airborne. It has a special place in my heart. But having units go out in places like West Virginia and work with people is really important for the work they're doing but also for the exposure.

One of the things that we need to work on is making sure that people get exposed to our soldiers so they know what the military is about and that type of training.

Senator CAPITO. I think one of the values in this particular exercise is for the soldiers to get ahold of some of the newer technology or the breaking technology so that it's not stuck in this developmental phase and you can actually see what's in a simulated real situation, see what's going to work and what isn't so we can get them into the actual production phase.

Thank you very much.

General McCONVILLE. Thank you, Senator.

Senator TESTER [presiding]. Senator Boozman.

Senator BOOZMAN. Thank you, Chairman Tester, very, very much for having this important hearing, and it's good to be with you all. We appreciate all of your hard work.

I understand, General, that you're retiring and we appreciate you, appreciate your service. You've had more than an outstanding career and we also appreciate your family. These are certainly family affairs and the sacrifices that they've made through the years.

It's always good to talk about the budget, talking about the fiscal year 2024 budget, trying to figure out what your priorities are, and then again how we can help you, Madam Secretary and General, as you work through this.

General, you've been focused on maintaining readiness and modernizing the Army to ensure it has the tools needed in future conflict in the Pacific. After recently visiting with Army leaders in the Pacific and visiting with Army personnel in Singapore, I learned

the importance the Army plays in supporting the Joint Force in the Pacific.

Can you highlight the importance of the Army's future role in a Joint Fight in the Pacific?

General MCCONVILLE. Yes, Senator. I think the Army has a critical role in the Indo-Pacific along with our joint partners. Some of the things that we do, the long-range precision fires, air and missile defense, contested logistics, and then certainly providing ground troops and, more importantly, working with our allies and partners on the ground to increase their capabilities, capacities, and competence so they can defend their countries. That is very, very important and where the American soldier goes it really reassures those armies that we deal with and they have the confidence to fight. So I think it's very, very important.

Senator BOOZMAN. What in the budget specifically supports the Army's role in Joint Force and where does it assume risk regarding the Indo-Pacific?

Secretary WORMUTH. Senator, I'm happy to speak to that a little bit. We are making a lot of investments in this year's budget aimed at the Indo-Pacific.

So, for example, the Chief talked about contested logistics. We have over \$850 million in this year's budget for Army pre-positioned equipment. Also, for contested logistics, we are investing in new composite watercraft that will allow us to take supplies and move it around, you know, that very large theater, and then, of course, in terms of our RDT&E Programs, we are investing in the long-range precision fighter support portfolios, so things like the precision strike missile, the mid-range capability, the long-range hypersonic weapon.

We are investing over \$550 million in integrated air and missile defense programs, things like Patriot, the indirect fighter protection capability which will be able to intercept advanced cruise missiles, and then we're also looking at deep sensing capabilities, things like HADES (High Accuracy Detection and Exploitation System), which is our airborne ISR, (Intelligence, Surveillance, Reconnaissance) sensing and then the Titan network and so that's another about \$300 million for deep sensing in that theater.

Senator BOOZMAN. Very good. I want to touch on something I think Senator Moran touched on earlier, but the Army's fiscal year 2024 budget request is a \$185.5 billion short of the 2018 National Defense Strategy's recommendation of three to 5 percent real growth. When adjusted for inflation, the Army's fiscal year 2024 budget is actually a rate of negative 2 percent growth over fiscal year 2023.

Madam Secretary, moving forward, how can we help you? Can the Army afford to continue its 2030 modernization strategy without increased top lines or reducing force structure?

Secretary WORMUTH. Senator, I feel that our budget of a \$185 billion, as I said in my opening statement, allows us to do our part in the National Defense Strategy. It allows us to keep our momentum on modernization, keep investing in readiness, and to take care of our people.

I think the challenge for us is going to be as we look to the out years, frankly. You know, the Future Vertical Lift Programs, for

example, are very, very expensive. You know, the Optionally Manned Fighting Vehicle Program is very expensive, and as we look at, you know, trying to—as those become programs of record and the Army needs to start fielding them at scale, that is going to get very expensive and so where I worry under the current budget is how are we going to manage all of this in the out years and still take care of our people.

We have a lot of infrastructure bills, frankly, not just associated with our housing for soldiers and families but also power projection. If Senator Schatz were here, he knows all about the infrastructure situation in Hawaii.

So it's looking more to 2030 and beyond where I think it gets challenging.

Senator BOOZMAN. Thank you all very much. Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

Senator TESTER. I will turn it over to Senator Moran for his close.

Senator MORAN. Chairman, thank you.

I'll submit for the record this question to both the General and the Secretary. The unfunded priorities list includes \$530 million to bring the total procurement of Abrams Tanks to a full brigade level.

I'd like to hear why that's not included or why it's important and see if we can be of assistance in that regard.

And then so much of what we've talked about and so much of the capabilities of the Army is dependent upon this issue of recruitment. It strikes me as at least interesting and maybe there's a good explanation why is recruitment so difficult when retention is so favorable.

One would think that those who are serving, who are making the decisions to re-enlist have encountered a good experience but it's not translating into people who have not yet served.

Is there some analysis or a way to take advantage of the circumstance in which people are reupping to get people to up for the first time?

Secretary WORMUTH. Senator, I would say that's part of what our Soldier Referral Program is aimed at is you're right. We've got really good retention, historically good retention. So people who are in the Army, you know, many of them are having good experiences. So we're asking our soldiers then to turn around and take that good news story to their communities and then if they're able to, you know, bring forward people who sign up and go to basic, they get points towards promotion.

So, you know, I think some of it is again about re-introducing the Army to the American public and really, you know, addressing legitimate concerns that parents have sometimes about what kind of housing their kid is going to be in or concerns about sexual harassment. I think there's some misperceptions sometimes about the Army, that it's somehow slowing people down, when in fact I would argue it can accelerate kids towards college degrees, but we need to do a better job of telling our story and we'd welcome your help with that.

Senator MORAN. Thank you. Thank you both.

General McConville, thank you for your service to the country.

Senator TESTER. I've got to ask a real quick question, too. This is on modernization programs and the transition.

The Army is going to invest in six modernization portfolios to build the Army of 2030. This requires sufficient funding for research, technology, maturation, prototype development, and experimentation of advanced military systems to meet future operational force requirements. However, the Army also is slashing enduring programs and hot production lines while undergoing this modernization. The impact on the defense industrial base and suppliers and workforce is significant and I would tell you after all we've heard in this committee about our industrial base and predictability, it is somewhat contrary to that and that's being kind.

So what are you hearing from the defense—this is for you, Secretary Wormuth. What are you hearing from the defense industrial base and our critical suppliers in response to repeated proposals to terminate hot production lines of enduring programs?

I don't mean that to be a pointed question. I mean that to be a question that I'm very concerned about our supply chains, very concerned, and I think one of the questions we've tried to do on this committee and all branches of the military and the defense budget overall is to make sure there is predictability in purchasing.

That being said, there are antiquated programs that need to go away and that's perfectly acceptable and good business, but the question is, is I don't want this to impact critical supply chain bases. So tell me what you're doing.

Secretary WORMUTH. Certainly, Chairman. First of all, it's very much in the Army's interests to have a robust and healthy defense industrial base.

Senator TESTER. Agreed.

Secretary WORMUTH. So we share that. With finite resources, we are constantly, the Chief and I, having to strike a balance between putting resources towards the new systems that we're developing in those six modernization portfolios that you mentioned but also trying to maintain our enduring programs, things like Abrams, things like PIM (Paladin Integrated Management), things like Striker, for example, and we, in making those choices and in setting that balance, do weigh the health of our industrial base.

So my view is we've tried carefully to not make any decisions that severely damage our industrial base and we are also—you know, the supply chain, that goes well beyond obviously the Army's organic industrial base and what we're trying to do there is work with our partners in industry, the big primes, to help them rebuild their supply chains.

Senator TESTER. Senator Shaheen for one question.

Senator SHAHEEN. Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

I'm sorry I didn't realize things were going to move so fast, but I wanted—because so much of the hearing has focused on recruitment and the challenges with recruitment, I wanted to raise a question that was presented to me last week. I had a chance to meet with members, former members of the Afghan female tactical platoon who are here and as you know, there are a number of Afghan former servicemembers who worked with us during that conflict.

I was interested to hear them say they would very much like the opportunity to continue to serve the United States. So as you think about recruitment challenges, are there ways in which we can enable people like these women who have honorable service who want to continue to support this country to serve?

Secretary WORMUTH. Yes, Senator. I actually met with those women, as well. They were incredibly inspiring and a number of them, when asked, held up their hand and said they'd like to join the United States Army.

We are looking—we do have pathways for folks who do not have U.S. citizenship to join the Army. You know, we have green card holder pathways, lawful permanent residents. My understanding is that the current immigration status that those women have, you know, may not be high enough, if you will, to allow them to join the Army at this time, but I offered, for example, to write a letter to Secretary Mayorkas at DHS (Department of Homeland Security) to try to help with their political asylum proceedings, but if they're able to, you know, be granted asylum, for example, assuming they meet our requirements and I think they will, these women are very skilled, if anything, the biggest issue for them will be the language requirement, but we are ready and able to receive them as soon as they're able to come through the process.

Senator SHAHEEN. Well, Mr. Chairman, I would urge the committee to think about what we can do to help advance that because we have a number of committed people who want to serve this country and we should give them the opportunity.

Senator TESTER. I appreciate you bringing up that point, Senator, and I think it's certainly worth considering and finding out how we can add to making the Army all it can be or all it wants to be or all it will be or all it is. Okay.

General McConville, I, too, want to add my voice to the folks saying thank you for your service. Thank you for what you've done. Thank you for being very professional in front of this committee. I might add I think your testimony took about 3 minutes. We like that. Get to the point.

I would also say that you may not be able to retire this summer. There is a hold on all flag officers right now, you know. So your placement is not confirmed and may not be confirmed unless we get a level of common sense around here to allow you to be able to go to Montana and retire like I'm sure you're going to do.

But we do appreciate what you've done and what you'll continue to do even in retirement.

We appreciate both of your testimonies. Secretary, thank you. General, thank you.

ADDITIONAL COMMITTEE QUESTIONS

Senators may submit additional written questions and we would ask that you respond to those questions as soon as possible within a reasonable time.

[The following questions were not asked at the hearing, but were submitted to the Department for response subsequent to the hearing:]

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED TO CHRISTINE WORMUTH

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR JON TESTER

Question. Last year, Congress accelerated investments in weapons so that our weapons magazines are loaded up for future contingencies.

In this year's budget, the Department is proposing to lock-in procurement quantities for 9 different weapons programs over the next 3–5 years to provide a predictable demand signal to industry.

This proposal includes two Army programs: the Guided Multiple Launch Rocket System, and Patriot missiles.

However, it is not yet clear what the private sector will invest in return for this predictability from the Government, nor is it clear that industry can actually ramp up and build the weapons at a rate that Army desires.

Secretary Wormuth, what industry investments are you expecting in return for this multi-year predictability? Have you directly engaged with the defense industrial base to ensure they can get you what you need when you need it?

Answer. The Army is confident industry can meet the demands of both the Guided Multiple Launch Rocket System and PATRIOT Advanced Capability-3 multiyear contracts if they are approved by Congress. Prior to requesting them, the Army did extensive reviews of both programs to ensure the targets required under the proposed contracts are achievable.

With regards to industry investments, Army acquisition leaders have been in discussions with the related companies concerning their intended investments related to the proposed multiyear contracts. However, the information about industry investments is proprietary in nature. The Army can provide information in a separate briefing to you facilitated by the committee.

Question. For several years, this Subcommittee has criticized the Department for not having a robust plan to defend Guam against high-end air defense threats. So I am pleased that this year's budget includes a total of \$1.5 billion to accelerate this capability.

However, we need people and infrastructure to get this done right, and these efforts need to be coordinated across all the military services and with the Missile Defense Agency.

Secretary Wormuth, the Army has a growing presence on Guam, but our understanding is that you have not yet signed a Memorandum of Agreement with your sister services regarding the use of resources. Why are the obstacles here?

Answer. The Army is developing elements to incorporate into the Joint Memorandum of Agreement (JMOA) with sister services for support of Guam. The process to develop, review, and evaluate the JMOA will involve stakeholders throughout DoD and could take several months to finalize. The JMOA lists how 44 distinct services will be delivered. Army support requirements for people, facilities, and sites where Army assets will reside are among the elements the Army is assessing. As part of this process, the Army will carefully assess the personnel requirements and phasing timeline for arrival of units in Guam. The requirements assessment will be informed by whether tours will be accompanied or not. If tours are accompanied, myriad support facilities will be required, such as schools, child development centers, healthcare facilities, family housing, etc. Existing support facilities are undersized for the current population, so even if tours are unaccompanied, support facilities will need to be expanded. Finally, Joint Region Marianas anticipates it will take 10 months to a year before the Secretary of the Navy conveys permanent basing/stationing decisions.

Question. When Congress provided authorities and funding for rapid prototyping, the intent was to rapidly develop, try out, and field initial capabilities that would inform future requirements before committing to large-scale programs.

We have supported this approach in the past in order to accelerate fielding decisions, and will continue supporting funding for prototypes where it makes sense, so we can see what works and what doesn't.

However, it appears the Army now wants to just continue buying prototypes well after initial prototypes have been fielded instead making substantial acquisition commitments.

This is concerning: it circumvents the spirit of the law; fails to field capabilities at scale; and does not provide a predictable and stable path for industry with respect to the Army's needs.

Secretary Wormuth, what steps are you taking to comply with the law, which prohibits funding excess prototype quantities that aren't specifically needed?

Answer. Middle Tier of Acquisition (MTA) Rapid Prototyping (RP) programs are required to create test strategies or plans that clearly identify the number of devel-

opmental items needed to support developmental testing or operational assessments and must seek written approval to purchase quantities that exceed those needed. This direction will be formally documented in the upcoming update to the Army's MTA policy. The Army Acquisition Executive (AAE) personally approves any effort seeking entry into MTA RP. This authority is not delegated below the AAE. Quantities required to fulfill the MTA RP are included as part of the program initiation decisions.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR TAMMY BALDWIN

Tactical Wheeled Vehicles and the Defense Industrial Base

Question. Wisconsin is home to Oshkosh Defense, a company that is a global leader in the design, production, and sustainment of military vehicles. In particular, Oshkosh specializes in manufacturing the Joint Light Tactical Vehicle (JLTV), the Family of Medium Tactical Vehicles (FMTV), and the Family of Heavy Tactical Vehicles (FHTV).

Army recently awarded the JTLV contract to AM General, after years of procuring that vehicle from Oshkosh.

Additionally, year after year the budget request includes procurement amounts for the FMTV and FHTV that are well below the minimum sustaining rate necessary to keep the production line running and skilled workers in place.

What is the Army's plan for managing the health of the defense industrial base for tactical wheeled vehicles?

Answer. A healthy and competitive tactical wheeled vehicle industrial base is key to controlling costs, enhancing innovation, and improving quality. The Army exercises frequent and deliberate engagements with industry to identify and address risks and issues that affect the industrial base with a focus on, minimum sustaining rates, potential production breaks, and supply chain impacts. The Army is balancing Tactical Wheeled Vehicle modernization by prioritizing Light Tactical Vehicles investments, by maintaining warm Heavy and Medium Tactical Vehicles production bases, and by increasing competition across the industrial base for programs such as the Common Tactical Truck (CTT) and electric Light Reconnaissance Vehicle (eLRV).

Question. I am concerned that when work for tactical wheeled vehicles is divided between two manufacturers, the budget request will not provide enough work for both companies to sustain their workforce and supplier networks. As such, how does Army plan to sustain the workforce and supplier networks?

Answer. The Army continues to assess the health of the industrial base to understand its ability to support military demands. In the case of the Joint Light Tactical Vehicle (JLTV), the Army planned for a multi-year transition phase. As the Army ramps-down the JLTVA1 production with Oshkosh through Fiscal Year (FY) 2025, the Army will ramp-up production of the JLTVA2 with AM General. The Army plans to award split procurements in FY 2023 and FY 2024 between Oshkosh and AM General and in FY 2025, all JLTV procurements are scheduled to be through AM General.

Additionally, Oshkosh will continue to produce Heavy and Medium Tactical Vehicles and AM General will continue to produce High Mobility Multipurpose Wheeled Vehicles.

Tactical Wheeled Vehicles and the future of logistics

Question. Tactical wheeled vehicle modernization programs—like FHTV, FMTV, and JLTV—with the latest advancements in payload, safety, and mobility are essential to supplying combat vehicles with fuel, ammo, and spare parts to take and control ground. In other words, tactical wheeled vehicles are a critical backbone of the logistics needed to sustain and win a fight.

Would you agree with this statement?

Answer. As the Army looks toward the future, multi-modal distribution is essential as is reduction in supply requirements within the tactical force. No single domain of transport will meet the distribution requirements of the Joint Force. Another key to this problem is human-machine integration that may allow for reduced manning in multi-modal transport systems providing reduced risk and higher efficiency to meet the Army and Joint Force supply requirements.

Question. With the Army developing a new Cross Functional Team focused on Contested Logistics, will Tactical Wheeled Vehicles be a focus area of the CFT?

Answer. The Contested Logistics (CL) Cross Functional Team (CFT) is still finalizing an approved portfolio. AFC will assign three to five modernization efforts to the CL CFT, focused on tactical level logistics. Multi-capable or multi-modal dis-

tribution platforms, which includes tactical wheeled vehicles, is one area that is being considered as an area of focus for the CL CFT.

Question. Will future Army budgets start to reflect Tactical Wheeled Vehicles' role as critical and primary enabling warfighting capabilities?

Answer. The Army is updating the Tactical Wheeled Vehicle (TWV) strategy with expected completion next year. In FY 2024, the Army is investing \$1.31B in the TWV fleet including FMTV, FHTV, JLTV, High Mobility Multipurpose Wheeled Vehicle (HMMWV), Palletized Load System (PLS), and the development of the Common Tactical Truck. The Army will continue to invest in a mix of vehicles within the TWV fleet in future budget submissions as we build the Army of 2030 and design the Army of 2040.

Future Army budgets will continue to take a fiscally responsible approach to procurement that minimizes risk while providing balanced modernization to our units. The Army recognizes the challenges of a contested logistics environment, and the Army addresses that challenge in the FY 2024 budget submission by continuing investment in Army watercraft, modernized fuel and water storage and distribution systems, and enhancing our aerial delivery capabilities.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR LINDSEY GRAHAM

Question. The Scales Child Development Center (CDC) at Fort Jackson is the installation's largest CDC and supports 313 children ranging from 0 to 5 years of age. This 34-year old facility is in poor condition and experiences frequent failures of the air conditioning and sewer systems. These failures result in extreme heat and sewage backup within the building. Additionally, the facility has multiple line of sight issues that make it challenging for staff to properly supervise the children. Given this:

Can you provide an update regarding the Army's plans to replace this structure?

Answer. There is a 338-child capacity replacement Child Development Center (CDC) for Fort Jackson in the FY 2024–2028 Future Year Defense Program (FYDP) for construction in FY 2025.

Question. What is the current design percentage of the new structure?

Answer. The project is at 35% design.

Question. Will this project be eligible for authorization and funding in FY25?

Answer. Yes.

Question. How has inflation impacted the projected cost of the project?

Answer. The current estimate for the total project cost is now \$41M. There has been an increase due to inflation and cost escalation.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR JERRY MORAN

Question. You mentioned a challenge for the Army in the coming years is to reduce structure to better align with manning. You also answered that the Army is currently considering options but has yet to make any conclusions on the best path forward.

When should we expect implementation to begin on these changes? You mentioned the Committee can expect a formal briefing within the next few months. Please specify a target date.

Answer. The Army continues to conduct analysis on the transformation to the Army of 2030 and will formally brief the committee at the earliest possible opportunity.

Question. You stated the Army must make force structure changes regardless of the end strength deficit to make room for the new structure needed for Army 2030. Some of this structure is already established or will be soon. This analysis should have included reductions to offset the new structure.

What changes is the Army considering to establish this new force structure?

Answer. The Army is moving to a Multi-Domain organizational design, this requires re-orienting from Brigade Combat Team (BCT) centric operations tailored for counterinsurgency (COIN) to division centric operations tailored for Large Scale Combat Operations (LSCO) against peer/near-peer adversaries operating in a multi-domain environment, naturally resulting in smaller, but more mobile, lethal, and agile formations to account for the pace of future warfare. Additionally, the Army seeks to grow capabilities that enable it to see and sense farther, mass highly lethal forces, win the first fight, protect the force, communicate, and sustain the fight in LSCO.

Question. Are any decisions final on force structure changes to manage the additions of new units?

Answer. The Army is still developing the plan for how these changes will be implemented by looking carefully at our operational requirements as well as military and community value analysis. Certain force structure changes will be needed to shed capabilities no longer needed for large scale combat operations and to make room for new capabilities, while other reductions due to decreasing end strength could be avoided if recruiting improves.

Question. Please provide a complete assessment of specific units and MOSs impacted by reductions if the end strength deficit is unresolved.

Answer. The Army must transform its force structure to make room for new capabilities relevant to current and future threats. The Army is in the process of determining how and where to make these changes. To make room for the new capabilities and shed over-structure at the same time, the Army will thin out various Military Occupational Specialties, reduce numbers of lower priority unit types, and divest some structure optimized for COIN and counter-terrorism missions. This will ensure Army units are modernized and sufficiently manned so they are ready to fight.

Question. To spread out these changes, you highlighted the Army's "people night court" and evaluation of "unit priority."

What were the findings of this night court?

Answer. These sessions sought to adapt branches and functional areas to support Army 2030 based on the National Defense Strategy and Defense Planning Guidance. This included creating new capabilities in some branches, while reducing or reallocating capabilities in other branches. These sessions were a component of how the Army is transforming from a COIN fight to support LSCO and the Army continues to conduct analysis on the transformation to the Army of 2030. The Army looks forward to briefing Congress on force structure changes later this summer.

Question. What were MOSs identified by the Army as ones who could handle reduced structure?

Answer. The Army continues to conduct analysis on the Transformation to the Army of 2030 and will brief the committee at the earliest possible opportunity.

Question. When evaluating "unit priority," which units were identified as low-usage units whose force structure could handle reductions?

Answer. The Army utilized an extensive modeling process to determine the most highly used and needed units relative to total Army inventory in Large Scale Combat Operations examining 8 years of recent deployment data. However, this is a component of the Army's Transformation to Army 2030 and the Army is still developing the plan for how these changes will be implemented. It is too early to make commitments on changes. The Army looks forward to briefing Congress on force structure changes later this summer.

Question. Please provide a complete list of assessed units and the Army's recent and projected usage determination.

Answer. This is a component of the Army's Transformation to 2030 and the Army is still developing the plan for how these changes will be implemented. The Army looks forward to briefing Congress on force structure changes later this summer.

Question. It has been several years since the Army signed a new ARSTRUC.

Why has the Army not signed an Army structure document in recent years?

Answer. The Army signed Army Structure Memorandum 2024–2028 on 12 January 2022. The Army is currently conducting analysis for Army Structure Memorandum 2025–2029.

Question. Force structure reductions will impact the quantity and types of equipment procured each year. As was mentioned at the hearing, the Army is managing the transition to Army 2030 amidst a flat budget—the Army must effectively prioritize the acquisition and fielding of equipment based on the future structure of the service.

Is a reduced force structure a consideration when scheduling modernization priorities and Army procurement?

Answer. The Army must transform its force structure to make room for new capabilities relevant to current and future threats. Guided by the National Defense Strategy, the Army is in the process of determining how and where to make these changes. Once analysis is complete, the Army will assess impacts to modernization priorities and Army procurement.

Question. Are these assumptions already built into Army MTOEs?

Answer. The Army is still developing the plan to transform to Army 2030. Once finalized, those decisions will be built into an Army MTOE.

Question. Can the industrial base adapt to a potentially lower Army demand quantity?

Answer. The industrial base has the flexibility to accommodate the demand profile based on the level of funding. Communicating with the organic and commercial

partners early and often is critical to managing the industrial base to ensure balance between requirements and capacity.

Question. The Army communicated to our office last June there is no operational need for a Multi-Domain Task Force to support a Division HQ.

Has this changed?

Answer. The Army does not have an operational need for MDTFs to support Army Divisions. The Army 2030 concept does make the Division the tactical unit of action and through our annual Total Army Analysis process we are reviewing options that build multi-domain capabilities to enable the division to fight and win in Army 2030.

However, over the past 12 months, the Army's considerations for MDTF locations have evolved to allow for options to make efficient use of CONUS facilities while providing combatant commanders flexibility to employ all or part of MDTFs from CONUS locations.

Question. What criteria is the Army considering for each of the remaining MDTF pending basing decisions?

Answer. MDTF stationing is a decision reserved for the Secretary of the Army. The Headquarters Department of the Army HQDA develops options to station our limited resources based on operational requirements found in the National Defense Strategy (NDS) and the Defense Planning Guidance (DPG). The Army Staff is currently assessing those requirements in our annual Total Army Analysis (TAA) that will be approved by the Secretary of the Army.

The Army makes stationing decisions for new formations under Army Regulation 5-10. The Army's primary consideration for stationing is operational need informed by guidance from the NDS and DPG. The Army assesses installations that satisfy operational needs using Military Value Analysis (MVA) and Community Support Value Analysis (CSVA). Lastly, no decision is final until the Army completes assessments in accordance with the National Environmental Policy Act.

The following is a summary of the MVA attributes the Army considers for stationing.

a. *Training*

(1) *Total Maneuver Land:* total acres of maneuver land.

(2) *Accessible Maneuver Land:* the amount of usable maneuver land with a factor applied for soil resiliency

(3) *Training Facilities:* ranges, battle command centers, and training support centers

(4) *Airspace:* area of largest single restricted airspace and total of all restricted airspaces

(5) *Duddled Impact Area:* size and number of impact areas

b. *Power Projection*

(1) *Surface Deployment Infrastructure:* rail loading and classification tracks, rail marshaling area, truck loading ramps, unit cargo stationing, and truck loading area

(2) *Air Deployment Infrastructure:* Aerial Port of Embarkation (APOE) runway length, Max Aircraft on Ground, and hot cargo pads

(3) *Deployment Support Infrastructure:* container transfer pad, inspection lanes, vehicle scales, and inspection staging area

c. *Well Being*

(1) *Access to Medical Care:* assessment of the Medical Treatment Facility based on bed capability, out-of-area capability, case mix index, market share, and supported population.

(2) *Soldier and Family Support Facilities:* Army Community Service, Child Development Service, Fitness Center, Chapels, Youth Service.

(3) *Family Housing:* number of houses and the quality of those houses based on age and recent renovations

(4) *Brigade Complex:* quantity, quality, and functional assessment of facilities for a brigade headquarters

d. *Expansibility*

(1) *Developable Area:* total of all the buildable acreage on the installation not counting training land.

(2) *Population Impact:* density of people in a 10-mile zone outside the installation, plus a growth factor.

(3) *Connectivity:* long haul network, computing capacity, and critical infrastructure.

The following is a summary of the CSVA attributes the Army considers for stationing.

e. *Professional License*: This attribute assesses spouse license reciprocity using a weighted sum of three metrics: state policy, implementation, and interstate compacts.

f. *Housing*: This attribute assesses the private sector shortfall, which gives the number of families likely to be unable to find suitable off-post housing.

g. *Schools*: This attribute incorporates data from public sources that assess schools at more local levels using a weighted sum of high school graduation rates, 3rd–8th grade learning rate (the change in test scores among a cohort of students from 3rd grade through 8th grade), and student to teacher ratios.

h. *Medical*: A measure, for each of a list of weighted specialties, of the percent of patients seen in under 28 days.

i. *Intergovernmental Support Agreements (IGSAs)*: This attribute considers efficiencies in Joint Basing through the number Common Levels of Support (CLS) services at an installation under an IGSA.

QUESTION SUBMITTED BY SENATOR JOHN HOEVEN

Question. The Army's unfunded priority list includes a number of cost-to-complete projects. These projects have already been authorized and appropriated for, but additional funding is needed in order to account for inflation, which has increased the cost of materials, and supply chain disruptions. Many of these projects are Army National Guard readiness centers, which play an integral role in ensuring the joint readiness of the Total Force.

Why didn't the Department prioritize these projects in its fiscal year 2024 budget request?

Answer. These cost increases emerged too late in the budget submission process. To the extent possible, the Army will program future existing project funding shortfalls in its base budget. Waiting for the next budget cycle to program these projects would delay the construction of the critical infrastructure, as well as cause further cost increases.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR JOHN BOOZMAN

Question. I anticipate the demand for munitions to remain high due to the war in Ukraine having no end in sight. Manufacturers in places like Camden, AR, are rapidly expanding and increasing their capabilities to meet demand. I saw in this year's budget it substantially expands investments in critical munitions through taking advantage of multi-year procurement authorities.

What concerns you most about the industrial bases capacity to meet increased demands for production?

Answer. A significant concern the Army has is that historically the Department of Defense (DoD)'s policy has been to operate effectively and efficiently and utilize competition to drive cost-effective solutions which necessitated lean manufacturing and lean capacities. Now, the Army is pivoting to rapidly expand capacities at orders of magnitude not seen in decades. This rapid expansion requires acquiring unique manufacturing equipment that can have long lead times of up to one to 2 years and the manufacturing locations are sometimes in remote locations that present significant workforce hiring challenges to meet the second and third shifts necessary to meet maximum production quantities.

In the area of artillery, a very large consumption item in Ukraine, the required volume of projectiles, propellants, explosives and the Load, Assemble and Pack (LAP) function are of concern. With the assistance of Congress, the resourcing being provided is enabling us to ramp up production as quickly as possible; however, required quantities of propellants and explosives are commodities to which the Army still needs to pay close attention. Global capacity for propelling charges and their associated supply chains have been taxed given the Ukraine demand signal and associated Army replenishment efforts. To that end, Multi-Year Procurement authority is being implemented in Fiscal Year 2023 that will help provide the Modular Artillery Charge System (MACS) LAP and MACS Metal Containers contracts with predictable and stable requirements.

Question. What measures does the Army propose to expand the supply and industrial base to support increased production of critical munitions?

Answer. The Army has three key lines of effort to increase production and deliveries of critical 155mm munitions. They are: (1) modernize the Organic Industrial Base; (2) expand and accelerate the commercial industrial base production capacity; and (3) leverage our foreign partners' capabilities and manufacturing capacities.

Also included in these lines of efforts is the on-shoring of select critical precursor energetic material that is currently only obtained through foreign sources.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR SHELLEY MOORE CAPITO

Question. What is the Army's plan to field hard-kill active protection systems (APS)?

Answer. The Army has fielded four Brigade Combat Team (BCT) sets of Trophy hard kill Active Protection Systems (APS) (Israeli, Rafael Systems) for Abrams platforms. The Army is also continuing with the platform integration and testing of the Iron Fist Light Decoupled (IF-LD) hard kill system (Israeli, Elbit Systems) for Bradley to support fielding one BCT set and are completing characterization of two other hard-kill APS solutions (Trophy MV, Rafael-ISR; and Strikeshield, Rheinmetall/GE/UBT (US, Michigan)) on test rigs to determine suitability for future ground combat vehicles. Further development of advanced active protection is continuing in the Science & Technology arena under the Combat Capabilities Development Command, which is the appropriate place for development, given the maturity levels of the technologies involved.

Question. Did the Army hold a competition for Abrams and Bradley APS capabilities, or was this a sole source award? If sole source, what was the rationale?

Answer. In 2016, a Department of Army memorandum provided a directed requirement to procure, and rapidly field Non-Developmental APS. To execute this, the Army leveraged existing competitive Science and Technology Other Transaction Authority APS proposals that had already been competed and selected under the National Advanced Mobility Consortium to begin characterization work of three systems for Abrams, Bradley, and Stryker. Additionally, a market survey was posted on FedBizOpps in 2017 to determine if other sources capable of satisfying an APS requirement on the Abrams and Bradley existed. Platform integration of the systems was subsequently performed either by government integration, or by the platform's Original Equipment Manufacturer on a sole source basis where insufficient technical data was available for competitive integration. The only system to enter production, Trophy, was awarded via a sole source contract to DRS SSI (St Louis, MO) based upon the sole responsible source exemption to the Federal Acquisition Regulation (6.302-1).

Question. Has the Army only proceeded with testing of foreign-made hard-kill APS solutions? If so, has this potential reliance on foreign sources raised concerns?

Answer. No, the Army has performed testing of numerous U.S. and foreign (industry and government) developed systems. Recent interim efforts associated with the Expedited Active Protection Systems (ExAPS) effort were informed by an extensive Office of the Secretary of Defense live fire evaluation of all available systems foreign (Trophy, Iron Fist) and domestic (Iron Curtain) that concluded in 2012. Subsequent development of hard-kill active protection systems under the Combat Capabilities Development Command's Ground Vehicle System Center is using U.S. sources where available.

Question. Is the Army open to further testing of a U.S. industry-developed hard-kill APS capability?

Answer. The Army has completed its assessment of available mature off-the-shelf active protection systems for Abrams and Bradley, having qualified installations for two systems and procured one (Trophy). The Army has yet to identify a system that is both suitable and mature enough to support Stryker. Continued development of advanced active protection is continuing in the Science & Technology arena under the Combat Capabilities Development Command. The Army is interested in industry solutions and test results; however, it is not currently resourced to test and verify every industry-claimed APS capability.

Question. Has observing the war in Ukraine raised any concerns about the vulnerability of U.S. armor to top attacks?

Answer. The Army Vehicle Protection community regularly collaborates with the Intelligence community to understand the threats observed in the Ukraine War (and elsewhere). Ongoing efforts exist within the development and acquisition communities to address a wide variety of top attack threats and those efforts continued to be informed by current world events.

Question. Does the Army plan to halt testing and development of hard-kill APS with industry partners in favor of a government-developed solution?

Answer. The Army remains committed to the development and testing of a Hard-Kill APS system, run by Combat Capabilities Development Command's Ground Vehicle System Center, in partnership with several companies from across the U.S. industrial base. Additionally, the Government continually evaluates available APS

technologies based upon their maturity, capability, and ability to support platform requirements in the full relevant environment.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED TO GENERAL JAMES C. McCONVILLE

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR JON TESTER

Question. For several years, this Subcommittee has criticized the Department for not having a robust plan to defend Guam against high-end air defense threats. So I am pleased that this year's budget includes a total of \$1.5 billion to accelerate this capability.

However, we need people and infrastructure to get this done right, and these efforts need to be coordinated across all the military services and with the Missile Defense Agency.

General McConville, The Army is requesting well over \$600 million this year for its portion of air defenses for Guam. Has the Army budgeted for the personnel to operate these systems as they arrive on the island? How is the Army coordinating its efforts with the Missile Defense Agency? How is the Army coordinating its efforts with the Missile Defense Agency?

Answer. Yes, the Army has incorporated the personnel requirements into our Total Army Analysis planning and will man and operate the Defense of Guam systems.

The Army and the Missile Defense Agency (MDA) have been coordinating the Defense of Guam efforts every step of the way since the 2022 National Defense Authorization Act. The Army and MDA co-led last year's Office of the Secretary of Defense, Defense of Guam Operational Planning Team that helped formulate Presidential Budget 24 and have continued to meet on a regular basis. The MDA participates in the biweekly program.

Executive Office (Missiles and Space) Defense of Guam Integrated Planning Team and the weekly U.S. Army Pacific (USARPAC)-led All Things Guam Operational Planning Team. The Army Staff and USARPAC Senior Leaders participate in MDA-led Senior Executive Review Group and MDA planning charrettes. The Army Staff also provides input to MDA's quarterly report to Congress and its in constant communication at the action officer and Senior Executive level.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR JERRY MORAN

Question. The Army's Unfunded Priorities list accompanying the FY24 budget request includes a compelling argument for adding \$530M to bring the total procurement of tanks to the full brigade level while lowering the unit cost of each tank greater than \$4.3M.

Please explain why the Army didn't include such funding in its budget request for this enduring platform.

Answer. The Army made the difficult choice to fund modernization efforts required to face near peer threats on the multi-domain battlefield. The base budget request maintains the production line and funds facility improvements at the Lima Tank Plant. The request included \$800.3M for 34 tanks (a battalion set) and \$105.8M for industrial base updates to facilitate production for a total of \$906.1M in procurement and an additional \$96.2M in Research Development Test & Evaluation (RDT&E) in FY 2024. The Abrams tanks we currently have in our formations (M1A1 SA, M1A2 SEPv2 and M1A2 SEPv3) remain the best in the world. The Unfunded Priorities List provides an option for the government to take advantage of the best available price point on Abrams if funding becomes available.

Question. We understand from the Department that the initial estimates for delivery of M1A2 Abrams tanks to Ukraine were about 1 year, but that will be sooner now that they have decided to ship M1A1 Abrams tanks instead.

Can you confirm whether the specific Abrams tanks have been identified?

Answer. Yes, the specific Abrams tanks that will eventually be provided to Ukraine have been identified. Additional details can be provided in a classified briefing.

Question. Please provide an update on the overall timeline for transfer, including where those tanks are and how the movement to Ukraine aligns with the training of Ukrainian troops.

Answer. The Department will begin delivery of the 31 tanks to Ukraine this fall, and earlier if possible. The tanks are now in the maintenance and conversion process to the proper combat configuration. The tanks are on schedule and their delivery is being synchronized to align with the training of Ukrainian forces.

QUESTION SUBMITTED BY SENATOR JOHN HOEVEN

Question. We want the best individuals to serve in the military and, as you know, educational benefits are one of the most effective ways to attract, retain, and develop outstanding Soldiers. Amongst many competing priorities, I applaud the Army for making tuition assistance a priority, including for those serving in the Army National Guard and Reserves.

How important is the Tuition Assistance Program to meeting the Army's recruiting and retention goals?

Answer. For many years, the Tuition Assistance (TA) program has consistently played a major role in supporting Army's recruiting and retention missions. In repeated surveys of new recruits, a majority report that education benefits, including Tuition Assistance (TA), are "very" to "extremely" influential on their enlistment decision. The Army knows from additional surveys and internal analyses that education benefits are repeatedly cited as a top reason for Soldier reenlistment. A 2021 study conducted by the Army's Office of Economic and Manpower Analysis (OEMA) found that TA usage is associated with a 9.5% increase in reenlistment among first term Soldiers.

SUBCOMMITTEE RECESS

Senator TESTER. This Defense Subcommittee will reconvene next Thursday, a week from this Thursday, on May 11, at 11 a.m. for a hearing with the Secretary of Defense and Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff. That will be an interesting hearing.

Until then, we stand in recess.

[Whereupon, at 11:27 a.m., Tuesday, May 2, the subcommittee was recessed, to reconvene at 11 a.m., Thursday, May 11.]

DEPARTMENT OF DEFENSE APPROPRIATIONS FOR FISCAL YEAR 2024

THURSDAY, MAY 11, 2023

U.S. SENATE,
SUBCOMMITTEE OF THE COMMITTEE ON APPROPRIATIONS,
Washington, DC.

The subcommittee met at 9 a.m. in room SD-124, Dirksen Senate Office Building, Hon. Jon Tester (chairman) presiding.

Present: Senators Tester, Durbin, Murray, Reed, Schatz, Shaheen, Murphy, Collins, Murkowski, Graham, Moran, and Boozman.

DEPARTMENT OF DEFENSE

OFFICE OF THE SECRETARY OF DEFENSE

STATEMENT OF HON. LLOYD J. AUSTIN III, SECRETARY

ACCOMPANIED BY HON. MICHAEL J. McCORD, UNDER SECRETARY OF DEFENSE (COMPTROLLER)/CHIEF FINANCIAL OFFICER

OPENING STATEMENT OF SENATOR JON TESTER

Senator TESTER. I want to call this hearing to order.

Good morning. I want to begin by welcoming our witnesses, Secretary Austin and General Milley. We appreciate your willingness to be in front of this committee this morning.

General Milley, this will be your last appearance before this subcommittee. I want to go off script here a little bit. You are the ultimate professional. You are somebody that has been very good for me and, I think I can say this for the whole committee, to work for with. You're a straight shooter and you've done a hell of a good job and I appreciate that and I just hope that the Senate will be able to find some common sense to be able to confirm your successor so that the department isn't forced to rely on an interim placeholder for your position because it's simply too important for that.

This is an unprecedented indefinite hold on military promotions that has frozen over 60 nominations and can affect as many as 650 by the end of the year.

I will tell you the people on this committee know what the threats are in this world, we need to be able to assist the military in being successful and this is not assisting the military to be successful. It is plain dangerous.

We are meeting today to discuss an \$842 billion budget request for next fiscal year. A few months ago, we passed the overdue

budget for this fiscal year of \$816 billion, which provided a \$74 billion increase over fiscal year 2022.

I bring up fiscal year 2022 because there are some who advocate for keeping all government spending at fiscal year 2022 levels.

In light of China's continued military aggression, that sounds plain irresponsible to me, but a majority in the other chamber proposes that.

It is my hope that today you can detail for us what such a drastic funding reduction would mean to our national defense.

Of course, all bets are off if we don't reach a bipartisan agreement on the debt soon. We have yet to deal with the debt in a responsible and a common sense way. I am hopeful that bipartisan talks can get going in earnest and that cooler heads will prevail before we come to a default.

The challenges we face are numerous. We need to solve the debt. We need to agree upon a top line for government spending. We need to agree on a top line for defense. We need to get qualified people into their jobs.

The risk of a government default is real. The risk of a government shutdown is real. The risk of a long-term CR (Continuing Resolution) is real, none which are good, by the way, and while we're busy fighting amongst ourselves, the Chinese continue their military buildup and aggressive behavior. The Russians continue their unjust war against Ukraine. Iran is continuing its malign influence in the Middle East and violent terrorist organizations plot to do us harm.

We have to get the budget done so that the men and women in uniform supported by the tireless civilians at the Department of Defense can go about their business of keeping us safe.

I support the ongoing efforts of Senators Murray and Collins who will work with anybody to get the job done. We will get to the specifics of your budget request here shortly, but my main question is are our troops getting what they need when they need it? Are we keeping up with our military modernization? Is industry spending taxpayer dollars wisely and delivering as promised because the truth is we can't afford to waste time and we can't afford to waste money.

Once again, I want to thank the witnesses for their testimony today. Before you make your opening remarks, I would turn it over to Senator Collins for her statement.

STATEMENT OF SENATOR SUSAN M. COLLINS

Senator COLLINS. Thank you very much, Chairman Tester, for holding this hearing on the fiscal year 2024 budget request for the Department of Defense.

General Milley, let me echo the Chairman's thanks and praise of you as you approach your retirement. Thank you for your more than 40 years of service to our country.

I am, however, not as confident as the Chairman that this is your last appearance before our subcommittee. So don't take any hope in that statement.

The Administration's 2022 National Defense Strategy rightly captures the importance of deterring China. I strongly support that objective and know that you both, the Secretary and General

Milley, have worked hard to develop a strategy-driven request within the top line that you were provided.

I also agree with Chairman Milley's written testimony that completing appropriations bills on time is a necessary condition to credibly deter China.

I would, however, suggest that it is not a sufficient condition and that the President's budget is inadequate to achieve this goal.

No matter how talented, innovative, and hard working our Armed Forces are, no matter how good their leadership, the military must also have a sufficient budget top line, and I have serious doubts that the Administration's budget request provides all of the resources necessary to deter an aggressive China and to deal with other global threats.

For example, the budget request would result in a smaller Navy, a fleet of 291 ships. This is five ships fewer than today's fleet of 296 ships and further from the Chief of Naval Operations' requirement which is informed by the INDOPACOM (Indo-Pacific Command) scenarios.

Moreover, China has the largest Navy in the world and is growing to 400 ships in the next 2 years. The story is very similar for the Air Force.

In the absence of a higher defense budget, this committee will have to fill in the gaps to deter China and to maintain readiness.

Let me highlight a few examples of what from my perspective is missing from the budget request. \$3.5 billion in INDOPACOM unfunded priorities, \$266 million to fund NORTHCOM (Northern Command) unfunded priorities to detect airborne targets, such as Chinese spy balloons, funding to replenish \$1 billion in presidential drawdown authority for Taiwan that Congress authorized last year.

The costs to fully implement what the Administration's own zero trust architecture policy to protect against insider cyber threats, the costs for the deployment of 1,500 Active Duty troops sent to the Southwest borders just this week, security assistance for Ukraine beyond September, and \$1.6 billion in under-budget fuel costs according to the Government Accountability Office analysis. That figure is 20 percent more than the budget request.

I recognize that fuel cost assumptions are driven by the White House, but last years' experience is instructive. If Congress had funded the department at the level that was requested last year by the Administration, our troops housing, food, healthcare, fuel, and readiness would be facing an \$8 billion inflation hole. That hole does not exist today because Congress insisted upon a higher and more realistic funding.

One final point on Ukraine about which I share the Chairman's commitment. It is critical that the Administration provide Ukraine with what it needs in time to defend and take back its sovereign territory. We expect the Administration not to wait until the 11th hour if the Ukrainians need more before the end of the fiscal year.

There are many issues for us to discuss today. Again, I thank all three of your witnesses for their extraordinary service and I look forward to discussing these issues with them.

Senator TESTER. Thank you, Senator Collins, for your statement. Secretary Austin, you have the floor.

SUMMARY STATEMENT OF HON. LLOYD J. AUSTIN III

Secretary AUSTIN. Thank you, sir.

Chairman Tester, Vice Chair Collins, and Distinguished Members of the Committee, I'm glad to be here with you to testify in support of the President's budget request for fiscal year 2024.

I'm joined as always by General Milley, and I remain grateful for his leadership and I'm also glad to be joined by the department's Comptroller and CFO (Chief Financial Officer) Mike McCord.

This is a strategy-driven budget and one driven by the seriousness of our strategic competition with the People's Republic of China.

At \$842 billion, it is 3.2 percent increase over fiscal year 2023-enacted and it is 13.4 percent higher than fiscal year 2022-enacted, and this budget will help us continue to implement our National Defense Strategy and the President's National Security Strategy.

Now I have three key priorities at the Pentagon: to defend our Nation, to take care of our outstanding people, and to succeed through teamwork.

The PRC (People's Republic of China) is our pacing challenge and we're driving hard to meet it. Our budget builds on our previous investments to deter aggression and we're investing in a more resilient force posture in the Indo-Pacific and increasing the scale and scope of our exercises with our partners.

This budget includes a 40 percent increase over last year's request for the Pacific Deterrence Initiative and it's an all-time high of \$9.1 billion. That will fund a stronger force posture, better defenses for Hawaii and Guam, and deeper cooperation with our allies and partners.

I look forward to being back next week before the full Senate Appropriations Committee to go into more depth on how we're working with our interagency partners to continue to outpace the PRC.

Now this budget also makes the department's largest-ever investments in both R&D (Research & Development) and procurement. We're requesting more than \$61 billion to sustain air dominance. That includes funding for fighters and extraordinary B-21 Strategic Bomber that I helped unveil last December.

We're also seeking more than \$48 billion for sea power, including new construction of nine battle force ships, and we're boosting capacity at America's shipyards to build the ships that our strategy demands.

We're investing a total of \$1.2 billion in the submarine industrial base and we're buying two Virginia Class attack submarines and one Columbia Class ballistic missile submarine.

On land, we're investing in air and missile defense and defenses to counter unmanned aerial vehicles. We're also requesting \$11 billion to deliver the right mix of long-range fires, including major investments in hypersonics. We'll also continue to modernize all three legs of our Nuclear Triad and bolster our strategic deterrence, and we put forward the largest space budget in Pentagon history. We've requested \$33.3 billion to improve our capabilities and our resilience in space.

Now let me again thank Congress for providing the department with multiyear procurement authorities and appropriations for critical munitions.

In this budget, we're requesting more multiyear procurement authorities and we're asking for more than \$30 billion to further invest in the industrial base and to buy the maximum number of munitions that American industry can produce.

This budget also moves us away from aging capabilities that aren't relevant to future conflicts so we can focus on the advances that our warfighters will need.

Now our National Defense Strategy calls out Putin's highly-aggressive Russia as an acute threat and under President Biden's leadership, the United States has rallied the world to help Ukraine fight Russia's indefensible invasion.

We reinforced NATO's (North Atlantic Treaty Organization's) defense and deterrence on Eastern Flank and our allies and partners have provided crucial security assistance, coordinated through the Ukraine Defense Contact Group that I lead.

We will support Ukraine's defense for as long as it takes and meanwhile the department remains vigilant against other persistent threats, including North Korea and Iran, and we will take all necessary measures to defend our troops and our interests overseas as seen from our air strikes in March against facilities linked to Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guards Corps.

We're also investing in over-the-horizon counter-terrorism capabilities. Now I know that you have been following the reports of unauthorized disclosure of sensitive and classified U.S. material.

I take this issue very seriously and I've ordered a comprehensive review of the department's security programs, policies, and procedures for safeguarding classified information. I've also discussed this issue with our allies and partners around the world. I've been struck by their solidarity and their commitment to reject efforts to divide us and we will not let anything fracture our unity.

Our Joint Force stands ready to meet any challenge. You could see the force's readiness after Russia's unprovoked invasion of Ukraine when we swiftly deployed elements of the 3rd Infantry Division to Poland to show up on NATO's Eastern Flank.

We closely monitor radios at the unit level and maintain response forces at our highest states of readiness while the rest of the force by design is preparing for future contingencies.

So this budget will help us maintain our readiness with a \$146 billion in funding for operations, training, and maintenance. This budget also invests in improving our readiness and resilience in the face of climate change and other 21st Century threats, and we are going to remain the strongest military in the world.

As we mark the 50th Anniversary of our all-volunteer force, I am enormously proud of the brave men and women who choose to wear the cloth of our Nation. We owe it to them and to their families to take the best possible care of our people and over the past 2 years we've made moves easier. We've cut commissary prices. We've made childcare more affordable, and this budget funds other key steps to increase the quality of life of our teammates, including the largest military and civilian pay raises in decades.

Now we're also pushing hard to eliminate suicide in our ranks, including immediate steps to hire more mental health professionals and improve access to mental healthcare.

Meanwhile, we're working toward a military that's free of sexual assault and we work with Congress to improve the response to sexual assault and related crimes under the Uniform Code of Military Justice and those reforms will be fully implemented by the end of this year.

And the department is also investing in a specialized workforce to combat sexual assault, harassment, suicide, and more.

Now the department's third priority is succeeding through teamwork. Our unrivaled network of allies and partners magnifies our power and expands our security, and in recent months our friends in the Indo-Pacific have taken major steps forward.

The Philippines has agreed to nearly double the number of sites where we cooperate together. Japan committed to double its defense spending and through the historic office partnership, we'll work with our Australian and British allies to build game-changing defense advantages that will deter aggression and boost our defense industrial capacity.

In sum, this is the budget that will meet this moment and I respectfully ask for your support and the single most effective way that this committee can support the department and our outstanding troops is with an on-time full year appropriation.

So I look forward to working with all of you so that we can continue to defend our democracy and support the forces of freedom in this hour of challenge.

Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

[The statement follows:]

PREPARED STATEMENT OF LLOYD J. AUSTIN III

Chairman Tester, Ranking Member Collins, distinguished members of the committee: thank you for the opportunity to testify in support of the President's budget request for Fiscal Year (FY) 2024.

On behalf of Deputy Secretary Hicks, the leadership of the Department of Defense, and our Service members, civilian workforce, and their families, let me also thank you for your continued support and partnership as we work to defend the United States. I also want to thank the Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, General Mark Milley, and the Department's Comptroller, Mike McCord, who are both testifying with me and are vital partners in realizing the Department's priorities.

The President's \$842 billion defense budget request for FY 2024 provides us with the capabilities and investments to advance our three key priorities: defending the nation, taking care of our people, and succeeding through teamwork.

This is a strategy-driven budget that provides the resources to continue to implement our 2022 National Defense Strategy (NDS) and the President's National Security Strategy. This budget will also enable us to strengthen our deterrent and defensive capabilities across domains, informed by our 2022 Nuclear Posture Review and our 2022 Missile Defense Review.

As President Biden has said, we are in a "decisive decade," and the choices that we make today will set our course for generations to come—not just for the United States but for the world. So the Department is rising to meet this moment, seizing on opportunities to outpace our competitors, strengthen our security, and move our world toward a more secure future.

As our National Defense Strategy makes clear, the People's Republic of China (PRC) is the Department's pacing challenge. To meet this challenge, the Department is honing new operational concepts, deploying cutting-edge capabilities, and making essential investments for the long term. This budget request shows it, including requests for the Department's largest procurement and R&D budgets ever—\$170 billion and \$145 billion respectively. And our budget request will also help us meet

the acute threat from Russia, as Russia's unprovoked war of choice against Ukraine is now in its second year.

To maintain our edge, this budget will invest in vital technological advancements for the Joint Force, while also reflecting the need to eliminate capabilities that no longer best serve our national defense. Such decisions can be difficult, but they will enable us to invest in the advanced programs that our security demands.

The Department is also intensely focused on taking care of our people, who remain our greatest asset. This budget invests in significant quality-of-life improvements, including the largest military pay raise in 22 years and the largest civilian pay raise in 43 years. We remain focused on continuing to recruit, retain, and develop the best talent from across the country to serve in both uniformed and civilian roles.

We owe it to our outstanding Service members, civilian employees, and their families to provide the support that they need to thrive. We also owe them environments that reward excellence, promote teamwork, and are free from harassment and abuse. So, we are implementing military justice reforms, fighting sexual assault, and redoubling our efforts to end suicide in our ranks. These challenges are personal priorities for me, and this budget paves the way for even more progress.

We rely on teamwork within our Department and beyond it—including with our interagency colleagues, Congress, the defense industrial base, and our peerless network of Allies and Partners worldwide. That network is a strategic advantage that no competitor can match. From rallying the world to support Ukraine's fight for freedom to conducting joint exercises in the Indo-Pacific with like-minded countries, our Allies and Partners are a huge force multiplier. They magnify our power, advance our shared security interests, and help uphold a world that is free, open, prosperous, and secure, and this budget will support the security partnerships that make America even stronger.

I have never been more confident in the power of our fighting force and the talents of our civilian workforce. The FY 2024 budget request will help ensure that we meet America's national security challenges and use this decisive decade to defend our democracy and forge a world of greater security, prosperity, and liberty. I therefore ask for your support of our budget and our mission as Congress writes authorizing and appropriations bills in the months ahead.

DEFENDING THE NATION

We are deeply aware of our responsibility to be responsible stewards of taxpayer dollars. This budget request has been carefully prepared to provide the resources for the objectives laid out in our 2022 NDS, Nuclear Posture Review, and Missile Defense Review.

The NDS directs the Department to act urgently to sustain and strengthen U.S. deterrence, with the PRC as our pacing challenge. The NDS also directs the Department to tackle the acute threat of Russia, as well as the persistent threats from Iran, the Democratic People's Republic of Korea (DPRK), and global terrorist groups.

The NDS clearly articulates our priorities: defend the homeland from the growing, multi-domain challenge posed by the PRC; deter strategic attacks against the United States, our Allies, and our Partners; deter aggression, while preparing to prevail in conflict if necessary, by prioritizing the PRC challenge in the Indo-Pacific, followed by the Russian challenge in Europe; and build a resilient Joint Force and defense ecosystem.

Within the Department, the NDS is our North Star, and we have aligned our processes, policies, and plans to implement it. The FY 2024 budget is the latest concrete manifestation of our strategy—and its deep recognition that the PRC presents a challenge now and in the years to come.

Prioritizing the PRC as Our Pacing Challenge

In recent decades, the PRC has demonstrated both the will and, increasingly, the economic, diplomatic, military, and technological power to reshape its region and the international order to suit its preferences. The United States will not let that happen. This budget will enable us to continue executing our strategy and outpacing the PRC, across all timeframes and domains.

Through the FY 2024 budget, we will strengthen U.S. deterrence and continue advancing new operational concepts, deploying cutting-edge capabilities across all domains, and investing in the innovations that we will need in the future. Through a \$9.1 billion request for the Pacific Deterrence Initiative, the largest ever, the Department is expanding the scope and scale of our activities to reinforce security and stability in the Indo-Pacific region, strengthen deterrence, and bolster our advantages and those of our Allies and Partners.

The Department is also investing in a more resilient posture across the Indo-Pacific region. For example, in Japan, Australia, Guam, and the Compact of Free Association States, we are forward-stationing and deploying more capable forces even as we make major infrastructure investments in airfields, logistics, domain awareness, and resilience. In addition, throughout Southeast Asia, we are executing rotational deployments, logistics cooperation, and targeted security assistance to strengthen our partnerships, deepen our interoperability, and enhance our collective readiness. This budget allows us to continue to support Taiwan's self-defense, consistent with our longstanding commitments enumerated in the Taiwan Relations Act, the three U.S.-PRC Joint Communiques, and the Six Assurances.

Across the Indo-Pacific region, we have increased the complexity and scale of our exercises and operations. In addition to building interoperability with our Allies and Partners, we are experimenting to build our warfighting advantages, which will help us further refine our operating concepts and investments. This budget request will enable us to continue that crucial work.

Meeting the Acute Threat of Russian Aggression

Russia's unprovoked further invasion of Ukraine poses a historic challenge to European and global security. Russia's campaign of conquest is also an attack on the rules-based international order that has helped to make the world safer and more secure since its creation in the aftermath of World War II. If Russia succeeds, it would send a message to other aggressor nations that they can attack and conquer their neighbors. With U.S. leadership, a broad coalition of Allies and Partners have rallied to help support Ukraine's defense of its sovereignty.

Over the past year, the United States has committed more than \$32 billion in game-changing security assistance to support Ukraine's fight against Russian aggression. This has helped meet Ukraine's most urgent needs—including for air defense, artillery systems, tanks and other armored vehicles, and other crucial capabilities—and it has translated to tangible gains on the battlefield. In the year since Russia's unjust war of aggression began, Ukraine's military forces have won the battles of Kyiv, Kharkiv, and Kherson—and they have inspired the world with their courage and resilience.

We will continue to support Ukraine's fight for freedom for as long as it takes. To keep pace with Ukraine's urgent security needs even as we maintain our own readiness, we are pushing to expand production from the defense industrial base. We are focused on increasing the resiliency of supply chains that are critical for national security. And we are focused on accountability of the security assistance that we have provided.

Our NATO Allies face a historic challenge from Putin's aggressive Russia, and we are making significant investments in bolstering European security. Those build on foundational investments in posture and presence that we have made in Europe since Russia's 2014 invasion of Ukraine and seizure of the Crimea region. These investments paid dividends in 2022 when we rapidly surged an additional 20,000 U.S. forces into the European theater to deter Russian aggression and reassure our NATO Allies. With little advance notice, the United States deployed additional combat power, repositioned U.S. forces already in Europe, and integrated deploying forces with prepositioned stocks of munitions and supplies. Our continued investments in posture and presence in Europe help deter Russian aggression against NATO—now and in the future.

Tackling Advanced and Persistent Threats

We remain vigilant against the advanced and persistent threats from the DPRK, Iran, and global terrorist organizations.

We continue to shore up security on the Korean Peninsula despite the DPRK's provocations, including through bilateral and trilateral cooperation. We will continue to stand with our Allies, the Republic of Korea (ROK) and Japan. We remain steadfast and ironclad in our extended deterrence commitments to the ROK and Japan, and we continue to demonstrate our ability to respond rapidly and firmly to any DPRK provocation. We are working to strengthen and modernize our alliances with the ROK and Japan and will continue to ensure that our forces in and around the Korean Peninsula are ready to "Fight Tonight" in the event of DPRK aggression.

Iran's nuclear program, its dangerous proxies, its support for terrorism, its cyber threats, and its proliferation of one-way attack unmanned aerial systems (UAS) all undermine Middle East security and threaten U.S. forces and Partners. We have acted decisively when Iran-backed militia groups have attacked U.S. forces in Iraq and Syria. As Iran deepens its partnership with Russia, including Russian military support to Tehran in return for Iranian one-way attack UAS to deploy in Ukraine, we are developing and fielding effective approaches to counter the proliferating

threats from Iran's UAS. This budget request seeks to tackle these persistent challenges through investments in integrated air and missile defense, maritime domain awareness, and counter-UAS systems. We have repeatedly demonstrated our ability to deploy combat-credible forces into the region to deter potential Iranian aggression, and we will continue to take necessary and proportionate military action to defend U.S. forces and facilities from attack, or threat of attack, from Iran or Iran-backed proxies. The United States will support and strengthen partnerships with countries that subscribe to the rules-based international order, and we will make sure those countries can defend themselves against foreign threats. These actions have the added benefit of demonstrating our commitment to the region's security that will offset the efforts by external powers to reshape the region in their interest and to our detriment.

Meanwhile, ISIS, al-Qa'ida, and other terrorist groups continue to threaten the security of the United States, our citizens, and our Partners in the Middle East, Africa, and South Asia. We are investing in a modernized, over-the-horizon counterterrorism architecture to prevent future attacks on our citizens and the U.S. homeland, and we have proven our continued ability to remove the most threatening al-Qa'ida and ISIS operatives from the battlefield.

One legislative authority that is key to our ability to tackle these advanced and persistent threats—Section 702 of the Foreign Intelligence Surveillance Act—expires at the end of this year. Section 702 provides essential, irreplaceable insights on the activities of critical foreign targets. The loss of this authority, or its renewal in diminished or unusable form, would profoundly damage the Department's ability to see and mitigate some of the most profound threats against the United States as well as its Allies and Partners. Reauthorization is therefore a matter of utmost priority. Along with our colleagues in the Intelligence Community and the Department of Justice, we look forward to working with this Committee and others, in order to secure Section 702's extension.

Innovating and Modernizing

The FY 2024 budget request will enable the Department to develop, acquire, and modernize across all domains to address all the above challenges, especially our competition with the PRC.

To maintain and expand our advantage over the PRC, we need to modernize not just our weapons systems but also our operational concepts and the ways that we do business. To operate effectively in a dynamic security environment, the Department is prioritizing investments to maintain a ready warfighting capability, build a skilled defense workforce, and work more effectively with our Allies and Partners.

A safe, secure, and effective U.S. nuclear deterrent is the ultimate backstop to deter strategic attacks on our country and our allies. The Department is committed to maintaining and modernizing our nuclear triad, while seeking to reduce the role of nuclear weapons in U.S. national strategy. The FY 2024 budget request, including an investment of \$37.7 billion in FY 2024, fully funds the nuclear triad and nuclear command, control, and communications, demonstrating our commitment to maintain reliable and effective legacy systems while pursuing their timely replacements.

The Department is also accelerating investments in cutting-edge defense capabilities, such as uncrewed systems that can operate on the water, underwater, in the air, and on land. Integrating human-machine teaming, autonomous systems, and resilient networks will make our operations significantly faster, more lethal, and more survivable.

The FY 2024 budget request includes \$30.6 billion specifically for our munitions enterprise. It invests in modernizing and growing our munitions industrial base and expanding production capacity and procurement quantities. The Department is seeking to use the unprecedented multiyear procurement authorities provided by Congress to affordably acquire critical munitions, while bolstering our inventories and providing our industry partners with a more predictable "demand signal."

The FY 2024 budget request makes long-term investments of \$33.3 billion in the resilience of our space architecture in the event of an attack. These investments will further expand and diversify constellations for space sensing and communications resilience, as well as augmenting our space warfighting capabilities. These steps will drive even deeper cooperation with the robust American commercial space sector.

In the cyberspace domain, this budget request makes targeted investments to speed the development and management of new cyber tools. This will help us integrate our sequentially developed Cyber Mission Force capabilities. It will also aid our transition to, and sustainment of, advanced cyber capabilities from the Department's Science and Technology (S&T) activities. These efforts will enhance the interoperability and effectiveness of our Joint Cyberspace Warfighting Architecture and

maintain an efficient pipeline from America's world-class cyber- innovation workforce into the Department's cyberspace operations forces.

The Department is also adapting to America's changing labor market to ensure that we have the right team to execute the NDS. This budget funds a new civilian cyber workforce-incentive program to target skill gaps, and it develops a curriculum of advanced cyber training for our military. We are also increasing investments in international research partnerships on critical technologies with our Allies and Partners.

Our technological superiority is not a given; we have to work for it every day. That includes rapid prototyping and commercial integration. So, the Department is investing in tomorrow's technology, such as responsible cutting-edge artificial intelligence, enhancing our critical supply chains, and modernizing our testing and training capabilities.

The Department continues to vigorously develop and test advanced weapons prototypes. Against the backdrop of our recent successful flight tests, the FY 2024 budget request expands the development of several hypersonic weapons programs, as well as demonstration and testing activities. This budget will also improve our subsonic cruise missiles to ensure their effectiveness against rapidly changing threats and targets.

The Department is pursuing a range of initiatives to harden U.S. basing and ensure that it is resilient against air and missile attacks. For example, we have made major investments in missile defenses for Guam and Hawaii, as well as infrastructure improvements across the entire Indo-Pacific region.

This budget request also funds the advancement of our joint warfighting concepts and the rapid experimentation and fielding of emerging capabilities across all domains. Ultimately, these initiatives will ensure a Joint Force that is increasingly agile, innovative, interoperable with allies and partners, and resilient.

After decades of combat and coalition experience for our Special Operations Forces (SOF) in recent conflicts, we are pioneering new SOF approaches to help meet today's primary challenges. This budget enables our SOF enterprise to continue to modernize its crisis-response capabilities, while developing creative, adaptable, and asymmetric options that ensure our Joint Force will present a range of dilemmas to our adversaries.

The Department will also expand the Pacific Multi-Domain Training and Experimentation Capability, which will help our forces train in the ways and places they may be called upon to fight. These investments boost our readiness and lay the foundation for advances in sensor-to-shooter networks that will multiply our forces' lethality. To improve the speed and global integration of our operational decision-making, we will deliver proven Joint All Domain Command and Control enhancements to our warfighters by 2027.

The FY 2024 budget is rooted in the recognition that our competitors and adversaries are not standing still, and we must make the right investments now to retain our technological advantages in the decades to come.

The Department will continue to draw on America's longstanding strategic advantages by investing in critical innovations—such as quantum computing, advanced materials, renewable energy projects, integrated networks, and future-generation wireless technology. To maintain the United States' position as the global leader in research and development, we are cultivating a strong, adaptive, and highly skilled workforce of scientists and engineers through programs like the Science, Mathematics, and Research for Transformation scholarship-for-service program.

Investing to Win Across All Domains

On land, the FY 2024 budget continues to build a combat-credible, ready, and lethal Army that can tackle challenges around the world. Our budget request seeks to strengthen Army capabilities in the Indo-Pacific region, with significant investments in our air and missile defenses as well as land-based long-range fires. We are also revitalizing and strengthening the Army's Organic Industrial Base by modernizing the Army's arsenals, maintenance depots, and ammunition facilities.

The FY 2024 budget builds on past investments in the Marine Corps Force Design 2030 concept, which focused on fielding capabilities and updating the Corps' force structure in the Indo-Pacific region. It also makes important new investments in electronic-warfare capabilities, command and control systems, air and missile defenses, and ground-force survivability, as well as in training and exercises.

At sea, this request helps deliver a ready and formidable naval force focused on deterring potential aggression from the PRC. The budget request continues the transition of our naval force to Distributed Maritime Operations, with an increased focus on uncrewed surface and underwater vehicles. Our request expands investments in long-range fires, more advanced weapons systems, and next-generation platforms,

including development of the *COLUMBIA*-class submarine. The Department also continues its critical investments in the submarine- construction industrial base; we will begin investing in better submarine-maintenance capacities, and we will increase our investments in the optimization of our shipyard infrastructure to make our industrial base healthier and more capable of meeting future needs. The budget request continues to move the Navy away from systems that are ill-suited for operations in highly contested environments.

In the air domain, the FY 2024 budget request makes significant investments to ensure air dominance in future conflicts. This includes F-35 and F-22 aircraft modernization, next-generation fighter development, and autonomous combat collaborative aircraft. These investments complement global strike capabilities such as the B-21 family of systems. The budget request invests in the development of strategic nuclear capabilities, such as Sentinel and the Long-Range Stand Off weapon. It also prioritizes long-range fires like hypersonic weapons, as well as a modern air command-and-control framework, rapid global mobility, and improved electronic warfare capabilities. To fully realize the tremendous advantages offered by our next-generation fighter and bomber platforms, we are investing in air-launched weapons that offer greater range, speed, precision, flexibility, and lethality. We are also closing shortfalls in supplying critical munitions by accelerating procurement where feasible, as well as expanding and procuring additional production capacity for our top-priority air-launched weapons. Moreover, this budget request continues to responsibly make the transition away from air- weapons systems that do not support our strategy, even as we invest in the maintenance and development of more advanced systems.

In the space domain, we continue to build our advantages over our competitors by investing in missile warning and tracking, data transport, communications, and space sensing. This budget request also funds upgrades to our launch infrastructure to support more government and commercial launches. Consistent with our recently completed Space Strategic Review, additional investments will deter hostile uses of space, and if deterrence fails, ensure that we can prevail in conflict in this domain, too.

This budget also strengthens our cyberspace operations force, which persistently engages both state and non-state cyber actors seeking to harm the United States, its interests, and its Allies. It upgrades our cyber operations training platform, accelerates the use of cloud-based capabilities, and invests in rapidly modernizing the software and hardware needed to further fortify our cyber posture.

Finally, over the past 3 years of the COVID-19 pandemic, we have seen the massive impact that biological threats can inflict on our country. Accordingly, the President's FY 2024 budget will enhance our ability to address any future pandemics or other biological threats.

Meeting the Climate Crisis

As the NDS makes clear, climate change is increasingly shaping the context in which the Department operates. That places new demands on the Joint Force, with implications for our readiness. Climate change is also creating new potential points of friction in places such as the Arctic, while affecting security relationships with Allies and Partners around the world. We are determined to ensure that the United States can meet and deal with these challenges.

This budget therefore invests in enhancing operational capability, mission resilience, and readiness. This includes programs that mitigate the risk of energy supply disruptions to critical military facilities—whether caused by extreme weather, cyber operations, or kinetic attack. The budget request also includes funding to improve the energy efficiency of combat operations and platforms while deploying new technology to improve lethality and mitigate logistics risk in contested environments. Throughout, our focus is on building our operational advantages. These are not only essential steps for the climate of the world that we share, but also strategic moves to defend our country and strengthen our military.

TAKING CARE OF OUR PEOPLE

The U.S. military is without a doubt the strongest fighting force in human history, and we remain determined to keep it that way. The foundation of that strength is our people. The Department is deeply committed to taking care of our total workforce by growing our talent, building resilience and readiness in the force, ensuring accountable leadership, and tackling even the most difficult workforce challenges.

This budget prioritizes our ongoing actions to take care of our outstanding Service members, and their families, including by increasing Service member and civilian employee compensation, raising housing allowance, and improving military housing. The budget also helps make quality childcare more accessible and affordable, includ-

ing through the launch of universal pre-kindergarten at all Department of Defense Education Activity schools. We are also making investments to fight a range of problematic and harmful behaviors. That includes continued efforts to combat sexual assault and sexual harassment, reform the military justice system, and prevent suicide in the Force.

Growing Our Talent

To defend our Nation's security, we must tap into the talent that exists all across our Nation. We must recruit and retain the best of America, building pathways of opportunity for all qualified patriots who seek to serve. In this budget, we continue to provide our force with exceptional opportunities for service and professional development. This means being the employer of choice for personnel with technological skills, mastery of foreign languages, and more. We are also investing in training and education, as well as creating scholarships for science, technology, engineering, and math. We will continue to deepen the Department's partnerships with America's best universities, paving the way for the next generation of leaders. I am proud that the Department recently established its first university-affiliated research center at an Historically Black College and University—just one of the many ways that we are building new ways for talented Americans to join our team.

Building Resilience and Readiness

Ensuring the safety, health, and well-being of our Service members is a sacred trust—and a matter of readiness. We know that when economic challenges hit our teammates where they live, it can make it even harder to serve. However, we also know that when we take care of our Service members and ensure they are well trained and well equipped, they continue to serve.

So, in addition to robustly funding the factors that immediately contribute to readiness—training, equipping, and maintaining—we have made continued investments to support our Service members and their families, launching targeted initiatives to bring down daily costs for Service members. Those efforts have made childcare more accessible and affordable, lowered prices in the commissary system and made access to affordable food easier through online ordering, eased moving costs, and increased opportunities for spousal employment and career mobility including through the launch of the Military Spouse Career Accelerator Pilot, a paid fellowship for military spouses that allows employers to connect with this diverse and talented pool of talent. We have also raised pay and allowances across the board. The FY 2024 budget will support a 5.2% pay raise for our Service members and our civilian employee workforce—the largest pay raise in decades. The FY 2024 budget also invests in full day pre-kindergarten at all Department of Defense Education Activity schools, providing our military children an essential head start on their education. There is no greater testament to the resilience and readiness of our force than the historically high retention rates across the Services.

Ensuring Accountability

The Department of Defense is committed to the health, safety, and well-being of our Service members and will not tolerate prohibited harmful behavior. This is a leadership issue, and we will lead. In February 2021, I ordered the creation of a 90-day independent review commission (IRC) on sexual assault in the military. The Department, including the Military Services, are now implementing the IRC recommendations that I approved.

The Department also worked with the President and Congress to enact historic legislation improving the response to sexual assault, domestic violence, and related crimes under the Uniform Code of Military Justice. The Offices of Special Trial Counsel, newly established to prosecute these crimes with independence and specialized expertise, will reach full operating capability in December 2023.

We will continue to work relentlessly to end sexual assault and related crimes, including through investments in a specialized prevention workforce and through important tools like the On-Site Installation Evaluations, which help us identify where our efforts are working and where more support is urgently needed.

The Department remains focused on efforts to eliminate suicide in the ranks and to respond better when these tragedies occur. This budget makes a significant investment in suicide prevention, and we are accelerating efforts to expand and increase access to mental healthcare, to including increased hiring and training of mental health professionals, to ensure that our Service members can access the help they need when they need it.

SUCCEEDING THROUGH TEAMWORK

Our world is increasingly defined by strategic competition, profound technological change, and 21st century challenges that pay no heed to borders. In this changing strategic environment, the United States is far stronger because of the power of our like-minded Allies and Partners, the improvements in industrial exchanges with our friends, the integration and development of innovation, and the interoperability of our forces. Our cooperation with Allies and Partners is central to co-developing advanced capabilities and rushing tangible improvements to our warfighters. These are strategic advantages that no rival can match. The Department is deeply committed to further strengthening our work with the Allies and Partners who magnify our might.

The AUKUS Partnership

The historic AUKUS partnership breaks new ground in working with two of our closest Allies—Australia and the United Kingdom—to take on the threats of the 21st century, just as we did together in the 20th century. As the President outlined in his State of the Union address, we are building bridges between Partners in the Pacific and those in the Atlantic, and AUKUS is a generational opportunity at the center of this change. This initiative translates our strategy into action, and it helps to forge a more advantageous balance of power in the Indo-Pacific, where the United States, Australia, and the United Kingdom are actively strengthening deterrence across the region. AUKUS will enhance our collective military capabilities, especially in the advanced technologies that we believe will be critical for security and stability in the future.

On March 13, 2023, the President announced our plans for the first major initiative of AUKUS: providing Australia with a conventionally armed, nuclear powered submarine capability. This phased approach will allow us provide this capability on the fastest possible timeline, while upholding the highest standards for nuclear stewardship and setting a precedent that strengthens the nonproliferation regime. As the President made clear, our three nations are making concrete commitments to each other, and we are backing these commitments up with significant investments to strengthen the industrial bases of each of our nations.

Allies and Partners in the Indo-Pacific Region

In the Indo-Pacific region, we continue to build and strengthen our peerless network of alliances and partnerships. Recent progress only underscores the enormous value of our Allies and Partners in the region.

For example, we are working closely with Japan to expand the roles and missions of our alliance. We are forward-deploying more versatile, resilient, and mobile U.S. capabilities even as we enhance Japan's capabilities, including in counterstrike, unmanned vehicles, and counter-hypersonic weapons. We are also increasing our trilateral cooperation among the United States, Japan, and Australia, further demonstrating regional commitment to a free and open Indo-Pacific region.

We are working with the ROK to ensure that our combined forces are able to deter the DPRK and help ensure peace and stability in Northeast Asia, including by returning our defensive exercises to historical norms.

In Australia, we have built a deep partnership on technology and the development of advanced capabilities, including space cooperation and space domain awareness. We are continuing the rotational presence of U.S. capabilities through Australia, across the air, land, and maritime domains. Working alongside our ally, we are identifying locations to support enhanced U.S. presence with necessary infrastructure improvements. In 2022, we also announced that we will preposition munitions and fuel to support U.S. capabilities in Australia.

In the Philippines, we are modernizing the U.S.-Philippine Alliance by enhancing maritime cooperation, improving interoperability and information sharing, and adding four important new locations under the Enhanced Defense Cooperation Agreement. These steps underscore our unwavering commitment to the Mutual Defense Treaty with the Philippines.

In Thailand, we are continuing to strengthen the long-standing U.S.-Thai alliance. Our annual Cobra Gold exercise, for example, contributes immeasurably to peace, security, and stability in the Indo-Pacific, while ensuring we are prepared to respond rapidly and effectively to a humanitarian disaster.

Meanwhile, with India, we are advancing our Major Defense Partnership and launching a new chapter in U.S.-India ties. The Department is bolstering the Indian military's deterrent capabilities to ensure that India remains the preeminent power in the Indian Ocean and can help uphold a favorable balance of power across the wider Indo-Pacific region. We are committed to working closely with India on technology cooperation; deepening our interoperability across key defense and security

domains, including space and cyberspace; and ensuring that the U.S.-India partnership supports the efforts of our broader network of like-minded Allies and Partners, especially the Quad.

European Security Cooperation and Support to Ukraine

Under President Biden's leadership, the United States has changed the course of history by surging critical security assistance to Ukraine over the past year. With the support of Congress, our response to Russia's full-scale reprehensible assault on its peaceful and democratic neighbor has provided historic levels of security assistance to Ukraine through a combination of Presidential Drawdown Authority and the Ukraine Security Assistance Initiative. The United States has also rallied like-minded countries around the world to support Ukraine's brave defenders. The engine of our efforts is the Ukraine Defense Contact Group, the coalition of some 50 countries that I convene regularly to spur and coordinate support to Ukraine. Our Allies and Partners have collectively committed approximately \$20 billion in security assistance to Ukraine, including hundreds of tanks, thousands of other armored vehicles, vital air-defense systems, hundreds of artillery systems, and other crucial capabilities.

In the face of the biggest threat to European security since the height of the Cold War, the NATO Alliance is more united than ever. We have moved urgently with our Allies to further fortify NATO and bolster its defenses on its eastern flank. Our commitment to Article Five of the North Atlantic Treaty remains ironclad. We will not be dragged into Putin's war of choice, but we will stand with Ukraine as it fights to defend itself, and we will continue to strengthen NATO's collective defense and deterrence.

Building Teamwork at Home

Our partners at the Federal, state, local, tribal, and territorial levels provide essential support for our Service members and their families, caregivers, and survivors at military installations and communities around the country. The Department is committed to working even more closely with these vital partners. Meanwhile, our Service members continue to proudly support our fellow Americans in times of crisis, as they have this year during natural disasters and amidst the lingering COVID-19 pandemic.

At the same time, we are supporting our Federal, state, local, tribal, and territorial partners' efforts to become more resilient and less reliant on Department of Defense support. Increased national resilience will ensure that America stands ready should an adversary choose to test our will with cyber or kinetic attacks on the U.S. homeland.

In addition, our partners in industry remain an engine of innovation—one that ensures that our warfighters remain ready to tackle the security challenges of this century. Our budget request will shore up our defense industrial base, strengthen its ability to produce the capabilities that we need, and develop critical technologies for the future.

It is the honor of my lifetime to lead our exceptional and dynamic team at the Department of Defense. We continue to strengthen our internal processes to ensure that we make timely decisions based on rigorous cooperation among civilian and military teams across the Department and with our interagency partners. We will demonstrate that spirit of partnership at the highest levels, and we will expect it from every person in the Department.

CONCLUSION

The way that we respond to today's challenges will help determine America's course for generations to come. The Department is seizing this inflection point in history. We will never flinch in the defense of the democracy that we have vowed to protect, and we will take care of all of the extraordinary patriots who comprise the world's strongest fighting force.

The FY 2024 budget enables us to deliver on these priorities, and we ask for your support as we build the Department of the future. We remain deeply committed to working with Congress on oversight and appropriations to ensure that we have the resources that our Total Force needs and deserves—today, tomorrow, and in the future.

We will be good stewards of those resources, for both warfighters and taxpayers. Defense reform will ensure that we use taxpayer dollars efficiently by modernizing our business processes, improving our financial and contract management, and completing the Department's audit. Above all, our accountability to both our own forces and the American public is core to our democracy and sets us apart from our competitors on the world stage.

Finally, we are grateful for our extraordinary Soldiers, Sailors, Airmen, Marines, Guardians, their families, caregivers, and survivors, and civilian employees. They are the foundation of America's strength, and we are honored to serve alongside them. Thank you.

Senator TESTER. Thank you, Secretary Austin.
General Milley, you have the floor.

STATEMENT OF GENERAL MARK A. MILLEY, CHAIRMAN OF THE JOINT CHIEFS OF STAFF

General MILLEY. Chairman Tester and Vice Chair Collins, and Distinguished Members of the Committee, thank you for the opportunity to testify before you today.

I've been privileged to defend this country for 43 years in uniform and next month I'll start my 44th year and hopefully, Senator Collins, this is my last posture hearing.

I thank Congress for your support to our military for the last four decades, not just for this budget but for four consecutive decades you've given great support to our military and I thank you all for that.

We could not be the military we are today without the support of the American people and the American people's representatives.

So what I ask for you today is that once again you approve an on-time budget.

I'm honored to represent the Joint Force and their families alongside the leadership of Secretary Austin and Under Secretary McCord both. I've been working with them both for many, many years and their leadership has been superlative.

Our Joint Force today is the most lethal and capable military in the world because of your support. The military's purpose is simple. It's to defend the United States against all enemies foreign and domestic and there is no other purpose for our military.

Fundamental to this is deterrence. More specifically, to deter great power war. To do this, our Number 1 priority is readiness now and readiness in the future and there is no other Number 1 priority.

The Joint Force will accomplish this with the fiscal year 2024 budget request of \$842 billion. Right now, the international system is under increasing stress. Both China and Russia have the means to threaten our interests and our way of life but war with China or Russia is neither imminent nor inevitable.

The PRC remains our Number 1 long-term geostrategic security challenge and it's been pointed out in our National Defense Strategy as the pacing challenge. The PRC has publicly stated that it intends to be the regional hegemon in Asia within the next 10 years and to exceed the United States overall military capability by mid-century.

Chinese actions are moving it on a path toward potential confrontation with its neighbors or the United States, but again war with China is neither inevitable nor imminent.

Additionally, Russia is an acute threat and remains very dangerous, especially under current conditions. Over a year ago, Russia undertook a war against Ukraine, threatening peace on the European Continent and global stability for the first time since the end of World War II.

We are supporting Ukraine to protect its sovereignty and supporting NATO with a force presence in every single nation on NATO's Eastern Flank.

Iran threatens to push the Middle East yet again into instability by supporting terrorists and proxy forces and they continue to improve their capability to produce a nuclear weapon.

From the time of Iranian decision by the Supreme Leader Iran could produce enough fissile material for a nuclear weapon in less than 2 weeks from time of decision and it would only take several more months to produce an actual nuclear weapon.

The United States policy remains the same and the United States remains committed that Iran will not have a nuclear weapon.

North Korea's continued ballistic missile testing and nuclear weapons development also pose threats to our homeland and our allies and partners, but we stand with the Republic of Korea shoulder to shoulder to deter North Korean aggression as we have for 70 years.

Terrorists continue to operate around the globe, threatening fear, destruction, and destabilization.

In short, the United States military stands ready to protect our Nation's interests and the American people.

We are currently standing watch on freedom's frontier with nearly a quarter of a million, 250,000, deployed troops around the world today, 5,000 sorties of United States Air Force and Naval and Marine aircraft and Army aircraft per day, a hundred ships at sea on a given day, and we never fight alone.

A key source of our strength is our large network of alliance and partnerships, and lastly our operational readiness rates are higher now than they've been in many, many years.

Currently, 60 percent of our Active force is the highest states of readiness and could deploy to combat in less than 30 days, well exceeding the minimum one-third standard we established many years ago.

Ten percent of our force, 10 percent of the United States military could deploy to combat in less than 96 hours. Examples of that, the President of the United States a year ago ordered the United States military to react to the unprovoked aggression by Russia. We deployed one core, two divisions, three brigade combat teams under the Army. We doubled the amount of fighter squadrons, and we doubled the amount of ships and submarines in the European theater of operations and we did that in 35 days. That doesn't happen by accident.

Another example just a few weeks ago, the President ordered the United States military to evacuate more than 70 governing personnel from Khartoum in a joint operation and so far the United States along with our allies and partners have facilitated the departure of more than 1,300 American citizens out of Sudan. That operation put Naval Special Operations forces on the ground, delivered by Army Special Operations aircraft, with U.S. Air Force support above with fixed wing fighter bombers, Army Rangers and a Quick Reaction Force, United States Marine Corps, and Vertical Lift and Reserve, and five U.S. Naval vessels off the coast along with National Guard in Djibouti ready to go.

That was a joint operation in support of 18th Airborne Corps and the AFRICOM (Africa Command) Headquarters as part of a whole of government effort to support the Department of State alongside many of our allies.

All of that was planned, coordinated, synchronized, and executed from a cold start. Our force can rapidly project flexible, responsive power anywhere around the globe and no adversary should ever doubt that.

Your military, the United States military, is ready. However, the Joint Forces are at an inflection point and we must balance operations, readiness, and modernization. We must not allow ourselves to create the false trap that we can either modernize or focus only on today. We must do both. We must integrate advanced technologies, including precision long-range fires, hypersonic weapons, quantum computing, artificial intelligence, robotics, and all the main sensors.

The time is now. We have very little margin to wait and the common thread critical to all of this is our people. We must continue investing in their training, their education, and their talent management.

I urge Congress to support this budget significant pay raise, healthcare, housing, and childcare initiatives.

The only thing more expensive than preparing for war is actually fighting a war. It is much cheaper to prevent war. This budget will significantly improve our military's current and future readiness in order to prevent war. We must act with a sense of urgency to deter war.

Thank you and I look forward to your questions.

[The statement follows:]

PREPARED STATEMENT OF GENERAL MARK A. MILLEY

After 43 years in uniformed service, 4 years as Chief of Staff of the Army, and 3.5 years as Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, this will be my last set of posture hearings. I want to thank the Congress up front for your continued support to our military, not only this year but every year for the last 4 decades. We would not have a military without the generous support of the American people and their elected representatives. Thank you for what you have done and, yet again, I ask that you support this year's request with an on-time budget approval.

I am honored to represent the Soldiers, Sailors, Airmen, Marines, Guardians, and their families of the United States Joint Force. They are the most lethal and capable military in the world. Our troops are the best led, best equipped, and best trained force anywhere because of your support. Side by side with our allies and partners, 250,000 American Soldiers, Sailors, Airmen, Marines, and Guardians are standing watch on land, sea, air, and space in 158 countries and conducting operations every day of the year to keep Americans safe.

The United States military is a key component of our national power. In concert with our diplomatic corps, economic organizations, and democratic institutions, we support efforts to sustain a stable and open international system. This hard and soft power provides a range of options to this legislative body and the Commander-in-Chief. Our strength deters adversaries and preserves peace. Although, if deterrence fails, the United States military is prepared to fight and win against those who attack the United States or our vital interests.

The Joint Force appreciates the work that our elected representatives do to ensure that we have the resources needed to train, equip, and man the force in order to be ready. The increased level of military funding beyond last fiscal year will ensure we continue future modernization while simultaneously meeting the national security readiness requirements of today.

The Joint Force will deliver modernization of our armed forces and security to the people of the United States at the FY 2024 budget request of \$842 billion. The people of the United States, through this body, have committed significant funding and

we will work diligently to ensure it is spent prudently in the best interest of this Nation. This budget will enable the investments and transformations necessary to build the Joint Force of 2030 and beyond.

In alignment with the National Defense Strategy (NDS) and National Military Strategy (NMS), this budget delivers a ready, agile, and capable Joint Force that will defend the Nation, while taking care of our people, and working with our partners and allies. There are direct linkages from the NDS and NMS to the Joint Warfighting Concept (JWC) which describes how we will employ and succeed as a Joint Force. The JWC is threat informed and fully integrated into our resourcing and requirements processes to build the force required for the future.

Stable, predictable, and timely budgets are critical for this Nation's defense. The passage of these budgets enables proper planning, prioritization, and programmatic investments necessary for continued progress. Continuing resolutions risk future modernization and impair our ability to meet our missions.

Preventing great power war through readiness and deterrence is very expensive but not as expensive as fighting a war and the only thing more expensive than fighting a war is losing a war. This budget is a significant step in the right direction to ensure that the United States military maintains the current readiness and develops the future modernization necessary to deter war and, if deterrence fails, to fight and win.

STRATEGIC ENVIRONMENT

The People's Republic of China (PRC): War with the PRC is neither imminent nor inevitable, however the potential for armed conflict is growing. The PRC remains our #1 long-term geostrategic security challenge. Since the reforms of Deng Xiaoping in 1979, the world has witnessed the greatest geopolitical shift in economic power in over 100 years. In the wake of the PRC's economic growth has come a rapidly increasing PRC military capability. Using economic and military hard power, the PRC's goal is to revise the global international order by midcentury, and it intends to be the regional hegemon in Asia within the next 10 years. Its intention is to exceed the United States' military capability within the Western Pacific in the next decade and to exceed the United States' global military capability by 2049.

The PRC continues to take increasingly aggressive actions to reshape the Indo-Pacific region and revise the global order. It is making significant economic investments in its military to improve technology and modernize its military forces. The PRC continues to challenge the stability and security in the Pacific as well as across the globe. Through economic coercion, the PRC is expanding its global footprint and increasing its ability to project military power at range and scale. It is aggressively modernizing its military in order to protect its authoritarian interests and are prepared to use force if required. The PRC seeks to strengthen its hard power enabling the PRC to coerce others with militarily might. These PRC actions continue to move it down the path towards confrontation and potential conflict.

The PRC remains focused on revising the global international order by midcentury. In short, the PRC continues to develop significant nuclear, space, cyber, land, sea, and air capabilities. It is working every day to close the technology gap with the United States and our allies. We must maintain our military superiority over the PRC in all the domains of war if we are to preserve the great power peace of the last 80 years. The PRC represents a real and growing national security challenge. This is a matter of national urgency.

History is not deterministic and war with the PRC is not inevitable. While the PRC is clearly an increasingly capable strategic competitor, it is imperative that we keep our relationship in competition and not in conflict. By maintaining a strong military with overmatch against the PRC, we are postured to deter conflict with the PRC. Through integrated deterrence, we will raise perceived costs to the PRC and deter aggression. If deterrence fails, then we will end the conflict on terms favorable to the United States.

Russia: Over 1 year ago, Russia undertook an illegal and unprovoked war against Ukraine threatening peace and stability on the European continent—a peace that ensures global stability and an international order where all nations can prosper. Russia's invasion of Ukraine is in complete contradiction to the basic rules that underline the United Nations Charter established at the end of World War II. Russia's war is a brazen assault against the free people of Ukraine and threatens to destabilize all of Europe and beyond.

In response to this Russian war of choice, we are supporting Ukraine as it fights to protect its sovereignty and supporting our NATO allies with a United States force presence in every single nation on NATO's eastern flank. Putin's war of choice has caused untold human suffering and terrorized a free country and its people. Putin

attempted to seize Kyiv, overthrow its government, and fracture the NATO alliance. NATO remains more unified than ever, and Ukraine remains free and independent.

The Ukrainian people have demonstrated immense bravery and resilience and inspired the world. The international community has come together to ensure that this unambiguous act of aggression by Russia does not go unanswered. This fight is not just in Ukraine's interests, it is in the global interest to protect the system and rules that have prevented great power war since the conclusion of World War II.

With the backing of the United States Congress, the United States is determined to continue to support Ukraine with the means to defend themselves. The United States has committed to provide Ukraine 160 155mm Howitzers, over 1,000,000 155mm artillery rounds, 38 High Mobility Artillery Rocket Systems (HIMARS), a Patriot air defense battery, 8 National Advanced Surface-to-Air Missile Systems (NASAMS), 31 Abrams tanks, and 109 Bradley Infantry Fighting Vehicles.

A broad mix of air defense systems protect the skies over Kyiv and the cities of Ukraine. Armor systems strengthen Ukrainian front lines enabling offensive and defense operations. Ukrainians employ long range fires to challenge Russian command and control and its ability to sustain Russian aggression. These systems will enable Ukraine to ensure that Russia does not achieve its strategic objectives. Russia failed in its initial war aims and continues to revise its strategic goals due to its sustained operational failures. Russia continues to pay extremely heavy costs on the battlefield.

Last year, in Poland, we established the first permanent United States installation on NATO's eastern flank. The United States maintains significant numbers of combat capable forces in Europe to deter aggression and to stand shoulder to shoulder with our allies and partners.

Russia retains a large nuclear capability to threaten the United States, Europe, and the globe. Vladimir Putin and his regime continue to use irresponsible nuclear rhetoric and posturing. Russia has repeatedly demonstrated its capability and will to conduct complex malicious cyber activities targeting American digital infrastructure, both military and commercial.

Through private military companies, Russia continues to undermine other nations' sovereignty and create unstable security situations. Aside from its brutal war in Ukraine, Moscow's actions in Africa and the Middle East demonstrate its aggressiveness, resourcefulness, and opportunism. Russia is an immediate acute and very dangerous challenge to the United States' national security.

North Korea: Its continued weapons testing and development pose real threats to our homeland as well as allies and partners in the Indo-Pacific. North Korea's rhetoric is becoming increasingly aggressive as it is growing more confrontational and continues to enhance its ballistic missile capability and capacity. Pyongyang shows no signs of relenting in its focus on its Weapons of Mass Destruction (WMD) program at the expense of its citizens and the peace of the Korean Peninsula as well as the entire region. Readiness of United States military forces on the Korean Peninsula and our ability to rapidly respond to provocation ensure stability and prevent war.

Iran: Iran's support for and involvement in conflicts in the region and its neighbors threaten to push the Middle East into broader regional instability and chaos. Through its funding of terrorist activities and support to partner and proxy forces inside the borders of its neighbors, along with its ballistic missile programs, Iran seeks to revise the regional order and balance of power in its favor. Iran's proliferation of UAVs across the region and into Russia pose critical security challenges for the United States and our partners. Iran is taking actions to improve its capabilities to produce a nuclear weapon, should it make the decision to do so, while continuing to build its missile forces. From the time of a national decision, Iran could produce enough fissile material for a nuclear weapon in approximately 10–15 days and it would only take several months to produce an actual nuclear weapon. The United States remains committed, as a matter of policy, that Iran will not have a nuclear weapon. The United States military has developed multiple options for our national leadership to consider, if or when Iran decides to develop a nuclear weapon.

Violent extremist organizations: Terrorist organizations such as Al-Qaeda, ISIS, Al-Shabaab, and others continue to export terror, destruction, and destabilization. Unless the root causes of instability that give rise to these types of groups are resolved, terrorists will continue to take root around the globe, threaten others with attacks, and undermine legitimate governments. The root causes can only be effectively addressed by including governments of the region and we can best influence outcomes with diplomatic, economic, information, stability, and counterterrorism efforts. Through coalition efforts to train, advise, and assist partners and allies as well as intelligence sharing, we will continue to ensure that terrorists do not possess

the capacity and capability to exert their will. Our counterterrorism strategy is to work by, with, and through our regional allies and partners and to conduct direct action counterterrorism strikes when necessary to protect the United States or our interests.

Allies and partners: Our alliances and partnerships are key to maintaining the rules based international order and a stable and open international system promoting peace and prosperity. This budget allows us to build our partners' and allies' capabilities, foster interoperability, and strengthen relationships. Doing so allows us, our allies, and our partners to counter the coercion of our strategic competitors, oppose the malign activity of regional threats, and meet the varied security challenges posed by state and non-state actors. We are stronger when we operate closely with our allies and partners.

READINESS AND MODERNIZATION

Right now, we are experiencing a fundamental change in the character of war. The character of war—how, where, and with what weapons and technologies wars are fought—is changing significantly. We must fully integrate developing technologies including precision long range fires, hypersonic weapons, quantum computing, artificial intelligence, robotics, and pervasive all-domain sensors.

The current rapidly changing technology will provide decisive advantage to the nations that can integrate and optimize the capabilities into military weaponry, doctrine, training, organization, and professional development. The future operating environment will be highly lethal and will be characterized by the ability to see and sense the environment like never before. The attributes of the future Joint Force will be characterized by stealth, resilience, and speed with agile, adaptive units operating in a constant state of motion. Most importantly, the Joint Force will be highly lethal. Our leaders and forces will operate independently and distributed in degraded communication environments with mission type orders and austere logistics.

Continued modernization is imperative for the Joint Force. Building the Joint Force required to implement our National Defense Strategy demands modernizing our capabilities, design, and employment. We must not allow ourselves to create the false trap that we can either modernize or focus only on today. We must do both. The United States has always had the advantage of time to conduct a long build up prior to the beginning of hostilities. Our fortunate geography with oceans on our east and west borders and friendly neighbors to our north and south have given us the strategic advantage of buffer zones to threats. With advances in technology and a growing global interconnectedness, we will no longer have the luxury of a long protected buildup prior to conflict. It is imperative that we have a modern advanced force in sufficient size and readiness to enable sustained deterrence and, if required, to be able to fight and win. We must make some fundamental changes to our Joint Force in order to leverage our military overmatch to deter conflict in a future operating environment.

Our strategic competitors are modernizing their militaries, weapons, and capability. We must continue to modernize ours; we have no choice. We must divest legacy systems to enable our modernization.

In the fall of 2019, the Secretary of Defense tasked the Joint Staff to develop the Joint Warfighting Concept (JWC) to address strategic conflict. This year, after extensive wargaming, the Joint Staff published the third iteration of JWC and will integrate the ideas into new joint doctrine, Joint Publication 1 to be published this summer. Today, JWC is the unifying vision to guide future force design, force development, and force employment to ensure we have the right people, equipment, training, roles, and doctrine. It will continue to incorporate evolving threats to help us shape our strategic environment and future operations. JWC 3.0 contains an updated description of the overarching military challenges facing the Joint Force, a refined explanation of the military solution—expanded maneuver—and a detailed description of how the Joint Force will apply this solution. This version of the JWC includes greater fidelity on key warfighting concepts and more precision on the operational approaches that will enable the Joint Force to gain positions of advantage against peer adversaries.

Joint All Domain Command and Control (JADC2) is a warfighting capability to sense, make sense, and act at all levels and phases of war, across all domains, and with partners, to deliver information advantage at speed to our forces and decision makers.

We are revising our leader development Joint Professional Military Education (JPME) to support the JWC. We are modernizing our JPME curriculum to develop strategically minded joint warfighters, who think critically and can creatively apply military power. Our focus remains on instructing mission command, operational

agility, and ethics to ensure our military leaders can effectively employ forces at all levels of warfare and respond to a dynamic battlefield. Additionally, we are increasing the amount of JPME devoted to the study of the changing character of war and Great Power Competition.

We are focused on building a more lethal Joint Force by ensuring that we continue to modernize our concepts, doctrine, training, and military education. We must continue to invest in capabilities that sustain our military overmatch, while strengthening alliances and attracting new partners. Investments in this budget ensure the Joint Force can execute all requirements leveled by our Nation. The investments made in this budget will ensure that we remain a capable and ready force while funding our priorities of nuclear modernization, long range fires, hypersonic technology, artificial intelligence, robotics, shipbuilding, space, and cyber.

Nuclear modernization: The nuclear triad is the foundation of our strategic deterrent. Our adversaries are improving their nuclear posture and potential nuclear threats continue to emerge. It remains critical that all three legs of the triad—bombers, intercontinental ballistic missiles, and submarines—remain a viable deterrent and allow us to hedge against geopolitical, technological, operational, and programmatic risks. Our legacy systems have been extended well beyond their original service lives and we must recapitalize our nuclear enterprise. Modernizing the nuclear triad will cost 3.7% of the Defense budget at its peak not including DOE/ NNSA warhead modernization. Costs will be significant but relatively less burdensome on the overall Defense budget relative to previous recapitalization efforts. Modernization of our nuclear forces, weapons complexes, and requisite nuclear command, control, and communications (NC3) capabilities are a high priority.

Long range fires: The war in Ukraine highlights the strategic and devastating effect provided by long range fires. The Joint Force must have a long range strike capability without having to also maintain air superiority. Long range fires provide significant offensive capabilities that are both cost-effective and cost-imposing means of improving deterrence. By enabling power projection from standoff ranges, the risk to critical United States assets decreases while the defensive burden imposed upon the enemy increases. These fires challenge an adversary's logistics, command and control, and basing forcing them to choose between increased risk or decreased effectiveness. The PRC has thousands of ground-launched theater-range missiles in its arsenal that would be difficult for the United States to counter given its current inventories. Investments in long range and hypersonic missiles launched from ground, sea, and air platforms are a cost-effective strategy that improves our ability to compete with the PRC. Recent budget requests have enhanced the lethality and resilience of the Joint Force by developing and expanding the long-range fires portfolio.

Hypersonic technology: Our adversaries are undertaking hypersonic weapons testing and development from a variety of delivery platforms. These weapons operate at speeds greater than Mach 5 and are maneuverable, which make the weapons challenging to detect and defeat. Weapons operating at these speeds will provide significant offensive capability that will challenge an opponent's decision timelines. We must invest in this technology to provide a suite of capabilities that provide transformational warfighting capability to our Joint Force.

Artificial intelligence and robotics: Decision making in warfare is fundamental to the outcome. Militaries must be able to collect, analyze, and assess vast quantities of data in order to make effective decisions. The military that can iterate through the decisionmaking framework fastest will have decisive advantage. Artificial intelligence has the potential to reform military decisionmaking processes at the tactical, operational, and strategic levels of war to enable rapid assessments and decisions that outpace human abilities. Additionally, artificial intelligence combined with new military platforms could enable the proliferation of robots across the battlefield. Robots in the land, sea, and air domains could provide significant quantities of firepower, logistics, and communications capabilities while decreasing risks to our military forces. Through human-machine teaming, each human warfighter would have exponentially increased abilities to shoot, move, and communicate in battle to prevail over the enemy.

Legacy platform divestment: Maintaining and operating weapons that are not relevant in the future fight and whose capabilities are matched by superior technology need to be divested. Continuing to purchase and maintain legacy equipment takes needed Defense dollars away from the acquisition of higher priority systems necessary for modernization. I strongly urge Congress to enact legislation that authorizes the Department to divest select legacy platforms to ensure that every Defense dollar spent on programs and equipment is relevant for the next fight. We must not be influenced by a sunk cost bias, and we cannot continue to mortgage our future by being wedded to technology of the past.

Shipbuilding: The United States Navy must always be the world's most powerful naval force in capacity and capability. We must never accept 2nd place in naval power. We are a maritime nation and the vast majority of international trade moves across the world's oceans. The United States is committed to a free and open global maritime common. Manufacturing our warships overseas is a strategic risk and is not in our national interest. Our shipbuilding and supporting industrial base are a national security capability that needs support to grow and maintain a skilled workforce. The FY 2024 President's Budget reflects the Administration's strong commitment to continued American naval dominance, including improvements to our industrial base to meet the demands of our current and future defense needs. This Nation must have the right ships, with the right crews, and the right capabilities on the right timelines in the theaters where they matter. This budget specifically procures warships and submarines with credible combat power to deter the PRC. We must continue to invest in the industrial base to support remotely operated ship development, fleet modernization, on time delivery of the *COLUMBIA* class submarine, and to accelerate production and maintenance of *VIRGINIA* class submarines to support both the United States and AUKUS needs.

Recapitalization of the sealift fleet is necessary to enable joint power projection. Sealift ships transport 90% of war material and supplies in support of major combat operations. The DoD sealift fleet is approaching the end of its useful life with an average age of 48 years. Our overall sealift readiness rate is consistently below our stated requirements. I urge Congress to remove all limitations on the Department's ability to procure additional used vessels to replace these aging ships.

Space: Space is essential to our way of life. Space capabilities are vital to our economy, quality of life, exploration initiatives, and national security. Every year we see additional commercial space launches and increased competition for lower earth orbit.

Our adversaries view space as a warfighting domain and believe that achieving supremacy in this arena will be a decisive factor in winning future conflicts. The exosphere is already contested as Russia has tested both a ground-based anti-satellite missile and an on-orbit anti-satellite weapon prototype, which threaten our space capabilities. Both the PRC and Russia view counterspace capabilities as a means to reduce United States and allied military effectiveness. Additionally, our adversaries have demonstrated space-jamming capabilities and maintain independent launch capabilities. Left unsecured, our capabilities in space will become strategic vulnerabilities. I urge Congress to support the significant increase in this budget for United States space capabilities.

Cyber: Adversaries continue to use operations in the cyber domain to compete with the United States and attempt to gain an information advantage. Malign cyber actors exploit commercial software vulnerabilities to gain network access and conduct cyber operations against United States citizens, organizations, and institutions. The low-cost barrier to entry and attribution deniability make this a priority method for adversaries to compete below the level of armed conflict while minimizing risk of escalation. The PRC, Russia, Iran, and North Korea use a range of cyber capabilities from information operations (IO) to cyber-attacks to collect intelligence, position for future operations, impose costs, and signal to the United States and adversaries.

Therefore, we must increase our ability to compete and prevail in cyberspace while ensuring all elements of informational power are integrated into operations, activities, and efforts to deter our adversaries and protect the United States homeland. This requires investments in technology, building and maturing cyber readiness and operations, reducing risk to weapon systems and critical infrastructure, strengthening cybersecurity, and improving network resiliency.

Advanced Capabilities: The changing character of war necessitates that we continue to modernize and innovate our technology, capabilities, and training. Data and communication networks are fundamental to how the United States trains, plans, and employs force. We must have rapid and robust linkages from sensors to shooters in a networked information environment. This will require investments in microelectronics and quantum computing to ensure we maintain a technological edge over our adversaries. The current globally distributed supply chains as well as access to critical materials and rare earth metals present vulnerabilities to the Joint Force's ability to acquire necessary parts and technology in the event of crisis. We must also find ways to deepen collaboration on advanced capabilities with our closest allies and partners, such as our trilateral cooperation under AUKUS.

TAKING CARE OF OUR PEOPLE

People are our most important resource in the Joint Force. We must ensure that we are doing all that we can to take care of and guard our most critical resource.

Taking care of people is a critical readiness issue and it decisively impacts unit cohesion, recruitment, retention, and confidence in leadership.

To attract, grow, and retain the best talent in the world, we must ensure that we are always taking care of our people. I urge Congress to support this budget's significant pay raise, healthcare, and housing initiatives. Additionally, this budget strengthens our accountability and prevention measures for sexual harassment and sexual assault. Finally, this budget supports improving our mental health and suicide prevention programs. Each of these initiatives is fundamental to taking care of our troops and their families.

We are ensuring that the military departments increase their childcare capacity, and the DoD system remains the gold standard of childcare. The DoD operates the country's largest employer-sponsored childcare program, with over 27,000 staff members providing daily care for more than 160,000 children from infancy up to age 12. This fiscal year, the DoD is making a significant investment in constructing new child development centers as well as repairing, renovating, and maintaining existing child development centers to ensure our children are in safe and well-maintained facilities. Funding support from Congress is vital for fully staffed military childcare, and to support efforts to expand capacity in the community. Childcare is key to keeping working families working, reducing the high unemployment faced by military spouses, and ensuring the safety of our military children. Despite the childcare capacity and quality provided by the DoD there are still challenges for military families to access that care or quality care in the community.

This budget equips our service members and families with the tools, skills, and resources necessary to ensure their health and well-being. The health and wellness of our force is a readiness, retention, and recruitment issue.

The Joint Force is committed to growing our talent and ensuring that all who meet the requirements to serve are able to serve. The Joint Force competes for the talent of America's youth along with every other business and organization who seeks our Nation's best and brightest. The Joint Force's objective is to field the most lethal and combat effective fighting force in the world. We will continue to support the accessions of all qualified people to all jobs and positions within the Joint Force.

CONCLUSION

The United States Joint Force is a flexible and adaptable force ready to deter, fight, and win our Nation's wars. Significant threats exist across the globe and the United States is ready to respond to these challenges. The PRC continues its aggressive attempts to revise the global order for its own benefits. It is building up its military might to achieve its goals through the use of force. With its illegal and unprovoked war in Ukraine, Russia attempted to overturn the rules based international order and fracture NATO. Russia's war of aggression and nuclear rhetoric is irresponsible and risks miscalculation and escalation.

International aggression, where large countries use military force to attack smaller countries and change recognized borders, cannot be allowed to stand. The Joint Force will continue to work with the interagency and in cooperation with our allies and partners to deter aggression and threats to the free world. America's network of allies and partners is a strategic source of strength. It is this robust network, this team of teams, that stands against those autocratic, revanchist, and revisionist regimes that are uninterested in a connected and prosperous world.

It is within this framework that it is imperative we modernize our force, training, and doctrine to remain the most capable and ready force on the planet. The United States has been challenged before by many other adversaries. Yet, conflict is not inevitable—our military might makes war less likely by allowing us to deter across the spectrum of conflict. Our contract with the American people is that we, the United States military, will always be ready to protect the Constitution and the fundamental principles of what it means to be American. We will always protect and defend this experiment in liberty, to deter our enemies, and, if deterrence fails, then to fight and win.

Senator TESTER. Thank you, General Milley.

To the members of the committee, everybody, almost everybody on this committee is going to participate today. So there will be 5-minute rounds. I would ask you to keep it as close to 5 minutes as you can.

I would ask the distinguished panelists to be as thorough and succinct with your answers as possible.

I'm going to start talking about continuing resolutions and their ineffectiveness. No corporation in the world would restrict their cash flow for the development or production of programs at the start of a fiscal year. Yet, in the business of national security some would say for our most important business we do just that.

So, Secretary Austin, if another CR is enacted for this fiscal year 2024, what programs are you most concerned about?

Secretary AUSTIN. Well, certainly I'm concerned about all of the new starts that we won't be able to perfect because of a CR.

You lose time, Chairman, under CRs and you can't—no amount of money can buy back time. Again, you can't start new programs.

I would point out that the PRC is not waiting. They will execute on their own timeline. I pointed out earlier, Chairman, that our budget is directly linked to our strategy and, of course, if we don't have a budget, we can't effectively execute that strategy.

So if we look at the investments that we're looking to make in fighter aircraft, you know, I mentioned earlier there's the \$61 billion in our investment in our Air Force, what we're asking for \$48 billion in our Naval Forces, those kinds of things we won't be able to get after because of continuing resolution.

So I think the best way that the Congress can support us in our efforts to execute our strategy is an on-time appropriations.

Senator TESTER. Inflation is real and it's a concern. This is an \$842 billion budget.

Have you guys been able to put any sort of numbers to determine how much a CR would cost us?

Secretary AUSTIN. Certainly, it would depend on how long that CR is in effect, Chairman, and I defer to Mike McCord there for any concrete numbers, but this is something that we'll continue to evaluate on a daily, weekly, monthly basis if we have to go to a CR, but it will cost us money.

Senator TESTER. Okay. Mike, would you like to comment to that?

Mr. MCCORD. Chairman, we've built significant funding into this budget to account for the inflation we project, including the pay raises the Secretary described, and that approach is \$40 billion. A CR, by definition, doesn't give us any of that, right. It keeps our top line where it was last year which is about a \$25 billion reduction and inflation is a significant hit there as are things like the Columbia and all three legs of the Triad.

Senator TESTER. Secretary Austin, I want you to talk about how a potential government default would impact your ongoing efforts.

Secretary AUSTIN. Well, certainly it would impact our reputation worldwide. You know, we are known for being very dependable, paying our bills on time, and a source of stability globally.

What it would mean realistically for us is that we won't in some cases be able to pay our troops with any degree of predictability and that predictability is really, really important for us.

But this would have a real impact on the pockets of our troops and our civilians.

Senator TESTER. General Milley, some would say that the department has gotten used to dealing with CRs, so they're no big deal. How do you respond to that?

General MILLEY. Thanks, Chairman. There's several key things to that. First is current operations and readiness. I think you'd see

it and we've done this drill many times, run the numbers, you'd see a significant degradation in the readiness of the force. The force that I just rattled off to you that's ready today, you'd see that depreciate over time. So your numbers of rotations at the CTCs (Combat Training Center), for example, for the Army here in D.C., the number of Red Flags, the number of Top Guns, all of those events would start being attrited over time.

You'd start seeing the number of flying hours, the 5,000 sorties I mentioned upfront per day, that would be cut down by a certain percentage, depends on how long the CR went. So you'd see flying hours for both rotor wing and fixed wing helicopters go down.

You'd see sailing time, those hundred ships that I said are sailing the seven seas right now, you'd have to cut that back because of fuel costs. So there'd be significant current operations and then for future readiness, future modernization, the Secretary mentioned the new starts. You'd also probably see some delays in some of the nuclear recapitalization. The Columbia could be at risk a little bit, I think.

You could see that B-21 that was just rolled out in California not too long ago, things like that would be stretched out long-term. So it's a terrible way to do business. I'm not a businessman, but it's a terrible way to run a business when you're doing basically budgets for 9 months at a time if you do a CR for 3 months.

So it would have, I think, very, very significant negative impact on the readiness and then, of course, future readiness but also there's the imponderable, the immeasurable one, which is morale. It sends a terrible signal to our soldiers, our sailors, airmen, Marines around the world when we do these CRs.

So it always leaves people in a sense of uncertainty and then it sends a terrible message to our allies and partners and our adversaries around the world. So I think it's significant.

Senator TESTER. Thank you.

Senator Collins.

Senator COLLINS. Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

Let's assume that we do achieve our goal of enacting the DoD (Department of Defense) appropriations bill on time. If we use the Administration's estimate for fuel costs, which the Government Accountability Office underestimates costs by 20 percent, General Milley, absent some relief from Congress, how would military readiness be affected in terms of the department's flying hours, training exercises, and other activities needed to stay within the 20 percent shortfall?

General MILLEY. Well, I think there's a direct relation. If it's 20 percent shortfall in fuel, you're going to have 20 percent less flying hours because all these aircraft, ships, as well, and ground vehicles, tanks and much infantry fighting vehicles. They all rely on fuel.

The Department of Defense is the biggest fuel consumer in the United States. So we would end up reducing the amount of operational tempo of our vehicle fleets, whether ground or air, and the specific number of hours, we've done the math, and I'd have to get back to you for the record on the specific number of hours they would have. It would depend on how long and how deep the CR

was, but it would have significant impact on flying hours, driving miles per vehicle, and the sailing of the ships.

Senator COLLINS. Thank you.

Secretary Austin, General Milley correctly noted in his statement when he was discussing Iran that Iran would only take several more months to produce an actual nuclear weapon and he goes on to say that the United States remains committed as a matter of policy that Iran will not have a nuclear weapon.

What are some of the policies that the Administration is pursuing to prevent Iran from developing very quickly a nuclear weapon?

Secretary AUSTIN. Well, from a military perspective, you know, my responsibility is to make sure that is our policy. Iran will not have a nuclear weapon.

My responsibility is to make sure that the President has options available to him to enforce that policy and so we remain focused on making sure that those options remain available and they are.

Senator COLLINS. All right. I'll move on to a different issue.

In January, the department announced that 31 Abrams tanks would be delivered to Ukraine. The latest information I have is that that will not occur until this fall, is that accurate? Could you update us on what the current delivery schedule is and whether there's any way to accelerate the delivery of these tanks to Ukraine?

Secretary AUSTIN. Thanks, Vice Chair. We are doing everything possible to accelerate the delivery of these tanks and early fall is a projection.

In the meantime, we've moved a number of tanks over into theater so that the Ukrainians can begin training on this capability and when they complete that—by the time they complete that training, the tanks will be available for them to use.

We're putting in the infrastructure to be able to sustain and support this capability, as well. As you know, this is a different capability, turbine engine, and a number of pretty sophisticated systems. We're moving as fast as possible to get the capability in the hands of the Ukrainians and will certainly have that available by early fall.

Senator COLLINS. Another threat to the United States is a terrorist attack. I think with our focus on China and Russia and Iran, North Korea, we can't lose sight of the fact that Afghanistan is once again a safe haven for many terrorist groups.

General Kurilla testified before the Armed Services Committee that ISIS-K will likely be capable of conducting operations outside of Afghanistan within 6 months and that that would come with little or no warning.

I know that the United States military made an effort to take most of its weapons and ammunition out of Afghanistan when our troops left, but the fact is that approximately \$7 billion worth of valuable useful military equipment provided to the Afghan Security Forces by the United States remains in that country.

Are you concerned about the fact that the weapons that the Americans gave to the Security Forces could now be turned against us and our Western allies in a terrorist attack?

Secretary AUSTIN. Vice Chair, you accurately described what we're looking at in terms of that equipment. The equipment that the United States troops were using was retrograded by General Miller and his staff when the decision was made to retrograde our troops out of Afghanistan. So we closed 11 bases, brought out thousands of tons of equipment that we were using that was equipment for our forces, and that retrograde was done very successfully.

As you know, over 20 years we did a lot to provide capability to the Afghan military and that over time turned out to be quite a bit of equipment.

Now when that government collapsed and when the Security Forces laid down their arms, then that material became available to the Taliban. So, yes, that equipment is still in Afghanistan, but again its equipment that we had provided to their forces, their Security Forces, and not the equipment that we left behind because we couldn't retrograde it.

Senator COLLINS. Thank you.

Senator TESTER. Thank you, Senator Collins.

Senator Murray.

Senator MURRAY. Well, thank you very much, Chair Tester, Vice Chairman Collins.

I'm really glad that we are continuing to hold these really important hearings and move closer to finally getting the committee back to regular order. So I appreciate it.

We've made good progress, but we have to stay the course if we're going to pass our Nation's funding bills in a timely manner. We know that our competitors, like the Chinese Government, are doing everything they can to gain ground. So we cannot afford to let our efforts get sidetracked and our investments fall behind.

Our military needs the certainty of a regular and smooth appropriations process that they can depend on. So I'm really glad to have this opportunity to hear from Secretary Austin about the resources needed to support our service members and keep our Nation safe, including support for our military families, like good housing and schools, mental healthcare, childcare, and a lot more, because, as I have said, our most important military asset isn't our weapons or our equipment, it is the brave and talented women and men who are willing to put their lives on the line to keep our country safe.

So we owe it to them to work together across the aisle, get our job done, get our government funded without drama, and get them the support they need.

So, Mr. Secretary, thank you for being here today. Let me start with a really important topic. Our Nation's suicide crisis is devastating and we see serious risk among our servicemembers. The latest report on suicide in the military shows a steady increase over the past decade and we finally saw a small decrease in 2021 but there's still a lot of work to be done.

Secretary Austin, you have previously noted how the stress caused by the unpredictability of life in the military, the demand for troops to confront so many threats abroad, real challenges accessing counseling, all contribute to this problem.

I understand the department is facing challenges hiring enough specialists to provide servicemembers with access to mental healthcare and counseling.

Can you tell us what steps you are taking to increase hiring so servicemembers have access to mental healthcare?

Secretary AUSTIN. This is something that's very, very important to me. You've heard me talk about this. This is something that remains very important to me. You've heard me talk about this a number of times.

Mental health is health, period, and I think we have to continue to maintain that outlook towards taking care of our troops.

I just had all our senior leaders, both uniform and civilian, in for a senior leader session, and this was one topic that was prominent in that session.

I'm asking you for \$200 million in this budget plus to devote to suicide prevention which includes increasing access to mental healthcare and I am really emphasizing to leadership that we need to do everything possible to make sure that we're working with, you know, the civilian capabilities in our communities to make sure that we have access to those, to increase the capacity that's available to us.

But we will remain sited on this and you're right, we did see an improvement in 2021. We're going to work hard to see if we can continue to improve, but this remains a challenge and access to mental healthcare is fundamental to this challenge.

Senator MURRAY. Thank you and we need to follow up on that. I appreciate it.

Let me change the topic. As you know, the Navy is sending a nuclear-armed submarine to South Korea for the first time since the 1980s and the USS *George Washington* will replace the USS *Ronald Reagan* in Japan so it can head to Bremerton, Washington, for maintenance.

These naval assets will only become more important as the U.S. works to strengthen our partnerships and support allies throughout the Indo-Pacific.

Maintaining this fleet is really paramount to our success and the Puget Sound Naval Shipyard is really vital, as you know, to the maintenance work.

PSNS (Puget Sound Naval Shipyard) is the only shipyard on the West Coast with Nimitz and Ford Class capable of dry dock and it's responsible for the maintenance of the majority of the West Coast-based attack submarines. Those dry docks are currently vulnerable to seismic activity.

Secretary Austin, I am disappointed that despite knowing about the need to address those seismic issues, it was left out of the budget request this year.

How is the department ensuring this multiyear project is and will continue to be a top priority for the Navy?

Secretary AUSTIN. Well, thanks and thanks for your continued support on this issue.

First of all, let me emphasize that the safety of our personnel and the protection of our assets is very important to the department.

When we experienced a challenge with the—because of the seismic activity recently, as you know, we rapidly deployed assessment teams to assess damage and also to outline steps that are necessary to get our capability back up and running. We have a high standard for safety and we have done that work and we are bringing those assets back online.

In this budget, Chair, I'm asking you for \$2.7 billion to continue to invest in our infrastructure. That's in the SIOP (Shipyard Infrastructure Optimization Program) Program and we will continue to invest in this in future budget requests, as well.

Senator MURRAY. Thank you. Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

Senator TESTER. Senator Moran.

Senator MORAN. Chairman, thank you, Chairman.

Secretary, thank you for your presence and your service.

Mr. Secretary, what's your explanation? How do we solve the problem with recruitment? What's the cause for the failure for young men and women to sign up? It strikes me that it's something that needs to be defined. I know at Fort Riley, we have the greatest level of retention of any military installation but recruitment is down.

So retention is there but not recruitment. What's your story?

Secretary AUSTIN. There are a number of challenges that have come together, Senator, to create headwinds. Foremost among those challenges is 2 years of COVID.

As you well know, sir, recruiters spend a lot of time interacting with prospective recruits at schools and so their access to schools is pretty important. If they don't have that access for 2 years, then it certainly creates a challenge for us.

You add that to the fact that we've seen the lowest unemployment rate in decades and so there are a number of things that have combined to create the challenge.

It's not the first time that we've seen challenges in recruiting, as you know. When I was in the military, I was a recruiter for a period of time and I know that the things that you have to do to improve, Number 1, you have to increase contact with your prospect, you have to invest in advertising and marketing, you have to have the right quality of recruiters out engaging the public, you have to engage centers of influence, like yourself and other key leaders in the community, and all of those things our services are working to up their activity in all of those areas and I'm optimistic that, you know, this trough that we entered because of the effects of COVID and other things we'll climb out of and we're seeing some positive trends and we'll continue to do the right things and invest in the right things to make sure that gets turned around.

Senator MORAN. Well, as you know, our capabilities of defending our country rest solely with the men and women who serve in uniform. I wish you well in those efforts and any way that I and I'm sure my colleagues can be of help to get folks to sign up, please include me. Please ask.

Secretary AUSTIN. I would ask—make one strong request and that is that we all emphasize the value of service and whether or not you serve in the military or whether or not you serve your community or you serve as a member of the Federal Government, serv-

ice is really important, but certainly hearing that from key leadership in the country I think would help this overall effort.

Senator MORAN. Thank you, sir.

Let me ask you about the National Guard. We've seen how important the National Guard is, what role they play in defending our Nation. The National Guard makes up 20 percent of the Joint Force, but the National Guard Vice Chief is the only vice chief that's a three star.

Thoughts about if that's appropriate or is there a plan to remedy that circumstance.

Secretary AUSTIN. I agree with you, Senator, that the National Guard is critical to our overall department, to the Department of Defense.

I can't overemphasize, you know, the capability that they bring to the force. This is something—you know, our structure and the number of billets that we have is something that we continue to evaluate.

I have all the authorities that I need. I don't need any authority, additional authorities or help, but that's something we'll continue to look at as we go from year to year into the future and right now I don't see the need to effect any changes.

Senator MORAN. Well, thank you for your consideration.

Finally, Secretary Austin, my time is about to expire. Congress last year—so I'll just make this point. Congress passed the PACT (Promise to Address Comprehensive Toxics) Act dealing with toxic exposure by our service men and women. We have significant challenges of families and servicemembers who are impacted by contaminated drinking water at Red Hill and if the department has not established an exposure registry, I encourage you to do so and I hope that this budget has the resources necessary to care for those servicemembers and their families.

Secretary AUSTIN. We have established a registry and so thank you, Senator.

Senator MORAN. You're welcome. General Milley, thank you for your service, appreciate you very much.

Senator TESTER. Senator Durbin.

Senator DURBIN. Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

General Milley, you've served our Nation well and when the history is written of your service, it will clearly recognize that America was safer under your watch and the troops you led had an effective and caring leader under your command, but this history may not tell the whole story unless you write it of your fidelity to our Constitution when there were serious questions of the peaceful transition of power which is essential to the preservation of our democracy.

Because of you, our Constitution and our Union survived and we are stronger today. Thank you.

Secretary Austin, yesterday I had a meeting in my office of several Senators with a man named Kareem Khan. He is the chief prosecutor of the International Criminal Court. He recently charged Vladimir Putin with war crimes. We know what he's basing that on, the unspeakable atrocities caused by the Russian forces in Ukraine, stealing, kidnapping hundreds, if not thousands

of children, rape, beheadings, torture, mass executions, and targeting individual private citizens for his bombardment.

Ukraine's Prosecutor general has documented more than 77,000 war crimes and crimes against humanity. Sadly, the number continues to grow.

When I met with Kareem Khan I asked him if there was more the United States could do to help him gather the evidence and documents necessary to prosecute Vladimir Putin for these awful war crimes. He said there was cooperation from the Department of State, the Department of Justice, but he did not include the Secretary of Defense and your department.

Khan's efforts regarding war crimes are so important that Congress last year passed additional authority allowing the U.S. to share critical war crimes evidence and intelligence with the International Court of Criminal Justice.

We have one president, we have one commander-in-chief, but I'm not certain that we have one policy when it comes to the War Criminal Vladimir Putin.

I'd like to ask you directly. Why are you reluctant to share the evidence that we have gathered in the United States through the Department of Defense from those who are holding Vladimir Putin accountable for his war crimes?

Secretary AUSTIN. Thank you, Senator.

I absolutely agree with what you said in terms of the atrocities that we've witnessed throughout. It's been absolutely despicable and we continue to see evidence of Putin deliberately targeting civilians, hospitals, and apartment buildings and you name it.

The department firmly supports the goal of holding Russia accountable for its violations in Ukraine. There are multiple ways to promote accountability, including the domestic Ukrainian efforts that you mentioned, and I believe in a principled approach to promoting accountability.

I will always prioritize the protection of U.S. military personnel in anything that we do.

Senator DURBIN. So why is your department not sharing evidence that we have gathered to help that effort? The Department of State is. The Department of Justice is. Why is the Department of Defense not doing so?

Secretary AUSTIN. Senator, I will just tell you that, you know, it's important to us to make sure that Russia is held accountable and we support the goal of holding him accountable, but again I do have concerns about reciprocity going forward and so we will continue to look for ways to support the effort of holding Russia accountable.

Senator DURBIN. Are you aware of the additional authorities we created by law that allow your department and the others of this government to cooperate with the ICC (International Criminal Court)?

Secretary AUSTIN. I am aware of the legislation, Senator.

Senator DURBIN. Do you feel there is a deficiency in that legislation that would hold you back from helping the prosecution of Vladimir Putin?

Secretary AUSTIN. I see no deficiencies in your legislation, no.

Senator DURBIN. Then what is the explanation? There's got to be a bottom line here. Why is it when these prosecutors come and meet with us they list the cooperating agencies of our government and specifically don't list the Department of Defense? Why?

Secretary AUSTIN. Again, Senator, we'll do everything within our power to make sure that we support efforts to hold Russia accountable, but again I remain concerned about the protection of U.S. military personnel—

Senator DURBIN. I've got to ask for more—General, I respect you and I voted for you and I'd do it again, but I got to ask for more. Your personal feelings about whether you do it or not should be second to the law, should it not?

Secretary AUSTIN. It is. They are, Senator.

Senator DURBIN. Well, if the law says cooperate and you refuse, what am I—what conclusion am I supposed to draw?

Secretary AUSTIN. Senator, we have not refused any—to abide by any law. So there could be some confusion here, but again we support the goal of holding Russia accountable.

Senator DURBIN. I have to ask you to prove it by doing so and I have to ask you why the people who have observed the conduct and policy of the agency think you're falling short and you're holding back.

Why we would hold back evidence against this War Criminal Vladimir Putin and the terrible things he's doing? I don't understand at all. You say you don't think the law is deficient, but you have a feeling.

Mr. Secretary, give me more than that. Tell me why. You must have a compelling reason for not cooperating. What is it?

Secretary AUSTIN. Again, I will always prioritize protection of our military personnel. That's my concern.

Senator DURBIN. And you don't think the law that we've passed does that?

Secretary AUSTIN. I didn't make a comment on the law, Senator. I think again the law is sufficient obviously. It's been established by Congress and we are compelled to respect the law.

Senator DURBIN. Well, I would never jeopardized our troops and I know Senator Graham feels the same. We both worked on crafting this law so it would necessarily protect our troops. You've drawn a personal opposite conclusion and I think it is frankly hurting the efforts to hold Putin accountable.

Thank you, Mr. Chairman. I yield.

Senator TESTER. Senator Graham.

Senator GRAHAM. Rather than beating this horse, I would recommend that we probably have a meeting, Secretary Austin, if that's okay with you.

Listen. I've been a judge advocate most of my adult life and we've written this law in a way to make sure it applies to foreign nationals, Russians, involved in war crimes in Ukraine to help hold Putin accountable.

Mr. Khan says we have a lot of valuable information that could accelerate his prosecution not only of Putin but of others.

Are you familiar with the Wagner Group, Mr. Secretary?

Secretary AUSTIN. I am.

Senator GRAHAM. Do you think they're a terrorist organization?

Secretary AUSTIN. I think they are a horrible terrorist organization.

Senator GRAHAM. Well, I'd like to prosecute them, too. So what I would like to do is meet with you and your team to make sure that not only you follow the law but you understand the benefit of this legislation to help this war effort.

So, General Milley, what do all those stripes on your arm mean on your right shoulder, right arm there, those white stripes?

General MILLEY. Each one represents 6 months in combat.

Senator GRAHAM. Okay. Since 9/11 how many years have you been away from your family?

General MILLEY. Seven, eight, nine, probably about half the time.

Senator GRAHAM. Is that more typical than not for people in the military?

General MILLEY. No, it's actually very typical. I think my peers and those probably NCOs (Non-commissioned officers) at this point that have been in this thing since 9/11 have probably spent year-on/year-off for, you know, half the time basically deployed in Iraq or Afghanistan in combat.

Senator GRAHAM. Well, I hope you get some time with your family and thank your family for their service to our country.

Let's go to Afghanistan right quick. Based on the withdrawal of Afghanistan, our withdrawal from Afghanistan, General Kurilla said that, as Senator Collins indicated, 6 months we could be attacked without warning. Is that a fairly accurate statement from your point of view?

General MILLEY. 11 months ago I actually testified and said 12–18–24–36, I rounded it like that. So what Kurilla had said in his testimony, that's within the ranges that I had mentioned, as well. So absolutely. I mean, look at our ability to monitor and track terrorists in Afghanistan is less than it was with boots on the ground, true, but we still have the ability to monitor.

Senator GRAHAM. I know, I know, but let me ask this right quick. Are we less safe than we were before?

General MILLEY. I would just say that the United States military is committed to continuing to monitor, track, and, if necessary, take action—

Senator GRAHAM. Okay. All right.

Senator MILLEY [continuing]. Against any terrorist threat.

Senator GRAHAM. All right. I would just say we're less safe.

So Putin, if he wins, perceived at winning, what does that mean for the world? If he's perceived as having lost, what does that mean for the world? Is there a correlation in your view between success of Putin or failure of Putin and China's likelihood to invade Taiwan?

General MILLEY. I think that the Chinese are watching the war between Russia and Ukraine very carefully and I think for Ukraine obviously it's an existential threat for their very existence, but for Europe, for the United States, I think the issue is about a rules-based international order and I think that what Putin has done is an illegal direct assault on that order and if he's allowed to succeed in that, China will learn certain lessons and it may not be the single decisive point but I think it will calculate into their decision-making process as to whether or not they attack and seize Taiwan.

So I think the outcome of Ukraine is critical to much broader issues than just Ukraine.

Senator GRAHAM. And if Putin is seen as having lost, does that make America safer?

General MILLEY. I think it does because I think that what loss being defined as Ukraine remains a free independent sovereign country with its territory intact. If that is the end result of this war, then I think Putin will have failed in his attempts to take Ukraine and undermine that rules-based order and I really think that that order, which has been in existence for eight decades now, since the end of World War II, that's critical to global stability and world peace.

Senator GRAHAM. Okay. Mr. McCord, in 2033 under this budget, how much will we be spending on defense in terms of GDP (Gross Domestic Product)?

Mr. MCCORD. Senator, we have been in the three range for quite a while and we'll probably be right around three at the end of the process.

Senator GRAHAM. Well, my information says 2.5. So check that one out, see who's right. Okay?

The Navy real quickly thinks they need 370 ships, 373, and to get there, they have to spend 5 percent above inflation.

Do you agree this budget will not allow the Navy to get to 373 ships?

Mr. MCCORD. Within the FY DP (Future Years Defense Program), we will not be at that number.

Senator GRAHAM. Yes. Cause we're spending under inflation.

So real quickly, Mr. Chairman, there's a bunch of scenarios. None of them are really good. The House budget, 2022 plus one, is about a 14 percent cut, is that right, Mr. McCord?

Mr. MCCORD. I'm sorry. The House—

Senator GRAHAM. The House proposal, the 2022 plus one percent, what would that mean to the military? How many dollars would be lost?

Mr. MCCORD. In this year, it would be about a hundred billion below our request. Over—

Senator GRAHAM. Okay.

Mr. MCCORD [continuing]. Five years it would be about \$600 billion.

Senator GRAHAM. Okay. So a CR is a loss to the military, right, General—Secretary Austin?

Secretary AUSTIN. That's right, Senator.

Senator GRAHAM. Okay. This budget puts you below inflation. So the committee's task is to reject all of this stuff and come up with a number that keeps us safe.

Senator SCHATZ [presiding]. Thank you very much.

Secretary Austin, General Milley, thank you for being here.

I want to start in Hawaii the people of Oahu have suffered tremendously with the biggest pollution event in the State of Hawaii at Red Hill bulk Fuel Storage Facility and the defueling and closure of Red Hill must continue to stay on schedule.

I want to submit for the record a Unified Statement from Hawaii State Leaders about the importance of pure water and the remediation of the lands impacted by the Red Hill Fuel Spill.

Without objection.

[The information follows:]



STATE OF HAWAII
STATE CAPITOL
HONOLULU, HAWAII 96813



CITY AND COUNTY OF HONOLULU
HONOLULU HALE
HONOLULU, HAWAII 96813

May 9, 2023

Unified Statement on Red Hill

If we mālama the water, the water will mālama us. This is a relationship that requires active stewardship. The contamination of the land above the aquifer and of the aquifer itself are unprecedented threats. Our unified efforts are required.

Our goal is to have clean and pure water now and for future generations. Closure of the Red Hill tanks and facilities and remediation of the lands upon which they sit must meet this goal. Corrective actions and restoration of the aquifer may be required in addition to remediation in order to meet the goal of clean and pure water now and for future generations.

Aquifer remediation should be undertaken guided by a policy document that describes our goals, the implementation process, roles, guidelines, and regulatory framework as an agreement between the State of Hawai'i and the federal government. Development of the policy and the remediation effort itself will benefit from constructive and timely public engagement.

We seek a proactive approach, plan, and operational integration rather than one that defensively regulates a cleanup to the extent that current laws allow. We understand that this will require new ways of thinking and acting, locally and nationally. This is in the interest of all of the people of Hawai'i and, we believe, in the interest of this country.

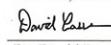
Supported by:


Governor Josh Green, M.D.
State of Hawai'i


Senator Ronald D. Kouichi
President, State Senate

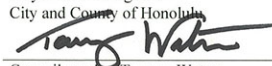

Dawn N. S. Chang
Chair, Board of Land and Natural Resources
Chair, Commission on Water Resource Management


Dr. Kenneth S. Fink
Director, State Department of Health


Dr. David Lassner
President, University of Hawai'i


Representative Scott K. Saiki
Speaker, State House of Representatives


Mayor Rick Blangiardi
City and County of Honolulu


Councilmember Tommy Waters
Chair, Honolulu City Council


Ernest Y. W. Lau, P.E.
Manager & Chief Engineer, Honolulu Board of
Water Supply

Senator SCHATZ. Secretary Austin, can you reassure the people of Hawaii that Red Hill will never be used for fuel storage or fuel operations once it is emptied?

Secretary AUSTIN. Yes, when I made that decision, that was my intent, Senator, and also thank you for everything that you and the delegation have done to help us move forward.

Senator SCHATZ. Are you on track to send your certification to Congress that our Indo-Pacific fuel needs won't be adversely impacted by the closure?

Secretary AUSTIN. Yes, we are on track and this is something that we work routinely. I just met with my leadership on Red Hill here last week to check to see where we are and, yes, we are.

Senator SCHATZ. Thank you.

As General Milley said, war with China is not inevitable. To avoid conflict, the department must use all tools available to it, new capabilities, alliances, partnerships and facilities in the AOR (Area of Responsibility).

Secretary Austin, the budget includes \$9.1 billion for the PDI (Pacific Deterrence Initiative). How are you going to ensure that these funds improve readiness and bolster deterrence without falling into the trap of fancy expensive gold-plated weapon systems?

Secretary AUSTIN. Well, this is something that, as you know, Senator, that we track very closely as the Indo-Pacific Command commander develops his requests. We work through each request with him and we're investing in those things that will provide us the ability to further forward station our troops and capability and so infrastructure is really, really important to us and you'll see that reflected in the PDI.

Senator SCHATZ. I think it's really important that we understand how achieved partnerships are compared to these weapon systems. Obviously we need a balance of both, but I think it's important for the Defense Appropriations Committee to make it clear to you that these partnerships are highly leveraged.

I mean, I think about Pacific Pathways with the Army. This is really small money and an enormous impact. Whenever I'm talking to INDOPACOM or in the Asia Pacific Region, they don't talk about the weapon systems. They talk about Pacific Pathways. I think Incas another example of a pretty highly leveraged partnership. It's not zero dollars but it's not nearly as expensive as the other stuff.

Commanders are preoccupied with failing sewer systems, fragile electrical grids, and deteriorating barracks. Dealing with these issues have real opportunity costs and take away from our readiness.

General Milley, the Active Army, Navy, and Air Force have requested over \$14 billion for FSRM (Facilities Sustainment, and Restoration and Modernization), a \$470 million increase over last year.

How are services ensuring that they'll make meaningful progress on improving the most critical aging infrastructure?

General MILLEY. Thanks, Senator, for that. Each of the services have very, very deliberate inspection programs. They have readiness calculations for all of their infrastructure. They go through a very rigorous process to ensure that their infrastructure remains modernized and up to date both from an operational standpoint for training but also for taking care of the families and the troops.

So they've got very rigorous processes to do that. Each one is slightly different, but I can come back to you with the exacts for each of the services if you'd like, but I've looked at those processes

when I was Chief Staff of the Army. They're all very rigorous in each of those services.

Senator SCHATZ. Please. Thank you.

Last question for Secretary Austin. Last year I stressed the importance of interagency coordination and the COFA (Compact of Free Association) negotiations and DoD's role as a silent but very important partner in the process.

Negotiations are ongoing, but I think they're going reasonably well and the strategic importance of these relationships with the Freely Associated States continue to grow.

Can you just talk about how important it is that the United States successfully renew the COFA Agreements on time?

Secretary AUSTIN. It's critical, Senator. These are partners that have—we have a long history with. They're incredibly helpful, incredibly patriotic, as you know. A large percentage of their population serve in our military and as you pointed out, State has the lead for this, but DoD is certainly a player and we will continue to contribute and hopefully help move things forward in a meaningful way.

Senator SCHATZ. As does VA (Veterans Affairs). I just wanted to quickly point out this. You know, we are talking about relatively small money, for instance, to make sure that veterans who are residing in COFA States get the VA services that they deserve, but we need a statutory change for that.

There's some resistance as if it's some big budget pressure item. It's not. But as you deal with Pacific Island leaders, you know, I would say thank God for small favors. These are the kinds of things that define our relationship with these Pacific Island leaders, whether we respect them, whether we respect their citizens, whether Secretary Blinken's slogan of friends, allies, partners is real to them, and so these big investments are important but it's the taking care of the people as though they are true partners that I think makes the difference.

Senator Murkowski.

Senator MURKOWSKI. Thank you.

Gentlemen, thank you. Chairman Milley, I know in your written testimony you acknowledged that this is your last set of posture hearings. So I don't know whether you're celebrating after this morning's hearing, but thank you. Thank you for your years of service and all you have provided us.

Today is kind of a significant day. We're all looking at the southern border with regards to Title 42 and all the implication there. The 11th of May is also a significant day far from the South in the Arctic. Today is the day that Russia is transferring the chair-ship of the Arctic Council to Norway. Hopefully all is going to be quiet and smooth and without a bump there and the governing body in the Arctic, the Arctic Council, will be moving forward, but it's something that I'm paying attention to cause both of you well know we're paying attention to the Arctic.

We appreciate the fact that all five services have updated their Arctic Strategy. We've come a long, long way as an Arctic nation and being able to focus clearly and with intent and so I was curious as I read through in full both of your statements this morning and

I am concerned because in neither of your statements is there acknowledgment or recognition of the Arctic.

Secretary Austin, you do use the word “Arctic” once in connection with the issue of climate, but I think we know that it is broader than just climate and certainly from a security perspective you’ve indicated that the budget is linked to strategy. It absolutely positively has to be and so the question to you this morning is whether or not you think the budget that we have in front of us is sufficient to implement these Arctic strategies?

Given the significance of the Arctic geopolitically, given what we’re seeing out of Russia, given what we’ve just seen in the past couple weeks with a very clear intention from Russia to be cooperating on bilateral perspective with China with regards to the Arctic, this should send signals to us that the partnering up there is changing, that peaceful multilateral cooperation that we have seen historically is changing in a dynamic way as a consequence of what we’ve seen with Putin’s aggressive and awful war in Ukraine.

But the question, I guess I’ll start with you, Chairman Milley, is whether or not you think that this budget is sufficient in regards to our priorities in the Arctic?

General MILLEY. Thanks, Senator, appreciate that.

I do think that because our forces are general purpose forces and they can be applied in the Arctic or they can be applied anywhere, and I personally think the Arctic is a critical geographic region of geostrategic importance and it’s increasing in its importance over time. That’s clear.

I’m attending the Arctic Chiefs Conference here shortly in the next couple weeks which I do every 6 months or so and that has all the chiefs of defense, Military Uniform Chiefs of Arctic Nations, not including Russia, by the way, and we get together to discuss the security issues with Norway and Canada and the other Scandinavian countries, etcetera. So we recognize the importance of the Arctic.

As you mentioned, all the services and all the commands have updated their programs, their strategies. In addition, we run a whole series of exercises and we’ve increased our capabilities. The 111th Airborne Division, for example, up in Alaska. So the Arctic is clearly recognized within the Department of Defense, within the Joint Force, as having a critical geostrategic importance and we have forces that are able to operate in the Arctic right now.

Senator MURKOWSKI. I think we recognize, though, that the training to the Arctic is perhaps a little more unique and this is why—

General MILLEY. Very unique.

Senator MURKOWSKI. This is why the 111th is so important with that focus.

Secretary Austin, in last year’s NDAA (National Defense Authorization Act), Section 603 authorized several policies that will improve the quality of life. We’ve been concerned about the issue of suicide, particularly up north, but we had included provisions related to special cold weather pay as well as an opportunity for the Secretary to reimburse eligible servicemembers for the cost of airfare, travel home to their home of record—well, their assigned on

duty location. All these designed to help offset some of the challenges that come when you are in a remote and expensive area.

I had asked earlier for some updates on when the soldiers might be able to expect receiving the cold weather duty pay as well as beginning receivements for the eligible travel and have not gotten responses that have clarified that.

So if you can help us with that?

Secretary AUSTIN. Certainly. We'll get you a response right away in terms of where we are in the process there in complying with the directive there.

Senator MURKOWSKI. Thank you. Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

Senator TESTER [presiding]. Senator Reed.

Senator REED. Well, thank you very much, Mr. Chairman.

First let me thank and commend General Milley for his extraordinary service. I first had the opportunity to meet the General when he was Assistant Commander of the 101st Airborne Division along with General McConnellville and since that time and before that you've been a remarkable soldier. Thank you, sir.

Mr. Secretary, you indicated to the Chairman that a default on our debt would have profound repercussions in the Department of Defense and that also tracks with the testimony of Avril Haynes, the Director of National Intelligence, before the Armed Services Committee.

But there's another aspect to this, too, and that would, I think, give China an opportunity to exploit this dramatically.

Do you have any concept of the strategic competition with China if we default?

Secretary AUSTIN. There is substantial risk to our reputation, Senator. Again, we are viewed as being a source of stability globally and we always pay our debts and there's just a number of things that we're working with allies and partners on that would come into question as to whether or not we'll be able to execute programs, but most important, this will affect the livelihood of our troops and our civilians. We won't be able to pay people like we should and I think that's something that China and everybody else can exploit.

Senator REED. Yes. Given the disposition of China, they would like to exploit every opportunity and this would present them a huge opportunity to provide disinformation to American citizens, to confuse them, and also in the world community, as you point out, to suddenly and miraculously look like the stable adult in the room and that would be—it's interesting we're all talking about strategic platforms and how do we, you know, operate vis-à-vis China.

This could be one of the greatest strategic eras vis-à-vis China in history, is that fair?

Secretary AUSTIN. I think that's an accurate statement there, Senator.

Senator REED. Thank you very much.

The Chairman also brought up the issue, which is, I found, profoundly disturbing of the inability to routinely confirm general officers and I know seven former Secretaries of Defense wrote a letter actually deploring this as a gross politicization of the military. You yourself wrote a letter to Senator Warren.

Mr. Chairman, I would like to include both these letters in the record.

Senator TESTER. Without objection.

Senator REED. Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

[The information follows:]



SECRETARY OF DEFENSE
1000 DEFENSE PENTAGON
WASHINGTON, DC 20301-1000

The Honorable Elizabeth Warren
United States Senate
Washington, DC 20510

MAY 05 2023

Dear Senator Warren:

Thank you for your letter requesting a full accounting of the impact on our national security and the risks to our military readiness resulting from Senator Tuberville's indefinite hold on the confirmation of our general and flag officers.

I appreciate and share your deep concern over this hold, which is unprecedented in its scale and scope. Delays in confirming our general and flag officers pose a clear risk to U.S. military readiness, especially at this critical time.

The Department of Defense has 64 three- and four-star nominations pending for positions due to rotate within the next 120 days. These include the Chief of Staff of the Army; the Chief of Naval Operations; the Commandant and Assistant Commandant of the Marine Corps; the Director of the National Security Agency and Commander of United States Cyber Command; and the Commander of United States Northern Command.

Additionally, several one- and two-star nominations are now on indefinite hold for general officers and flag officers slated to take command or support critical positions across the Joint Force. Within the next nine months, approximately 80 three- and four-star rotations are projected across the Department. Those positions include the Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, the Vice Chief of Staff of the Army, and the Vice Chief of Staff of the Air Force. In total, between now and the end of the year, the Department projects that approximately 650 general and flag officers will require Senate confirmation.

This indefinite hold harms America's national security and hinders the Pentagon's normal operations. The United States military relies on the deep experience and strategic expertise of our senior military leaders. The longer that this hold persists, the greater the risk the U.S. military runs in every theater, every domain, and every Service.

Mission Vacancies

The tenure of Service Chiefs is limited by law, and thus, incumbents must vacate their positions at the appointed time and may only be extended under extraordinary circumstances. Collectively, these positions oversee more than 1.2 million active and reserve component Service members and provide Service personnel and resources to the commanders of the unified combatant commands. By law, Service Chiefs preside over the capabilities, requirements, policies, and plans of their Services and serve as the principal military advisors to the Secretaries of the Military Departments. Put simply, our Service Chiefs train and equip the Joint Force.

Without these leaders in place, the U.S. military will incur an unnecessary and unprecedented degree of risk at a moment when our adversaries may seek to test our resolve.

The hold causes especially acute, self-inflicted problems in new domains of potential conflict. The Director of the National Security Agency and Commander of United States Cyber Command, is responsible for supporting every combatant commander and Service member around the globe — including troops in hostile or hazardous areas — with actionable signals intelligence and cybersecurity support. The Director also ensures that military communications and data remain secure and out of the hands of our adversaries, safeguarding our advanced command, control, communications, computer intelligence, surveillance, and reconnaissance capabilities against the People's Republic of China, Russia, Iran, North Korea, ISIS, and more. Failing to fill this position weakens the cybersecurity of the United States.

Furthermore, delays in confirming a large number of one- and two-star general and flag officers jeopardizes our current and future readiness. The Department relies on these experienced leaders to execute tactical actions every day and extend our strategic advantages for the long term. General and flag officers at this level are responsible for executing strategy, acquiring new technologies, enhancing tactical effectiveness, conducting joint training, and strengthening global alliances. These general and flag officers also provide direct leadership and mentorship to thousands of enlisted Service members and junior and field grade officers across the Department. Their importance cannot be overstated.

Power Projection Abroad

General and flag officers provide oversight of the Department's military and civilian staffs, help decide how we employ our forces, and take care of the Service members, civilians, and families in their organizations. Delays in confirmation will soon foist vacancies on the most senior military positions across each of the Services, imposing new and unnecessary risks on U.S. warfighters across multiple theaters of operations.

The hold also makes it harder for the United States to fulfil its global leadership responsibilities, including to our treaty allies and our valued partners around the world. Our smoothly running normal processes and predictable military transitions have long set helpful expectations among allies and partners. Now, however, this hold has created unnecessary uncertainty. That diminishes our global standing as the strongest military in the world, which is in large part based on our stable processes and orderly transitions.

General and flag officers have the authority to make decisions and commit resources, develop key policies, work with our allies and partners, and confront our rivals and foes. The full impact of this hold may not be immediately noticeable because of the resilience built into our military organizations, but over time, the hold will cause cascading impacts to our readiness and needlessly hinder our ability to meet our strategic objectives in the Indo-Pacific, Europe, the Middle East, and beyond.

The absence of experienced and Senate-confirmed senior leadership limits our ability to deepen our cooperation with our allies and partners through multilateral training and cooperative

engagements. Recent exercises, such as Balikatan 2023 with the Armed Forces of the Philippines or joint U.S.-Israeli naval activity in the Bab el-Mandeb Strait, may become even more difficult if delays in confirmation force other leaders to take on the responsibilities of officers held up by the Senate. This hold could force senior leaders to become dual-hatted, which would force them to juggle competing priorities and sap their ability to excel.

Knowledge and Expertise

Our general and flag officers cultivate their expertise and experience over decades of service. Military units need leaders, and our Service members deserve to be led by fully confirmed general and flag officers. The failure to confirm leaders in key roles transfers strategic risk down the chain of command and forces our units to operate with less experienced decision makers in charge. By destabilizing the senior military promotion and rotation process, we put our short- and long-term readiness at significant risk.

Failure to fill these positions in a timely manner is simply irresponsible. We owe it to our Service members to provide them with the best leadership possible, and the current hold jeopardizes the continuity and effective transition of leadership.

Service Members and Families

This hold disrupts not only our most senior military leaders but their families as well. Service members and military families are resilient, but the current hold adds another layer of stress and unnecessary uncertainty.

The damage here includes not just the disruption to our most senior officers, but also profound confusion and disturbance to our rising one- and two-star general and flag officers and their families. Extended holds increase the time from selection to promotion, which could further delay promotion timelines by 12 to 24 months. This impedes not only the current cadre of officers but those in the groups behind them as well.

General officer and flag officer end strength is tightly controlled by statute. Promotion of one cadre of officers is possible only with the retirement of others. Long-term holds have a corrosive and cascading effect: they prevent our rising officers and their families from being able to predict promotion and rotation windows, which can increase the pressure to leave the military in favor of greater stability. The more our normal promotion processes are jolted, the more we risk the loss of the diverse warfighting and technical expertise that America needs to confront its 21st-century security challenges.

The current hold also means delaying or canceling permanent change of station moves — not only for those now nominated and on hold but also for numerous officers and their families who must be extended on station to prevent critical gaps. Military children will be unable to move to new schools when the next school year begins, which imposes needless additional stress on those students and their families. Military families enrolled in the Exceptional Family Member Program may endure serious delays or be unable to access the services and support that they need and deserve when they transition to their new duty stations. And outstanding military

spouses may not be able to accept or start new jobs because they cannot predict when they could start. The families of our general and flag officers serve right alongside their Service members. The current hold imposes additional burdens upon our military families that are both unnecessary and unconscionable.

A Perilous Precedent

As such, the Department urges the Senate to resolve the current situation as swiftly as possible to limit these serious consequences. Never before has one Senator prevented the Department of Defense from managing its officer corps in this manner, and letting this hold continue would set a perilous precedent for our military, our security, and our country.

The ripple effects of this unprecedented and unnecessary hold are increasingly troubling. Ultimately, the breakdown of the normal flow of leadership across the Department's carefully cultivated promotion and transition system will breed uncertainty and confusion across the U.S. military. This protracted hold means uncertainty for our Service members and their families and rising disquiet from our allies and partners, at a moment when our competitors and adversaries are watching.

As public servants and officials sworn to protect and defend our Constitution, I hope that we can all acknowledge the national security risks posed by these needless delays and come together to safeguard the lethality and readiness of the most powerful fighting force in human history.

Thank you for your continued strong support for our Service members and our national security. I again urge swift action to confirm all U.S. general and flag officers.

Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read "Robert J. Butler". The signature is written in a cursive, flowing style with a large, stylized "B" and "T".

Letter from Seven Former United States Secretaries of Defense

May 4, 2023

The Honorable Chuck Schumer
Senate Majority Leader
U.S. Senate
Washington, DC 20510

The Honorable Mitch McConnell
Senate Minority Leader
U.S. Senate
Washington, DC 20510

Dear Leader Schumer and Leader McConnell,

As former Secretaries of Defense, we strongly urge the Senate to act expeditiously on the nearly 200 nominees for general and flag officer who are being blocked from Senate confirmation.

The blanket hold on the promotion or reassignment of these senior uniformed leaders is harming military readiness and risks damaging U.S. national security. Because the Senate is required to confirm every general and flag officer for promotion or for reassignment, this practice has traditionally been a *pro-forma* exercise, except where there have been specific concerns about individual nominees, which were then handled separately.

The current hold that has been in place now for several weeks is preventing key leaders from assuming important, senior command and staff positions around the world. Some are unable to take important command positions, such as leading the 5th Fleet in Bahrain and the 7th Fleet in the Pacific, which are critical to checking Iranian and Chinese aggression, respectively. Others include the next military representative to NATO, a post essential to coordinating allied efforts in support of Ukraine, as well as the future Director of Intelligence at U.S. Cyber Command. Leaving these and many other senior positions in doubt at a time of enormous geopolitical uncertainty sends the wrong message to our adversaries and could weaken our deterrence.

Moreover, if this blanket hold is not lifted, nearly 80 three- and four-star commanders who are ending their terms in the coming months will not be able to be replaced. Worse, this will impact certain members of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, including the Chairman of the JCS.

There are also real-world impacts on the families of these senior officers. Most cannot move and resettle their families; their children cannot enroll at their next schools on time; and spouses cannot start new jobs at the next duty station. We can think of few things as irresponsible and uncaring as harming the families of those who serve our nation in uniform.

We appreciate that Senators can have sincere and legitimate concerns about a Pentagon policy, including as it may relate to broader domestic or social issues. These lawmakers also deserve timely and thorough responses to their questions. However, we believe placing a hold on all uniformed nominees risks turning military officers into political pawns, holding them responsible for a policy decision made by their civilian leaders.

Rather, senators should leverage the numerous means available to them to challenge and change DOD policy, such as introducing legislation, conducting oversight hearings, or amending the annual National Defense Authorization Act.

We, therefore, strongly urge the Senate to ensure the continued readiness of the U.S. armed forces by lifting the blanket hold and promptly voting to confirm these uniformed nominees.

Sincerely,

The Honorable William J. Perry
Former U.S. Secretary of Defense

The Honorable William S. Cohen
Former U.S. Secretary of Defense

The Honorable Robert M. Gates
Former U.S. Secretary of Defense

The Honorable Leon E. Panetta
Former U.S. Secretary of Defense

The Honorable Chuck Hagel
Former U.S. Secretary of Defense

The Honorable James N. Mattis
Former U.S. Secretary of Defense

The Honorable Mark T. Esper
Former U.S. Secretary of Defense

Senator REED. General Milley, we talked conceptually about this issue. Can you give us an idea of the impacts that are beginning to happen and that will accelerate?

General MILLEY. Again, Senator, thanks. Let me make one comment on the default piece, though.

Senator REED. Yes, sir.

General MILLEY. China right now describes us in their open speeches, etcetera, as a declining power. Defaulting on the debt will

only reinforce that thought and embolden China and increase risk to the United States.

With respect to the general officers, there's about 650 that are on various lists throughout the services that are up for nomination, confirmation, and they're all going to go replace someone and they're going to be replaced. So it's 650 really times three. So you're looking at 1,800, maybe almost 2,000 officers. Probably all of them, I don't know for sure, but probably most of them are married. They probably have some kids. So you're probably looking at 3,000 to 4,000 lives that are directly impacted in my view. So that will have significant personal impact.

Then from a readiness standpoint, these are flag officers. So they're in charge of very large complex organizations and this is unsettling for the institution and it will have over time, I think, a significant degradation in readiness and capability, morale.

I think the impact is pretty significant on that whole—and I understand I'm going to stay out of the whole issue of why it's being held, but I think holding up commissioned officers' confirmations on anything other than their own personal talent and skills further politicizes the military and if the intent is to not politicize the military, I think it has the opposite effect. It drags the uniformed military right in the middle of a political argument.

Senator REED. I think you're exactly right and that's why we'll do our best to reverse this. Again, I think the cumulative effect is very, very dangerous to both readiness and certainly to the families of these officers.

A final point. I'm running out of time, but we talk a lot about the number of platforms you're going to have and etcetera. My recollection that has to be checked by the historians is that the French Army had many more tanks than the Wehrmacht in 1940, but what they didn't have is the combined arms teams, the communications, etcetera, and one of the areas we're trying to do is to get JADC2 (Joint All-Domain Command and Control) in place so that we can communicate which will multiply our power so that, you know, X number of platforms can be more effective even if our opponents have a lot more platforms.

Is that accurate or fair?

General MILLEY. It is, Senator. JADC2 is a critical component of the modernization of the Warfighting concept. It is the command and control section that brings it all together in a combined arms way. It involves software, hardware, procedures, etcetera. It's a key piece of the way the United States military intends to operate in the future operating environment and without it, you won't be able to execute combined arms operations. The JADC2 is critical.

Senator REED. And multiply the number of platforms we have effectively.

General MILLEY. Absolutely.

Senator REED. Thank you. Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

Senator TESTER. Senator Shaheen.

Senator SHAHEEN. Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

Secretary Austin, General Milley, Deputy Secretary McCord, thank you all for being here and, General Milley, let me echo all of the thanks from other members of the subcommittee for your long service to this country.

I would like to follow up on Senator Reed's comments and I'm disappointed that more of the members of the subcommittee aren't here because I'm not sure that everyone understands what the impact of holding these general officer nominations are on the military and I think Senator Reed and I are the only ones on this subcommittee on Armed Services who have had a chance to see this play out.

And while you may not want to get into the reason why these officers are being held up, I'm going to ask you, Secretary Austin, to explain the policy that you put in place that is the reason why our colleague from Alabama says he is holding these nominees.

Secretary AUSTIN. You're speaking of our policy on reproductive healthcare.

Senator SHAHEEN. Absolutely.

Secretary AUSTIN. Thank you, Senator. As you well know, Senator, about 18 percent of our force is female.

Senator SHAHEEN. That's right, and can you speak to how important it is to be able to recruit those women into the military, especially given that recruitment is down right now?

Secretary AUSTIN. I think it's critical that people be assured that if they join the force they will continue to have access to reproductive healthcare and currently we have about 80,000 of our women that are stationed in those areas where they don't have ready access to reproductive healthcare and they don't get a chance to pick where they live and where they're stationed.

And so, you know, what this policy does is ensure that that access exists, that they have the means to access reproductive healthcare, especially those things that are non-covered reproductive healthcare, and again this policy is firmly rooted in law. We've talked about the fact that the DOJ (Department of Justice) has provided an opinion. That opinion is posted on their website and so this is important for our force and again we have a young force and about one in five of our troop's area women and I think it's critical that they be assured that they'll have access.

I want them focused on the mission and not worried about whether or not they're going to have access to reproductive healthcare.

Senator SHAHEEN. And I would just add that we know that women serving in the military have a higher rate of unintended pregnancies than the general population in this country. So that's another reason why this is so important, but can you also address whether we would be making our recruitment numbers that we need to make for the military if we were not able to recruit women?

Secretary AUSTIN. Well, certainly that problem would be compounded by an order of magnitude. Again, our women do incredible work for us, Senator, and we are all very proud of them and they continue to amaze us each and every day and we would not be the force that we are without the contribution that they bring to the table and again it's throughout DoD. I'll make that comment.

Senator SHAHEEN. Well, thank you very much. I appreciate it as I do so many people the policy that you've put in place and I think it's absolutely critical and I hope that we are going to see this body address those holes that are being placed on our general officers.

I talked to one of them yesterday who's waiting to be sent out to another posting and he doesn't have his new title. He's basically in a holding pattern while he waits for that.

Secretary AUSTIN. It would be tragic if that kind of talent began to vote with their feet and because of the unpredictability leave our service and go do something else.

These people have earned the right to be promoted and their families deserve what comes with that, as well, and so we certainly don't want to begin losing people because we can't promote them.

Senator SHAHEEN. Absolutely. Mr. Secretary, you were asked, I think by Senator Moran, about the registry for those people at Red Hill and you said that that is in fact in place which I appreciate. I think that's important.

But DoD has not sought to set up a registry for military members who have been exposed to PFAS (Per- and Polyfluoroalkyl Substances). Can you speak to why that is?

Secretary AUSTIN. You're right. Obviously we have not done that and certainly PFAS is a national challenge and DoD continues to do everything that we can to help address this issue.

We recognize the importance of it and so we'll take a look at whether or not we can and should do that. We've increased our testing across the board and so I'll have our staff provide some recommendations to me and we'll come back to you and discuss this with you.

Senator SHAHEEN. I appreciate that. I've introduced an amendment in the last three NDAA's to try and set up a registry. We have a health study that the Agency for Toxic Substances and Disease Registry is about to complete at eight sites around this country with the health impacts of PFAS that will give us that real health data on which to base the impact of PFAS, but it's clear we know or we're pretty sure it's a carcinogen and so I hope that you will in fact take this seriously and I stand ready to be helpful in any way that I can.

Thank you. Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

Senator TESTER. Senator Murphy.

Senator MURPHY. Thank you very much, Mr. Chairman. Thank you all for being here and for your service.

As the new member of this subcommittee, General Milley, I've not had the pleasure to work with you through the appropriations process, but I am deeply grateful for your service and your willingness to continue to work with this committee.

I wanted to speak with you for a moment about information warfare. Our National Defense Strategy today has a robust information component. Today, the amount of money that Russia and China are spending on propaganda unfortunately dwarfs the amount that we are allocating to fight misinformation.

Obviously this has to be a component of your strategy, but you're partnered often with the State Department. There are certain things you can do that the State Department cannot. For instance, the Global Engagement Center at the State Department funds not-for-profits and fact-checkers on China and Russia's periphery that are trying to set the record straight.

So I want to just to ask you about why that partnership is important. I think we have to a whole of government approach to fight-

ing misinformation that involves making sure that your commanders have the ability to be nimble in fighting back against narratives that are endangering our Nation's security and endangering their security, but also it means making sure the State Department has resources to do the same.

General MILLEY. So, thanks, Senator, for the opportunity to comment.

Information has always been critical to the conduct of war. Throughout history and it's probably never more important than it is today, we're in the Information Age. We've got a wide variety of information tools. We've got the explosion of social media. You've got all kinds of tools that literally you can walk around with, iPhones, for example, and these are very, very powerful tools.

Now we're in the age of artificial intelligence algorithms. You've got the ability to do deep fake stories out there with people or store other things. So this is an area in which we need to get better and we need to get more coordinated.

Information oftentimes can be a decisive factor in the conduct of war. We've got a lot of really good programs inside the military and we know that we work well with intelligence agencies, for example, and the State Department, but this effort needs to be more coordinated and I think advanced to a greater level, given the capabilities of not only Russia but China. They have very significant information capabilities in cyber, very significant electronic warfare capabilities, and very significant disinformation capabilities, and they're active every single day.

So this is an area of real importance and we need to improve ourselves.

Senator MURPHY. Well, thank you for challenging this committee to step up on that effort.

General, Secretary Austin, there's reports that the Pentagon has sought a high level meeting with your counterparts in China and obviously we have been missing high level dialogue with the Chinese since the flying of the Chinese balloons over U.S. air space. There's no excuse for the provocative actions of the Chinese Government, but at the same time it's not good when we're not talking to each other at a high level and so my question is this.

My belief is that there's no choice to be made between having an effective China policy to try to make sure that their power does not expand in a way that hurts the United States and continuing a dialogue about the things where we can work together and the ways in which we address our challenges.

Can you just talk about the state of the mil-to-mil dialogue with China and your views on whether it's important to keep those channels open?

Secretary AUSTIN. I think it's critical, Senator. Thanks for bringing this topic up.

I have reached out to my counterpart on a number of occasions. I have conducted face-to-face meetings with the former Minister of Defense. There's a new Minister of Defense in the seat now. I've reached out to him. I've sent him a letter and offered to talk, as well. I'll continue to do that. I think that's critical.

You know, when you have two countries with this kind of capability and we're operating, you know, globally, I think we have to

have the ability to manage potential crises and really there are things that we will have to address from time to time and we really need to be able to pick up the phone and talk directly to senior people.

So I'll continue to work this. I think it's really important. We'll probably have another opportunity as we go out to Singapore for a conference in Singapore and if the opportunity presents itself, I'll look to engage my counterpart.

I think that we need to open that door and continue to engage each other.

Senator MURPHY. Well, I appreciate your public statements to that effect and the outreach that you're doing. Agree that these are not mutually exclusive goals to keep that dialogue open to avoid conflict, but also to make sure that we are plusing up resources both at DoD and at State to make sure that we are ready.

Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

Senator TESTER. Senator Boozman.

Senator BOOZMAN. Thank you, Madam Chairman, and — I'm sorry. Mr. Chairman.

Senator TESTER. Thank you for that.

[Laughter.]

Senator BOOZMAN. I was just with Senator Murray at another meeting. So I've got my Chairmen's mixed up.

I just want to say I agree with the point that Senator Murphy was trying to make that the communication really is real important. We've seen that in other areas when we've had situations like our situation with China and I know that you're working really hard to do that.

Congratulations to all of you for your great careers. We're going to miss you, General Milley. Who would have thought that the young hockey player would have all the stars and have such a tremendous career? So again congratulations.

Secretary Austin, you mentioned in your testimony that our cooperation with our allies and partners is central to co-developing best capabilities for our warfighters.

Recently, the record of decision was signed by Secretary Kendall that will make Ebbing airfield in Fort Smith, Arkansas, the future home for F-35 U.S. allied pilot training.

I continue to work with the Air Force to make having a premier pilot training center and ensure it's ready for time to train our ally and partner pilots.

Secretary Austin, can you briefly speak to how important this mission in Arkansas is to our national security?

Secretary AUSTIN. It's critical as our allies and partners invest in the kinds of capability that we have. F-35s are a great example.

We need to make sure that we're working together to increase interoperability and we do that, you know, by not only making sure that we have the policies and procedures in the right place but there's frequent contact. This working together with each other is—you know, you can't replace that. Also builds trust.

We know that when you need trust, you can't surge it. It has to be there. It's something you've got to work on each and every day and so the capability that you're speaking of in Arkansas I think

is critical and I know that we have some allies and partners that are really looking forward to using that capability.

So thanks for what you're doing to broaden our capacity here.

Senator BOOZMAN. Okay. Thank you. In regard to the foreign military sales, there's all kinds of benefits. We've seen that as stimulating the economy in our country and again just in providing the protection that we desperately need.

Unfortunately, this system is overburdened with regulation, bureaucratic logjams, and according to Mr. Eric Fanning's recent testimony in the Armed Services Committee it's resulted in an average delay of over 18 months to get on contract.

This leaves our allies vulnerable and turning to other countries to buy military capabilities.

Secretary Austin, how does FMS (Foreign Military Sales) contribute to the department's strategy of deterrence and what specific processes contribute to the unacceptable delay for getting capabilities on contract?

Secretary AUSTIN. Well, certainly FMS helps us to magnify our capability because if our allies and partners are working with the same kinds of equipment and are skilled on that and using that equipment, then it's really helpful in terms of expanding our footprint, our capability.

In terms of the kinds of things that contribute to lags, there are a number of things that come together. One, industry owns a piece of that and we would hope that, you know, as the contracts are inactive that they're able to meet the timelines and so coming out of a period of 2 years of COVID, that's had an impact on a number of things.

But there are also to your point bureaucratic issues that often get in the way. Now what we did, what I did early on 2 years ago was I put together a group of our senior people to really focus on the FMS process and to identify those bureaucratic issues and roadblocks that we could knock down and so that body continues its work and it's hard work, but we're going to do everything possible on our end to make sure that bureaucratic issues in the Pentagon are not solely holding things up, but again there are a number of things that come together to make this process more complicated than it should be.

Senator BOOZMAN. Right. I know sometimes we make that more difficult. So I think I can speak for the committee if there's anything we can do legislatively or, you know, be sure and let us know. That's so very important.

So thank you, Mr. Chairman.

Senator TESTER. Thank you, Senator Boozman, and I'm going to dovetail on to what you just said.

I can tell you what Congress can do to make things easier, not default on our debt like the House of Representatives wants us to do. Get a budget done on time so these guys don't have to deal with this uncertainty of a CR. Take the holds off the military promotions because, quite frankly, it's flat stupid and politicizing our military. That's what we can do and I know, Senator Boozman, you're a good man and I don't think you'd disagree with me. So thank you.

But the truth is, is this, Congress needs to step up and do their job. If we want to hold you guys accountable, if we want to hold the contractors that supply us with our military equipment accountable, we need to do our job and part of that job is making sure that we get a budget that keeps this country safe, and the other part of it is just not do stupid things like CRs and defaults and holding military promotions.

I just want to say thank you. Thank you for what you do every single day to keep this country safe, to lead some of the finest people on earth in our military. We appreciate your testimony here today.

ADDITIONAL COMMITTEE QUESTIONS

Senators may ask additional questions. I would ask that you get back to them as quickly as you possibly can with a response.

[The following questions were not asked at the hearing, but were submitted to the Department for response subsequent to the hearing:]

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED TO LLOYD J. AUSTIN III

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR JON TESTER

Question. The budget request assumes an inflation rate of 2.4 percent. However, yesterday's Consumer Price Index is now at 4.9 percent—lower than last year's peak, but still higher than your budget.

Secretary Austin, have you re-reviewed your budget request to account for price increases? Have you identified specific programs where you're going to be short of what's required to buy what you need?

If yes, can you please provide that data to the Committee?

Answer. This is a strategy-driven budget designed to implement the 2022 National Defense Strategy and the budget incorporates the Administration's FY 24 inflation projections. The Department thanks Congress for the additional funding and authorities provided in FY 2023 to help us on key areas like fuel, housing, and subsistence allowances.

The Department is working to counter the impacts of inflation and looks forward to working with Congress on this important matter. Our budget request uses inflation estimates provided by OMB, which are similar to those recently released by Congressional Budget Office. If those estimates do not prove to be on target, that will stress our ability to execute our budget.

The Department continues to assess the impacts of inflation and will continue to work with both the Administration and Congress to address resource implications. I can assure you that I will never hesitate to ask the President for the resources I believe we need to execute the mission.

Question. Based on current trends, are you comfortable with DoD's 2.4 percent estimate for next year?

Answer. The 2.4 percent estimate for FY24 is OMB's government-wide inflation projection, which the Department is required to use. It is very similar to the most recent estimate of 2.7 percent from the Congressional Budget Office. However, if the inflation estimates once again undershoot the real inflation rate, it may stress our ability to get all of our programs on contract and delivered in full on time. Similar to prior years, we may have to reprogram funds, such as for utilities, to address emergent requirements.

Question. For good reason, when we talk about China, we spend a lot of our time talking about its bad behavior in the Taiwan Strait.

However, we can't overlook the fact that China's global ambitions are presenting problems for every Combatant Command, including in Africa and Latin America. If we only prepare for a high-end Indo-Pacific fight, we will come up short worldwide.

Secretary Austin, these Combatant Commands aren't afforded significant force structure. Are they sufficiently resourced to ensure we remain the preferred partner of these regions? It seems to me that for relatively minor investments, we could make major headway here.

Answer. In FY 2023, the Department allocated more than \$130 million in appropriated funds for security cooperation programs to build the capacity of foreign partner national security forces in Central America, the Caribbean, and South America, and also \$175 million for such programs for foreign partner national security forces in Africa. These investments are in addition to the up to \$200 million appropriated under section 8068 of the Department of Defense Appropriations Act, 2023, for USAFRICOM or USSOUTHCOM to expand cooperation or improve the capabilities of allies and foreign partners in their areas of responsibility. This totals over a half a billion dollars in FY 2023 spending to expand cooperation and build partner capacity.

With the concurrence of the Secretary of State, the Department will continue to prioritize smart, targeted investments in and with these partners to deepen our shared security and build real capability in a way that strengthens security sector governance and enhances strategic resilience, within a global prioritization of security cooperation efforts.

Question. The War in Ukraine is now entering its second year, and both sides are gearing up for a spring offensive.

There are some who argue that given the threat from China, we can't afford to invest in Ukraine. I strongly disagree but defer to our military experts.

Mr. Secretary, to date, over \$60 billion has been appropriated for Ukraine's defense needs. Do you have the resources you need to continue supporting Ukraine?

Answer. Ukraine's battlefield requirements have evolved over time since Russia's unprovoked full-scale invasion on February 24, 2022. The security assistance we provide Ukraine is based on a collective assessment of the capability needed for success on the battlefield. Shifting dynamics on the ground necessitate agility in our security assistance efforts. The consistent and strong bipartisan support from Congress continues to help Ukraine make key gains, and we will continue evaluating the need for additional funding as the situation on the ground evolves.

Question. Last year, Congress accelerated investments in weapons to load up our weapons magazines for future contingencies.

In this year's budget, the Department is proposing multi-year procurement agreements for 9 different munitions. This would provide significant predictability and stability to the industrial base.

Secretary Austin, what is the industry feedback to these proposed contracts?

Answer. First, let me thank Congress for supporting our multi-year procurement authorities request in FY 2023. These authorities will help us send a clear demand signal to industry as we work to build our munitions stockpile to be ready to fight and win in any contest if called upon.

Industry feedback on our request for multi-year procurement authorities has generally been positive. Industry leaders see the advantages of increased predictability of demand from the Department. This persistent demand provides a signal to the industrial base, and it helps provide stability for sub-tier suppliers. Department and Service leadership are currently meeting with industry to map out the multi-year plans to increase inventory, reduce cost, and improve industrial base resilience. Multi-year procurement contracts remain a valuable tool for the Department to procure the munitions needed to support national defense. Moving forward, we will continue to advocate for ways to increase long-term flexibility for critical munitions to ensure that we have the rounds that we need.

Question. Secretary Austin, have you mapped-out the supply chains for each of these contracts to ensure that there won't be bottlenecks as quantities increase?

Answer. That work is currently underway. There are multiple, critical components with long lead times across the Department's programs, and several are common to multiple systems for which we are pursuing multi-year procurement. We are examining approaches for enabling those suppliers to meet the necessary ramp-up. Industry is also looking across its portfolios to identify commonality of critical components with long lead times and broadcast these demand signals across the industrial base.

Question. Shortages in our supply chain are delaying major programs across every military Service, hampering our ability to field new capabilities to the warfighter on cost and on time.

Secretary Austin, when the Department makes a contract award, how does it track the performance of suppliers? It seems we often rely on the prime contractor instead of identifying and managing key suppliers ourselves. The results have been mixed.

Answer. The Department tracks performance of its suppliers via the Federal-wide Contractor Performance Assessment Reporting System to measure the quality and timely reporting of past performance information. The prime contractor is held responsible for managing their supply chains, including tracking sub-supplier per-

formance. The Department is currently evaluating other methods and approaches to engage with sub-suppliers on a more regular basis.

Question. Secretary Austin, this budget request includes billions of dollars of direct spending to suppliers in the industrial base. If we don't have the data to track what they're providing—and to whom—how are we ensuring that this investment is paying dividends and accelerating weapons deliveries?

Answer. I agree that the Department needs data to track whether or not we are getting equipment into the hands of warfighters as soon as possible, an effort that is ongoing in the Department. We have also worked with industry to identify steps it can take to accelerate production, such as workforce initiatives and advance procurement of long lead time items. We have also leveraged authorities such as the Defense Priorities and Allocations System under DPA title I to help accelerate deliveries.

The accelerated deliveries we are seeing from these engagements and investments show that these efforts are paying dividends, especially in Ukraine. For instance, these efforts have enabled production of 155mm artillery projectiles at a higher monthly throughput and did so 6 months earlier than were originally projected. Similarly, suppliers in the GMLRS supply chain have been able to increase production rates ahead of schedule, increasing overall deliveries compared to last year. These multi-pronged efforts are building enduring industrial capacity, both to support Ukraine and potential conflict with peer adversaries and to ensure the security of the United States, our partners, and our allies.

Question. The Department of Defense spends roughly \$40 billion a year on Information Technology systems.

However, instead of delivering modernized and transformational IT systems, the end product is often behind schedule and over budget. This is not just a DoD problem, the VA struggles with the exact same issue.

For example, the Navy's new pay and personnel system has disrupted pay and benefits for thousands of sailors and veterans in recent years. This is unacceptable.

Secretary Austin, how can we close the gap between what we need these IT systems to do for us and what is actually delivered in a timely and cost-effective manner?

Answer. DoD recognizes the imperative of improved software to enable defense operations using modern development approaches. Following the publication of the DoD Software Modernization Strategy in 2022, the Department is transitioning to an agile approach to buy, develop, and deliver secure software at the speed of relevance, while adapting DoD culture to embrace modernization. Further, the Department has implemented the Software Acquisition pathway under the Adaptive Acquisition system to support this approach. By adopting this strategy, software is being delivered more consistently, faster, and more securely than ever before.

Question. Secretary Austin, what processes do you have in place to ensure we are getting what we pay for?

Answer. DoD has several procedures in place to ensure that it is receiving the Information Technology (IT) systems for which it paid. These include management of requirements, procurement, development, testing, deployment, operation, maintenance, and oversight. The complexity, speed, and cost of IT systems are some of the issues DoD must overcome to maintain the effectiveness and efficiency of its IT systems. Despite these obstacles, DoD is dedicated to making sure it receives value for the money spent on IT systems.

Question. This budget request is again proposing record investments in research and development. You are asking for \$145 billion dollars in R&D spending, which is more than \$5.2 billion over the fiscal year 2023 enacted amount.

Mr. Secretary for years, R&D has been used to mature and prototype technologies like hypersonic weapons and artificial intelligence. These technologies will give us decisive capabilities in a near-peer competition with China, so when will they become real programs that are fielded at scale? My concern is that we are at risk of falling into the trap of 'perennial prototyping', and not actually delivering capability in relevant numbers to our troops by increasing procurement. This budget does not transition prototypes to procurement in significant numbers.

Answer. The Department is in a period of modernization that will ensure our ability to deter and, if necessary, defeat any potential adversary. This necessitates that the Department experiment with new capabilities and invest in inserting new technology into our systems to provide our warfighters with the capabilities they need to meet the pacing challenge.

The Department is constantly working to improve existing tools and pathways to transition technology. The Middle Tier of Acquisition opens new opportunities for program offices to prototype and/or field new capability while developing the documentation for a formal program of record. The Department's Competitive Advantage

Pathfinders initiative is identifying bureaucratic gaps in our system and working with the Services to develop or inform new processes in the Defense Acquisition System.

Through the Rapid Defense Experimentation Reserve program, we are also developing the capacity for rapid prototyping, to deliver game-changing capabilities to the battlefield quickly. We are focused on getting the right capabilities as fast as possible to the warfighter.

Finally, the Department has stood up a new Acquisition Integration and Interoperability office to address the challenges in acquiring and managing joint capabilities, including transitioning new technology.

Question. Congress has established a Commission to review the Department's budget process and make recommendations to speed up the process of getting stuff to the warfighter. Often, these Commissions point the finger at Congress (in some cases, rightfully so!) without addressing barriers inside the Department that you could fix yourself.

Secretary Austin, where do you feel the primary pitfalls are in DoD's current budget process, and what is the Department doing internally to improve its processes?

Answer. Delivering state-of-the-art capabilities at speed and scale is critical to ensuring that we maintain our enduring military advantage. The Department regularly reviews obstacles across the acquisition, requirements, and resourcing systems to maximize critical capability delivery. Any discussion regarding speeding up acquisition must also account for the considerable effort required leading up to the initiation of procurement processes, namely the identifying military requirements and securing resources. For that reason, the Department works collaboratively between program and acquisition workforces to improve our policies and processes to get the right capabilities to the warfighter as fast as possible.

Question. Mr. Secretary, Congress has already provided authorities to reduce paperwork and speed up acquisitions. Yet we continue to hear about internal roadblocks, such as long contracting times. How are you addressing this?

Answer. Maintaining focused alignment to the strategy while balancing limited resources across the Department's many competing missions, priorities, and constituencies is always the primary challenge throughout the programming and budgeting process. Over the last several cycles, the Department has made significant progress toward implementing the 2022 National Defense Strategy by actively shaping our internal review processes to ensure that senior leadership's program and budget deliberations are tightly scoped to the most compelling challenges facing the Department. By streamlining the avenues for the submission of issues utilizing both top-down and bottom-up processes and emphasizing the analytic and programmatic links to the strategic priorities and focus areas, the Department continues to substantively improve the budget-to-strategy alignment.

Delivering state-of-the-art capabilities at speed and scale is critical to ensuring that we maintain our military advantage. The Department brought together a team that is actively identifying obstacles across the acquisition, requirements, and resourcing systems, and working to deliver critical capability faster. We are also implementing organizational improvements, coordinating with allies and partners and industry, and using lessons learned from our Foreign Military Sales tiger team to ensure that acquisitions can rapidly support the joint force and our allies and partners. Through the Rapid Defense Experimentation Reserve program, we are also developing the capacity for rapid prototyping, to deliver game-changing capabilities to the battlefield quickly. We are focused on getting the right capabilities to the warfighter as fast as possible.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR RICHARD J. DURBIN

Question. Can the Department describe how it will engage with EPA to establish robust, safe, and science-based clean-up standards to protect communities and to continuing to update these standards with EPA as science and technology on PFAS contamination evolve?

Answer. There is nothing I take more seriously than the safety, health, and well-being of the force, of our military families, and of the communities around our installations. The Department has taken a number of actions over the last few years to remove PFAS from things we currently use—like firefighting foam—to strengthen our drinking water monitoring efforts, and to provide support to Service members who have healthcare concerns about past PFAS exposure. PFAS are a national challenge, and the Department is committed to doing our part. We continue to work with the U.S. Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) to understand the potential

health impacts from PFAS-impacted drinking water, and support EPA efforts to finalize a safe drinking water standard for PFAS to also be used in our PFAS clean-ups nationwide.

Question. Please detail the Department's research and development of PFAS alternatives in critical uses in national security including but not limited to microelectronics and weapons systems, and non-incineration PFAS destruction technologies, including but not limited to: electrochemical oxidation, SCWO, and other thermal treatment processes?

Answer. The Department is currently assessing the mission and readiness risks associated with emerging constraints in the PFAS supply chain. Currently, PFAS are enablers of critical defense technologies and have essential application to our critical infrastructure. PFAS also have essential uses in microelectronics, semiconductors, energy storage, and batteries.

To fully address PFAS in our systems and to develop and scale alternatives, we have a long road of research and development ahead of us. We will work with suppliers to rapidly assess and adopt alternatives currently under development that meet performance specifications. The Department's research and development officials are working with our best scientists across the interagency to develop a long-term plan for replacements. We estimate that it may be between six to 10 years before viable alternatives can be developed and demonstrated, with the potential for significant associated costs.

Question. How does the Department plan on coordinating with relevant agencies, industry, and academia to research alternatives to these critical PFAS in both?

Answer. We must be deliberate in taking a nationwide, cross government approach to ensure research investments are efficient and complementary as we jointly seek to determine the viability and scalability of alternatives to PFAS. The Department's Emerging Chemicals Governance Council oversees coordinated lines of effort to identify essential uses of PFAS and prioritize actions according to vulnerabilities to national security. The Department is also expanding resources, as well as working within the Strategic Environmental Research Development Program, an interagency group established in statute to review development needs. In addition, the Department coordinates with industry and the interagency through routine engagement meetings to discuss obsolescence risks and possible PFAS alternatives.

Question. As the Department advances in destruction technologies, can you work to assure that these alternatives do not release PFAS or products of their incomplete destruction into the air, water, or other environmental media?

Answer. DoD is committed to using and advancing the best available science and treatment technologies to treat, destroy, and dispose of PFAS. The Department currently uses disposal options with the most stringent controls where an environmental regulator has issued a permit for the facility. The Department is engaging in robust efforts to advance our knowledge on destruction removal efficiencies, potential releases of products of incomplete destruction, and effective emission control devices. This year, the Department's Environmental Security Technology Certification Program will award over \$40 million to 16 projects focused on improving the effectiveness and reducing the implementation costs of advanced destruction technologies.

Question. Can the Department achieve a broader phase-out of non-essential, or non-critical, PFAS uses and procurement in the next 10 years?

Answer. We are rapidly and deliberately assessing uses of PFAS in the Department's supply chain. However, it is difficult to determine a timeline for completion. We are phasing out non-essential and non-critical uses of PFAS where there is no mission impact such as in food packaging, cookware, furniture, and personal protective firefighting equipment in accordance with requirements. However, the PFAS supply chain is not transparent, and it will require multiple government agencies working together to phase out non-essential or non-critical PFAS uses and procurement. We will continue to keep the Congress informed on this issue.

Question. If not, can you put a timeline on how long such a phase out may take?

Answer. It is difficult to establish a timeline for completion. We are challenged by the need for transparency in the supply chain, the complexity of dissecting the defense industrial base value chain, anticipating market dynamics, identifying the number and specificity of products requiring alternatives, related requalification requirements, and the complexity of the supply chain dependencies. Nevertheless, the Department is committed to addressing this important issue deliberately and expeditiously, and keeping the Congress informed as we work through this process.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR BRIAN SCHATZ

Existing Red Hill Health Registry

Question. During the May 11 hearing, Secretary Austin confirmed that DoD established a registry of potentially exposed individuals to the Red Hill fuel spill.

Is this registry synonymous with the DOEHRS Red Hill incident report?

Answer. Yes, this registry is synonymous with the Red Hill Defense Occupational and Environmental Health Readiness System (DOEHRS) Incident Report.

Question. What population is included in the registry? Are non-DoD affiliated individuals included?

Answer. DoD-affiliated individuals potentially exposed to the JP-5 fuel release in November 2021 are included in the registry. Non-DoD-affiliated individuals are not eligible to be included in the Red Hill DOEHRS Incident Report.

Question. Are individualized health data captured within this registry?

Answer. No. Individual health data for TRICARE beneficiaries is maintained in the DoD electronic health record system, which can be linked to the Red Hill DOEHRS Incident Report by DoD Identification Number.

Question. How will DoD utilize these data to track long-term health effects?

Answer. DoD will analyze healthcare encounter data to determine whether there is any presence of health conditions which occur at a greater frequency than would otherwise be expected in the general population.

Future Red Hill Health Registry Options

Question. There is limited data on the long-term health effects of exposure to jet fuel, particularly for vulnerable populations like pregnant people and young children. This lack of data means that it is essential to take up ATSDR's recommendation to launch a third-party registry and conduct long-term epidemiological studies of the exposed population. DHA has indicated that it is exploring potential avenues, including a third-party registry. Time is of the essence as the longer DHA delays, the harder it will be to ensure a comprehensive account of all who were exposed.

How many individuals have been added to the Red Hill incident report through the hotline?

Answer. 446 out of 28,626 individuals in the Red Hill DOEHRS Incident Report were added through the call center.

Question. A critical function of an effective registry is as a communications tool, including sharing resources and new data as it becomes available. Beyond the initial outreach to housing sponsors to inform them that they and their dependents were included in the Red Hill incident report, how has DHA used this tool to share information with individuals included?

Answer. DoD publicly presented an interim update on registry planning at the last Hawaii Fuel Tank Advisory Committee in November 2022 and will do so again in June 2023. We are also actively engaged in communication with the surrounding and affected community. Once Joint Base Pearl Harbor-Hickam workers are added to the Red Hill DOEHRS Incident Report, which we expect to be within the next month, DoD will update all sponsors in the Red Hill DOEHRS Incident Report by email.

Question. If DHA adopts a third-party registry: Would the registry be procured and administered by DoD or HHS?

Answer. The registry will be funded by DoD. A third party will independently administer the registry via a DoD grant.

Question. How does DHA intend to consult with subject matter experts on the design and operation of the registry, including ATSDR?

Answer. DoD has been regularly consulting with exposure registry subject matter experts at the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention's Agency for Toxic Substances and Disease Registry and the Department of Veterans Affairs.

Question. How will DHA ensure it is managed and maintained independently?

Answer. DHA is committed to a fully independent Red Hill registry through awarding a grant to a qualified third partner.

Question. What is DHA's plan to collaborate with trusted community partners on this effort?

Answer. DHA expects that the selected registry partner will actively engage with the Red Hill community and consider their needs, values, and preferences in the design and conduct of the Red Hill registry. This will be written into the grant requirements.

Question. Does DHA have authorities necessary to transfer data from DOEHRS to ATSDR/its contracted grantee? If not, what authorities are required?

Answer. Yes, DHA generally has the authority to enter into a data use agreement.

Question. What steps will DHA take to ensure effective recruitment of civilians?

Answer. DHA will work with the third-party registry partner, the Hawaii Department of Health, Centers for Disease Control and Prevention's Agency for Toxic Substances and Disease Registry, the EPA, and other partners to ensure individuals potentially exposed to the fuel release are educated and encouraged to enroll in the registry.

Question. How long would DHA intend to maintain the registry?

Answer. DHA does not have a registry end date at this time. DHA will support the registry as long as it maintains value to the Red Hill community, stakeholders, public health authorities, and researchers.

Question. What factors would DHA weigh to decide whether to maintain or suspend the registry?

Answer. DHA will support the registry as long as it maintains value to the Red Hill community, stakeholders, public health authorities, and researchers.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR TAMMY BALDWIN

Building and Maintaining the Defense Industrial Base

Question. One takeaway military leaders mention regarding institutional lessons learned from our support for Ukraine is the importance of the domestic defense industrial base and the ability to quickly ramp-up production to meet replenishment requirements. The U.S. is currently struggling to replenish munitions stockpiles as the war with Ukraine continues—just one example why not just building a strong and enduring defense industrial base is critical to meet today's challenges and future threats.

What is the Department of Defense's current assessment of the domestic defense industrial base's ability to meet sudden increases in demand, particularly with regards to munitions production, in the wake of unexpected geopolitical developments such as the 2022 Russian invasion of Ukraine?

Answer. America's defense industrial base (DIB) is one of our core strategic assets, and the Department is focused on shoring up this advantage. Decades of under-investment in critical munitions and an uneven message to the DIB have resulted in some challenges to its ability to quickly respond to demand. However, we have seen significant improvement over the past 2 years, particularly as the DIB has moved to support Ukraine's self-defense and maintain U.S. readiness.

We are sending steady and certain demand signals to industry, in particular through a \$170 billion FY24 President's budget (PB) request for procurement—the largest ever—and seeking multi-year procurement authorities for critical munitions.

I am regularly briefed on the status of our munition stocks given the ongoing need to provide weapons to Ukraine, backfill stocks for the United States, and support our allies and partners. Securing investments in munitions to meet the quantities necessary today and tomorrow is critical to our ability to deter and, if necessary, defeat any would-be challenger.

Question. Does the President's proposed defense budget provide sufficient predictability and support for the defense industrial base, particularly in capital and labor-intensive areas such as shipbuilding, vehicle maintenance, and other related sectors?

Answer. Yes. The Department is making major investments to shore up shipbuilding, including in the FY24 PB request: \$2.7 billion for the Shipyard Infrastructure Optimization Plan, and \$1.2 billion for the submarine industrial base. We are also working to on-shore defense supply chains, including FY24 budget request investments of \$2.6 billion in microelectronics, \$177 million in forging and casting, and more than \$250 million in critical materials. This budget request also includes \$48.1 billion for modernization of our naval forces, and you will see us deliver nine battle force ships this year.

Question. What is the status of the Department's implementation of Executive Order 14005?

Answer. The Department is committed to maximizing the use of goods, products, and materials produced in, and services offered in, the United States, consistent with Made in America laws and regulations.

The Department plays an instrumental role with other Federal agencies to implement Executive Order 14005, Ensuring the Future is Made in All of America by All of America's Workers. The Department is supporting the implementation of the order in the Federal Acquisition Regulation (FAR) rule (FAR Case 2021—008), effective October 25, 2022, that executes an initial increase of the domestic content threshold from 55% to 60% and then a phased, multi-year increase to 75% by calendar year 2029.

The Executive Order also requires the Department to submit bi-annual reports to the Office of Management and Budget/Made in America Office describing progress toward the implementation of and compliance with Made in America laws and the Department's use of waivers or exceptions. The most recent report submitted in February 2023 included a Build America, Buy America Act Implementation Plan. The Department is currently supporting the development of further implementing guidance in the FAR and Defense FAR Supplement.

Clean-up parity between Active Duty and National Guard locations

Question. I am committed to ensuring that the Defense Environmental Restoration Program successfully cleans up all toxic elements in impacted areas, to include National Guard locations. In previous years there was a discrepancy between access to funding between active component and National Guard installations. Due to a policy change in 2017, the National Guard was removed from the Defense Environmental Restoration Program and no longer had the same access to funds as active duty locations. My colleagues and I secured a reversal of this policy to place National Guard installations back into the program.

How does the program currently prioritize sites for clean-up of hazardous substances?

Answer. The Department shares your concern about hazardous substances and the safety, health, and welfare of all personnel on DoD bases as well as members of the surrounding communities in and around our facilities. The Department prioritizes sites based on risk, by evaluating the relative risk to human health and the environment and addressing the highest risk sites first across all installations, including National Guard installations.

Question. Do National Guard installations currently have access to clean-up funds through the Defense Environmental Restoration Program?

Answer. Yes. National Guard installations that meet the requirements for the Defense Environmental Restoration Program (DERP), as updated by the FY 2023 NDAA, have access to clean-up funds under that program. Each Military Department prioritizes the cleanup of its DERP sites based on risk. The Air Force and Army prioritize their sites and DERP-eligible National Guard sites together and address the highest risk sites first.

Question. What was the impact of being removed from the program for National Guard installations and what is being done to address any backlog that National Guard installations may have experienced when they were excluded from the program?

Answer. The Department is committed to addressing releases at National Guard installations. National Guard sites impacted with certain per- and polyfluoroalkyl substances, had full access to Defense Environmental Restoration Program funds during the time period covered in the FY23 NDAA provision, and the Department will continue to ensure that all facilities, including National Guard installations have access to clean-up funds.

Noise Mitigation

Question. The Office of Local Defense Community Cooperation provides critical assistance to counties and municipalities to both foster cooperation with military installations as well as to address any concerns or challenges communities encounter as neighbors to military installations.

This office has provided critical assistance to Wisconsin in the form of a planning and outreach grant as the state starts to receive the F-35 aircraft at Truax Airfield in Madison.

I've noticed a trend over the last few years in which the budget request for OLDCC falls well below what many deem necessary to accomplish its increasing program demands.

What are you doing to support OLDCC as it expands in both staffing levels and in demand for its programs?

Answer. The Department recognizes that defense communities provide indispensable support to our installations, our Service members, and their families, and that it is imperative that we be conscientious and committed partners with those communities. The Office of Local Defense Community Cooperation (OLDCC) staff and programs are a critical component of that partnership, and the Department remains committed to community outreach programs that improve community infrastructure and improve installation resilience.

Question. Does the current budget for this program support this critical community outreach program?

Answer. Yes, it does. The FY24 budget request for OLDCC is \$118.2 million. The Department appreciates the work the OLDCC does with states and communities to

respond to defense activities and actions and will continue to ensure they have the resources necessary to fully carry out their programs of assistance.

QUESTION SUBMITTED BY SENATOR SUSAN M. COLLINS

Question. Budget Top-line: Today, China already has the largest Navy and Army in the world. Its Navy and Air Force will continue to grow and modernize while this budget request proposes to shrink our Navy and the Air Force. I am having trouble squaring the Administration's national security strategy with a budget request that proposes to increase non-defense spending by 8.5 percent, while defense spending would increase at a rate of 3.3 percent, which is less than half the rate of growth for non-defense spending.

Does the budget request include only those China-related investments that fit within external constraints (e.g. topline from OMB)?

Answer. The President's FY 2024 Defense budget request is a strategy-driven budget which aims to fund the right mix of capabilities necessary to deter and, if necessary, fight to win in any contingency. The 2022 National Defense Strategy (NDS) makes clear that the People's Republic of China (PRC) is our pacing challenge and we have crafted a budget that addresses that challenge.

As the PRC races to modernize its military, this budget makes major investments in our dominance in all warfighting domains, including space and cyber, and invests in integrated air and missile defenses and operational energy efficiency. The budget also invests in critical munitions, including hypersonic and sub-sonic weapons, to sustain our military advantage. The FY 2024 budget request includes \$9.1 billion for the Pacific Deterrence Initiative, an increase of more than 40% over the FY 2023 enacted level. These funds will support the development of advanced capabilities, new operational concepts, and a more resilient force posture in the Indo-Pacific region as we continue to work to build the Joint Force necessary to maintain dominance and have a distributed and resilient security architecture in the region.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR LISA MURKOWSKI

Question. Secretary Austin, thousands of U.S. service members, five ships and more than 150 aircraft are participating in Northern Edge 2023 (NE23-1), a joint field training exercise at various locations in and around Alaska, which began 4 May 2023. Preliminary reports state there have been challenges with the coordination of Link16 between the DoD and FAA.

Are these challenges having a tangible impact on our military competitiveness both in the ability to execute training and to modernize our weapon systems?

Answer. The Northern Edge joint training exercise is an important opportunity for the Department to learn about our capabilities in a high-end conflict, and to identify challenges that we must address to remain dominant on the battlefield.

Link 16 is critical for coordinating joint fires between our partner nations and ourselves and providing essential situational awareness to protect Allied forces from hostile and friendly fire threats during this exercise. The spectrum employed by Link 16 in CONUS is allocated to the Federal Aviation Administration (FAA) and used for radio navigation aids utilized in the national airspace, so we must strike a balance between our needs for operational training and the FAA's requirement to prevent interference with navigation radars and collision avoidance systems.

From a military competitiveness perspective, there have been no significant impacts to modernization efforts. However, DoD is currently working with FAA to develop new certification and deconfliction procedures to expedite the approval of Link 16 systems to permit unconstrained operations in the national airspace.

Question. Can you discuss some of the current impacts experienced?

Answer. There have been some challenges to exercises and training due to this current restriction of requiring FAA approval within 200 nautical miles of the United States. My staff is engaged with the FAA to resolve this issue in a way that supports DoD use of the National Airspace System while ensuring safe and efficient use by commercial and general aviation. We also continue to work with the Services to ensure these impacts are minimal by initiating requests as early as possible and ensuring that FAA coordination is present during all exercise and event planning.

Question. Were there difficulties getting Link16 approval from the FAA for NE23-1 and if the approval hadn't gone through last minute what would the impacts have been to this exercise?

Answer. While there were some challenges, FAA collaborated with DoD extensively to facilitate the objectives of the Northern Edge exercise. Without the approval of the FAA, our exercise would not have delivered a realistic training envi-

ronment for our warfighters, and we would have lacked the interoperability we seek with joint counterparts and allies.

Question. Secretary Austin, recently I was on a CODEL to Ukraine, and I continue to be awe-inspired by the resilience of the Ukrainian people and the leadership of President Zelenskyy in the face of the unspeakable atrocities unleashed against them by Vladimir Putin. More than ever, I am fully committed to ensuring that Congress provides the assistance that Ukraine needs. This assistance is not a waste and is vital to their success. We recently saw the Ukrainians use their Patriot Battery to shoot down an inbound Russian ballistic missile. I want to thank you, Mr. Secretary and Chairman Miley, for your unwavering support of Ukraine and for the assistance you provided them. However, for all this success, there are areas in which they need greater assistance. For example, Russia's electronic warfare capabilities have been taking a significant toll on Ukraine's forces.

Mr. Secretary, can you explain what the DoD has done to bolster Ukraine's electronic warfare capabilities?

Answer. The Department provides Ukraine with equipment based on a collective assessment of the capabilities Ukraine needs to be successful on the battlefield, while balancing U.S. readiness requirements, required training, sustainability, and other factors. Our assistance to Ukraine has included defense articles to support Ukraine's electronic warfare capabilities such as electronic jamming equipment and detection equipment. This equipment, combined with all the other security assistance we have provided, has helped the Ukrainians to achieve success on the battlefield.

Question. What are we doing to bolster our own electronic warfare capabilities?

Answer. The Department is taking actions to bolster our capabilities to fight in a contested and congested electromagnetic spectrum. We are investing in advanced technologies and fielding electromagnetic warfare capabilities with intelligent analytics to address the sophisticated near-peer threat. We continue to invest in offensive electromagnetic attack capabilities and pathfinder initiatives which leverage Service-specific electronic warfare investments and rapidly transition them to other Services. In addition, we have increased manning and resourcing at USSTRATCOM to expand training and exercising, which enable an assessment of the performance of our operational forces and systems in a contested and congested electromagnetic spectrum.

Question. Secretary Austin, in the FY2023 NDAA, Section 603 authorized several policies that will drastically improve the quality of life of soldiers stationed in Alaska. After making inquiries with leadership in the state, I understand there has been no guidance released for how these new policies should be implemented. Servicemembers are missing out on time-limited incentives to help alleviate the unique hardships of serving in Alaska, as well as improve recruitment and retention in the state. This is not AIP (Assignment Incentive Pay) from the Army programmed budget, which includes all AIP programs (Korea, USASOC, CYBER, Operational Deployments, etc.) whereas when soldiers arrive in Alaska and signs a written agreement to serve the prescribed tour. Congressional intent is for this to be in addition to what the Army is currently providing service members through AIP.

What is the status on implementation of Section 603(a) of P. L. No. 117-263 regarding cold weather special duty pay?

Answer. The Department thanks Congress for enacting laws that allow the Department to assign incentive pay and special duty pay to members serving in cold-weather locations. Implementation of policies pertaining to cold weather special duty pay is on track.

The Military Departments have the necessary flexibility to offer the monetary incentives Congress envisioned to Service members assigned to cold weather locations. Monetary incentives in these locations are dependent on and driven by the needs of the individual Services. The Secretaries of the Military Departments have sufficient authority to establish or abolish assignment incentive pay or special duty pay for cold weather and to increase or decrease the amounts payable for any assignment, location, or unit at any time as necessitated by mission requirements. These incentives are currently being implemented within existing restrictions and limitations in accordance with the needs of the individual Services. In addition to the one-time, lump-sum assignment incentive pay the Army pays to Soldiers accepting assignments to Alaska, members of all Services serving in Alaska receive an overseas cost-of-living allowance to compensate them for the increased costs of non-housing goods and services. Furthermore, members assigned to installations above the Arctic Circle receive \$150 per month in hardship duty pay.

Question. When should servicemembers expect to begin to receive a cold weather duty pay?

Answer. Service members can expect to receive cold weather duty pay if the Secretary of the Military Department concerned determines such pay is required to meet and/or maintain mission requirements.

Question. Secretary Austin, in response to Executive Order 14017, the DoD drafted a report titled Review of Critical Minerals and Materials—Department of Defense. This report highlights the challenges that DoD faces in their efforts to maintain secure supply chains and reduce net import reliance on necessary strategic and critical minerals. For many who have been following critical minerals, this report looks a lot like the reports that came before it. It screams out loud that we have a problem. It highlights the current vulnerabilities we face with our high levels of import reliance for some of these minerals and it highlights the potential dangers that reliance poses for the United States.

Given that this report is nearly 2 years old, please explain what progress the department has made in addressing the key concerns?

Answer. America's defense industrial base is one of our core strategic assets and we are focused on shoring up this advantage, including by on-shoring several defense supply chains and mineral production. The Department's FY24 budget request invests more than \$250 million in critical materials. We are also deploying several tools to mitigate reliance on foreign produced critical minerals. This includes increasing our stockpiles and investing domestic capability under the Defense Production Act, where practicable.

Question. Are we more or less import reliant on these minerals now than we were 2 years ago?

Answer. On balance, the Department's net import reliance for 2023 is approximately the same compared to 2021. Reducing the Department's reliance on imports will occur over the long-term. DoD has made key investments over the last 2 years to reduce import reliance for strategic and critical materials to safeguard supply chains and preserve national security. The DoD has awarded and is continuing to evaluate awards for Defense Production Act title III investment funds to build domestic mining and processing capacity for a range of critical materials, including rare earth elements, battery storage minerals, and more.

Question. How has the war in Ukraine changed the DoD's priority of addressing the vulnerabilities in this report?

Answer. The war in Ukraine has reinforced the urgent need to secure supply chains for critical materials necessary for key DoD systems. The recent Presidential Waiver authorizing the use of the Defense Production Act to bolster domestic capacity for materials and systems demonstrates the Administration's and DoD's commitment to this effort. The waiver allows DoD to expand domestic production capabilities for key minerals to help secure munitions supply chains. The war in Ukraine has provided real-world data on supply chain dynamics in times of crisis, information which is informing analysis to model DoD materials stockpiling needs.

Question. Congress supported the recommendation to open title III DPA funds for EV mineral projects. Can you please provide information into what projects have been funded, how much funding has been awarded to date, and the number of applications DoD has received for funding?

Answer. The Department is grateful for Congressional support in our efforts to secure the battery supply chain. Batteries are a vital component in weapon systems, including missiles and munitions. The Inflation Reduction Act provided DoD's DPA fund with \$250 million to address sourcing for these vital raw materials. Currently, DoD is evaluating various proposals to resolve gaps in this supply chain. These potential projects range from feasibility studies to modernization and construction of production facilities. Planned investments in battery materials include graphite, lithium, manganese, nickel, and cobalt with an average project value of \$28 million. The Department anticipates announcing awards in the next few months.

Question. What additional authorities or resources does the DoD require to reduce the overall level of vulnerability that this report laid out?

Answer. DoD's continued efforts to secure critical and strategic materials require Congressional support of the Department's FY24 budget request. DoD has several key methods for investing in the industrial base, including the DPA's title III program and the Industrial Base Analysis and Sustainment (IBAS) program. Our budget request includes \$968.6 million in DPA and \$1 billion in IBAS funding to continue the Department's commitment to strengthening the domestic industrial base essential to national defense.

The Department also submitted a legislative proposal that, among other things, would expand the definition of the "domestic industrial base" within the DPA to include our AUKUS partners Australia and the United Kingdom. Expanding the definition of "domestic industrial base" would strengthen DoD's ability to secure critical materials, establish robust secondary markets, and leverage allied nations to enrich

U.S. manufacturing and industrial base capabilities, increasing the nation's advantage in a competitive environment.

In addition, the National Defense Stockpile program is key to reducing U.S. vulnerability to near-term supply disruptions. The current stockpile inventory is insufficient to meet projected U.S. materials needs in the event of a national emergency. Appropriations would enable the National Defense Stockpile to acquire materials critical to preparedness, readiness, and national security.

QUESTION SUBMITTED BY SENATOR LINDSEY GRAHAM

Question. Section 1204 of the FY23 NDAA modified the authorities for the Irregular Warfare Center that was first authorized in the FY21 NDAA. It requires you to submit to the Senate and House Armed Services Committees, within 180 days, a plan for establishing the Center, including a determination as to the desirability of establishing it at a university through a partnership like a UARC.

I would like to note, first, that the 180-day deadline for that plan is fast approaching—June 21 will be 180 days since the President signed the NDAA on December 23. That's a little less than six weeks from now.

I am aware that last July you directed an "expedited" basing analysis to find the permanent home for the Center. But that was more than 9 months ago now, and you have not even taken the first step of submitting to Congress the criteria by which a site will be selected. So, as far as we know, you have made zero progress in selecting a site.

I will further note that the strategic basing analysis was your idea—it is not mandated by statute, nor directed by either the FY21 or the FY23 authorization. In fact, Congress has repeatedly signaled its intent to have the center located at and operated as a partnership with a civilian research university, and the NDAA also expressed the sense of Congress that the center should be named in honor of our late colleague, Senator John McCain. The preferred path here is clear.

It has been more than 28 months since Congress gave you the authority and the resources to establish the center in accordance with this vision. Congress has renewed the appropriation three times now, and we have essentially nothing to show for it. Meanwhile, the challenges the center is meant to address are only growing more acute. Frankly, our adversaries are unmoved by your commitment to this protracted bureaucratic process.

Can I have your commitment to delivering by June 21 a plan to establish the center in accordance with congressional intent?

Answer. Yes, the Irregular Warfare Center (IWC) report will be provided in June 2023. The Department has determined that the final location for the IWC will be at a DoD installation in order to address the IWC's inherently governmental tasks and will note this determination in the report. However, the Department will contract for irregular warfare (IW) research, curriculum development, and teaching support with a civilian institution of higher education—including by establishing a Center of Excellence or University Affiliated Research Center. The Department has identified several DoD installations as potential locations for the Center and approved a set of criteria for evaluating those options. While the Department is still identifying the optimal arrangement for the civilian institution partnership, the priority of the Department is to identify an arrangement through a robust competition that optimally supports the IWC's prescribed mission areas and can be completed expeditiously. The IWC reached initial operating capability in October 2022 and is conducting IW programs in accordance with section 345 of title 10, United States Code, as we identify a final location. The Department is committed to keeping Congress informed on this issue.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR SHELLEY MOORE CAPITO

Question. What specific steps is the Department of Defense taking to analyze production constraints, and to expand capacity, at facilities within the (1) organic defense industrial base and (2) U.S. energetics industrial base?

Answer. The Department is laser-focused on ensuring that our defense industrial base is resilient, and we appreciate the support from Congress as we work together to re-invigorate its capacity. In particular, our depots help ensure that our weapons systems are well-maintained, which is critical to maintaining readiness and is at the core of our strength as a Department.

Over the past 2 years, the Department established organic industrial base (OIB) goals that define priorities, constraints, risks, and opportunities within the OIB to meet current and future readiness objectives. In addition, the Department created

an ammunition capacity framework assessment to facilitate production requirements to meet war munitions readiness levels.

Our energetics base is also essential to generate new and innovative technologies. The Department is investing directly in the energetics industrial base, including over \$200 million in onshoring energetics production that are high risk due to foreign-sourced or single-sourced materials.

Question. What mechanisms are currently available to the Department of Defense to provide support or capacity expansion for the organic industrial base?

Answer. The Military Services provide direct investments to the OIB through the regular appropriations process, as well as Ukraine supplementals and replenishment funding. The Department also can utilize the Defense Production Act to expedite and expand the OIB to promote the national defense.

The Department also exercises existing authorities to designate depot-level activities and military arsenals as Centers of Industrial and Technical Excellence. This encourages the use of Public-Private Partnerships to maximize the use of OIB capacity, reduce cost of ownership of industrial facilities, and leverage private sector investment to accelerate efforts like plant and equipment recapitalization.

Question. Understanding the recent adjustment making the organic industrial base newly eligible for Defense Production Act funding, is the Department currently lacking any other authorities that would help provide support for the organic industrial base? If so, what are those authorities?

Answer. The Department does not lack any authorities to provide necessary support to the OIB.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED TO GENERAL MARK A. MILLEY

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR JON TESTER

Question. For good reason, when we talk about China, we spend a lot of our time talking about its bad behavior in the Taiwan Strait.

However, we can't overlook the fact that China's global ambitions are presenting problems for every Combatant Command, including in Africa and Latin America. If we only prepare for a high-end Indo-Pacific fight, we will come up short worldwide.

Chairman Milley, how are Combatant Commanders in AFRICOM and SOUTHCOM adjusting and planning for increased PRC activities within their areas of operation?

Answer. The Joint Staff provides each Combatant Commander with campaign and posture planning guidance to ensure their strategies are globally integrated and support our National Security priorities.

In line with this guidance, AFRICOM has developed a strategic competition framework that takes into account the PRC's activities in Africa, and which is designed to adapt as required with dynamic conditions. Their plans are fully nested within global priorities, and synchronized with other Combatant Commands, the interagency, and select partners and allies to ensure unity of effort.

Key efforts include monitoring PRC basing activity, countering Illegal Unreported Unregulated (IUU) fishing through increased maritime domain awareness, intelligence sharing with partner nations to expose illicit or malign activity, and security sector cooperation/capacity building to help African partner states to resist coercion and conduct independent security activities.

AFRICOM continues to see tangible results from their activities, as many of our African partners continue to request increased U.S. security sector cooperation, and training.

The Joint Force participates in a globally integrated approach to deterrence that seeks to deny the PRC the perceived benefits of aggression, while strengthening partnerships with, and the capabilities of, states across the SOUTHCOM AOR. By closely monitoring China's military and dual-use activities in the region while supporting our regional partners, we aim to mitigate Beijing's malign influence and maintain our position as the partner of choice.

To do this, SOUTHCOM is extensively engaged in security cooperation efforts that train partner nation personnel and modernize equipment. Through Foreign Military Sales, Foreign Military Financing, the transfer of Excess Defense Articles, Joint Exercises, the National Guard's State Partnership Program, and the International Military Training and Education Program, we help our partners meet shared threats to regional security, while demonstrating U.S. values and commitment.

The Joint Force also counters China's influence by supporting the people of Latin America and the Caribbean in ways that highlight shared American values. In 2022, for example, the USNS COMFORT hospital ship deployed to five countries in the

region, treating over 30,000 patients. The U.S. Army Corps of Engineers (USACE) also works with SOUTHCOM and regional partners on infrastructure development projects that advance U.S. security interests. In Peru, USACE is helping the Peruvian Navy to build port facilities, and in Ecuador, USACE is mitigating the negative effects of a substandard PRC construction project at the Coca Coda Dam. Activities like these, and many others, build good will and enhance our readiness and posture to operate in the region. Together, SOUTHCOM's efforts help limit China's ability to expand its military influence in the region.

Question. The War in Ukraine is now entering its second year, and both sides are gearing up for a spring offensive.

There are some who argue that given the threat from China, we can't afford to invest in Ukraine. I strongly disagree, but defer to our military experts.

General Milley, simply put, why is our continued support of, and investment in, Ukraine critical to our own national security?

Answer. Russia poses an immediate and persistent threat to international peace and stability. Providing security assistance to Ukraine, coupled with Ukraine's battlefield success against Russian aggression, sends a deterrent signal to our potential adversaries. Alongside our allies and partners, America is helping to make Russia's war on Ukraine a strategic failure. The overwhelming multinational response to Russia's unprovoked and unlawful war against Ukraine to restore international order is unprecedented and vital to the security of sovereign nations across the globe.

Question. Last year, Congress accelerated investments in weapons to load up our weapons magazines for future contingencies.

In this year's budget, the Department is proposing multi-year procurement agreements for 9 different munitions. This would provide significant predictability and stability to the industrial base.

Chairman Milley, are these planned procurement quantities enough to fund our munitions requirements for potential future conflicts and rebuild our stockpile?

Answer. We thank Congress for the multi-year procurement and other flexible acquisition authorities granted in recent legislation. Multi-Year Procurement (MYP) authorities will improve taxpayer buying power, bolster inventory, and provide a more stable and predictable demand signal to industry.

Following 20 years of conflict in Afghanistan and Iraq to combat terrorism, the Department is shifting its focus to near-peer conflict. The Department is constantly evaluating its munitions inventories and munitions procurement strategies, and this realignment of the munitions ecosystem will take time. Our PB24 request includes plans to pursue MYP for five munitions and will continue to identify additional opportunities to leverage existing MYP authorities, and recommend additional authorities. We will continue to work closely with industry to expand production capacity and deliver the needed quantities of munitions, while being good stewards of the capital provided by the American taxpayer.

Question. This budget request is again proposing record investments in research and development. You are asking for \$145 billion dollars in R&D spending, which is more than \$5.2 billion over the fiscal year 2023 enacted amount.

General Milley, for years, R&D has been used to mature and prototype technologies like hypersonic weapons and artificial intelligence. These technologies will give us decisive capabilities in a near-peer competition with China, so when will they become real programs that are fielded at scale? My concern is that we are at risk of falling into the trap of 'perennial prototyping', and not actually delivering capability in relevant numbers to our troops by increasing procurement. This budget does not transition prototypes to procurement in significant numbers.

Answer. The Joint Staff continues to work with Combatant Commands, leveraging a portfolio management approach, to highlight our capability gaps, requirements, and prototyping opportunities. Further, the Joint Force is continually experimenting with new technologies to identify those capabilities most needed by the warfighter. While not every effort matures into a game changing capability, those that do transition often face challenges in crossing the "valley of death" from R&D to procurement. To facilitate technological transition the department has established new prototype pathways such as the Rapid Defense Experimentation Reserve (RDER) and the Accelerate the Procurement and Fielding of Innovative Technologies (APFIT) pilot. We have organizations such as the Strategic Capabilities Office (SCO) and Defense Innovation Unit (DIU) to help guide promising technologies to programs. And the department is leveraging acquisition authorities such as Middle Tier-Acquisitions (MTA) to speed the delivery of innovation to our warfighters.

For example, our first land battery of the Army's Long Range Hypersonic Weapon (LRHW) will achieve its initial operational capability in FY23 thanks to the MTA pathway. In FY25 this hypersonic capability will expand to the sea as the Navy's

Conventional Prompt Strike (CPS) program achieves initial operational capability using the same missile as the LRHW. CPS will also deploy in the payload modules of VIRGINIA class SSNs currently under construction.

We will endeavor to prioritize initiatives that enable R&D projects to deliver results in operationally-relevant timelines to allow us to deter and, if necessary, prevail against threats.

Question. Congress has established a Commission to review the Department's budget process and make recommendations to speed up the process of getting stuff to the warfighter. Often, these Commissions point the finger at Congress (in some cases, rightfully so!) without addressing barriers inside the Department that you could fix yourself.

Chairman Milley, do you feel the warfighter is getting a fair shake in articulating their needs?

Answer. In terms of addressing warfighter needs, I believe the Joint Capabilities Integration and Development System (JCIDS) offers our individual Services and Combatant Commands the venue necessary to identify requirements and inform our acquisition enterprise. The Joint Requirements Oversight Council provides necessary strategic guidance while facilitating warfighter need identification from the Combatant Commands to ensure that our capability development efforts are concept-driven and threat-informed. We will continue to work with Congress and across the Department to align requirements, resourcing, and acquisition activities to accelerate the fielding of capabilities to the warfighter.

SUBCOMMITTEE RECESS

Senator TESTER. Thank you for what you do. General Milley, your record speaks for itself. Thank you very much.

This Defense Committee will reconvene on Tuesday, May 16, at 10 a.m., in a classified session to hear from the Director of Military Defense Agency and the Commander of U.S. Northern Command on the Budget Request for Hypersonic Threats, Missile Defense, and the Protection of the U.S. Homeland.

With that, we stand in recess.

[Whereupon, at 11:26 a.m., Thursday, May 11, the subcommittee was recessed, to reconvene at 10 a.m., Tuesday, May 16.]

DEPARTMENT OF DEFENSE APPROPRIATIONS FOR FISCAL YEAR 2024

THURSDAY, JUNE 1, 2023

U.S. SENATE,
SUBCOMMITTEE OF THE COMMITTEE ON APPROPRIATIONS,
Washington, DC.

The subcommittee met at 9:30 a.m. in room SD-192, Dirksen Senate Office Building, Hon. Jon Tester (chairman) presiding.

Present: Senators Tester, Durbin, Baldwin, Shaheen, Collins, Murkowski, Moran, Hoeven, Boozman, and Capito.

DEPARTMENT OF DEFENSE

NATIONAL GUARD AND RESERVE

STATEMENT OF GENERAL DANIEL R. HOKANSON, CHIEF OF THE NATIONAL GUARD BUREAU

OPENING STATEMENT OF SENATOR JON TESTER

Senator TESTER. Good morning. We are going to call this committee to order. I want to begin by welcoming our witnesses. I thank you all for being here to discuss your fiscal year 2024 budget priorities.

General Bellon, I think this is your last appearance before this committee. We extend a particularly warm welcome to you and wish you the best in your upcoming retirement. And we don't really care whether you retire in Maine or Montana—

[Laughter.]

Senator TESTER. But either one of the places will work, okay.

Senator COLLINS. Split the year, maybe.

Senator TESTER. Yes—house in each State. You can move back and forth. Either one will be a heck of a lot better in Kansas, right?

[Laughter.]

Senator TESTER. At any rate, I want to say thank you for what you guys do. The National Guard and Reserves have always done more with less, fewer full-time personnel, smaller budgets, older weapons systems and vehicles, and aging IT infrastructure and facilities.

The men and women that you lead have one foot in civilian life and the other foot in the military. They juggle their homes, their families, their duties while unselfishly serving their country, both here and abroad.

And the workload certainly isn't decreasing, and the ongoing mission in the Southwest border, as well as your support to European

Command, demonstrate exactly that. However, over the last 5 years alone, the National Guard and Reserves collective forces have shrunk by more than 40,000 servicemembers.

You are not immune from recruiting challenges that our active-duty military services face, nor are you immune from disruptive impacts of Government shutdowns, continuing resolutions. It is my sincere hope that with the threat of Government default hopefully averted, we can now make progress on passing the Government's budget on time, get it out of the cycle of annual continuing resolutions.

I want to hear how you are managing these challenges and how you are providing a ready modernized Guard and Reserve Force, as well as ensuring the healthy work life balance and rewarding military career for these men and women.

Once again, I want to thank you for being here. I want to thank you for your testimony ahead of time. But before you begin that testimony, I want to turn it over to Susan Collins. Senator.

STATEMENT OF SENATOR SUSAN M. COLLINS

Senator COLLINS. Thank you very much, Mr. Chairman, for holding this hearing on the National Guard and Reserve component fiscal year 2024 budget request. As the Chairman is well aware, I am very concerned about the budget request and its adequacy. The citizens Soldiers of the Guard and Reserve serve in the proud tradition of the Minutemen who fought for the very founding of our country.

In fact, the 133rd Engineer Battalion of the Maine National Guard has an unbroken line of service from 1760 to this very day. That is a distinction of which we are all very proud in the State of Maine. By design and consistent with the tradition of our Nation's founding, the United States military is not able to fight a war without the Guard and Reserve.

For the past 2 decades, Guard and Reservists have accounted for nearly half of deployments to Iraq and Afghanistan. The Guard has also borne the brunt of supporting the Department of Homeland Security along the Southern borders since 2018, and they will continue to do so until our border is finally secured.

The need to properly resource ready, well-equipped, and integrated Guard and Reserve components could not be more clear. The Guard's State Partnership Program is also an essential international security cooperation tool. To date, Guard units have formed ADA (Americans with Disabilities Act) partnerships with 100 countries around the world.

The Maine Guard's partnership with Montenegro paved the way for that country's successful accession to NATO (North Atlantic Treaty Organization) in 2017. And yet the President's budget request cuts the Guard and Reserve budget by \$3 billion compared to fiscal year 2023 enacted levels, impeding both modernization and readiness.

As General Hokanson has previously shared with the committee, the National Guard represents a lower cost option to deliver deterrence and combat power. I understand all of you have considerable equipment shortfalls, and none of you has parity with the active components in terms of fielding the most modern capabilities available.

Congress has repeatedly needed to provide the National Guard and Reserves with up-to-date vehicles, platforms, and aircraft that were excluded from inadequate budget requests. Finally, the committee is aware of efforts to transition DoD's (Department of Defense) ongoing mission at the border from active duty to guard or reserve units.

I would welcome an update from our witnesses on the status of that plan and what the Department's plans are to pay for those deployments. I look forward to the testimony and join the Chairman in thanking each of you for your service.

Senator TESTER. We will start out with General Hokanson, Chief of the National Guard Bureau. General, you have the floor.

SUMMARY STATEMENT OF GENERAL DANIEL R. HOKANSON

General HOKANSON. Chairman Tester, Ranking Member Collins, and esteemed members of the subcommittee, thank you for the opportunity to testify before you today. Your investment in the National Guard has built a ready, capable, and professional force vital to our Nation's defense and our communities in times of crisis.

Thank you for your support. I would also like to recognize the efforts of my wife, Kelly, and our senior enlisted adviser, Tony Whitehead, for their support and partnership in addressing Soldier, Airmen, and family needs.

As a community-based force with the authorities to perform almost any mission, ensuring healthy and resilient Guardsmen and families is not only our highest priority, it is foundational to all we do. This is my third time before you on behalf of the Soldiers, Airmen, and families at the National Guard.

In that time, the National Guard has repeatedly demonstrated its capability, capacity, and readiness, both at home and overseas, on a historic scale. Over the past 3 years, we performed over 28 million man-days in our communities, responding to emergencies of every kind. And as I speak, Guardsmen are supporting typhoon relief operations in Guam.

In the last 3 years alone, the National Guard has rescued or saved 18,826 individuals. In the midst of all those events, our formations still met every one of our overseas deployments. This included the Nation's final days in Afghanistan, where National Guardsmen helped defend the Kabul airport, evacuate refugees, and then assist with Operation Allies Refuge.

One of our other missions is the Joint Multinational Training Group-Ukraine. In concert with California's 30 year State partnership with Ukraine, our Guardsmen helped establish a training center in Ukraine after Russia's first invasion in 2014. Focused on combat arms and lessons learned, our National Guard trainers were some of the last to leave Ukraine before Russia's unprovoked invasion.

A few months after the war began, we reestablished our training group and have been training our partners every single day since then. Today, every Combatant Commander leverages our State Partnership Program, which was recently mentioned, now includes 100 nations around the globe.

Always ready, always there is not just our motto. It is our promise to America. A promise we have kept for over 386 years. And in

the 2,800 communities we call home, they know whenever or wherever a disaster occurs, the National Guard will be there because we already are.

As I begin my final year as chief, there are still many things we must accomplish to ensure the National Guard remains always ready, always there. Today, I will shorten that list to four priority areas. The first is our Air National Guard units who have been performing space missions for over 28 years. In 1947, when the Air Force was established, the Air Guards' 29 original squadrons were established concurrently, and today's Air Force is the envy of the world.

In 2019 when the Space Force was formed, it did not address nearly 30 percent of its operational squadrons that reside in the National Guard. With 1,000 personnel in 14 units, we are almost all tooth and no tail. These highly skilled Airmen are absolutely vital to the success of this space mission, and just like our Air Force, we want today's Space Force to be the envy of the world.

The second is premium free healthcare for currently serving Guardsmen and Reservists. There are many things we can surge in times of emergency, but medical readiness is not one of them. Access to care is critical to medical readiness and the number one concern I hear from our Guardsmen and recruiters when I visit our States and territories. To help recruit and retain the most talented, skilled, and ready force, all National Guard servicemembers, regardless of status, need medical coverage.

This is a matter of readiness, a matter of duty to the Guardsmen who serve and sacrifice for our Nation. We are working closely with the Adjutants General and the Defense Health Agency to clarify the number of Guardsmen this would impact and what current programs could be reduced or eliminated so we can accurately identify the cost and the readiness benefit it could provide.

The third is recapitalization of Air Guard fighter squadrons. We have 25 fighter squadrons in the Air Guard, and our Nation needs every single one of them. By working with the Air Force and Congress, we believe there is a path to recapitalize all 25 squadrons to the F-35, F-15EX, and our newest F-16s through fleet leveling and new aircraft buys.

This would help the Air Force divest its older platforms and retain the capability, capacity, and force structure it needs to help meet Combatant Command and warfighting requirements.

Lastly, I ask for your support in meeting the intent of the National Guard Empowerment Act. To be a full member of the Joint Chiefs of Staff and appropriately represent our 430,000 Guardsmen and their families, our Vice Chief cannot do that effectively as a subordinate to his peers.

In closing, I want to thank you again for the National Guard we have today. All we do would not be possible without your support that you provide to our Soldiers, Airmen, and their families. I look forward to your questions. Thank you.

[The statement follows:]

PREPARED STATEMENT OF GENERAL DANIEL R. HOKANSON

Chairman Tester, Ranking Member Collins, and esteemed members of the Subcommittee, thank you for the opportunity to submit this statement prior to my testimony. Your investment in the National Guard has built a ready, capable, profes-

sional force that is vital to the Joint Force and our American communities in times of crisis. Thank you for your ongoing support.

I would also like to recognize the efforts of my wife Kelly and Senior Enlisted Advisor Tony Whitehead for their support and partnership in addressing Soldier, Airmen, and family needs. We are a unique force with unique needs and ensuring healthy and resilient Guardsmen and families is our highest priority and foundational to all we do.

NATIONAL DEFENSE STRATEGY

The 2022 National Defense Strategy (NDS) identifies the People's Republic of China (PRC) as our pacing challenge and most consequential strategic competitor. The NDS focuses the Department of Defense (DoD) on this pacing challenge while taking steps to manage other threats in this dynamic strategic environment.

The National Guard plays a critical role in implementing the NDS and advancing DoD's priorities of: Defending the homeland; deterring attacks against the United States, our allies, and our partners; deterring aggression while being prepared to prevail in conflict when necessary; and ensuring our future military advantage through a resilient Joint Force and defense ecosystem.¹ These priorities are how we intend to meet and deter threats to our national security and the rules-based international order.

National Guard Soldiers and Airmen are actively engaged in every aspect of our NDS. As twenty percent of the Joint Force, we are a significant component of integrated deterrence. As the combat reserve of the Army and the Air Force—manned, trained and equipped to fight our Nation's wars, and currently serving in every Combatant Command—we play a key role in campaigning. As a dual-status force that builds key partnerships at every level—including international state partners, the Federal interagency, regional emergency management, and local law enforcement—we provide enduring advantages not found anywhere else in DoD. The NDS cannot succeed without the National Guard.

NATIONAL GUARD SUPPORT TO THE NDS

Priority one is defending the homeland, and the National Guard is the fundamental element in this regard. The National Guard has a community-based force structure, and our wide-ranging geographic distribution provides unique advantages to defending the homeland. Guard members defend the National Capital Region, support Ground Based Missile Defense in Colorado and Alaska; man non-stop, 24-hour intercontinental ballistic missile defense systems from Alaska and California; protect American air sovereignty; support the U.S. Space Force with fourteen operational space squadrons; mitigate critical cyber vulnerabilities; and use National Guard manning, training, and equipment to assist our communities in times of need.

Priority two is deterring strategic attacks against our homeland and our allies and partners. This priority clearly demonstrates both the interconnected nature of the threats and challenges we face and the cooperative approach we must take to counter them. Through the National Guard's State Partnership Program's (SPP) 88 partnerships with 100 nations around the globe, Soldiers and Airmen experience the global operating environment, develop military-to-military relationships, improve readiness, enhance access and influence, and ensure our Nation has trusted, capable, interoperable Allies and partners at our side. With the assistance of Congress, the SPP has proven to be one of the most valuable security cooperation programs available and continues to grow in support of the National Security Strategy, NDS and Combatant Commanders' theater security objectives. Fully funding the SPP through the services will ensure continued access to timely, consistent, and adequate resources to maximize the program's potential and historically robust return on investment. As the NDS makes clear, mutually beneficial alliances and partnerships are an enduring strength, and a key to the integrated deterrence and campaigning efforts of the National Guard.

Priority three is deterring aggression and preparing to prevail in conflict when necessary. This speaks directly to the National Guard's purpose: fighting and winning our Nation's wars. The National Guard is an operational force. We participate in combat, peacekeeping and stability operations, training exercises, and humanitarian missions' shoulder-to-shoulder with our parent services, and the Joint Force. We serve in every Combatant Command, enhance the readiness of the Joint Force, and support missions within the Global Force Management Allocation Plan (GFMALP) process. Being fully modernized and interoperable with our parent serv-

¹ The 2022 National Defense Strategy, p. 1.

ices and the Joint Force ensures we present a combat-credible force that can successfully deter and defend aggression from our strategic competitors and prevail in conflict if needed.

Priority four is ensuring our future military advantage by building a resilient Joint Force and defense ecosystem. This priority speaks to both people and systems—strengthening the resilience of the Soldiers and Airmen who serve, improving the resilience of the critical infrastructure on which we rely, and enhancing the resilience of our organization. We continue to devote time and resources to improve all aspects of National Guard culture to make service more appealing and inclusive, to include fostering an environment that values education and understands the importance of mental and physical well-being. We also continue efforts to enhance national resilience by protecting our nation's critical assets, communications and control, and infrastructure; and increasing our ability to withstand the effects of natural and manmade disasters.

LOOKING TO THE FUTURE

The Department's FY 2024 budget request helps build a Joint Force that is the most lethal, resilient, survivable, agile, and responsive in the world. Paced to the China threat, it builds combat-credible forces able to deter, defend, and defeat aggression if required. It advances recruiting, retention, and readiness while enhancing unit and personal resilience; strengthens deterrence, Ally and partner nation capability, and interagency capacity. However, budgetary uncertainty and inflationary pressures could erode buying power, stressing National Guard programs and personnel, and diminishing our Joint Force readiness. Continuing Resolutions in particular impede our ability to implement the NDS, hurts service members and their families, and undermines the predictability needed for Reserve Component (RC) personnel to effectively support the Joint Force.

As I engage with senior leaders and service members throughout the 50 states, three territories, and the District of Columbia, I remain concerned with several issues that directly impact future readiness and the health of the force. I look forward to working with the Subcommittee and your colleagues on solutions to address the challenges before us.

National Guard Space Operations

For 28 years, National Guard space units have been providing missions as varied as strategic missile warning, nuclear detection, space domain awareness, command and control, and electromagnetic warfare, and the U.S. Space Force continues to rely on these critical space capabilities. It is imperative we appropriately train, and equip in-line with U.S. Space Force standards and U.S. Space Command priorities.

Modernization and Recapitalization

To fulfill NDS obligations, the National Guard must be deployable, sustainable, interoperable and survivable on any battlefield, in any domain. For example, the Air National Guard has twenty-five fighter squadrons today, each essential to the defense of our Nation, our integrated deterrence capabilities, and our ability to campaign. As the National Guard transitions from legacy platforms, it is essential we pursue cost-effective solutions that preserve our capability, capacity and generational experience to meet the today's threats.

Recruiting and Retention

The National Guard provides the unique opportunity to combine military service with a civilian career. Every member and potential recruit weigh the benefit of that military service with impact on their lives and that of their families. We've taken concrete steps to improve community outreach, bolster recruiting and retention programs, and foster a culture that makes service more appealing, inclusive, and secure. Ensuring we recruit and retain America's best in the National Guard must remain a top priority; to do so, every aspect of our recruiting and marketing enterprise must be fully resourced.

Healthcare

According to a 2019 Office of the Secretary of Defense study, roughly 60,000 Guardsmen are uninsured and lack access to healthcare when not in a duty status. If unable to seek treatment for a physical ailment or mental health crisis or obtain follow-on care due to a lack of insurance, it impacts their medical readiness and ability to serve. We cannot surge medical readiness; our people must be ready when they are needed. I have formed a working group dedicated to providing the best estimate of cost and areas of potential savings and look forward to sharing those find-

ings soon so we can identify the true cost of premium-free healthcare options and how it would impact the readiness of our force.

CONCLUSION

The NDS signals a new era of challenges and opportunities for our Nation. With the support of Congress, the National Guard will continue to be a force for integrated deterrence, campaigning, and building enduring advantages that empower our Nation to compete and prevail. With your continued support, we boldly face the future: Always Ready, Always There.

Senator TESTER. Thank you, General Hokanson. Next up, we have General Daniels, Chief of the Army Reserve. General.

STATEMENT OF LIEUTENANT GENERAL JODY J. DANIELS, CHIEF OF ARMY RESERVE

General DANIELS. Chairman Tester, Ranking Member Collins, distinguished members of the committee, on behalf of the 190,000 Soldiers and civilians of the Army Reserve, Command Sergeant Major Lombardo and I thank you for this opportunity to testify, and for your continued support to our Soldiers, civilians, their families, and our other employers.

Present in 20 time zones and on 5 continents, the Army Reserve makes up nearly 20 percent of the total Army's personnel, at just 5 percent of the total Army operation and maintenance budget.

We provide key units and capabilities with nearly half of the Army's maneuver support and a quarter of its force mobilization capacity, while sustaining the mobilization and deployment of more than 10,000 Soldiers and civilians annually.

As a Federal response partner, the Army Reserve maintains a ready posture for defense support to civil authorities by providing critical dual use capabilities such as petroleum distribution, water purification, and railroad operations.

In an extremely challenging recruiting environment, our highest priority is sustaining the resources required to recruit and retain the best today and into the future. We also rely heavily on the support of families and communities, as well as the willingness of employers to share their best talent.

By changing our culture to refocus on tough, realistic training done safely, we are helping to bridge the knowledge divide between the military and the American public. This creates better experiences for civilian Soldiers who want to share with their communities.

As we build the Army of 2030, we are grateful for the authorizations and appropriations that invest in our people, enhance readiness, and accelerate equipment modernization to maintain superiority over any potential threat.

The need for Reserve component duties to perform cannot be overstated and is long overdue. That is why we support DoD proposal to fundamentally redesign the current system, aligning benefits to duties performed, and ensuring our Soldiers receive the entitlements that they earn.

The Army Reserve also appreciates Congress's efforts to improve access to childcare. However, access to quality and affordable childcare remains a challenge for our Soldiers, especially during battle assembly weekends. As the Army Reserve pilots new initiatives and deepens partnerships, continued Congressional support to

address weekend childcare gaps will help enhance retention and readiness.

Finally, as the Army Reserve looks to the future, leveraging the National Guard and Reserve Equipment Account, or NGREA, remains a key component of our modernization strategy. This funding enables the Army Reserve to fill mission critical shortages that improve overall readiness interoperability.

Command Sergeant Major Lombardo and I are incredibly proud to lead the men and women in America's Army Reserve, and I look forward to your questions.

[The statement follows:]

PREPARED STATEMENT OF LIEUTENANT GENERAL JODY J. DANIELS

THE UNITED STATES ARMY RESERVE

READY NOW! SHAPING TOMORROW . . .

In today's unpredictable global environment, the Army Reserve is more consequential than ever. Since its establishment 115 years ago, the Army Reserve has never failed to answer the call to serve. Since 1908, more than one million citizen soldiers have been mobilized in defense of the nation—at home and around the world.

The core strength of the Army Reserve is its ability to provide high-quality military capabilities, enhanced by citizen soldiers' civilian skills, education, training, and experience. As the Army prepares for Multi-Domain Operations, harnessing private sector education and expertise in areas such as artificial intelligence, cyber, and sustainment are vital in providing the Army and the nation an asymmetric advantage against potential adversaries. These capabilities, critical during Large-Scale Combat Operations, are also crucial in defending the homeland.

The Army Reserve is both a component and a command. Flexible and adaptable, the Army Reserve provides the Army, combatant commanders, and the nation with "forces to rapidly surge and provide follow-on forces, thereby mitigating force structure reductions and impacts from prolonged operations." On any given day, more than 10,000 Army Reserve soldiers are mobilized or deployed in support of combatant commands worldwide. Thousands more participate in deployment training or annual Joint exercises that strengthen our alliances and partnerships, contributing to integrated deterrence and campaigning. And on average, the Army Reserve supports the mobilization and deployment of more than 10,000 soldiers and civilians from force generation installations annually.

The Joint Force cannot deploy, fight, and win without the Army Reserve. The Army provides the bulk of sustainment forces to the joint fight, and the majority of these capabilities reside in the Army Reserve. Citizen Soldiers maintain specialized skills required to support Large Scale Combat Operations—including theater-opening and theater-level sustainment—as well as civilian-acquired skills, training, and certifications that are costly to maintain on active duty, such as medical, cyber, legal, engineering, and port operations.

BY THE NUMBERS

The Army Reserve has an FY23 authorized strength of 177,000 soldiers, includes 11,000 civilians, and is present in all 50 states and five U.S. territories. Fiscally efficient, the Army Reserve supports the needs of the Total Force, with just 15% of the component serving as fulltime support.

Making up nearly 20% of the Total Army's personnel, the Army Reserve provides critical units and capabilities—nearly half of its maneuver support, and a quarter of its force mobilization capacity—at a cost of just 5% of the total Army Operation and Maintenance budget.

More than 50% of the Army's quartermaster and medical formations, over 80% of its civil affairs, legal, psychological operations, and religious units, and over 40% of its chemical and transportation forces reside in the Army Reserve. Some critical enabling capabilities include petroleum distribution, water purification, and railroad operations.

The Army Reserve maintains five installations and an Army Support Activity: Fort Hunter Liggett and Parks Reserve Forces Training Area, California; Fort McCoy, Wisconsin; Fort Buchanan, Puerto Rico; Devens Reserve Forces Training Area, Massachusetts; and Army Support Activity—Fort Dix, New Jersey. Addition-

ally, with 742 Army Reserve facilities, the Army Reserve's dispersed footprint is in every corner of the country, enabling the U.S. to project combat power and creating an added layer of resiliency.

Each year, Army Reserve facilities support upwards of 335,000 servicemembers from every Department of Defense (DoD) branch—partnering with Federal, state, and local agencies for joint training missions—with ranges, maneuver areas, urban assault, military transport aircraft-capable landing sites, transient barracks, and dining facilities.

RECRUITING AND RETENTION

Preserving the all-volunteer force is vital to our national security interests. In an extremely challenging recruiting environment, sustaining the resources required to recruit and retain soldiers is critical to the Army Reserve's ability to generate the readiness required to deploy trained, capable, combat-ready, and lethal soldiers.

In fiscal year (FY) 2022, the Army Reserve recruited 9,400 new soldiers, falling short of our mission. To close the gap, commanders, and staff are maximizing every potential source of high-quality accessions and working to minimize preventable attrition.

Recruiting and retention investments include \$164.4 million in incentives, and approximately 3,000 full-time soldiers directly supporting Army Reserve recruiting and retention activities.

In 2022, the Army Reserve achieved 107% of the Army Reserve Active Component to Reserve Component (AC2RC) mission by retaining more than 4,000 active component service members. This program continues to perform strongly in FY 2023.

The Army Reserve Private Public Partnership Office (P3O) is contacting transitioning active component members about the AC2RC program by linking transitioning active duty servicemembers to civilian career pathways through continued service in the Army Reserve. This initiative—currently being implemented at the soon to be Fort Liberty, currently known as Fort Bragg, Fort Stewart, Fort Cavazos, Fort Bliss, Joint Base Lewis-McChord, and Schofield Barracks—allows the nation to retain valuable talent while providing transitioning service members with civilian career opportunities.

P3O is also working with U.S. Army Recruiting Command to link new Army Reserve recruits with an employment specialist to explore their civilian career options.

In order to connect with the public—and future soldiers—we recently introduced a new branding strategy, including a new logo and public outreach program to better reflect today's citizen-soldier—the selfless professional who balances the responsibilities of both nation and family, uniform and civilian workplace.

SOLDIERS AND FAMILIES

Citizen Soldiers are invaluable to our nation's defense, bringing civilian-acquired skills and experiences to the Army Reserve, and personifying the Army's values in their local communities. The Army Reserve is a highly educated, experienced and diverse force, which provides operational flexibility and strategic depth.

African Americans, Hispanics, Asian/Pacific Islanders, and Native Americans comprise over half of the Army Reserve force. Women comprise more than 25% of all Army Reserve soldiers and 22% of general officers.

Thirty-three percent of all Army Reserve soldiers hold a bachelor's degree or higher. In the officer ranks, 32% hold master's degrees and 13% hold doctorates. Soldiers in the enlisted ranks are also pursuing higher education. More than 13% hold bachelor's degrees, and nearly 4% have a master's or doctoral degree—benefiting employers and the nation.

The Army Reserve relies heavily on the support of families and communities, as well as the persistent willingness of employers to share their best talent. From family-focused programs to quality-of-life initiatives and employer partnerships, the Army Reserve's focus on caring for soldiers and families is at the core of our shared Army values—and crucial to the readiness and health of the force as we strive towards improved work-life integration between Army Reserve requirements, civilian career responsibilities, and family.

Army Reserve family programs continue to provide our geographically dispersed soldiers and families across more than 1,200 communities with a clear path to command and community resources, assistance, and referrals for every aspect of military life, including Military Onesource, childcare, food assistance, and behavioral health resources.

The Army Reserve recruits and retains our soldiers where they live and work. Providing civilian employers with advance notification of military commitments and

treating them as partners in national security demonstrates that everyone has a role in serving the American people.

To support work-life integration, P3O links eligible team members to immediate and long-term employment opportunities. This year, P3O partnered with more than 150 businesses across career fields such as engineering, healthcare, finance, cyber security, and logistics. Through these connections, 730 soldiers, spouses, and family members were hired—an 86% placement rate.

Through quality-of-life initiatives such as travel and lodging expenses, health, and childcare programs, we continually improve how we care for our soldiers. From training management to a focus on culture and work-life integration, the Army Reserve's People First approach makes the Total Force stronger. The Army Reserve focuses on supporting all aspects of a soldier's life: families, civilian employment, and educational goals, integrated with a rewarding uniformed experience that delivers the training, confidence, and leadership skills that employers seek.

ADDRESSING HARMFUL BEHAVIORS

The Army Reserve is evaluating programs and activities surrounding harmful behaviors to determine the effectiveness of existing efforts—taking a scientific, data-based approach to decreasing risk factors and increasing protective factors.

The development and implementation of an Integrated Prevention Advisory Group will allow a collaborative look at primary prevention activities, including policies, programs, and practices that aim to prevent harmful behaviors—sexual harassment and assault, as well as suicidal behavior and ideations will be particularly examined.

SEXUAL HARASSMENT/ASSAULT RESPONSE AND PREVENTION (SHARP)

The Army Reserve Sexual Harassment/Assault Response and Prevention (SHARP) program continues to provide staff assistance to every major subordinate command's program. Based on the results of an internal analysis—in coordination with Army's People First Task Force and the Independent Review Commission on Sexual Assault in the Military recommendations as approved by the Secretary of Defense—the Army Reserve is executing a SHARP Fusion Directorate pilot.

The 99th Readiness Division's SHARP Fusion Directorate's victim-centered program is showing improvements in the ability of Sexual Assault Response Coordinators, and Sexual Assault Prevention and Response victim advocates, in coordination with law enforcement, to create a flexible and responsive system which streamlines what can be a complex process—from making a report through case resolution and long-term recovery. Established as a year-long program in July 2022, this virtual alternative reporting process is tailored to the Army Reserve's geographically dispersed force, leveraging technology to connect victims with providers throughout a 13-state region.

SUICIDE PREVENTION

Suicide remains one of the Army's most complex challenges, and prevention requires a comprehensive approach. In 2022, the Army Reserve experienced a slight decrease in suicides—however, one suicide is one too many. Our suicide incident reports reveal soldiers are demonstrating increased confidence in leaders and actively seeking help. The Army Reserve supported nearly 500 soldiers needing help and intervention through the support of unit leadership, Chaplain Corps, Suicide Prevention Program Managers, Army Reserve Psychological Health Program, and Military OneSource. An increased number—82%—of soldiers are seeking help on their own initiative. Likewise, an increased number of leaders are recognizing changes in behavior and engaging in intervention.

Families are on the front line of defense against suicide. The Army Reserve now offers family members free virtual suicide prevention training to help them build the skills to provide support and dispel any stigma about seeking care.

Virtual command team suicide prevention training assists commanders in building prevention programs that empower soldiers and leaders at all levels to identify and address high-risk behavior early on. Soldiers—down to the squad-leader level—are empowered to escort any soldier in crisis to immediate life-saving care.

TRAINING

With the statutory minimum of 39 days a year to meet individual and collective readiness requirements, the Army Reserve focuses on tough, realistic training done safely to generate the readiness required to support operations home and abroad.

Added emphasis on individual and collective training opportunities enhances unit readiness and allows soldiers to improve their individual skills.

Optimizing the time to shape, grow, and retain the future force through effective and efficient training and maintenance management allows soldiers to build proficiency in their mission-essential tasks and deepen their technical skills—giving them a sense of purpose and fueling their passions.

By removing redundant administrative tasks and concentrating on creating the kinds of relevant experiences citizen soldiers will want to bring back to their communities, the Army Reserve is changing its culture—and helping to bridge the knowledge divide between the military and the American public. As soldiers learn, train, and grow, employers and members of more than 1,200 communities stand to benefit from their accumulated knowledge, leadership, and technical expertise.

READINESS

The Army Reserve is present in 20 time zones and on five continents around the world—around the clock. This presence makes a difference every day, in communities across America, and around the world. It also expands relationships with allies and partners and serves as a critical deterrent against our near-peer adversaries.

An example of this integral role can be seen across Europe and in the Indo-Pacific—the DoD's priority theater—where the Army Reserve's regional forces span Hawaii, Alaska, America Samoa, Saipan, Guam, and 12 additional countries.

More than 7,000 soldiers and 43 units enable early-entry theater-opening and sustainment of Joint operations across vast distances, strengthening our partnerships, enhancing interoperability, and increasing collective readiness. Combined with additional staff augmentation and operational support from 13 commands on the mainland, they deliver functional support to U.S. Indo-Pacific Command, U.S. Forces Korea, U.S. Forces Japan, and U.S. Army Pacific.

The Army Reserve strengthens logistics and sustainment to support of the Joint Force in the Indo-Pacific and Europe, enhancing the Army's readiness in the regions. Our contested logistics capabilities ensure freedom of action and prolonged endurance for our combatant commanders, extending operational reach to the vital points of conflict.

The Army Reserve also supports Operation Pathways, a series of key international exercises, including Pacific Sentry and Talisman Saber in Australia, Garuda Shield in Indonesia, and Salaknib in the Philippines. These exercises help deter aggression, build joint readiness and interoperability, and increase the confidence of our allies and partners across the Indo-Pacific.

Twenty-three units and more than 1,000 Army Reserve soldiers are also supporting NATO missions in the U.S. European Command area of operations with a broad spectrum of capabilities, including cyber, intelligence, logistics, transportation and civil affairs.

Since the onset of war in Ukraine, the Army Reserve supplied more than 100 pieces of equipment, including armored personnel carriers, cargo trucks, and mine countermeasure equipment under Presidential Drawdown Authority directives.

SUSTAINED FUNDING IS ESSENTIAL FOR CONTINUED NATO SUPPORT.

Army Reserve units regularly participate in realistic collective training events to prepare for Large-Scale Combat Operations in a multi-domain environment. In FY 2022, 2,600 soldiers rotated through the National Training Center at Fort Irwin, California, and more than 1,500 participated in collective training at the Joint Readiness Training Center at Fort Polk, Louisiana, honing the skills needed for future multi-domain operations.

DEFENSE SUPPORT OF CIVIL AUTHORITIES

With soldiers and equipment strategically postured throughout the country, the Army Reserve flexes critical assets to support Homeland Defense and Defense Support of Civil Authorities—such as “Heavy Lift” helicopters search and rescue, supply, medical, civil affairs, and engineer capabilities.

Army Reserve Emergency Preparedness Liaison Officers (EPLOs) stand ready to support state and local authorities in times of natural and man-made disasters. Over the past 5 years, more than 2,500 Army Reserve soldiers supported incident response.

Recently, 23 EPLOs deployed to provide critical connectivity as Federal and military officials reached out to communities in need during Hurricanes Ida, Fiona, Ian, and Tropical Storm Nicole. EPLOs have also supported winter storm response in the western United States.

Army Reserve aviation assets are among those called to provide key capabilities needed for disaster response. UH-60 Blackhawk crews assisted in fire-fighting operations in central Texas, while CH-47 Chinook aircrews also assisted civilian first responders in conducting search and rescue operations on Mount Rainier, Washington.

MODERNIZATION/FACILITIES/SHAPING TOMORROW

The Army Reserve is evolving to meet the challenges of our time—preparing not only for the future of Large-Scale Combat Operations, but also for the increasingly complex needs of the Joint warfighter in a multi-domain operational environment by balancing mission-critical capabilities across the force spectrum.

To meet the evolving needs of the Army and the nation, we will simultaneously focus on recruiting the next generation of Citizen Soldiers while ensuring that the current force is Ready Now. Building on this, the Army Reserve will concentrate on increasing interoperability through targeted modernization efforts and capability development, ensuring seamless support to the Joint Force throughout the conflict continuum.

The Army Reserve is modernizing its facilities and serving as a sustainability leader in energy and water resilience, environmental compliance, solid waste management, vehicle electrification, and long-term sustainability planning.

As part of the “Defense Innovation Unit Electric Vehicle Support Equipment” pilot, the Army Reserve is also implementing a climate resiliency process, which includes recommendations on prioritizing projects that increase the resilience of buildings and natural infrastructure.

Soldiers assigned to the 75th Innovation Command are employed in a wide range of career fields, bringing critical job experience and skill sets to accelerate innovations and technologies. Areas of expertise include artificial intelligence, autonomy, and robotics, block-chain, cyber, medical, synthetic biology, and space. As the Army moves toward multi-domain operations, Army Reserve soldiers will play a critical role in linking the private sector into the defense enterprise.

Professional skills in areas like defensive cyber operations provide valuable capabilities. The Army Reserve provided 25% of the Total Army’s Cyber Protection Teams aligned to the U.S. Cyber Command’s Cyber Mission Force. Our soldiers conduct defensive cyberspace operations in support of the Army, Combatant Commands, the DoD, and Interagency operations worldwide.

The Army Reserve is preparing to conduct home-station defense cyberspace operations in support of Exercise Defender Europe 23—designed to support mission partners and assist in real-world exercises.

As the Army Reserve looks to the future, leveraging National Guard and Reserve Equipment Account funding is a key component of our modernization strategy. This enables the Army Reserve to fill mission-critical shortages that improve overall readiness and interoperability.

CONCLUSION

In an era of strategic competition, the Army needs forces capable of defeating adversaries, responding to crises, and preparing for the future. To accomplish these goals, the U.S. needs a dedicated Federal reserve force that is ready today and prepared to shape the world of tomorrow. That force is the United States Army Reserve.

To deliver cutting-edge capabilities at home and abroad, America needs a modernized, powerful, and resilient Federal reserve force of highly skilled men and women. From force structure optimization to equipment modernization and operational realignments, it will take the unique strengths and capabilities of each of the Army’s components to ensure we are on a sustainable, strategic path.

The Army Reserve is grateful for the Congressional support of our Citizen Soldiers, civilians, and their families, along with resources that positively impact the readiness and modernization efforts to ensure our adversaries cannot out-range or outpace us on the traditional battlefields or in the new frontiers of space and cyberspace.

As always, we are Ready Now! Shaping tomorrow . . .

Senator TESTER. Thank you, General Daniels. Next, we have Admiral Mustin.

STATEMENT OF VICE ADMIRAL JOHN B. MUSTIN, CHIEF OF NAVY RESERVE

Admiral MUSTIN. Good morning, Chair Tester, Ranking Member Collins, and distinguished members of the subcommittee. It is my distinct honor to report to you today alongside my peers Reserve service chiefs and General Hokanson on the status and the vision of America's Navy Reserve.

I would like to begin by recognizing my wife Kim, whose steadfast support for 30 years exemplifies the unsung sacrifices typical of our military spouses. And I would also like to thank Navy Reserve Force Master Chief Tracy Hunt for his tireless efforts in support of our enlisted Reserve Sailors.

Additionally, I would like to express my thanks and appreciation for my colleague and friend, Lieutenant General Dave Bellon for his exemplary multi-decade career of service in uniform. We are going to miss you, General. Fair wind, shipmate.

Finally, I call the committee's attention to the 103,000 Sailors, the 450 civilians, the families who sustain them, and the thousands of employers who value and enable the worldwide service of our citizens Sailors.

All are essential to the success of our Reserve force. For more than a century, the Navy Reserve has reliably responded when needed in times of peace, in times of war. In the recent past, the Navy Reserve provided the rapid activation of nearly 9,000 Sailors in response to the coronavirus 19 pandemic and surged nearly 500 Sailors on equally short notice to support the ongoing security crisis in Europe.

Most recently, they were instrumental to the execution of non-combatant evacuation operations in Sudan, rapidly removing American citizens from harm's way. These activations highlight the flexibility, readiness, and value our citizens Sailors bring to the fight, and yet these contributions merely hint at the demands expected of the Navy Reserve in a conflict with a great power maritime competitor.

The Navy Reserve is rapidly transforming to deliver a peerless force designed, trained, and ready to fight confidently and boldly in sustained multi-domain high end warfare. To this end, the singular priority of our Navy Reserve is simple, warfighting readiness.

Modernizing Reserve equipment, training systems, and mobilization processes is critical to delivering this readiness and a mandate to ensure the readiness and availability of the critical response team our service component and Combatant Commanders depend upon.

To ensure our Sailors are ready to activate and serve on day one of any conflict, the Reserve force must maintain parity with our active counterparts and operate relevant, modern equipment.

To this end, procurement of the modern C-130 Juliet aircraft variant to replace legacy C-130 airframes is the Navy Reserve's number one equipment priority. In the past year, Navy Reserve fleet logistics squadrons flew 26,000 hours, moved 96,000 passengers, and 19 million pounds of cargo at a cost avoidance of \$1 billion over alternative methods.

However, with an average age exceeding 3 decades, the current C-130 fleet is unable to meet sustained fleet logistics requirements

due to obsolescence issues. In conflict, the strain on supply chain will be an Achilles heel to contested logistics requirements and operations.

The KC-130 Juliet is a more capable, modern airframe that delivers increased capacity supported by cost savings from parts, commonality, fuel efficiency, and reduced lifecycle costs, resulting in a reduction of \$1,000 per flight hour. In addition to equipment modernization, we are leveraging technology advancements to improve and modernize access to work and training, and to bring the Navy Reserve into the 21st century.

These comprehensive transformative improvements include hardware and software upgrades, the creation of digital workflows, and the implementation of policies and processes that harness our greatest assets, the minds, talents, ideas, and civilian skills of our Reserve Sailors.

In concert with these efforts are adaptive mobilization process, demonstrated during our response to the COVID pandemic and multiple mass mobilization exercises, will leverage the Navy Reserve's nationally distributed infrastructure to locally mobilize 50,000 Sailors in only 30 days, rapidly, accurately, and at scale.

Our Reserve Sailors are central and vital to our Navy's enduring warfighting advantage, so we are investing in the personal and professional development of every Sailor. We are committed to recruiting and retaining the very best of our society, and we are equally committed to maintaining a culture of excellence, eliminating disruptive behaviors, ensuring Sailor wellness, and fostering a diverse, inclusive culture.

Doing so is about warfighting readiness, and doing so enhances the asymmetric advantage generated by our lead winning team. I am grateful for the committee's support of the Navy Reserve. Our efforts are made possible by the timely delivery of a fiscal year 2024 appropriations bill.

That provides predictability to our Sailors, their families, their employers, and most importantly, to our global Combatant Commanders. Chair Tester, Ranking Member Collins, and distinguished members of this committee, I remain humbled every day by the commitment and contribution of our citizen Sailors, our dedicated civilians, and the supportive families and employers that collectively are your Navy Reserve.

Thank you for your continued support and your attention today, and I look forward to your questions.

[The statement follows:]

PREPARED STATEMENT OF VICE ADMIRAL JOHN B. MUSTIN

Chair Tester, Ranking Member Collins, distinguished members of the Committee, thank you for the opportunity to testify today regarding the contribution of the Navy Reserve to national defense, both as it stands today and as we prepare for the threats of tomorrow. On behalf of Navy Reserve Sailors, civilians and their families, thank you for your continued leadership and support as we optimize the warfighting readiness of your Navy Reserve Force for strategic competition.

In 2020, the Navy Reserve began a transformation to improve and modernize the way we organize, man, train, equip, and mobilize to generate the combat power and critical strategic depth the Navy requires to prevail in conflict. We have embraced the imperative to redesign the Reserve Force—structurally, procedurally, and operationally—to align with strategic priorities calibrated for a competitive security environment. With a singular focus on generating warfighting readiness, this generational transformation will provide the most capable force possible to our

Navy's Numbered Fleets and deliver integrated all-domain naval power to the Joint Force in competition, crisis, and conflict.

Throughout its rich 108-year history, the Navy Reserve has proven to be an elite fighting force—a deep well of strategic depth from which our great nation has drawn time and again to prevail in competition, crisis and conflict. The talent our Navy Reserve Sailors bring to bear provides an unequivocal asymmetric advantage. As we transform the organization, training, and mobilization processes of the force, we have not lost sight of our collective responsibility to recruit and retain our nation's precious talent. I remain in awe of the dedication and professionalism of Navy Reserve Sailors, civilians and the families that support them. They provide the foundation that underwrites more than a century of successful contribution to the Navy and our Joint Force, and the reason I gaze optimistically to the future.

Timely, predictable and relevant funding from Congress is critical for the Navy Reserve to meet mission requirements and, as always, we are grateful for your continued support and enduring interest. Keeping the Reserve Personnel Navy account funded at President's Budget levels enables the Reserve force to deliver trained Sailors ready to fight and win in the early stages of conflict as readily as they are to sustain combat operations. The National Guard and Reserves Equipment Account (NGREA) affords the Navy Reserve agility in rapidly acquiring and implementing equipment solutions that fill mission-critical shortages and generate readiness. Continued Congressional support will ensure the Navy Reserve provides relevant, modern capability and capacity, keeping parity with active duty service members in training, facilities and equipment, and a resilient surge force today and into the future.

DESIGN THE FORCE: CAPABILITIES

For the two decades following the unprovoked attacks of 9/11, and during our global fight against violent extremism, the Navy Reserve provided operational support in land-based combat environments. The recent strategic shift to address peer adversaries in the maritime domain has forced an evolution to address the ready force the Navy Reserve must deliver. With the resurgence of a global pacing challenge, generating warfighting readiness requires a force design process focused on modernization and accelerated delivery of relevant, current capabilities.

Multi-domain warfighting capability and capacity relevance remains an imperative guiding principle in the modernized Reserve Force. As such, we are investing heavily in capabilities that directly align with winning future wars, including Maritime Operations Centers, contested logistics, surge maintenance, integrated fires, and Naval Special Warfare. New technologies and capabilities in space, cyber, imagery analysis, battle damage assessment and repair, autonomous and uncrewed platforms, artificial intelligence, machine learning, data analytics and additive manufacturing represent growth areas that capitalize on the unique skills and experiences of Reserve Sailors and the civilians that enable the Reserve Force.

The Navy Reserve delivers these modern capabilities through three employment models: readiness units that augment active Navy units with trained, warfighting-ready Reserve Sailors, individual Sailors with unique skills that enhance the Total Force, and stand-alone operational units that supplement active component capabilities. The Navy Reserve's operational units require investments in modern equipment to ensure strategic depth in logistics, aviation, security, medical, special warfare as well as investments in critical capabilities.

Navy Unique Fleet Essential Airlift (C-130J)

The Chief of Naval Operations' Navigation Plan identified Distributed Maritime Operations (DMO) as one of the Navy's key operating concepts necessary to prevail in conflict. In Navigation Plan 2022, the CNO emphasizes resilient logistics in contested environments as a critical Force Design Imperative and directs recapitalization of the C-130 fleet, a reserve-only capability, by 2030. The C/KC-130T aircraft are the Navy's only long-range aerial logistics platform capable of transporting bulk cargo, such as boats, diver recompression chambers, submarine masts, and all modules of the F-35 engine. Operated entirely by the Navy Reserve, Navy Unique Fleet Essential Airlift (NUFEA) consists of 27 C/KC-130T and 17 C-40A aircraft that comprise the Navy's organic intra-theater air logistics capability.

Last year, NUFEA aircraft transported 96,105 passengers and 18.8 million pounds of cargo for the Navy and the Department of Defense. This capability saved the Department \$1.14 billion in expenditures relative to alternative means of transportation. Despite their demonstrated necessity and value, the C-130T's age, lack of available parts due to obsolescence, and increasing cost of flight hour, drive a growing gap between Fleet's demand for this mission and the Navy's capability to fulfill it. Compared to the legacy "T" model, the more efficient and reliable "J" model

incurs a cost saving of approximately \$1,000 per flight hour. The essential mission these aircraft provide make recapitalization of the C-130T to the KC-130J the Navy Reserve's number one equipment priority.

Adversary

The aviation adversary mission ensures readiness for the Navy's carrier-based tactical aircraft and develops Navy pilots' air-to-air combat skill. The Navy Reserve's Tactical Support Wing (TSW) maintains 29 F-5N/F and 2 F-5N+/F+ aircraft that replicate low-to-mid level threats. The Navy Reserve is modernizing the F-5N/F avionics suite to improve safety of flight and resolve obsolescence limitations. Further upgrades will improve the range of the aircraft and generate more accurate threat replication. The current fleet of F-5s will reach the end of their service life by the early 2030s; however, eleven upgraded F-5s purchased in FY20 will come into service over the next 3 years to ensure adversary capability does not lapse prior to fielding a replacement aircraft.

In April the Navy Reserve received twelve F-16C aircraft that provide dissimilar aircraft training and high-end adversary support to the fleet. These aircraft have sufficient airframe hours remaining to sustain adversary missions through 2035. Ongoing efforts to upgrade F-5 and F-16 aircraft, together with investments in Live-Virtual-Constructive technology, will increase the fidelity of modern threat replication and keep Reserve adversary training relevant to the fleet until follow-on platforms become available.

Maritime Patrol and Reconnaissance (P-8A)

The P-8A aircraft is the nation's only full-spectrum, broad-area Anti-Submarine Warfare platform. Additionally, it provides armed Anti-Surface Warfare and networked Intelligence, Surveillance and Reconnaissance capability. The Navy Reserve's Maritime Patrol and Reconnaissance Aviation (MPRA) squadrons mirror the active component units and integrate seamlessly into the Global Force Management (GFM) deployment cycle. The Navy Reserve is in the process of transitioning from the P-3C to the P-8A. VP-62 received their first two P-8A in February and March of 2023 with their third aircraft scheduled for delivery in July. VP-69 began the transition process to the P-8A in April 2023, with the first aircraft scheduled for delivery in August 2023. Transitioning to the P-8A sustains the joint forces military advantage over our pacing threat by providing worldwide, continuous deployed presence to deter adversaries and provide robust support of maritime operations. Hangars to support the new aircraft in the two squadrons are late to need and are the number one and two military construction priorities for the Navy Reserve. The recapitalization of Reserve MPRA ensures equipment parity with active units to deliver operational resiliency and strategic depth to the Joint Force. I am grateful for your support.

TRAIN THE FORCE: READINESS

The singular focus of the Navy Reserve's transformation is to generate and deliver warfighting readiness. As such, each Reserve Sailor's peacetime training and active duty service must translate directly to readiness in their programmed warfighting billet. We are ensuring that training resources, and the policies that support them, provide Reserve Sailors the "reps and sets" they need to excel, on day one, in their wartime roles in a maritime fight.

For the first time, the Navy Reserve issued explicit Force Generation Guidance, released in December of last year, establishing a force-wide process to define and validate training requirements and to assess force-wide status. Most importantly, the guidance ensures that every Sailor is familiar with their unique training plan, tailored to their mobilization billet. Automated systems document individual training requirements and allow Commanding Officers of Reserve Readiness Units to evaluate and report the status of each Sailor's training, specific to their unique mobilization billet. Accurate, relevant information gives Sailors and their leadership actionable tools to manage their warfighting readiness effectively and optimizes training investments to enable "plug-and-play" integration with active-duty forces.

Billet-Based Activation—activating individual Sailors and Reserve Units of Action to their programmed maritime assignments—represents an important inflection for the Navy Reserve in our transformation from a legacy force providing Individual Augmentees mobilized for land-based conflict against non-state, violent extremism. In the future, when necessary, we will activate units of action rather than individuals to meet reserve-appropriate requirements.

Individual Sailors will train and activate into roles that align to their wartime billet and their specific experience and qualifications. This effort is in-line with the Secretary of the Navy's updated policy for sourcing active and reserve Sailors to fill

current requirements. The Secretary's policy directs the DoN to apply the Total Force to source ongoing global requirements, and to continue developing permanent manpower solutions in lieu of individual augmentees. Billet-Based Activation provides reserve Sailors practical experience, while preserving strategic depth for the new reality of multi-domain warfare in competition, crisis and conflict with peer and near-peer adversaries.

MOBILIZE THE FORCE: CAPACITY

A Reserve Force designed and trained to fight and win must be ready and capable of mobilizing rapidly, and at scale, to provide the strategic depth necessary to sustain multi-domain combat operations. We will deliver on the imperative to mass mobilize the entire Reserve Force within 30 days when called upon.

Adaptive Mobilization

Our legacy approach to mobilization, in which individual Reserve Sailors were processed through a single, centralized facility to receive specialized training over the course of several months, did not meet the demand of a complex, dynamic security environment. To enable the readiness and deliver the Reserve Force to the fight immediately, we developed Adaptive Mobilization (AM) processes tailored to each billet, and distributed mobilization pathways to bring mobilization-ready Sailors into their active duty warfighting role efficiently and at scale.

Using the AM model, six regional Readiness and Mobilization Commands (REDCOMs) and their subordinated Navy Reserve Centers (NRCs) support distribution of current and future activations by mobilizing the entire Selected Reserve population—roughly 50,000 Sailors—within 30 days of the demand signal. This model capitalizes on Training and Administration of the Reserve (TAR) staffs, located at the REDCOMS, NRCs and within Fleet units, and leverages the nationally distributed infrastructure unique to Reserve Forces to execute the AM model across globally distributed regions. The Navy Reserve has intentionally and frequently exercised these processes through force-wide mobilization exercises that stress-test our capabilities and drive future improvements.

Navy Reserve Center Optimization

The 115 Navy Reserve Centers spanning the United States, Puerto Rico and Guam make up a critical support network for Reserve Sailors across the world. In Fiscal Year 2020, the Navy Reserve began a crucial effort to optimize this network by strategically closing small, off-installation NRCs in order to realign TAR staff personnel to fill vacancies at under-staffed NRCs and REDCOMs. The Navy Reserve benefits by optimizing essential manpower to train and administer Reserve Sailors and to implement Adaptive Mobilization. NRCs outside of military installations incur force protection and security risks that “on-installation” NRCs do not.

Evaluating these “off-installation sites” for closure reduces risk to the Force and curtails the expense and mobilization impact of Armed Watch Stander programs. The effort, which aligns with SECNAV's 10-year infrastructure reset direction to divest the Navy's facility footprint by 10%, reduces the Navy Reserve facility footprint by 10.3%.

Administration and Management of the Individual Ready Reserve

The Navy Reserve is comprised of 54,607 Selective Reserve (SELRES) Sailors, 9,966 TAR Sailors and 39,214 Individual Ready Reserve (IRR) members, totaling over 103,787 Sailors. The IRR is a critical component of the Navy Reserve, enabling additional surge capacity for the Navy Reserve Force at a significantly reduced cost. IRR Sailors also maintain many of the primary benefits associated with military service, such as access to the military exchange, commissary and Morale Welfare and Recreation facilities, Space-Available travel, Psychological Health Outreach Program (PHOP) and Sexual Assault Prevention and Response (SAPR) services. In order to leverage the potential of this population as a relevant source of strategic capacity, we have defined critical skills for the IRR, shifting the focus from the land-based fight against violent extremists and Individual Augmentee roles to those focused on the maritime domain. We are deliberately exercising the IRR muster process via the application of a new technology solution to refine and improve the experience. Engaging with our IRR Sailors through proactive musters has also proved an effective means of recruiting experienced personnel by tapping into a desire to affiliate with the Selective Reserve.

DEVELOP THE FORCE: SAILORS

Navy Reserve Sailors and civilians provide the asymmetric advantage that allows the Navy Reserve Force to provide world-class warfighting readiness to the Fleet;

as such, they remain my primary focus in the transformation of Reserve design, train, mobilize, and develop initiatives. These efforts support the professional, military, and personal growth of our Sailors, with special emphasis also on minimizing administrative distractions, enhancing talent management, and improving quality of life. The Navy Reserve has promoted particular efforts to improve mental health, resiliency and suicide awareness. We are focused on fortifying a culture of dignity and respect that exemplify our Navy's core values of honor, courage and commitment.

Recruiting and Retention

We are competing for talent within a discriminating labor force under rapidly evolving economic conditions. The labor market in the United States is the tightest in recent memory, with more job openings than people to fill them. However, the turmoil and uncertainty of the last few years have shown that many Americans are more likely than ever to pursue work for organizations that provide purpose to their lives and align with their deeper values. We believe the Navy Reserve is the employer of choice for those seeking challenge, purpose, and personal growth within a cohesive community of diverse and motivated individuals. To reach our goals, we are at General Quarters to spread this message to talented Americans who are eager to serve.

Reserve component recruiting and retention includes parallel efforts to access new Sailors as well as those with prior service. The Prior Service Mission is unique and critical to manning the Reserve force: in order to ensure we can fill critical gaps, the Navy Reserve must maintain a deep reservoir of talent, which requires active duty Sailors to affiliate with the Navy Reserve prior to leaving active Navy service. With this in mind, the Navy established the Navy Recruiting Reserve Command (NRRRC), charged with retaining Sailors transitioning from active duty for continued service in the Reserve Component. The new NRRRC can focus on the prior-service Reserve mission in today's competitive job market. To improve this process, NRRRC has established Prior Service Detachments in the five continental fleet concentration areas and at two locations outside the continental United States. These detachments are staffed with reserve benefits advisors whose sole purpose is to act as an extension of the Career Transition Office and to educate Sailors on the transition process and the benefits and opportunities available in the Navy Reserve.

We are also aggressively activating accession and retention levers by promoting Active Component to Selected Reserve (AC2SELRES) opportunities during Transition Assistance Program classes and required career development sessions. Additionally, we are expanding bonus opportunities, including implementation of a TAR selected re-enlistment bonus for selected rates, extending High Year Tenure exception to policy to allow more flexibility in the process for service members, executing a High Year Tenure Plus program that automatically approves continuation of SELRES Sailors through 30 September 2024, extending Tuition Assistance Programs to SELRES Sailors and implementing SELRES exit surveys to identify additional issues or potential policy changes that could support the recruiting and retention mission. The Navy has also updated the Military Service Obligation construct by creating mandatory SELRES service for eligible Sailors identified as fitting a specific need within the Reserve Force.

The Navy Reserve is projected to miss New Accession Training goals by 973 Sailors and to finish approximately 3,000 Sailors short of the FY23 10,330 recruiting goal. To address end strength shortfalls, the Navy and Navy Reserve are collaboratively embracing innovative digital advertising methods to identify candidates for high-demand fields such as Special Warfare, aircrew, Information Technology, and healthcare specialties. Digital advertising is especially critical since the Navy Reserve derives 40.2% of all new contracts from marketing and advertising leads.

Navy Personnel and Pay Modernization

Legacy pay and personnel systems continue to challenge and frustrate our reserve sailors and their families. The Navy is undertaking an Enterprise personnel and pay transformation to modernize and streamline the processes that govern activation and deactivation of Reserve Sailors, their career management, their pay, and the service and support they receive and deserve throughout their career. The Navy is modernizing the MyNavy HR Enterprise, to include Manpower, Personnel, Training and Education systems, to improve performance, achieve Active Component/Reserve Component permeability, increase productivity, achieve auditability and generate cost efficiencies in all aspects of personnel readiness for all Navy sailors and their families. The centerpiece of this transformation is the Navy Personnel and Pay (NP2) system, which will enable a single, integrated personnel and pay system that allows Reserve Sailors to seamlessly transition on and off active duty, without a dis-

ruption in pay. This capability will accelerate Adaptive Mobilization and provide the efficiency required to mobilize rapidly and at scale. While modernization efforts have been delayed, the Navy Reserve is pressing forward with initiatives integrating antiquated systems that decrease timelines and mitigate shortfalls in operating capacity to support sailors and their families.

Culture of Excellence

As we transform the Reserve Force for strategic competition, Sailors form the foundation of our readiness and remain our most important customers. As such, we remain focused on strengthening an inclusive and diverse culture that is intolerant of sexual harassment and assault, and that provides comprehensive support to Sailors, civilians and their families. We are optimizing the warfighting readiness of the Reserve Force by empowering Sailors, promoting organizational trust and transparency, and ensuring inclusion and connectedness among every member of the Reserve Force.

The Navy Reserve is an exponentially more effective warfighting-ready force when it capitalizes on the diverse backgrounds, experiences, perspectives and talents of those who serve. With this as our guiding principle, the Navy Reserve is committed to fielding a force as diverse as the country and harnessing the asymmetric advantage of our Sailors to accelerate our warfighting advantage. In aggregate, the diversity of the Reserve Force has increased across all categories over the previous five-year period. We must continue to foster inclusion and equity in order to harness the diverse and unique capabilities of our Sailors.

Suicide Prevention

The well-being of Reserve Sailors, civilians and their families is an imperative for a healthy, whole force. We continue efforts to decrease barriers to mental health treatments, including the negative beliefs about help-seeking, and ensure appropriate services are available to all service members and their families. The Psychological Health Outreach Program (PHOP), a Reserve program, provides counselors, coordinators and resources 24/7/365. In FY22, PHOP completed a total of 506 Reserve Center on-site visits and 29 virtual visits, a 25% increase from FY21. Additionally, they received 3,377 Navy Reserve referrals. Electronic behavioral health screenings are available to every Sailor and family member for immediate access to PHOP services, while Resiliency Check-ins provide screening and referrals as necessary. Reserve Sailors, civilians and their families are critical to our warfighting readiness and remain our most important asset and, as such, the importance of their health, wellness and safety underscores all of our efforts.

CONCLUSION

We are transforming the Navy Reserve and delivering ready units of action and augmentation manpower to support Navy warfighting throughout the spectrum of conflict. To remain ahead of our pacing threats in the coming decades, we must continue to transform our force with urgency, to face the challenges of today while preparing for the war of tomorrow. My unambiguous focus remains warfighting readiness. Strategic and tactical guidance supports this singular goal, with the enduring foundation of professional, empowered, proficient Sailors at the core. We have made great strides in modernizing how we man, train, equip and mobilize the force. But we still have much to do. Our Navy is stronger as a result of the Navy Reserve's contribution to the fight. As it has for well over a century, America's Navy Reserve remains "Ready Now."

On behalf of the men and women of the United States Navy Reserve, thank you for your steadfast support of Navy Reserve Sailors, civilians, families, and employers. Today, we face a new era with new challenges. With your continued support, we will lead the transformation of our Navy Reserve to address the current and future global environment with speed and agility.

Senator TESTER. Thank you, Admiral. Next up, we have General Bellon, Commander of the U.S. Marine Corps Reserve. General.

STATEMENT OF LIEUTENANT GENERAL DAVID G. BELLON, COMMANDER, MARINE FORCES RESERVE

General BELLON. Chairman Tester, Ranking Member Collins, and distinguished members of the subcommittee, it is great to be here with you today to share a conversation, a public conversation with Forward Sergeant Major Carlos Ruiz and Command Master

Chief Mike Mussett who are sitting behind me about your Marine Corps Reserve.

Congress has been a great partner to us as a service as we have been in the middle of this historic inflection point to evolve the Marine Corps in order to meet the threats that we have been directed to meet, and hopefully my comments today will provide a little extra context about what the Marine Corps Reserve has done to meet those demands. Time, time is what I want to emphasize.

This is a time sensitive task that we have been given by you and by the Department of Defense and by the Combatant Commanders to evolve quickly in order to first deter, and then if necessary, meet threats. So, what have we done about that? What have we actually done in the last year to meet that need with your help?

I want to talk about a couple of things specifically. I will talk first a little bit about a vignette. I mean, the lens through which we see the world, we focus on the Marines first, right, the all-volunteer force effort. We believe in our hearts that we are tasked with winning our Nation's battles and we win our Nation's battles with Marines and Sailors. We don't man equipment. We equip Marines and Sailors.

So, as we looked deep into the threat and deep into our tasking, and what we acknowledge is we have this amazing human capital that joined us because they want to serve. They chose us because they thought it was going to be a harder task. It was going to be more difficult than other choices.

And what they are asking us to do is to make their service worthwhile, to honor them with the most difficult tasks, and then to arm and equip them to achieve those tasks. So, to that end, we have formed what we call the Marine Innovation Unit. It was an acknowledgment that this population that we all enjoy had this unique combined experience and education. They have their military service, and they have their civilian occupation and education.

And if we bound them together, they could do amazing things, if we didn't pay attention to military occupational specialties and ranks, and instead to a desire to serve and their human capital. This Marine Innovation Unit accelerated an opportunity for us to transition legacy capacity and capability, and you gave us the tools to do it.

By using degree of funds from fiscal year 2022 and 2023, we were able to take 400 Marines who were facing a sundowning scenario with legacy equipment, and instead buy a littoral craft capability, a maneuver capability that allowed them to not only have a new mission set, but more importantly reinvigorated them.

And here is the lesson I learned from that. By placing a littoral craft in both Tampa, Florida, and Galveston, Texas, we went from a scenario where our re-enlistment rates in those two companies because they perceived that their service was undervalued, to some of the highest in my component.

They were simply looking for a signal from us collectively that their service is meaningful and that the task we were going to give them would be meaningful. And so, with your help and with the help of your staffs in particular, we got great guidance from you, and we moved at the speed of relevance, and enabled and empowered these volunteers to continue service in a way that is inspiring.

So, the future, what do I believe the future is. The other thing we did was we combined the authorities that you have given us by combining the commands of Marine Forces Reserve and Marine Forces South—Southern Command. So, we accomplished two tasks at once. We raised the capabilities and readiness of our Marine Forces in the Reserves, and also provide capabilities and capacities to a significantly under-resourced Combatant Command.

And I believe the American people want us to do that, and your Marines and Sailors love it. I am excited about the future. The quality of the Marines that we have are phenomenal. The environment for recruiting is going to be difficult, and the American people and our forces are waiting for us to show that service is meaningful, and they can trust us as institutions, and today is all about that.

So, I appreciate the opportunity and I look forward to your questions.

[The statement follows:]

PREPARED STATEMENT OF LIEUTENANT GENERAL DAVID G. BELLON

Chairman Tester, Ranking Member Collins, and distinguished members of the Subcommittee, it is my privilege to testify on behalf of the Commandant of the Marine Corps and provide an overview on the current state of the Marine Corps Reserve and an insight into our vision for the future.

Your Marine Corps Reserve has always been ready, relevant, and responsive for the Nation, and to maintain that status we must innovate and evolve to meet the threats of both today and tomorrow. As part of the Marine Corps' effort to modernize our force and our warfighting capabilities through Force Design, the Marine Corps Reserve has embraced several unique initiatives to drive innovation on multiple fronts. The establishment of the Marine Innovation Unit (MIU) aboard Stewart Air National Guard Base in New York is a shining example of how your Marine Corps Reserve is leading from the front in this area. The MIU harnesses an untouched talent pool of Reserve Component Marines with unique skill sets from diverse backgrounds. MIU, in partnership with the Marine Corps Warfighting Laboratory, postures the Marine Corps to accelerate the adoption of advanced capabilities, and transform Naval Service capacity for technology while retaining and investing in Total Force human capital. In addition to the MIU, and in collaboration with the Defense Innovation Unit, the Marine Corps Reserve has been exploring a unique opportunity to identify and purchase dual-use commercially available small craft for littoral operations. These craft will allow the Marine Corps to leverage Reserve Component Assault Amphibian Battalion units and their littoral warfighting expertise to support Service-level experimentation and learning in littoral areas of operations. Continuous refining of how to compete and fight against a peer adversary is key to retaining the talent and service of these maritime-oriented Marines, and it is key to our evolution.

Just as we innovate and evolve, the Marine Corps Reserve remains dedicated to connecting with and contributing to the communities in which they reside, forming a critical link between the Marine Corps and our communities across the Nation. In 2022 we celebrated the 75th Anniversary of the Marine Corps Reserve Toys for Tots program. For 75 years Marines and their families have given back to their local towns and neighborhoods through their participation in this program; uniting local communities in a common cause to help less fortunate children through annual toy collections and distribution campaigns. Every year, no matter the clime or place, the Marine Corps Reserve is on the forefront of this initiative to support communities and families across the Nation.

I am deeply impressed by the professionalism, competence, and dedication of our Reserve Marines and Sailors. Like their Active Component counterparts, they serve selflessly to protect our great Nation. I am inspired by the way they balance family responsibilities, civilian careers, and military service with humility and a sense of pride and dedication that is consistent with the great sacrifices of Marines from every generation. As a warfighting organization, the key to our success has been and will continue to be individual Marines and their families. Your support of the National Guard and Reserves, down to the individual Marine Reservist, ensures we have the resources and funding to fight and win our Nation's battles.

A TOTAL FORCE

Throughout the past year, the Marine Corps Reserve continued global deployments supporting Combatant Commander requirements by providing multifaceted forces focused on combat operations, crisis prevention, crisis response, and theater security cooperation. In addition to the Active Component Marines already deployed, 2022 saw an additional 1,847 Reserve Marines activated and mobilized to support 22 operational requirements across six geographic Combatant Commands. The Marine Corps Reserve continues to meet the demand for use as an Operational Reserve; however, challenges to our readiness and ability to meet strategic requirements remain.

In FY23, the Marine Corps Reserve has already activated more than 83 Marines in support of four Combatant Commands and is forecasting the activation and mobilization of 589 additional Reserve Marines to support 21 separate formations. These operations significantly increase the Reserve Component's readiness and interoperability with the Active Component, Joint Forces, allies, and coalition partners. Planning is currently underway for increased activations and deployments across the globe that integrate Reserve forces with the Active Component commencing in FY24 and stretching across the Future Years Defense Program in support of high-priority Combatant Command requirements.

Throughout 2022, the Marine Corps Reserve continued to provide direct support to Operation ALLIES WELCOME with more than 1,100 Reserve Marines. Upon the successful completion of Operation ALLIES WELCOME, 103 Reserve Marines volunteered to extend their mobilization and deploy to Kosovo for Operation ALLIES WELCOME-KOSOVO located aboard Camp Bondsteel. The ability to augment this humanitarian aid mission with volunteers from the Reserve force speaks volumes to the dedication, professionalism, and compassion of our Reserve Marines. The Marine Corps' continued employment of the Reserve Component as a supplemental force has enabled the Active Component to focus its effort on global crisis response and contingency operations.

In addition to participating in operational requirements, the Marine Corps Reserve conducts a wide array of combat related training exercises across the globe. The purpose of these exercises is to improve the Marine Corps Reserve's combat readiness, international relations, and interoperability between allied nations and partners. In FY22, the Marine Corps Reserve led or participated in 59 military exercises across 16 countries, contributing 10,599 Reserve Marines. In FY23, the Marine Corps Reserve is forecasted to participate in 49 exercises globally, with a total force of 9,887 Reserve Marines. We expect the overall number of exercises and engagements to increase in the coming year as planners from the Marine Corps Reserve continue to attend exercise-planning events.

The Marine Corps Reserve continues to participate in the Department of Defense (DoD) Innovative Readiness Training (IRT) Program, which provides joint/military training in the United States and its territories to increase deployment and unit readiness. The IRT program simultaneously provides key services such as healthcare, construction, transportation, and cybersecurity with lasting benefits for our American communities. In 2022, the Marine Corps Reserve participated in nine exercises under the IRT Program, with two of those exercises involving both Active and Reserve forces. Our participating units were able to train to mission essential tasks involving both horizontal and vertical construction, logistical support, communications, and medical care while making tangible, meaningful impacts in communities located in Alaska, Indiana, Ohio, Texas, and Hawaii. With your continued support of these efforts, we look to expand our footprint in this program; to include airlift, construction, medical, and cybersecurity efforts.

In addition to participating in operational requirements throughout the world, the Marine Corps Reserve supports the Total Force by dutifully executing the sensitive and crucial mission of providing casualty assistance to the families of our fallen Marines. There is no responsibility we treat with higher regard than this solemn mission. Inspector-Instructor (I-I) and Reserve Site Support staffs are geographically positioned to accomplish the vast majority of Marine Corps casualty assistance calls and are trained to provide compassionate and thorough assistance to families. Indeed, most Marine Corps casualty notifications and follow-on assistance calls to the next of kin are made by our Reserve Marines.

During FY22, I-I and Reserve Site Support staffs supported 247 of the 298 active casualty calls performed by the Marine Corps. The professionalism and compassion of our Casualty Assistance Calls Officers (CACOs) continues well beyond the initial notification. We ensure that our CACOs are well trained, equipped, and supported by all levels of command through a combination of in-person and online training. Once assigned, the CACO serves as the family's central point of contact and coordi-

nates with funeral homes, government agencies, and other organizations as needed. They assist family members with planning the return and final resting place of their Marine and ensure the filing of appropriate documents so that families receive all entitled benefits. In many cases, our CACOs provide a long-lasting bridge between the Marine Corps and the grieving family.

The Marine Corps Reserve also performs the solemn mission of military funeral honors, and our Reserve units take pride in performing many of these services for our fallen Marines and their families. Marine Corps funeral honors are dedicated to ensuring all Marines who have served honorably receive the appropriate honors. It is a final salute to their life and the final demonstration of our country's gratitude to those who, in times of war and peace, have faithfully defended our Nation. Marine Corps Reserve units performed 22,819 military funeral honors in 2022, 93% of the total funeral services provided by the Marine Corps.

PERSONNEL

Our Marines, Sailors, and civilian Marines are the foundation of all that we do. The resources we dedicate to sustaining and developing this foundation directly contribute to the success of our Service and the Marine Corps Reserve. The vast majority of the Marine Corps Selected Reserve's authorized end strength of 33,000 falls under Marine Forces Reserve. The Selected Reserve is composed of Marines in four categories: Selected Marine Corps Reserve (SMCR) Units, Active Reserve (AR), Individual Mobilization Augmentees (IMAs), and service members in Initial Active-Duty Training (IADTs). Embedded with these Marines are 1,502 Active and Reserve Component Sailors who serve critical roles in the operational, medical, dental, and spiritual readiness of our Reserve Force. The success of the Marine Corps Reserve would not be possible without the support of these Sailors and U.S. Navy programs.

In addition to the Marines and Sailors of the Selected Reserve, the Marine Corps Reserve administratively manages approximately 64,500 Marines who serve in the Individual Ready Reserve (IRR). The Marine Corps Reserve continues to monitor the activation viability of these IRR Marines with muster events at multiple locations across the country. The events also provide the opportunity to address administrative issues, conduct mental health and post-deployment assessments, review Reserve obligations and new opportunities, and meet with Marine Corps prior-service recruiters. During the past year the Marine Corps Reserve conducted 24 muster events in which 4,626 IRR Marines attended. In addition to the in-person muster events, the Marine Corps Reserve contacted and screened 47,711 IRR Marines.

The Marine Corps Reserve strives to attract and retain the most qualified Marines capable of fulfilling our leadership and operational needs. Marines approaching the end of their current contracts, whether Active or Reserve Component, receive counseling on the tangible and intangible benefits of remaining affiliated with the Selected Reserve. We educate each transitioning Active Component Marine on opportunities for continued service in the Marine Corps Reserve through the Marine Corps' transition assistance and educational outreach programs.

As the Marine Corps modernizes our forces to ensure we are postured to confront future potential adversaries, we are making every effort to retain those Marines who are affected by Force Design initiatives. During 2022, the Marine Corps Reserve deployed a series of Personnel Transition Teams (PTTs) to every Reserve unit where the Commandant's Force Design program had a direct impact on Marines and their ability to continue serving; this also included those units who were affected by the Marine Forces Reserve Site Optimization program. These PTTs were specifically designed to ensure each Marine was provided information, education, and one-on-one career counseling concerning available incentives, career opportunities, and continued service options. We successfully retained more than 64% of all Reserve Marines assigned to those site locations through voluntary reassignment to another Marine Reserve unit, while an additional 14% of those Marines chose to transfer to another Service to continue their military careers. Survey responses show that 83% of the Reserve Marines felt they had been provided with the information and support needed to make an informed decision, while 90% of the Reserve Marines felt their best interests were kept in mind.

Recruiting and retaining high-quality Marines is essential to the Marine Corps' role as the Nation's force-in-readiness. Although the Marine Corps Reserve has recruited and trained Marines safely in the face of the global pandemic, the challenges with recruiting in a COVID-19 environment have persisted into the past fiscal year. The Marine Corps Reserve still enjoys high affiliation from non-prior service recruiting and accomplished its recruiting goals in FY22. The Marine Corps Reserve is thankful for and greatly appreciates the retention programs supported by Congress and the DoD, which include inactive duty travel reimbursement and multiple bonus

programs. These programs are essential to ensure we continue to meet authorized end strength and retain our most talented Marines. Your continued support of these critical programs has helped preserve our overall personnel end strength at 84.6% of the total requirement and maintain a grade and Military Occupational Specialty match rate of 72.3%. Our personnel readiness not only reflects the health of the force, but it directly contributes to our overall operational readiness. We fully expect to meet or exceed our Selected Marine Corps Reserve retention goals this year. Continued use of available incentive programs is critical to optimally match individuals to our requirements, maintain individual and unit-level readiness, address shortfalls in our staff non-commissioned officers' ranks, and fully rebuild readiness from previous force structure changes.

EQUIPMENT

Every Marine Corps Reserve unit is manned, trained, and equipped to standards that facilitate seamless integration and employment of forces to meet the requirements of both the Service and Geographic Combatant Commanders. Marine Corps Reserve units, along with their personnel and equipment, continue to be in high demand due to their high interoperability with their Active Component counterparts.

The Marine Corps Reserve is designed to be equipped at near parity with its active component counterpart due to the Total Force approach to equipment fielding. However, the high demand for Reserve units and the resulting high operational tempo places stress on the Marine Corps Reserve's ability to maintain equipment and replenish deficiencies. Inadequate or delayed fielding coupled with delays in appropriation of funds disrupts our ability to program long-term activities and challenges our efforts to improve current and future readiness. One of the greatest ongoing concerns has been our Individual Combat Clothing and Equipment (ICCE) deficiencies. The National Defense Authorization Act for FY23 provided a line-item appropriation specifically providing the Marine Corps Reserve the ability to place ICCE procurements at levels which will meet current materiel Table of Equipment allowance requirements. Currently, ongoing enterprise-wide contracting and manufacturing delays have impeded the replenishment of unserviceable items. In the event of a large-scale wartime mobilization, to include any sizable call-up of the IRR, ICCE deficiencies may become a Service-level risk.

The Marine Corps Reserve continues to mitigate risk and ensure maintenance readiness through Training Allowances (TA), Operation and Maintenance Marine Corps Reserve (OMMCR) funds, and third-party logistics. First, we refine a unit's TA, which is that portion of a unit's full Table of Equipment (TE) located at Reserve Training Centers (RTCs). Our goal is to balance the amount of equipment necessary to conduct training with the amount of equipment that can be maintained within personnel, facility, and fiscal constraints. Second, we leverage OMMCR funds to employ mobile maintenance support teams that augment our limited maintenance capacity in the Marine Corps Reserve. Third, we utilize a Service-managed third-party logistics provider to repair secondary components that cannot be repaired organically due to limited intermediate maintenance capacity. Congressional support for Reserve funding is paramount to our continued success in sustaining our equipment and maintenance readiness.

The Joint Light Tactical Vehicle (JLTV) and Amphibious Combat Vehicle (ACV) will provide the Reserve Component with the latest generation of combat equipment. The Marine Corps Reserve began receiving its allocation of 2,628 JLTVs in 3rd quarter FY21; to date, we have received only four vehicles. An additional eight specialty vehicles for the artillery community are scheduled for fielding in FY23/24. All Marine Corps Reserve ACV deliveries are currently scheduled for FY27. Final ACV Full Operational Capability (FOC) quantities and timelines will be determined pending future Service-level Force Design 2030 assessments.

TRAINING

The Marine Corps Reserve participates in a number of training exercises in the United States and abroad each year to improve combat readiness and enhance our ability to rapidly activate and integrate with the Active Component. The Reserve Force's ability to participate in and conduct training, drill weekends, and annual training periods have resumed to a steady state following the global pandemic. Local commanders continue to demonstrate initiative and creativity in conducting meaningful training for the Reserve Marines at each opportunity. Virtual training continues to allow for an increase in individual skills, but the focus of effort is to conduct in-person unit training at the company and battalion levels.

The dual-hatted Marine Forces Reserve and Marine Forces South command structure has resulted in efficiencies by enabling Reserve Marines to meet Geographic

Combatant Command requirements while simultaneously providing realistic multinational training for our Reserve formations. During FY22, Marine Corps Reserve Forces participated in the annual Service-level Integrated Training Exercise (ITX) at the Marine Corps Air Ground Combat Center, Twentynine Palms, California. ITX provides an opportunity for units to perform realistic, coordinated, live-fire training to meet Marine Air Ground Task Force mission essential tasks. In addition to the tactical training, ITX also serves as a rehearsal exercise in the activation and mobilization processes. The Reserve Force that forms at Twentynine Palms for training, receives orders to muster and move personnel from 77 different units located at 58 disaggregated Home Training Centers. Additionally, units plan for and coordinate the transportation of equipment to arrive simultaneously with the units in Twentynine Palms. These actions replicate similar tasks the units would be required to perform should there be a wartime activation and Reserve Force mobilization. 4,237 Marines participated in ITX across the span of 20 training days this year. This realistic training aids in improving combat readiness for all exercise forces and enhances efficiency in Total Force integration to enable more rapid activation response times at the battalion and squadron levels.

The Marine Corps Reserve continues to focus on operational readiness within the Marine Air Ground Task Force and the Joint operational environment. Using joint aviation assets from the Marine Corps, Air Force, Air National Guard and Army National Guard, the Marine Corps Reserve conducted Tactical Air Control Party training to sustain Joint Terminal Air Controller (JTAC) qualifications at Smoky Hill Bombing Range in Salina, Kansas. This training benefitted the other Services by enabling more than 45 fixed and rotary wing aviation platforms to achieve mission essential training in close air support while certifying Reserve Marine JTACs.

Resident Professional Military Education (PME) courses regained momentum in FY22 as seat capacity returned to 1,091 Reserve Component seats. In addition, the Marine Corps Reserve continues to leverage distance education and virtual learning to maximize PME training opportunities.

The Marine Corps Reserve uses training simulators wherever and whenever possible to preserve fiscal and materiel resources. Marine Corps Reserve units employ Indoor Simulated Marksmanship Trainers (ISMTs) to maintain combat marksmanship skills and to maximize the use of their most precious resource, time. The ISMTs enable onsite training and eliminate long distance travel to remote DoD training locations. The use of this and other simulations systems, as well as increased online training, enabled the force to complete mission essential tasks and required DoD and Service-level annual training.

FACILITIES

The Marine Corps Reserve occupies facilities in 47 states, the District of Columbia, and the Commonwealth of Puerto Rico. These facilities include 28 sites that are owned and maintained by the Marine Corps Reserve. The other 130 Reserve Training Centers, in which the status is "Tenant," are owned and maintained by other Services. Although some sites are located onboard major DoD installations, most Reserve Training Centers are located within civilian communities, ranging from residential neighborhoods to industrial and commercial districts. With a continuous effort to improve the maintenance and security of all our facilities, our main goal is to ensure the safety of our Marines and Sailors by facilitating effective readiness training and efficient activation and mobilization locations.

Traditionally, the Marine Corps Reserve has committed 100% of the facilities budget to support the sustainment and maintenance of existing infrastructure and day-to-day operating costs. Because of this investment and commitment, we have been able to improve the overall readiness of our facilities' inventory. Moreover, through the comprehensive utilization of the Facilities Sustainment, Restoration, and Modernization (FSRM) program, we have also retained and maximized inadequate facilities that were deemed vital to support the Marine Corps Reserve's mission. Currently, we are working to identify major FSRM projects for future funding. In conjunction with our maximization efforts, we also sought out cost and funding savings in the divestiture of facilities and demolition of excess footprint. In the last 2 years, the Marine Corps Reserve has divested, or is in the process of divesting, from 19 sites at a savings of approximately \$200k-\$300k savings per site.

As we capitalize the utilization of the Military Construction, Navy Reserve (MCNR) program, our focus is on providing construction for new and enduring capabilities, as well as recapitalization of our aging facilities. The construction projects enabled by the annual authorization and appropriation of MCNR funding are a significant factor in advancing our facilities support mission, especially as we optimize our force laydown throughout the Nation. Continued support for our MCNR pro-

gram requests is essential for the planning and execution to modernize our capabilities and, when needed, the ability to divest from failing infrastructure or facilities that no longer meet the mission.

The combined effects of our targeted site consolidations, FSRM, and MCNR Programs have steadily reduced the number of inadequate or substandard Reserve Training Centers and enabled improved support to the Reserve units and personnel. However, as our infrastructure ages, the operating costs have steadily increased and will continue to increase as the Marine Corps modernizes to meet the requirements of the National Defense Strategy. The continued support of our annual funding request for our facilities program will enable us to improve the overall physical infrastructure that reinforces the operational readiness of our units and personnel.

The safety of our Marines, Sailors, and their families is of utmost importance; therefore, we are actively engaged in ongoing efforts to improve the overall force protection at all our sites. We take pride in working with our Service partners and the National Guard to improve our sites where joint occupation is optimal. Throughout the last 10 years, numerous force protection assessments have been conducted at our facilities and security-engineering reports have been generated to assist in developing designs that mitigate protection concerns, specifically within the realm of physical security. These assessments identify requirements and serve to prioritize enhancements, which ultimately improve the overall facility security for our Marines, Sailors, and their families. While we are funded for the Installation Physical Security of our owned sites, at Reserve Training Centers where we are considered "tenants," we are reliant on the other Services to fund the physical security requirements. However, to ensure the Physical Security requirements for these units, the Marine Corps Reserve often funds security projects that should be funded by the host command. As a direct result, the Marine Corps Reserve plans to submit a budgetary increase in the future years to ensure our projects are funded to the required levels.

HEALTH SERVICES

The Marine Corps Reserve Health Services Support (HSS) system prioritizes the health and wellness of our Reserve Marines and Sailors. We improve medical readiness through a robust Individual Medical Readiness Program within the Marine Corps Reserve and by accurate monitoring, identification, and supervision of unit-level actions necessary to attain readiness goals. Additionally, our Health Services personnel participate in Force Readiness Activation Assessment Program inspections and audits which provide oversight at the individual unit, as well as the ability to monitor readiness and adherence to policy.

The Reserve Health Readiness Program (RHRP) has greatly increased overall medical and dental readiness throughout the force. This program uses contracted civilian medical and dental providers to work with units that do not have organic medical or dental support personnel or are remote from, or not supported by, a nearby Military Treatment Facility (MTF). During FY22, the RHRP performed 11,237 Periodic Health Assessments (PHAs), 54 Onsite Post-Deployment Health Re-Assessments (PDHRAs), 17,465 audiological examinations, and 8,600 dental examinations.

The Marine Corps Reserve HSS's priority is to achieve the DoD's goal of a 90% medically ready force. While national, regional, state, and local restrictions on travel and group activities due to COVID-19 affected scheduling and availability of both organic unit and RHRP readiness events over the course of several months, FY22 individual medical and dental readiness rates were nevertheless 91% and 89%, respectively. Marine Corps Reserve units rely heavily on RHRP to maintain our medical and dental readiness, and continued support of this program is imperative for maintaining overall readiness.

As a result of the overlapping Marine Forces Reserve/Marine Forces South relationship, MARFORRES/MARFORSOUTH HSS coordinates with Headquarters Marine Corps and Navy Medicine to align with Force Design 2030. This relationship provides unique opportunities to achieve Mission Essential Tasks (METs) and Knowledge, Skills, and Abilities (KSAs) to address prioritized expeditionary medical support capabilities, including Prolonged Casualty Care, Multi-modal Patient Transportation and Patient Movement, and Scalable Force Packages for support to Expeditionary Advanced Based Operations (EABO) and Littoral Operations in a Contested Environment (LOCE).

In partnership with USSOUTHCOM, the Marine Corps Reserve has aligned with Service components to advance the USSOUTHCOM Global Health Engagement strategy. Opportunities to foster relationships with Partner Nations throughout Central and South America and the Caribbean could not have come at a more fortuitous time. In an environment where instability, post-pandemic restrictions, and ma-

lign near-peer influence may impact access, the Marine Corps Reserve is initiating smart, innovative, and cost-effective medical capability concepts in partnership with the Marine Corps Warfighting Lab that include the Tactical Scalable Surgical System (TS3) and Virtual Reality training to demonstrate constant U.S. presence and support to our partners in the USSOUTHCOM region. A fully developed suite of collaborations in the Global Health and Medical Education spaces further demonstrate how the Marine Corps Reserve and other Service components will continue to be the partner of choice in the region, as well as a vehicle to preparation for operations throughout the world.

BEHAVIORAL HEALTH

The Marine Corps Reserve executes a multifaceted behavioral health program that includes Combat Operational Stress Control Capability, DoN's Deployment Health Program, Psychological Health Outreach Program (PHOP), and collaboration with the National Guard Bureau and the Department of Veterans Affairs (VA), as well as targeted initiatives for Suicide Prevention Capability, Substance Abuse Prevention, and Family Advocacy Programs. The Combat Operational Stress Control (COSC) capability provides essential knowledge, skills, and tools to assist commanders with improving mission readiness, force preservation, and improving the long-term health of Marines and their families. The COSC is comprised of two trainings: Operational Stress Control and Readiness (OSCAR) and Deployment Cycle Training (DCT).

OSCAR builds teams of selected Marines and unit leaders along with medical and religious personnel to work together as sensors for the commanders by identifying small changes in personnel behavior. OSCAR teams help to enable a bias for action within the command and link individuals to appropriate resources. The DCT is conducted across every rank and is delivered to service members at the appropriate point in the deployment cycle. The combination of these programs helps to prevent, identify, and effectively manage combat and operational stress, whether deployed or in garrison. Each of these tools supports the unit commanders in building unit strength, resiliency, and readiness, as well as keeping Marines and Sailors in the fight.

The Navy Bureau of Medicine and Surgery supports behavioral health through various independent and contracted programs such as Post-Deployment Health Reassessment/Mental Health Assessment (PDHRA/MHA) and PHOP. The PDHRA Program is intended to focus specifically on identifying issues that emerge after our Marines and Sailors have returned home from deployment. The MHA is conducted at multiple intervals throughout the deployment cycle, annually with a Marine or Sailor's physical health assessment (PHA), and during the Separation Health Assessment (SHA). The MHA serves as a screening for any mental health concerns including but not limited to depression, alcohol misuse, and post-traumatic stress syndrome symptoms. PHOP secures behavioral health screenings, psychological treatment referrals, and essential follow-up treatment to ensure our service members' behavioral health needs are met. In FY22 PHOP connected with 9,129 Marine Corps Reservists; an estimated 13% of those connections resulted in intensive case management. Through their outreach services, PHOP addresses general behavioral health needs, post-deployment concerns and crisis-related interventions by providing our Marines and Sailors access to local resources through a network of contracted behavioral health programs. Internally, PHOP and Marine Corps Reserve's Force Chaplains regularly exchange contact rosters to multiply networking effectiveness. These programs remain critical to maintaining a resilient force by providing pathways for Marines, Sailors, and families to seek behavioral health assistance.

Access to reliable behavioral healthcare is a barrier to many Reservists and their families. However, memorandums of understanding (MOUs) with the National Guard Bureau, and the Department of Veteran's Affairs have greatly increased the resources available to Reservists and their families. Marines, Sailors, and their families can now utilize more than 400 additional resource sites through the National Guard Bureau's Family Assistance Centers, and 383 veteran centers (83 of them mobile) through the VA. Veteran centers are able to provide psychological assessments, counseling, and additional treatment options.

Signs of operational and combat stress may manifest long after a service member returns home from deployment. This delayed onset of symptoms presents unique challenges to Reserve Marines and Sailors who may be detached from vital medical care and the daily support network inherent in active-duty Marine Corps units. Encouraging Marines to recognize and communicate mental health challenges is a pervasive issue facing our commanders. The Marine Corps Reserve addresses the stigma associated with mental healthcare through key programs such as the Yellow

Ribbon Reintegration Program (YRRP) and COSC. We market all our behavioral health initiatives and programs through our Marine Corps Reserve website, our smart phone mobile application (app), and during key Marine Corps forums throughout the year.

The Marine Corps Reserve smart phone mobile app, USMC Reserve Connect, is tailored to Marine Reservists and family members. This Defense Information Systems Agency (DISA) approved app is an enterprise-wide, mobile app that serves as a gateway to public content on government websites. The app delivers portable, timely, and relevant information to Marines, Sailors, and their families and reduces reliance on traditional computers to access career and personal resources. The app is customizable, enabling units to provide Reserve Marines and Sailors with relevant, unit-specific information. The app includes a mobile Common Access Card (CAC) portal that allows Marines to pair their devices with a mobile CAC reader to access some CAC-secured sites. USMC Reserve Connect increases engagement, communication, and connectedness through greater access to career, lifestyle, and behavioral health resources. The app is free to the public and is available for download in most mobile app stores.

The Marine Corps Substance Abuse Program educates Marines and Sailors on substance misuse and how it may impact relationships, coping mechanisms, thinking patterns, and risk awareness. The Substance Abuse Program provides tools to promote the safety and total fitness of Marines, Sailors, and their families to sustain and improve personal readiness and unit performance. The Marine Corps Reserve relies profoundly on its Drug Demand Reduction Program that uses random urinalysis testing to deter the use of illicit drugs and misuse of prescription drugs. Each Reserve unit conducts monthly drug testing to screen Reserve Marines and Sailors for drugs as well as breathalyzer testing to screen for alcohol use while in a duty status. In FY22, with the decrease in COVID-19 restrictions and bases returning to Health Protection Condition Alpha (HPCON A), units have reintegrated the Alcohol Screening Program into their monthly testing requirements. In response to this, the Substance Abuse Program has increased education and training for Alcohol Screening Program Coordinators.

Additionally, the Substance Abuse Program staff provides quarterly on-demand education and awareness training on the dangers of abusing prescription drugs, information on the proper disposal of unused and outdated medications, and annual supervisor-level training that increase leaders' awareness of the dangers of abusing prescription drugs. In FY22, the Substance Abuse Program continued the use of Prime for Life in our educational efforts. This 4.5-hour training is designed for Substance Abuse Control Officers and their unit leaders to explore how biology and choices affect an individual's risk of alcohol and substance dependence, with emphasis focused on values and goals.

The Marine Corps Reserve recognizes there are a myriad of factors contributing to suicide-related events. Risk factors can include depression, social isolation, impulsive or aggressive tendencies, and substance misuse and abuse. Common precipitating stressors are consistent with the previous year and include relationship, legal, and financial challenges, as well as disciplinary problems. Commanders employ a coordinated and effective suicide prevention methodology that allows for the identification of stressors and application of mitigation measures to prevent and address conditions that lead to suicidal behaviors within their units. Force Preservation Councils are conducted monthly to optimize the potential of all Active and Reserve Marines and Sailors. Through engaged leadership and consultation with subject matter experts, unit leaders identify potential risk factors and apply holistic risk management courses of action in order to improve individual and unit readiness.

The Marine Corps' Unit Marine Awareness and Prevention Integrated Training (UMAPIT) educates every Marine on the basics of suicide prevention, assists with normalizing life changes, and emphasizes the need to seek help with the aim of decreasing the negative stigma around behavioral health. UMAPIT is a tiered initiative designed to improve the total fitness of Marines, help foster mission readiness, and increase the chance for early intervention. This training incorporates evidence-informed practices and raises awareness about common risk factors and warning signs associated with a range of behavioral health issues such as substance abuse, suicide, family maltreatment, and combat operational stress before such issues become unmanageable. The Marine Corps culture toward encouraging Marines to seek help continues. This culture shift aids in reducing barriers to care and the fear of reprisal for seeking help. Lastly, all Marines are taught to recognize suicide warning signs and to seek appropriate resources for themselves and others to ensure that no Marine is left behind.

Care Management Teams focus on supporting Reserve Marines and Sailors through the Department of Veterans Affairs Transition Care Management Program. The Reserve Marines and Sailors are provided with a Care Manager who oversees the referrals, follow-on care, and individual healthcare needs of the Reserve member. The Marine Intercept Program (MIP) is an evidence-informed, targeted intervention for service members serving on active duty or activated Reservists who have had an identified suicide ideation or suicide attempt. MIP includes a series of telephonic contacts in which a counselor assesses the Marine for risk, encourages the use of a safety plan, and identifies and addresses barriers to services or resources. These services are also provided to our Reserve Marines and Sailors through PHOP.

Our Reserve Marines and Sailors have proven their strength in navigating challenging issues such as frequent moves, deployments, and separations from loved ones. To help with these challenges, our Marines, Sailors, and family members can access behavioral health programs at Marine Corps installations through Marine Corps Community Services (MCCS) while on active-duty orders. Additionally, we continue to support Military OneSource which provides confidential, non-medical counseling, resources, and support to service members and their families anywhere in the world.

SEXUAL ASSAULT PREVENTION AND RESPONSE

Sexual assault is a corrosive problem across the Department of Defense with damaging impacts to the victims and their families, friends, communities, and the organizations they serve. Each case of sexual assault causes harm to unit cohesion, morale, unit and individual readiness, and the reputation of the Service as a whole. Recruitment, retention, and most importantly the health and wellbeing of our men and women in uniform also suffer. For the Marine Corps Reserve, improving the health and safety of our service members by fostering a culture of dignity and respect are top priorities as they are key to reducing and ultimately eliminating sexual assault within our ranks. The Marine Corps Reserve has a robust Sexual Assault Prevention and Response (SAPR) Program that provides training, advocacy, guidance, and supportive services across our geographically dispersed force. Our current SAPR Program is comprised of seven full-time professional employee positions developed to ensure the efficacy of the program and provide both prevention and response services. In addition to the force-level Sexual Assault Response Coordinator (SARC), each Major Subordinate Command (MSC) within the Marine Corps Reserve has a full-time civilian SARC who serves as a special staff officer and subject matter expert to their Commanding General. The SARCs manage each MSC's SAPR Program from Marine Forces Reserve headquarters in New Orleans, Louisiana, along with two professional civilian SAPR Victim Advocates (VAs) who are available to travel throughout the country to provide in-person advocacy services, training, and unit-specific program guidance to Marines, Sailors, and their families. The Marine Corps Reserve's SAPR personnel work diligently to provide prompt and effective victim response, outreach, and sexual assault prevention by approaching these efforts as a team. The SARCs and SAPR VAs work together to ensure there is never a gap in coverage, regardless of the MSC or location. Leaders at every level and anyone in need of support services have access to a SAPR staff member for program guidance. To strengthen both prevention and response efforts, the Marine Corps Reserve will be adding more full-time civilian SAPR personnel across the Force in a phased hiring plan based on the Independent Review Commission on Sexual Assault in the Military (IRC)'s recommendations adopted by the Secretary of Defense. The additional SARCs will be advisors to our Regimental and Battalion Commanders, and professional full-time civilian Victim Advocates will further support our leadership at every level and the Marines and Sailors across the country. The SAPR staff historically have trained up to 160 service members to become new victim advocates each year during week-long courses held quarterly in New Orleans. We will continue to reinforce our SAPR program with collateral duty Victim Advocates in operational and deployed as well as geographically isolated environments as we establish a larger full-time civilian staff in alignment with the IRC recommendations approved by the Secretary of Defense. SAPR personnel respond to Marines, Sailors, and adult dependents who request support services related to a report of sexual assault. The SARCs and VAs screen for potential safety issues, develop individualized safety plans, and offer advocacy services and referrals in the military and civilian sectors. A nationwide database of resources is maintained in order to effectively support Reserve Component members who may not have access to military providers.

The Marine Corps Reserve operates a dedicated Sexual Assault Support Line that is staffed by the professional SAPR team 24/7. The Marine Corps Reserve also ac-

tively publicizes the DoD Safe Helpline, an additional resource that offers crisis support services for members of the DoD community. The DoD Safe Helpline is available 24/7 worldwide with telephonic, secure chat, and web-based resources and can be used anonymously for confidential support.

The Marine Corps Reserve's prevention strategy is holistic and integrated with other programs aimed toward eradicating sexual assault and interpersonal violence, such as the Equal Opportunity Program, Safety, Spiritual Readiness Initiatives, PHOP, Total Force Fitness initiatives, and Behavioral Health. Leaders at every level are encouraged to actively engage with Marines and Sailors to create a positive environment free from attitudes and harmful behaviors that are incompatible with our core values. Each year, all Marines and Sailors receive SAPR training that covers reporting options, available resources, and prevention techniques. New course material focusing on the prevention of interpersonal violence is in development and additional efforts toward fostering a healthy command climate are being highlighted. Along with overall education about the SAPR Program, these periods of instruction give individual Marines and Sailors an opportunity to interact with their local Command SAPR representatives, thereby helping to generate trust in the program and confidence that the prevention of sexual assault is a priority for leadership.

MILITARY EQUAL OPPORTUNITY

A key component to mission readiness is a healthy command climate, devoid of unlawful discriminatory practices and unacceptable behaviors that are collectively referred to as Prohibited Activities and Conduct (PAC). These harmful behaviors may include bullying, dissident and protest activity, harassment, hazing, prohibited discrimination, sexual harassment, and wrongful distribution of an intimate image. The Military Equal Opportunity (MEO) Program is enforced throughout the Marine Corps Reserve to eliminate such behaviors and foster a culture of dignity and respect, regardless of race, color, national origin, religion, sex (including pregnancy), gender identity, or sexual orientation. The MEO Program is staffed by fully trained, Active Component Marines who possess the 0147 (Equal Opportunity Advisor) Military Occupational Specialty. These billets include a force-level Equal Opportunity Advisor (EOA) and three additional EOAs at the MSC levels. Currently the MEO program is undergoing a restructuring to increase the number of personnel to support the Marine Corps Reserve's unique structure and geographical dispersion. The Marine Corps Reserve EOAs work cohesively as trusted agents to ensure seamless coverage by providing sound program advice to commanders and assistance to members across the force. EOAs are also assisted in program implementation by unit-level Equal Opportunity Representatives (EOR), a collateral duty maintained by Staff Noncommissioned Officers and higher at every O5 and O6 level command. Additional EORs are utilized at geographically dispersed subordinate units throughout the force for additional program implementation at the lowest level.

Both EOAs and EORs provide training to all Reserve Component members in preventing, identifying, and reporting PAC. Additional guidance is provided to ensure members understand the benefits of a healthy command climate and the adverse impact that PAC has on individual members, units, and the Service. EOAs and EORs are responsible for monitoring and advising commanders on command climate issues to include those identified in their Defense Organizational Climate Survey (DEOCS) results. During FY22, Marine Corps Reserve units were in full compliance with the Secretary of Defense-directed DEOCS requirements, including all follow-on corrective action plans. In addition to MEO resources, commands utilize the SAPR and behavioral health programs for a holistic approach to maintaining healthy command climates. Both EOAs and EORs work cohesively to ensure formal PAC complaints are addressed in a timely manner and in accordance with the applicable references. During FY22, the Marine Corps Reserve resolved 36 unique cases through the complaint resolution process. Throughout this process, commanders ensured complainants were protected against all forms of retaliation, maltreatment, ostracism, and reprisal.

QUALITY OF LIFE

The Marine Corps Reserve is committed to ensuring quality of life programs are designed to effectively assist all Reserve Marines, Sailors, and their families, whether they are deployed or on the home front. The Marine Corps Reserve is geographically dispersed throughout the country and often stationed away from most traditional brick-and-mortar resources available at major bases and stations. Therefore, we strive to provide awareness of and access to the diverse support programs available for their benefit. Face-to-face and virtual learning opportunities are available

along with toll-free telephone and Internet resources. The ability to access the comprehensive set of MCCS programs, which support operational readiness, warfighting capabilities, and quality of life can have a profoundly positive effect on the well-being of our Marines and their families. MCCS programming includes Exceptional Family Member Program (EFMP), School Liaison Program, personal and professional development, fitness and recreation, readiness and deployment support, family team building, and prevention. MCCS is an accessible and responsive resource that provides continual and lasting support to Marines and their families throughout their entire service or affiliation with the Marine Corps. The Unit, Personal, and Family Readiness Program is supported by civilian Deployment Readiness Coordinators and Uniformed Readiness Coordinators who implement a commander's family readiness vision and provide a vital link to Marines, Sailors, and their families to ensure a constant state of family readiness.

MCCS programs are flexible, constantly adjusting to meet the needs of our geographically dispersed Reserve Marines and their families. The training programs provided to our commanders, Family Readiness Command Teams, and Marines and their families help to produce a ready and resilient force equipped to achieve success. The Marine Corps Family Team Building (MCFTB) Program enhances readiness and resiliency through non-clinical preventative education, professional training, and community-building support to Marines, Sailors, and their families throughout the wide array of mission, life, and career events. During FY22, the Marine Corps Reserve conducted 183 training events in which 4,848 Marines, Sailors, and family members received essential information to assist them throughout the deployment cycle. These events helped them prepare for and flourish during deployments and achieve a positive post-deployment reintegration experience.

A Reserve Marine's quality of life and resiliency runs deeper than mental and physical wellness. The Marine ethos includes an impressive resolve forged in the spirit and able to perceive that which is greater than self. This connection with the transcendent inspires Marines to be their best and is undergirded by 167 chaplains and Religious Program Specialists who deliver religious ministry support and care to all Marines and Sailors, regardless of religious affiliation. Beyond equipment, training, and technical skill, it is the strength of spirit that enables our Marines and Sailors to accomplish the mission with honor, to overcome adversity, and to sacrificially serve with meaning and purpose. Religious Ministry Teams (RMT) comprised of uniformed chaplains and Religious Program Specialists, help to increase the readiness of Marines, Sailors, and their families by preparing them for the rigors of military life, including the demands of military operations. The Marine Corps Reserve has chaplains embedded in 39 Marine Corps Reserve units across the country and nine Religious Ministry Support Units directly supporting the Active Component. Through personal presence, these RMT's cultivate trust with leadership in carrying out the competencies of provision, facilitation, care, and advisement.

Chaplain Religious Enrichment Development Operations (CREDO) is a programmatic means to increase the spiritual readiness and resilience of service members and other authorized persons as part of the Department of Navy's Strategic Plan for Religious Ministry. Operating within the Command Religious Program (CRP), CREDO provides transformational retreats and workshops, including the Marriage Enrichment Retreat (MER), the Personal Resiliency Retreat (PRR), and Suicide Intervention Workshops such as Applied Suicide Intervention Skills Training (ASIST). The MER initiatives equip Marines, Sailors, and their families with practical relationship and communication tools that strengthen marriages and individual resiliency on the home front and during mobilizations. The PRR helps Marines and Sailors set personal goals, make healthy decisions, develop coping skills for stress, and live their lives with greater purpose and satisfaction. During FY22, chaplains invested in 145 couples through 10 MERs and in 578 individuals participating in 31 retreats and workshops focused on resiliency and team building in the context of leadership and human dynamics.

In an ongoing effort to reduce death by suicide and suicidal events, the CREDO Program offers ASIST, Suicide Alertness for Everyone (safeTALK), and START training to Marines and their families. These are evidence-based skill trainings for intervention in suicidal events to prevent death and increase prevention until care is available. Chaplains trained a total of 71 people in five workshops including three in remote locations. Participants in these programs self-reported an 83% increase in their likelihood to intervene to help a person having thoughts of suicide.

The Marine Corps emphasizes the importance of readiness for Marines and family members in many areas of life. The Marine Corps Personal and Professional Development Programs provide training and educational resources to increase awareness and build skills for individual and family development. These programs enhance the quality of life for our military community by promoting self-reliance and self-suffi-

ciency, as well as continuing the tradition of “taking care of our own.” The Marine Corps Personal and Professional Development Programs include transition readiness, personal financial management, voluntary education, and information and referral.

The Marine Corps’ Transition Readiness Program (TRP) is a comprehensive program that helps Marines, and their families develop and attain effective post-transition employment, educational, and entrepreneurship goals. It provides the tools and resources needed to comply with DoD directed Career Readiness Standards (CRS). Transition Readiness is a process that occurs across the Marine for Life Cycle; it is not an event that occurs at a single point in time, but rather takes place throughout a Marine’s career. The Marine for Life Network helps to link our Marines to employment, education, and community resources in their hometown areas to support their future goals. The Transition Readiness Seminar (TRS) is a week-long program required by Title 10 for all Active and Reserve Component Marines and Sailors who have served a minimum of 180 consecutive days on active duty. Marines are encouraged to attend TRS at the closest military installation to their location regardless of affiliation. For geographically dispersed Marines, many of whom are not located near a military installation, a virtual course is available to meet the requirement. In FY22, the Marine Corps Reserve transition staff assisted 800 geographically dispersed Marines with pre-separation counseling and capstone completion.

Additionally, Marines may take advantage of the DoD partnership with Tutor.com, which offers our Marines, Sailors, and their dependents access to 24/7, no-cost, live tutoring services for grades K–12 and college students. Our Marines are also provided with remote access to language courses through Mango Languages, which supports more than 70 languages, including English as a Second Language. Peterson’s Online Academic Skills Course helps Marines and Sailors build math and verbal skills to excel on the job, pass exams, and advance their careers and education.

Marines with a solid understanding of their personal financial situation and sound financial management practices are better prepared to meet the needs of the nation. The Personal Financial Management Program (PFMP) provides personal financial education, training, counseling, information, and referral as the number-one source for unbiased financial information to Marines and their families. The PFMP utilizes Financial Education Action Points to increase the knowledge and improve the financial practices of Marines at predetermined milestones within their career, such as promotion, permanent change of station, marriage, birth of a child, and others. The PFMP is available to all Marines and their families free of charge and on a variety of platforms (in-person, hybrid, and virtual).

The Marine Corps’ Semper Fit Program coordinates with our bases and stations to provide fitness education activities that promote physical and mental readiness and develops positive self-esteem and healthy lifestyles. Additionally, the High-Intensity Tactical Training (HITT) Program focuses on physical resiliency, combat readiness, and injury prevention. The HITT Program provides hands-on, science-based strength and conditioning courses and online physical fitness tools to include instruction on injury prevention, nutrition, and weight management. Life Athlete Readiness and Resilience programs provide opportunities for life skill development, social health, community connectedness, and stress management. Programs include recreational aquatics, outdoor recreation equipment checkout, community centers, community-wide activities, competitive events, parks, trails, picnic areas, youth sports, and other recreational programs.

The Yellow Ribbon Reintegration Program (YRRP) is a DoD-wide effort to promote the well-being of National Guard and Reserve members, their families, and communities by connecting them with resources throughout the deployment cycle. The YRRP is an enduring and invaluable part of our efforts to build resiliency. Since its inception in 2010, we have conducted more than 971 training events for more than 58,348 Marines, Sailors, and family members. In FY22, we conducted 27 virtual events connecting more than 1,795 participants with local resources before, during, and after deployments.

The Marine Corps Reserve is a dedicated advocate for flexible quality of life programs and services that evolve and adapt to the changing needs of our Marines, Sailors, and their families. The combined effect of these programs and services is critical to the readiness and retention of our Reserve Marines, Sailors, and their families.

SUPPORTING OUR WOUNDED, ILL, OR INJURED MARINES AND THEIR FAMILIES

The Marine Corps ensures the availability of full spectrum care to all wounded, ill, or injured (WII) Active and Reserve Service members through the Marine Corps' Wounded Warrior Regiment (WWR). Due to the unique nature of how Reserve Marines are activated and mobilized, they often encounter unique challenges to healthcare when WII. The Marine Corps has sought to address these challenges through the establishment of a WWR Liaison Officer whose sole purpose is to provide subject matter expertise in WII policies and procedures, coordination between Reserve leadership and WWR staff, and guidance and training to Reserve units throughout the recovery care continuum.

The WWR staff includes the Reserve Medical Entitlements Determination (RMED) Section, which maintains specific oversight of all Reservists requiring medical care for service-incurred and duty-limiting medical conditions. During this past year, RMED solidified professional relationships with key personnel at Defense Health Agency-Great Lakes in order to streamline the process for Reserve Marines injured in the line of duty to access medical healthcare benefits. This close working relationship resulted in the publication of a coordinated Marine Corps Administrative Message providing detailed guidance and instructions to Reserve units in order to reduce the time between an injury occurring and a Reserve Marine receiving treatment. We believe that arming Reserve units with this knowledge results in improved access to medical healthcare, which will greatly aid in an injured Marine's recovery timeline and have a positive impact to overall personnel readiness throughout the Marine Corps Reserve.

In addition to the oversight of medical care, RMED administers the Incapacitation Pay Program for the Reserve Component. Qualification for Incapacitation Pay is determined based upon the member being physically disabled as a result of their service-connected injury and the member demonstrating a loss of civilian earned income from non-military employment or self-employment as a result of that injury. During Fiscal Year 2022, the RMED section processed 323 Incapacitation Pay requests for payments totaling \$272,274.

Reserve Marines facing complex care and recovery needs have access to WWR's network of 45 Recovery Care Coordinators who provide one-on-one transition support and resource identification for WII Reservists and families who often live long distances from military installations.

The WWR also has medical advocates on the regimental staff who are available to assist Reserve, Active, retired, and veteran Marines in need of medical care coordination and advocacy. This support is called the District Injured Support Coordinators (DISC) program which is provided by WWR Reserve Staff Non-Commissioned Officers who are activated each year through Active Duty for Operational Support (ADOS) funding. The DISCs are dispersed throughout the country and assist in performing face to face meetings as part of their care and case management processes. The DISCs are the WWR Commanding Officer's representatives in the field with the mission to facilitate care and case management to personnel with highly complex needs and the successful transition of post-9/11 WII Marines from the Active or Reserve Component to veteran status.

The DISCs also provide direct support to more than 1,500 Marines currently on the Temporary Disabled Retired List (TDRL) to assist them in meeting all their requirements prior to the Department of the Navy's final determination of their disability. The DISC mission is accomplished by providing needs-based support and problem resolution, to include non-medical case management to post-9/11 WII veterans and their families to ensure the Marine Corps keeps faith with all Marines. Due to the reduction of ADOS funding, WWR reduced the DISC manning to minimal viable capability in FY23. Much of the support to the recently separated WII Marines and those on the TDRL has shifted to fully remote.

The Marine Corps will not forget the sacrifices our Reserve Marines made for this great Nation, and we will continue to work with WWR to establish resources and improve programs that address the unique and ongoing needs of our Reserve service members and their families.

FORCE DESIGN

The Marine Corps Reserve, operating as both a strategic and operational Reserve, is a critical part of the Total Force Marine Corps. As the Marine Corps transitions toward Naval Campaigning in response to Strategic competition, the Reserve Component continues to be an integral element of the planning effort. The Marine Corps' force design process is strategy-driven, threat informed, and concept based. Force development is then achieved through deliberate experimentation, wargaming, integrating planning teams, and analysis to provide valuable data in our Campaign of

Learning to identify what is effective. The Marine Corps Reserve provides support to this force design effort, while remaining a vital global contributor in meeting Combatant Command requirements.

Although the Active Component forces have been able to rapidly modernize under the direction of the National Defense Strategy (NDS) and the Commandant, the Reserve Component has yet to mature as quickly due to resource limitations. Currently, the deactivations of 4th Tank Battalion, bridging units, VMU-4, and VMGR-542 have been the only divestment requirements for the Reserve Component. The requirement to divest in Tanks and the associated bridging assets was a total force initiative, while the divestment in VMU and VMGR were specific to the Reserve Component. With each unit deactivation, whether a Marine is contractually obligated to serve or is no longer obligated, Personnel Transition Teams (PTTs) travel to those locations to meet with each individual Marine in order to assist them in finding opportunities for continued service. As changes to the Reserve Component alter the physical location of Reserve units across the country, we will continue to actively analyze their efficacy to ensure that any and all unit relocations are analyzed in detail and driven by relevant qualitative and quantitative factors.

The Reserve Component remains nested with all Service-related initiatives supporting Force Design. As the Active Component evolves, so too will the Reserve Component while also remaining ready and relevant to maintain its position as a vital contributor in support of Combatant Command requirements. Additionally, the Reserve Component, alongside Active Component planners, specifically 2nd Marine Expeditionary Force, are working to design and mature the concept of Service Retained Forces in support of global crisis and contingency operations. The Service Retained Force concept provides an opportunity for the Reserve Component to remain relevant and ready and provides a clear role for Reserve Marines in the future force under Force Design. This will include potential adjustments to the current capabilities and platforms within the Reserve Component that will ultimately serve to make a more lethal and capable Reserve Force. Opportunities for Marine Corps Special Operations Command integration are also being explored in relation to the Intelligence, Surveillance, Reconnaissance, and Targeting (ISRT) focus area from the MCWL Littoral Maneuver Experimentation Plan.

INNOVATION AND EXPERIMENTATION

The establishment of Littoral Craft Companies (LCC) is a comprehensive initiative producing strong linkages across several Marine Corps Reserve Lines of Effort (LOEs). The establishment supports numerous key objectives including Site Optimization, Talent Management, New Platforms and Technologies Integration, Experimentation and Wargaming Support as well as Service component integration in a way that effectively aligns broad aspects of the Marine Corps Reserve's strategic vision.

The LCC initiative emerged in response to a 2020 Service-level decision directing the divestment of C (Galveston, TX) and D (Tampa, FL) Companies, 4th Assault Amphibian Battalion (AA Bn) in FY25 and FY24 respectively. Preserving the talent and facilities at these two key coastal sites became imperative. Recruiting and retention at both Tampa and Galveston are consistently well above average comparable to the rest of the force at a time when the Marine Corps Reserve Component is recovering from COVID-19 and other end-strength challenges. In addition, both sites offer exceptional littoral training venues and wide-ranging opportunities for Joint and Interagency maritime partnerships within the Gulf-coast region.

Transitioning C and D Cos 4th AA Bn into LCCs presents an ideal Talent Management and Site Optimization solution to the problem, with the bonus of integrating new Platforms and Technology in the form of littoral craft. In partnership with the Defense Innovation Unit, the Marine Corps Reserve is pursuing a rapid acquisition of dual-use commercially available vessels through an Area of Interest solicitation to Industry. This highly flexible process offers direct access to vendors capable of producing state of the art littoral craft to the Marine Corps Reserve on an aggressive delivery timeline.

The Marine Innovation Unit and other staffs across the reserve component are coordinating closely with Service-level capability developers and the Marine Corps Warfighting Lab (MCWL) to posture the LCCs for support to live force experimentation in response to Service-level littoral maneuver, mobility, and tactical sustainment-oriented learning demands. Exploration is already underway in key focus areas to include "Training and Training Sustainment" and "Littoral Maneuver Craft Characteristics." Support to Experimentation is expected to rapidly increase once the LCCs are formally established allowing the Marine Corps Reserve to contribute significantly to the ultimate Total Force capability solution(s).

Initial planning efforts have begun for LCC participation during bi-lateral and multilateral exercises as well as waterborne Theater Security Cooperation activities in the U.S. Southern Command and other Global Combatant Command Areas of Responsibility once initial operational capability is achieved. Opportunities for Marine Corps Special Operations Command integration are also being explored especially in relation to the “Surveillance and Reconnaissance” and “Kinetic and Non-Kinetic Fires and Effects” focus areas from the MCWL Littoral Maneuver Experimentation Plan. This represents yet another clear example of how the LCC initiative links the Marine Corps Reserve Infrastructure, Human Terrain/Talent Management, Capabilities and Capacity and Utilization/Employment LOEs in an extraordinarily cohesive manner with potential wide-ranging, operational benefits for the Total Force Marine Corps.

TALENT MANAGEMENT

Earning victory in the increasingly complex and multi-domain warfighting realm of the future requires Marines to achieve and maintain an advanced level of technical, intellectual, and physical capability, and to operate comfortably in distributed and ambiguous environments. The Marine Corps of the future will require significantly more low-density/high-demand skillsets that are difficult to achieve and retain, particularly if we continue to rely so heavily on the Active Component. To achieve Service objectives, the Marine Corps is leveraging the Reserve Component to attract and retain diverse personnel with unique talent and skill, while also providing a path to service more compatible for Reserve Marines who choose to maintain a civilian career in conjunction with military duty. The Marine Corps Reserve is aligned with service goals to mature the force through the introduction of new initiatives to increase career flexibility and further develop talent in the Reserve Component. Initiatives such as the Direct Affiliation Program (DAP) provide unique opportunities for departing Active Component Marines with valuable skills to continue their service in the Reserve Component and provide a vital advantage to increasing reserve unit personnel readiness. Additionally, the Marine Corps Reserve promotes a variety of talent management initiatives, to include the Diversity Aimed Officer Program (DAOP) which targets historically underrepresented populations and provides them an opportunity to visualize and pursue their career path as a Marine Corps Officer through educational events, hands on experience, and senior leader mentorship. In the summer of FY23 we will host our third annual DAOP event, comprised of Marines chosen through a highly competitive process.

As the Active Component Marine Corps develops and implements new talent management and diversity objectives, policies and programs, the Marine Corps Reserve offers the Service many unique opportunities to attract, recruit, identify, incentivize, and retain the most talented individuals across the Total Force. The Marine Corps Reserve has already begun to integrate with Active Component teams at Headquarters Marine Corps, Manpower and Reserve Affairs and Marine Corps Recruiting Command to ensure the Reserve Component is seamlessly integrated into all Service-level talent management efforts. Soon, a sample Reserve Component officer billet will be included in the initial release and testing for the Marine Corps' Talent Management and Engagement Platform (TMEP). When this platform reaches full operational capability, TMEP will greatly enhance talent management, leadership development, as well as enhance diversity, inclusion, and equity throughout the Reserve Component. Moving forward, the Marine Corps Reserve will continue to develop innovative policies, pathways, and tools designed to capture, catalogue, and maintain visibility of our diverse pool of talent and ensure these Marines have a path for future service.

CONCLUSION

As the operational environment changes, your Marine Corps Reserve will continue to innovate and evolve in order to meet future challenges and deter the pacing threats as prescribed in the National Defense Strategy. Through efforts such as the MIU and the acquisition of dual-use small littoral craft, we are constantly shaping and refining that evolution. As we are evolving our force, we are continuing to keep faith with and remain true to the communities that have supported us with programs such as Toys for Tots. The key to our success has been and will continue to be individual Marines, Sailors, and their families. Your Reserve Marines will continue to answer their “irrational call to serve” and, with your continued support, we will remain ready. Semper Fidelis!

Senator TESTER. Thank you, General. Next up, we have General Healy, Chief Air Force Reserve.

**STATEMENT OF LIEUTENANT GENERAL JOHN P. HEALY, CHIEF OF
AIR FORCE RESERVE**

General HEALY. Chairman Tester, Ranking Member Collins, and distinguished members of the subcommittee, on behalf of the 70,000 men and women of the Air Force Reserve, it is an honor for me to be here today with my senior enlisted advisor, Chief Master Sergeant Israel Nuñez.

As a Commander, I am continually amazed by the accomplishments of our Reserve Airmen as they meet every challenge put forth in front of them on behalf of our Nation. This year marks the 75th anniversary of the Air Force Reserve, and during that time we provided the Nation with an operational capability, strategic depth, and surge capacity across every core mission set of the United States Air Force.

As a largely part time force, we provide a ready now, accessible force that is both mission effective and cost efficient. As our near-peer threat increases, we are committed to the Secretary of the Air Force's operational imperatives, the Chief of Staff's vision of accelerate, change, or lose, and the Chief of Space Operations' three lines of effort.

When I took command of the Air Force Reserve almost a year ago, I issued a task order with my two priorities of ready now and transforming for the future. In the past year, we have got to prove that ready now force through our ability to rapidly surge and provide experienced Reserve Airmen to Combatant Commands and the Joint Force.

Reservists provided critical support to our NATO allies and our European partners, and performed everything from intelligence analysis and cybersecurity, to airlift and air superiority missions, to aircraft maintenance and force protection. The U.S. Air Force and the U.S. Space Force would not be able to support Ukraine and deter Russian aggression without Reserve citizen Airmen.

To optimize our performance as part of the total force, the Air Force Reserve must transform for the future. That transformation requires the Air Force Reserve be proportionately and concurrently modernized with the regular component. Maintaining equipment parity with the regular component ensures our ability to match pacing threats.

Legacy aircraft divestment without recapitalization and delayed modernization adds substantial risk to the ability to sustain combat credible air superiority and strategic storage capacity in the future. We are grateful to Congress for the National Guard and Reserve Equipment Account.

NGREA enables us to modernize, sustain our capability, and replace obsolete equipment when recapitalization by the active component is not feasible. Our most important weapon system is our Airmen. We are focused on ensuring that Reserve citizen Airmen receive the support they need.

This includes providing mental health resources, investment in resilience initiatives, offering social support through yellow ribbon reintegration programs, implementing recommendations from the Independent Commission on Sexual Assault, and policy changes to remove barriers from service.

Over the past 75 years, the Air Force Reserve has provided conduct proven readiness. We are confident the Air Force Reserve will remain prepared to defend our great Nation now and in the future.

Thank you for your continued support of the Air Force Reserve, its citizen Airmen, and their families. I look forward to answering your questions.

[The statement follows:]

PREPARED STATEMENT OF LIEUTENANT GENERAL JOHN P. HEALY

UNITED STATES AIR FORCE RESERVE

The Air Force Reserve is a combat-ready force, with a Fiscal Year (FY) 2023 end strength of 70,000 Reserve Airmen, stationed at over 60 locations throughout the United States, and serving globally in air, space, and cyberspace. As a cost-efficient and mission-effective force, the Air Force Reserve provides the Nation with operational capability, strategic depth, and surge capacity, both overseas and here at home. The Air Force Reserve's wide-ranging operational capability serves the diverse needs of every Combatant Commander, whose requirements are as varied as the geographic and functional areas they support.

With over 80 percent of our Reserve Airmen serving part-time, this combat-tested experience is retained in a cost-efficient force, available whenever the Nation calls. Further, the Nation benefits from the intrinsic value gained by a member's civilian experience in a variety of career fields, from pilots and nurses to teachers and cyberspace professionals.

The Air Force Reserve directly supports the United States and neighboring countries with special capabilities, including aerial firefighting, aerial spray, and weather reconnaissance, better known as the "Hurricane Hunters." The Air Force Reserve's relationship with other Federal agencies, including the National Weather Service and U.S. Forest Service, demonstrates how Federal, military, and civilian organizations can work together to support the entire Nation.

The Air Force Reserve is a proven part of the Total Force. We are committed to the Secretary of the Air Force's Operational Imperatives, the Chief of Staff's vision of Accelerate Change or Lose, and the Chief of Space Operations' three Lines of Effort. The Air Force Reserve is critical to the Department of the Air Force's (DAF) effort to address the four National Defense Strategy (NDS) priorities: defending the homeland, deterring strategic attacks, deterring aggression, and building a resilient joint force. We execute the full spectrum of DAF missions, providing strategic depth and maintaining an operational readiness to deter our adversaries, defend the United States and our allies, and respond to any contingency—at a fraction of the cost of the Regular Component of the U.S. Air Force and the U.S. Space Force.

AIR FORCE RESERVE FISCAL YEAR 2024 POSTURE STATEMENT

Total Force operations require Total Force investments. The Joint Force faces a complex battlespace across multiple domains. The Regular Component of the U.S. Air Force and U.S. Space Force are working to fulfill the NDS priority of building a resilient joint force and defense ecosystem. The Air Force Reserve meets these challenges as part of the Total Force. Our mission capabilities rest on one single foundation—our people. Our Reserve Airmen must be able to work side by side with their Regular Component partners in the U.S. Air Force and the U.S. Space Force. To do that, we must train and equip our Reserve Airmen in a manner that is proportional and concurrent with the Regular Component. This will ensure the Air Force Reserve remains a credible operational and viable strategic reserve that can provide a surge capacity in a crisis or contingency.

With Congress' support, we were able to improve our readiness. Upon taking command of the Air Force Reserve, I issued a Task Order that emphasized two priorities: Ready Now and Transforming for the Future. The order empowers Reserve Airmen to own their individual readiness and establishes accountability across the entire command to become the force the Nation needs. The approval of our FY 2024 budget request will enable us to continue building readiness while also transforming for the future.

This year marks the seventy-fifth anniversary of the Air Force Reserve, and I am proud to say we have responded to every U.S. conflict and contingency since 1948. It has not been easy. The Air Force Reserve first mobilized to halt aggression on the Korean Peninsula in 1950, without a mobilization plan. Despite this challenge, Reserve Airmen brought combat air power to support United Nations Forces. Today,

Reserve Airmen remain ready, such as when an Air Force Reserve C-17 and its crew supported earthquake relief operations in Turkey and Syria by transporting 28 tons of cargo, 76 personnel, and 6 search and rescue dogs within 10 hours of notification on February 6, 2023.

During the last year, we accelerated the readiness of our nuclear deterrence forces and continued our focus on ensuring preparedness against pacing threats. We modernized key weapon systems and closed the gap on critical staffing shortfalls. We increased our organizational effectiveness and improved our ability to provide excellent care for our Reserve Airmen and their families while also working to bolster individual and organizational resilience.

My intent is to prioritize every dollar spent on initiatives that optimize readiness. We will hold ourselves accountable from planning to execution of a comprehensive and effective strategy to build a ready force and transform the organization. By employing data analytics coupled with new tools and processes, we are making timely and informed programmatic decisions. We are implementing policy reform that facilitates modernization and reduces administrative requirements. The result is an agile and judicious execution of financial resources. Continuing resolutions hamper Total Force readiness and degrade our ability to sustain progress.

While we continue to prioritize readiness, we still face challenges. Like the Regular Component of the U.S. Air Force, in FY 2022 the Air Force Reserve did not meet its end strength and in FY 2023, we are projected to fall short of end strength again. The FY 2024 budget request includes funding that will allow the Air Force Reserve to offer bonuses to help recruit and retain personnel. The budget will also provide funds to bring Airmen on status for additional training to support readiness. This is dual purposed as readiness training also improves an Airmen's experience, providing our members a sense of purpose and thereby improving retention.

The Air Force Reserve will support the DAF as it makes hard choices in Airpower and Spacepower modernization to keep pace with our strategic competitors. This is critical to address the four NDS priorities, which depend upon effective command and control capabilities that are survivable in the threat environment of today and tomorrow. The Air Force Reserve must be a part of that decisionmaking process since concurrent fielding, recapitalization, and divestment of airframes, systems, and equipment is essential to our ability to integrate effectively with the Regular Component and support the Geographic and Functional Combatant Commands. We conduct operations in every DAF core function and support both DAF services: the U.S. Air Force and the U.S. Space Force. For the Air Force Reserve to remain a viable contributor to joint operations, the Total Force must maintain equipment parity and interoperability. The FY 2024 budget continues to integrate Air Force Reserve capabilities with the Joint Force.

Reserve Airmen and their families are the foundation of our readiness, operational capabilities, and organizational success. Our Airmen's diverse talent and depth of experience are a force multiplier. Their dedication to our mission is second to none. We owe our Airmen stability and predictability. The Air Force Force Generation (AFFORGEN) model will increase predictability and lessen Reserve Airmen's time away from family and the financial burdens they may incur being away from their civilian occupations.

Our FY 2024 budget request supports our continuing efforts to implement the NDS by making deliberate and impactful investments in readiness. The Air Force Reserve value proposition is simple: we are a cost-effective strategic force that is experienced and accessible. We will use budgeted funds to ensure the Air Force Reserve has the capabilities and training required to generate combat power for the future security environment. We also will ensure readiness to answer our Nation's call, as we've done over the past seventy-five years. With the requested Congressional support, we will continue to organize, train, and equip our Reserve Airmen to remain a ready force to defend our Nation and its interests.

AIR FORCE RESERVE'S ROLE IN DEFENDING THE NATION

The Air Force Reserve is codified in law to provide trained and qualified personnel available for active duty in time of war, national emergency, or in response to a crisis or contingency. Recognizing that joint warfighters need air and space power, the DAF plays a critical role in defending the homeland, deterring strategic attacks, deterring aggression, and building a resilient joint force. The accessibility of the Air Force Reserve is critical to ensuring the DAF has a surge capacity to meet joint warfighter requirements. Because operational demands fluctuate, the Regular Component cannot be staffed to meet peak operational demands and is therefore right-sized for steady-state operations. The Air Force Reserve provides the strategic depth and operational support the DAF needs to meet these demands. This requires Re-

serve Airmen to be organized, trained, and equipped in line with the Regular Component to be a ready, resilient, and combat-credible force in reserve. We are transforming for the future to become the Air Force Reserve the Nation needs.

Our President's Budget (PB) request for FY 2024 enables the Air Force Reserve to be an operational and ready part-time force with a strategic surge capability. The PB allows us to invest in readiness and continue supporting every DAF core function. As the Regular Component divests legacy systems and brings new weapon systems online, the Air Force Reserve is following suit. The Secretary of the Air Force and the Chief of Staff of the Air Force concurred with the recommendation from the National Commission on the Structure of the Air Force report published on January 30, 2014, which stated that as the Air Force acquires new equipment, force integration plans should adhere to the principle of proportional and concurrent fielding across the components.

When mobilized, our Reserve Airmen provide full-time support to the Joint Force. In addition to our daily contributions to global operations, we provide rapid surge capability and strategic depth for national defense. In FY 2022, 3,299 Reserve Airmen deployed to support taskings. In FY 2023, over 2,500 Reserve Airmen are projected to deploy. This support is critical to the Regular Component by burden-sharing deployment requirements and providing the expertise of Reserve Airmen to Combatant Commands and the Joint Force. For example, since February 2022, 1,849 Reserve Airmen have supported U.S. Air Forces Europe and the United States European Command by serving 145,313 days on active duty orders. These Reservists have performed everything from intelligence analysis and force protection to aircraft maintenance and reconnaissance flights to deter Russian aggression.

Force Structure

With 80 percent of Air Force Reserve members serving part-time, most Reservists serve alongside our Regular Component counterparts in association constructs. Approximately two-thirds of the Air Force's associations are with the Air Force Reserve. Integrating through associations delivers significant taxpayer value, both in cost savings and improved mission effectiveness, by sharing aircraft, equipment, and facilities with the Regular Component. Our part-time force brings a wealth of knowledge and expertise from their civilian careers to their military service. This strengthens our capabilities, enables the integration of commercial best practices, and facilitates beneficial partnerships with industry and other institutions. This can be seen in organizational initiatives known as "Bullpens" that leverage Individual Mobilization Augmentees who have critical high demand low density skills that are lacking in the Regular Component. These Bullpens are critical to supporting the Secretary of the Air Force's Operational Imperatives and a great example is the bullpen being established to study Hypersonics. The Hypersonic Bullpen has 13 Reserve Airmen who are experts from industry and academia. There is also a China Bullpen with Reservists who have expertise spanning several disciplines including language, internal politics, and strategy.

Classic Associations

Unit associations between geographically collocated Regular Component and Reserve Component units exemplify Total Force Integration. In this construct, equipment resources are officially assigned to the lead unit but are shared between the lead and associate unit. Associations further enhance our interoperability and give the Regular Component access to the experience of the more seasoned Reserve force. This ensures parity in equipment and training, while providing cost savings and readiness benefits to both components. There are 79 associations between the Reserve and the Regular Components which span nearly every major mission set. The Reserve Airmen of the 477th Fighter Group at Joint Base Elmendorf-Richardson, for example, include some of the most experienced F-22 pilots and maintainers. The pilots average over 1,200 flight hours in the F-22 alone, compared to their Regular Component counterparts' 400 hours. Every pilot is mission commander and instructor pilot qualified, providing vital operational and instructional capacity to the associate unit. As the F-22 costs \$80,000 an hour to operate, the cumulative F-22 flying experience of the Reserve pilots has a replacement value of \$1.1 billion. Our Reserve maintainers provide a stable base of deep experience to mentor maintainers across the Total Force.

AFFORGEN

The DAF established AFFORGEN to enable force presentation to meet Combatant Command requirements in a sustainable, predictable manner while ensuring operational preparedness and required readiness. AFFORGEN is an evolution and maturation of the Air Expeditionary Forces model that balances risk between Combatant Command requirements, Air Force readiness, and modernization, by deploying pre-

identified units who have trained together. Since 2015 the Air Force Reserve has executed a form of AFFORGREN through Reserve Component Periods (RCPs). In FY 2024, AFFORGREN will meet initial operational capability, and the Air Force Reserve will provide 671 personnel to the initial Expeditionary Air Base Sourcing rotations and another 548 personnel for Supplemental Expeditionary Air Base Sourcing rotations totaling 1,219 Reserve personnel. These Reserve Airmen will include Logistics, Security Forces, Administration Personnel, Civil Engineers, Aerial Porters, and Communications troops. The Air Force Reserve will also provide additional Airmen to augment gaps in the Regular Component AFFORGREN manning.

The AFFOGREN model will provide Reserve Airmen with predictable deployment cycles. This predictability enables Combatant Commanders and the DAF to preplan and budget for the utilization of Air Force Reserve forces that is consistent with Congressional intent and Title 10 USC Section 12304b. It also enables Reserve Airmen, their families, and their employers to prepare for the demands of defending our Nation.

Core Functions

Our ability to meet current taskings and to supply strategic reserve staffing are predicated on equipment parity and our readiness. The Air Force Reserve provides daily operational support to the Joint Force, while maintaining a ready and accessible strategic force during major conflict or surge operations and unforeseen events, such as national disasters and contingencies. As an operational Reserve, we must maintain our readiness to support present-day missions while aligning our capabilities to meet the requirements of the NDS. We remain ready to employ traditional capabilities, while continuing to modernize our equipment to deter and defeat pacing threats.

Air Superiority

Preserving the advantage in strategic competition requires generating combat power in contested environments. Maintaining equipment parity with the Regular Component ensures our ability to match pacing threats. Legacy aircraft divestiture without recapitalization and delayed modernization programs add substantial risk to the ability to sustain combat-credible air superiority and strategic surge capacity in the future.

The Air Force Reserve provides vital experience to the DAF's 5th Generation fighter capabilities. The Air Force Reserve's first unit-equipped F-35 wing at Naval Air Station (NAS) Joint Reserve Base (JRB) Fort Worth, Texas will begin the conversion from F-16s to F-35s in FY 2024. We currently execute F-35 combat operations through our Classic Association at Hill Air Force Base (AFB), Utah. We conduct F-35 formal training at Luke AFB, Arizona and Eglin AFB, Florida through Classic Associations. We also perform operational test and weapons instructor course missions at Nellis AFB, Nevada through a Classic Association. The experience of our Reserve pilots and maintainers in all aspects of 5th Generation fighter operations reduces costs, improves the experience of the Total Force, and improves the Regular Component. This is critical to meet the challenge from our pacing threat in a future fight.

Intelligence, Surveillance and Reconnaissance (ISR)

Our ISR enterprise is optimized to provide strategic depth and operational surge capacity in traditional and emerging mission sets. Currently the ISR enterprise supports missions in Targeting, Special Operations, Distributed Common Ground Station (DCGS), Signals Intelligence, Human Intelligence, Geospatial Intelligence, Measurement and Signatures Intelligence, Acquisition Intelligence, Combat Air Force support, Mobility Air Force support, Cyber, Space, and Combat Operations Squadrons (COSs). We continue to develop capabilities in areas to support the Joint Force while ensuring current mission sets provide decision advantage against pacing threats.

There are 4,400 ISR Reserve Airmen supporting every Air Force Major Command and all Functional and Geographic Combatant Command Intelligence Directorates. We are exploring mission growth with Air Combat Command and 16th Air Force to determine the way forward for the Air Force Reserve ISR Enterprise to be involved in synchronizing and integrating Information Warfare efforts into daily operations. There are also plans in place to have steady state Air Force Reserve ISR units available to the Global Force Mission Allocation Plan for the Regular Component to have additional access to our capabilities.

Rapid Global Mobility

Global power projection through Rapid Global Mobility hinges on a robust airlift enterprise and the extended range provided by a modern aerial refueling fleet. The

Air Force Reserve enables combat delivery through our strategic and tactical airlift fleets. We provide 65 percent of the total aircrews and 100 percent of student aircrew training capabilities for the C-5. The Air Force Reserve also provides 31 percent of aircrews for the C-17. Air Force Reserve's C-5 and C-130H fleets continue to face sustainment challenges due to aging aircraft, diminishing vendors, and increased part costs. Each of our mobility platforms require continued investment in modernization to ensure survivability in contested environments.

The Air Force Reserve air refueling fleet consists of seven unit equipped wings. In 2022, the 916th Air Refueling Wing, a Reserve unit stationed at Seymour Johnson AFB completed the conversion to the KC-46 and took possession of its twelfth and final aircraft.

Nuclear Deterrence Operations

Nuclear capability is foundational to national security. Our Nuclear Deterrence Operations assets include nuclear strike, air refueling, and nuclear command, control, and communications capabilities (NC3). To modernize our capabilities and maintain Total Force interoperability, we will equip all seven of our NC3 capable command posts with the new primary strategic communication system, the Global Aircrew Strategic Network Terminal, which will be fielded to units in FY 2024. This system will replace legacy terminals that are based on 1990s technology. The Air Force Reserve is also standing up the MH-139 Field Training Unit at Maxwell AFB as part of the 908th Airlift Wing mission conversion. It is postured to begin training in FY 2026. The MH-139 will enable increased Intercontinental Cruise Missile (ICBM) security.

Command and Control (C2)

Joint All-Domain Command and Control (JADC2) is the Department of Defense's top modernization priority. The Advanced Battle Management System (ABMS) is the Air Force's primary contribution to JADC2 as it provides the situational awareness and decision support tools to close hundreds of kill chains on relevant timelines in all domains—air, land, maritime, space, and cyber—while operating in a highly contested environment.

To assure strategic depth, the Air Force Reserve must maintain equipment parity to achieve enterprise mission optimization as the DAF fields new capabilities. This includes ensuring legacy platforms are equipped with ABMS capabilities to guarantee interoperability and lethality. The Air Force Reserve also provides non-material support for ABMS initiatives with C2 manpower. Investment in digital infrastructure and applications, along with modern air and space communication platforms, provides the foundation of C2 with the speed, adaptability, and resilience needed to achieve these objectives.

Cyberspace Operations

Integrating cyber capabilities enhances our ability to generate combat power but exposes us to new threats, as digital technology is both pervasive and inexpensive. The Air Force Reserve is exploring continued growth in cyber mission sets to counter persistent threat actors. We continue to posture our forces to better align with United States Cyber Command and Air Force Cyber requirements.

Special Operations Forces and Personnel Recovery

The Air Force Reserve has one wing dedicated to personnel recovery and another multi-mission special operations wing. Both wings operate in low-density, high-demand environments. As the Regular Component fields new platforms and realigns missions, we will continue to provide support across the spectrum of these no-fail missions. It is critical that Air Force Reserve units associated with Special Operations Forces and Personnel Recovery be proportionally recapitalized and concurrently fielded in the future.

Space Superiority

The establishment of the U.S. Space Force underscored the criticality of space operations to our national security. This point has been amplified by recent space weapons tests by our strategic competitors. The Air Force Reserve is a major contributor to space operations with 1,400 space operators in the Air Force Reserve. These personnel executed 26 percent of daily space missions directly supporting United States Space Command taskings. The Air Force Reserve will continue to provide focused support to the Space Force.

Equipment and Infrastructure

Credible strategic depth requires concurrent fielding of systems for Active and Reserve Components. Effective support to the Joint Force demands continuous up-

grades to legacy platforms to assure interoperability and combat effectiveness. Rapid technological advancement and the wide proliferation of digital technology have increased the tempo of strategic competition. These forces drive the need for continuous equipment modernization and equipment parity with the Active Component.

The Air Force Reserve must also be able to divest its obsolete legacy platforms. Deliberate divestment avoids gaps in critical capabilities and frees up resources for investment in capabilities to match pacing threats. Asynchronous airframe divestment can cause significant per platform sustainment cost growth due to diminishing vendors for spare parts. Further, it can also drive increased training costs as we are unable to hire qualified Regular Component members for obsolete legacy platforms.

Weapon System Modernization and Sustainment

Fully funding the Air Force Reserve FY 2024 Weapon System Sustainment (WSS) request is essential to bridging the concurrent fielding gap and maintaining parity with the Regular Component. As new systems are brought online to enhance the DAF's combat capabilities, both the Regular and Reserve components will continue to rely on proven platforms in our inventory. Aircraft modernization and system upgrades will provide capabilities needed for strategic competition by ensuring survivability in contested environments. A balanced portfolio of new and legacy platforms will achieve adequate wartime readiness. The WSS budget increase to \$186.8 million in FY 2024 will balance the portfolio. In addition to modernization, many of our airframes require upgrades, repairs, and component replacements to maintain airworthiness and extend service life. For example, to achieve adequate wartime readiness the FY 2024 budget provides increases in B-52, C-5M, C-130H, and WC-130J aircraft.

Infrastructure and Facilities

Maintaining and modernizing our infrastructure and facilities is critical to readiness, force protection, and ensuring a safe work environment for our Reserve Airmen. Military Construction (MILCON) appropriations fund new facilities and major infrastructure projects. The Facility Sustainment, Repair, and Modernization (FSRM) funds included in our Operations and Maintenance (O&M) appropriation are used to repair and modernize existing facilities and to extend the service life of existing infrastructure. While we work diligently to maximize use of existing facilities at our nine host installations and fifty-seven partner locations, we still have \$1.077 billion in MILCON projects and \$1 billion in validated FSRM projects in backlog. We are grateful to Congress for providing an additional \$49.3 million in MILCON funding and \$10 million in FSRM funding for FY 2023, for our most urgent projects.

During FY 2022, the Air Force Reserve utilized FSRM funding to make ongoing investments in airfield pavement sustainment and repair. FSRM funds are used to repair and modernize existing facilities to accommodate new missions such as the KC-135 Conversion at Niagara Falls Air Reserve Station (ARS), New York, F-35 bed-down at NAS JRB Fort Worth and KC-46 bed-down at March ARB. The Air Force Reserve FY 2024 MILCON funding request includes plans to replace a facility from 1942 at NAS JRB Fort Worth with a modern warehouse and three separate projects that will enable on-time delivery of KC-46 aircraft at March ARB. Finally, our Aerial Port Facility MILCON project request will replace an existing undersized facility at Andersen AFB, Guam and move port operations onto the flightline—enabling effective operations at a critical base in the Pacific.

AIR FORCE RESERVE'S ROLE IN TAKING CARE OF PEOPLE

Taking care of our Reserve Airmen and their families is critical. It begins the moment a member joins the Air Force Reserve and continues throughout their career. The Air Force Reserve does everything possible to support our Airmen as they balance their military career, civilian obligations, and family responsibilities. This assures the Air Force Reserve retains talented Airmen who can leverage diverse experience from their military service and civilian lives. The FY 2024 budget provides the support our Reserve Airmen need to be successful. This support includes suicide prevention through investments in resilience, social support through the Yellow Ribbon Reintegration Program, working to implement the recommendations from the Independent Review Commission (IRC) on Sexual Assault, and removing significant barriers to service through expansion of childcare programs.

Recruiting and Retention

Like the Regular Component of the Air Force, the Air Force Reserve did not meet its recruiting goal in FY 2022. The Air Force Reserve missed the Congressional mandated end-strength requirement of 70,300 by 2,252 personnel. The projections for FY 2023 indicate the Air Force Reserve will fall short of the Congressional end-strength of 70,000.

The recruiting environment continues to present significant challenges based on multiple factors to include a reduced propensity to serve, competitive civilian compensation and difficulty in medically clearing recruits. Along with the Chief of Staff of the Air Force and collective Total Force team, we have identified accession policies that limit our ability to recruit young adults to serve in the military. Three important changes include: revising the tattoo policy to allow for limited hand and neck tattoos; adjusting body fat standards to align with the other Services (increasing to 26% for males and 36% for females for accessions); and allowing members to join without a driver's license. The Air Force Reserve human capital strategy calls for 70% prior service (PS) and 30% non-prior service (NPS) recruiting mix but currently we are challenged on both fronts. The accession model is built on the expectation that there will be sufficient prior-service members leaving active duty who will affiliate with the Air Force Reserve. The Air Force Reserve strives to affiliate ready trained airmen. However, current trends indicate increased reliance on NPS recruits which increases training costs and dilutes unit experience. We are proactively increasing our targeted outreach efforts to connect with potential recruits, specifically focusing on members of the Regular Component. By expanding our reach, we aim to effectively communicate the benefits and opportunities available in the Air Force Reserve. The Air Force Reserve is also executing a plan of action to mitigate recruiting challenges with Reserve Component Affiliation Incentive Bonuses and a deliberate on-boarding process to increase recruiting production.

Increasing retention provides cost savings by decreasing training requirements. We are presently targeting retention through bonuses and special salary rates. A single \$15,000 retention bonus results in a cost avoidance of roughly \$45,000 in training funds and prevents an approximate three-year readiness gap, which occurs while a replacement is trained. In FY 2022, \$24–27 million was spent in reenlistment bonuses and Air Force Reserve primary retention tools. In FY 2023, the Air Force Reserve offered a \$10,000 bonus for enlisted members to fill vacant positions and a \$5,000 bonus for fully qualified members to fill an authorized overage. To address shortfalls in pilot manning, the Air Force Reserve has utilized an Aviation Bonus Program to stabilize both full-time and part-time manning.

Pilot Staffing

The Air Force Reserve provides a mechanism to retain talent by providing continued service options for members who separate from active duty. The DAF understands the importance of retaining experienced talent from both a cost-effectiveness and capacity perspective. During FY 2022, the Air Force Reserve had an 81 percent overall pilot staffing. This is a marked decline from FY 2021 when we experienced a high of 94 percent overall pilot staffing. Full-time pilot assigned manning decreased slightly from 990 at the beginning of FY 2022 to 981 at the beginning of FY 2023. During Calendar Year 2022, there was an unprecedented hiring effort by civilian airlines. This hiring has made full-time retention a challenge. For ART aviators, we offer recruitment, relocation, and retention incentives, which can equal up to 25 percent of annual base pay, and special salary rates which can equal up to 30 percent of annual base pay.

In FY 2022, we offered aviation bonuses up to \$35,000 for priority units at critical manning levels. Each of these measures has been implemented to retain significant investments in well-qualified pilots. While the overall Aviation Bonus Program cost increased from \$3 million in FY 2017 to \$31 million in FY 2022, this contributes to a cost avoidance of \$10 billion in replacing the over 3,600 pilots in the Air Force Reserve.

Training

Thanks to the FY 2023 increase in the Reserve Personnel Appropriation (RPA) budget, we were able to address the cost of training for NPS recruits. RPA execution for FY 2023 is showing a marked improvement as January's execution numbers were 29 percent, compared to the 22 percent 3-year average. The FY 2024 request was increased by \$13 million due to a 5.2 percent military pay raise, a 2.4 percent non-pay inflation adjustment, and 4.2 percent Basic Allowance for Housing increase.

To make a meaningful contribution to the DAF core functions, the Air Force Reserve maintains a focus on being Ready Now which requires the Air Force Reserve to have the capability to train Reserve Airmen. The FY 2024 budget provides the

Air Force Reserve the funds and flight hours to train our Airmen. The budget also allows the Air Force Reserve to work closely with Combatant Commands and gain joint experience in training events.

Accelerated Mission Readiness Training (AMRT) is crucial to developing technically proficient Airmen to provide a qualified force to Combatant Commanders. In FY 2023, nearly 46 percent of the enlisted personnel and 38 percent of the officers in the Air Force Reserve were NPS. This places a significant strain on readiness thresholds. Emerging threats and evolving requirements of building Multi-Capable Airmen requires a technically proficient force that cannot be achieved through Unit Training Assemblies and Annual Tour days alone. Without AMRT funds to accelerate training, the average NPS Reservist would need two-three years to become minimally proficient on mission requirements. With decreasing numbers of fully qualified members transferring from the Regular Component to the Reserve, there is an increased training burden upon the command. Without continued funding, the Air Force Reserve can expect to see a 20% decrease in qualified, deployable airmen, and an increase in excessive training times across all career fields.

The Yellow Ribbon Program

The Yellow Ribbon Reintegration Program is a vital resource for providing pre- and post-deployment education on mental health resources for Reservists and their families. Historically, the feedback for these events has been overwhelmingly positive, with 97 percent of attendees finding the events beneficial. After 2 years of disruption due to COVID-19, we have returned to in-person events which resulted in increased participation rates. The rising costs of travel and venue expenses has resulted in the Yellow Ribbon Program not being able to meet all attendance requests.

Childcare

Access to reliable and quality childcare is crucial to the retention of service members in the Air Force Reserve, as it directly alleviates a major stressor for those balancing service and family responsibilities, enhancing their ability to focus on their duties and increasing the likelihood of continued service. The Air Force Reserve has worked to ensure that childcare is available during training periods at no cost to parents

through the Home Community Care (HCC) program. Many of our Airmen have gaps in childcare due to being single parents or dual military couples. Airmen who do not have another adult to provide childcare during training periods are eligible for the program. The HCC program addresses gaps in coverage at host locations without Child Development Centers and at Regular Component host facilities without weekend childcare options. Currently, the HCC is available at 41 Air Force Reserve locations, and we are working to recruit more providers by zip code. This program is vital to retention, as 50 percent of Reservists cite family and work/life balance issues as their reason for separating during exit surveys.

Suicide Prevention

We remain firmly resolved to preventing suicide across our workforce. Our suicide prevention efforts are along four lines of effort: building connections, detecting risk, promoting protective environments, and developing resilient Airmen and families. We have placed Violence Prevention Integrators (VPIs) at each of our nine host base locations and NAS JRB Fort Worth, who are keenly focused on preventing interpersonal and self-directed violence.

In FY 2021, we completed the process of providing full-time Religious Support Teams (RSTs) consisting of a chaplain and chaplain's assistant at each of our nine host installations and NAS JRB Fort Worth. These RSTs fill a previously identified gap in care for Airmen and their families by providing spiritual support and liaising with helping agencies. In FY 2022, there was an increase from 757 to 1,571 counseling sessions provided per year, as well as an increase in religious services provided per year from 2,500 to over 7,000. In FY 2021, we hired 20 full-time First Sergeants to work directly with Airmen and their families to navigate support agencies. We anticipate being able to place full-time First Sergeants at each of our wing and wing-equivalent organizations by FY 2024.

Mental Health

Access to Mental Healthcare is a challenge facing our Nation. The Air Force Reserve promotes mental health through early intervention, identifying and supporting members at elevated risk and managing crisis response. While traditional reservists are not eligible for active duty benefits, there are reserve specific resources available to them. This includes 37 mental health providers in the Director of Psychological Health (DPH) Program, who have been embedded throughout the Reserve Wings to advise leadership. DPHs provide non-clinical services to reservists

and their families during unit training assemblies or during the week to include training and education, consultations, and referrals, needs assessments, suicide prevention, resiliency building, crisis intervention and command advisement on psychological and mental health issues. Reserve Airmen can also access the Military Family Life Consultants, who are licensed contract counselors that work outside of Military Treatment Facilities to provide anonymous and confidential assistance to all military members in problem solving issues resulting from deployment, reunions, reintegration, and/or other times of change. Finally, there is the AFRC Psychological Health Advocacy Program that provides psychological health referral services to Reserve Airmen and their families through telephone calls or site visits.

Sexual Assault Prevention and Response

We are working diligently with our Total Force partners to aggressively implement all the accepted recommendations from the Secretary of Defense's IRC on Sexual Assault and Sexual Harassment. We are working to recruit, retain, and develop our full-time prevention workforce to ensure our prevention footprint is optimized to meet the unique needs of Reservists. We will also continue increasing efforts to educate our force on prevention and local area resources for survivors. Based on the IRC's recommendations, our VPIs will focus on sexual assault prevention, allowing Sexual Assault Response Coordinators to focus exclusively on supporting survivors.

COVID-19 Vaccination Noncompliance

The FY 2023 National Defense Authorization Act (NDAA) was enacted requiring the Secretary of Defense to rescind the mandate that members of the Armed Forces must be vaccinated against COVID-19. I immediately issued a memorandum that stated COVID-19 Vaccination Status was not a barrier to service in the Air Force Reserve. Prior to the FY 2023 NDAA's enactment, the Air Force Reserve did not separate members for COVID-19 vaccination noncompliance, but rather utilized Individual Ready Reserve (IRR) reassignment actions. 547 members were consequently reassigned to the IRR for noncompliance with the vaccine requirements and this approach allows for a streamlined process for those members to return to duty.

Stability for Members

Our Reserve Airmen and their families need stability and predictability. Exit surveys suggest the high operations tempo and the demands of maintaining a work/life balance are the top reasons for leaving the Air Force Reserve. Without deliberate and planned deployments and training, Reservists are unable to adequately prepare their families and notify their civilian employers. The Air Force Reserve is working to provide members stability and predictability. This is done via AMRT funding which allows Reserve Units to offer predictable training timelines. AFFORGEN offers Reserve Airmen predictable deployment cycles. These efforts aid our Reserve Airmen when preparing for deployments and guarantees Air Force Reserve support to the DAF and Combatant Commands.

AIR FORCE'S ROLE IN SUCCEEDING THROUGH TEAMWORK

Teamwork for the Air Force Reserve begins within the DAF, where the Air Force Reserve provides an experienced and accessible surge capacity to the Regular Component of the U.S. Air Force and the U.S. Space Force. We work to maintain a Ready Now posture that can support almost every core function in the DAF. Maintaining this readiness and teamwork with the Regular Component and the Joint Force requires consistent training.

The Air Force Reserve is implementing training to develop Multi-Capable Airmen proficient in sustaining operations, hardening air bases, and recovering air bases following attack. The FY 2024 budget provides funds for training, ensuring our Reserve Airmen are Ready Now to support the Regular Component as well as the Joint Force. At several Air Reserve bases, we have developed organic training centers that provide Reserve Airmen the chance to train in Agile Combat Support (ACS) and Agile Combat Employment (ACE) requirements and hone their expeditionary skillsets. These centers also support the Regular Component, the Joint Force, Federal, and local agencies. At Westover ARB, Massachusetts, the Dogpatch Expeditionary Training Area was revitalized to offer an expeditionary airfield, as well as a drop zone and tactical vehicle training route. At Youngstown ARS, Ohio, we identified a training need for Security Forces Reserve Airmen.

This base established a site that provides a venue for Reserve Defenders to build proficiency and lethality through a 180-hour program of realistic training that simulates combat situations and prepares Security Forces members to deal with stress under fire. The training also prepares participants for ACE and ACS missions. The

site has been so successful that we are partnering with U.S. Army Reserve and U.S. Marine Corps Reserve to use the area for joint force training events. Civilian and Federal law enforcement have also used the Youngstown site for training. Finally, at Grissom ARB, Indiana, we developed bivouac sites to better rehearse ACS and ACE events and conduct deployment exercises. Thanks to funding from Congress, we can provide our Reserve Airmen the facilities to conduct realistic training while also working with the Regular Component, joint partners, Federal, and local agencies.

In addition to supporting the Regular Component in the DAF and global military operations, the Air Force Reserve expands its teamwork by partnering with and supporting multiple Federal and civil organizations. We routinely participate in humanitarian aid, disaster relief, and scientific research efforts. The Air Force Reserve provides direct support to civil authorities through the execution of Modular Aerial Spray System (MASS), Modular Airborne Firefighting System (MAFFS), and Weather Reconnaissance missions which utilize specially modified C-130 aircraft.

Modular Aerial Spray System

The 910th Airlift Wing's 757th Airlift Squadron (AS) from Youngstown ARS operates the Department of Defense's only aerial spray capability. In FY 2022, the 757 AS conducted 11 MASS missions treating 165,018 acres and applying 51,939 gallons of product. These missions control insect populations, eliminate undesired and invasive vegetation, and disperse oil spills in large bodies of water.

In FY 2022, acceptance testing of the first Electronic Modular Aerial Spray System (EMASS) was completed. It represents a decade-long acquisition project to insure the sustainability of the Aerial Spray program. EMASS provides additional capacity and more accurate calibration for precise application of products when compared to our aging legacy MASS.

Modular Airborne Firefighting System

The MAFFS is another specialty mission the Air Force Reserve supports, conducted by the 302d Airlift Wing (AW) from Peterson Space Force Base, Colorado. As the only Title 10 Aerial Firefighting asset available for direct tasking, the 302 AW's MAFFS mission supports U.S. Northern Command's Defense Support to Civil Authorities (DSCA) efforts and represents 25% of MAFFS assets in the DoD. The Air Force Reserve's MAFFS capability mobilized between 20 July and 29 September 2022 and represented 28% of 929 drops, 942.6 employment hours, and over 2.5 million gallons of retardant delivered during California wildfires. The 302 AW surged its MAFFS assets for 31 days, between 24 August and 23 September and provided 3 aircraft and 37.5% of total MAFFS efforts.

Weather Reconnaissance

The United States military has been flying into hurricanes since the Second World War. Today, the Air Force Reserve maintains the only operational military weather reconnaissance unit in the United States. The 53rd Weather Reconnaissance Squadron (WRS) is the only DoD unit that conducts aircraft reconnaissance missions into severe tropical weather during hurricane season and flies winter storm missions off both coasts of the United States. Flying out of Keesler AFB, Mississippi, the WC-130 operations improve forecast accuracy up to 30%, enabling commanders and civil authorities to make informed, fiscally responsible decisions to protect personnel and assets during extreme weather events year-round. Mission modernization and resourcing is essential to this expanding mission set that supports our military and civilian population across the United States.

In FY 2022, the 53 WRS flew 141 missions with flight hours at the third highest in the past eight fiscal years (1,160 hours). This included 310 hours in support of 21 West Coast Atmospheric River requirements and 35 hours supporting East and Gulf Coast requirements. The Atmospheric River mission capability released 825 dropsondes over 39 intense observation periods, resulting in a 30–75% forecast improvement across the US, translating to an additional 72 hours of lead time for decision makers. The 53 WRS also flew 815 hours of hurricane reconnaissance across 7 storms in the Atlantic, Caribbean, Gulf of Mexico, and East Pacific Ocean, supporting 112 lead Federal agency (LFA) requirements and safeguarding of forces throughout the Western hemisphere. Since the beginning of FY 2023, the 53 WRS flew 468 hours into four storms supporting 54 LFA requirements.

Mission modernization and resourcing is essential to the expanding weather reconnaissance mission sets that support our military and civilian population across the United States. The Weapons Systems Sustainment allocated to the Air Force Reserve allowed for several hardware and software upgrades some of which are still in progress. With funding from Congress in the FY 2024 budget, the Air Force Reserve can continue supporting critical weather reconnaissance as well as aerial

spray and aerial firefighting missions, ensuring that the Air Force Reserve can defend and protect the Nation through teamwork with the Regular Component, the Joint Force, as well as Federal, state, and local agencies.

SUMMARY

Our FY 2024 budget request is carefully crafted to ensure interoperability with the Regular Component and the Joint Force. The request will maintain Air Force Reserve readiness to support our allies and partners around the world. This request will continue weapon system modernization, positioning our force to be more capable, survivable, and lethal while also enhancing support to our Reserve Airmen and their families. In an era of strategic competition and increased resource constraints, we will continue to provide strategic depth and operational surge capacity to meet pacing threats in the most cost-effective manner possible. Reserve Airmen will continue to leverage their unique blend of military and civilian experience to bring outsized impact to pursuing the DAF's Operational Imperatives. For this to occur, we need to take care of our Airmen and the FY 2024 PB request allows the Air Force Reserve to do that. With your continued support, we are confident the Air Force Reserve will remain prepared to deliver effects anytime, anywhere to fly, fight, and win in Air, Space, and Cyberspace.

Senator TESTER. Thank you, General. I want to thank you all for your statements. Appreciate it very, very much. I am going to start out with a story that has been well documented over the last 2 or 3 months.

It is about a 21-year-old Air Guardsman that posted highly classified documents on the Internet, including intel about the war in Ukraine. I can tell you, I don't know anybody that can tell me why this person had access to this particular classified information, but it is troublesome, and I don't think it gives the Air National Guard a particularly good look.

So, General HOKANSON, what can you tell me about the status of the investigation?

General HOKANSON. Chairman, thank you for the question. With respect to the Airmen of the Massachusetts National Guard, the Secretary of the Air Force has initiated an IG (Inspector General) investigation, which is just about to complete, and we look forward to the results soon.

Any and all recommendations they make will obviously be implemented immediately. With respect to the individual, it is an ongoing FBI (Federal Bureau of Investigation) investigation, and we look forward to the results of that investigation.

Senator TESTER. So, I think we need to learn from the past as we move forward in the future. How confident are you that with the IG information, with the information, you know, and the people that you have talked to, that this kind of situation will never happen again?

General HOKANSON. Chairman I am very confident this will never happen again based on what we have found. Unfortunately, we have been doing this for a long period of time. A lot of personnel, a lot of units are doing this.

This one individual was an individual action and not indicative of the entire system. But we are looking at safeguards that we can put in place that would prevent any individual in the future from ever being able to do this.

Senator TESTER. Ultimately, this person didn't do it without somebody above him knowing what was going on. Are the people that allowed this to happen being held accountable to?

General HOKANSON. Yes, Chairman. They have removed some folks temporarily in light of the investigation. Based on the results of the investigation, not only active Air Force or if it applies to the National Guard, we will take appropriate action against those individuals.

Senator TESTER. Okay. A couple of the presenters talked about the NGREA account. Just for a point of reference, Congress has appropriated \$2.9 billion over the last 3 years. And by the way, this was a Congressional add to make sure that the Guard and Reserves have the equipment they need, modern equipment that is ready when you are called upon.

And I think it is important we plan for how utilize this money and so that the taxpayer gets the biggest bang for the buck. At the end of March, basically half the money had been spent.

As I said, I think it is important to plan, but I think your needs are great—I don't think anybody would dismiss that. For all of you, and be as brief as possible, why does it seem, at least seem to me that it has taken so long to get this money out the door to actually get the equipment you need? Whoever wants to start can. It doesn't matter.

General HOKANSON. Chairman, on behalf of the National Guard, we program to get about a 99 to 100 percent execution of all our NGREA funding. And as you mentioned, it is absolutely critical to modernization and also for some of our dual use of equipment. Unfortunately, what we have found is some of the supply chain issues has delayed the delivery of some of those goods, but we are on track to spend all of that money.

Senator TESTER. Anybody else want to comment? Go ahead. General Daniels, go ahead.

General DANIELS. So similar to the National Guard, we take a very hard look at what equipping lines are open, what critical dual use capabilities are prioritized at the top of the list.

Sometimes we cannot get access to that equipment in the sequence that we would like to get it, but we do monitor a lengthy list of requirements and make sure that we spend those funds judiciously across the 3 years that we have the funds available to us.

Senator TESTER. Admiral.

Admiral MUSTIN. Comment was going to be very similar in that with the 3-year look, we phase out the expenditures. There is pressure in a CR (Continuing Resolution) environment, however, for new starts or new contracts, which has delayed in some cases what we had intended to originally buy. So, we will probably address that topic at a later moment, but CRs certainly have an impact on us.

Senator TESTER. General.

General BELLON. Yes, sir. For us, the biggest delay this year was the fact that we wanted to reroll some of the money you had already approved and your staff, some of who are sitting here, helped us with that. We are going to be 100 percent committed this year. And as a good teammate, if there is any leftover, we will spend that too.

Senator TESTER. General Healy.

General HEALY. Sir, the same. The CR does impact our ability to get a start with it. But once we do get started, the money does

flow through our proportional multi-year plan of implementation. We plan to fully execute.

Senator TESTER. Thank you. I have got about 20 seconds left. General Hokanson, you talked about 25 flying missions within the Guard. You needed every one of them, I believe, is what you said. A-10s are going away and they should go away. How many missions does that impact?

General HOKANSON. Mr. Chairman, specific to the A-10s, we have three squadrons, and all three would convert to a more current aircraft, either F-35, F-15EX, or one of the, what is called a post block F-16, our newest ones.

Senator TESTER. Okay. So, there are plans for every A-10 mission that goes away in the Guard to replace them with another fighter mission?

General HOKANSON. Yes, sir. That is the plan that we are working with the U.S. Air Force on. And we believe through fleet leveling, and by current scheduled aircraft buys or any additional, we could provide the ability to do that.

Senator TESTER. Okay. Senator Collins.

Senator COLLINS. Thank you, Mr. Chairman. I want to follow up on the important issue you just raised since we have heard our witnesses talk about the need to recapitalize the aircraft fleet. General Healy, I understand that more than three quarters of the 25 Air Guard fighter squadrons operate legacy F-15 fighter aircraft.

That obviously reduces interoperability and compatibility with the active-duty units. The disproportionate fielding of the aircraft affects other units as well, such as the air refueling wing in my home State of Maine.

My understanding is that the current KC-46A basing plan places 71 percent of the new KC-46 with active units, 14 percent with Reserve units, and 15 percent with Guard units, even though the Guard flies almost 38 percent of all Air Force tankers.

So, it seems disproportionate to me if only 15 percent of the new aircraft is going to the Guard, if the Guard is flying 38 percent of all Air Force tankers. Should new aircraft be fielded in a manner that is proportional to the Guard's operational contributions?

General HEALY. Ma'am, I agree 100 percent that it appears disproportionate right now. 77 percent of the Air Force Reserve fleet is legacy. And in the words of the Secretary of the Air Force, legacy is defined as does not concern the PRC (People's Republic of China) in a fight. KC-135s, C-130Hs, pre-block F-16s, A-10 divestment are all issues and concerns for the Air Force Reserve in terms of proportionality.

The National Commission on the Structure of the Air Force in 2014 called for and recommended proportional and concurrent fielding of weapon systems with the Guard and Reserve in association with the active component, and we are constantly advocating adherence to that recommendation.

As weapon systems are upgraded and recapitalized in the active component, if the Guard and Reserve, and specifically my concern, the Reserve are not proportionally recapitalized, we will ultimately lack the capacity and the capability to participate in that near-peer fight if we are still flying in 37-year-old aircraft, pre-block F-16s.

Whether it is the F-16s to the F-35, one for one, KC-135 to the KC-46, or any of the bombers for the B-21 family systems, we are looking to contribute and we want to be that surge capacity that we provided for the last 75 years.

Senator COLLINS. Thank you very much. General Hokanson, I want to follow up on the Chairman's questions to you about the Massachusetts Air National Guard member who has been accused of leaking classified documents.

What was most disturbing to me was when I learned through some of the court filings that there was an Air Force memorandum that indicated that he had been repeatedly warned. So, this was not a deviation that came out of the blue.

But in fact, he had been reprimanded and he had been instructed to, "stop any deep dives into classified intelligence information" and focus on his job. He "had been observed taking notes on classified intelligence materials."

These reports are very concerning because it appears that this serious breach might have been prevented or stopped much sooner if the Airman's Guard unit had taken greater action to restrict his access to classified information.

My question is, what is the standard practice when someone has been reprimanded for misuse of classified information and then does it again? That to me shouldn't require an IG report. That should be on the books now, I think.

General HOKANSON. Yes, Senator. I found this extremely concerning as well. Any time there is a disciplinary action, the chain of command should address it immediately.

I know it is not specifically the IG investigation that is looking at it, but also the FBI investigation that is looking at that to determine if there was negligence within the airman's chain of command at the time he was mobilized under Title 10 working for a Combatant Commander.

And we were looking at very closely the chain of command who is responsible for that. And if there was negligence on their part, it will be addressed immediately.

Senator COLLINS. Thank you.

Senator TESTER. Senator Shaheen.

Senator SHAHEEN. Thank you, Mr. Chairman. Good morning, everyone. Thank you all for being here. As the co-chair of the National Guard Caucus, I am especially appreciative of hearing your concerns this morning.

General Hokanson, I want to start with you, and I think you may wish to weigh in as well, General Healy, but in your opening statement, you talked about the readiness concerns, and you mentioned specifically the fighter squadrons.

But I am—with the 157th Air Refueling Wing in New Hampshire at Pease Air Force Base, I am very concerned about the status of those KC-46 units, both the fact that we still don't have all of them flying the way they were commissioned to fly, but also what we have seen at the 157th is that they have face cuts to their personnel, placing them about 5 percent below the national average.

While I recognize that you faced constraints, and you all talked about that, I am very concerned that we have got these aircraft sitting in New Hampshire and I know they are being used, but it

doesn't feel like they are being used to their full extent because of those personnel constraints.

So, can you talk about how you expect to resolve some of those issues? And I understand you are conducting a manning study for the KC-46. So, when do you expect the results of that study, and do you have any insights into what that is going to show?

General HOKANSON. Yes, Senator. And you bring up a great organization. In fact, I believe that refueling unit just set a world record for the longest continuous flight of an aerial refueling. So, it is a great——

Senator SHAHEEN. We are very proud of them.

General HOKANSON. Yes, ma'am. It is a great organization. And when we look across the entire Air National Guard, as I am sure the Air Force Reserve does as well, if we have any positions that are in excess of our authorized end strength, we need to account for those.

Now, the personnel actions were not specific to the 157th, but really holistically at all of our Guard units. But because you are the first of our KC-46 units, we are evaluating it on an annual basis to make sure that we have the right number of personnel in the right positions so that we can fully leverage the capability of that system.

And so, this is a temporary measure, ma'am, to keep in touch with what we are authorized, but as we review this and identify additional capabilities, we will reallocate the manpower to fill those shortages.

Senator SHAHEEN. But it has been temporary now for several years.

General HOKANSON. Yes, ma'am. And that is, as we have mentioned before, our end strengths have reduced in some cases, and so we have got to look across the entire Air National Guard to identify where that personnel savings could come from.

Senator SHAHEEN. And so, do you have any insights from the staffing study for the KC-46? Do we know what that might recommend?

General HOKANSON. I am not aware of that right now, ma'am, but I can follow up with our staff on the exact specifics of that study.

Senator SHAHEEN. General Healy, do you have any additions to that?

General HEALY. With the Reserve KC-46 units, we are currently in Seymour Johnson in North Carolina, and we have seen great results in terms of coming up to speed and delivering on schedule.

I know that the Air Force, the Air Mobility Command, is holding the manufacturers to task to ensure that we are releasing all the capabilities as fast as they are able and to recover the capabilities that weren't initially produced the way they should be.

We are very much looking forward to deliveries to March Air Reserve Base on California next, and expect by then, with the first aircraft delivery in 2026, we expect to see a fully capable KC-46.

Senator SHAHEEN. How many years late?

General HEALY [continuing]. yes, ma'am——

Senator SHAHEEN. I appreciate that, but I think it is a message to Boeing to do better in the future as well. General Daniels, you

mentioned the importance of childcare in your opening statement, and I think that is very critical that we think about how important that is.

We have an interesting cooperative effort between the Portsmouth Naval Shipyard and the Air National Guard in New Hampshire to do a joint childcare center that they would share. But can you speak to why that is so important to the Guard?

General DANIELS. Yes, ma'am. My challenge is that I have got 850 Army Reserve centers sprinkled across the United States, most of which are not within a 50-mile radius of a major installation.

Therefore, they are out in communities, and historically, we have challenges finding weekend care. We just can't find the providers that are willing to work on weekends. So, we have done a number of different pilot activities over the past year and that is still our challenge.

We found a couple of organizations we think we are going to make some inroads with to help us have that weekend opportunity.

Senator SHAHEEN. Well, thank you. I look forward to hearing more about what you have learned and seeing how this committee can be supportive of that.

I am out of time, but General Hokanson, I just wanted to go to your first priority for how the Guard gets integrated into the Space Force, because I think that is a very real concern. I have asked General Saltzman about that issue on several occasions, and the ambiguous response has not been reassuring.

So, I hope that we can continue to work with you on how that gets done. Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

Senator TESTER. Thank you, Senator Shaheen. From the beautiful Sunflower State, Senator Moran.

Senator MORAN. Thank you, Chairman. I have always known you to tell the truth, at least on some occasions. Thank you, all of you, for being here. Thank you for your service to our Nation. I understand and appreciate the crucial role that the National Guard and Reserve play, our components play in our military.

Disaster at home, around the world, you are there and a great asset to the well-being and National Security of our country. General Hokanson, to follow up on Senator Shaheen's beginning conversation about the space mission. When General Saltzman was in front of this committee, I asked him about the creation of a Space National Guard.

He testified that his best military advice supported the most cost-effective alternative that preserves operational capabilities. In your best military advice on creation of a Space National Guard, how would you answer that request from General Saltzman?

General HOKANSON. Senator Moran, thank you for the question. And I would argue that the comments that the Chief of Space Operations made describe exactly the Air National Guard units performing the space mission.

From my best military advice, when I look at the fact that we have been doing this mission for over 28 years, in some cases, we are the only ones that ever have done those missions. We have got 14 units of about 1,000 people. We are about 30 percent of the operational squadrons today.

And to me, my greatest concern is readiness to the force. And by simply redesignating those Air Guard units performing the space mission to a Space Guard type organization, I could do that within the resources that I currently have in my budget, and it would simply be from one drill weekend to the next, where our Airmen would change their name tape from Air Force to Space Force.

And at no time would it interrupt the capabilities they provide to our Nation. The personnel would stay in the same place, same civilian jobs, doing the same mission that they are doing every single day today. In fact, some of them are deployed right now providing that support to our Nation.

My concern is, if we looked at reestablishing them in another component, it could cost our Nation about \$1 billion. And that is not only to restructure and rebuild this within a different component, but then also the need to retrain those current Air Guard members that are performing the mission into another mission set.

And overall, when you look at this, it is a, I think, a very easy decision.

Senator MORAN. Thank you, sir. I was going to ask you about the cost to stand up a National Guard component, and perhaps you have answered that, but I would give you the chance to in a sentence to make that clear.

General HOKANSON. Yes, sir. So, we look at the cost of about \$640 million to re-mission what currently exists into a future type organization. But the concern that we have is right now the Air National Guard space units are the only unit equipped surge to war capability.

Our Air Force Reserve counterparts that are being incorporated in the Space Force are primarily individual fillers, whereas the National Guard is actually manned, trained, and equipped units.

The concern there, as well as when you look at the 28 years of experience that we have, to replicate that or to reconstitute it, it may take 7 to 10 years to get those folks through schools and trained, and I don't think our Nation can afford to see that reduction in readiness over that time period.

Senator MORAN. Thank you, sir. General Daniels, would you elaborate on the significance of the National Guard Reserve equipment account to the U.S. Army's Reserves mission?

General DANIELS. Thank you for that. It is vital to my ability to modernize. The Army has focused on lethality and modernizing its lethality elements over the last several years and looking forward to the 2030, 2040 future battles.

The Army Reserve is primarily combat support and service support, and therefore our modernization efforts have lagged behind those of the lethality elements. And so, the NGRE account supports about 35 to 40 percent of my ability to modernize, in terms of raw dollar value.

Senator MORAN. Thank you. General Hokanson, you and I have had a conversation. I appreciate what you told me. I have a goal of seeing that the STARBASE Program is expanded in Kansas.

STEM (Science, Technology, Engineering, and Mathematics) education is hugely important to the National Security and economic well-being of our Nation. STARBASE, which I have visited on several occasions, is very compelling in its mission and having success,

but we have parts of the State, particularly those that are the most rural, that are underserved or unserved, and I appreciate your willingness to work with me to see that we change that circumstance.

And General Bellon, we appreciate your service to the Nation. I thank you for your testimony today but thank you for the years you have spent in duty to country. And all Kansans, and particularly those who share your alma mater, are particularly honored by that service.

Senator TESTER. Senator Baldwin.

Senator BALDWIN. Thank you, Mr. Chairman. Thank you to all of our witnesses this morning. General Hokanson, you have listed healthcare for the National Guard force as a command priority. Like you, I believe that increasing access to healthcare and dental care for our Guard and Reserves service members would pay dividends in readiness, especially for short notice deployments.

Last Congress, I introduced the Health Care for Our Troops Act, a bill that would provide all National Guard and Reserve service members premium free healthcare coverage. Can you please describe the impact of this proposal, what sort of impact it would have on increasing the readiness of the total force?

General HOKANSON. Thank you, Senator. And I think you hit it right on the head. The premium free healthcare and dental care as well are critically important. And having been through multiple deployments, one of the biggest things that we see addressing—to address and readiness is medical and dental readiness for our personnel to go.

In fact, I would say that is the largest thing that impacts our readiness. And so having that ability so that every Guardsmen and reservists that is in uniform, is serving that has that ability to get preventative care or care when they need that, and the same with dental care, will ensure their medical readiness.

And we look at the investment that we put in our individuals in terms of the training and the time that goes into it, and not only that, but their investment and their time away from their families and employers—to me, this is the best way to ensure that when we make that call, they are ready to go to answer whatever our Nation needs them to do.

Senator BALDWIN. Thank you. General Hokanson, last month, the F-35 aircraft started to arrive at Truax Field in Madison, Wisconsin, entrusting the Wisconsin Air National Guard with a critical capability for our Nation's defense.

I have a couple of questions about that basing. The unit supports a significant number of jobs. What are the economic benefits for the local community that we can anticipate from hosting the F-35 fighter wing?

General HOKANSON. So ma'am, first and foremost, just the community there that established such a fantastic unit obviously came out through the Air Force basing process.

The benefits there is aerial ranges, there is gunnery ranges, there is aerial refueling units nearby, and there is airspace, which made that just a great choice. But when you look at the community now, you have a State-of-the-art aircraft that is going to be there for decades.

And the number of folks that are employees and are going to be there to support that unit are going to make a huge difference to the local community. And frankly, having been there, just the coordination between the unit and the local community makes a huge difference.

Senator BALDWIN. Yes. While I am very grateful that my home State is making a significant contribution to National Security, I would say that neighbors proximate to the airport are concerned about the impact of increased noise in the area surrounding the airport.

I helped secure resources in a previous appropriations bill to help us start planning for noise mitigation activities. Can you please elaborate on efforts the National Guard is taking to help with this planning and to engage the local communities that will be impacted by the noise?

General HOKANSON. Yes, Senator. So, the key there is for us to work with the FAA (Federal Aviation Administration) and also the unit. And as we get the aircraft, and to identify those areas where we can reduce noise, and this may affect the approach patterns that they use or the type of approaches into the airport, also their departures.

And also working with the air crews to identify the areas where they can reduce noise. And then also make the communities aware of grants or resources available to them to help reduce the noise locally.

Senator BALDWIN. And are these activities well underway?

General HOKANSON. Yes, ma'am. As we get more aircraft and I look forward to being out there September 7th for the welcome ceremony. But I think as we go on, they are going to definitely want to be good neighbors with the community there because they are great supporters of that organization.

Senator BALDWIN. Thank you.

Senator TESTER. Senator Boozman.

Senator BOOZMAN. Thank you, Mr. Chairman. And thank you all for being here. We appreciate your service. I always enjoy getting to visit with you when we talk about military construction.

And we appreciate your service, and as always, we appreciate your families. This is certainly a family affair, and again, all that you represent. General Daniels, one key element of funding for the Reserve component is the funded Reimbursable Authority.

Each year, this committee authorizes this funding authority for military intelligence activities in support of Combatant Commands and defense agencies. Can you speak to the importance of this authority?

And if you believe funded reimbursable authority should be expanded to other high demand skills such as cyber and space activities?

General DANIELS. Yes, thank you. The funded reimbursable authority allows the Combatant Commands to use their operational funds to bring on and pay for reservists. It is done in a voluntary manner, and it allows them to have additional capacity for those folks who are available and willing and capable of using their civilian skill sets and their military trained skill sets to support the requirements within the Combatant Commands.

Expanding beyond intelligence to those other key technical areas would be of great value to the commands, and it allows the individuals to again use those civilian and military acquired skills and be very expert and facile in those areas. So, expansion would certainly be welcomed.

Senator BOOZMAN. Thank you very much. Duty status reform is an initiative that seeks to streamline and simplify the activation and utilization of Reserve component members.

Efforts to consolidate this burdensome duty status system has gone on for almost 3 decades, which I know has been frustrating for our servicemembers.

Can you all just kind of jump in, and if you would, briefly discuss how consolidating this system would positively impact servicemembers and their families and increase retention? How can Congress be more helpful in getting this effort?

Again, this is something we have talked about forever, but with the situation that we are in now with retention and this and that, it is more important than ever.

General HOKANSON. Senator, I will start out. When we look at the 28 different duty statuses, the ability under duty status reform to reduce these to about 8 really simplifies how we would mobilize and utilize our Guardsmen and Reservists. But the biggest thing that we have a concern is we just want equal pay for what we do.

We want either Guardsmen or Reservists to be treated exactly the same as their active-duty counterparts if they are doing the same mission at the same location at any time. The last thing we want is two Soldiers or Airmen, or Sailors and Marines to be standing next door to each other, and one is getting a benefit that the other one isn't.

And so, this goes a long way to resolve that and really address some issues that have long gone neglected.

Senator BOOZMAN. Very good. Anybody else?

General DANIELS. Yes, we would fully endorse being able to have that passed into law to help us not only to have, you know, equal pay and equal entitlements for those same activities, but also to remove the administrative burden of knowing which is the right pay status to put someone in and simplifying the entire process for everyone that is involved. That would be of great value and time savings as well.

Senator BOOZMAN. Very good. General Bellon, as we all know, every service has encountered challenges with meeting their recruiting goals. What has the Marine Corps Reserve done to meet your specific goals and are there specific examples you can provide that will help this committee better understand how we can help all the services going forward?

General BELLON. Well, I think, sir, for this year, I think we are the only one that came close to meeting the goal. But our requirement is smaller, so let me frame that, and our population we are recruiting a slightly different. But I don't think we should draw their own conclusions.

I would say we were successful this year, but as you know, sir, the Commandant of the Marine Corps, the Secretary of the Navy, and the Assistant Commandant all have testified that the future

end strength of the Marine Corps Reserve is going to be back at 37,000. We are at 33,000 today.

That has to happen by the end of the decade. And as I look at where we are now, the trends in society, I have questions about how we are going to do that. So, one of the things we are doing is proactively looking at reestablishing capacity where the population is and will be. By that I mean some of our drill centers are located where the population was in the 50s, not where it is and will be.

So, there are a number of things we are doing, but a big part of it is simply proving to the American people that service is honorable and worthwhile. And as you know, the trends are not good in that direction, and I don't see that as a bad thing. Should we not have to prove to our citizens occasionally that the Nation is worth defending? Absolutely.

Senator BOOZMAN. Right. Very good. Thank you all. Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

Senator TESTER. Senator Hoeven.

Senator HOEVEN. Thanks. Just picking up on that, General, how do you do that? How do you convince them that, you know, that they should want to step up and serve?

General BELLON. Well, I had a vignette earlier where I worked with your staff. We had a need that emerged, a very fast need for literal craft capability.

At the same time, we were looking at sundowning a couple of units that were very healthy in Florida and Texas. And the demonstration, by working with this committee, and the staff, and Congress in General, to find the right authorities to move at the speed of relevance, took two units whose re-enlistment rates were going down because they saw no future in service, and now they are among the top of all of my formations.

And all they needed was a demonstration from us that we value the service, and we are going to give them the tools and equipment they need to be ready when the Nation needs them. So that is an example of what we can do.

But I also think days like this where we have open testimony, and we demonstrate an open conversation that we are trying to find ways to reestablish some of the faith and confidence we might have lost over the previous years.

Senator HOEVEN. I would add a recruiting tool that I think is incredibly important and has great utility, not only for the services and not only for the individuals while they serve with you, but for their future as well, and that is the Federal tuition assistance program. And I would like each of you to weigh in on that.

And I want to start with you, General Hokanson, because we put together and funded a pilot program through this committee, and that Air National Guard Reserve pilot program is incredibly important not only to recruit those individuals in, but to keep them. And there is a difference between the services, and there is a difference between active duty, and Guard, and Reserves.

And I think we need to beef that thing up right now. It won't only help pull people in. It will help keep them in and it will make them better, Soldiers, Airmen, Marines, you name it for all of you, and I would like to hear from each one of you on that.

General HOKANSON. Yes, Senator. It is a great program. And when I visit the 54, when I always talk to our recruiters and I ask them, what are those things why people still come in, and education is still one of those consistent things.

And we have been fortunate, and we look across the entire National Guard, all of them but Guam, the State helps provide tuition assistance so that we have that stability throughout the process.

Unfortunately, we had to balance sometimes with the fiscal year and the academic year to fully utilize that funding, but any time we have the ability to utilize that not only for tuition assistance but also for tuition payback, and then also retention bonuses, will make a huge impact.

Senator HOEVEN. Do you agree we should make it a priority to get that in place and strengthen it as a tool for recruitment and retention?

General HOKANSON. Yes, sir. Education. Any benefits we can provide to them is always a benefit when it comes to recruiting.

Senator HOEVEN. Thank you. And I will come back to General Bellon and ask the same of the others.

General BELLON. Briefly, I want to offer this context. Less than 1 percent volunteer. So, who are they? They have a call to service already. So, anything we can do to invest in them has an amazing return on investment. From a citizen's perspective, they are self-motivated. They already have a call to service. Why wouldn't we invest in them?

Senator HOEVEN. And particularly if they enlist the Marine Corps, right? Not easy duty. General.

General DANIELS. So, the Army Reserve used about \$25 million of tuition assistance in 2022, and then \$31 million this year.

And we put in a request for about \$33 million next year. It is a growing—and its credentialing assistance is another fund that we use simultaneously. It is super important for our members to become more and more educated along with our—not just only our enlisted, but our warrants as well.

They leverage the credentialing assistance quite a bit. So, this is vital for us to keep them on the cutting edge of their technical experience for their civilian careers and then to be ahead of their peers. So, it is super important.

Senator HOEVEN. Admiral.

Admiral MUSTIN. It is a winning program, and we recognize the impact both on recruiting, which is obvious in that we can offer this incentive. Secondly, we continue to, like Lieutenant General Daniels, to invest within the Navy Reserve for selected Reserve tuition assistance as a new program, also recognizing the benefit that provides to our Sailors.

The Navy is a very technical force. That education benefits the individual, but it is a selfish interest on my part as well to ensure that our Sailors are trained and ready to perform when we need them.

Senator HOEVEN. Right. I mean, I have been waiting to hear some of you lob that in. I mean, you are becoming so technologically sophisticated, every one of you, that they need that ongoing education to handle all the amazing systems that you have, and we are developing.

Admiral MUSTIN. Absolutely, Senator. I would say that in the past we used to say, hey, we are competing for the same resources to recruit against the Marine Corps, or the Air Force, or the Army. Now, I tell people we are competing with Amazon, Google, Meta, and others. It is a very technical—out there.

Senator HOEVEN. Absolutely. General.

General HEALY. You know, the Navy beat me to the punch on that one. The Air Force is absolutely a very technical field, every one of them—

Senator HOEVEN. Yes, absolutely.

General HEALY [continuing]. And the \$4,500 a year that we spend, and tuition assistance absolutely directly impacts our ability to recruit and retain.

Senator HOEVEN. Tester and I have to get old pickup trucks because the technologies on the new one, we can't figure out, so.

Senator TESTER. 100 percent correct.

Senator HOEVEN. Thank you, Mr. Chair.

Senator TESTER. Senator Murkowski.

Senator MURKOWSKI. Thank you, Mr. Chairman. And thank you all. Thank you for your service. Thank you, certainly on behalf of the State of Alaska. We certainly appreciate our Reserve and our National Guard servicemembers and civilians. They provide extraordinary support to us in the State and certainly to the country.

We have got continued success that we see with innovation, readiness, training, IRT (Innovative Readiness Training), certainly when it comes to homeland defense, missile defense, absent key air refueling, combat search and rescue, strategic airlift, there is just so much.

And so, we are very grateful. I am very, very proud of the Guard and Reserve men and women who serve us and provide such benefit. I also am thankful for the cost savings that you bring to all of the effort here, so.

General Hokanson, we had an opportunity yesterday to visit about some of the more specific concerns that you and I had shared, but we have discussed previously the issue of the Space Force and the mission there of the Air Guards, 213th Space Warning Squadron at Clear Air Force Base.

They have been doing extraordinary work there with the ground-based radar missile warning mission since 2006 now. We are seeing Space Force becoming more mature. That is good. But I have been concerned that there hasn't really been a clearly articulated or perhaps an adequate plan to ensure that these Airmen and their mission are cared for in a way that works going forward with the Space Force. I fear that they may miss out on opportunities, or education, or equipment.

I understand that prior to my arrival at committee here, you did address a question regarding Space Force to Senator Moran. I appreciate that. I don't know if you want to add anything further to that in terms of your opinion on the establishment of the Space National Guard to really ensure that these Guardians are equipped and trained for the mission set that they clearly are in the front on.

General HOKANSON. Yes, Senator. And as clear as you mentioned, this goes back to once again the years and years of experi-

ence that our Airmen have doing this mission set and just the incredible capability they provide our Nation each and every day. And as you mentioned, we are the only unit equipped, surged go to war capability that exist within the Reserve component for the space mission.

And so having a clear pathway for them will not only help with our current recruiting, but it will also ensure that all of those years of experience, all the work that they have done, and frankly, the ability of our Guardsmen to bring—over half of them have backgrounds in technical or high tech or aerospace industries.

They bring that knowledge base to work with them when they come to drill. And, you know, we rely on them to deploy around the globe and continue to do their mission. So, anything and everything we can do to retain them.

And as I mentioned earlier, my best military advice to reduce any impact at all to readiness or the ability to field these unit would be to transfer the current Air National Guard units doing the space mission into a National Guard component for the Space Force so they can continue everything they are doing today, tomorrow.

Senator MURKOWSKI. Thank you for just clarifying that and putting that on the record. I appreciate it. I would like to direct a question to you, General Healy. I think, fair to say that we are both pretty proud of the 477th Fighter Group, U.S. Air Force's oldest, most experienced F-22 unit in the inventory.

I think they have produced some pretty qualified fighter pilots. You had mentioned in your testimony the term concurrent and proportional fielding that allows the Air Force Reserve to incorporate new aircraft at the same rate and proportion as their active-duty components.

How will the current—excuse me, concurrent and proportional fielding affect units like the 477th, especially as we are looking to the new airframes coming on such as the next generation air dominance and the E-7s?

General HEALY. Thanks very much for the question, ma'am. And I don't know who wants to brag more on the 477th. I have had the great opportunity to go twice this year up to Anchorage to visit them.

Simply put, twice the F-22 fighter experience than their active-duty counterparts, three times the fighter time experience in their active-duty fighter time—or active-duty counterparts, makes them the most experienced F-22 unit in the entire Air Force, and they are exactly where they need to be, at the forefront of the defense of the country.

They are the tip of that tip of the spear that Alaska provides. I think as we look towards the future and possible recapitalization from F-22s and to the possibility of next generation air dominance, I think that air superiority experience and 5th gen aircraft will translate perfectly and would be the template to go by, if we were to look at the current proportional servicing of and progression to the NGAD (Next-Generation Air Dominance) family of systems.

Likewise, with the E7, the experience, both with the Guard in Alaska and the Reserves in the continuous States, allows us to provide that same degree of expertise and experience moving forward.

Senator MURKOWSKI. Yes, thank you. Mr. Chairman, I have got a couple more questions, but I will submit this for the record.

Senator TESTER. Perfect. Senator Durbin.

Senator DURBIN. Thank you, Mr. Chairman. I chair the Senate Judiciary committee, and I just happened to adjourn in time for me to make this hearing, and I am glad to be here. I would like to say to all the witnesses, the GAO (Government Accountability Office) noted last year that the Pentagon is facing the most challenging recruitment environment in 50 years.

The Army, for example, has especially struggled to meet recruitment goals. The service missed its end strength number by 15,000 or 25 percent in fiscal year 2022. I am glad to see this budget request increases competitive compensation and funding for recruitment marketing programs, as well as improving quality of life for current servicemembers.

So, I would like to ask you if you would tell me what the impact has been on the Guard and Reserve with this recruiting challenge?

General HOKANSON. Senator, I will start with the National Guard. So, when you look at where we are today, our recruiters, particularly in the Army side, have really been able to adjust to the current environment and we have seen a steady increase in our recruiting abilities. In fact, we have been over 100 percent the last 3 months.

And right now, the Army National Guard is on path to meet our end strength by the end of the fiscal year. In terms of the Air National Guard, we are a little bit challenging environment. We look at to be at about 97 percent of our authorized end strength by the end of the year. But we have seen very positive increases, especially over last year.

Now, I am not declaring victory, but I am saying right now all the trends are very positive and we hope to continue those into the new year, and make sure we maintain our Army National Guard authorized end strength and reach our Air National Guard authorized end strength.

Senator DURBIN. Tell me what the elements are that you think are most persuasive for those who are enlisting.

General HOKANSON. Senator, thank you for the question. When I go across the 54, I visit with recruiters everywhere I go. Educational benefits are one of the first things they bring up. The other one is benefits such as healthcare. What they are finding in the current environment to be competitive is many companies are now offering benefits that they didn't before. Medical, educational benefits.

And so, the competition out there for the same individuals is getting much stronger. And then also internally, we are working with our own systems, and that is reducing the time it does to get—personnel to get waivers. And also addressing policies that are preventing some folks from serving.

Senator DURBIN. Any other members of the panel have a comment?

General BELLON. Yes, Senator, I think it is important to realize the math component here. The population that we are all trying to recruit right now is significantly smaller among Gen Z than the

millennials, so that is a fact we have to deal with. But also, the propensity to serve has diminished.

And that is all about us earning the confidence of the American people back that service is worthwhile. There is a pretty holistic problem but there is a math component as well. Thank you.

Senator DURBIN. I would like to just make a comment. I am about to say something that is a secret. It is not classified, but I am going to share it with you. We have 780,000 DACA (Deferred Action for Childhood Arrival) recipients, people who are protected under DACA, many of whom want to serve this country, where they grew up.

There is an obstacle, Congress. We have not given them a pathway to citizenship. This should be a pathway. You ought to open up your opportunities, we should across the board in the military, to Dreamers and to DACA recipients who really want to serve this country and I think are genuine about it.

For some reason, there has been a resistance. Perhaps it was the luxury of a lot of recruits, and we didn't need others. But I would just tell you, I have met them. I know them. They would make great sacrifices for just to have this opportunity to wear the uniforms you are wearing today.

And I hope that when you are in the highest levels of the Pentagon, that you discuss this candidly. Your predecessors have not always been cooperative when I have raised this issue. There is a resistance because these folks are, "undocumented."

They may not have been born here, but they love this country as much as any of us who pledge allegiance to that flag, so I hope you will consider that. Thank you, Mr. Chairman.

Senator TESTER. Senator Capito.

Senator CAPITO. Thank you, Mr. Chairman. I thank all of you, and I add my voice of thanks and gratitude to all of you for your service, and to your families as well.

I wanted to ask General Hokanson, West Virginia is the home to some of the National Guard Special Forces capabilities, including the Special Operations Detachment Europe and the Second Battalion 19th Special Forces Group.

Can you speak to the importance of the Guard's Special Forces capabilities and what they contribute to the Joint Force?

General HOKANSON. Yes, Senator. It is an incredible capability. When you look at the two Special Forces groups that are not in the active component, they are both in the Army National Guard. And if you go back really to the early days of 9/11, it was Guard Special Forces folks that were there, and they have served admirably around the globe ever since that time.

For us, it is something we have worked very closely with Special Operations Command to make sure that we make the ability for those leaving active duty to come into the National Guard and then also to recruit those directly out of the National Guard into our formations.

It is a critical skill set that we utilize each and every day, and our Combatant Commanders can never get enough of them. So, we are doing everything we can to recruit and retain and provide those bonuses and incentives to keep them in our formations.

Senator CAPITO. So, you have a transition pipeline from active to—for the Special Forces talents? Is that what you are saying?

General HOKANSON. Absolutely, ma'am.

Senator CAPITO. Yes, good. Good. I would note that in the early days of 9/11, when the Special Forces deployed, we lost a good West Virginian at the very beginning of that, and he was a Special Forces National Guard.

This is kind of a technical question, and I am going to ask it, but I am not sure exactly what I am asking in terms of the technical parts of it. Accurate positioning, navigation, and timing, and GPS (Global Positioning System) services are essential to U.S. critical infrastructure and for military operations.

So, our State is one of the States of West Virginia to participate as a test site for the National Guard's National Integration of Time Resiliency for Operations, or called NITRO. Could you tell me a little bit about NITRO and where you see that is going, and how important that is?

General HOKANSON. Yes, ma'am. It is a very important capability because it provides alternate resilient timing for GPS, and many of our systems operate on that. Currently, we have six States that have fielded it, and we are working very closely to support the States because this provides that capability to the States and local first responders in the case there is a loss of the GPS terrestrial signal.

Senator CAPITO. Does this capability go through all different forces? I mean, would this be something that every Guard and Reserve would have a great deal of interest in?

General HOKANSON. We are not sure of the exact fielding plan, ma'am. It is based on the funding that is provided. But we do have it in 6 States right now, and 21 others have expressed an interest. So, we are looking at the long-term viability of this, or if there are other alternate capabilities that provide the same.

Senator CAPITO. Right. Does anybody else want to speak to that? Let me ask a question on cybersecurity. I am assuming that all of you have certain cybersecurity components. Is it growing? How important is it to you? And is there a coordinating aspect to this across the forces? So, I am going to start over here with General Bellon.

General BELLON. I think, you know, acknowledging we are in the information age, it is only going to get more important. It is vital to everything we do.

And I think for all of us, we are looking for a more streamlined way for us to get our Marines, Soldiers, Sailors and Airmen who have civilian expertise and qualifications, but may not have the military occupational specialty, to find a way to expedite their access to our systems.

That doesn't exist right now. It is a very Byzantine, very ham-handed approach that we have now. We need to do better than that.

Senator CAPITO. Yes. General.

General DANIELS. So, the Army Reserve is looking to expand the amount of our force that is cyber warriors. We are growing out a cyber-protection brigade, adding an additional capability.

And I meet once a quarter with the Army cyber lead, along with the Army National Guard director, and we coordinate activities to make sure that we are not hitting the, you know, training pipeline too heavy, too fast. We are trying to make sure that we are all in sync as we go forward, looking to 2030.

Senator CAPITO. Okay. I am going to go to the Admiral next. I am going to skip—

Admiral MUSTIN. So, cyber is a growth area for the Navy Reserve.

So, we currently have about 8,000 Sailors within our information warfare community, and we continue to work very closely with CYBERCOM, as well as our fleet cyber, which is 10th Fleet, to ensure the creation of our cyber protection teams and offensive cyber capability continues to mature.

Where I see this happening most effectively is also related to our recruiting initiatives—

Senator CAPITO. Right. Absolutely.

Admiral MUSTIN [continuing]. Because we have got some fantastic civilians that can walk in the door immediately and we can do direct commission. We have recently created a new cyber designator, which is a pretty significant step from a community management perspective.

Senator CAPITO. Or out the door. I mean, once they have served and maybe they have decided where they want to transition, and they have got such an incredible skill set here. I mean, to me, that is a big selling point. And finally, yes—

General HEALY. Yes, ma'am. Absolutely a growth industry within the Air Force Reserve, currently getting into mission assurance, increasing in defensive and offensive cyber operations, and absolutely looking forward towards leveraging our civilian experience and taking that to benefit the Reserve as well.

Senator CAPITO. Right, right. So, General Hokanson, do you want to wrap it up on cyber?

General HOKANSON. Yes, Senator. Obviously we have 4,000 cyber professionals in the Guard. We are part of the Cyber National Mission Force and fully integrated into CYBERCOM.

The one thing I would highlight though is we have State partnerships with 100 nations. One of their greatest requests is to help them with the cyber defense and network defense in their country.

And we are finding when we look at misinformation campaigns, that this is absolutely critical to helping our partners and allies, and that is something we leverage at every opportunity.

Senator CAPITO. Thank you all very much.

Senator TESTER. We appreciate your testimony here today. We appreciate your work and making sure that our national defense is up to where it needs to be. General Bellon, we wish you all the best in the next phase of your life.

ADDITIONAL COMMITTEE QUESTIONS

Senators may submit additional questions. We would ask that if additional questions come in, that you answer them as quickly as you possibly can. The defense subcommittee will reconvene on Tuesday, June 20 at 3:30 p.m. for a classified hearing with the intelligence community.

[The following questions were not asked at the hearing, but were submitted to the Department for response subsequent to the hearing:]

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED TO GENERAL DANIEL R. HOKANSON

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR JON TESTER

Question. The National Guard and Reserve is a part-time force, but also relies heavily on Active Guard and Reserve.

We understand that when Guard and Reserve personnel learn that a continuing resolution is on its way—especially longer-term, they stick with their civilian jobs.

What impact does a continuing resolution have on your overall force?

Answer. The impacts of a continuing resolution vary depending on its length. The longer the continuing resolution lasts, the likelihood increases that the National Guard will not be able to meet readiness requirements to support the Joint Force or support the nation's Governors when they need us most.

Specific impacts from a short-term continuing resolution (1–3 months) include: potential curtailment of non-statutory training such as additional training days (i.e. flight training), resulting in degraded readiness across the formation; degraded ability to maintain/manage real property inventory and unit stationing actions; and the increased likelihood of missing critical training gates at prescribed times during the training year cycle resulting in the inability to meet readiness milestones.

Continuing resolutions lasting beyond 4 months significantly increase risks for the National Guard. Impacts include: continued pressure on soldiers and civilians from the impacts of inflation by not receiving a pay raise; decreased ground OPTEMPO and flying hours resulting in lower readiness proficiency; curtailment of readiness-enhancing training exercises; reductions in depot repair of airframes, tactical wheeled vehicles, and weapon systems; inability to address Base Operations Support (BOS) shortfalls (e.g., fire and emergency services; range services), impacting operational readiness and Soldier/Family well-being; increased potential for the need to furlough State employees; delays in modernization of inadequately structured facilities/infrastructure and delays deficit reduction of critical facility types (readiness centers, maintenance facilities, and barracks); and inability to afford filling critical vacancies and limit bonuses/incentives which will degrade the ability to meet accessions goals and end strength.

Question. How does a continuing resolution impact participation rates in drills, training, and schools?

Answer. Continuing resolutions definitively impact the participation, attendance, and execution of schools. The uncertainty of funding degrades the capability to maintain fulltime staff and instructors to execute training, causes registered students to adjust commitments for attending, and has a risk to student lodging payments for courses longer than 140 days. Without the proper appropriation, there is a high probability for schools to cancel.

Question. The National Guard is now in year six of the Southwest border mission supporting Customs and Border Protection.

Today, there are approximately 2,500 Army Guard personnel at our Southwest border, with another 1,500 Active Duty troops headed down there following the Biden administration's decision to end Title 42.

This mission has never been budgeted for by DoD or the National Guard. However, we have now spent more than \$1.65 billion for the southwest border mission.

General Hokanson, if the current surge of 1,500 Active Duty troops is prolonged, I understand National Guard personnel may be deployed. What can you tell the Committee about the likelihood and feasibility of such an expanded Guard footprint there?

Answer. I acknowledge the difficult task the Department of Homeland Security is faced with in securing the Southwest Border. However, continued National Guard support has created an enduring, readiness-degrading law enforcement support mission. In addition, the mission's costly personnel tempo is having a negative impact on our service members, their families, employers, and impacting retention of servicemembers. The primary mission of the National Guard is to fight and win our Nation's wars as the combat reserve of the Army and Air Force. In today's environment, combat readiness is paramount for all National Guard formations. Anything that negatively impacts readiness, that can be accomplished by other responsible agencies or can be contracted, should be eliminated. Lastly, development of a strategic plan to off-ramp military support may quicken development of more cost-effective or contractual solutions to those currently being performed by the National

Guard. I continue to recommend that the border mission can be accomplished by other agencies.

Question. General Hokanson, how is this mission impacting the readiness of Guard personnel?

Answer. During operational employment for the Southwest Border (SWB) mission, National Guard unit readiness is consumed rather than built. Unit preparation, deployment, and redeployment, may overlap with training and modernization year activities, further negatively impacting a unit's ability to build combat readiness and modernize on schedule. SWB units are mobilized for 400 days, resulting in nearly 13 months with no wartime mission training. Additionally, the National Guard has received so many requests for support from National Guard UH-72 helicopters that the SWB is depleting the serviceable life of the aircraft 2.5 times faster than programmed, significantly impacting Army aviation readiness and modernization.

Question. In the past 2 years, Congress has provided funds for thirty-two new C-130J aircraft specifically for the Air National Guard.

Upgrading our airlift fleet is a top priority of mine. The Air National Guard—including the 120th Airlift Wing based in Great Falls—is in real need of capable airlift so that you can perform the critical missions assigned to you.

I understand that the basing decision for these aircraft is still underway, with a decision slated for later this year.

General Hokanson: What can you tell me about your priorities for the strategic basing process for these aircraft from the Guard's perspective? How are you coordinating with the Active Duty Air Force to ensure your equities are addressed?

Answer. The Air National Guard is utilizing the Air Force Strategic Basing Process for the C-130J basing decision. The Secretary of the Air Force has delegated the C-130J basing decision to the Director, Air National Guard and the process will provide a standardized, repeatable, transparent, and deliberate decision.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR BRIAN SCHATZ

Emergency Management Assistance

Question. How would the National Guard provide technical assistance to guard units that are activated via Emergency Management Assistance Compact (EMAC) in expediting resources to states that have requested assistance but are geographically isolated, such as Hawaii?

Answer. The National Guard uses five means to mitigate the risks associated with disaster assistance to geographically isolated States. First, the National Guard regularly embeds Liaison Officers (LNOs) at the Federal Emergency Management Agency's (FEMA) National Response Coordination Center during declared emergencies. These LNOs inform FEMA of National Guard capabilities and forces available to support disaster response in geographically isolated States. Second, the National Guard may embed trained emergency management personnel with EMAC Advanced Teams (A-Teams) assigned to FEMA's Regional Response Coordination Center in impacted regions. Guardsmen and women assigned to A-Teams ensure National Guard support synchronizes with the Federal response. Third, the National Guard uses the Threat and Hazard Identification and Risk Assessment (THIRA) to assess risks, develop mitigation strategies, and develop needed capabilities for potential employment during disaster response. THIRA is especially valuable in synchronizing the National Guard's responses and resources with FEMA to ensure states such as Hawaii enhance their resilience in disaster response. Fourth, NGB dispatches Joint Liaison Teams (JLT) to impacted states prior to or at the start of an emergency. These teams assist the Joint Force Headquarters with coordinating response options between the state and the National Guard Bureau. Fifth, isolated states may authorize their Guardsmen and women already in a state active duty status to support immediate responses to domestic emergencies until such time as either the impacts of a disaster subside or resources from National Guard units external to the impacted state arrive. The National Guard Bureau ensures states and territories adhere to relevant statutes and policy for the use of immediate response authority.

Question. What coordination is there between the National Guard Bureau (NGB) and the Federal Emergency Management Administration (FEMA) when considering which guard units would assist another state that has requested assistance? How does NGB account for geographic isolation as factor when coordinating logistics?

Answer. The National Guard Bureau (NGB) conducts annual workshops to coordinate with the 54 States and territories, FEMA, United States Indo-Pacific Command, and United States Northern Command to supporting relationships during emergencies through the construct of an Emergency Management Compact (EMAC).

The National Emergency Management Association (NEMA), through the National Coordination Group (NCG), facilitates requests to deploy an EMAC Coordination Team. These teams synchronize EMAC activities with Federal personnel whenever requested by FEMA Headquarters during an incident.

Responding to disasters in geographic isolated locations requires a whole of government logistics response. Upon the Federal Declaration of an Emergency or Federal Disaster Declaration associated with a domestic response requiring military support, a Mission Assignment (MA) is generated by the FEMA field office. The Defense Coordinating Officer in this office coordinates with the state or states Emergency Managers and the National Guard liaison and decides which forces are best suited to fulfill the request beyond the scope of EMACs already in place and executed. All requests for support, including logistics outlined in the MA are prioritized in coordination with FEMA, the state, NGB, and other agencies against available transportation assets to move personnel and supplies into the impacted region. These efforts require constant coordination between agencies to ensure allocated transportation space is maximized and support is provided at the point of need.

Training and Partnerships

Question. How does the National Guard Bureau support unofficial partnerships between National Guard units and Taiwan's military to improve Taiwan's defensive and deterrence abilities?

Answer. The Taiwan Relations Act requires the U.S. to make available defense articles and defense services as necessary to enable Taiwan to maintain a sufficient self-defense capacity as determined by the President and Congress. The National Guard has several elements working with personnel in Taiwan to increase proficiency in several areas. I would be happy to follow up with you in person to discuss further.

Question. How is the National Guard Bureau tailoring more State Partnership Program programming towards partnerships with nations in the Indo-Pacific?

Answer. The National Guard Bureau works very closely with the Geographic Combatant Commands (GCC) including U.S. Indo-Pacific Command to prioritize programming. Because the State Partnership Program supports GCC Theater Campaign Plans, the prioritization of programming is a function of many variables to include availability of Guardsmen and women to participate in the event, partner nation availability, and—crucially—the timing of availability of funds relative to the NGB and the partner nation.

Question. Which State Partnership Programs yield the best cooperation between National Guard units and foreign militaries? Are these high-yield partnerships primarily focused on niches the guard excels at like cybersecurity and disaster response?

Answer. The State Partnership Program currently has 88 partnerships with 100 countries ranging in age from 30 years old to new ones just formed this year. Most of our partnerships thrive and encompass whole of government and whole of society. Consistently, the following partnerships stand out and yield the best access, influence, and friendships. Lithuania/PA, Senegal/VT, Jordan/CO, Uzbekistan/MS, Kazakhstan/AZ, Brazil/NY, Malaysia/WA, Morocco/UT, Latvia/MI, Poland/IL. These partnerships all share the same attributes: highly-engaged state-level staffs, strong partner nation commitment and involvement, exceptional Combatant Command Security Cooperation staff with clear integration into their Theater Campaign Plan (TCP), and a strong motivation to engage with the United States in a mutual effort to gain increased security for our citizens.

High-yield partnerships are not focused on any particular niche. All partnerships are based on the partner nation's desires, identified capability gaps, and the priorities of the Combatant Commander.

National Guard Pay and Benefits Reforms

Question. Does the National Guard Bureau support states passing plans to reimburse health insurance fees for guardsmen?

Answer. Yes, the National Guard Bureau supports any plan that improves Guardsmen's ability to receive health insurance and increase access to healthcare when not in a duty status. Proactively managing health through regular visits provides Guardsmen and women an opportunity to stay ahead of medical issues.

Question. Have states that previously implemented health insurance fee reimbursement seen increases to recruiting?

Answer. To the best of our knowledge, Maryland is the only state to enact health insurance reimbursement into law. The Health Care for Heroes Act of 2023 was passed on May 12th, 2023 and will not go into effect until July 1st, 2023. We look

forward to working with the Maryland National Guard to determine if it has a positive impact on recruiting.

Question. How will the National Guard focus future training opportunities on in-demand workforce skills, like cybersecurity and medical training, to support, recruitment, retention, and work-transfer opportunities for guardsmen?

Answer. The National Guard offers many in-demand specialty jobs that can be leveraged to pursue a civilian career, which enhances recruiting and retention within the National Guard. We are implementing direct commissioning and constructive credit to not only allow us to meet emerging mission needs, but to reward and incentivize the civilian skills many of our recruits have gained.

National Guard Cyber Capabilities

Question. How is the National Guard using its robust cyber capabilities to partner with state, city, and local government to help protect systems and critical infrastructure from cyber attacks?

Answer. National Guard cyber forces routinely leverage full scale cyber training exercises (i.e., Cyber Shield, Cyber Yankee, etc.) along with tabletop exercises, innovative readiness training, direct engagements, and technical assistance engagements (when requested) to partner with state, city and local governments to build the appropriate relationships needed to help protect systems and critical infrastructure.

As a specific example, over the last 10 months the National Guard participated in the Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Agency (CISA) regionally aligned Homeland Defense & Critical Infrastructure tabletop exercises to improve the collaboration required to protect and defend critical infrastructure. The intent is to bring together state and Federal partners to: gain a shared understanding of the operational environment and understand threats and vulnerabilities to critical infrastructure (including force projection platforms and transportation nodes); consider potential Defense Support to Civil Authorities (DSCA) triggering events during a homeland defense operation; and reveal resource/capability gaps as applied to defense of the homeland.

Question. What cyber capabilities does the National Guard need to further invest in to keep pace with growing cyber threats and what support does the guard need to enable this skillset?

Answer. National Guard cyber forces need to be equipped with standard cyber tools and training common to all Federalized mission forces to operate effectively within the homeland cyber domain (i.e. operational technology, incident response).

Question. How is the National Guard designing its cyber capabilities to assist CISA in protecting election infrastructure from foreign attacks?

Answer. The National Guard Bureau (NGB) works with the Army and Air Force to design the required force structure to meet wartime requirements and to ensure the National Guard is structured to perform cyber operations as required. Like other types of force structure within the National Guard, the wartime capabilities of the cyber units allow our professionals to assist CISA and the states to protect the election infrastructure from foreign attacks.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR JEANNE SHAHEEN

Question. General Hokanson, can you provide an update on the importance of corrosion prevention and control for National Guard assets. Specifically, on the C-130 aircraft?

Answer. Aircraft corrosion prevention and control, to include C-130 aircraft, is critical. Corrosion contributes to increased need for both field-level and depot-level maintenance. Every ANG Wing adheres to strict standards of corrosion prevention and control through a Corrosion Prevention and Control Program detailed in Air Force Instruction and in Technical Orders.

Question. How many C-130 aircraft does the National Guard currently have in inventory?

Answer. The Air National Guard has 127 C-130 aircraft in inventory, 87 C-130Hs and 40 C-130Js.

Question. I understand that the Air Force is undergoing an air worthiness assessment on a new blanket liner technology, the Improved Thermal Acoustic Blanket (ITAB), for the C-130 that has the potential to significantly reduce corrosion to the airframe. Could you also provide an update on what the National Guard is doing on this effort specifically, as well as the importance of corrosion control for the C-130 in general?

Answer. Corrosion control is extremely important for the C-130 aircraft. The National Guard Bureau supports any and all efforts to better control corrosion on airframes. It is our understanding that the Air Mobility Command has the lead for testing a variety of acoustic blankets, and we are looking forward to their test results.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR LISA MURKOWSKI

Question. The Alaska Air National Guard's 168th Wing at Eielson AFB is the only Arctic region capable air refueling unit in the United States. Due to the extreme environment at Eielson AFB, the addition of four KC-135 aircraft without the addition of hangar space will put DoD objectives at risk. The current fleet of nine KC-135 aircraft at Eielson often see mission capable (MC) rates below 60 percent during the coldest months. These MC rates are largely driven by extremely limited hangar availability and based on historical data, scheduled and fuel maintenance alone will utilize the two current hangars at 85%. If additional hangars are not constructed, an MC rate above 50% will be difficult to achieve in the winter months. (ANG OPR)

Do you support additional hangar space at Eielson AFB to facilitate the additional maintenance requirements while simultaneously providing secure alert parking?

Answer. Yes, The National Guard Bureau has assessed current and future tanker aircraft hangar needs at Eielson AFB, AK. Through a Business Case Analysis conducted in 2022, we have validated a requirement for an additional covered aircraft maintenance spot. This would provide two covered aircraft maintenance positions as well as a covered fuel cell maintenance position for 3 total covered aircraft spots. A project to construct the additional maintenance space is in early scope development.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR JOHN HOEVEN

Question. Last year's omnibus included \$350 million to bring 12 Gray Eagles to the Army National Guard, and we expect to procure additional Gray Eagles for additional Army National Guard Divisions. We need to ensure that the National Guard has capabilities equivalent to its active duty counterparts.

How important will this new capability be to the National Guard?

Answer. It is always vitally important that the Army National Guard (ARNG) has the same force structure, training, and equipment as the Active Army to ensure interoperability with the Joint Force.

Question. When do you expect the 12 Gray Eagles procured last year to be fielded in the National Guard?

Answer. The ARNG expects to field Gray Eagle in the middle of calendar year 2027.

Question. When would you expect the Army National Guard to have personnel trained to operate and maintain those 12 aircraft?

Answer. The training seat allocations for Soldiers to be trained to operate and maintain the 12 Gray Eagle aircraft will be available after the unit's force structure, which allocates personnel authorizations and equipment fielding, is finalized. The Army National Guard currently expects to field the aircraft in mid-2027, and begin training in 2026 or early 2027.

Question. In the fiscal year 2022 defense appropriations bill, \$15.5 million was included for the Dickinson Readiness Center. This project was fully authorized and appropriated for, but due to inflation and the rising costs of construction and materials, the project now carries a cost-to-complete of over \$5 million. This problem isn't specific to North Dakota, but is affecting National Guard projects all over the country.

How important of a role do readiness centers play in helping the National Guard carry out its missions and objectives?

Answer. Readiness Centers are vitally important to the National Guard because they serve as the "Home Base" for all National Guard Soldiers. The Readiness Centers serves as the primary Command Center for Mobilization, Disaster/Emergency and Contingencies, and support the unit home station. Readiness Centers are crucial to training and readiness preparation, supporting Individual and Collective Training, Supply distribution, Family Support, Community support, Recruiting and Retention.

Question. The 817th Engineer Company is operating and training out of a sub-standard facility in Jamestown, North Dakota. The North Dakota Army National Guard has prioritized and has expected the Jamestown Readiness Center to be listed on the future years defense program (FYDP) since 2021. The unit is currently

preparing to deploy to the U.S. southern border and my concern is that without a new readiness center, the unit's ability to meet readiness, recruiting and retention, and training objectives will be adversely affected.

Can you take a close look at the need for the Jamestown Readiness Center and work to have it listed on next year's FYDP?

Answer. The Army National Guard uses a transparent scoring process called the Installations Requirement Plan to score all 54 States' and Territories' priorities in order to maximize total ARNG readiness. The North Dakota Army National Guard (NDARNG) has submitted the Jamestown Readiness Center project for consideration to be included in the FY30 program year. The National Guard Bureau will continue to work with the NDARNG to ensure their requirements are being fairly considered.

Question. We need to do more to ensure Guardsmen and their families have timely access to mental healthcare services. Due to accreditation and licensing obstacles, only a limited number of civilian mental healthcare providers are eligible to participate in the TRICARE network. As a result, many of these providers do not have availability due to high workloads, leaving Guardsmen and their families waiting weeks, if not months, to access the mental healthcare they need and have earned.

How are you working to address this problem?

Answer. The National Guard has hired Psychological Health Specialists in every State and Wing to provide Soldiers and Airmen access to mental health assessments, psychological education, solution-focused mental health interventions, and referrals to community-based resources. Additionally, the National Guard Bureau (NGB) has developed partnerships with several national organizations focused on improving access to mental healthcare allowing members to access additional treatment options within their local communities (e.g., psychological evaluations, evidenced based therapy, crisis counseling, etc.). We have established and implemented a program to provide community-level civilian providers with no-cost training on military culture, treatment protocols, and other relevant topics to enhance care and incentivize providers to join the TRICARE network. NGB continually evaluates the effectiveness and feasibility of expanding best practices of State initiatives nationally.

Question. Have you identified any solutions to increase the number of mental health providers participating in the TRICARE network to increase timely access to these important services?

Answer. The TRICARE benefit is managed by the Defense Health Agency (DHA). The National Guard Bureau (NGB) is working closely with DHA leadership to address access issues for Guardsmen and women with TRICARE. More than 237,000 National Guard members currently live outside of TRICARE Prime service areas, where there are little to no contract incentives to maintain robust provider networks. Future TRICARE contract modifications could address reimbursement rates and provide incentives to expand service, especially in more rural areas.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED TO LIEUTENANT GENERAL JODY J. DANIELS

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR JON TESTER

Question. The National Guard and Reserve is a part-time force, but also relies heavily on Active Guard and Reserve.

We understand that when Guard and Reserve personnel learn that a continuing resolution is on its way—especially longer-term, they stick with their civilian jobs.

What impact does a continuing resolution have on your overall force?

Answer. Budgeted annual increases for Military and Civilian personnel costs remain unfunded throughout a continuing resolution. The U.S. Army Reserve (USAR) will curtail the accession of Active Guard and Reserve (AGR) Soldiers and the hiring of Military Technicians (MILTECH) and Department of the Army Civilians (DAC) to restrict budget execution within prior-year, short-term funding allocations. The USAR's full-time support, consisting of AGRs/MILTECHs/DACs, comprises only 14% of the overall force, but is responsible for providing direct support to prepare USAR units for their wartime mission by conducting maintenance and other operational support, including organizing, administering, recruiting, instructing, and training Army Reserve Soldiers and units. Reduced full-time support will impact the planning, execution, and effectiveness of training for Troop Program Unit (TPU) Soldiers (part-time), resulting in lower levels of individual and unit readiness. The cumulative effect of the uncertainty and lost purchasing power associated with multiple, short-term continuing resolutions, results in inefficient spending, lost training opportunities, sub-optimal decisionmaking, and the decreased likelihood that the

USAR will be able to sustain the recruiting and retention momentum, having begun in Fiscal Year 2023, necessary to achieve our authorized end strength objective.

Question. How does a continuing resolution impact participation rates in drills, training, and schools?

Answer. Commanders continue to execute monthly statutory drills/training periods for Soldiers during a continuing resolution, in accordance with 10 U.S. Code §10147, but units will delay the planning/scheduling of exercises, larger training events, and schools necessary for professional development, functional training, and MOS-qualification. The Army Reserve schedules most of its large-scale exercises and collective training in the 3rd and 4th quarters of the fiscal year. Continuing resolutions that extend past the 1st quarter may result in the postponement, cancelation, or scaling back of training events and schools which leads to a decrease in individual and unit readiness. Multiple, short-term continuing resolutions that last well into the fiscal year preclude commanders from conducting long-range planning. Delays in planning/executing exercises, collective training events, and schools results in late notification to Soldiers/Families/employers as well as ineffective budget execution and contracting actions, which leads to decreased Soldier availability/participation and increased costs.

The President's Budget for Fiscal Year 2024 includes requested increases of +\$418 million for Operation and Maintenance, Army Reserve (OMAR) and +\$155 million for Reserve Personnel, Army (RPA). The USAR would limit expenditures to the FY 2023 funding levels under an extended continuing resolution, which, when combined with continued inflationary cost increases, significantly decreases purchasing power. The USAR would be unable to fund planned Military and Civilian pay increases or fully execute all equipment maintenance, statutory drills/training periods, exercises, collective training, and schools if funded at FY 2023 levels.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED TO VICE ADMIRAL JOHN B. MUSTIN

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR JON TESTER

Question. The National Guard and Reserve is a part-time force, but also relies heavily on Active Guard and Reserve.

We understand that when Guard and Reserve personnel learn that a continuing resolution is on its way—especially longer-term, they stick with their civilian jobs.

What impact does a continuing resolution have on your overall force?

Answer. A full-year continuing resolution (CR) would be a fiscally unsound way of funding the Department, the Navy, the Navy Reserve and government as a whole. It would misalign billions of dollars in resources in a manner inconsistent with evolving threats and the national security landscape, which would erode the U.S. military advantage relative to China, impede our ability to innovate and modernize, degrade readiness, and hurt our people and their families. And it would offer comfort to our enemies, disquiet to our allies, and unnecessary stress to our workforce. A full-year CR cedes ground we cannot afford to yield. Put simply, it puts our national security at risk.

Specifically, a full-year continuing resolution will impact our ability to pay and grow the force. The Fiscal Year 2023 enacted amount is over \$100 million less than the Fiscal Year 2024 Presidents Budget request for Navy Reserve MILPERS (RPN). An obligation authority equal to the FY 2023 level in FY 2024 is not sufficient to grow the force we need and conduct the necessary readiness training. This is especially challenging given the record low unemployment and recruiting challenges we all face. An overall shortfall in MILPERS will require a reduction in end strength, curtailment of PCS moves, reduction in training and elimination of most new bonus awards. Navy Reserve will end the year significantly below authorized end strength.

The Navy Reserve Operation and Maintenance (OMNR) appropriation would also have a reduction of over \$100 million to the FY2024 Presidents Budget request in a full-year continuing resolution. This overall shortfall in OMNR accounts will delay maintenance on facilities, equipment, and aircraft, and likely reduce flying hours, impeding our ability to maintain the required readiness in support of the National Defense Strategy.

Question. How does a continuing resolution impact participation rates in drills, training and schools?

Answer. The Navy Reserve does not anticipate negative impacts due to a full-year continuing resolution on drill participation and annual training. However, a full-year continuing resolution will force a reduction of funding for schools and additional training in order to fund the basic entitlements for drills and annual training.

The lost opportunity to attend schools and conduct additional training will degrade readiness in the long term.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED TO LIEUTENANT GENERAL DAVID G. BELLON

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR JON TESTER

Question. The National Guard and Reserve is a part-time force, but also relies heavily on Active Guard and Reserve. We understand that when Guard and Reserve personnel learn that a continuing resolution is on its way—especially longer-term, they stick with their civilian jobs.

What impact does a continuing resolution have on your overall force?

Answer. Continued budget uncertainty negatively impacts the Marine Corp's ability to modernize and build a force that is manned, trained and equipped for the future operating environment.

The inability to reprogram funds under CRs drastically reduces the ability of the Marine Corps to respond to unplanned urgent requirements or to address funding gaps that potentially impact our forces in high threat areas.

There is a direct relationship between readiness and modernization. We seek to modernize platforms, systems and training rather than continuing to expend resources to maintain aging, less lethal systems not suited for the future operating environment. Although DoD has never been forced to operate under a full-year CR, continued budget uncertainty delays modernization efforts, resulting in reduced readiness and exposing our forces to greater risks on future battlefields.

CRs drive cost increases that result in a reduction of purchasing power. Available funding in each incremental CR period drives the requirement to break contract actions into multiple transactions that would otherwise be done once. This incremental approach results in the Marine Corps not getting the best contract price, paying multiple times for contract fees, and losing time and skilled labor in redundant tasks.

Question. How does a continuing resolution impact participation rates in drills, training and schools?

Answer. CRs have not proven to impact participation rates in drills, training and schools for the Marine Corps Reserve. Participation rates have remained consistent and steady over the past several years with the only downturn attributed to COVID, however current rates have returned to pre-COVID levels.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED TO LIEUTENANT GENERAL JOHN P. HEALY

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR JON TESTER

Question. The National Guard and Reserve is a part-time force, but also relies heavily on Active Guard and Reserve.

We understand that when Guard and Reserve personnel learn that a continuing resolution is on its way—especially longer-term, they stick with their civilian jobs.

What impact does a continuing resolution have on your overall force?

Answer. The operational effectiveness of the Air Force Reserve (AFR) is heavily reliant on a stable and predictable budget, necessary for maintaining readiness, driving modernization, and ensuring consistent and effective training. Continuing Resolutions (CRs) introduce significant instability, curtailing improvements in Total Force readiness and hinder our ability to make sustainable progress.

As a predominately part-time force, our Reserve Citizen Airmen rely on predictability to help balance military commitments with their civilian careers. CRs introduce a level of unpredictability that strains this delicate balance, and when CRs extend over a long term, this unpredictability intensifies, potentially damaging the trust and morale our members. This can lead to considerable difficulties in recruiting and retaining personnel, thereby affecting the strength and functionality of the force.

Question. How does a continuing resolution impact participation rates in drills, training and schools?

Answer. Continuing resolutions (CRs) have a direct negative impact on participation rates in drills, training, and schools within the Air Force Reserve (AFR). The uncertainty and funding disruptions created by CRs can lead to cancellations of formal school programs, causing a ripple effect of rescheduling into limited class schedules. As a CR extends into the fiscal year, rescheduling becomes increasingly complex, resulting in lost seats and reduced future training capacity.

Furthermore, the funding delays caused by CRs significantly disrupt the careers of personnel on long-term formal school orders, who are only funded until the end of the current CR period. This causes discontinuities in pay and benefits, which can deter Reserve Citizen Airmen from fully committing to these educational opportunities.

Additionally, the delays introduced by CRs negatively impact recruitment efforts, notably postponing Basic Military Training (BMT) attendance. This leads to lost potential recruits and delays in mission posturing, further reducing participation rates.

Continuing resolutions (CRs) also lead to a notable delay in the attendance to initial skills schools and advanced courses for new recruits, a consequence that can significantly impede the readiness of the AFR. These training courses are critical to developing the necessary skills, qualifications, and expertise among our new accessions, equipping them to become fully integrated, capable, and deployable assets. Any delay in this process hampers the immediate effectiveness of these individuals and slows down the overall readiness rate of our force. Over time, this can create a backlog of untrained personnel, leading to a continuous cycle of deferred readiness, potentially compromising the AFR's operational capacity.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR LISA MURKOWSKI

Question. My understating is that the Air Force is not planning on standing up a reserve NGAD squadron, like they did with F-22s at the 477th Fighter Group. Do you have specific concerns regarding future basing and structure decisions as these new platforms get fielded?

Answer. The Air Force Reserve (AFR) stands ready to defend our Nation while concurrently adapting for the future. We are committed to investing in a comprehensive range of systems that enable our Air Force to maintain effective deterrence and command of the skies.

In transitioning from the F-22, we will fully support the Air Combat Command, capitalizing on our rich experience to integrate manned next-generation air dominance (NGAD) platforms with collaborative combat aircraft (CCA). Coupled with command and control, sensors, and weaponry, this approach will enhance our force's lethality and performance in highly contested environments.

Our strategy hinges on concurrent and proportional fielding and progression to the NGAD family of systems, and as of now, we are not aware of any approved decisions that deviate from this plan.

As these new platforms are fielded, it will provide a tremendous opportunity to harness the continuity, expertise and cost-effectiveness of the AFR. By leveraging our strengths and actively integrating the AFR into these systems through a strategy of concurrent and proportional fielding, we will position ourselves to significantly bolster our operational efficiency, readiness and ability to defend our Nation.

Question. The Alaska Air National Guard's 168th Wing at Eielson AFB is the only Arctic region capable air refueling unit in the United States. Due to the extreme environment at Eielson AFB, the addition of four KC-135 aircraft without the addition of hangar space will put DoD objectives at risk. The current fleet of nine KC-135 aircraft at Eielson often see mission capable (MC) rates below 60 percent during the coldest months. These MC rates are largely driven by extremely limited hangar availability and based on historical data, scheduled and fuel maintenance alone will utilize the two current hangars at 85%. If additional hangars are not constructed, an MC rate above 50% will be difficult to achieve in the winter months. (ANG OPR)

Do you support additional hangar space at Eielson AFB to facilitate the additional maintenance requirements while simultaneously providing secure alert parking?

Answer. Yes, The National Guard Bureau has assessed current and future tanker aircraft hangar needs at Eielson AFB, AK. Through a Business Case Analysis conducted in 2022, we have validated a requirement for an additional covered aircraft maintenance spot. This would provide two covered aircraft maintenance positions as well as a covered fuel cell maintenance position for 3 total covered aircraft spots. A project to construct the additional maintenance space is in early scope development.

QUESTIONS SUBMITTED BY SENATOR JOHN HOEVEN

Question. We need to do more to ensure Guardsmen, Reservists, and their families have timely access to mental healthcare services. Due to accreditation and licensing obstacles, only a limited number of civilian mental healthcare providers are eligible to participate in the TRICARE network. As a result, many of these providers do not

have availability due to high workloads, leaving servicemembers and their families waiting weeks, if not months, to access the mental healthcare they need and have earned.

How are you working to address this problem?

Answer. While the Air Force Reserve (AFR) does not directly control the TRICARE program, we recognize the need for improved access to mental healthcare services for our Reserve Citizen Airmen and their families.

We have implemented the Director of Psychological Health Program (DPH) that places Licensed Clinical Social Workers (LCSWs) within our units. We currently have 37 LCSWs who provide supportive services, to include, but not limited to needs assessment, psycho-educational skills, goal/value clarification, short term problem solving, enhanced mental health referral coordination, advocacy, and appropriate training to members of the AFR population. They provide short term supportive counseling (approximately 3–6 visits) and refer Reserve Airmen for appropriate complex or high-interest related treatment to military or community-based providers.

The AFR DPH program is currently under review as we work to assess expanding coverage across all Reserve wings, in addition to redesigning the clinical support, guidance, privileging, and data/trend tracking initiatives within the program.

Question. Have you identified any solutions to increase the number of mental health providers participating in the TRICARE network to increase timely access to these important services?

Answer. The Air Force Reserve does not oversee the TRICARE network, which is managed by the Defense Health Agency (DHA). However, we are dedicated to ensuring that our members have access to necessary mental health services. To this end, we've implemented the Director of Psychological Health Program, which positions Licensed Clinical Social Workers directly within our units (as mentioned in the response to Question 1a above).

Additionally, our Airmen have access to the Military Family Life Consultants, who provide free, short-term support to service members, their families, and survivors utilizing confidential non-medical counseling on installations worldwide. While we cannot directly increase the number of providers within the TRICARE network, these initiatives significantly bolster the mental health support accessible to our members and their families.

DHA has reported that they continue to accept applications from eligible mental health providers. This policy indicates an active and sustained effort by DHA to expand the provider network. Despite the global shortage of mental health providers, we remain committed to improving mental health support within our capabilities for all Reserve Citizen Airmen.

CONCLUSION OF HEARINGS

Senator TESTER. This committee stands in recess.

[Whereupon, at 10:51 a.m., Thursday, June 1, the hearings were concluded, and the subcommittee was recessed, to reconvene subject to the call of the Chair.]

DEPARTMENT OF DEFENSE APPROPRIATIONS FOR FISCAL YEAR 2024

U.S. SENATE,
SUBCOMMITTEE OF THE COMMITTEE ON APPROPRIATIONS,
Washington, DC.

NONDEPARTMENTAL WITNESSES

[CLERK'S NOTE.—The subcommittee was unable to hold hearings on nondepartmental witnesses. The statements and letters of those submitting written testimony are as follows:]

PREPARED STATEMENT OF THE AMERICAN UROLOGICAL ASSOCIATION

The American Urological Association, the premier organization for urologists worldwide with over 15,000 urologists across the United States, thanks Chairman Tester, Ranking Member Collins, and fellow members of the committee for the opportunity to provide written testimony on the health needs of our military and veterans, including bladder cancer. Our testimony will outline the importance of combatting bladder cancer to our Nation's military and veteran population. Specifically, we respectfully request an \$8 million line item within the Fiscal Year 2024 Congressionally Directed Medical Research Program (CDMRP) for bladder cancer to stabilize the field and fund groundbreaking science that can finally bend the survival rate of bladder cancer in the right direction.

Bladder cancer is the fourth most commonly diagnosed cancer in U.S. military and veteran populations, and the sixth most commonly diagnosed cancer in Americans. Additionally, it is estimated that approximately 82,290 Americans will be diagnosed with bladder cancer in 2023. While survival rates for many other cancers have increased, the 5-year survival rate for bladder cancer has not improved in more than 30 years. Congress has previously provided funding for bladder cancer research through the DoD's Peer Reviewed Cancer Research Program (PRCRP). Despite the support to date for innovative and competitive bladder cancer research, there remains an urgent need to provide predictable investment that will improve the outcomes for this deadly cancer. A dedicated funding line will help attract researchers to this field by demonstrating a sustained commitment to this work.

The American Urological Association represents the interests of urologists across the United States. We understand that new tools, treatments, and techniques are necessary to ensure that a bladder cancer diagnosis has good long-term outcomes. Yet time and again, research dollars go to other, higher profile cancers. Highlighting bladder cancer's importance to our military community by including a line item will ensure that the research field can grow and that more research applications are funded moving forward, particularly for younger investigators who may be interested in pursuing bladder cancer research but are unsure of the field's financial stability and the feasibility of their grant applications given extremely limited resources.

The relevance to U.S. veterans is clear: many veterans were exposed to high levels of "rainbow herbicides," including Agent Blue and Agent Orange which are both recognized as highly toxic. In the National Defense Authorization Act for FY 2021, Congress directed the addition of bladder cancer to the Department of Veteran's Affairs list of presumptive diseases linked to Agent Orange exposure. This addition came after the National Academy of Medicine included bladder cancer on its list of "suggestive evidence of association" with Agent Orange exposure. Additionally, researchers are just learning that there may be a significant link between exposure to burn puts and bladder cancer, which must be further explored. Unfortunately, bladder cancer is a lagging indicator for carcinogens given it tends to impact older

individuals. However, we can be sure that there is likely a connection to burn pits based on other inhaled carcinogens being known risk factors.

Our membership has seen first-hand what bladder cancer can do to a patient. For example, one bladder cancer patient is a 71-year-old veteran of the Vietnam war living in Maryland with high-risk non-muscle invasive bladder cancer. Like many patients, he was unfamiliar with bladder cancer when he began to have blood in his urine several years ago. When told that bladder cancer was the fourth most common cancer among men in the United States, he and his wife were shocked. He was treated with intravesical BCG, the standard treatment for this type of bladder cancer. BCG is also a relatively ineffective vaccine for tuberculosis and is more than one hundred years old. Unfortunately, soon after treatment his cancer recurred. At that point, his options were either a radical cystectomy, surgery to remove his bladder necessitating urinary tract reconstruction, or a second-line therapy. With few FDA approved therapies available, the patient chose an experimental clinical trial involving intravesical gemcitabine and docetaxel therapies. He has responded well thus far on this second line therapy.

The fact that the general standard of care for bladder cancer is a very old, ineffective TB vaccine should both shock and also reinforce the necessity of more research funding for this disease. This case highlights the critical need for more funding to further research and scientific understanding of bladder cancer, a disease which is particularly prevalent among veterans. From this one example, it is clear that there is a gap in patient awareness about bladder cancer and a lack of treatments available for patients who recur after BCG. We know that second-line therapies are lacking and identifying novel therapies that avoid major surgery is a prominent focus of research efforts. It is clear more must be done, and that our men and women in the armed forces will directly benefit from advancements against bladder cancer given its higher incidence rate among veterans than the general public. By establishing an \$8 million Bladder Cancer Research Program in FY 2024, we can ensure that bladder cancer research and the well-being of bladder cancer patients, particularly service members and veterans, is a national priority.

We thank you for your time and attention to this urgent health priority for our military and veteran population.

PREPARED STATEMENT OF THE GOVERNMENT ACCOUNTABILITY OFFICE

Chairman Tester, Ranking Member Collins, and members of the Defense Appropriations subcommittee, thank you for the opportunity to submit this written testimony.

The Government Accountability Office plays a critical role in Congressional oversight of the Executive Branch. Unfortunately, that role may be stymied when it comes to the Intelligence Community (“IC”). Despite the fact that, by statute, GAO already has the purview to conduct oversight of all Federal agencies¹ and has since its creation in 1921,² the IC has, with a few exceptions, insisted that it is not subject to such audits since its inception. This effectively deprives Congress of one of the most effective tools in its arsenal, especially at a time when the activities of the IC present some of the most pressing needs for robust oversight in the Executive Branch. I respectfully recommend that Congress take steps to conclusively validate GAO’s jurisdiction in such matters.

In response to the IC’s recalcitrance, some Members of Congress have periodically attempted to resolve the matter over the past few decades. For instance, then-Congressman Leon Panetta introduced a bill in 1987 called the CIA Accountability Act to officially clarify GAO’s authority vis-à-vis the Central Intelligence Agency (“CIA”) and the IC as a whole.³ Unfortunately, it was not enacted. In 1988, GAO attempted to conduct an investigation “[i]n order to evaluate whether ‘information about illegal activities by high level officials of other nations may not be adequately considered in U.S. foreign policy decisions,’” leading the National Security Council to request an opinion from the Department of Justice Office of Legal Counsel which has been cited ever since:

We therefore conclude based on the nature of the GAO request that the subject of the GAO investigation is the Executive’s discharge of its constitutional

¹ See 31 U.S.C. §§ 712, 717, 3523(a) (GAO has authority to investigate each “department, agency, or instrumentality of the United States Government.”).

² Budget and Accounting Act, Pub. L. 67–13, 42 Stat. 26, June 10, 1921 (“All departments and establishments shall furnish to the Comptroller General such information regarding the powers, duties, activities, organization, financial transactions, and methods of business of their respective offices as he may from time to time require of them.”).

³ H.R. 3603, available at <https://fas.org/irp/eprint/panetta-1987.pdf>.

foreign policy responsibilities, not its statutory responsibilities. The subject is thus not “a program or activity the Government carries out under existing law,” and it is beyond GAO’s authority under 31 U.S.C. § 717(b)....

In addition to the infirmity in GAO’s statutory authority to pursue this investigation, we believe that GAO is specifically precluded by statute from access to intelligence information. In establishing by law the oversight relationship between the intelligence committees and the executive branch, Congress indicated that such oversight would be the exclusive means for Congress to gain access to confidential intelligence information in the possession of the executive branch.

This intelligence oversight system has been codified at 50 U.S.C. § 413. That section sets forth requirements for the Director of Central Intelligence, the heads of all other Federal agencies involved in intelligence activities, and the President to inform the Congress through the intelligence committees (and in some circumstances the Speaker and minority leader of the House of Representatives and the majority and minority leaders of the Senate) of intelligence activities.⁴

Over two decades later, this fight was still underway. When an amendment to the FY2010 Intelligence Authorization Act (“IAA”) sought to reaffirm GAO authority, it prompted a veto threat in the form of a letter from Director of the Office of Management and Budget Peter Orszag,⁵ which Acting Comptroller General Gene Dodaro thoroughly refuted, demonstrating that “[n]either the language of section 413 nor its legislative history provides support for this position” and that the IC’s resistance “has greatly impeded GAO’s work for the intelligence committees and also jeopardizes some of GAO’s work for other committees of jurisdiction, including Armed Services, Appropriations, Judiciary, and Foreign Relations, among others.”⁶

Despite Mr. Dodaro’s testimony, the enacted law took a middle-of-the-road approach, stating that clarification was necessary but deferring to the Executive for that clarification, instructing the Director of National Intelligence (“DNI”) to “issue a written directive governing the access of the Comptroller General to information in the possession of an element of the intelligence community.”⁷ The DNI, for his part, issued Intelligence Community Directive 114 the following year, which reluctantly admitted that GAO had some authority to investigate the IC, but adopted a severely restrictive interpretation of the scope of that authority:

Information that falls within the purview of the congressional intelligence oversight committees generally shall not be made available to GAO to support a GAO audit or review of core national intelligence capabilities and activities, which include intelligence collection operations, intelligence analyses and analytical techniques, counterintelligence operations, and intelligence funding. IC elements may on a case-by-case basis provide information in response to any GAO requests not related to GAO audits or reviews of core national intelligence capabilities and activities.⁸

In other words, GAO can investigate anything involving the IC that the Intelligence Committees cannot, which amounts to basically nothing. Moreover, this is not an academic dispute: in response to a question about this matter from Congressman Yoder in 2018, Mr. Dodaro explained that this remained an ongoing controversy, although the situation is minimally better than it was before 2010:

Mr. YODER. Do you need additional support from Congress—

Mr. DODARO. Yes.

Mr. YODER [continuing]. Or direction to the intel agencies to make sure they are aware that this is an authority you have?

Mr. DODARO. Yes, that would be helpful.⁹

⁴Investigative Authority of the General Accounting Office, 12 Op. Off. Legal Counsel 171 (1988).

⁵Letter from Orszag to Feinstein of 3/15/10, available at <https://fas.org/irp/news/2010/03/omb031610.pdf>.

⁶Letter from Dodaro to Feinstein of 3/18/10, available at <http://www.pogoarchives.org/m/co/dodaro-letter-to-intel-committees-20100318.pdf>. Mr. Dodaro concluded that reaffirming GAO’s authority in this area “would prove beneficial both to the conduct of oversight by the intelligence committees and to the efficiency and effectiveness of IC operations.”

⁷50 U.S.C. § 3308.

⁸ICD 114(D)(4)(b), available at https://www.dni.gov/files/documents/ICD/ICD_114.pdf.

⁹Legislative Branch Appropriations for 2019: Part 2, Fiscal Year 2019 Legislative Branch Appropriations Requests, Hearings before the Subcomm. on the Legislative Branch of the House Comm. on Appropriations, 115th Cong., 2d Sess. 310 (Apr. 25, 2018) (testimony of Comp. Gen. Gene Dodaro) (testifying that GAO has been able to investigate peripheral matters in the IC such as “a facilities area” and contract management in the last few years).

When Mr. Dodaro testified before the House Legislative Branch Appropriations subcommittee in 2019 regarding GAO's FY2020 budget, Chairman Ryan again asked him about this matter, and Mr. Dodaro again remarked that GAO needs "the cooperation of the Intelligence Community" because GAO "ha[s] more difficulties when the request comes from non-intelligence committees," concluding, "I think we could do more, particularly in the management area, and in the investments that are made, in that area, whether there's good return on the investments in all cases."¹⁰ And in his testimony before that subcommittee in 2020, Mr. Dodaro testified, "It's the same status as it was last year. Congress could work with the Intelligence Committees to provide better direction to the intelligence agencies to cooperate with us."¹¹

In fact, however, even the involvement of the Intelligence Committees is not sufficient to overcome the IC's reliance on ICD 114 to obstruct meaningful GAO access. In a meeting in 2019 with staffers from the House Legislative Branch and Defense Appropriations subcommittees, a member of the latter subcommittee's staff dismissed the need for reform, arguing that IC components do not refuse GAO requests for information if GAO was acting pursuant to an Intelligence Committee request. That presumption is unfortunately false. One need only consider the example of AR 13-5, the internal CIA regulation which implements ICD 114. This regulation directly addresses the question of how the Agency should respond to a GAO request for information when GAO is acting under the direction of an Intelligence Committee:

As a general rule, if GAO makes a request on behalf of or to obtain information responsive to a tasking by an intelligence oversight committee, the [Point of Contact ("POC")] will ensure that the CIA response to GAO does not contain information prohibited in paragraph b.(2)(c)(3) above.¹² The response to GAO shall indicate that information responsive to the tasking, but not authorized for release to GAO under the provisions of ICD 114, shall be made directly available to the requesting intelligence oversight committee. The POC shall prepare an additional response for the intelligence oversight committee that contains information responsive to the committee request, but not authorized for GAO access.¹³

In other words, if GAO asks CIA for any information which would fall under the jurisdiction of an Intelligence Committee, CIA will simply refuse to cooperate, but if an Intelligence Committee tasks GAO to make the request, CIA will still refuse to provide the information to GAO, but instead will send the information directly to the relevant Intelligence Committee. In neither situation does GAO receive the requested information.

GAO possesses significantly more resources and institutional expertise in certain kinds of Executive Branch investigations than even the most robust committee staff, and there is frankly no reason for this arbitrary restriction on its authority. Congress gave the Executive Branch a chance to establish reasonable limitations which balanced the Executive's legitimate interests with one of the most important functions of Congress-effective oversight. Instead of crafting a reasonable policy, the DNI memorialized the IC's original hardline position.

I recommend this subcommittee include language to remove any doubt concerning GAO's audit power over the IC by advancing a measure that reStates Section 335 of the FY2010 IAA, as engrossed by the House of Representatives in February 2010.¹⁴

Not only would taking such a measure resolve a longstanding problem, but it would be revenue neutral, since it would not require GAO to take on any more responsibilities than it already has; it would only open the universe of matters it may investigate. When one considers the fact that the number of GAO employees with Top Secret/Sensitive Compartmented Information ("TS/SCI") clearances is higher

¹⁰ Available at <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=G3WU2uZMlyk>.

¹¹ Available at <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=uaRnD62qun4>. Mr. Dodaro's testimony last year reiterated the same point, see <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=-PQWaMSJG7Y>.

¹² That paragraph reads:

Information that falls within the purview of the congressional intelligence oversight committees generally shall not be made available to GAO to support an audit or review of intelligence collection operations; covert action; intelligence capabilities related to national intelligence activities; counterintelligence operations; intelligence analysis and analytical techniques; intelligence sources and methods; or intelligence budgets or funding; (including records or expenditures made under the authority of 22 U.S.C. 2396(a)(8) or 10 U.S.C. 127, 7231 and 50 U.S.C. 403j(b)).

¹³ Available at https://s3.amazonaws.com/demandprogress/documents/2023-03-17-AR_13-5.pdf.

¹⁴ Available at <https://www.gpo.gov/fdsys/pkg/BILLS-111hr2701eh/pdf/BILLS-111hr2701eh.pdf>.

than the combined number of staffers employed by both Intelligence Committees, it is clear that these artificial restrictions on GAO's authority are causing Congress to expend more financial and manpower resources to accomplish less oversight over a significant portion of the Executive Branch. In a time of crisis, when agencies across the Government are spending vast amounts of time, money, and resources to combat a once-in-a-century threat, it is more important that ever that GAO be able to investigate allegations of governmental waste, fraud, abuse, and violations of law wherever they may be found. It is time for Congress to assert its prerogatives to protect its oversight capabilities over all agencies.

[This statement was submitted by Kel McClanahan, Executive Director, National Security Counselors.]

PREPARED STATEMENT OF THE HALO TRUST AND MINES ADVISORY GROUP AMERICA

As the world's largest humanitarian demining organizations, The HALO Trust and Mines Advisory Group (MAG) America protect lives and restore livelihoods for those threatened by explosive hazards. We remove and destroy landmines, improvised explosive devices (IEDs) and other explosive remnants of war and help secure weapons that could fall into the hands of terrorist groups. For 20 years, HALO and MAG have partnered with the U.S. Department of Defense's (DOD) Humanitarian Demining Research and Development (HD R&D) Program in more than 10 countries and territories. This program, implemented by the U.S. Army, specializes in developing and testing innovative technologies to detect and clear landmines, unexploded ordnance (UXO), and IEDs. These technologies increase the effectiveness, efficiency, and safety of demining operations for military and humanitarian use—saving lives and taxpayer money.

The HD R&D team designs technologies to respond to technical challenges in the field, drawing from new commercial technology, equipment currently in use by the DOD, and advanced sensor technology available only through other DOD R&D programs. They then trial prototypes in real field conditions through partnerships with the Department of State's (DOS) humanitarian demining programs. During field evaluations, operators provide feedback on the functionality and effectiveness of the equipment. This allows HD R&D to modify and improve the equipment and increase the U.S. technical capacity to respond to explosive threats.

HD R&D produces four specific outcomes. First, the field evaluation process collects data that helps to improve demining technologies used by the U.S. Armed Forces and to support geographic combatant commands in achieving humanitarian mine action objectives. Second, successfully trialed equipment is used to train and equip explosive disposal units of the U.S. military as well as allied militaries. By equipping partner militaries to address their own explosive threats, U.S. soldiers are more likely to remain out of harm's way. Third, HD R&D equipment saves civilian lives from landmines, most frequently children, and amplifies the impact of American assistance by increasing the amount of clearance performed on DOS projects without increasing costs. Fourth, the HD R&D program supports American jobs by utilizing American manufactured machines and products when possible in their equipment development process.

The HD R&D Program has a track record of success, having performed nearly 250 operational field evaluations in 43 countries since 1995. The program is responsible for developing advanced technology for the Handheld Standoff Mine Detection System (HSTAMIDS), which combines metal detection with ground penetrating radar, the rotary mine comb, designed to efficiently excavate low metal content anti-vehicle mines, and TRAXX, built to cut through hard-to-see tripwires and lift mines from soil. Overall, HD R&D equipment has been used to clear more than 25,300 acres of land, and to destroy more than 400,000 mines and UXO.

As you know, HD R&D now receives funding from the following account: Research, Development, Test & Evaluation, Army/Advanced Component Development & Prototypes/PE: 0603920A/Program Title: Humanitarian Demining. Due to strong bipartisan support, the program received \$21 million in Fiscal Year 2023. However, the FY24 President's Budget proposes only \$9.068 million for HD R&D, which would represent a 57% decrease from the previous year's appropriation. This proposed funding reduction would substantially curtail the ability of the HD R&D program to develop necessary demining equipment that would otherwise protect members of the Armed Forces.

HD R&D equipment has created huge cost savings for humanitarian demining programs managed by the State Department through increased efficiencies. Through the deployment of HD R&D-developed HSTAMIDS detectors, HALO's program in Zimbabwe estimates a cost savings of approximately \$16 million over the last 6

years and the program was able to clear in 5 years what would have otherwise taken eight. The Rebel Crusher, a mobile soil sifter and rock crusher used by MAG in Lebanon and Iraq has allowed for mine clearance at a rate five times faster than with a traditional demining team. Remote-controlled Robocut machines, used to cut through tripwires in Ukraine, has accelerated clearance rates by an estimated 400%. The Wirehound in Afghanistan, used to identify hard-to-detect IED components, has increased clearance by over 200% compared to traditional methods. The FAE Mulcher, a vegetation clearing tool being used by MAG in Cambodia, can clear 200% more area than a single deminer using a handheld strimmer. Investing in resources for HD R&D will allow humanitarian and military deminers to eliminate threats far more quickly.

Innovative technology developed by HD R&D also protects deminers. Advanced machines including the Mini MineWolf and the Medium MineWolf, can operate remotely to physically destroy anti-personnel (AP) and anti-tank (AT) landmines with no threat to demining personnel.

This program has a long list of unfunded projects it is waiting to trial, including magnetic technology in Iraq. HD R&D equipment will also be essential to demining efforts in Ukraine, where technological advancements are already beginning to support the removal of mines and various items of unexploded ordnance in urban areas from the current conflict.

We appreciate the support this subcommittee has provided for this valuable program, and urge the subcommittee to raise funding to a level of \$23 million in FY24 for HD R&D. This additional funding will improve the ability of U.S. soldiers and our allies' ability to safely detect and clear landmines, UXO, and IEDs. This funding is especially important as new conflicts uncover new challenges in Ukraine and the Middle East.

Thank you for your consideration of this request.

[This statement was submitted by Chris Whatley, Executive Director, The HALO Trust and Jamie Franklin, Executive Director, Mines Advisory Group America.]

PREPARED STATEMENT OF THE HUMAN FACTORS AND ERGONOMICS SOCIETY

On behalf of the Human Factors and Ergonomics Society (HFES), we are pleased to provide this written testimony to the Senate subcommittee on Defense and Related Agencies for the official record. HFES urges the subcommittee to provide robust funding levels for Research, Development, Test, and Evaluation (RDT&E) at the Department of Defense (DOD) in the fiscal year (FY) 2024 appropriations process. Specifically, we urge the subcommittee to direct DOD to identify opportunities across the services to transition human performance research to defense RDT&E activities and acquisition programs to reduce cost, strengthen force protection, reduce the potential for re-engineering, and enhance training.

HFES and its members believe strongly that investment in scientific research serves as an important driver for innovation and the economy, and for maintaining American global competitiveness. Accordingly, we thank the subcommittee for its longtime recognition of the value of scientific and engineering research, and its contribution to innovation in the U.S.

THE VALUE OF HUMAN FACTORS AND ERGONOMICS SCIENCE

HFES is a multidisciplinary, professional association with over 3,500 individual members worldwide, including psychologists, scientists, engineers, and designers, all with a common interest in designing safe and effective systems and equipment that maximize and adapt to human capabilities.

For over 50 years, the U.S. Federal Government has funded scientists and engineers to explore and better understand the relationship between humans, technology, and the environment. Originally stemming from urgent needs to improve the performance of humans using complex systems such as aircraft during World War II, the field of human factors and ergonomics (HF/E) works to develop safe, effective, and practical human use of technology. HF/E does this by developing scientific approaches for understanding this complex interface, also known as "human-systems integration." Today, HF/E is applied to fields as diverse as transportation, architecture, environmental design, consumer products, electronics and computers, energy systems, medical devices, manufacturing, office automation, organizational design and management, aging, farming, health, sports and recreation, oil field operations, mining, forensics, and education.

With increasing reliance by Federal agencies and the private sector on technology-aided decision-making, HF/E is vital to effectively achieving our National objectives.

While a large portion of HF/E research exists at the intersection of science and practice—that is, HF/E is often viewed more at the “applied” end of the science continuum—the field also contributes to advancing “fundamental” scientific understanding of the interface between human decision-making, engineering, design, technology, and the world around us. The reach of HF/E is profound, touching nearly all aspects of human life from the healthcare sector to the ways we travel, to the hand-held devices we use every day.

HUMAN FACTORS AND ERGONOMICS AT THE DEPARTMENT OF DEFENSE

HFES strongly believes that Federal investments in DOD-funded research will have a direct and positive impact on national security, the economy, and the overall safety and well-being of Americans. For this, HFES supports robust funding for DOD RDT&E programs, including HF/E research programs across the Services to encourage further advancements in technology and safety, among other areas.

With the creation of the Department of Defense Human Factors Engineering Technical Group (DOD HFE TAG), DOD has demonstrated the value it places on the inclusion of HF/E-related research and has acknowledged the benefit of inter-agency collaboration, as it relates to RDT&E in this field. DOD HFE TAG is comprised of technical representatives from DOD, the National Aeronautical and Space Association (NASA), the Federal Aviation Administration (FAA), the Department of Homeland Security (DHS), and the Department of Veterans Affairs (VA).

The scope of this working group is broad, making its benefits diverse. The goals of DOD HFE TAG are to:

- Provide a mechanism for the timely exchange of technical information in the development and application of human factors engineering.
- Enhance coordination among government agencies involved in HF/E technology research, development, and application.
- Assist in the preparation and coordination of tri-service documents, and sponsor in-depth interaction, which aids in identifying HF/E technical issues and technology gaps.

In addition, the American National Standards Institute recently approved ANSI/HFES 400–2021, the Human Readiness Level Scale in System Development Process. This standard, created by HFES, defines the nine levels of the Human Readiness Level (HRL) scale and provides guidance for their application in the context of systems engineering and human systems integration processes. The HRL scale both complements and supplements the existing Technology Readiness Level scale to evaluate, track, and communicate the readiness of a technology or system for safe and effective human use.

HFES strongly believes that all DOD programs developing new technologies should be required to report to the Department on the HRL of their systems on an annual basis. The HRL should be reported for each major component of new military systems, and should be used to identify deficiencies and areas where additional attention to human-system integration is warranted to reduce risks to program schedules, human safety, and effectiveness. DOD’s HRL scale should correspond to the requirements set forth in ANSI/HFES 400–2021. By incorporating this standard DOD will better understand if needed human-system integration activities have been conducted before deploying new national security systems and technologies.

Continuing to prioritize HF/E research at DOD, along with incorporating the Department’s use of the HRL system would undoubtedly produce positive impacts on the safety and well-being of American citizens.

CONCLUSION

Given DOD’s critical role in supporting fundamental research and development across defense and engineering disciplines, HFES supports robust funding levels for DOD RDT&E programs, especially those that specifically fund human factors RDT&E activities, in FY 2024 as well as improvements to the inclusion of human systems integration in acquisition programs. These investments fund important research studies, enabling an evidence base, methodology, and measurements for improving organizational function, performance, and design across sectors and disciplines.

On behalf of the HFES, we would like to thank you for the opportunity to provide this testimony. Please do not hesitate to contact us should you have any questions about HFES or HF/E research. HFES truly appreciates the subcommittee’s long history of support for scientific research and innovation.

[This statement was submitted by Carolyn Sommerich, President and Steven C. Kemp, CAE, Executive Director, Human Factors and Ergonomics Society.]

PREPARED STATEMENT OF JUMP AERO

Dear Members of the U.S. Senate Committee on Appropriations, subcommittee on Defense,

Emergency response times for 46 million rural Americans are twice as long as response times in urban areas. This disparity contributes to higher mortality rates in 430,000 time-critical medical emergencies each year in rural America. Dual-use electric vertical takeoff and landing (eVTOL) technologies such as those being developed at Jump Aero have the potential to cut rural response times in half—helping first responders save an additional 100,000 lives each year in the United States.

The U.S. Air Force's Agility Prime program has been instrumental in catalyzing and accelerating the development of Jump Aero's lifesaving eVTOL technology. The Agility Prime program should have the full support of all who care about improving emergency response outcomes for both the warfighter and rural Americans.

Beyond Jump Aero's particular mission, it is strategically critical that the United States assume a global leadership role in the emerging advanced air mobility industry. As an experienced aviation entrepreneur, I can say with certainty that funding the Agility Prime program is the most direct and impactful avenue to achieving the goal of US leadership in advanced air mobility. It will continue to help small companies like Jump Aero develop and deliver on our life-saving promise. I ask that the committee consider increasing funding for the Agility Prime program.

I would be happy to make time to elaborate on any of the points above if given the opportunity. Thank you for your due consideration.

Best regards,
Carl Dietrich
Founder & CEO
carl@jumpaero.com

[This statement was submitted by Carl Dietrich, Ph.D., Founder & CEO, Jump Aero.]

PREPARED STATEMENT OF THE NEUROFIBROMATOSIS NETWORK

Thank you for the opportunity to submit testimony to the subcommittee on the importance of continued funding for the Department of Defense's Peer-reviewed Neurofibromatosis (NF) Research Program (NFRP). NF is a terrible genetic disorder closely linked to many common diseases widespread among the American population. The highly successful Neurofibromatosis Research Program has shown tangible results and direct military application with broad implications for the general population.

On behalf of the Neurofibromatosis (NF) Network, a national organization of NF advocacy groups, I speak on behalf of the 120,000 Americans who suffer from NF as well as the millions of Americans who suffer from diseases and conditions linked to NF such as cancer, brain tumors, heart disease, memory loss, bone abnormalities, deafness, blindness, and psychosocial disabilities, such as autism and learning disabilities. Thanks in large part to this subcommittee's strong support, scientists have made enormous progress since the discovery of the NF1 gene in 1990 resulting in clinical trials now being undertaken by the NFRP.

In Fiscal Year 2024, we are requesting at least \$25 million for the Peer-reviewed Neurofibromatosis Research Program (NFRP) within the Defense Health Program, the same as the Fiscal Year 2023 enacted level. The NFRP is now conducting clinical trials at nation-wide clinical trials centers created by NFRP funding. These clinical trials involve drugs that have already succeeded in eliminating tumors in humans and rescuing learning deficits in mice. In addition, in March 2020, the Food and Drug Administration approved the first ever drug, co-developed by NIH and AstraZeneca, with seed money from the NFRP, for the treatment of plexiform tumors in neurofibromatosis type 1 (NF1). Administrators of the NFRP have stated that the number of high-quality scientific applications justify a much larger program. For these reasons, it is imperative that we continue to invest in research if we are to advance toward treatments and a cure for the numerous diseases associated with NF.

WHAT IS NEUROFIBROMATOSIS (NF)?

NF is an unpredictable genetic disorder of the nervous system that affects almost every organ system in the body. There are three types of NF: NF1, which is more common, NF2, which initially involves tumors causing deafness and balance problems, and Schwannomatosis, the hallmark of which is severe pain. NF causes tu-

mors to grow along nerves including in the skin, just below the skin, and in the brain and spinal cord. NF is the most common neurological disorder caused by a single gene and affects more people than Cystic Fibrosis, hereditary Muscular Dystrophy, Huntington's disease and Tay Sachs combined. It strikes worldwide, without regard to gender, race or ethnicity. Approximately 50 percent of new NF cases result from a spontaneous mutation in an individual's genes and 50 percent are inherited.

NF can cause a myriad of devastating clinical problems including nerve and brain tumors; disfiguring skin growths; inability to heal after bone fracture, which may ultimately require amputation; psychosocial disabilities, including autism and learning disabilities; unmanageable chronic pain; deafness; blindness; cardiovascular defects; vascular disease; and paralysis. NF gene mutations are also important 'drivers' of cancers in the lungs, liver, brain and breast.

NF'S CONNECTION TO THE MILITARY

Neurofibromatosis (NF) has become a clinical 'model' for advancing medical research. The genetic information learned from NF holds the key to understanding a number of health issues that benefit the war fighter, as well as the general population, including cancer, bone fracture and repair, vascular disease, nerve regeneration, behavior and psychosocial issues, and pain.

The Neurofibromatosis Research Program (NFRP) is providing critical research that directly benefits the War Fighter including:

Bone Repair.—At least a quarter of children with NF1 have abnormal bone growth in any part of the skeleton. In the legs, the long bones are weak, prone to fracture and unable to heal properly; this can require amputation at a young age. Adults with NF1 can have low bone mineral density, placing them at risk of skeletal weakness and injury. The NFRP is a strong supporter of NF1 bone defects research and as a result this field has made significant progress in the past few years. Bone fractures sustained by the war fighter and how to repair them is of interest to the military. Research studies will identify new information about understanding bone biology and repair and will pave the way to new strategies to enhancing bone health and facilitating repair.

Pain.—Severe and unmanageable pain is seen in all forms of NF, particularly in schwannomatosis, and significantly impacts quality of life. NF research has shown similarities between NF pain and phantom limb pain. NFRP funding has been critical in supporting this. Chronic pain, and how to treat it effectively, is one of the most poorly understood areas of medicine but has very high relevance to those in the military recovering from service-related injuries. NF Research in this area could help identify new ways to target pain effectively with the right drugs or therapies.

Vascular Disease.—NF1 elevates the risk of vascular disease including aneurysm, stroke and vessel occlusive disease. NF1 predisposes patients to early cardiovascular disease, which is also the leading cause of death among United States Veterans. NF research has demonstrated that when treating affected NF mouse models with an antioxidant medication it reduced vessel disease. Discoveries related to cardiovascular disease in NF1 are likely to be more broadly informative, including for veterans and active-duty military personnel.

Psychosocial and Cognitive Disabilities.—NFRP research has revealed common threads between NF1 learning disabilities, autism and other related disabilities. Research being done within the NF Clinical Trials Consortium, NFRP created clinical centers, has led to important findings and expanded research in this area. This research contributes to our broadening understanding of how brain signaling can impact on behavior and psychosocial difficulties. Members of the military returning from service can suffer from psychological trauma and it is not easy to understand how this can be effectively treated. As we learn more from the NF population about psychosocial function, we will be able to shed light on this area for the benefit of the military.

Nerve Tumors and Repair.—Nerves are the most common location for tumor development among patients with NF1, NF2, and schwannomatosis. Tumor growth alone, or treatments for the same, commonly cause nerve injury and associated deficits. Identifying mechanisms to improve nerve repair would benefit patients with NF, as well as advance the science needed to better treat nerve injury common in warfighters.

DOD' CONTRIBUTION TO NF RESEARCH

While other Federal agencies support medical research, the Department of Defense (DOD) fills a special role by providing peer-reviewed funding for innovative and rewarding medical research through the Congressionally Directed Medical Research Program (CDMRP). CDMRP research grants are awarded to researchers in

every State in the country through a competitive two-tier review process. These well-executed and efficient programs, including the NFRP, demonstrate the government's responsible stewardship of taxpayer dollars.

Recognizing NF's importance to both the military and to the general population, Congress has given the NF Research Program strong bipartisan support. From FY1996 through FY2023 funding for the NFRP has amounted to \$427.85 million, in addition to the original \$8 million appropriated in FY1992. In addition, between FY1996 and FY2021, 471 awards have been granted to researchers across the country.

The CDMRP funds innovative, groundbreaking research which would not otherwise have been pursued, and has produced major advances in NF research, including conducting clinical trials in a nation-wide clinical trials infrastructure created by NFRP funding, development of advanced animal models, and preclinical therapeutic experimentation. Because of the enormous advances that have been made as a result of the NFRP, research in NF has truly become one of the great success stories in the current revolution in molecular genetics. In addition, the program has brought new researchers into the field of NF. However, despite this progress, Army officials administering the program have indicated that they could easily fund more applications if funding were available because of the high quality of the research applications received.

In order to ensure maximum efficiency, the Army collaborates closely with other Federal agencies that are involved in NF research, such as the National Institutes of Health (NIH). Senior program staff from the National Institute of Neurological Disorders and Stroke (NINDS), for example, sit on the NF Research Program Integration Panel which sets the long-term vision and funding strategies for the program. This assures the highest scientific standard for research funding, efficiency and coordination while avoiding duplication or overlapping of research efforts.

Thanks in large part to this subcommittee's support, scientists have made enormous progress since the discovery of the NF1 gene. Major advances in just the past few years have ushered in an exciting era of clinical and translational research in NF with broad implications for the general population. These recent advances have included:

- In March 2020 the Food and Drug Administration approved the first ever drug, co-developed by NIH and AstraZeneca, with seed money from the NFRP, for the treatment of plexiform tumors in neurofibromatosis type 1 (NF1).
- Phase II and Phase III clinical trials involving new drug therapies for both cancer, hearing tumors, vision tumors, bone graft and cognitive disorders.
- Establishment of the Neurofibromatosis Clinical Trial Consortium which includes an operation center and 25 clinical sites. Allows for partnerships with well-established NF Centers, pooling expertise and resources, quicker turn arounds of scientific reviews and regulatory approvals, leveraged work with pharmaceutical companies all towards the common goal of new treatments and a cure for Neurofibromatosis.
- Successful elimination of tumors in NF1 and NF2 mice with the same drug.
- Development of advanced mouse models showing human symptoms.
- Rescue of learning deficits in mice with an already existing well known drug.
- Determination of the biochemical, molecular function of the NF genes and gene products.
- Connection of NF to numerous diseases because of NF's impact on many body functions.

FISCAL YEAR 2024 REQUEST

The highly successful NF Research Program has shown tangible results and direct military application with broad implications for the general population. The program has now advanced to the translational and clinical research stages, which are the most promising, yet the most expensive direction that NF research has taken. Therefore, continued funding is needed to continue to build on the successes of this program, and to fund this promising research thereby continuing the enormous return on the taxpayers' investment.

We respectfully request that you include at least \$25 million in the Fiscal Year 2024 Department of Defense Appropriations bill for the Peer-reviewed Neurofibromatosis Research Program. With this subcommittee's continued support, we will prevail. Thank you for your support.

[This statement was submitted by Kim Bischoff, Executive Director, The Neurofibromatosis Network.]

PREPARED STATEMENT OF THE SOCIETY FOR INDUSTRIAL AND
ORGANIZATIONAL PSYCHOLOGY

On behalf of the Society for Industrial and Organizational Psychology (SIOP), we are pleased to provide this written testimony to the Senate Appropriations subcommittee on Defense for the official record. In this testimony, SIOP urges the subcommittee to increase social science funding within the Department of Defense, including through the Minerva Research Initiative.

CONTINUED SUPPORT FOR SOCIAL SCIENCES

SIOP encourages Congress to continue funding for social science research at the Department of Defense. Inquiry into social and behavioral sciences, including topics covered by industrial and organizational (I-O) psychology, is critical to ensuring our National security, allowing military and civilian officials to better understand our adversaries and the social and political context that influences future conflicts. I-O psychology is the study of human behavior in the workplace, including pressing national security topics such as hiring and selection of individuals suited to high-risk jobs, enabling better collaboration between service branches using team science, improving morale and productivity, and examining training and onboarding procedures. I-O psychology research contributes to the Department's readiness mission by improving warfighter performance and providing evidence-based best practices on organizational structure and teaming. We therefore ask that you continue to support I-O psychology by providing no less than \$37 million to the Minerva Research Initiative part of the Department's Defense Wide Basic Research Initiatives program, a \$20 million increase.

Minerva is the Department's premier social science program, informing topics like cyber defense, social impacts of autonomy, deterrence, and sociopolitical instability, and supporting the societal and technological objectives of the 2022 National Defense Strategy by providing a basis for integrated social sciences (religion, politics, social culture, and history) into DOD's tactical and strategic operations. Leveraging the social sciences helps the military understand, anticipate, and prevail in the face of challenges defined by rapid technological change, adversaries in every operating domain, and a combination of conventional threats with state and non-state actors and individuals capable of interrupting diplomatic and political activities through disinformation and cyber activities.

The knowledge created through sound social science research—the hallmark of the Minerva program—is critical to the Department's development of complex military strategies that address threats and challenges across the full spectrum of military action. Minerva's cutting-edge social science research sets the foundation for a better understanding of current and future conflicts and arms decision-makers with knowledge about the social, cultural, behavioral, and political dynamics that shape our global interactions.

Thank you for the opportunity to offer SIOP's support for DOD research. Please do not hesitate to contact SIOP should you have any questions. Additional information is also available at www.siop.org.

[This statement was submitted by Dr. Mo Wang, President and Tracy L. Vanneman, Executive Director, Society for Industrial and Organizational Psychology.]

PREPARED STATEMENT OF TB ALLIANCE

TB Alliance is pleased to submit this testimony to the Senate Committee on Appropriations, subcommittee on Defense for consideration in fiscal year (FY) 2024 appropriations. TB Alliance is a not-for-profit organization dedicated to the discovery, development, and delivery of better, faster acting and affordable tuberculosis drugs that are available to those who need them. We submit this testimony and urge the subcommittee to once again include Tuberculosis (TB) in the Congressionally Directed Medical Research Program's Peer Reviewed Medical Research Program's (CDMRP PRMRP) list of eligible diseases in FY 2024 as it did the previous fiscal year.

As you know, the men and women in our armed forces are responsible for protecting our Nation from threats both domestic and abroad. A critical element of DoD's mission is supporting infectious disease research, which it conducts at various facilities such as the Walter Reed Army Institute of Research and the Naval Medical Research Center. Since DoD cannot programmatically fund every disease that could cause harm to our Nation's military personnel, Congress fills this gap in research through the CDMRP, which presents a critical opportunity for Congress to

directly influence research funding by providing a list of approved diseases eligible for competitive peer reviewed grant opportunities via the PRMRP.

TB, an airborne disease, is the second leading global infectious killer globally—just behind COVID-19—with about 1.6 million deaths in 2021 according to the World Health Organization (WHO). The global TB pandemic, including the rapid spread of drug-resistant TB, poses a serious global security threat. Although considered a low-incidence country, every US state continues to report TB cases each year and the airborne disease continues to be a significant public health issue. According to the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC), there are up to 13 million individuals in the U.S. with latent TB infections; a future reservoir of active TB cases. In 2021, the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention reported nearly 8,000 cases of TB in the U.S. The cost to treat and care for a patient with TB in the US averages \$20,000 for drug-susceptible TB, \$182,000 for MDR-TB, and \$568,000 for XDR-TB according to most recent estimates.

TB also remains of particular concern for the Department of Defense (DoD) because of its potential impact on our armed forces. Our global military footprint means that American military men and women are posted in countries and regions that experience high rates of both active TB disease and TB infection. For instance, in Europe, where over 100,000 U.S. troops and dependents are stationed, there were nearly 164,000 cases of TB and 73,000 cases of MDR-TB in 2021. In the Western Pacific region, nearly 82,000 troops live amidst over 1.8 million cases of TB and 70,000 cases of MDR-TB according to the most recent WHO estimates. Ukraine alone had an estimated 31,000 cases of TB and 11,000 cases of MDR-TB. With the war in Ukraine sadly ongoing, millions of Ukrainians are seeking refuge in NATO ally countries, some of whom are on TB treatment or have undiagnosed TB. Outbreaks of MDR-TB around the world could cause drug shortages, severe economic consequences, and possibly extensive fatalities as well as global destabilization. Funding research and development now can make this scenario less likely in the future.

Additionally, through programs like the Pacific Pathways, thousands of US military members rotate through countries around the Pacific Rim like the Philippines and Thailand to strengthen our military alliances, where a combined 844,000 cases of TB occurred in 2021, including thousands of cases of MDR-TB. However, the WHO estimates that global TB numbers are actually much higher than currently reported due to disruptions in diagnosis stemming from the COVID-19 pandemic and resource diversion.

For these reasons, more research into TB and related treatments, vaccines, and diagnostics is imperative if we want to avoid tragic scenarios of MDR- and XDR-TB outbreaks in the future. Having adequate treatments on hand in case our warfighters fall ill with TB is critical to our military's mission readiness and our National security. Today, we are at a unique and unprecedented point in TB research due to positive advancements in key areas of development. Recently, the FDA approved a new drug regimen to treat XDR-TB and complicated MDR-TB—demonstrating that better diagnostics, a fully effective vaccine, and shorter, less toxic treatment regimens are the only way we will successfully eliminate TB. The DoD CDMRP funding has been integral in these efforts.

We thank the subcommittee for its previous inclusion of TB in the CDMRP PRMRP in FY 2023. However, we urge you to build off the progress already made and continue to include TB in the list of eligible diseases for FY 2024.

Respectfully,

[This statement was submitted by Pietro Turilli, Senior Vice President, External Affairs, TB Alliance.]

PREPARED STATEMENT OF THE TriSERVICE NURSING RESEARCH PROGRAM

We are writing to ask you to consider an issue critical to military health care in the FY 24 NDAA budget: line-item funding in the DHP budget and an amount of \$12 million for the TriService Nursing Research Program (TSNRP), a program that continues to have a positive impact on servicemembers and the health care professionals that care for them and their families.

TSNRP has a 30-year history of providing value-added research conducted by PhD prepared active duty, reserve component and retired military nurses on relevant healthcare issues that are important to servicemembers and their families, as well as combat-related care not replicated elsewhere in the DHA or civilian medicine. TSNRP is the Nation's first and only Federal research program that supports military nurses to conduct research on the reserve and active-duty populations and

translate that knowledge into evidence-based practices. Neither the NIH/National Institute of Nursing Research nor the VA fund research on this population.

Until FY 2023, when Congress more than doubled its budget, TSNRP funding levels have remained static since 1992; in the past two decades, funding remained at \$6M annually. TSNRP has been funded either through congressionally directed funding or by DOD, through use of USUHS O&M dollars that are fungible and movable to meet other needs. Though authorized in 10USC 2116, TSNRP has an uncertain future should budget cuts force the elimination of this valued research program as was the case in FY 2020. Without this program, there is no dedicated funding stream for military nurse researchers to continue the vital research that has saved lives and significantly improved the care of our Nation's warfighters. It is time to place TSNRP in its own line item in the budget to ensure its sustainability and to raise the funding level so more studies by nurse researchers can be funded. We need your support to maintain funding for TSNRP (\$12M) and create a line item for it in the NDAA budget for FY24 and throughout the remainder of the 24–27 FYDP.

Military nurses have been conducting research to improve force readiness and patient care since the 1950s. With the financial support of the TSNRP in the 1990s, military nursing research has expanded with notable results. TSNRP also supports the dissertation research and translation projects of military doctoral students in nursing schools around the country to improve health and quality of life outcomes for servicemembers and their families. TSNRP requires that funded researchers provide mentorship to new researchers, ensuring knowledge and skills are passed from year to year and along generations of military researchers.

SELECT TSNRP DISCOVERIES

- Home-based and field therapy with self-managed electrical stimulation devices relieving both knee and back pain, helping service members return to duty more quickly and maintain Force Readiness.
- Specific ventilator settings result in better methods of weaning patients from life support.
- CoQ10 supplements decrease brain cell injury, potentially mitigating TBI.
- Powdered clotting agents stop hemorrhage in wounded soldiers, saving lives after severe blood loss from injury on the battlefield.
- Pocket devices allowing women on the battlefield to care for personal and hygiene needs without embarrassment.
- Certain transport litters decrease the chance of skin ulcers in wounded service members while in field situations and in transport to fixed military facilities.
- Blood markers exist for genetic Vitamin D deficiency, and Vitamin D supplements in this population improves bone health, reducing stress fracture injuries that often occur during physically demanding military training.
- Mental and ethical preparation and resilience training helps service members function better mentally and emotionally in combat, and upon returning home.
- Complementary treatment modalities such as acupressure can be done in field settings.
- Soldiers who receive their care in Soldier Centered Medical Homes recover and resume basic training more quickly than those who receive care in a typical medical clinic.
- Better nurse staffing in military hospitals is associated with fewer medication errors. Burnout in military nurses is linked to low quality of patient care, job dissatisfaction and intent to leave the job and/or the military. Ongoing TSNRP-funded research during the pandemic will provide an update on the military nurse workforce.

SELECT TSNRP OUTCOMES

- TSNRP research assisted families to cope with deployment; addressed gaps in care for active-duty women; ameliorated long-term effects of PTSD on family caregivers; improved the quality of life for burn survivors; and improved patient safety.
- The TSNRP Women's Health Research Interest Group (WHRIG) recently hosted the inaugural virtual Women in Combat Seminar, which provided education to thousands of participants globally and included topics such as operational performance, mission readiness, and health and well-being.
- TSNRP has been the leader in evidence-based practice and implementation science in the military healthcare system. The program funds not only research, but also supports education and guidance to implement the research. It aims to ensure that nurses are using the most up-to-date practices to provide bene-

ficiaries the best care possible on the battlefield, in transport, and in military facilities.

In summary, TSNRP funded research has been responsible for enhanced injury resuscitation protocols, improved air-evacuation processes, increased readiness of warfighters through bench science research, behavioral and nutritional research, and widespread implementation of evidence-based practices. One need only peruse the funded studies to find sophisticated methodologies in a far-reaching array of research from TSNRP funded scientists. For more about TSNRP, visit the website at www.triservicenurse.org

[This statement was submitted by Hon. Linda S. Schwartz, Maj. (Ret), U.S. Air Force; MG (Ret) Margaret C. Wilmoth, U.S. Army Reserve; BG (Ret) William Bester, U.S. Army; COL (Ret) Patricia A. Patrician, U.S. Army; LTC (Ret) Deborah Kenny, U.S. Army.]

PREPARED STATEMENT OF YOUNG MARINES

The Young Marines thank the Senate Committee on Appropriations, subcommittee on Defense for this opportunity to provide testimony in support of the Young Marines program. Young Marines is a 501c3 national youth program for boys and girls ages 8 to high school. The program focuses on leadership development, citizenship through community service, and living a healthy drug free lifestyle. This includes fitness programs and extensive drug demand reduction education. We are the largest single program with a focus on drug demand reduction education for youth. Over 6 thousand youth members participated in FY22 nationwide, over 200 thousand have been members since our start in 1959. Historical data shows approximately 30% of alumni members enter military service with a similar cohort for teaching and first responders.

The last few years have produced volumes of reports regarding the challenges to our current generation of youth. Obesity, suicide, depression, poor overall fitness, negative social media impacts, difficulties with personal interaction, and increased dangers from new and extremely deadly drugs are all contributing to one of the most dangerous and difficult periods for our Nation's youngest member's personal development. This is reflected in numerous current studies about their declining mental health and ability to be engaged members of our society and future workforce. Young Marines does not profess to be the answer for all children, but our unique combination of programs has proven extremely effective for its members.

Last year we spanned over 230 locations across 40 States, the District of Columbia, and military bases in Okinawa, Japan. The Young Marines mission is supported by over 2 thousand volunteers and a paid staff of just ten, making it extremely cost effective. Program interest is strong coming out of COVID. New unit starts are over double the previous averages of the last 5 years and we are spreading into new areas of the country. Young Marines youth membership is also coming back after the difficulties of meeting during the pandemic. Pre-pandemic membership was over 8 thousand. We continue to receive the highest rating from multiple independent non-profit reviewing organizations. A detailed map and other program information can be found on our website www.youngmarines.org.

Young Marines has experienced tremendous growth in size and capability over the last decade due in key part to an annual Congressional Grant for \$4M started in FY10. The grant has been placed in the Defense Appropriations Bill: Title VI, Other Defense Programs, Drug Interdiction and Counter-Drug Activities Defense (DICD), Drug Demand Reduction (DDR). Young Marines did not receive grant funds for the last 2 years due to FY22 and FY23 Omnibus Appropriations process. The program is running off residual grant funds and reserves but will soon be forced to make hard choices on how to continue. These funds provide the structure and support to run the general program activities, training and education for youth and adults, and institutional risk management programs to ensure a sound and safe youth development program. The funds keep programs affordable to larger cohorts and support critical drug demand reduction education missions which are not a normal activity for youth programs. The drug demand reduction mission is a main pillar of the program, and Young Marines must complete required hours to advance or take part in unique events within the program. Furthermore, Young Marines earn additional credit for taking the drug demand reduction education mission to their local communities and peers. Last year we provided over 50 thousand hours of drug demand reduction educational activities in our communities even with COVID constraints, in recent years past we routinely provide over 100 thousand hours of drug demand education to local communities. Last year saw record drug overdose deaths across the country. Young Marines works to educate its volunteers, parents, and youth

members along with local communities of the extraordinary dangers of current drugs. These efforts have seen the Young Marines program win the annual Department of Defense Fulcrum Shield award for Drug Demand Education excellence 12 times, numerous awards from the Drug Enforcement Administration, and multiple awards from other public organizations.

The Young Marines program directly supports future personnel needs of the Department of Defense, National Security workforce, the Intelligence Community, Federal Government, over 7 million critical transportation jobs, and professions requiring a drug free workforce. The Young Marines program exposes youth to the value of service in and out of uniform. Contact at Bill.davis@youngmarines.org.

We appreciate the consideration of the subcommittee members in supporting various FY24 requests by members of the Senate. We also appreciate the support of the subcommittee in reconciliation with the House of Representatives Defense Appropriations efforts in support to our program.

[This statement was submitted by Col William P. Davis, USMC (Ret), CEO, Young Marines.]

LIST OF WITNESSES, COMMUNICATIONS, AND PREPARED STATEMENTS

	Page
American Urological Association, Prepared Statement of the	325
Austin, Hon. Lloyd J., III, Secretary, Office of the Secretary of Defense,	
Department of Defense	185
Prepared Statement of	190
Questions Submitted to	236
Summary Statement of	188
Baldwin, Senator Tammy, U.S. Senator From Wisconsin, Questions Sub-	
mitted by	84, 177, 242
Bellon, Lieutenant General David G., Commander, Marine Forces Reserve,	
Department of Defense	269
Prepared Statement of	271
Questions Submitted to	322
Berger, General David H., Commandant of the United States Marine Corps,	
Department of Defense	30
Prepared Statement of	32
Questions Submitted to	86
Boozman, Senator John, U.S. Senator From Arkansas, Questions Submitted	
by	81, 85, 88, 181
Brown, General Charles Q., Jr., Air Force Chief of Staff, Department of	
Defense	95
Prepared Statement of	99
Questions Submitted to	136
Capito, Senator Shelley Moore, U.S. Senator From West Virginia, Questions	
Submitted by	138, 182, 247
Collins, Senator Susan M., U.S. Senator From Maine:	
Questions Submitted by	244
Statements of	2, 92, 186, 252
Daniels, Lieutenant General Jody J., Chief of Army Reserve, Department	
of Defense	257
Prepared Statement of	258
Questions Submitted to	320
Durbin, Senator Richard J., U.S. Senator From Illinois, Questions Submitted	
by	239
Feinstein, Senator Dianne, U.S. Senator from California, Questions Sub-	
mitted by	79
Gilday, Admiral Michael M., Chief of Naval Operations, Department of De-	
fense	16
Prepared Statement of	18
Questions Submitted to	81
Government Accountability Office, Prepared Statement of the	326
Graham, Senator Lindsey, U.S. Senator From South Carolina, Questions	
Submitted by	178, 247
HALO Trust and Mines Advisory Group America, Prepared Statement of	
The	329
Healy, Lieutenant General John P., Chief of Air Force Reserve, Department	
of Defense	286
Prepared Statement of	287

	Page
Healy, Lieutenant General John P., Chief of Air Force Reserve, Department of Defense—Continued	
Questions Submitted to	322
Hoeven, Senator John, U.S. Senator From North Dakota, Question Submitted by.....	136, 137, 181, 184, 319, 323
Hokanson, General Daniel R., Chief, National Guard and Reserve, Department of Defense	251
Prepared Statement of	254
Questions Submitted to	315
Summary Statement of	253
Human Factors and Ergonomics Society, Prepared Statement of the	330
Jump Aero, Prepared Statement of	332
Kendall, Hon. Frank, Secretary, Office of the Secretary, Department of the Air Force, Department of Defense	91
Prepared Statement of	99
Questions Submitted to	133
Summary Statement of	93
McConville, General James C., Chief of Staff, Department of the Army, Department of Defense	148
Prepared Statement of	149
Questions Submitted to	183
McCord, Hon. Michael J., Under Secretary of Defense (Comptroller)/Chief Financial Officer, Department of Defense	185
Milley, General Mark A., Chairman, Joint Chiefs of Staff, Department of Defense	199
Prepared Statement of	201
Questions Submitted to	248
Moran, Senator Jerry, U.S. Senator From Kansas, Questions Submitted by.....	80, 85, 144, 178, 183
Murkowski, Senator Lisa, U.S. Senator From Alaska, Questions Submitted by.....	79, 84, 134, 138, 244, 319, 323
Murray, Senator Patty, U.S. Senator from Washington, Statement of	53
Mustin, Vice Admiral John B., Chief of Navy Reserve, Department of Defense	263
Prepared Statement of	264
Questions Submitted to	321
Neurofibromatosis Network, Prepared Statement of The	332
Saltzman, General B. Chance, Chief of Space Operations, United States Space Force, Department of Defense	97
Prepared Statement of	99
Questions Submitted to	138
Schatz, Senator Brian, U.S. Senator From Hawaii, Questions Submitted by	241, 316
Shaheen, Senator Jeanne, U.S. Senator From New Hampshire, Questions Submitted by	318
Society for Industrial and Organizational Psychology, Prepared Statement of the	335
TB Alliance, Prepared Statement of	335
Tester, Senator Jon, U.S. Senator From Montana:	
Opening Statements of.....	1, 91, 143, 185, 251
Questions Submitted by	75, 81, 86, 133, 136, 176, 183, 236, 248, , 315, 320, 321, 322
Toro, Hon. Carlos Del, Office of the Secretary, Department of the Navy, Department of Defense	1
Prepared Statement of	5
Questions Submitted to	75
Summary Statement of	3
TriService Nursing Research Program , Prepared Statement of the	336

	Page
Wormuth, Hon. Christine E., Secretary, Office of the Secretary, Department of the Army, Department of Defense	143
Prepared Statement of	149
Summary Statement of	146
Questions Submitted to	176
Young Marines, Prepared Statement of	338

SUBJECT INDEX

DEPARTMENT OF DEFENSE

DEPARTMENT OF THE AIR FORCE

UNITED STATES SPACE FORCE

OFFICE OF THE SECRETARY

	Page
Additional Committee Questions	132
<i>United States Air Force</i>	105
Air Force's Role in:	
Defending the Nation	105
Succeeding Through Teamwork	108
Taking Care of People	107
<i>United States Space Force</i>	102
Space Force's Role in:	
Defending the Nation	103
Succeeding Through Teamwork	104
Taking Care of People	104

DEPARTMENT OF THE ARMY

OFFICE OF THE SECRETARY

50 Years of the All-Volunteer Force	154
Additional Committee Questions	175
Delivering the Army of 2030	151
Enduring Army Priorities	149
People Are Our Greatest Strength and First Priority	152
Ready to Fight and Win	149

DEPARTMENT OF THE NAVY

OFFICE OF THE SECRETARY

Additional Committee Questions	75
Amphibious Warfare Ships	40
Building a Culture of Warfighting Excellence	11
Capabilities	26
Capacity	28
Childcare	46
Climate Change Resilience	52
Contributions to the Joint Force, Nested in the National Defense Strategy	20
Doctrine	48
Enhanced Infantry and Leader Training	49
Facilities Sustainment, Restoration and Modernization (FSRM)	51
Fiscal Year 2024 President's Budget, The	7
Force Design:	
and Current Operations	34
and Marine Forces Reserve	42
and Marine Special Operations Forces	42

	Page
Force Design—Continued	
and the Ground Combat Element (GCE)	36
Campaign of Learning	40
Emerging Capabilities	37
Experimentation in Support of Contested Logistics	39
Experimentation with Littoral Mobility	39
Guam and H2B Visas	52
Healthcare	47
Infrastructure	51
Installations:	
and Logistics	51
Assessment and Resources	51
Plan 2023 (IPLAN)	51
Maritime Challenges to U.S. National Security, The	19
MILCON Priorities in Support of Force Design	51
Modernized Marine Corps Training Environment (Project Tripoli), The	49
Navy's Unique Peacetime Mission	19
Posture	32
Readiness	22
Recruiting and Retention	45
Research, Development, Test & Evaluation (RDT&E)	38
Resources	33
Sexual Assault Prevention and Response	47
Strengthening:	
Maritime Dominance	8
Strategic Partnerships	13
Substance Abuse Prevention	46
Suicide Prevention	47
Talent Management	42
Way-Ahead	44
Three Enduring Priorities Guiding the Department of the Navy	5
Training:	
and Education	48
Areas and Ranges	50
U.S. Navy Priorities	22
Warfighting Readiness	33

NATIONAL GUARD AND RESERVE

A Total Force	272
Additional Committee Questions	314
Addressing Harmful Behaviors	260
Air Force Reserve Fiscal Year 2024 Posture Statement	287
Air Force Reserve's Role in:	
Defending the Nation	288
Taking Care of People	292
Succeeding Through Teamwork	295
Behavioral Health	277
By the Numbers	258
Defense Support of Civil Authorities	261
Design the Force: Capabilities	265
Develop the Force: Sailors	267
Equipment	274
Facilities	275
Force Design	283
Health Services	276
Innovation and Experimentation	284
Looking to the Future	256
Military Equal Opportunity	280
Mobilize the Force: Capacity	267
Modernization/Facilities/Shaping Tomorrow	262
National:	
Defense Strategy	255
Guard support to the NDS	255
Personnel	273
Quality of Life	280
Readiness	261

	Page
Ready Now! Shaping Tomorrow . . .	258
Recruiting and Retention	259
Sexual:	
Assault Prevention and Response	279
Harassment/Assault Response and Prevention (SHARP)	260
Soldiers and Families	259
Suicide Prevention	260
Supporting our Wounded, Ill, or Injured Marines and their Families	283
Sustained funding is essential for continued NATO support.	261
Talent Management	285
Train the Force: Readiness	266
Training	260, 274
United States Air Force Reserve	287
United States Army Reserve, The	258

OFFICE OF THE SECRETARY OF DEFENSE

Additional Committee Questions	236
Defending the Nation	191
Readiness and Modernization	204
Strategic Environment	202
Succeeding Through Teamwork	197
Taking Care of Our People	195, 206